A Compilation of the Bab's Writings — 1844–1846, Volume 3

Translated Using GPT-5

The Bab

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Preface

This book collects the writings of the Báb in chronological order, arranged in three parts: 1844–1846, 1847 (the year of the Bayán), and 1848–1850.

Each writing is identified by its BB reference number.

The Bab—Early Writings of the second period (Shiraz, early-mid 1846)

Volume 008-008. Contains 30 writings.

BB00017: Sahifiy-i-'Adliyya = Risaliy-i-'Adliyyih (Epistle of Justice: Root Principles)

Chapter One: Concerning the mention of God, exalted and glorified be He

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

All praise and glorification belong to that Beauty of the Divine Essence, Who hath ever been singular in His existence, with naught else beside Him. His Being forever remaineth in that most exalted state wherein He hath ever dwelt, without change or alteration. Description of His holy Essence is impossible, for naught existeth beside Him. He hath not charged any soul with the knowledge of His innermost Essence, by reason of His utter separation from all existence. None hath known Him, for none existeth in His presence. None hath worshipped Him in a manner befitting His holy Essence. Every being that hath desired to love His Essence hath been rejected before God and all creation, for it hath sought the impossible.

He who claimeth to know His innermost Essence is an infidel, for it is impossible for creation to know Him. Whosoever seeketh to unify His innermost Essence becometh at once a polytheist, for none but His Essence can unify His Essence, and none but Him hath known Him. He alone is worthy of praise and glory through His Own praise of Himself. He is sanctified above the knowledge of all created things and the expression of all existing beings, with true transcendence and holiness. His Essence hath no attribute or name besides His Essence. He is the Truth, there is no God but Him. Thee do we worship and Thine aid we seek.

All else besides Him are brought into being through His creation and origination. There is neither connection nor separation between Him and contingent beings. Through pure creativity He hath brought

the contingent Will into being from the midst of sheer nothingness, and hath attributed it to Himself as a mark of honor, even as He hath called the Kaaba His House. He hath brought all creation into existence through its existence. How transcendent is His power and how perfect His handiwork, that He hath invented all things from between the letter "la" which is pure nothingness, from nothing through Himself. He hath ordained it a sign of His sovereignty, that all beings might be immersed in the surge of pure negation, and might shine forth with the radiance of pure affirmation of all created things.

Therefore, all creation belongeth to Him, after the independence of His holy Essence. He is the God of all creation, while there is no deity at His level. He knoweth all things, while there is no known thing in His holy presence. He is powerful over all things through His Essence, while His knowledge encompasseth no object of power besides His Essence, for there is no object of power with Him to which knowledge might attach. All things in their existential and material stations are present before His sovereignty. He knoweth all things before their creation and after their coming into being. He is in His Essence independent of all else besides Himself. This very independence which proveth His existence without the existence of anything else likewise proveth His knowledge of all things without the existence of any known thing.

I seek forgiveness of Him and take refuge with Him from the description of all existing things and the attributes of all contingent beings, for every mention is a deficiency in His holy court and every description is a falsehood regarding His mighty Essence. No path remaineth for anyone save inability and acknowledgment of failure, although in the very act of mentioning the sublimity of divine unity and the grandeur of divine oneness, mention of powerlessness seems remote. Yet there is no escape in the realm of knowledge except that one must believe in God with conviction, acknowledging that permanence in the kingdom belongs to the King, that the attribute of the contingent is contingency, and that the description of the dependent is powerlessness. The Essence of Eternity is not known, and for Him there is no name or attribute mentioned, except such attributes as His Essence has revealed of itself to created things. He is more glorious and greater than any mention of sublimity or grandeur. There is no God worthy of worship except Him—verily, there is no God but He, the Most High, the Most Great.

Infinite blessings and beginningless peace befit the court of Glory, whose holy name in the Concourse on High and the realm of eternity is Muhammad—may God's blessings be upon him and his family—who is the source from which are derived the praised names of the Lord of Might, exalted be His glory. O Lord, how can I praise the Manifestations of the power of Thy Beloved, when Thou hast inscribed with Thy hand of power upon the tablets of the hearts of all beings: "I cannot praise them as Thou hast praised them." O Lord, bless them through all Thy breezes and verses, through the perpetuity of the might of Thy Essence, for Thou art as Thou art. Verily, Thou art the Mighty, the Strong.

I praise Thee, O God, and I send blessings upon them, and I speak by Thy wisdom as revealed in Thy Book:

> "Glorified be thy Lord, the Lord of Might, above what they describe. And peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds."

To continue: this servant, who is dependent upon God and who holds fast to the cord of the family of God, declares that after returning from pilgrimage, when the proof had been completed through the manifestation of knowledge to all the world through authoritative books and firm writings, numerous

books from every direction, from the people of knowledge and utterance, were revealed in the midst of the ocean of grief and solitude. In most of their verses, they expressed inability to produce Arabic verses like these from those who were not people of knowledge. And since the decree of fate had not been executed to answer them in the original Persian explanation in the manifest religion, the ruling was to return to the first one knowledgeable of the First Book, until the sun of mutual imprecation rose from the horizon of pitch darkness, concealed by divine permission in the letter Sin and in the exalted year 1262.

This supreme praise and greatest gift coincided with the rising of the star Jupiter from the book of the noblest of notables and the most beloved of all beings from the horizon of the unseen, raining down verses of powerlessness, verses of oath and poverty, from the manifest cloud. Praise and gratitude be to God as is worthy of Him and as He deserves.

Since the response of one soul gives life to the spirit of the humble ones, by God's permission, in the tongue of the people of the Bayan, the non-Arabs among humankind are granted, through these non-Arabic verses of Arabic truth from the ocean of my powerlessness and grief, according to what flows from me for the sake of truth, life in the essence of knowledge of the root and branch, so that all people of the world, both the learned and the distressed, might be illumined by the dawning light of preeternity from the first Muhammadan Light—may God's blessings be upon him and his family—through His servant, and might attain certitude in acknowledging the power of the Single, Unique Creator, and might not utter concerning the writer of these tablets any judgment save that of pure servitude, whether in secret or openly, so that they might not remain veiled in any condition from the eternal bounty and the breezes of the everlasting Sun. O people! Purify your souls when the sun shines forth with radiance and night retreats by decree.

The decree hath come from every quarter of the heavens' horizon, and the earth hath conversed with its people above the waters. Verily the trumpet hath been sounded in the land of manifestation. The darkness hath been illumined in the depths of mystery. The peacock of the cloud-realm hath sung at the setting of Cancer. The cock hath crowed unto the dove from the branches of the blessed tree. Here have the doers of good attained success, and the wrongdoers suffered loss. Even thus should the workers work, and for such should the strivers strive.

Chapter Two: Concerning the Balance by the Command of God, the Mighty, the Exalted

Know thou, O seeker of the Root and Branch, that the Lord of Glory hath imposed no obligation upon anyone beyond their capacity and strength. The root and branch of religion in every world and age have circled round the divine Will. And know thou the creation of all things even as thine own creation, which began from the stage of the sperm until the infinitude of stations ordained for thee in God's knowledge. Observe with certainty how thy first station is subsidiary to thy second station. Indeed, the essential purpose of creating the sperm is to form the clot, and so forth unto infinity, through stations decreed by the Lord of Glory. The proof of this matter is the manifestation of possibilities, which are the loci of the revelations of power.

Now that thou hast observed the Point of Truth in all things, be likewise certain of the decree of religion, that the sperm of religion was in the early days of Adam, peace be upon him, when the people of that

time were situated at the station of the sperm of truth. In like manner did religion itself and its people progress through God's power until the day of the manifestation of the Muhammadan Reality, peace be upon him and his family, when the station of religion and its people had reached the stage whereof He said:

> "Then We clothed the bones with flesh; then We produced it as another creation."

Blessed, therefore, be God, the Best of creators!

This is the cause of the abrogation of laws and religions, for an obligation suitable to the stage of the sperm would be sheer tyranny if imposed at the stage of the clot. And after the obligation pertained to the stage of flesh-creation, since no further transformation was ordained for it, this holy Law shall never be abrogated. Rather, what Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, made lawful is lawful unto the Day of Resurrection, and what Muhammad made unlawful is unlawful unto the Day of Resurrection. And after the sperm of religion and its people reached the stage of human creation, God ordained religious obligations for them. Until they reached the age of discernment of divine unity, He entrusted the preservation of religion and its people to fourteen holy souls.

And after the people of religion reached the first year of maturity, He ordained the occultation of His Proof and commanded the creatures to follow His Proof, that through struggles of the soul they might progress to the station of the knowledge of ijtihad. And He established differences among the group of researchers over the course of a thousand years, that all might, through fear of God and the decree of religion, through sincere struggles and righteous deeds, attain the station of action independent of following others, until they become worthy of the day of the rising of the shining moon from the eastern quarter, according to the explicit words of the Commander of the Faithful, peace be upon him.

In these days, through tribulations sent down, He hath removed the insincere from the manifest religion, that those bereft of the consciousness of unity, which is the essential purpose of all created things, might be excluded from the circle of those who have attained.

A divine analogy: If one should have acted in accordance with what the Prophet of God—peace and blessings be upon Him and His family—commanded, attaining the utmost station of deeds, and should have acknowledged the authority of the immaculate Household—peace be upon them—but then turned away from the decree of Husayn ibn Ruh—God's mercy be upon him—who was one of the deputies during the Lesser Occultation, there is no doubt that all such deeds would be as scattered dust. This is because the fruit of all these acts is obedience to God through acknowledging Him, and the deeds of no one in any age will yield benefit unless they constitute obedience to the divine will and decree for that time.

Now that thou hast been acquainted with a drop from the ocean of truth, know that God's Cause in every aspect is more manifest than the sun, and none hath any argument against God—exalted be His transcendent glory—after differences in the days of occultation reached their utmost degree and souls drew near to the purity of the consciousness of unity. It becometh incumbent upon the station of God's mercy to choose and manifest a servant with sufficient proof from His own Proof, that he might bring the paths of differences to the point of unity. Just as the essence of religion and its people have progressed

beyond the physical realm, so too have the divine verses progressed infinitely beyond the station of limitation. It is necessary that the proof of that servant be above the realm of intellects, which comprises the stations of knowledge and abstraction.

Since acceptance of this matter hath been difficult for most people, these mighty stations have been brought to the level of embodied words in such wise that none can produce the like thereof, and no limit hath been set for them, that they might serve as a proof like the sun in the midst of heaven for all created things. How wondrous is the handiwork of the Lord of Glory, and how perfect His power, that in the midst of religious differences He hath chosen a servant from among the Persians and opened his tongue with verses in such wise that none before him hath produced their like. In whatsoever he willeth and whenever he willeth, he speaketh without pause and writeth without rest of pen. Such is their resemblance to the verses of God that none can distinguish between them, yet their station is not like that of the verses of the Qur'an. Rather, they are verses that serve as proof for all the peoples of the earth, and their likeness in form and meaning is as an image reflected in a fifth mirror.

All the verses that God hath caused to flow from my tongue, both in meaning and expression, are as nought compared to a single letter of the Book of God and the words of the immaculate Household. Thus far, what hath been witnessed in the Kitab-i-ʿAdl amounts to four thousand firm verses, of which a single verse sufficeth as proof for the peoples of the earth, inasmuch as they have flowed by pure divine nature [fitrat] from the treasuries of the unseen through God's grace. Nor should the people marvel at this; for after the descent of the Book of God, in the very midst of a people consummate in eloquence and discourse, for ten years did no one acknowledge it. Some cried, "Fables of the ancients!" others, "Words like unto the speech of a non-Arab!" and yet others, "Tales of former times!"—until, at the last, beholding their own impotence, they confessed.

O inquirer! The Sahifiy-i-A'mal-i-Sannah contains fourteen chapters, and its verses number in total two hundred and fourteen. Present it to all the learned ones, both Arab and Persian. By the One Who is the Truth, if all the peoples of the earth were to gather together, they could not produce the like of even one chapter thereof. From the day of the appearance of this Cause until now, by the True One Who knoweth all things, I have not seen a single verse from anyone, and from one who denied all the verses, I requested one tradition and he was unable to produce it. Indeed it is impossible and unattainable. And if anyone should compose words, they would be plagiarized words, not that which he could utter from the nature endowed by God. And whatsoever he produceth is from the depths of hell.

None can contend with this Cause save one who possesseth power like unto the Author of this Book, who, if he so desireth, could throughout his entire life speak naught but the verses of God concerning any matter, and no powerlessness would be found in him. And if anyone should say that the Proof of the Imam (peace be upon him) must possess all verses, this is true. However, he hath but one verse, before which all other verses are as nothing. And if he produceth naught else, his proof is complete. Yea, if his proof were other than verses, it would be incumbent upon him to produce whatsoever anyone might ask. But now that his proof is that which is supreme over all physical verses, this is not incumbent upon him, and his proof is sufficient unto all.

As He hath revealed:

> “Verily, one verse that We have now revealed unto thee in this Book equalleth in the Book of God all the verses of the Prophets. And after this all creation shall be questioned concerning the proofs of God.”

And if anyone should say this proof is his own artifice, this is rejected, like that which is said about the Qur’an, letter by letter. And whenever a falsifier sayeth that in some instances the verses are contrary to the rules of the people, this is a calumny. Nay, all verses flow according to the divine rule, like the verses of the Qur’an, and other than this is the falsehood of satans and the ignorance of the writers.

And if all the learned ones should desire to find in the Kitabu’l-ʿAdl or the Sahifah Baynu’l-Haramayn one letter of grammatical error or two unconnected letters, according to the rules of the Book of God and the people, verily they shall never be able to do so.

Nay, one verse that conformeth to the rules of the people proveth the claim and sufficeth for all. Say: Die in your wrath, and enter the fire through your associating partners with God, then become stones from the depths of hell, arranged in rows. This verse alone sufficeth for the people of doubt and denial, throughout the power and glory of God.

Know thou that God hath chosen someone for the protection of His religion and His proof, and through his hands He hath caused sufficient proofs and conclusive evidences to flow forth. He was raised among the Persians and received no instruction from anyone regarding these true traces. Rather, he was completely unlettered in such traces, and it hath never been witnessed that one raised among the Persians, nor is it possible henceforth, should have such power over words, as the eloquent ones and sages among the mystics have confessed their impotence and lack of knowledge regarding the outward meanings thereof. And yet the twenty-nine letters have been and remain in the hands of the learned. This wondrous method hath never flowed from anyone’s pen, nor is it possible.

Should any learned one take up the pen to write verses spontaneously without drawing from the Book of God, it becomes evident how supremely mighty and difficult this matter is, and impossible for anyone save whom God willeth. And since the perfect divine power is complete, besides this Most Great Sign and Supreme Proof, He hath bestowed strange divine qualities upon the bearer of this soul, such that every living being may be convinced that these verses are impossible for anyone without divine permission—as for instance, that in the space of twelve hours a mighty scroll floweth from his pen without reflection.

And what proof could be greater than this, that man should attain the station of intimate communion with the Beloved, than which no loftier station in contingent existence can be conceived? Even as the blessed Sadiq—peace be upon him—hath explicitly stated in the Misbahu’sh-Shari’ih.

And until now none among the sages and learned ones hath fully manifested this station. Had this occurred, surely some writing would have remained from them. And none save the Immaculates—peace be upon them—have claimed this station.

Even as the author of Haqqu’l-Yaqin hath written that the greatest miracle of the Family of God—peace be upon them—was their words. And concerning the Sahifiy-i-Sajjadiyyih all the divines have called it the Psalms of the Family of the Prophet, likening it to the heavenly scriptures.

How is it that all affirm the divine authority regarding the Sahifiy-i-Sajjadiyyih, yet hesitate concerning these few writings wherein the matter hath reached from the limited world to infinity and beyond? I seek refuge with God from the promptings of Satan, for he is mankind's manifest enemy.

When one possessed of knowledge considereth the reality, he knoweth how difficult it is to bring stations that transcend the world of reason into the realm of words, which is the body, in less than the twinkling of an eye. Observing its inner and outer arrangement, he knoweth how mighty a matter this is.

By the truth of God Who revealed the Qur'an to His Holiness the Messenger—peace be upon him and his family—a single intimate communion with God, with outward eloquence and true arrangement, is greater than all sciences and nobler than all acts of worship, especially when it manifesteth lofty stations through wondrous words.

And whoever hath examined the writings of the author of this book knoweth that he hath brought forth meanings and words from the Concourse on High that exist in none of the traditional prayers. Let none imagine that I claim these prayers are more perfect or greater. Nay, by the truth of God Who manifested the Family of God through His absolute authority, my existence, attributes and words that have flowed and shall flow by God's leave from my tongue and pen shall never equal a single letter of the prayers of the Immaculates—peace be upon them—for they dwell in the sources of God's Will, while all others are mentioned only in the effects of their deeds. This is beyond the reach of aspiring hands. Glory be to God above what they describe.

Secondly, among the attributes of the stations of holiness is this: that in His sermons the loftiest utterances—before which the masters of eloquence and exposition stand abashed—flowed from His pen, with a facility surpassing all things, from His very hand. Had all the proofs of the One Who occupies this station been but a single sermon from among those that have been revealed, it would have sufficed for all. Yet now all see and know how, after much contemplation and study of books, the divines compose a single sermon with great difficulty. And when at last it is placed alongside these mighty sermons, it is as the babbling of children. God will judge between all with truth. Had the divines not turned away from this Cause, no one would have suffered injustice. And now whatever transpires, the sin thereof shall rest upon them until the Day of Resurrection.

The third of the divine attributes is the knowledge manifested by Him Who occupies this station, Who hath expounded lofty and hidden truths in brief utterances, in such wise as no divine hath ever done before. Whatever He hath written, He hath established through wisdom, which is the greatest of explicit proofs. In most instances He hath made no mention of proofs based on exhortation or disputation, that He might raise mankind beyond such limited bounds to the highest heaven. Every person of understanding who hath beheld His commentary on the Surih of the Cow, His treatises, and His answers to the questions of the learned, hath attained certitude regarding what hath been mentioned. Matters which the divines have discussed at length in numerous debates have been set forth more perfectly and concisely in His wondrous words, such that all the learned have acknowledged that this is indeed from God, the Almighty.

As to His alteration of certain words in some passages and His departure from the rules observed by the people of limitations, this is so that men might be assured that the One Who occupies this station hath not acquired His verses and knowledge through study, but rather His breast hath been dilated with divine knowledge through the light of God. They will then recognize that His alterations are of a wondrous nature and His departure from rules conforms to a divine pattern. Indeed, numerous examples of such expressions have been revealed in the Book of God. For instance, where a feminine word should appear, the Lord of the worlds hath revealed a masculine pronoun, as in His words "and a Word from Him, whose name is the Messiah." And in describing a feminine attribute He hath revealed "one of the greatest," as in His exalted words "Verily it is one of the greatest warnings to mankind." And He hath given permission to whomsoever wisheth to follow either the divine rules or to hold back, meaning to follow the rules of the people, for verily they were an ignorant folk.

Similarly, He hath revealed contrary to the rules of all the learned this phrase: "These two are certainly sorcerers." This is so that all might know with certainty that the creation of words is dependent upon divine decree, not upon the conventions of those who are not people of the Bayan. Indeed, just as the worlds have progressed, so too have words and their inflections progressed. How near is the day when the verses of God shall be recited without regard for the rules and inflections customary among the people. O Lord, hasten by Thy grace the deliverance of the family of God. Verily, Thou art the Lord of ancient bounty.

And after thou hast become aware of these subtle and celestial allusions, know that today among the Twelver sect discord hath reached its height. Some are known as Usulis and consider truth to be with themselves after acting upon conjecture, which is agreed upon among them. And others are known as Akhbaris and who recognize no authority but radiant reason, and those who are known by the name of the late Shaykh Ahmad ibn Zayn al-Din (may God sanctify his resting place) and who claim for themselves pure and absolute truth—yet they have not grasped even the outer shell of the words of that great monotheist. And some are known as Sufis and claim to possess the inner meaning of the Law, while they are veiled and distant from both the inner and outer meanings. Rather, they have chosen the path of pure darkness and polytheism, though they perceive it not.

And there is no doubt that within each of these four schools there are endless differences, to such an extent that some declare others to be unbelievers. Although besides these four well-known sects, there are others who have made themselves leaders and founders of schools, such as the followers of Mulla Sadra and their like. Each regards itself as absolute truth and all others as absolute falsehood. How well spoke the Arab poet:

> "Each claims connection with Layla, but Layla acknowledges them not. When tears flow down cheeks, it becomes clear who truly weeps and who feigns weeping."

There is no doubt that among all these differences, the pure truth has been with the Twelver sect alone, although those of other sects, when they have acted for the love of God and exerted their utmost effort, have been rewarded. When matters reached this point, through the grace of the Hidden Imam (may God hasten his appearance), He chose one of His servants from among the common people and nobles to preserve the Faith, and bestowed upon him the knowledge of divine unity and true wisdom, which is the

greatest of all good things. And since in every age people have prided themselves on their greatest signs, the one who is sent must appear among the people with the greatest of those signs, so that people of understanding may not hesitate to acknowledge him.

There is no doubt that in this age, the glory of the scholars has been in their knowledge of Qur'anic verses and traditions, and the glory of the mystics in their understanding of the subtleties of the Supreme Assembly. Therefore, it is necessary that the chosen servant appear among the people with the greatest of these signs—which is knowledge of the innermost mysteries and eloquence both outward and inward—so that the proof may be complete for all scholars and mystics. Any person of subtle perception who examines the verses and words will find the matter clearer than the sun at its zenith, and any discerning scholar who observes the eloquence of the verses will see the truth with the eye of certainty.

Today, after the rising of the manifest moon from the East, which was foretold in the tradition of the Prince of Believers (peace be upon him), it is incumbent upon all to obey and love him and follow his ordinances. This is the pure religion of the One God. Whoever wishes to acknowledge it does so for their own sake, and whoever wishes to deny it does so to their own detriment. God's proof is complete for all the world. O people! Whosoever knoweth Me knoweth God and His Messenger and His chosen ones, and whosoever knoweth Me not knoweth not God and His Messenger and His chosen ones, and this sufficeth as glory unto Me, and God sufficeth as a witness.

Know thou that this revelation of verses and supplications and divine knowledge is from a dream wherein was beheld the holy head of the Prince of Martyrs, peace be upon Him, severed from His pure body, along with the heads of His kindred, and seven draughts of blood were drunk from the blood of that martyred one with utmost love. And it is through the blessing of His blood that my breast was expanded to reveal such firm verses and decisive supplications. Praise be to God Who caused me to drink the blood of His Proof and made it the reality of my heart, and for this have I consented to affliction. Verily we are God's and to Him do we return, and for the like of this let all strivers strive.

Chapter Three

Part 1: "Concerning the Knowledge of God and the Knowledge…"

Concerning the Knowledge of God and the Knowledge of His Chosen Ones as God, the Mighty, the Glorious, Hath Commanded

Know thou that the foundation of religion is the knowledge of God, and the perfection of knowledge is unity, and the perfection of unity is the negation of attributes and names from His holy Essence, and the perfection of negation is entrance into the depth of oneness, through certain knowledge and witnessing the manifestation of His bounty. The reality of these stations is the sign of God alone, through which knowledge and certitude of the existence of the Lord of Glory is attained.

And know thou that the Ancient Being's outer reality is His very inner reality, and His essence is His very being. He hath ever been, and no thing had existence, and now too He is as He was in eternity, and no thing hath existence at His level. Whatsoever can be termed a thing, apart from the Essence of God, is His creation. His Essence is known to none, for knowledge requireth existence and association, and all else

hath no existence at His level, much less requiring association. None hath known God save His holy Essence, and none hath unified God save His holy Essence.

Whosoever claimeth to know Him is an infidel, by the testimony of his own self which is contingent and temporal. And whosoever claimeth to unify Him is a polytheist, by the testimony of his own self, for association with Him is impossible, and it is impossible to attribute names and descriptions to His Essence. No one hath any way or means to know Him. His proof from all eternity hath been His Essence, and it is impossible for anything contingent to become His proof. Whosoever manifesteth the unity of His appearance through His Essence for His Essence hath plunged into the ultimate bounty of contingency. And whosoever taketh contingent beings as proof of knowledge of Him remaineth veiled from the bounty of the ultimate creation by Himself through Himself. The manifestation of divinity is too well-known and evident and exalted and honored to be known through His creation. Nay, all besides God are known through His existence. Those who claim the unity of existence are polytheists, by the testimony of existence itself, for the unity they affirm is contingent upon the existence of two, else from what station would come the negation of two and affirmation of unity? Likewise those who consider the Essence of Truth to be the cause of contingent existence.

Those who believe in causation are infidels. For causation is contingent upon the connection between cause and effect, and connection is contingent upon the existence of duality. Both stations are utterly false. Rather, the True Reality is the Essence of Truth. Creation is contingent, and nothing beyond contingent creation is conceivable. Truth has ever been Truth, and no thing is known. Creation will ever be creation, and connection with the Essence is impossible.

And since God, the Ancient One, created creation for the recognition of His power manifested within them, and made reward and punishment the cause of this same matter, He created the Will ex nihilo through His own causation—a Will without qualification or explanation. And after that He created all things through its causation. And it is impossible for anything to be created upon which the word “thing” may be applied except through seven stages of contingency, less than which is impossible for any contingent thing. These seven stages are Will, Purpose, Destiny, Decree, Permission, Term, and Book. And whoever believes that God created a thing without the causation of these seven stages is, by the explicit text of tradition, an infidel.

The first mention of a thing without relation to thingness is the existence of Will. At the time of relating existence to thingness it is Purpose. At the time of mentioning meanings it is Destiny. The manifestation of these three ranks is Decree. And at this station it is obligatory upon all contingent things to acknowledge the origination of God, glory be to Him, the Most High. For there is no origination after Decree. And the ruling of Permission, Term and Book is established after confirmation, nay rather, the reality of origination. And the mystery of invention is the existence of these seven in the world of the unseen and the visible, which is the manifestation of fourteen holy souls. Glory be to God above what they associate with Him.

Know, O questioner, that the philosophers have mentioned in their books proofs for the existence of the Creator, and the mystics for His unity. All are rejected by the testimony of their own proofs which are contingent. It is impossible for proof to be contingent essence. Rather, whenever anyone gazes upon the

Point of Reality and removes the veils and allusions, he becomes immediately certain that mentioning proof of the One, and establishing unity through other than God's attributes, is among the greatest of sins and the most grievous of abominations. Rather, there is no proof with me for His existence and unity other than Him. None has known His Essence except His Essence, and all description by created things returns to their own selves.

How greatly have the expositors of certain truth presumed in mentioning affirmative and negative attributes, while remaining veiled from the words of the Prince of Believers, peace be upon him, negating attributes. Not even a letter's worth of reality in mentioning this matter have they expressed or understood. If they affirm unity, whence comes mention of eight? And if they do not affirm it, they remain veiled from unity. Rather, in truth His holy Essence has no attribute other than His Essence. And the attributes which the Holy Household, peace be upon them, have explained are, by the explicit word of His Holiness Rida, peace be upon him, for sweeping away delusions. God has ever been Knowing while nothing was known with Him. His Knowledge is His Essence. And whoever has sought to know His Knowledge and its modality, he is an infidel. For His knowledge is not attainable by anyone. He hath ever been the All-Powerful, the All-Hearing, the All-Seeing.

And there was no object of power, nor anything heard, nor anything mentioned with Him. He knoweth all things before their existence, even as was explained in the first sermon of the Book as a drop from the ocean of truth. The mention of negation is a branch of affirmation. God is sanctified from all else besides Him. All attributes are but mention of the existence of His Will. All names are but the name of His Purpose. He is sanctified from all else besides Himself through His own Essence. I seek forgiveness from Him for mentioning aught else besides Him before the court of His nearness. Glory be to God above what they attribute unto Him.

And after thou hast witnessed that there is no way unto the knowledge of God, the Most Merciful—neither through attributes, nor through explanation, nor through names, nor through recognition, nor through inability, nor through the reality of contingent existence—for all else besides Him were pure nothingness before existence, and now too there is none with Him and in His station all are pure nothingness. And after the existence of contingent beings, He hath described His own Self in the realm of possibility through possibility. And it is incumbent upon all the world to worship His sacred Essence, alone, alone, there is no God but He, with such attributes as He hath revealed in the Qur'an. Exalted be God far above what the wrongdoers say with great exaltation! Know thou that the foundation of knowledge in the affairs of causality hath seven stages, which all are bound to acknowledge, and knowledge is not complete without them, and the first is not acceptable without the last. And this, in truth, is according to the detailed explanation which His Holiness Ali ibn al-Husayn, peace be upon them both, emphasized and commanded to Jabir. And the original hadith in Arabic is as follows:

"As related in the Book of Anis al-Samra, Ahmad ibn Abdullah related to me, saying Sulayman ibn Ahmad related to me, saying Ja'far ibn Muhammad related to me, saying Ibrahim ibn Muhammad al-Mawsili related to me, saying my father informed me from Khalid from al-Qasim from Jabir ibn Yazid al-Ju'fi from Ali ibn al-Husayn, peace be upon them both, in a long tradition. Then he recited His word, exalted be He: ʿThis Day We will forget them as they forgot the meeting of this their Day, and as they were wont to deny

Our signs.' By God these are Our signs and this is one of them, and by God it is our authority. O Jabir… until he said: O Jabir, dost thou know what knowledge is? Knowledge is first the affirmation of Divine Unity, then knowledge of the Meanings second, then knowledge of the Gates third, then knowledge of the Imam fourth, then knowledge of the Pillars fifth, then knowledge of the Chiefs sixth, then knowledge of the Nobles seventh.

"And this is His word, mighty and glorious: Say: If the sea were ink for the Words of my Lord, the sea would be exhausted before the Words of my Lord were exhausted, though We brought the like thereof to help.' And he also recited: And if all the trees on earth were pens and the sea (were ink), with seven more seas to help it, yet would not the Words of God be exhausted: for God is Exalted in Power, full of Wisdom.'

> "O Jabir, the affirmation of Divine Unity and knowledge of the Meanings—as for the affirmation of Divine Unity, it is knowledge of God, the Ancient, the Hidden, Whom sight comprehendeth not while He comprehendeth all sight, and He is the Subtle, the All-Aware, and He is the unseen, the hidden, as We shall mention it as He hath described Himself. And as for the Meanings, We are His meanings and His manifestation among you. He hath chosen us from the light of His Essence and entrusted unto us the affairs of His servants. We act by His leave as We will, and when We will, God willeth, and when We purpose, God purposeth. We have made God, exalted be His glory, the source of this station. He has chosen us from among His servants and made us His proof in His lands. Whosoever denies anything that proceeds from us has denied God, glorified be His name, and disbelieved in His signs, His Prophets, and His Messengers."

Were I to expound but a single letter of this tradition with what God has ordained, all the oceans of the contingent world would vanish before a single letter could be explained. Since this book was written for the conviction of those endowed with understanding, that they might ascend from the realm of limitations to the revelations of the heaven of glory, and since no proof save that of wisdom—which leads to certitude—was intended to be mentioned, divine words are set forth for the conviction of all, that all might become worthy of attaining the presence of the Beloved.

Know thou that there are seven degrees of knowledge [ma'rifat]. The first is the knowledge of God, to which reference has been made, and verses have been revealed for the knowers in the first sermon and second gate, that all might acquire knowledge through separation from the point of union to distinction. The four stations of unity return to the essence of unity itself. Whoso truly understands unity has acted according to its stations. Most people have become polytheists in the station of the unity of worship and unbelievers in the station of the unity of deeds, though they perceive it not.

Know thou that the One Essence, alone, without partner, is worthy of worship and none other. Whosoever worships His Essence without attention to aught else in His creation, and without desire for any recompense save Him, has truly worshipped God in the manner possible within the realm of contingency. One must be certain that the Essence in its essence was and is beyond description, recognition, or worship. The worship of none is worthy of His sanctified presence. This station is the ultimate divine gift to the servant, for when one attains it, all are beheld beneath the shadow of His

grace. Should anyone turn in worship to any name, attribute, or any of the family of God, peace be upon them, he has become an unbeliever and has not worshipped God.

Should anyone worship Him or call upon Him in hope of paradise or fear of hell-fire, he has indeed been veiled from true worship of God and is unworthy of His Essence. Rather, the way of worship is to worship Him according to how He has described Himself, without mention of aught else. Even had He decreed the firm verdict of hell-fire for the worshippers, it would be true, and the worshipper should worship Him for His Essence's worth and be content with the fire. However, the decree is contrary to this, and paradise is the first gift from the Worshipped One to the sincere believer. Glorified be God above what they associate with Him.

In the station of the unity of deeds, it is incumbent upon the believer in God to acknowledge no creator but Him and to transcend the decree of compulsion and delegation in all things, which is pure unbelief. Rather, for everything to which the word "thing" can be applied, God alone is its Creator, through the causality of seven characteristics by the thing's own choice. In the perspective of Truth, it is neither predestination nor delegation. Rather, the Command of God transcends these two matters. And this Command is vaster than what lies between the heaven of Will and the earth of inanimate matter, which is the ultimate degree of receptivity. The secret of the Command is that God knows the volition of all things, and through the path of volition creates all things, and rewards them according to their volition.

Were He to create anything contrary to its own degree of receptivity, He would have wronged it. However, He has created all through His love and the love of His chosen ones, and thereafter caused His decree to flow through their sanction, that all may receive their portion. In four stations has He created all things through His Will and taken a covenant, that none may have argument against Him. In the first realm, He took from all the covenant of His Divinity. In the second realm, He took from all the covenant of the Prophethood of Muhammad, peace be upon Him and His family. In the third, He established firmly the covenant of the guardianship of the Family of God. And in the fourth, He took the covenant of love for the people of guardianship.

He created all with volition, and volition with the self, and none can possess any deed save through their own volition. It is incumbent upon all to acknowledge the unity of His Essence, Attributes, and Acts, and to worship as befits the One God. Creation has no way to know His unity, neither through affirmation nor through inability. Rather, it is incumbent upon all to witness the four signs in the Being whom God has associated with His Self. The most perfect words regarding the unity of acts is "There is no power nor strength save in God," revealed from the treasuries of the unseen.

As for what has spread on the tongues of some opponents—that the late Shaykh Ahmad, may God's mercy be upon him, and his successor in knowledge, in their worship turn to the Commander of the Faithful, peace be upon him, and consider him the Creator—this is pure falsehood and calumny. One who believes this is an infidel and polytheist by consensus. Rather, that great one and his successor in knowledge hold the same belief as was explained regarding unity. They consider him and his pure Family, God's peace be upon them, as the loci of knowledge, the origin of Will, standing in the place of the Divine Identity, and the ultimate station of Divine Absoluteness. And they consider the Family of God, peace be upon them, in these stations that were mentioned, as honored servants who will not act before He acts,

rather their will in every station is the Will of God itself, and their volition in every station is God's volition itself.

Indeed, God's volition is their very volition. To say that volition is an attribute of the Essence is pure infidelity. Rather, volition is determination upon Will, which is the first creation. Whoever considers anyone other than God to be the creator of things is an infidel, whether they believe this independently or dependently. I seek God's forgiveness for what I have expressed regarding the stations of unity, for none save the Holy Essence is capable of knowing the science and reality of unity. He and His knowledge suffice for the servants' acknowledgment of His unity. He is the Most Great, the Most High.

The second [degree of knowledge] is the knowledge of meanings—and for this station God, the One, the Single, has ordained infinite stations. Indeed, He has created a meaning for every name. And the foundation of certitude is in meanings and submission to all its stations. It is the recognition of Muhammad ibn Abdullah ibn Abdul-Muttalib ibn Hashim ibn Abd Manaf, that he is the first creation and noblest being, whom God the All-Knowing has created. He established him to stand in His own station in giving, decreeing, originating and executing. And in the realm of God's knowledge there is none like him, nor can there be any semblance of him in innovation and creation. Rather, all that power, like the existence of the First Mention which is the Will, is connected to and is precisely the support of the Prophet, peace be upon him and his family. And his likeness is impossible in the forms of the highest heaven, nay even in the forms of the lowest depths—all return to the Primal Point and are impossible. And God the All-Knowing has been and is in every condition powerful over and knowledgeable of all things.

And for the knowledge of His Holiness, may my spirit be sacrificed for him, there are seven fundamental stations, which are the reality of the seven characteristics revealed in the tablets of the Book of Truth.

The first station is that of the Primal Point. And in this station its beginning is identical to its end, and its outward is identical to its manifest aspect, as it has ever been by God's command, and no beginning or end is mentioned for it. It is pure essence and the sign of oneness that indicates itself by itself for God, the One, the Single, besides Whom there is no God. And in this station no one has any share in the knowledge of that Eternal Sun. Rather, limits, allusions, names and attributes are cut off from His holy precincts and are prevented by His sublime majesty. And in this station of contingent existence He is without likeness or semblance. And the People of the House of Infallibility, God's peace be upon them, have no mention in this station before that Most Great Lord. All are pure servants and signs of servitude for the manifestation of that noble one's majesty. None has known Him in this station save God the All-Knowing. Indeed, in contingent existence nothing but this explanation is possible. And this is the most exalted aspect of the Will and its hiddenness. None knows it save God Who created it. And glorified be God, its Originator, above what they associate with Him.

The second station is that of the Point of Contingency. And His Holiness in this station is the First Mention and the Wondrous Adam, which is the station of the determination of the First Point. And in this station he is mentioned by his self, essence, hand, face, eye, hearing, sight and all active names in their state of attribution to God. And the People of the House of Infallibility, God's peace be upon them, are mentioned in this station in the manner of contingent mention before His presence. And none besides has any share

in the knowledge of this station, and in this station none has known His Holiness save God alone. And glorified be God above what they describe.

Part 2: "The third station is that of the Point…"

The third station is that of the Point of Separation—and in this station His Holiness is the gate of bounty for the Family of God, God's peace be upon them. And upon the people of infallibility, God's peace be upon them, as befits their station. And none else has any share in the recognition of this rank and the expression of this divine remembrance. And may God's blessings be upon Him as befits Him. And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

The fourth station is that of the Point of Connection—and in this station that Exalted One is the Pole of the realm of the heart and the Mystery of the world of creation, whom God has sent forth unto all. For His Holiness in this station, knowledge of the beginning is obligatory and belief in the end is unbelief. The Family of God, God's peace be upon them, in this rank are His Family, illumined by that Light and branches of that blessed Tree. And none else, even the Prophets, have in this station any mention or share of recognition. Glory be to God above what they describe.

The fifth station is that of the Point of Reality—and in this station all prophets and successors are created from the light of that Most Great Luminary. And in this station He alone is the First to respond in the world of pre-existence, none other. And all are mentioned through His mention, may my spirit be sacrificed for Him. And He is independent of all save Himself through God the Glorified, and He is the Most High, the Most Great.

The sixth station is that of the Original Point—and in this station all lights circle round His Holiness. And the believers among humankind and the angels are manifestations of His grace. This is the station of multiplicity and mention of the most glorious rank, which is the sixth degree of action. And the tradition "I was a Prophet while Adam was between water and clay" refers to this station, wherein believers among humankind recognize His Prophethood and receive their portion through acknowledging the majesty of that Unique One. Glory be to God, His Creator, above what they describe.

The seventh station is that of the Point of Being—wherein it is obligatory upon all things, even unto the atoms in minerals, to acknowledge His Prophethood from the day of His mission, which was after forty years, when He arose by God's command. The descent of Gabriel, peace be upon him, the decree of revelation, scripture, command of reward and prohibition of punishment pertain to this rank, wherein contingent beings have reached from beginning to ultimate remoteness. The obligation of holy war pertains to this rank, wherein those who do not believe in Him appear. Recognition of these seven stations through the signs deposited therein is obligatory upon everyone. The first is not accepted except through the last, that one may be certain of the day of His mission after the passing of forty years.

His Holiness in this station is the poorest of all beings and human like other men. The requirements of the stations of this rank are too mighty to mention and too great to write. This much suffices for complete certitude in the station of belief; nay, it is obligatory upon all souls to believe in His Holiness as He is

through God's grace, even if they cannot comprehend it. Rather, they should witness His grace as the grace of the Lord of Glory upon all beings. Glory be to God above what they describe.

The third [degree of knowledge] is recognition of the Gates—and in this station it is obligatory to acknowledge the Successorship of the Prince of the Believers, peace be upon him. In this realm there exists naught without interval save His holy Self. And all the aforementioned degrees in the knowledge of meanings are obligatory in this station, with their conditions and pillars. And this means that in all these stations thou must know the holy Being Who bears absolute Sovereignty to be the servant of the Messenger of God, peace be upon Him and His family. Indeed, the absolute sovereignty of that Most Great Lord is His very Successorship to Muhammad, peace be upon Him and His family. And none hath comprehended the essence of the knowledge of His Holiness save the One God and the Most Great Lord, the Messenger of God, peace be upon Him and His family.

And He is the absolute Gate of God, through whose permission alone can any word of creation come into being, and no letter can ascend unto God except by His decree. And the knowledge of His Holiness is identical to the knowledge of the Messenger of God, peace be upon Him and His family. Indeed, the word of unity and the testimony to prophethood are themselves acknowledgment of His Holiness' sovereignty. By the decree that none knoweth the Essence save Him, and that the Kingdom endureth in the Kingdom, and none can unify Him save Him, and that the knowledge of God was identical to His knowledge, eternally without mention of aught or description of decree.

And this is the pure religion of God: that the servant should believe that His Holiness is a created and sustained servant, and hath no life except by God's leave. And whosoever believeth aught regarding His Holiness save absolute servitude is undoubtedly an infidel. And all the words of His Holiness concerning divine knowledge and His own station return to this point of justice. And His Holiness, may my spirit be sacrificed for Him, hath been the Shirt of Light, and the House of Manifestation, and the Sign of the Worshipped One, and the Public Declaration of Ahmad, peace be upon Him and His family. Indeed He was He after there was no he in Him, nor He other than they.

Glorified then be God, His Creator, above what they describe. This much the servant of my Lord must believe with certainty regarding His Holiness. Thereafter, any description other than the Ahmadic station that one attributes to His Holiness is fitting and true. Indeed, all existence in the presence of His Holiness, whether in life or in death, is pure nothingness, and if mentioned is like a ring in His hand. And He is above the praise of those who speak and the comprehension of those who perceive. And He is the one who was patient in God's religion and bore all that came from God's enemies until He attained the station of martyrdom at the hand of an infidel. We are God's and unto Him do we return. And may God's blessings be upon Him as befitteth Him, verily He is the Most High, the Great.

The fourth [degree of knowledge] is the knowledge of the Imamate. And in this station it is incumbent upon all beings to know the twelve holy Souls who were the representatives of absolute sovereignty. And the stations mentioned in the knowledge of meanings are, as they are, obligatory in this rank. And their holy names, which are the mirrors of explanation, are these: Al-Hasan ibn Ali, Al-Husayn ibn Ali, Ali ibn Al-Husayn, Muhammad ibn Ali, Ja'far ibn Muhammad, Musa ibn Ja'far, Ali ibn Musa, Muhammad ibn Ali, Ali

ibn Muhammad, Al-Hasan ibn Ali, and the Proof, the Qa'im, Muhammad ibn Al-Hasan, the Lord of the Age.

And upon Fatima the Most Truthful be the blessings of God upon them all. These suns of grandeur and stars of might have, in every aspect, stood in the place of the Messenger of God, may God's blessings be upon Him and His family—whether in performance, in judgment, in confirmation, or in origination. Their will in every station is identical to the will of the Commander of the Faithful, peace be upon him. Indeed, the verse "they will not except as God wills" is true regarding them, through the love of God and His good-pleasure. How can the pen move to describe their attributes, when it itself bears witness to its utter inadequacy in their station? It is incumbent upon the believer in the Family of God, peace be upon them, to regard the relationship of the phrase "there is no god but God" as one in relation to all created things.

And regarding their own stations, the precedence of some over others is mentioned in the traditions, such as the excellence of Hassan over Hussein, peace be upon them both, and the excellence of the Imam of the Age, the Lord of the Era, peace be upon him, over the other Imams, blessings of God be upon them, and the excellence of the Eight Letters over the Holy Leaf from the Primal Tree, who was Fatima, blessings of God be upon her. These ranks are due to their proximity to the Act of God, and none can reckon them save the Lord of the worlds. Belief in their return is a pillar of faith in them, and today the existence of all things is by the will of the Remnant of God, the Imam of the Age, peace be upon him.

Belief in his occultation is like belief in the return, and among the greatest signs of the return is the appearance of the Commander of the Faithful's form upon the orb of the sun—though it exists now, but is veiled from the eyes of creation. And on the day of the approaching manifestation, by the blessing of that True Sun, the cover shall be removed from all eyes, God willing. The detailed ranks of this station are infinite unto infinity, and it is for the Lord to expound and inspire, and for the servants to submit and be assured. These clear indications suffice for the believer in the Family of God, peace be upon them, and they are an excellent helper for the servant of infallibility. Trust in them suffices as a guardian for myself and for the souls of the believers.

The fifth [degree of knowledge] is knowledge of the Pillars, like the stations mentioned in the rank of inner meanings, and the degrees that pertain to this station. In this rank, certainty in the existence of all Prophets, Successors, verses and their books is incumbent upon the believer, that he may be assured that the realities of the hearts of the Prophets and Successors were created from the light of the noble form of Fatima, peace be upon her, and they guide to God through her and her light. The pillars of this chain in prophethood are the four Prophets endowed with constancy, who are Noah, Abraham, Moses and Jesus, peace be upon them. The rank of Imamate that exists in their realities is utter nothingness before the Imamate of the Family of God, peace be upon them.

In every age the existence of pillars is necessary, just as from the mission of the Messenger of God and His family until the days of the return, four prophets were the pillars for receiving grace, and they are Jesus, Khidr, Elias and Enoch, peace be upon them. All receive grace from the Imam of the Age, peace be upon him, and acknowledgment of them is from the foundation of religion. The ranks of acknowledgment of this station exceed mention and expression. And God encompasses all. Nay, this is a glorious Qur'an inscribed on a preserved tablet.

The sixth [degree of knowledge] is the knowledge of the Nuqaba (Chiefs). Know thou that the Path of God extends through this station. They are nearest to the Imam through the Pillars, from among all created things. No fixed number is prescribed for them. Without their existence, grace reaches no one. Their minimum number is one, and their maximum thirty. Nay, should God will it, even more than that is possible. Even now there are those who attain the presence of the Imam of the Age, peace be upon him, as mentioned in the tradition:

> "How excellent is the pure abode. With thirty there is no loneliness."

They are never veiled from the presence of the Imam of the Age—may God hasten his days—for less than the twinkling of an eye. They behold none save him, and knowledge of them through the seven aforementioned stations is obligatory. However, these seven stations are interwoven in their rank, as they are interwoven in the final rank of the Pillars, just as in the Pillars up to the station of Ahmad—peace be upon him and his family—the matter remains concealed.

The nobility of man lies in knowledge of this station, and his nearness to God the All-Knowing stems from nearness to the Source. For it is possible in the mystery of this rank that one might surpass another without knowledge or deeds, but rather through the nobility of precedence in existence and nearness to the Worshipped One. The obstacles of this rank are beyond counting or mention.

The greatest sign of knowledge of the Nuqaba is knowledge and deeds concerning the Family of God—peace be upon them. They dwell among the people and associate with them, yet none knows them except some of the Nujaba who recognize some of them. Even their own families and children know them not. When one of them passes away, God the All-Knowing casts into the heart of one who is worthy to become his successor and attain the presence of that Most Great Luminary—may my soul be sacrificed for him. By God's leave, they are the bearers of grace in creation and legislation. The training of the Nujaba is entrusted to them. They have power over wondrous signs and remarkable marvels, yet they manifest none without the Imam's permission, peace be upon him.

They manage the earth and all upon it by the Imam's leave, peace be upon him. Their vision of the Proof, peace be upon him, is a vision of the heart, which is identical to physical vision with these same eyes. Wherever they may be on earth, they are present in the pure and blessed land. Should anyone acknowledge the five stations of knowledge but deny this station or any soul among them, all his knowledge would be as scattered dust, for the thread of knowledge has been ordained in this pattern. No deed of any doer shall be accepted save through knowledge of this station, as it is and as befits its people. It is obligatory upon all servants to act with mercy and love toward all, lest they deviate from the path of servitude in dealing with the people of the letter Lam.

Knowledge of the name and person of each is not incumbent upon all save for one person, as none knows them. Yes, it is possible that if one asks the Imam, peace be upon him, for their names, and he reveals them either in sleep or through true possible circumstances whereby the servant becomes certain of their authenticity, and whoever gains knowledge receives a portion.

The seventh [degree of knowledge] is the knowledge of the Nujaba—and the perils of this station are neither comprehended nor mentioned. The Nujaba are servants who, after the Nuqaba, have received

divine grace in the chain of existence—and from them it flows to all creation. Their number is not specified in the words of the Household of the Prophet, peace be upon them. Some of the people of the Bayan have recorded their number as forty, but the truth is that there is no specific number. They are, during the occultation of the Imam, peace be upon him, scholars who convey divine ordinances to the people. No share of meeting the Eternal Sun has been written for them, except as God may will. However, in dreams they attain the presence of His Holiness the Imam, peace be upon him, and receive divine ordinances. No one knows these noble ones by name or lineage. Rather, all people are gathered with them, and they convey divine grace to all through the Nuqaba, in both creation and legislation.

The sign of knowledge of them is that they are related to a word, the lightest of which is not uttered in contingent existence. Indeed, the number of the letter "Ha," which is the mystery of letters and the station of unity, is the number of that good word, which is the very manifestation of "Ha" in the station of letters.

Today these near ones of the Most Exalted Horizon are veiled from people's sight. Indeed, some of them have been rejected and reviled by certain human devils, who know not what they do. Most men and women of the Twelver sect will enter hellfire due to their lack of recognition of this station. If a soul accepts with certainty all six ranks but denies the decisive point in this station among the seven mentioned stations regarding the knowledge of one of the Nujaba, all their deeds become void and scattered dust.

Indeed, the knowledge of God in the station of manifestation is not complete except through the knowledge of these seven. As soon as a servant becomes certain of these stations and receives their duties from one who is divinely supported, they need have no fear, for they will assuredly be forgiven, God willing.

It is incumbent upon all to act with love toward all people, lest they enter into rejection of one of these near ones. For rejection of one of them is rejection of all, and recognition of one of them is recognition of all.

They are the men who preserve the traditions of the Imam, peace be upon him. Rejection of them is rejection of the Lord of the worlds, and obedience to them is obedience to Him.

In the station of brotherhood, it is incumbent upon all that whatever they desire for their believing self, they should desire for their brother who is with them in the fourth particle. There is no brotherhood between one who denies the fourth particle. Rather, it is incumbent upon the believer to use their forbearance to make the denier believe in this firm principle, which is part of the fundamentals of religion.

The conduct of servitude and the journey toward God has been mentioned in detail in the scroll of the Two Sanctuaries. It behooves all who seek advancement to act upon it. And the brief point of conduct for all is that they move in every condition for God's sake.

The recognition of this matter is exceedingly difficult and momentous. How often does a person act, in his own belief, for God's sake, yet is in fact an unbeliever, moving in reality out of enmity towards God. Such

are the deeds of the Sunni group, who act, in their own belief, for God's sake, yet are unbelievers, and God is innocent of their deeds.

Indeed, in reality their orientation is not towards God, but towards idols and false deities. As the Qur'an states that they say: "By God, we desired only good," yet God revealed their denial in the Qur'an.

And like them are those who deny and revile Shaykh Munfarid in the station of unity (may God's mercy be upon him), and his successor and those who love him. Though they act, in their own belief, for God's sake, Satan has made truth appear as falsehood in their eyes.

And according to the explicit tradition, a Nasibi is one who denies our Shi'ihs. And there is no doubt among the possessors of wisdom that that unique one is like unto a pure Shi'ih.

And the judgment of those who deny the Shi'ihs of the family of God will be made manifest in the Return, God willing. And today their judgment in association is like unto the judgment of pardoned blood. And God is sufficient and witness to all, and He is the Most High, the Most Great.

Chapter Four: On the Explanation of the Return unto God, Mighty and Glorious

I counsel all in this book to fear the justice of God, and not to take lightly the denial of those drawn nigh to the Supreme Concourse. And according to the command of the Qur'an: "O ye who believe! Fear God and speak a straightforward word," guard your tongue, for the life of this world compared to the life of the hereafter is as nothing. And on the Day of Resurrection, by the one true God Who hath no partner, the severest punishment and greatest chastisement shall be for those who cast satanic words at the people of the knowledge of the family of God, peace be upon them. Nay, in this world, were they to witness God's judgment, they would burn in the fire of justice at the moment of denial and rejection. As the all-knowing God hath indicated: "Did ye but know with certainty of knowledge, ye would behold hell-fire. Again, ye will behold it with certainty of sight. Then shall ye be questioned that Day about the delights." And these are they who are in delight in this world and the next, and these are they who are truly heedless.

O concourse of religious leaders and scholars of certainty! Fear the judgment of this noble verse in every condition: "And verily hell shall encompass the unbelievers." And God the All-Knowing is in every condition All-Knowing and Witness, and He is the Absolute Independent One. And I seek forgiveness from Him as I deserve, and He is the Kind, the Merciful. And know, O questioner, that the foundation of religion is the recognition of the seven matters commanded in the tradition, and the laws of the Return and the hereafter are also recorded under its shadow. Indeed, these seven ranks of recognition are the judgment of the seven holy paradises. And the laws of the Return are in the next world, and the obligations of that world are like unto the obligations of this world, letter by letter, and certainty in the Return and the gathering of spirits and bodies, and the stations which God the All-Knowing hath ordained after death.

Recognition of God is part of certitude. And whosoever denies any aspect of the sacred law which is binding in this world, or any word concerning the stations of the next world which pertain to existence after death, is as one who has denied the unity of God. Affirmation of all aspects of this world, from the ascension and its prescribed stations to the laws that lie beyond it, is in all stations obligatory like belief in

divine unity. Belief in His ascension in His physical body, with His garments and sandals, is obligatory and certain. And belief in the tradition and intention regarding Humayra is likewise obligatory in this station—that at the hour of ascension the Prophet was in His house. Indeed, at that very hour He ascended bodily to the kingdom of the heavens and earths, while simultaneously remaining physically in His place.

The explanation of this matter and mention of the resurrection and the doubts of philosophers and sages has been made in the Sahifiy-i-Sharh Du'a-i-Ghayb [Sahifiy-i-Ja'fariyyih]. It suffices that man look to the power and action of God. He will then affirm these matters with absolute certitude, even if he cannot fully comprehend them.

One who claims spirits return without bodies shows lack of knowledge of the Most Holy Essence of the Lord of Might. That which has become widespread among people—that the late Shaykh Ahmad, may God sanctify his dust, did not believe in bodily return—is pure falsehood. The source of this doubt is from religious students who did not understand the words of that pole of the realm of hearts. Rather, that one established upon the throne of unity in the paradise of rafraf before God is innocent of believing such a thing. Indeed he affirms the return of all things, through a knowledge that encompasses the Book of God—the heart in its station, the mind in its station, the soul in its station, and the body with the three in its station. Whoever deviates from this is among the polytheists.

Know that certainty in the existence of paradise and hell is also obligatory. In both are creatures, as God wills, who entered their stations after resurrection and gathering, before the existence of this wondrous cycle. The origin of paradise and its blessings was created from the light of the Prince of Martyrs. One who knows the truth of His station sees himself in paradise and partakes of its blessings, even while in this world. Do not imagine this refers to something internal and imaginary. No, by God! Rather in truth, were the veil lifted from your eyes, you would witness the stations of paradise just as you witness the created things of this world, just as Musa ibn Ja'far (peace be upon them both) showed to Harun's servant girl.

By the God in whose hand is my soul—due to the perfection of my certainty in God's existence, were all veils to be lifted, my certainty would not increase. I see with the knowledge of certainty, in this land of unity where I sit, all the blessings of paradise and its stations, like one established upon raised couches in paradise. If you wish to witness and drink from the Kawthar in this limited world, visit Husayn ibn Ali ibn Abi Talib (peace be upon them both). For by God, at the time of visitation and belief in this matter, you will have drunk from the spring of God's hand in the cup of God's Messenger (peace be upon him and his family). So blessed are you, rather blessed are those who perceive.

The sincere ones can distinguish the stations of the people of Paradise by their words, and judge them in this world by their deeds. Yet God is witness that despite these manifest stations, time has not grieved me to such an extent that it can be mentioned. The divines of this age, in truth, can only confess their powerlessness, due to their inability to comprehend my words. Nevertheless, that which was decreed came to pass. The human devils who were incapable of producing a single tradition have dared to pronounce God's judgment, and have committed acts unprecedented in creation.

Should an observer behold the reality with insight, he would see that the number of the inverse letters 'yad' bore all the letters of negation in the face. This, despite knowing that whoever leads a single soul

astray is as though he has led all humanity astray and slain them. Sufficient is the testimony of God, the Almighty, against the perpetrators, and sufficient for their helper is the man who seized the verses of divine judgment. And the enmity of the Family of God, peace be upon them, shall face them on the Day of Resurrection. Soon shall the wrongdoers know what fate awaits them. Nay, should they turn to their own souls and witness the grandeur of God's justice, they would surely read the Book with certitude. This very judgment is hotter for their hearts than the fire of hell, did ye but know. Were ye to know with the certainty of knowledge, ye would see the Hellfire. Then would ye see it with the eye of certainty. Then, on that Day, shall ye be questioned about the bounties. I know that whatever has passed in God's knowledge shall come to pass, but the Day of Meeting is in God's hands. And I say, by the decree of the Qur'an:

> "Nothing will befall us save what God has prescribed for us. He is our Protector, and in God let the faithful put their trust."

By the truth of the Most Great Lord, may my soul be sacrificed for Him, I long for death more intensely than a suckling babe for its mother's breast. Verily, there is no power nor strength save in God, and to God do we belong and to Him shall we return. The wrongdoers shall soon know what fate awaits them, and think not that God is unaware of what the wrongdoers do.

Know, O questioner, that matters of belief concerning the Hereafter are beyond counting. It is incumbent upon those who believe in the eight Paradises to believe with certainty in the six Precincts and their people, and to believe in the seven Hells and their stations.

Know that the fruit of belief in these and their people is this: that in this world, one should conduct oneself with love and mercy toward the people of Paradise, and deal with the people of each rank according to their stations as ordained by the Lord of Might. Should one explain the mysteries of the knowledge of the people of Ridvan to the people of the Paradise of Peace, one would have strayed far from perfect faith and wronged them. Nay, it is incumbent upon the believer in God to explain the stations of the people of the eight Paradises as they are, according to what is befitting them.

There is no doubt that were the knowledge of the Paradise of Oneness to be bestowed upon the people of the seven Paradises, they would all become polytheists and be expelled from Paradise. And likewise are the ordinances of the people of the Paradises to the people of the Precincts. How mighty is the conduct of the pure servant in this world with all creation, for every soul deserves a particular kind of bounty for each thing. The example of the believer is the station of the All-Merciful, who bestows equally upon all from the throne of bounty. So, too, is the decree regarding the people of hell and its confines, and the stations which God, the All-Knowing, has ordained for the infidels. And whenever in this world the rejection and denial that is destined for those of the first station is given to those of the second, injustice has occurred. Nay, it is incumbent upon the believer in God to dissociate himself secretly, openly and in all ways from the people of hell and its confines. And if, God forbid, due to love of anything, one hesitates in rejecting them, he has instantly entered the fire, and the verse "verily hell encompasses the unbelievers" is true regarding him.

And none of the seven stations of mystic knowledge pointing to the knowledge of the hereafter are acceptable except through dissociation from the enemies of all these stations. And if anyone doubts the

judgment of dissociation from any one of these enemies, he himself is an enemy, and the Cause of God is far greater and more exalted than can be indicated. And if anyone dissociates from the enemies of these seven stations but does not dissociate from the enemy of the station of the connecting point in the final rank, he is surely a polytheist.

And the matter is exceedingly difficult, while the Law is easy and tolerant. Nothing easier than the letter of the word "Gate" has been revealed in the Word of God regarding its tolerance. And this is evidence of the mystery of the Cause. Those possessed of understanding know that what is here can only be known through what is there.

And belief in the questioning of the grave and its pressure, and the world of Barzakh, and the Day of Resurrection, and the Balance, and the Bridge, and the Reckoning, and the conditions of the gathering place, in the manner transmitted in the words of the Immaculate Ones, peace be upon them, is obligatory. And elaboration of the stations causes the servant to be veiled.

The prayer mentioned in the fifth gate encompasses all stations of belief, such that after reciting it, the servant has acted according to the fundamental principles of his religion. And this prayer suffices all in the station of belief. And in every state be aware of God's Bada' and justice, which is the greatest of all stations of good.

And take all the indications made in these four gates regarding the fundamental principles of religion, and know them as the leaves of the Blessed Tree. And behave with your women in the most excellent way of love, for believing women are the leaves of the camphor tree in Paradise. And harm them not even with a glance, for to the extent of that glance you will be veiled from God's decree.

And in every state be prepared for the meeting with God, for death is nearer to man than all things. And avert your gaze from the world and its ornaments, for all the pleasures of this world compared to one hour of the next world are pure torment. And be certain in all indications, and the extent of certainty is that you fear no one given God's existence in His obedience and decree.

And these four gates suffice all in the station of belief. And God encompasses all from beyond, nay, it is a glorious Qur'an in a preserved tablet.

Chapter Five: Concerning the Prayer of Sincerity to God, Mighty and Glorious

In the Name of God, the Most High, the Most Great

Praise be to God Who brought forth the heavens and earth by His command. Then those who disbelieve in His signs shall be gathered unto God. O God! I bear witness unto Thee, as Thou dost bear witness unto Thyself before all things, that Thou art God, the One, the Self-Subsisting, the Ever-Living, the Self-Sustaining. No description of anything can grasp Thee, nor can any mention of anything define Thee. Thou hast ever been without the existence of anything, and wilt ever remain without reference to anything. And now Thou art as Thou hast been in the eternity of eternities. Nothing was with Thee, nor can anything be mentioned in Thy station.

Glorified, glorified art Thou! None can know Thee as befits Thy true essence, nor can any servant worship Thee as befits Thy reality. I testify before Thee in this my station that Thy Self points to absolute severance and prevention, and Thy Being bears witness to complete restraint and despair. Every description returns to the station of Thy creation, and every attribute points to the station of Thy invention. If I say "Thou art Thou," I have but compared like with like, for Thou canst not be known through Oneness. And if I say "He is He," I have but indicated Unity through Majesty, for Thou canst not be described through Identity.

Glorified, glorified art Thou, O my God! None hath any way unto Thee—neither through mention, nor certitude, nor praise, nor explanation, nor through inability, nor through names, nor through attributes. I seek Thy forgiveness, O my God, in this hour when the Angel of Death descends by Thy leave, for all that Thy knowledge encompasses about me and Thy Book enumerates. O my God, Thou knowest my secret and my public self. I have never denied Thy unity, and if I have done evil, I seek Thy forgiveness and turn unto Thee. All hope hath been cut off from me in that state from all things, and I find no helper for myself other than Thee alone, there is no God but Thee.

O God! I believe in Thy justice and Thy origination, and verily, O my God, if Thou shouldst punish me with all Thy punishment for all eternity, by the permanence of Thy Essence, as recompense for my mention before Thee, I would deserve that, for Thou art praised in Thy deeds and obeyed in Thy judgment. I have no intercessor other than Thyself, so forgive me, O God, through Thy generosity and mercy, for Thou art independent of my punishment, while I am in desperate need of Thy forgiveness. If Thou shouldst abandon me, I would surely be among the perishing ones. Send down victory upon me in that hour through Thy origination and Thy presence, and through the forgiveness of Thy angels and the descent of Thy mercy, for Thou art who Thou art.

My breath hath been cut off from me, and I am who I am, so do with me as Thou art who Thou art. Verily, Thou art the Lord of bounty, generosity, might, grace, sovereignty, utterance, favors, and grandeur. There is no God but Thee and no creator for me besides Thee. Thou art the Lord of might over all creation.

I bear witness, O my God, to Muhammad, Thy Beloved, Thy Messenger, Thy Chosen One, and Thy Best Beloved, to his Prophethood, to all that Thou hast ordained regarding his station, making him stand in Thy stead in performance, decree, origination and execution, and all that Thy knowledge encompasses concerning him, and what Thou hast sent down to him of the Qur'an and Thy verses, and what Thou hast prescribed for him of Thy laws and stations, and how Thou hast honored him on the Night of Ascension with Thy signs and evidences, and what Thou hast sent down concerning the decree of his religion which overshadows all. Verily, Thou art witness over all things.

O God! I believe in him, in his Book, in all his obligations and traditions, and in what Thou hast sent down to him of Thy pure religion. I bear witness that he hath delivered that which was entrusted to him of Thy revelation, and hath counseled truly regarding the Cause among his people. May God reward him according to his obedience to Thee and his love for Thee. O God! Send Thy blessings upon him with all Thy prayers, benedictions, gifts and signs, through Thy grace which Thou hast made the grace of Muhammad, may the peace of God be upon him and his family, over all creation. And I bear witness to the successors of Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family after him, to Ali, then after him to

Hassan, then Husayn (4); then after Husayn, Ali (4); then after Ali, Muhammad; then after Muhammad, Ja'far (4); then after Ja'far, Musa; then after Musa, Ali (4); then after Ali, Muhammad; then after Muhammad, Ali (4); then after Ali, Hasan (4); then after Hasan, the Master of the Age, Thy Proof and Thy Remnant. May Thy blessings be upon them all.

And I bear witness that they stand in the station of Thy Beloved in all things, save that Letter which Thou hast specially assigned unto Him alone among His successors. And I bear witness that they have been the repositories of Thy knowledge, the treasuries of Thy grandeur, the seats of Thy glory and the signs of Thy oneness from all eternity. None precedes them in nobility, nor equals them in rank. Therefore, O my God, bless them as they have proclaimed Thy unity, upheld Thy Faith, and endured tribulation in Thy path. And I bear witness that they are Thy honored servants who speak not until He hath spoken, and who act by Thy command. And I bear witness that their Qa'im, Thy blessings be upon Him, is Thy Proof and my true Imam.

Through Him do I turn to Thee, through Him do I hold fast to Thy cord, through Him do I hope to attain Thy presence, and through Him do I seek Thy good pleasure. O God, aid him who seeks Him, and abandon him who knows not His right and denies His servant. Verily, Thou art knowing of all things. And I bear witness that their followers have been the champions of Thy Faith, the bearers of Thy Book, the interpreters of Thy revelation, and the pillars of Thy unity. And I hereby believe in their hidden and manifest aspects, their first and their last, their outward and their inward, their living and their dead, their present and their absent, their foremost and their greatest, even as they are through Thy grace. Therefore, O God, send down upon them Thy mercy and Thy blessings as Thou art what Thou art. Verily, Thou art the Mighty, the Wise.

And I bear witness that today, obedience to Thy servant, Thy Proof, whom Thou hast honored with Thy signs and established in the station of those near to Thy chosen ones, is obligatory by Thy decree. And I recognize His right and am free from all His enemies. And I bear witness that He hath conveyed that which was entrusted to Him from the bounty of Thy Expected Remnant, and that He is among those who believe in Thee and in Thy signs. Therefore, O God, reward Him in Thy Faith as Thou art what Thou art, and forgive those who acknowledge His authority as Thou art what Thou art, and abandon those who show enmity towards Him as Thou art what Thou art. Verily, Thou knowest all things, and nothing is hidden from Thee in the heavens and the earth, and Thou art witness over all things.

And I bear witness that death is true, and the questioning in the grave from the pillars of Thy Faith is true, and the resurrection is true, and the reckoning is true, and Paradise is true, and the Fire is true, and that the Hour will come, there is no doubt about it, and Thou wilt raise those who are in the graves, in the return of Thy chosen ones and the day of the passing of Thy servants. Nothing escapes Thy knowledge, and Thou art the Self-Sufficient, the Praiseworthy.

O my God, I hereby bear witness before Thee to all that Thou lovest as Thou lovest it, and to all that Thou abhorrest as Thou abhorrest it, and that these words constitute my belief before Thee. By them do I live, and upon them shall I die by Thy leave, and through them shall I be raised, God willing, before Thee. Therefore, make them by Thy leave a trust with Thee now, and return them to me through Thy grace in times of fear, and make them for me signs of intimacy in tokens of remoteness. For Thou art the Ever-

Living, the Self-Subsisting, the Powerful, the One, the Eternal, the Single, the Unique, Who begets not nor is begotten, and there is none like unto Thee nor equal to Thee. And Thou art God, the Lord of all worlds. I bear witness that there is no God but God, and I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant and His Messenger, and I bear witness that Ali and His successors and Fatima, God's blessings be upon them, are God's trustees and His beloved ones. And I bear witness that Ali was the servant of God's Remnant in every preserved tablet.

Send down Thy blessings, O my God, unto Muhammad and the family of Muhammad. And verily I speak through Thy wisdom concerning what Thou hast sent down in the Qur'an for the remembrance of the people of Paradise. And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00039: Risala Furu' al-'Adliyya (Epistle of Justice: Branches)

Introduction

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

I bear witness that there is no God but God, alone with no partner, and I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant and His Messenger. O God, bestow Thy blessings upon Muhammad and the family of Muhammad. Peace be upon you, O people of God, and the mercy of God and His blessings. Peace be upon you, O people of Ta-Sin-Mim, and the mercy of God and His blessings. Peace be upon you, O people of Ta-Ha, and the mercy of God and His blessings. Peace be upon you, O people of Ya-Sin, and the mercy of God and His blessings. Peace be upon you, O people of the House of Power, the dwelling place of the Perfect Word, the mine of glory, the manifestation of sovereignty, and the mercy of God and His blessings. Peace be upon you, O people of the Divine Will and its sister, the pillar of destiny and its place, the ordainer of execution and its wisdom, the enumerator of the Book and its verses, and the mercy of God and His blessings.

O people of God! How can I count your praises after God has placed the door of praise between me and you? And how can I fail to mention your bounties when God has placed nothing between me and you? But since praise of you has been enjoined upon the servant, accept my transgressions against you and remember my sins in your presence. I beseech your generosity to forgive my existence and its effects, for my very life in your sanctuary is the greatest sin, with which no other sin can compare. How much more so when sin begets another sin! I know well that your generosity has ever been most exalted and your grace will forever remain most glorious. None need ask for your pardon, for knowledge of your forgiveness after recognition of your station would be the greatest pardon in my right, with which no other pardon can compare.

Had you dealt with me according to my first mention of you, neither I nor my turning away would have caused all things to perish. But when I witnessed your forbearance and your gifts toward me, I must mention some aspect of your generosity concerning me, that my heart may be sweetened by your remembrance and my innermost being illumined by gratitude to you.

O people of God! Strengthen me through your remembrance—your remembrance, then your thanks—your thanks, then your glory—your glory, then your grace—your grace, then your holiness—your holiness, then your knowledge—your knowledge, then your love—your love, then your good pleasure—your good pleasure. For what could be sweeter in my secret and public life than your manifestation?

O people of God! How can I praise you when That which is That is like the reflection of mirrors that existed in mirrors with you, and nothing has existence before you? I bear witness that the Will has willed through your will, that Purpose has been determined through your purpose, that Destiny has been ordained through your power, that Decree has been decreed through your execution, that the Divine Plan has been realized after being perfected before it was mentioned, through your beneficence, that Permission has been granted through the permission of your glory, that the Term has been completed through the permission of your praise, and that the Book has been sent down from the clouds of justice of your verses.

By what description shall I remember you after knowing that description is cut off from your essence? By what attribute shall I quiet my heart after being certain that attributes are prevented from your reality? The signs of the divine cloud have been manifested through the appearance of your revelation, and the signs of praise have been effaced from the inmost depths of your manifestation, and the stations of glory have been magnified through the traces of your mercy, and the birds of paradise have sung from the leaves of the verses of your might.

So glory be unto God, your Creator! Not a letter of your praise has been known, nor has anyone uttered aught of praise in your presence save that which returns unto himself. Blessed is the servant who has recognized your station and has not transgressed his bounds. I testify that when one of your followers was made manifest upon the Mount in the eternal Day, all realities and their traces were found, and hearts fled to their stations, and the gardens and their lights were created, and hell and all therein were set ablaze, and all declared in unison: “There is no God but God!”—glorified be He above all that they attribute unto Him.

I call you to witness, O my Masters, that I have believed in you and in your signs and in whatsoever has been sent down in every condition from the signs of your grace and the clouds of your power. Have mercy upon me through your glance, preserve me through your power, cause me to return in the days of your return, and forgive me on the day of the manifestation of your sovereignty upon the most great plain. For verily I am your servant and your visitor, seeking refuge in your dust and beseeching your intercession through love for you. Write down in my behalf and in behalf of whosoever seeks you with justice, O people of grace, that which befits your power and might. Verily I declare: You are sufficient unto me, sufficient unto me in every condition. Glory be unto God, your Creator, above all that they attribute unto Him, and praise be unto God, the Lord of the worlds.

The Eighth Chapter, concerning that which God has ordained before prayer, including:

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Know that God does not burden any soul beyond its capacity, nor does He compel anyone in any matter. All deeds are the servants’ acts of worship to God their Creator, such that if anyone were to worship God

according to their pure nature, undistracted by worldly affairs, they would worship God in pure faith according to what God has ordained, without having to learn from anyone. This is a token of God's grace to His servants.

Know that prayer is the first fruit of religion and upon it revolve all deeds. It is the first thing God made obligatory upon His servants. In its entirety within God's Book, it is the temple of unity springing from the heart. None shall be accepted who does not know its laws, and none shall be elevated save through observing all its stations. Indeed it is difficult except for those who are humble, as mentioned in the Furqan. None can draw near to God through anything like it. In God's Book it is an obligation from Him and a tradition from His Prophet Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family.

The first obligatory prayer is the noon prayer of four rak'ahs, then the afternoon prayer likewise, then the sunset prayer of three rak'ahs, then the night prayer like the first, then the dawn prayer of half that, then the Friday prayer during the days of occultation which is two rak'ahs—a prayer revealed by God with its laws. Today this prayer is not permitted to anyone except myself and those whom I judge to be righteous, those who follow my verses and in whom God has established true justice. For others, if they are righteous it is incumbent upon them, otherwise God will question them about it on the Day of Resurrection, for it is the station of the trustees as explained in the prayer of the Scripture [du'at al-sahifah].

Then there is the prayer for solar eclipse, lunar eclipse, earthquakes, and for every wondrous sign that descends from heaven or occurs on earth by God's leave. Then the circumambulation prayer for obligatory pilgrimage and lesser pilgrimage and women's circumambulation. Then what becomes obligatory through vows or covenants or what is prescribed in the Book. Each of these prayers in God's Book consists of two obligatory rak'ahs. These are God's bounds regarding obligatory prayers.

Then God's decree regarding recommended prayers: God has prescribed for the believers eight rak'ahs before and after noon prayer, then the same number for afternoon prayer, then half that number after sunset prayer, then a quarter after night prayer, then eleven rak'ahs in the last third of every night, then before dawn prayer the same number. These are God's bounds for each day and night. What is beyond this is not counted in the Book.

The closest prayers after these are the prayer of Ghadir day, then the prayer of Mubahila day, then the additional prayers, then the circumambulation prayers, then what was revealed regarding Muhammad, Ali, Fatima, Salman and Ja'far, peace be upon them, then what was revealed for the nights of God's month and what was detailed before and after it from the family of God, peace be upon them. These are God's bounds regarding recommended prayers, and none of them consists of more than two rak'ahs each.

Let none perform prayer except through two cycles of prostration, and when they understand the ordinances of God as revealed concerning prayer, it cannot be deemed valid without its obligatory requirements. Among these is God's decree concerning purification from ritual impurities, which comprises eleven conditions: sleep that overcomes hearing and when the heart perceives with certainty the absence of awareness; unconsciousness and illness that prevents remembrance; that which issues

from the two extremities of man except under certain conditions, for in these there is no obligation; then what becomes necessary through sexual intercourse; menstruation, irregular bleeding and post-partum bleeding in women; and touching the bodies of deceased believers after they have grown cold and before their purification. This is God's ordinance in His Book.

God has ordained for the purification from these conditions the laws of ablution, washing, and the use of clean earth when water cannot be found or when its use would be harmful. He has ordained ablution for sleep, unconsciousness, illness that prevents prayer, and for what issues from the two extremities except for major impurity. Its limits in the Book of God are washing the face with water—the face being defined in God's Book as from the hairline to the chin and what is encompassed by two fingers in a circular motion—then washing the hands from the elbow to the fingertips, with the right preceding the left, maintaining continuity as decreed in the Book. Then wiping the head with wet hands to the extent of three joined fingers from the forehead to the hairline once, then wiping the feet from the tips of the toes to the ankles. These are God's limits concerning ablution. It is valid to wash the face and hands twice according to tradition, but thrice washing and immersion are not found in the Book. These are God's just limits—transgress them not.

Beyond this, the Book prescribes full washing, which is obligatory in seven cases: after sexual intercourse; for the state of pilgrimage for men and women; washing after menstruation for women; touching the bodies of deceased believers before their purification; washing the deceased believers—men, women and children. What is beyond this that appears in traditions with words of obligation is according to custom, and these are numbered washings that none should abandon except with just cause.

For major ritual impurity no ablution is required, but the body must be purified with water before washing. In this case both immersion and sequential washing are valid with proper conditions. For other cases, one must perform ablution first, then wash the head to the end of the neck three times with three handfuls of water—less than this is not valid—then the right side, then the left side in this sequence. Continuity is not required. In God's Book, for the believer in washing and ablution, a small amount of water like oil suffices when water is scarce. The ruling is the same for men and women. We have detailed the ordinances concerning major ritual impurity and similar matters previously in the Book. These are God's limits—transgress them not.

God has ordained the use of clean earth in place of ablution and washing for men and women when commanded by God after water cannot be found or when its use would be harmful. And know that, according to God's decree, prayer is not valid except with pure earth. If this is not possible, then it is valid with particles of earth as they exist. It is obligatory during the act to form the intention of pure devotion to God, glorified be He. Then one should strike the earth with both hands, raise them, shake them off, and then pass them over the face from the hairline to the tip of the nose, then wipe the backs of both hands.

This is God's ordinance concerning the substitute for ablution. For the ritual bath, it is obligatory to strike one's hands upon the earth twice, as is clearly stated in the two traditions.

Having learned some of God's ordinances, know the ruling concerning water: that it is pure and purifying according to the decree of the Qur'an. The water of heaven, the sea, and flowing springs never becomes impure. As for other waters, if impurity overcomes the water such that its essential nature is changed—whether in color, taste or smell—it is not valid for anyone to use it for anything. However, if the impurity has not changed it and it amounts to a kurr or more in quantity, then it remains pure and purifying. Indeed, when water reaches the amount of a kurr, nothing can render it impure.

If water is less than a kurr and comes into contact with impurities—whether from the hand of an unbeliever, polytheist, or one who does not believe in the remnant of God, His Lord's proof from the text of the Qur'an; or what emerges from the openings of humans and inedible animals; or carrion; or what was not slaughtered with God's name; or blood, dog, wine, pig, and other things deemed impure by the infallible ones, God's blessings be upon them—then it is not valid for anyone to perform ablutions with it or ritual bathing, unless it is purified according to God's ordinance.

Well water, if it definitely amounts to a kurr, follows the ruling of kurr water except in known cases. If it is less, it should be purified of whatever has fallen into it of things mentioned in the words of the Family of God, God's blessings be upon them. Human impurity is purified when the substance is removed and kurr water or flowing water contacts it. After removal of the substance, if less than kurr water is used, it is obligatory to wash twice with pure water. These are God's limits concerning these just ordinances.

The sun and earth and [transformation and transfer] for animals are purifiers of things under conditions that God and His chosen ones have ordained when implementing them. The blood of the Family of God and what would be impure from others is pure and purifying for the Family of God. Whoever believes their ruling in this is like that of ordinary people has disobeyed their Lord. Among the purifiers in certain cases is what falls before the eyes of the Family of God, even if no scholar has mentioned it. But the matter is evident to those whom God has made witness to the creation of the heavens and earth—it needs no mention. What we have mentioned regarding religious practices suffices for the believers in this chapter. And God is well-informed of what the doers do.

Chapter Nine: Concerning the Laws of Prayer and What Was Revealed in the Furqan Regarding It

In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful

Praise be to God Who hath revealed in His Book the laws governing all things and hath ordained for all things a measure duly measured. He hath enjoined upon the believers that they should turn their faces at the time of prayer towards the Sacred House in the Sacred Mosque, and prayer is not valid unless one stands facing towards the House. The Ka'bah in all its quarters is the qiblih for those who pray in the Sacred Mosque, and its most exalted station lieth between the door of the House and the corner wherein is placed the Black Stone. God hath made the Mosque from all its quarters the qiblih for the people of the Sacred Precinct, and the Sacred Precinct is the qiblih for all the peoples of the earth. These are God's ordinances in justice.

God hath prescribed the noon and afternoon prayers from the time of noon, though the latter followeth the former, and in some lands it is determined by the length of the shadow after its decrease until sunset. The beginning of the time for the evening and night prayers is from the first disappearance of the evening glow in the east until midnight, and the measure of four rak'ahs before sunset and before midnight constitutes the right time for performing the afternoon and night prayers. Then God hath ordained the time after midnight until the break of dawn as the time for the night prayer, and its period is the measure of thirteen rak'ahs before dawn. When the white line appeareth on the horizon of darkness, perform the morning prayer, and its time extendeth until the sun riseth from its station. These are God's ordinances in justice.

Delay not thy prayers from their earliest hours, for if thou prayest at the beginning of the time, God will elevate thy prayers through the prayer of His Proof on earth. If thou delayest without excuse, then upon thee is sin in the Book of God. Beware, beware concerning the time of evening and morning prayers, for whoso performeth the evening prayer after the stars have appeared and the morning prayer after the stars have set, upon him is grievous error in the Book of God. And be watchful at the time of noon, for there the All-Merciful bestoweth His grace upon the honored servants of the family of God who act only according to His command.

When thou desirest to pray, purify thy body and thy garments from all defilements, then ensure thy ground is not usurped according to the Book of God. Then stand facing the House and proclaim the words of the Takbir four times, then the two testimonies twice. The mention of the Guardians and the hidden pillar from the Shi'ih tradition is not obligatory, and whoso uttereth it with the intention of it being an essential part invalidateth his deed, but if one sayeth it out of love for goodly words and remembrance of God's loved ones before Him, it becometh light upon light above all light. Then mention the five revealed phrases twice, then recite the Iqamah of thy prayers like the Adhan except with two fewer Takbirs at the beginning and the connecting phrase at the end, and the addition of the word in its stations.

Then form thy intention purely for God alone, which is that whereby the deed is established, and I love not its utterance by tongue nor its passing through the heart. Then proclaim the Takbiratu'l-Ihram for it is obligatory in the Book of God. Then recite the Fatihah with the Bismillah for it is obligatory, then from the surahs of the Qur'an except those containing obligatory prostration, which are four. Then two surahs, though reciting a surah is not obligatory, but I do not like anyone to abandon it in the religion of God. If you intend one surah but recite another, return to the first except for Surat al-Tawhid and Surat al-Kafirun, for from these it is not valid by God's command.

Recite the verses in prayer with the most beautiful melody God has created in you, and let the letters emerge from their proper places which God has created in you. I dislike affected voices of reciters. Do not follow their errors nor distort your natural form through contortion during recitation, for the letters emerge by God's leave from their proper places, unless you are uncertain about similar letters—in that case you must learn from those who recite verses naturally. Do not take from one with affected knowledge. Do not recite aloud in known instances like Dhuhr and Asr prayers and what God has prescribed otherwise, and do not whisper in designated stations like Maghrib and the first two rak'ahs of Isha and Fajr prayers.

Seek a middle way in optional prayers and similar, such that if you wish you may recite aloud or whisper—these are God's just limits. Recite the Bismillah aloud in every prayer for it is among the signs of believers. Silent recitation is not valid in stations requiring loud recitation unless you do not know God's ruling. If you know and deliberately violate this your prayer is nullified, but if done in forgetfulness there is no blame. When you become aware during recitation, follow God's ruling. Know that standing connected to bowing is a pillar of prayer, and bowing comprises one-third of prayer. Remember God your Lord in bowing with these words three times: "Glory be to my Lord the Great and praise be to Him."

Once suffices, as does any pure remembrance of God the Glorious, but do not abandon blessings upon Muhammad and God's family in the remembrance of bowing and prostration, for they complete glorification, declaration of unity, praise and magnification. Bow in proper form, then stand straight, then prostrate properly on eight bones with your forehead and tip of nose upon the soil of Husayn, peace be upon him. Prostration is permitted on earth and what grows from it except what is eaten or worn. All prostration comprises one-third of prayer. Recite these words if you wish seven times: "Glory be to my Lord Most High and praise be to Him." Once suffices along with blessings upon Muhammad and God's family, peace be upon them.

Observe the second rak'ah with its pillars and do not neglect the Qunut for it is a praiseworthy tradition, nor the testimony for it is obligatory with the two testimonies and blessings upon Muhammad and God's family, nor the last two rak'ahs with their conditions. Recite the four glorifications in them once, though thrice is better in God's Book. The recitation of the Fatihah was abrogated by the decree of the Proof, peace be upon him. Exit prayer with the final Salam for it is obligatory upon you just as you entered with Takbir.

It is obligatory in the Book of God that you should not forget before prayer to use perfume, an agate ring, the turban, and the toothbrush, nor after it the invocation of Fatima (peace be upon her), for it equals a thousand cycles of prayer in the Book of God. Do not recite two chapters of the Qur'an in a single obligatory cycle of prayer, though there is no harm in doing so in voluntary prayers. If one forgets the opening declaration (takbir), the prayer is obligatory upon him again. For one who forgets to recite after its proper time has passed, there is no requirement to repeat the prayer in the Book of God. But if one omits it deliberately, his prayer is void.

Similarly is the ruling for one who omits bowing and prostration through forgetfulness—repetition is obligatory in the Book of God. Perform two prostrations of forgetfulness for every addition or omission as decreed in the Book of God. Doubt is not valid in the first two cycles, and when you are certain of two cycles, your prayer is not invalidated—act according to your will. If your uncertainty persists and you are in the sunset prayer, conclude it then rise and add one cycle, for al-Sadiq (peace be upon him) has said this is among that which shall never be adjudged otherwise. If you are in the noon prayer or its like, and your doubt is between three and four cycles, conclude then pray one cycle.

If between two and four, conclude then pray two cycles standing. If between two, three and four, decide on four then pray two cycles standing and two sitting. What exceeds in your record, God will record for you in voluntary prayers. Between four and five, break your standing, conclude, then perform two prostrations of forgetfulness. Prayer is invalidated by deliberate speech, and for forgetfulness God has

decreed two prostrations of forgetfulness. If during prayer one turns completely away from the qiblih, repetition is obligatory. Whenever you doubt words or actions and have moved on to others, nothing is required of you. Acting upon doubt is not valid when it occurs three times in one prayer or in three prayers. Prayer is not valid in pure silk except in holy war, nor in the skins of carrion, nor in the fur of what is not lawful to eat.

Pray in khazz garments for they are from sea creatures whose slaughter God has made to be their emergence from water. God has made it obligatory for women to cover their heads and hair in prayer, but this ruling is not obligatory for slave women. Do not pray in the ten places mentioned in tradition for they are disapproved. Let nothing bearing an image be before your qiblih unless it is covered. The same is God's decree concerning fire and lamp. Do not pray wearing anything of gold or iron unless you fear someone, for then the sword becomes lawful for you. Women's prayer is not valid alongside men unless they stand behind them by the measure of a span.

If they pray to the right, left or in front of men, it is obligatory to distance themselves more than ten cubits from men. It is recommended to pray in pure sandals—these are God's just limits. Some rulings have changed in certain cases due to dissimulation, which is of the pure religion. So follow God's decree in what We have mentioned in this chapter, for God knows what is in the heavens and earth, and He is Well-Aware of what you do. Praise be to God, Lord of the worlds.

Chapter Ten: Concerning Zakat

In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate! Praise be to God Who ordained the payment of Zakat after prayer for His believing servants through His command, and then revealed its ordinance concerning nine things: precious metals, namely gold and silver; grains, namely wheat and barley; fruits, namely dates and raisins; and livestock, namely camels, followed by cattle, then sheep. God hath exempted the believers from paying Zakat on anything beyond these as set forth in the Book. He hath established for each of these a limit in His Book and hath ordained for whatever exceeds that limit another limit. He hath ordained that the Zakat on gold, after it reaches twenty dinars, shall be half a dinar when it is minted and a year consisting of eleven months according to the Book of God hath passed over it.

When it exceeds that amount by four dinars, three-fifths of a dinar is due on it, and thus God hath ordained up to its prescribed limit. If thou desirest to remove from thyself the ordinance of Zakat, then keep the gold in ingots, though I do not like this for anyone. God hath ordained the Zakat on silver similar to gold in terms of the passing of a year and its being minted, after it reaches two hundred dirhams. At that point, five dirhams are obligatory upon its owner by God's decree. For every additional forty dirhams beyond that amount, one dirham becomes obligatory, and thus the ordinance continues up to its prescribed limit. This is God's ordinance concerning the first two of the nine items.

Before mentioning livestock, God ordained concerning four enumerated items that when any of these reaches sixty wasqs, which is three hundred sa's, then one-tenth is due if it was watered by rain or natural irrigation, otherwise one-twentieth is due, and if it was irrigated with difficulty, then after one-twentieth,

one-fortieth is due. This is God's righteous decree. God hath not ordained Zakat on these four items except once, even if a year passes over them repeatedly.

God hath ordained concerning camels, after the completion of a full year, that five sheep are due for five camels, then for every five camels, one sheep until reaching twenty-five. When it exceeds that, a one-year-old female camel is due, and if one does not have this, then a two-year-old male camel is due, up to thirty-five. When it exceeds that number, God ordains a two-year-old female camel up to forty-five. When it exceeds that number, then a three-year-old female camel is due up to sixty. If it increases, then a four-year-old female camel is due up to seventy-five. If it increases beyond that number, then two two-year-old female camels are due up to ninety. If it increases beyond that number, then two three-year-old female camels are due according to the Book of God until reaching one hundred and twenty. If it increases beyond that number, then for every fifty, a three-year-old female camel is due, and for every forty, a two-year-old female camel is due according to the Book of God. These are twelve limits concerning the ordinance of camels.

As for cattle, after a year has passed, for every thirty cattle, a one-year-old calf is due, and for every forty that reach sixty, then two calves are due. When the number reaches eighty, then for every forty, God ordains a mature cow. When it reaches ninety, three yearlings are due, and when the number reaches one hundred and twenty, then for every forty, a mature cow is due. This is God's ordinance concerning cattle.

As for sheep, after the passage of a year there is nothing due if they number less than forty. When they reach forty, one sheep is due, until they reach one hundred and twenty. When they exceed this by one, two sheep are due, up to two hundred. When they exceed this number by one, three sheep are due, up to three hundred. When the sheep increase beyond this, for every hundred sheep one sheep is due, and the first ordinance ceases to apply, and nothing is due on less than a hundred thereafter.

These ordinances concerning livestock—camels, cattle and sheep—are binding when they graze in open pastures by God's bounty. However, if they are fed by their owner through purchase or other means, no zakat is due on them. If their circumstances vary, the ruling reverts to the days of plenty after scarcity. No zakat is due from the owner of camels and cattle used for working the land according to the Book's ordinance, but otherwise it is obligatory except if one trades with them and profits, and if loss occurs it remains obligatory. The same applies to pearls and animals, and likewise is the ruling for the beloved ones in God's Book, for the ordinance applies from God to the free, mature and sound of mind. No burden is laid upon children in God's Book, nor upon the foolish who do not understand prayer and its ordinances. These are God's true bounds.

God has not ordained zakat on property absent from its owner except when it becomes accessible, but if he deliberately leaves it while able to take possession, zakat is due for all the years that have passed. The same applies to debts, unless it is the creditor who delays collection, and likewise to the borrower only after taking possession and the passage of a year. The borrower is obligated to pay God's due during the days God has placed the property in his hands. The Family of God, peace be upon them, have permitted their followers to give zakat two months before or after its due date. It is not permissible for anyone to

spend zakat except among the people of his town, and if he cannot find recipients, he must send it to the believers.

If he sends it while knowing of eligible recipients in his town and it is lost en route, he is obligated to give an equal amount as God's due. Charitable contributions are only lawful as God has ordained in the Book: for the poor who do not persistently beg from people; for the needy who are people of religion; for those who work to collect and preserve it until delivering it to its rightful recipients; for those whose hearts are to be reconciled, who are people who have professed God's oneness and abandoned worship of aught else beside God—God has appointed for them a share in the charitable contributions; for freeing of slaves—people liable for expiations; for those in debt who have spent in God's obedience; in God's path—people who go forth to holy war or other good causes but lack means; and for the wayfarers who travel in obedience to God and whose means are cut off and whose wealth is depleted.

It is incumbent upon the Imam (peace be upon him) to return them to their homelands using funds from the charitable offerings. All such recipients must be adherents to all the verses and this wondrous Cause. For one who has not attained recognition of the family of God (peace be upon them), nothing is permitted to him from the Book of God.

It is not lawful for one who possesses sufficient means to take from the charitable offerings. However, for one who owns a house and has a servant but then falls into need, it becomes lawful according to the Book of God. It is not permissible for a servant to give Zakat to father, mother, son, daughter, grandfather, grandmother, wife, or slave, even if they are poor and possess nothing, though it is permitted for other relatives. Do not give less than five dirhams from Zakat funds to anyone, and increase above that amount as much as you are able in the path of God. If you enrich someone completely, that is better than giving to many without meeting their needs. Do not mention that it is Zakat when giving, for this humiliates the face of the believer, and God has linked his honor with His own honor, and He does not wish humiliation upon him in anything. It is not lawful for any of the children of Hashim according to the Book of God to take Zakat from anyone, though they may give charity among themselves.

Verily, the Messenger of God—may blessings rest upon Him and His family—ordained alms as a practice for everything the earth bringeth forth, save fresh greens and herbs, and whatsoever spoileth the selfsame day. Likewise did He judge concerning merchandise: if a full year elapse over the goods of trade while their owner holdeth them seeking increase above the principal, then the ruling is the same.

And even so is the ordinance for noble-bred horses… And God hath appointed for every horse, each year, two dinars; and He hath decreed upon the mules one dinar. These are the bounds of God, in equity.

Moreover, in the Book of God He hath prescribed the Zakat al-Fitr from the break of dawn on the Day of the Feast until before the prayer—for every soul that is free and of age—that he discharge it for himself, and for those whose provision God hath placed in his hand, and for that with which he breaketh the fast on the night of the Feast: that he give, in the path of God, a sa' of wheat, or of dates, or of what is less than these. And upon him who receiveth the zakat and the fitrah there is no [further] fitrah due; yet that he, in the path of God, should give is most beloved unto Him in His Book. And if he be poor, let him give

of himself to one of his dependants, then take one and give one, that there may be, for them all, a single fitrah.

And in the Furqan hath been sent down the Word of Justice for the needy: “And render the due thereof on the day of its harvest”—that is, a handful after a handful; and for other produce, a measure after a measure. These are the bounds of God, in equity.

It is commendable, according to the Book of God, that the servant send all the zakat unto the Proof of God in His dispensation, for He is the most knowing of the welfare of His flock. And in the days of occultation, the decree is that it be sent unto the just divines, that they may give each his right. And God knoweth what men do. Glorified be God above that which they ascribe unto Him, and praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds.

Chapter Eleven: Concerning Khums

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who created the earth and all that is upon it for His vicegerent on earth. Whosoever thinks that the Imam needs what is in the hands of people is an unbeliever according to the decree of the Book. God has made lawful for the believers who fulfill their covenant with God what they possess in the religion of God according to the judgment of the Qur’an. Then He made obligatory upon them, in all that people acquire, the Fifth (Khums) and attributed it to the honor of the kindred of the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, by Himself, like the ordinance of pilgrimage. Indeed, honor belongs to God, then the pilgrimage to the House for those who are able, then the Fifth of what people acquire in everything is for Himself, then for His Messenger Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, then for the near of kin—the successors of Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, then for the orphans, the poor, and the wayfarer from the progeny of Hashim, as they are called after their fathers. This is a decree in the Book of God.

Today, half of the Fifth is for the Remnant of God alone, and half is justly for his assured followers from the progeny of Hashim. It is not lawful for anyone to withhold even the weight of a mustard seed from God’s right for His Remnant, nor from God’s right for His followers.

God has made the Fifth obligatory in the wealth that Muslims take from the unbelievers by the sword, then in mines of gold and silver and what God has placed in the earth besides these when their value reaches the amount of one dinar, and there is nothing due on what is less than that, then in buried treasure, then in what comes from the sea of pearls, rubies, chrysolite, ambergris, and what God has created in the sea besides these when their value reaches one dinar, then in land which a protected non-Muslim buys from a Muslim—God has made the Fifth obligatory upon him, then in profits from trade, agriculture, and crafts after one’s living expenses and what God has made as sustenance by one’s hand.

What the oppressor takes—that is God’s just decree. For any wealth in which the unlawful has entered, it is obligatory for whoever wishes to purify it to give the Fifth to those whom God has designated. These are God’s true boundaries. God has ordained that one may take the property of the hostile one (Nasib) whenever it is found and extract from it the Fifth for its rightful recipients. This is God’s bounty to the

believers, as Imam Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, explained in his words, for God has not given the hostile one any sanctity in God's Book, and they are further removed in judgment in the Book than the unbelievers, for they are a people who revile Ali and his successors, peace be upon them, after knowing their majesty in God's Book.

The Family of God, God's peace be upon them, have made lawful for their followers the use of land so their prayers upon it would be accepted, and they have made lawful for them in marriage the right of the Fifth so their children would be pure in God's religion. They will never make their right lawful for anyone. It is obligatory upon all to collect half of the Fifth as the Imam's right, peace be upon him, and to preserve it in trust with themselves. If they know someone from the presence of the Imam, peace be upon him, as an authority for themselves, they should give it to him; otherwise they should make a bequest for its preservation until it reaches the one whom God has made it his right. Today it is obligatory upon all to give half of the Fifth to whom God has made His proof, peace be upon him.

Verily today it is obligatory upon all to give half of the fifth (Khums) to Him whom God hath made His Proof—peace be upon him—as the guardian of the Cause. Indeed, I have not permitted anyone today to take even a mustard seed, and I have taken less than a mustard seed from all to purify their souls from the right of God. Whoso wisheth may give and whoso wisheth may withhold. Verily the most severe position on the Day of Resurrection shall be for one who came while in his possession was even a mustard seed from the right of the Family of God—peace be upon them. And the other half is obligatory upon their souls that they should give with their own hands to the orphans and the poor and the wayfarer from among the progeny of the Family of God—the peace of God, the Merciful, be upon them.

And it is not permitted for them to send it to me. And those who act upon this matter must discharge their trust and not withhold from them even as much as the film of a date-stone. For verily today the progeny of the Family of God—peace be upon them—are poor in the hands of God. Soon will God gather the wealthy with them and question them concerning their rights with such questioning that hearts shall tremble that day from its magnitude. These are the bounds of God concerning the fifth.

And verily the anfal (spoils) on that day are the right of the Imam—peace be upon him—and these are the spoils which people seized without the permission of the Imam—peace be upon him—so they belong to him by the judgment of God. Then the land which was conquered without the employment of horse or camel, and the dead lands, and the property of those who have no heirs, or that whose owner is not known, and what God hath made from the mines and the fiefs of kings, as hath been revealed in the tradition, for the people have no share in these. These are the bounds of God in truth.

And verily the land of Fadak today is entirely from the anfal and it is not permitted for anyone to take anything from it. And its boundary in the Book of God: one of its boundaries is Mount Uhud, and one of its boundaries is Arish of Egypt, and one of its boundaries is the seashore, and one of its boundaries is Dumat al-Jandal. And it hath been made obligatory upon whoso is able to take its fruit and deliver it to the one in whose hands is the proof from its owner that none can bring the like thereof. And likewise is the decree concerning all anfal. These are the bounds of God with justice. Follow ye the command of God with justice, for on the Day of Resurrection ye shall be questioned concerning what ye did and what ye concealed and what ye were capable of and what ye performed and what ye established. And verily God

will not be questioned about what He doeth, but ye will be questioned. Glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. And peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

Chapter Twelve: On Jihad

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

God has made jihad one of the branches of religion, and it is like prayer when God and His chosen ones call for justice. Indeed, He sent Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, with five swords, three of which shall not be sheathed until war lays down its burdens. And war shall not lay down its burdens until the sun rises from the west. When the sun rises from the west, on that day no soul shall benefit from its faith if it had not believed before or earned good through its faith.

Among these is a sword against the polytheists of Arabia, as God the Exalted has said:

> "Slay the polytheists wherever you find them, and take them, and confine them, and lie in wait for them at every place of ambush. But if they repent and establish prayer and give alms, then let them go their way. Indeed, God is Forgiving and Merciful."

From these servants nothing is accepted except death or entering Islam.

And among them is a sword against the People of the Book, as God the Exalted has said:

> "Fight those who believe not in God and the Last Day and do not forbid what God and His Messenger have forbidden, and do not follow the religion of truth, from among those who were given the Scripture, until they pay the tribute willingly while they are brought low."

The Imam, peace be upon him, and his representatives take the tribute from the People of the Book according to what they observe of their wealth, and there is no tribute in God's religion upon their poor who possess nothing, nor upon the mentally deficient, nor upon those who have lost their reason.

And among them is a sword against the polytheists of the earth, as God the Exalted has said:

> "Strike the necks until, when you have inflicted slaughter upon them, then secure their bonds, and either confer favor afterwards or ransom."

From these servants nothing will be accepted except death or entering Islam.

After these three, there is a sword for the people of rebellion, as God the Exalted has said:

> "If two factions among the believers fight, then make settlement between them. But if one of them oppresses the other, then fight against the one that oppresses until it returns to the ordinance of God."

By the ruling of this verse, Ali and his successors, peace be upon them, fought according to its apparent interpretation, and by it the Remnant of God, peace be upon him, will slay the rebels on the day of his

appearance. The ruling of jihad is not lawful for anyone besides the Proof of God, peace be upon him, unless he permits it.

And the fifth sword is sheathed for the sake of retribution, as God the Exalted has said:

> "And We prescribed for them therein: Life for life, eye for eye, nose for nose, ear for ear, tooth for tooth, and for wounds is retribution. But whoever gives charity with it, it is an expiation for him. And whoever does not judge by what God has revealed—then it is those who are the wrongdoers."

Its ruling was in the hand of the Imam, peace be upon him.

These are the swords with which God sent the Prophet, peace be upon him and his family. Whoever denies them, or denies one of them, or anything of their conduct and rulings, has disbelieved in what God has revealed to Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family. These are the ordinances of jihad as God the Exalted has revealed to Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family. And sufficient is God as a witness for the believers. And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

Chapter Thirteen: On the ordinances

In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Praise be to God Who hath sent down certain ordinances as guidance and remembrance for those who recognize the verses of God with justice and who follow the ordinances of religion as a duty. And God is well aware of what ye do. We have written in that chapter for the devout one from the Land of Ha, and for whomsoever followeth that ordinance, that he should interpret the laws of prayer in the foreign tongue of mankind. And upon the exalted one from the Land of Ta, and whomsoever he pleaseth, in the form of parables, is the command that he should multiply such parables of that Book in his land. And verily this hath been from God's grace upon them both, and God is well aware of what the doers do. Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. And peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds. And blessings and peace be upon Muhammad and his pure kindred.

BB00318: as-Silsilatu'th-Thamaniyya

> "O our Master and Lord! Several questions have arisen and I beseech your exalted grace to favor your servant with answers to them, even briefly according to my understanding and comprehension, for this is my ultimate aim and utmost desire. Kindly explain to your servant with clear evidence from the Book and Tradition the arrangement of the eight longitudinal series, and how each lower one is a ray of its higher one. And among them the distinction between the third inner meaning and what is above it, and between the interpretation of the inward and the manifestation of the outward of the outward and what is above it. And among them the relationship between our Siyyid [Kazim] and our Shaykh [Ahmad], and likewise the

> relationship of the Remembrance who stands with authority after them—that is, what his relationship is. Make this clear—may God make me your sacrifice and illuminate your proof."

In the Name of God, the Wondrous, besides Whom there is no God, the Mighty, the Wise

Today a letter has come to me from Abdullah Abdul-Jalil.

Know, O thou who standeth upon the upright line and planteth thy feet firmly on the straight path, and prepare thyself for what God shall impart to thee concerning the way of division.

As for the question about the eightfold chain, understand that God has not ordained anything with its essential reality except that He has already prescribed its decree in the Book, with causes explained for those possessed of understanding, so that people might have no argument against God. And verily God does not withdraw the proof from among the people until He has conveyed the decree of the Book to all people.

As for the evidence from the Book, this word is from the Book: "And eight shall bear the throne of thy Lord above them"—through the mystery of oneness after the triangular form unto the square temple, witnessed by those possessed of insight.

And as for the evidence from the Tradition conforming to the Book letter by letter: verily the gardens are eight, and the ranks of knowledge after the solitude of oneness are seven, as indicated by Ali al-Sajjad in the tradition of Jabir, explained in detail.

As for the exposition, it is that thou shouldst worship the All-Merciful according to the limit of the exposition concerning the creation of man, without reference to multiplicity or differentiation, but rather in the aspect of unity—and this is the garden of oneness: he who is within it has not gone out, and he who is without it has not entered. And God has ordained no path for those who would enter except after effacement from all else. Glorified be thy Lord, the Lord of might, above what they describe. None knoweth how He is except He, the Ancient, the All-Knowing.

When God willed a thing, the Will came into being through God, not from anything, and fell prostrate upon its throne before God:

> "Verily Thou art God, there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner, and I am the first of those who prostrate before God, the Exalted, the Praiseworthy."

And since the effect indicates naught but the state of its cause, God created from the Will an essence of volition with perfect potentiality therein. Then God created from that essence the five gardens and their seven precincts according to what befitteth it—and naught befitteth it except what He hath made to befit it—out of bounty and grace. And there is nothing that doth not glorify His praise, but people know naught of the knowledge of the Book save some limited letters.

As for the indication through radiation between them, thou seest naught with the people of truth confirming that word, for if there were separation or connection between the high and the low, or if they were indicated through conjunction, the example would not reflect its cause and the order would be

nullified in the decree of the Book. Exalted is God above what those who compare liken unto His creation, apart from the example concerning their Creator. Sufficient is the word of God, the Exalted:

> "Thou seest no imperfection in the creation of the All-Merciful; look again—seest thou any flaw?"

God has not ordained any connection between the high and the low by decree of the Book as written.

As for the distinction between the inner and outer in manifestation, know that God has made for every inner an inwardness and for every outer an outwardness, and the soul in them is but one soul, and the command is but one, and it is nearer. So burn away all veils through the gaze of oneness until thou witnesseth for each as the Book has witnessed: "Every soul shall taste of death" as written.

As for the relation between the two gates, be certain then fear God besides Whom there is no God, and ask not about a thing which God created above thy perception by one hundred and seventy thousand years, for God burdens not any soul beyond what He has given it. And grieve not at rejection, for God has decreed rejection for the one who turns away, and there is no repelling God's command which is justly asked.

And God has made naught between them save as God has placed between motion and rest—if thou knowest distinction from connection, thou shalt attain thy portion of what is prescribed in the Book.

As for the question between me and them—how small is thy frame and how great is thy question! None knows this save God, my Lord and the Lord of all the worlds, and He is the Exalted in the heavens and earth, in the Mother Book by decree of the Book, praised.

As for the manifestation through questions—who prevents thee from the gate of mercy? Fear God—He will teach thee the interpretation of traditions wondrously. Preserve my counsel to thee, for God has ordained for the preservers a goodly station and a goodly return as a resting place.

And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00031: Answer to seven questions

Introduction

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who caused to shine forth that which shone forth, and caused to rise that which rose, and caused to gleam that which gleamed, and made utterance the letter of derivation at the beginning of separation. Then He created the ordinances for the people of the Covenant, and created the water of the seed of those who act with hypocrisy beneath the temples of this Light wherewith He filled the horizons and whereby was illumined all that was thunderstruck and then recovered, and whereby shall be uncovered leg from leg on the Day when the Herald shall call out according to the decree of the Covenant.

O God! Thou knowest that today there hath come down to me a letter from one who hath borne injury in the path of certitude from the people of concord, and he hath asked concerning seven questions which have bewildered the minds of the people of concord when God desired to reveal their inner meanings as on the Day when leg shall be uncovered from leg. But since I knew what the people know not, and what the people of discord desire for the people of justice and the Covenant, I opened not his letter which descended in weakness unto the horizon of fellowship and the portico. But since I knew that in his heart there stirred that which the deniers from among the people of discord and hypocrisy had fabricated, I sprinkled a sprinkling from the ocean of the glory of realities concerning that which he asked and desired before the day of his meeting, in verses of mysteries and hidden subtleties, of that which wavereth in the hidden secrets of souls and shineth in the essences of the depths of minds.

And I seek God's help in what I desire regarding the path of the inward and the manifest outward appearance from the Light that shone forth upon the Mount and the Symbol concealed in the Preserved Book and the Outspread Parchment and the Frequented House.

O thou questioner who art veiled and afflicted by the trial of the languid one from among those who lack understanding! Ask thy Lord about the six matters referred to in the Preserved Book, and We have given thee the limit in one of them, and rely upon God, the All-Forgiving.

On visitation in the days of fear to the Sacred Sanctuary

As to what thou hast asked concerning visitation in the days of fear to the Sacred Sanctuary which hath dawned from the light of the Eternal Morn and which hath spoken through the Two Letters from the First Letter: empty thy heart, calm thy mind, steady thy thoughts, and purify thy body according to what is prescribed in the Holy Law. Then perform ablutions, and when thou hast finished, don thy finest attire and use perfume. Then stand facing the House in the Sacred Mosque and pray two cycles of prayer with the Surih of the Spirit. When thou hast finished, recite the Prayer of Occultation for the Proof (upon him be peace). Then arise, look toward a point in the heavens and say:

I bear witness that there is no God but God, alone without partner, even as He hath testified to His own Self by His own Self, and none of His servants can comprehend His knowledge. Glory be to Him and exalted is He above what they describe. And I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant whom He chose from the midst of creation to stand in His own station in fulfillment and decree, for verily sight comprehendeth Him not, but He comprehendeth all sight, and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed. And I bear witness that the successors of Muhammad (peace be upon him and his family)—Ali, Hasan, Husayn, Ali, Muhammad, Ja'far, Musa, Ali, Muhammad, Ali, Hasan and the Qa'im (may God's blessings be upon them all)—are the Imams of religion and guides of all creation, pillars of justice and certitude, preservers of knowledge and the Clear Book. They are God's trustees in the kingdoms of command and creation. Nothing precedes them, no knowledge is hidden from them, and they have no authority except by God's leave. They are honored servants who speak not until He hath spoken, and act by His command.

O God! I bear witness before Thee to that which Thou dost witness concerning their rights. And I know that religion is not complete except through knowledge of them and repudiation of their enemies who deny their station which God hath ordained for them, while they neither know nor understand. And I bear

witness, O my God, that in every age Thou hast a Living Proof, renowned yet fearful and concealed, lest anyone should say "Had God made His Proof known to me, I would have followed him and been among the believers." And I bear witness that today Thy Proof is the Concealed Light, the Praised One who is hidden, whose name Thou didst reveal in Thy Book when Thou didst say—and Thy word is truth—"What remaineth of God is best for you if ye be believers."

I testify that through His very being the signs are made manifest in the heaven of the immaterial realm, by that Light wherewith Thou didst reveal Thyself unto Moses, son of ʿImran; whereupon he recovered, and the tokens were unfolded throughout the realities of the horizons. The evidences quivered within the hidden recesses of the hearts of the people of the Covenant, while the inward secrets of the people of schism and hypocrisy were laid bare. Glory be to Thee, O my God! I am powerless to reckon His praise; for even as He is, He is a light from Thy countenance, a disclosure of Thy very Being, a sign of Thy oneness, a visage of Thy dominion. No description pertaineth unto Him drawn from aught that existeth, inasmuch as all things came into being through the radiance of the traces of His revelation upon the forms of material existence. Neither hath He mention within any thing, for mention itself ariseth only through the presence of His remembrance within the essential realities.

Glory be to Thee, O my God! None but Thee can know His praise, nor doth it befit Thy holy court that any save Thyself should describe Him. If I say that He is the light of Thine eternity, all who dwell in the kingdom of command and creation would at once gainsay me; for that which Thou hast named the Light of God is but a remnant of His manifestation in Thee, and a sign of His self-disclosure within the hearts. And if I say, "I know nothing of His description," and thereafter keep silence, then doth Thy dealing with those brought nigh unto Thee stir my longing in His praise; for when they described Him, Thou didst graciously accept it from them through Thy bounty, and didst not repel them, such is the plenitude of Thy favor.

So glory be to You, O my God! You know my secret and my manifest self. Far be it from me to claim that my existence before His beauty is even like a particle of rock, or that my praise before His majesty is even like the blink of an ant's eye. I seek Your forgiveness for attempting to define the infinite, for His existence has ever been through the light of Your existence, and my existence has no mention before His existence, and likewise is the state of my praise.

Glory be to You, O my God! I bear witness before You and those who bear witness in Your presence that if You were to punish me with all that You are capable of at the time of reckoning as recompense for mentioning my existence and praise before the court of His might and the majesty of His sovereignty, I would truly deserve it. You have ever been and will ever be praised. None questions Your actions, while all are supplicants at Your gate, fearful of Your justice, seeking refuge in Your presence, apprehensive of Your might, and there is no shelter for anyone except with You.

Glory be to You and exalted are You! I bear witness that all You promised regarding Your Proof concerning the laws of his occultation, his emissaries, and those who falsely claim the truth has come to pass. What remains are the signs, tokens and proofs You promised, at which minds will be bewildered, and whose realities none will understand until after the setting star appears.

O God! Hasten his days, manifest his sovereignty, complete his proof, exalt his word, and make him prevail over all religion until none worship You on earth while associating anything of Your signs with You, even though the unbelievers despise it.

O God! The deaf strife has occurred among Your servants—some deny others and some reject others. You know the realities of affairs and what is hidden behind veils. So manifest Your word and complete his proof through Your signs. You know all things and nothing in the heavens or earth escapes You, and You are the Mighty, the Wise.

O God! I bear witness before You and those who bear witness in Your presence that every Proof must have an emissary who knows the laws of religion and the hints of God's Clear Book, to bring people to true certainty through signs and tokens from certain knowledge. You know all things, O my God! Some have claimed this lofty station and exalted word while being unable to demonstrate even the inner meanings of the Qur'an's knowledge or the laws of the people of the Bayan. You know their realities, and there is no doubt that Your Proof in every matter is conclusive, Your word is complete, Your will is swift, and none has any argument against You, for You have made clear, completed, perfected and beautified all that creation desired regarding the path of Your Proof. Those who ascribe partners to God have lied and gone clearly astray.

O God! Establish Your proof in the hearts of the believers and make them adhere to the word of piety lest they go astray after guidance and become wretched. There is no doubt, O my God, for Your friends that You have nullified the work of the deniers through what their hands have earned. Thou hast spoken, and Thy word is truth:

> "If God were to punish men for their deeds, He would not leave on the earth a single creature, but He reprieves them to an appointed time; when their term comes, then verily God is All-Seeing over His servants."

O God! I bear witness that I believe in Thee and in Thy Book and in those whom Thou lovest as Thou wouldst have them loved, and none knoweth this save Thee. I am innocent of those among Thy servants who have fabricated lies about Thee, some saying words at which the heavens are well-nigh rent asunder, and the earth split open, and the mountains fall down in ruins—that Thou art one of three, or questioning where God is, or claiming that Thou art poor while they are rich. Glory be to Thee! Glory be to Thee! Glory be to Thee! Thou art God, there is none other God but Thee, the Single, the Self-Subsisting, the One, the All-Sufficient, the All-Powerful, the Self-Subsisting. No description can grasp Thee, nor any attribute define Thee. Thou art as Thou art—none can know Thee, and no servant can describe Thee.

Therefore forgive me for mentioning the words of the polytheists in the presence of the blind concerning Thy friends, for if they possessed certain knowledge, they would see the fire in their own souls as a manifest truth before Thy face, for verily Thou art the All-Sufficient, the Most Generous. Among them are those who rejected Thy Messengers, and those who rejected Their successors, and those who rejected the believers, both men and women, who followed them—as though they were dead, having no awareness. O God! Curse them in the most hidden recesses and in open manifestation, and deal with them as Thou hast ordained in the Tablets for their forebears.

I swear by Thy might, I am quit of them and of all that pertaineth unto them, and of those who love them as they follow their vain desires while imagining themselves to be guided. O God! I know not all that Thou knowest. Therefore, O God, deal with those who revile Thy friends before Thee and who show enmity toward them without right, according to Thy might, power, majesty and grandeur. Verily, Thou art the Strong, the All-Compelling. Thou didst say—and Thy word is the truth—"It was incumbent upon Us to help the believers." Then Thou didst say: "Verily the promise of God shall come to pass."

O God! Make us to be of Thy party, for they are the doers of good, and if they be slain or oppressed, these are they who shall triumph. O God! Hasten Thy promise and assist Thy Cause, and show us His countenance which reflecteth the light of Thy glory and beauty. Fill the earth through Him with equity and justice after it hath been filled with oppression and tyranny. Verily, Thou art the Mighty, the All-Wise.

Then turn toward the door of the Sacred House from the eastern corner wherein is the Stone, and say: Peace be upon thee, O faithful servant who art concealed, O fearful and expectant one who art renowned, whose mention God hath made in a Book inscribed on an outstretched parchment and in the Frequented House—the Light of God that shone upon the Mount through less than a needle's eye from the dawning-place of Manifestation, whereupon there appeared that which appeared from the light of God's Name, the Ever-Living, the All-Forgiving. Then He filled the horizons therewith, manifesting thereby God's Name, the Ever-Living, the All-Praising, illumining thereby the darkest depths of night.

I testify that thou art light upon light upon light, whereby every light is illumined. I bear witness that thou hast believed in what God hath revealed in the Qur'an and hast followed the path of the people of the Bayan. Thou art the one whom the All-Merciful taught the science of utterance without having learned from any human being. Thou art he who set down the decree of the sun and moon according to measure. The darknesses alter thee not from the ordinances of the people of the Bayan, nor do the deeds of those who have fabricated lies against God render thee powerless to judge with certitude.

I testify that thy likeness in the Qur'an is as a tree whose knowledge almost enlighteneth, though no fire hath touched it. Thou hast spoken to the people of that which God bestowed upon thee as a sign, according to the decree of the Criterion, as was promised in the Qur'an where He said—and His word is the truth:

> "Fear God and He will grant you a criterion to judge between people"

and nullify the works of those who fabricate from among the friends of Satan. I testify that thou hast revealed what thou didst bear of the inner meanings of the Book, and hast expounded what thou didst know of the decrees of decisive utterance, and hast written what thou didst attain in the path of servitude in volumes of intimate prayers that bring the servant to the ordinances of the Day of Return, and hast explained what people need in books whose knowledge none can comprehend save whom God willeth, from the fundamentals of religion to the decree of dust.

Sufficient honor is this for the sincere party and the chosen band, for through thy verses the decree of this Faith is established with a proof of truth that none can deny unless he denieth what he believed before, and through them are nullified the works of those who denied the Imams of Justice.

I bear witness that the deniers have slandered Thee as the misguided deniers slandered those nigh to God in former times. They have uttered words at which the heavens are well-nigh rent and cleft asunder, and the earth split open, and the mountains crumble to dust, words that no human soul can comprehend. Some among them claimed that He asserted the authority of the Guardianship and its sisters; others that He claimed divine revelation and the sending down of verses and the Criterion; still others that He pronounced in His book a ruling making obligatory the law of fasting on the Day of Warning and the Sacred Month—and this is the decree that was revealed in the Qur'an—then some claimed it was a promise unfulfilled, then a decree abrogated.

The decree was inscribed in golden ink, and in his words were verses that accorded with the decree of the Qur'an, though between them was no connection, like what the Arabs said concerning the decree of heaven which He raised and established the balance. Then some were inspired by Satan to claim that he had added to the laws of the Faith and claimed the word of the Bab with what was not in truth revealed. God shall slay them for what they have fabricated against thee and transgressed in thy decree and violated what God commanded to be fulfilled, and desired to spread corruption in the earth and conceal the word of truth. But God will perfect His light though the idolaters be averse.

I bear witness before God and His angels and His Prophets and His faithful servants that thou art innocent of these words, and of those who believed such false words concerning thee, and those who slandered thee and wronged thee. Those who have acted unjustly shall soon know what fate awaits them. I bear witness that thou claimed naught save pure servitude, which thou didst express and to which testified those pages that filled the East and West of the earth, wherein God revealed through thy hands in six hours whatsoever He willed as He willed—and this verily is the great attainment.

I bear witness that thou claimed not the decree of the Qur'an nor divine revelation except what God promised in the Furqan to the believers and the revelation of verses to Moses and all who were with him. I bear witness that thou hast not violated a single letter of God's religion nor added a letter to God's Book—and whoso doeth this is an idolater and doubter. I bear witness that thou hast expounded the inner meanings of the verses and traditions in ways that no minds of the discerning and far-seeing can encompass, as attested by the well-known books among both the righteous believers and the wicked transgressors.

I bear witness that God knoweth thy station and sendeth blessings upon thee as He promised in the Qur'an to the believers. Had He known thou desired aught but His good-pleasure, He would have invalidated thy proof by creating a mortal who could naturally recite God's verses as thou dost recite and write, which none among creation can do. This suffices as a remembrance from God—and this verily is the supreme triumph, for by this proof are established the laws of that true Faith with such justice that none can deny it unless they disbelieve what they believed before. And through it shall the religion of Islam triumph over those Arabs who disbelieved, and conflicting laws shall return to one law, though the unbelievers be averse.

O thou patient and wronged one, O thou Name concealed yet known! How can I praise and thank God for honoring me in thy days with thy recognition and belief in thy verses and following those who love thee, and disclaiming those who denied thee and opposed thee and those who wronged thee and slandered

thee. Here I stand in this station—God and those who witness with Him bear witness—loyal to whomsoever is loyal to thee, hostile to whomsoever is hostile to thee, loving whomsoever loveth thee, detesting whomsoever detesteth thee, submitting to whomsoever submitteth to thy decree, and warring alongside whomsoever warreth with thee, and I testify with certitude that faith profiteth not, and deeds are not accepted, except through acceptance of this bounty from God in thy regard.

I seek refuge with God and His words from being among those who recognize the bounty of God and then deny it, or from being among those who hear what Thou didst pronounce in the Sacred Mosque seventy times before God and the witnesses from among His creation, yet believe not in God's Cause regarding thee, or from those who look upon these words and thereafter fabricate falsehood knowingly and spread doubt. O God! I testify before Thee that I believed naught regarding this Thy servant save what Thou lovest and art well-pleased with, and I have no doubt that Thou hast described with the tongue of Thine infallible ones [what] hath been decreed concerning those who believe in Thy signs that they cannot be described.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Since Thou didst reveal these words concerning them, I verily know that all these verses cannot ascend unto them, for they, through Thy grace and bounty, are far exalted above such description. Glorified art Thou, O Lord of the Throne, above what they describe! Then turn unto the House of Light, the Garment of Manifestation, the Hidden Name, and the Resplendent Light, and say: I testify that they who falsely attribute to Thee the word "Babi" like unto the Four Gates, through a specific text from the Imams, have indeed gone astray and led others astray unknowingly. I bear witness that Thou didst not speak such words, and in the words Thou didst utter Thou intended naught save such goodly names as Thou didst attribute to Thyself. And I firmly believe that Thy proof is conclusive and Thy word is complete, and that wert Thou to desire through such proof to do whatsoever Thou willest, it would be right, and none could question Thee about it or ask "why" or "wherefore" lest they bear the burden of sin and transgression forthwith. Yet Thou hast not done, nor wilt Thou do, aught save that whose decree hath been revealed in the Qur'an, whereunto the people of the Bayan do testify.

And verily, when my heart is emptied through Thy remembrance, and my innermost being is gladdened through the recitation of Thy prayers, and my heart findeth tranquility in standing before Thy glory, I recite in this my station before Thee what ʿAli, the Commander of the Faithful, peace be upon him, hath spoken in his sermon, alluding to Thy decree. Then say: Praise be to God Who hath guided us to this; we could not have found the way had it not been that God guided us. Indeed, the messengers of our Lord did bring the truth. And they shall be called: This is Paradise which ye have inherited for what ye used to know.

I beseech Thee, O God, by the right of Muhammad and his family, Thy blessings be upon them, to hasten Thy days and to pour forth patience upon us in what hath been sent down from Thee, and to grant us victory over those who have transgressed against Thy right, and to gather us among those who have repented and turned unto Thee and followed Thy path. And protect them, O Lord, from the torment of the Fire. I seek Thy forgiveness, O my God, for what I have said before Thy Beauty and what I have committed before Thy Majesty. Verily, Thou sufficest all things and nothing sufficeth apart from Thee. Therefore suffice me, O God, through Thy generosity, and guard me through Thy grace, and assist me

from Thy presence, and fill my heart with fear of Thee, and show me the countenance of Thy proof, and inspire me at all times with Thy beginning and Thy seizure, then with hope in Thee and Thy grace. Verily, Thou art God, the Lord of the worlds.

We have, indeed, in former times sprinkled forth, in the exposition entitled Tamtam of the Sea, a measure of those matters whose immensity hath bewildered minds in certain of their aspects, and whose realities have been partially apprehended in the exposition of the Luminous Visitation that shone forth from the effulgences of the Light of the Morn of Eternity. And now, by the leave of God, I but allude to some portion thereof, even as a few drops overflowing from the all-encompassing Ocean upon the slope of the mountain. Know thou of a certainty the truth of that which We have sent down unto thee from the Spirit of God; for God confirmeth whomsoever He willeth by His grace, and verily He is Powerful, Mighty.

Be thou therefore assured with a certainty beyond doubt concerning the second question which thou didst ask, touching the saying of ʿAli—peace be upon him—in the supplication for the Day of Sha'ban, wherein he saith, exalted be His remembrance: Make me of those who continually remember Thee, who break not Thy covenant, who are not heedless of Thy gratitude, nor make light of Thy divine command; and join me to the Light of Thy might, that I may know Thee, turn away from all beside Thee, and fear Thee with watchfulness. For all that are in the heavens and on the earth abide beneath the shadow of a single letter thereof, even as a leaf of myrtle; and whatsoever is intended in those allusions—its source none can encompass save Him alone.

I do but point, by the Spirit of Divinity wherewith I have been invested—and which is that very Word—unto the prayer: Join me to the most resplendent Light of Thy might. For the servant attaineth not unto the Light wherewith God hath revealed Himself unto him, and which He hath made His most glorious Light within the being of His remotest servant, save through the removal of veils and the signs, stations, and tokens thereby disclosed. These, however, are unveiled only by denying disclosure itself, and by negating negation upon negation; and when that which is negated is itself negated from negation, then doth the Light of the Manifest One arise within the temple of thy heart. At that moment shalt thou become even as He—exalted be His remembrance—hath said: that I may know Thee.

And His saying—exalted be His remembrance—"and turning away from all beside Thee" is itself the very essence of unity in the midst of multiplicity, after the third journey through its abodes and at the threshold of the first stages of the fourth journey. This day, however, the greater part of those who profess unity are veiled from that station, save such as God willeth. The third rank implied in His words—"turning away from all beside Thee"—is a reality following upon the primal reality expressed in "that I may know Thee." Alas, alas! I myself breathe as one sore oppressed, and cry aloud like the separated ones, in the ocean of decree.

I point to my breast and swear by my Lord: within this is a vast knowledge. Were I to expound all that the knowledge of God hath encompassed in a single letter of that supplication—concerning the station of His unity at the summit of Names and Attributes—it would be beyond the power of God's command to convey. Yet this day none can bear that whereunto I have alluded in that station, save whom God willeth. Sufficient is that which We have distilled and caused to shine forth for thee. Purify therefore thy heart for

God, and turn away from all beside Him; for this day thou art unable to recognize any Cause save by God's leave. Verily, to God do we belong, and unto our Lord shall we return.

On His saying "Say: the Day of Justice shall be…"

As for that which thou didst ask concerning His saying—exalted be His remembrance—"Say: the Day of Justice shall be the day of separation between me and you; on that day God shall inform you of that which ye have laid up and concealed, and which ye understood not"—there is no knowledge thereof today save on the Day of Justice, when God shall instruct me; then shall God acquaint thee with that which He willed. Fear not, however; for in the spacious realm of severance the judgement of reunion is written in the Book of God as truth. Verily, to God do we belong, and unto Him do we return.

On the exposition of the tradition of al-Rida

And as for that which thou didst ask regarding the exposition of the tradition of al-Rida—peace be upon him—addressed to the Exilarch: one letter thereof would not be exhausted by the oceans of heaven and earth. Be thou assured, however, of that which the Imam—peace be upon him—made known to thee in his saying that the Cause is twofold, faith is twofold, yet the judgement concerning them is one.

Disbelief, likewise, is twofold; denial is twofold; Satan himself is twofold. Each of these true conditions is a letter of unity within the letter Ha'; and in like manner, the conditions of falsehood are letters of association within the letter Waw. Their conjunction is unity as facing the unity of the Essence; thereafter is the Cause in prophethood as facing the unity of the Attributes; then the twofold faith is faith in the Cause of guardianship as facing the unity of the Acts; then the Cause in the pillar of the Shi'ah as facing the unity of attraction.

The judgement within these ranks is the knowledge of utterance: that God is the Essence whom no servant shall ever know or worship; from everlasting He is, without the mention of any thing. Whoso seeketh to know Him hath in that very instant associated others with Him; and whoso seeketh to affirm His unity denieth, for as He is, none but He can know Him, and none but He can affirm His oneness. His essentiality severeth all essences from comprehension; His beingness withholdeth all modes of being from expression. He is known through His signs, described by His tokens. Whoso apprehendeth His judgement in the fifth rank glorifieth God to the utmost degree of possibility in the stations of His unity, acknowledging that He as He is can be known by none save Himself, and that He hath no description as He is in Himself. Whoso describeth Him by a description and worshippeth Him thereby hath indeed associated others with Him, and hath not affirmed His unity in the truth of possibility—which is the utmost portion of the servant from creation, and the share of all beings from origination.

He hath no partner in act nor in worship. He createth what He willeth, as He willeth—choosing the thing at the moment of choice, at the moment of choice—without compulsion and without delegation. Nay, this is the mystery of destiny: that there is no creator save God, and no effective power but God. God hath created all things as they are, endowed with choice, and recompenseth them, at the moment of origination, according to their description; He judgeth them, at the moment of their response, by the response of the decree, through a hidden judgement. For the answer, at the moment of origination, is

itself the very question. None perceive, amid the splendors of majesty, those radiant allusions from the horizon of origination, save the men of hearts, in that very instant.

Sufficient for thee, concerning faith, is that which the All-Merciful hath sent down in the Qur'an: The All-Merciful—He hath taught the Qur'an; He created man; He taught him utterance. Were it not for my sorrow over that which the hands of men have wrought, that which lieth within existence would have been made manifest to open vision. Yet today, by God's leave, I withhold from them that which He hath granted me in the knowledge of utterance; upon Him do I rely, at the beginning and at the return.

When you have understood what I have cast upon you of the elixir of unity in the letter Ha', then know the number of the Vav, for these two forms of denial exist and these two rejections are manifest and these two satans are at work. None can attain to the Most Glorious Light in the stations that indicate after the negation of indication except after knowing it in the number of the Vav and being free from its aspects in what they are of that which God, exalted be His glory, detests. The one who gazes with the light of the heart knows from the flowing pen that all that God detests in His knowledge is from the aspects of that number, and its pillars are: denial of the efficient cause in the presence of the unity of the Essence, then the material cause in the presence of the unity of the Attributes, then the formal cause in the presence of the unity of Acts, then the final cause in the raptures of holiness and glory, then the preservation of those manifestations in a single soul, then hesitation in disclaiming what denies a decree from the all-encompassing soul.

Let not the allusions confuse you, nor the indications be difficult for you, for the Essence is the Truth, and whoever has unified Him through the unity of the Essence has unified Him in all stations. All else is His creation and in His grasp. Whoever associates anything of His creation with Him in His unity or His attribute or His act or His worship has denied Him and not unified Him, and will be gathered in the shadow of the number of the Vav and punished by its limits. Whoever worships God purely and sincerely through His attributes with which He has described Himself in His Book has reached the lowest point of the zenith of possibility and ascended the stages of Truth in certitude.

Therefore cleave thou to fear of bada' and rely upon God against the evil of decree; for the Tree of Sinai, by the grace of God, uttereth the Name of Baha in every age. Unto God belongeth praise for what He is in the act of creation. None comprehend these allusions, nor the melodies of the birds of the immaterial realm, nor their trills and purifications within the atmosphere of divinity, nor the reeds of the thicket of dominion, nor the indications of the signs of sovereignty and the Kingdom, save whom God willeth. Despair not of the Spirit of God, for despair is a condition belonging to the letter Waw; rather, beseech God of His bounty, for this is a condition among the manifestations of the letter Ha'. And in every circumstance say: There is no power and no might save in God, the Most Exalted, the Most Great.

On the deeds that God loveth for thee: the silence

As for that which thou didst ask concerning the deeds that God loveth for thee: the silence of the tongue amid the assemblies of Satans; the remembrance of the Utterance in the presence of God and the sincere; and thereafter beware of any deed that stirreth sedition in the religion of God, for such a deed is more grievous than killing in the Book of God. Grieve not over what thou beholdest in the religion of God:

the Christians forged lies against God, the desert Arabs against the Messenger of God—may God's blessings be upon Him and His kindred—and whosoever beareth a light from God hath no escape from encountering the darkness of men. The servant attaineth not unto the station of faith until he behold all falsehood as utterly dead, black as the pupil of a lifeless eye.

Nay—God forgive me for speaking in terms of excess. Be patient, even as the believers before thee were patient; for God hath said—and His word is truth—It was incumbent upon Us to succor the believers. And if thou wert to look today with the eye of reality, thou wouldst behold the victory of God within thine own self; for victory is the truth. Concerning Us it hath been written: I will assuredly prevail, I and My Messengers. Verily God is Powerful, Mighty.

Though it hath ever been witnessed by all that the Messengers of God were accounted liars, and some were slain; yet in the very hour of abasement and seeming defeat they were the true victors and the conquerors. Today the fire of hell hath encompassed the unbelievers. Fear not, neither be thou dismayed; but say as God hath said in the Qur'an: The Messenger hath believed in that which hath been sent down unto him from his Lord, and so have the believers. All believe in God, His angels, His Books, and His Messengers; we make no distinction between any of His Messengers. And they say: We have heard and we obey. Grant us Thy forgiveness, O our Lord, and unto Thee is the return.

God burdeneth no soul beyond its capacity; it shall have the good it hath earned, and bear the ill it hath wrought. Our Lord! Take us not to task if we forget or err. Our Lord! Lay not upon us a burden such as Thou didst lay upon those before us. Our Lord! Burden us not with that which we have no strength to bear. Pardon us, forgive us, and have mercy upon us. Thou art our Protector; so help us against the people who disbelieve. And say: Our Lord! Pour out upon us patience, and give us victory over the transgressing people. And verily, unto our Lord are we steadfast.

On the holy passage from the Prayer of Lamentation, know thou

As for what thou hast asked concerning the holy passage from the Prayer of Lamentation, know thou with certainty that all letters tell of but a single letter, and all differences return to a single point, and the Cause of God is but one. And that which he—may my spirit be a sacrifice for him—hath indicated in his words "And I have offered unto them the Most Exalted Remembrance and the Most Glorious Praise" is a reference to that which God hath specially conferred upon the Imams of Justice through the sublimity of His Will and the praise of His Purpose, wherein no thing can precede them in that nobility, nor can any servant equal them in that station. All besides them have no mention in their presence, and if they are mentioned, they are only mentioned in the shadow of their manifestation unto others through their own selves.

They are the foremost ones in the heaven of divinity and the praise of the realm of might and in the dark clouds of dominion and kingdom. Nay, there is no life in the existence of creation except through them and their manifestation. Through them move the moving things among those who are in the depths of union, and through them rest the resting things among those who are in the depths of separation. They are servants of God who act according to His command, and they are in fear of His awe. Among them is a living Imam from whom nothing of knowledge is hidden, and verily he is the one who renews the

tradition with the new tradition, and verily he is the fulfiller who restores the glorious sovereignty. None knoweth him in this station save He Who created him, and we are but submitters unto Him.

On the inner interpretation of that blessed verse

As for what thou hast asked concerning the inner interpretation of that blessed verse "Until, when the apostles despaired, and the people imagined that they had been untruthful, Our help came unto them, and whom We would was delivered. But Our punishment will not be averted from the people who are sinners," verily its reality hath appeared. Nay, by thy Lord, there shall come unto men God's term, then suddenly the Hour, then all shall be gathered unto God thy Lord. Then the Hour of God shall arrive [in perfect eloquence], suddenly shall it come, then all shall be gathered unto God thy Lord. And verily from knowledge of these signs thou shalt understand the meaning of this verse from the Qur'an: "The heaven, We have built it with might, and We verily are powerful to expand it."

Indeed what is meant by His exalted mention "with might" is the repetition of the degrees of action which equal in their number the letters of "hand," being fourteen in count, and this is the mystery of the name "the All-Bountiful," "the Countenance," "the Generous," and "the Hand." He who knoweth the signs understandeth that which the Lord of Names and Attributes knoweth not, neither through signs nor their negation. Verily the opposites in the judgment of the Book return through justice when thou observest therein the decree of [grace].

What We have indicated to thee regarding the Seven sufficeth by what We have sworn by the Seven, and they are: Will, Purpose, Destiny, Decree, Permission, Term, and the Book. When thou observest the signs of the Answer, thou shalt witness the Balance of correspondence in the pavilion of the Cause. Verily in those impenetrable, pitch-dark, blind, and gloomy depths of hell is the number of the letter Vav, and in the presence of the Manifestation of the Word is that which equals the number of the letter Ha.

The possessors of understanding know not here except through what is here. Through this the decree was known once. The signs in the depths of those indications were known, but today thou art not able save by God's leave. And whoso knoweth what hath dawned and gleamed, and witnesseth what hath shone forth and glittered and illumined, yet turneth away—his connection is severed after having been joined in what he hath attained and seen. He knoweth the decree of connection in the midst of separation between the letter Alif and Lam. Thus hath he attained the seats of mysteries and witnessed the light of lights and feared the justice of the Almighty, for the cycles have been adorned with mountain peaks and the repetitions have been adorned with cycles.

And verily through the traditions [from] the pure ones, the decree of the righteous returneth through the mystery of free will to the Book of the chosen ones, and the decree of mysteries through the law of necessity to the Book of the wicked. And upon God do thou rely, then by God's command be silent in manifesting through proclamation, for when the sun is raised in the fourth heaven, all shall witness God's command therein that unto God return all matters. Glory be to God, Lord of the Throne, above what they attribute, and peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, Lord of the worlds.

Take from this red elixir what God hath permitted thee, and revive thereby all the verses and traditions. For when thou gatherest together the opposites on the Day which is equivalent to a thousand years of your reckoning, they are transformed by God's leave into harmonious elements. And likewise with all that thou desirest regarding the path of things conjoined and separate. And whatsoever thou hast asked concerning the verses and traditions shall be revived with thy Lord through this flowing water from the spring which God hath created in this House, which hath no end. If thou comprehendest what We have distilled unto thee and thy heart findeth rest in what We have bestowed upon thee, then praise God, thy Lord. Otherwise, ask thereafter from the Book of Justice, for therein is the decree of all things which We have detailed in a clear Book.

As for what thou didst desire regarding the derivative laws, take all that thou hast understood from Our allusions, and concerning that which thy knowledge encompasseth not, act according to what hath been revealed in the traditions to the utmost degree. We have not neglected anything in the Book. How canst thou mention the words of Kazim—may my spirit be a sacrifice for him—regarding the station of the Shi'ih while not acting upon its laws, when thou seest that the ray hath been concealed like unto its source? But think not that I am veiled from manifest presence, for your Guardian is not heedless of what ye need. If ye have learned all that ye desired in Our days, then give thanks to God, your Creator. Otherwise, let your souls be at rest through the proof that hath shone forth from the dawn of eternity, which none can produce the like thereof, just as ye act upon the Qur'an and traditions though ye know not all their laws. Say: Despair not of God's Spirit, for the gates of questioning are opened and the answer is assured for whosoever calleth upon Him. He is not veiled from you nor heedless of your concerns.

Say to those who desire disputation and dwell beneath the tree of argument: Close the gates of your questioning and act according to what hath been revealed in the "Alfayn" from your Guardian, and dispute with people through it and through what We have revealed in the interpretation of [the Surah of] Kawthar, for it is a Book wherein are mentioned, when God willeth, the laws of Return and what ye desire.

On the rapturous allusions, the Hour hath come unto thee

As for what thou asked regarding the rapturous allusions, the Hour hath come unto thee with truth and thy Lord shall reward thee for thy striving. And concerning what thou asked about healing thine eye from the white spot, if God willeth to remove it, recite after every prayer the Verse of Light:

> "God is the Light of the heavens and the earth. The parable of His Light is as a niche wherein is a lamp. The lamp is in a glass. The glass is as it were a shining star. (Kindled) from a blessed tree […] though fire touched it not. Light upon Light. God guideth unto His Light whom He will. God speaketh to mankind in allegories, and God knoweth all things."

As for what was written regarding the law of answering through the Tongue of Life, far be it to think of thee thus, for verily the abode of the Hereafter is Life indeed, if ye be of them that are certain.

On the four names in the air, be thou discerning

And concerning what thou asked about the four names in the air, be thou discerning and perceptive regarding the allusions. The air is that which God created between the body of the Imam and his heart, and when it descendeth, it descendeth at once upon the Messenger of God and then upon the Imams of Justice—the blessings of God be upon them—and there is nothing with them except that the Messenger of God—peace be upon him—hath preceded them therein. And verily the Messenger of God (peace be upon Him and His family) preceded them, and verily the Kawthar water which We gave thee to drink brought those signs to life.

On the two prostrations of forgetfulness, recite in them

As to what thou hast asked concerning the two prostrations of forgetfulness, recite in them "In the Name of God" and "By God" and "God's blessings be upon Muhammad and His family." And when thou sittest, recite the two testimonies, then send blessings upon Muhammad and His family, then speak the word of peace. And unto God do we make our complaint, both in the Hereafter and in this world.

On pre-seminal and seminal fluid, there is nothing prescribed for them

And as to what thou hast asked concerning pre-seminal and seminal fluid, there is nothing prescribed for them, but I love cleansing when God hath permitted man to purify himself.

On the matter of disagreement—if thou didst intend

And as to what thou hast asked concerning the matter of disagreement—if thou didst intend the ruling about doubt in the evening prayer, then complete the prayer, and if thou intended another matter, then inform me so that I may reveal unto thee another verse.

And as for what thou desired concerning complete understanding in the laws of purity, if God were to permit me I would mention it afterwards, God willing, but God hath revealed all jurisprudence in these words:

> "Fear ye God; God shall teach you, and verily God's promise shall be fulfilled."

As for what thou hast mentioned regarding thy wonderment at marveling at my Cause—if thou dost marvel, then marvel, and if thou dost not marvel, then marvel at thy soul's wonderment. We have not neglected anything in the Book, and no one hath any proof against Me; rather, the proof is Mine against all the worlds. Know thou these days, for never hath the sun risen upon their like. Raise up the Cause of God and fear not the party of Satan nor the friends of those who disbelieve and transgress, for verily the party of Satan was ever weak. But fear God, lest thou utter a word that would cause sedition around us, and speak unto them in kindly words.

On commerce, mention unto the people Our signs and raise up

As for what thou didst inquire regarding commerce, mention unto the people Our signs and raise up Our tokens, for God hath ever been a profitable commerce for the sincere ones. And concerning what thou didst ask about anointing the head during ritual impurity, it is incumbent upon thee three times, but for the right and left sides once sufficeth thee—like oil when thou canst not find water or art unable to use it. Say: Verily He is All-Encompassing.

As for thy question about washing the hands, it is as is known among you from the elbow to the fingertips. And regarding what thou asked about being compelled away from Me, fear not, for the believers in that sedition are like the leaves of the tree of love—the tree doth not turn away from thee when thou hast not withered. Cast not thyself down, but fear God and hold fast to the firm handle that cannot be broken, and be thou of the thankful ones.

As for what dawned upon thee concerning what God revealed unto thee when thou desired wondrous proofs, matchless verses, beautiful stations and subtle signs—God knoweth them; I have no knowledge save what my Lord hath taught me. Verily I have forsaken the path of the people who believe not in the Hereafter and are disbelievers. Say: Had I that which ye seek to hasten, the matter would be decided between me and you. God knoweth best the questioners. But verily I saw thee one day in the sacred court and spoke with thee. Alas! Alas! Were the Master alive he would lift my sorrow and give me peace. O Lord, draw nigh the days of meeting Thee, for this world hath passed and unto Thee do we return.

As for thy question about defiled vessels, once sufficeth thee in running water, but in standing water when thou seest signs of cloudiness, wash twice. And regarding what thou asked about the call to prayer and the standing prayer—I love not that thou shouldst abandon them in obligatory prayers, though if thou abandon them entirely, no blame attacheth to thee. The call to prayer may be omitted if thou desirest not to give it, but the standing prayer is incumbent upon thee from God's Book, glory be to Him.

As for thy question about the two prostrations of forgetfulness, recite them after prayer when thou hast entered into prayer. And regarding the prayer of precaution, I judge not for thee separation but rather continuation, lest something be omitted from thy prayer. If thou practice separation, God will question thee concerning it, though God is kind to His servants.

As for thy question about recitation, verily I know not the people's conventions, and though I would love to know I know not. But the balance is in My hands—it is the pure nature. However, proper pronunciation in its proper places is the right of the eloquent reciter. Those whose voices cause hearts to recoil are among those who follow Satan's promptings—these are they who are the lost.

And verily those whose voices repel hearts are among those who follow the promptings of Satan, and these are they who are the lost. And as for those who ask thee concerning the tradition regarding one like unto Yaqtin, say: I have no knowledge. God effaceth what He willeth and confirmeth what He willeth, and with Him is the Mother of the Book.

On seeing him, peace be upon him, God hath willed

And concerning what thou hast asked about seeing him, peace be upon him, God hath willed that none should see him save the truthful ones, as mentioned by Muhammad ibn ʿIsa al-Bahrani. And whosoever claims to have seen him, say: they lie. And as for what hath come in his missive, peace be upon him, it is true that God effaceth what He willeth and confirmeth what He willeth, and with Him is the Mother of the Book. And concerning what thou hast asked about the Book of Laws, act according to it, but compare it with what hath been revealed by Me, for verily conjecture is a sin that availeth naught against truth. And verily what hath been revealed here for thee, if thou seest no error in it, is truth, and if thou seest an error in any book from Me, then I shall change it by God's leave, for it is not from Me, and God knoweth all that people know not.

On the prayer of making up missed prayers, make them up

And concerning what thou hast asked about the prayer of making up missed prayers, make them up as hath been ordained and perform the obligatory prayers at their appointed times, for God loveth from among the believers those who act according to what He hath commanded them, and He is indeed Self-Sufficient, All-Appreciating.

On the tradition of Jabir, I have indeed sprinkled a drop

And concerning what thou hast asked about the tradition of Jabir, I have indeed sprinkled a drop from the ocean of divine decree in its interpretation in the tongue of the Persians, and if thou wishest to interpret it in truth, take from the elixir which I have cast unto thee and revive therewith the earth of hearts and souls, for God loveth the believers.

On the ordinance of thy obedience on the witnessed night, God

And concerning what thou hast asked about the ordinance of thy obedience on the witnessed night, God knoweth its wisdom, for knowledge belongeth unto God and unto whomsoever He willeth. And verily thy newborn on the indicated night is a remembrance from God that thou mayest know the power of God in the nineteen days which was the number of gates […] before the sacred month which is the gate of Paradise. And rely thou upon God, then pray for mankind and curse the sun and moon in their calculated courses.

On the Imams of justice, peace be upon them, having made

And concerning what thou hast asked about the Imams of justice, peace be upon them, having made themselves a condition of mentioning God, exalted be He, this is true, and We have indeed removed the veil from this mystery in the interpretation of Kawthar—read what We have revealed therein, for it is indeed a wondrous matter.

On the prayer of precaution […] and verily the punishment

And concerning what thou hast asked about the prayer of precaution […] and verily the punishment is inevitable, and none can avert the decree of God.

Concerning adhan and iqamah—yes, they may be omitted. However, on Friday if you perform the Friday prayer with a just person, then yes [they should be performed]. But [on Friday] if you pray the noon prayer alone, I love that you recite after it the Prayer of Lamentation, then give the call to prayer and perform the afternoon prayer. And this is God's grace to all the believers.

On speaking with [strange] women whom God has not permitted you

As for what you asked about speaking with [strange] women whom God has not permitted you to see—God has not permitted it in the Book except out of necessity, and then only five words. Fear God and be not among the despairing ones.

On contracts—it is right in God's Book that they

And as for what you asked about contracts—it is right in God's Book that they be between two parties, and thus should the sincere ones act.

On the laws of fasting and its customs, and the laws

Concerning what you asked about the laws of fasting and its customs, and the laws of purification and its conditions—if God permits me I shall expound upon these later, God willing. But you should avoid among people dust which would alter your taste, and if something reaches you, expel it with your mouth, for I do not love for anyone [to be other than among the God-fearing].

On taking certain properties from the believers, both men and women

As for what you asked about taking certain properties from the believers, both men and women—know that for the fifth (khums) among people, half is the right of the assured believers in this Cause [from the descendants of Hashim] and half is the right of the Imam, peace be upon him. And it is obligatory upon its owner to deliver it to whom God has appointed to His Cause, or to make provision in his property until the Day when God takes His right. And verily, may my spirit be sacrificed for him, his right is not lawful for people, as was explicitly stated in that sublime directive from that holy, exalted, most high One:

"In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate. The curse of God and the angels and all mankind be upon whoever makes lawful for himself even one dirham from our properties." However, concerning the descendants of Ali, peace be upon him, according to what the scholar mentioned in his chapter from beyond the White Sea, on the authority of the trusted noble Munir Shams al-Din son of the Fifth Proof, peace be upon him—and this ruling is in accordance with the primary traditions that were revealed regarding permissibility from [illegible] [peace be upon them] the pure ones, upon them be the blessings of God, the Almighty Sovereign.

And you—take the right of justice when anyone sends it to you, then preserve it until I give you permission. But fear God and be among the humble ones. Glory be to God, Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. And peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, Lord of the worlds.

BB00100: Alfayn Munajat

Part 1: "Praise be to God Who, by His command…"

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who, by His command, hath fashioned the heavens and the earth, and Who shall gather unto their Lord all who have believed in God and in His signs. O my God! Thou art verily God, the Lord of heaven and earth. All things are known unto Thee; naught in the heavens or on the earth is hidden from Thee.

Thou, of a certainty, art aware that on this very day a letter hath been sent down unto me from one of Thy servants, because he had implored the tokens of Thy power and the evidences of Thy stations.

Wherefore, behold me, O my God, calling upon Thee with a lowly heart and trembling limbs. How could I speak in Thy presence when I know that all paths are cut off and every proof withheld from all? And how could I remain silent before the City of Thy might, when Thou art in that state which none but Thyself can comprehend? Thou hast commanded me to supplicate, and Thou hast sent down upon the arrogant the word of chastisement, that Thou mightest draw me into the court of Thy nearness, admit me among Thy chosen servants in Thy precincts, cause me to drink of the water of the wine in cups of pearl through the hands of Thy mercy, and bestow upon me the bounties of Thy Paradise in Thy presence, before the throne of Thy majesty.

Happy is one such as I, if Thou be indeed my Remembrancer! Happy—nay, thrice happy—am I, if Thou be my Companion! Happy—nay, thrice happy—am I, if Thou be my Speaker! Through Thee I have loved Thee; for were it not for Thee, I had been naught. Through Thee I have known Thee; for were it not for Thee, I should not have known how Thou art the Lord. All praise be unto Thee, O my God, for what Thou dost inspire into me of the hidden meanings of Thy verses, for that Thou dost honor me at every moment with the breaths of Thy days, and draw me at every instant through the gracious favors of Thy bountifulness. How sweet to me is Thy remembrance!

How glorious to me is Thy bounty! How great in my sight is Thy mercy! Through Thee I have been enabled to utter the praises of Thy sanctity; through Thee have I remembered the favors of Thy Paradise; through Thee have I given thanks for the majesty of Thy everlasting Singleness. How sweet art Thou to me, O my God, in my secret being, and how sweet art Thou to me, O my God, in my outward state! Through Thee have I been patient; but for Thy promise I had been dead. Through Thee have I endured; but for Thy succor I had been forgotten and lost.

Glorified art Thou! Shall one such as Thou, my Lord—powerful over all things—be patient in regard to me? Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou! Shall one such as Thou, O my God—knowing all things—behold

me in sorrow? By Thy might, I love not any of Thy doings nor am I heedless of Thy chastisements. Whenever Thou dost afflict me with sorrow, I take hold of a portion of the mantle of my Lord. My Lord, my Lord, my Lord, my Lord, my Lord, my Lord! Cast me not away from Thy door, and seize me not through Thy justice; for I am a prisoner to Thy praise, seeking refuge within Thy court, fearful of Thy justice and in need of Thy mercy. And whenever Thou dost rebuke me, I lay hold of a portion of the robe of Thy might, and cry: My God, my God, my God, my God, my God, my God!

Gladden me not with aught that would cause me to forget Thy favors and Thy bounties; and suffer me not to be contented so that I cease to ask of Thy gifts and Thy salutations. For I am poor at Thy gate, thankful for Thy blessings, trembling before Thy chastisements, enraptured by Thy signs. Thou art God, my Lord; none can empty my heart of remembrance of any save Thee—Thou alone, without partner. O my God! Whenever calamity descendeth upon me, I say: This is naught but of Thy mercy; and whenever joy descendeth upon me, I say: This is naught but of Thy trial, that Thou mayest test me by the bounties of Thy kingdom and turn me away from aught save Thy face, then seize me in my heedlessness.

Glorified art Thou! There is no God but Thee. I seek refuge in Thy very Self from the remembrance of any beside Thee, and I cleave to Thy love lest I enter stations remote from Thy presence.

And verily, O my God, when there now descendeth upon me the breath of the morning of meeting with Thee, and I hear, in the expanse of the air, the warbling of the birds of the unseen, mercy overcometh me and casteth out vengeance. Hope crieth aloud, even in the face of chastisement:

> “Give thanks unto Him for that which He endureth in thy regard.”

Through Thee is my heart stilled, and my inmost being emptied of all save Thee; and I lie upon the couch of Thy tenderness for less than a tenth of a ninth of the minutes of the hours.

O my God! Thou art He Who hath created me and sustained me, and then hast honored me and raised me up; then hast inspired me and strengthened me, and hast caused Thy verses to descend upon me. Why, then, hast Thou been patient, O my God, in dealing with the unjust? Is it not that Thou wast the God of all worlds? Is it not that I was a servant of the faithful? Why didst Thou, O my God, behold the deeds of the slanderers? Is it not that Thou wast the Lord of the truly one? Is it not that I was a servant of the repentant? Why didst Thou, O my God, hear uttered against me the words of the hypocrites?

Is it not that Thou wast the Helper of the wronged? Is it not that I was a servant of the oppressed? Why hast Thou called Thyself All-Knowing and All-Powerful, and yet, in the hour of dire necessity, hast not commanded the fire, nor said: “Be thou coolness and peace unto My believing servants”? Why didst Thou deliver Abraham from the fire, and yet unveil for me the tests of fire? For I have not beheld, in Thy dealings, a straight path: at one time Thou dost destroy all the wrongdoers for the she-camel of Salih, and at another Thou dost endure, in the case of one like unto Husayn—upon him be peace—until the idolaters compass about the chiefs of Thy near ones amongst men, and bring them into the presence of the unbelievers.

Glory be to Thee, glory be to Thee! All my sorrow is from Thee, and all my hope is of Thee. To Thee be praise, in that Thou hast preserved me from the shameful deeds of the unjust and from the grievous

assaults of the idolaters. Glory be to Thee, glory be to Thee! When I stood before Thee upon the throne of nearness, I dared against Thee and spoke, and I feared not my remoteness from Thee nor Thy justice, for I knew Thy nearness and Thy bounty, if I was patient in tribulation.

Yet Thou, O my God, art more patient than I; for Thou hast heard from the Christians and the Jews the word of association, and Thou hast borne with them. Glory be to Thee! I turn unto Thee in repentance, and I am the first of the repentant. I implore Thy forgiveness, O my God, for all that Thy knowledge hath encompassed concerning me, and which Thy Book recordeth against me. Behold me, then, penitent before Thee, clinging to Thy cord, trusting in Thee alone, without partner, and committing my whole affair into Thy hands. Excellent art Thou, O my God, as Protector, and excellent art Thou, O my Master, as Help in need. All good is from Thee and for Thee; it descendeth from Thy presence and returneth unto Thee. Thou alone—there is no God but Thee. And all evil is by Thy command, yet shall it not be ascribed unto Thee.

Glory be to Thee, O God! Thou art the God Who hath existed before all things, Who will exist after all things and will last beyond all things. Thou art the God Who knoweth all things, and is supreme over all things. Thou art the God Who dealeth mercifully with all things, Who judgeth between all things and Whose vision embraceth all things. Thou art God my Lord, Thou art aware of my position, Thou dost witness my inner and outer being. Grant Thy forgiveness unto me and unto the believers who responded to Thy Call. Be Thou my sufficing helper against the mischief of whosoever may desire to inflict sorrow upon me or wish me ill. Verily Thou art the Lord of all created things. Thou dost suffice everyone, while no one can be self-sufficient without Thee.

Shield, O God, Thy believing servants from the evil of all enemies, by the truth of Muhammad and His kindred—Thy blessings be upon them. For through Thee do I traverse the seas of mine enemies; and, by Thy leave, make the letters Kaf-Ha-Ya-Ayn-Sad, and then Ha-Mim-Ayn-Sin-Qaf, my talisman against them all. Admit me, then, into Thy protection in the land of safety; guard me with Thine eye that sleepeth not; strengthen me through Thy sovereignty that suffereth no abasement; shelter me beneath Thy pillar that none can assail; have mercy upon me by Thy power which hath prevailed over all things; preserve me from stumbling by Thy mercy which hath embraced all things; confirm me in every state by the light of Thy countenance wherewith all things are illumined; and vouchsafe unto me, in every condition, the grace of Thy Name that hath been established beneath Thy shadow, which goeth not forth unto any save Thyself, which is not sought by aught beside Thee, nor befitteth any other than Thee—the Most Great, the Most Glorious, the Most Bountiful Name—whereby Thou didst reveal Thyself unto Moses upon the mountain, and the mountain was crushed, and Moses fell swooning; and when he recovered, he said:

> "Glory be to Thee! I turn to Thee in repentance, and I am the first of them that worship."

O my God! How many a bounty hast Thou bestowed upon me, yet I have failed to render Thee the thanks due therefor! How many an affliction hast Thou visited upon me, yet I have failed to show the patience that befitteth it! How many a word of inspiration hast Thou breathed into my secret being, yet I have not bowed down in my outward life before Thy face! How many a word of mystery hast Thou strengthened me by, yet I have not turned wholly unto Thee! Glory be to Thee, glory be to Thee! Thou art the Ever-Known, the Ever-Abiding, the All-Powerful, the Self-Subsisting, the One Who standeth over all things.

Part 2: “And I, O my God, have been guilty…”

And I, O my God, have been guilty of great rebellion and mighty transgressions. Hadst Thou not mercy upon me, hadst Thou not forgiven me, who could forgive me? I am he who disobeyed Thee in secret, yet Thou didst not expose me; and I am he who associated others with Thy bounties in the open, yet Thou didst not abase me; and I am he who acquired sins, and Thou didst forbear with me. By Thy might and Thy majesty, O my God, I have found none more bountiful than Thee, nor do I know one more laden with offences than myself. Thou art He Who hath honored; Thou art He Who hath brought forth; Thou art He Who hath originated; Thou art He Who hath quickened; Thou art He Who hath sustained; Thou art He Who hath numbered; Thou art He Who hath forgiven; Thou art He Who hath pardoned; Thou art He Who hath been patient; Thou art He Who hath seen; Thou art He Who hath witnessed; Thou art He Who hath inspired; Thou art He Who hath confirmed; Thou art He Who hath bestowed; Thou art He Who hath preferred; Thou art He Who hath done good; Thou art He Who hath repelled; Thou art He Who hath spread; Thou art He Who hath preserved; Thou art He Who hath sufficed; Thou art He Who hath known; Thou art He Who hath accepted; Thou art He Who hath raised up; Thou art He Who hath sent down; Thou art He Who hath distinguished; Thou art He Who hath delivered; Thou art He Who hath manifested; Thou art He Who hath concealed; Thou art He Who hath made plain; Thou art He Who hath perfected; glory be to Thee, glory be to Thee, O God—there is no God but Thee—glory be to Thee! Verily I have been of the wrongdoers.

How, then, shall I mention mine own self, O my God, when I know that the mention of myself, in the presence of the City of Thy power, is a sin wherewith no sin can be compared; and that, were Thou to punish me through the everlastingness of Thine Essence as a recompense for my remembrance before Thee, I should indeed deserve it; and Thou art the All-Praised—Thou wilt never deal unjustly with any one.

Yet, O my God, I desire the dawning of the sun of Thy pardon and Thy mercy; therefore do I mention a little of the much that Thy Book recordeth against me, that haply one of the dwellers of the heavens and the earth may hear my cry, weep over me, and call upon Thee for my forgiveness. And Thou lovest that Thou shouldst hear his prayer and answer him; and thereby I should be forgiven in Thy presence.

O my God, my Lord, my Master, my Protector, my Owner! I am he who hath remembered himself without right; I am he who doth not remember Thee as Thou dost deserve; I am he who denied Thy verses after Thou hadst made them manifest to me in all things; I am he who was heedless of Thy bounties, though bounties encompassed me from every side; I am he who sinned, who erred, who forgot, who was negligent, who turned away, who transgressed, who fell short; I am he who entered the land of the “Glories” without Thy leave; I am he who sought forgiveness for my faults and returned unto them; I felt no shame before Thee in the midst of men; I disobeyed Thee, O Almighty of the heavens and of the earth, after Thou hadst taught me Thy chastisements and caused me to behold Thy visitations.

Alas, alas! If I sit before the throne of Thy dominion, hoping for Thy forgiveness, Thy decrees and Thy justice terrify me; and if I weep over myself, knowing Thy justice and Thy decrees, Thy dealings with Thy near ones that encircle Thy throne draw me on. Alas, alas! If Thou wouldst decree, by the rule of justice,

concerning me, I swear by Thy might that I have no power to endure Thy justice; and if Thou shouldst cast me, for what mine hands have wrought, into the fire—by Thy truth, besides which there is no God—I have no power to bear separation for days without remembrance of Thee, nor remoteness from the presence of Thy chosen ones among Thy purest friends.

O my God! Thou art rich without my torment, and I am poor in need of Thy forgiveness. If Thou admit me into the court of Thy nearness, naught will be diminished from Thy kingdom; and if Thou chastise me with the fire of Thy justice, naught will be added unto Thy kingdom. Yet if Thou permit me unto Thy good-pleasure, my heart will be emptied of all save Thee, my soul will rejoice, my secret will be stilled, and my outward state will be gladdened—nay, all who are in the kingdoms of Thy heaven and Thine earth will rejoice in Thy bounty toward me and in Thy generosity in my regard, and will say, one and all:

> "Thou art God; there is no God but Thee, the Possessor of grace and beneficence and bounty and favor; verily Thou art the Lord of great bounty."

Glory be to Thee, O my God! Far, far be it from my thought that I should think of Thee otherwise than as forgiving and well-pleased. By Thy might, I have not thought, nor do I think, by Thy power and Thy strength, that Thou wouldst will for me aught save Thy good-pleasure, Thy pardon, Thy concealment, and Thy generosity.

How, then, O my God, shall I complain of what hath befallen me by Thy decree and by Thy leave? At one time the sun of Thy being and Thy mercy riseth upon my right hand, and thereby am I at rest before the City of Thy power; and at another Thou dost permit it to set upon my left, whereupon darkness encompasseth me, and the earth speaketh to me in signs. In this moment I weep for my station of nearness; then I weep for my station of intimacy; then I weep for my station of supplication; then I weep for my loneliness from the seat of my loved ones; then I weep for that from which I have been veiled of Thy breaths in my regard; then I weep for what the earth telleth me of its "I-ness," and occupieth me from Thy remembrance; then I weep for that which Thou knowest of my station—how Thou art patient in regard to me.

O my God! Should I weep until the spirit departeth from my body, I shall not taste delight nor find repose until the sun hath risen again from the place of its rising. Then shall I bear witness unto Thine own Self with that wherewith Thou bearest witness unto Thine Essence before all things: that Thou hast ever been, from everlasting, in Thy primal state, and wilt ever remain; that Thou art as Thou wast in the beginning; none can know Thee, for Thy selfhood cutteth off all from the path, and Thy very "I-ness" shutteth the worlds from proof. Thou art God, the Ever-Abiding, the Single, the One, the Self-Subsisting, the Incomparable, the Living, the Self-Subsisting; no description from aught can seize Thee, nor can any attribute from aught encompass Thee. Verily Thou art God, the Lord of the worlds. […?]

And now I seal my prayer before Thee with the mention of the dwellers of Paradise in the Qur'an: "Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds."

O God! Thou verily knowest that in that latter inquiry hath been made concerning the Pure Soul slain in the land of Kufih, and concerning him who shall arise from Khurasan and Taliqan, and concerning the rule of the Sayyid of the Hasani line.

O God! Thou knowest that I know nothing save what Thou hast taught me, and with Thee is the knowledge of all things in a Book that neither erreth nor forgetteth. And even as I have believed, had bada' not been decreed for those ordinances, all these would surely have appeared by God's leave; nor doth bada' occur in what hath been promised unto the chosen ones of the All-Merciful. Today I know not my own self, nor do I say that I am one of them, nor that they circle or refrain around that matter. Yet in the inward station there is no doubt that the Bearer of that Most Great Name is greater than them all in the Book of God; and they are servants who shall appear, if God willeth, when God willeth.

I bear a knowledge like unto that of Kazim; if God manifesteth another command, it shall be the joy of mine eye—otherwise I lay no claim, nor say that I am one of them. And Thou, O my God, knowest the lands of obedience, and that today the land known of men is a land of Khurasan, then beyond Qazvin; yet I know not whether it be a land between Mecca and the Kufih—God knoweth its place. Far, far is the Day of the manifestation of the Cause! Had men not denied this Cause, haply God would have forgiven them and hastened the days of His Proof; but today they have deprived themselves of the blessings of the days of manifestation. I beseech God, my Lord, to forgive me and to hasten the days of His sovereignty. Verily there is no God but He, the Possessor of surpassing bounty.

O God! I bear witness before Thee that he who shall arise from Khurasan and Taliqan, who shall be slain between the Corner and the Station and upon the plain of Kufih, and whose hosts shall be joined to the army of truth—men whom God shall cause to appear if He willeth—verily the promise of God hath been fulfilled.

Glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they ascribe unto Him! And peace be upon the Messengers. Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00364: Fi Bayani Lawhi'l-Mahfuz (Letter on the Preserved Tablet) (part II)

The questioner inquired of the Preserved Tablet; make thou known unto him that which the All-Encompassing God hath wrought. Behold, I have cast unto thee from the outpourings of those resplendent Tablets, until every people hath come to know its own draught from the spring which God hath placed within the most hidden recess of the secret of their inmost hearts—that men may know that God created the heavens and the earth, haply they may believe through the knowledge of God. Foreordained for him in the Book was faith in that intended matter—"Doth not He Who created know?—He is the Subtle, the All-Aware." The believers from among the people of the Bab and of the Book have followed it, bearing witness to that ink, according to what God hath made to flow in the Tablet of rectitude: verily God hath ever been All-Knowing of all things.

And God hath appointed for the downtrodden among men and women a safeguarded Book. Glorified be God, the All-Knowing, Who hath fashioned things by the art of choice in a manner worthy of the wondrous lights: by the Will—the secret of possibilities; by the Purpose—the hidden core of existents; and by Decree—He ordained the triune marking for the sake of the sign of delimitation. From this did the Christians take the form of the cross and the notion of the indwelling of lahut in nasut. The Beloved hath

informed of their corrupted consciences, and the Christians said, “God is the third of three,” though He is but One God—exalted be He above that which they associate!

After the creation of Decree, the All-Merciful adjudged the Judgment, established for the people of effacement and confirmation, that We should not enforce upon you the ordinance of alteration (badaʾ), inasmuch as God knew within your souls the exigency thereof. God hath ratified what He decreed, and naught of the Cause of God is subject to nullification. Moreover, the All-Merciful warned His servants, after the decree of effacement and confirmation, lest men speak concerning God aught but the truth. The Imam—upon him be peace—said: “The spirits of the qadaris are exposed to the Fire, morning and evening, until the Hour ariseth; and when the Hour hath arisen, they shall be chastised with the people of the Fire by divers punishments. Then they shall say: O our Lord! Thou hast chastised us in particular and chastised us in general!’ And one, the keeper of Saqar, shall answer them: Verily, We created all things by a fixed measure.”’

Thereafter did the All-Merciful set, following the Judgment of ratification, that there is no grasping nor outspreading, nor in the realm of possibility any thing, save by the leave of the All-Merciful. God thus ordained this ratification for what He had placed within the Judgment, by the mystery of exigency; and thou shalt never find any change in the wont of God. Then did the All-Wise inform, after the establishing of the five, of the decree of the Term and the Book, that naught of the ordinances of the Gate should fall from aught of things. God appointed the Term for the sake of causes, and He exalted the Book through the establishing of effects—so that naught of existents should escape from the Book, but that they should find it expounded in causes within this Book, and its reasons made plain in the secret of this Gate.

God hath made that Book the Greater Tablet, and hath decreed therein what was initiated in the Beginning and in the Seal. God ordained for that Book two gates—the secret of the two Tutanjs—upon the twin gulfs of water: the one, the sweet water of Kawthar—the realities of the sublime among the people of the two Easts, the near ones; the other, the bitter salty water—the people of the two Wests, the far-removed. God engraved upon each gate the images of the triad, and within the image of the triad the temple of the triad, that the gates of Gehenna be fully nine and the arrows ten, by the ruling of the Ancient. Yet within the inwardness of that Tablet He placed mercy and rest, while upon its outward face, from before God, there is chastisement. Glorified be God, its Fashioner, exalted above that which they ascribe!

BB00244: Bayan fi ’Ilm al-Jawamid wa’l-Mushtaqat

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate! All praise be to God Who hath singled out His loved ones with supreme glorification and distinguished His gates in the knowledge of the exalted substances, Who hath described His beloved ones in the Mother Book for the purpose of describing that Gate of Return in answering questions amidst the gathering of the beloved to the seeker standing in the land of allusions from the paths of glory. Glorified be God, Creator of earth and heaven, above what people imagine concerning the paths of His love through ways of attribution and finality.

O ye company of lights! Fear God, your True Lord, by entering into the depths of otherness, for God hath honored the chosen ones with lights at the Dayspring of mysteries. Verily the Sun hath risen in truth at the zenith of heaven at noontide. By the Lord of the House! There is no escape for anything save through entering that Gate of Return, after being forbidden from allusions and infinities. The people of the two sacred places have falsified concerning thy sin, for thine is the questioning of the two questioners. The light is naught but in the two souls, the mystery naught but in the two names, and truth naught but in the two worlds, save from this Soul, the mystery of the ancients.

O people of the two stations! Verily your Ancient Lord hath made this Gate the mystery of the two lights among the latter ones, the manifestation of the two appearances on the two mounts. He is the light upon the two foreheads, the luminary of the two luminous ones, the radiant one at the dayspring of the two easts and the two wests. He is the pure water in the two gulfs, the fire in the two trees, the camphor water in the two rivers, the mystery of manifestation in the two vessels, and the forgiving cause in the two stations, through the knowledge of the two Imams in the mystery of this Gate, the mystery of the two lights from the temple of the two primary pockets.

The questioner hath known what God hath bestowed upon thee from the sprinklings of His lights and the essence of mysteries, and the world of manifestation from the point of the cloud in crimson hue, and upon the point of radiance through the letter of praise, and at the rising of Cancer in white hue, until he turned back from the fire of regression and acknowledged the power of the Almighty in those lights upon the paths of the chosen ones through the mystery of choice. This hath been a sign for whom God hath placed in the worlds of cycles and ages, through what His exalted knowledge hath encompassed in the realm of creation and origination, that He might perfect His proof for the observers through the proof of His word for the wayfarers. In this the polytheists have associated partners, that the unitarians might affirm His unity. For the like of this let the strivers strive and the workers work.

Write thou to the remote questioner, who is far removed from the light of perception, that God hath created the point of knowledge of substances and derivatives from the water of this pure, manifest sea, descending from the clouds of attributes and praises, and upon the path of sprinkling through the sprinkling sprinkled from the primal drop. God hath not created anything save that the thing might know the knowability of its Creator within itself and might recognize His purpose in the creation of multiplicities and the descent of things from the plane of beginning to infinities and finalities, lest anything be ignorant of anything. All have known the mystery of the Gate in everything.

Verily the substances have stood before the Gate, questioning from this afflicted exposition. Be thou certain with decisive certainty and look with the eye of certainty toward the point of substances—thou shalt see it still in the depths of its heart where no sign of movement is possible therein. Then look with the glance of certainty—thou shalt see it in the mystery of its stillness moving through the bounty of creation and revolving around itself through the support of invention upon the truth of origination from the Creator of all things through the impregnable truth above similitudes and likenesses. All this—God hath created the point of knowledge of substances and derivatives from a drop of water from this Most Great Sea, the ocean of glories. Trust thou in God thy Lord, seek His aid, and take refuge from Satan and his casting.

Verily the heaven has been folded up, and the day has dawned, and the night has darkened. Whoso believeth, it shall be to his own benefit, and whoso disbelieveth, it shall be to his own loss. And no soul that hath disbelieved but shall We cause to taste the heat of the burning fire, according to the established decree, by the leave of God, Creator of destiny. And verily his standing upon the Bridge shall be fifty thousand years concealed. Fear thou God, thy True Lord, and magnify His verses sent down from the clouds of His glory and power. For verily the opposers, on the Day of Presence and the Day of Manifestation, shall hang down their heads before their Lord, and thou on that day shalt be veiled from the Gate. And naught veileth thee from Him save that which thy vain imaginings have veiled thee therefrom. Indeed He hath come unto thee from every direction in many an hour, yet thou hast veiled thyself through choosing evil thoughts within thyself. And God knoweth what thou thinkest in thy heart concerning the Most Great Gate and the honored companions. God shall soon judge between Me and the wrongdoers in the gathering place of resurrection. Verily He hath ever been just and wise.

Have mercy on thyself and enter with humility through the Gate of Remission. Ask forgiveness of the Gate through the Gate, and await the Mystery of Mysteries in the Point of the Qur'an after the separation on the Day of the revelation of the Criterion in the gathering of unity. As for knowledge of the Point of Derivatives, cast out from thyself desires and habits, then look with the eye of careful examination toward the truth of certainty. Verily its solution lieth with Me in the movement when limitations clothe the forms of the limited, as God hath willed concerning it from what it hath willed for itself. God hath caused the decree to flow upon it through its choice, and there is no suspension of God's grace. Verily God hath decreed for all from these two Points according to the decree of the Mystery of the Gate in this white leaf, and verily the Command hath been, in the Mother Book, from around this Gate, decreed.

God shall soon guide those who have believed in the Gate to the path of reward through the call of that Gate of Return. Soon shall the people of the Gate witness, concerning the movement of the Glorified Mystery Letter in the shade of shadows, that which God hath willed regarding their right from the abundance of bounties. Sufficient unto me is God, my Lord, Lord of Majesty—how excellent a Lord and how excellent a Friend! I have made manifest the proof with the perfection of grace in these answers for the distant soul. And sufficient is God, and he who hath knowledge of the Book, as a witness. And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00342: Fi's-Sighari va'l-Kibar

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Glory be to Him Who creates whatsoever is in the heavens and on earth by His command. Then those who believe in God and His signs—these are they who shall be gathered unto God. And now, in this thy letter I bear witness that there is no God but God, alone with no partner, even as His Essence hath testified to His Essence, and He is sanctified above any likeness to His servants. There is no God but He, the Mighty, the Wise. And I bear witness unto Muhammad, peace be upon Him, even as God hath borne witness unto Him in the knowledge of the unseen, wherein He made Him unique among the children of

mankind in the worlds of His command and creation, for verily He cannot be compared to what His servants have devised, nor can the highest essences of the hearts of His loved ones comprehend Him.

He graspeth all vision, and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed. And I bear witness unto the successors of Muhammad, peace be upon Him, even as God hath borne witness unto them in the essence of the Divine Being and the essence of the attributes. Verily, there is no God but He, the Mighty, the Exalted. And I bear witness unto myself according to what God hath willed and desired and ordained for me. Verily creation is in His hand, then He causeth it to return, then all shall return unto Him.

To continue: O thou Abdul-Wahhab! Thou hast known what thou hast composed regarding the excellence of the Gates, and that is indeed the decisive word concerning the beginning and the return. Know thou, regarding what thou hast asked about the conditions in my youth and manifestations in my maturity, that by the decree of limitation none can know what lieth beyond the decree of limitation, for every condition hath infinite conditions within its rank, and every manifestation hath infinite manifestations within itself. It sufficeth in describing the Divine Essence to refrain from interfering in the pure countenance of affirmation, and in describing the attributes what He said in His intimate communion with the Lord of Names and Attributes:

> "O my God! If Thou shouldst punish me through the eternity of Thy Essence as requital for my mention of Thy Self—then by Thy might and Thy majesty, and there is no power nor strength save through Thy Will, I would deserve that, and unto Thee be praise in Thy deed and obedience in Thy decree. I say not why' or wherefore' or how' or where', for Thou art God, the Powerful, the Doer of what He willeth, the Wise."

And in mentioning the state, His words:

> "O my God! Thou art Thou—I have known Thee not through other than Thee. Thou art Thou—I have loved Thee not through other than Thee. Thou art Thou—I have desired Thee not through other than Thee. Glory be unto Thee! If I should mention the remembrance of love for myself rather than Thy Self, then there would be a veil between me and Thee. Nay, by Thy might, I say Thou art Thou, and even if Thou shouldst punish me for this with all Thy vengeance as requital, I would be content with it through Thy might and Thy power, and I say: Thou art Thou. Glory be to Thy Lord, the Lord of might, above what they describe."

And in mentioning deeds, His words:

> "O my God! My very existence is a sin, so how then when I commit another sin? My Lord, I know that were I to perform for Thee every deed encompassed by Thy knowledge, I would not have remembered Thee as Thou hast remembered me, nor would I have known Thee as Thou hast made Thyself known to me. And if Thou shouldst punish me after that, then unto Thee is the power of origination regarding me, and I shall never deny Thy justice. And if I should disobey Thee with every sin encompassed by Thy knowledge, as I have disobeyed Thee with the like thereof, and what Thou art able to multiply upon it from the numbers by Thy knowledge's encompassing of it… still I hope for Thy grace and maintain good thoughts of the sovereignty of Thy mercy, Thy pardon and Thy concealment. I fear nothing, for unto Thee is

the power of origination—Thou doest what Thou willest as Thou willest. None can repel Thy command nor reverse Thy word. O God! Bestow Thy blessings upon Muhammad and his family, the best of Thy servants. Verily Thou art God, the Generous, the Bestower."

This is a mention from the four verses concerning myself. And if thou desirest mention of the all-encompassing, the lofty mosque, the towering might and the exalted praise, then remove from the first letter the ayn, and from the last letter the dal, and from the other letter the 'mim', for it is from the hidden and a wise decree. And fill the tablets of thy book with that decree, for I have taken from the Greatest Name, and it is indeed a mighty oath, did ye but know. It is indeed a treasured Qur'an which none touch save the purified ones. Glory be to thy Lord, the Lord of might, above what they describe. And peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00510: Answer to Mirza Sulayman

"Be as a zealous lion for God until He decrees with justice and thereafter brings about His Cause. Fear not the onslaught of the satans, for they are but uprooted shadows without proof, neither in the Book of Truth nor before creation, nor even in their own eyes. Their likeness is as the likeness of a dog: if thou attack it, it pants with its tongue out, and if thou leave it, it pants with its tongue out. Still their excessive panting with a mighty gift that thou mayest find rest from their evil. Draw not nigh unto those who have wronged lest their torment touch thee, for they have no life in them. Walk with them toward thy goal, for this is permitted to the believers in the Book of God." [BB00072]

The best of all knowledge is the knowledge of courage in this world. When thou findest thyself like unto a mountain which neither storms can move nor thunderbolts displace, then hast thou attained the summit of the Cause and its ultimate end.

And His most exalted Word: By Him Who holdeth my soul in His hand! The attribute of jealousy in all people is as naught compared to My jealousy, and likewise in all attributes and conditions. Yet have I been patient for the good-pleasure of God, and verily what hath befallen Me of tribulation compared to thy tribulation is as a green ocean compared to a drop of water. Be thou neither frightened nor complaining, for God hath indeed revealed in the Qur'an His promise, and it was binding upon Us to help the believers. By Him Who holdeth my soul in His hand! If thou wert to witness the mystery of reality, thou wouldst be content to be cut to pieces in the path of this Cause. And verily, were all upon earth to be unjustly slain for this Cause, the blood of them all would not equal the beauty of a single verse that hath been sent down from the decree of God.

BB00239: Fi 'ilmi's-Sarf va'n-Nahv (Treatise on grammar)

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who hath manifested Himself unto man through the detached, moving Point from the Dawning-Place of the Bayan, and praise be to God Who hath ordained through His bounty that which He

hath ordained for man through the connected, quiescent Point in the syntax of the Bayan, that the two seas might meet at the point of convergence upon the form of the pentacle, and lest the people of clear vision suppose concerning what God hath ordained in the Point between the two limits the decree of the two gulfs.

Verily hath the All-Merciful created the point of grammar from the realm of effacement, and God hath perfected within it the laws of limitation according to the decree of the imagined from the point of the known. With God is the power of alteration in His decree, and there is nothing but hath its appointed term. No thing can outstrip God's decree concerning it, and this is a binding decree from God, the Truth, concerning creation according to pure truth.

When God created the center of grammar from around the mystery of the line, We revealed unto it:

> "Draw not nigh unto the Tree of Beginning, for it is forbidden unto thee in truth."

Then I allotted it a portion from the dust of the land of truth concerning nearness, but it drew nigh without permission. Then We decreed its expulsion from the Garden of the Gate, and from that portion which rose from its lower members We created the point of morphology as its mate. Then God's command for its descent was fulfilled upon the tablets, and it was written in the Mother Book among the people of change in the line of limitation.

Until now have the two points wept in the land of the tablets, but lo, I have forgiven their drawing nigh by God's leave, their Lord, when they acknowledged their powerlessness concerning that Gate. Verily I have been, in truth, unto all worlds by God's leave, All-Forgiving.

Furthermore, O thou pure Gate, know that after the rising of the sun from the dawning-place of permission, the believing youths have a right concerning that Gate not to acquire the paths of knowledge from books of opposition, for their fathers have tasted love of the fruit from the Tree of Eternity. It behooveth not the rain descending from the cloud-sea to drink love from the body of the calf, for God desireth to purify the earth for His Greatest Day, that they worship none save Him. Verily, He is the Truth, there is no God but Him.

Write thou upon the paths of excellence for the youth from the teaching of the Creator of man from the Dawning-Place of the Bayan within thyself, according to the manifestation of His majesty over all contingent beings and realities, that they might testify after reaching maturity to the transcendence of the Gate above the limitation of explanation.

Verily hath God created the two knowledges from the drop distilled from those two seas—"He hath let flow the two seas that meet together: between them is a barrier which they do not transgress." O people of earth and heaven! God hath not ordained nobility for man in that knowledge from those two seas, for it is the portion of the people of the two gulfs. True nobility with God is knowledge of the All-Merciful and of the barrier standing between the two worlds.

So desire ye the equatorial line standing between the two seas, which bringeth forth from one of them the pearl of syntax and from the other the formation of coral. The first is a decisive limit from God—

nothing knoweth excellence save through conjunction after separation. The second is a perfect decree—rest is not known save through cessation after separation.

Cast thou the ways of rules from the water of the elixir upon the verdant tablets from the form of unity from the shade of the supreme realm, that the people of understanding among the faithful might witness that what is there cannot be known save through what is here, and no letter can be written except there draweth nigh unto it the decree of origination and the word of execution from the All-Merciful. “Verily, unto God do we belong and unto Him do we return.”

Open thou the gate of the Book upon the twenty-nine letters, and cause to flow from these upon all the decree of nearness.

Begin with what God has inspired you through the tongue of the Bab and commence with mention of the verb, for it is the pivot of the decree. These are its numbers through repetition in the Ancient Verb. Judge the point of the isthmus by the decree of the two unseen in the two testimonies, and distinguish its decree in the meeting of the two gatherings. Make mention of the proximity of the unseen to the visible after your consideration of the numbers of the letters in their fewness and abundance. Judge the lesser unto the depths of nearness, and write upon the greater the point of remoteness. Direct the verb upon the pure manifestation, parse the noun with pure water, and judge the letter by the connection from the world of manifestation to Mount Sinai. Here for you is the blowing of the trumpet, and all letters call from the Mount that the sun has risen, the day has dawned, the noon has passed, and the night has retreated. God has not ordained for us on that day any stopping at the Gate. God is my Lord, there is no God but He. Thus should the doers act.

Then know, O my strong confidant, that the name is the mark of the thing as it is in its essence. It has ranks, among them that mirrors are its grace, words its limit, forms its attribute, and inscribed images its trace. For every book according to the decree of all is from God, inexhaustible. God has made words as bodies for spirits which are meanings, and God has written with His hands between them a true relationship, and there was naught between them save as between the Kaf and the Nun. As for the verb, it is the movement of the thing, and upon it depends the axis of the noun and letter. The origin of the verb is a motionless creation not known by stillness, and according to our doctrine, which is the truth, a moving creation not known by movement. Whoso knows separation from union has indeed attained the point of knowledge.

As for the letter, it is the meaning which tells only of connection. When God desired to create the letters, He originated a word of four letters, and God named each letter: for the first, verb; for the second, noun; for the third, preposition; and for the fourth, the hidden secret that sustains them. And here I am making known to you that letter which al-Sadiq (upon him be peace) indicated in the tradition of the Name. Creation has been filled from the outpouring of that letter, and none knows its subtle workmanship save Him. Rely upon God and say: There is no power nor strength save in God. And let the pen flow upon the Point of the Gate by the Gate. In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate. Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00088: Answer to Navvab-i-Hindi

Part 1: “Praise be to God Who hath made…”

In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful

Praise be to God Who hath made the ornament of names, in their primary derivation, the ornament of the Alif, which assumed a cubic form through two letters and stood upright between two others, which shone forth from the tablet of creation and rose with the rising of the sun of invention, which was determined after it had been willed, ordained and decreed, before it was permitted, appointed and distinguished. Thus doth its revelation shine upon all forms, its light radiating from the first reed of the Divine Realm, from the blessed leaf of the Tree of Grandeur, and from the delicate fruits of the trees of sovereignty and dominion, until its light hath filled all that exists in the realities of souls and the depths of the horizons.

Praise be to God Who hath caused to speak what He hath caused to speak, hath caused to shine what He hath caused to shine, and hath caused to rise what He hath caused to rise. Glorified and exalted is He! His Essence is sanctified above any indication from the loftiest peaks of essential realities, and His Being is exalted above the ascent of the most sublime bird of hearts from the depths of quiddities. He is, as He hath ever been throughout all eternity, in His justice, greatness and majesty. None knoweth Him save Himself, and none can find Him except Him, for all else is severed from His creation by His creation, and prevented from His invention by His invention.

And verily, even as He is in His own right, He can in no wise be associated with the mention of any thing, nor with the name of any thing; for names are but the contrivance of His creation, and attributes are but tokens for His servants. Glorified be He! From everlasting He hath been, with none beside Him, and in His rank there hath been neither description belonging to any thing, nor any name; for names are the contrivance of His creation, and attributes are tokens for His servants. Glorified be He! From everlasting He hath been, with none beside Him—no description within His station, no name before the City of His might. And He shall ever remain—even as He hath ever been—the Ever-Being in the eternity of eternities, untouched by any change or transition.

Glorified, then, be He! Whoso hath presumed to describe Him by any name hath, in truth, made that name a token of His Essence and a path unto the knowledge of Him. Glorified and exalted is He! Sanctified is His inmost Reality above being known through aught else than Himself, or being described by any other than His own Self; for proof is but proof of him who of himself pointeth not unto himself, and a path is but a path for him whose path lieth apart from the majesty of his own being.

Exalted is His Being above the description of contingent things and the attributes of essential realities. Whosoever desireth to describe Him with an attribute hath made that attribute a mirror for His beauty and an existence before His existence. Glory be to Him and exalted is He! His Being is sanctified from anyone other than Him describing Him or anyone save Him knowing Him, for knowledge is a branch of association and description is a branch of separation.

Exalted be His station! He hath ever existed without being known through any mention by His creation or being described by any judgment of His servants. The essences are cut off from knowing Him, as His Essence transcendeth all expression and proof, and the realities are prevented from describing Him, as His Being is beyond all recognition and path.

Glory be to Him and exalted is He! All names are but marks of His Will, and all attributes are but qualities of His Power. He, as He is, none knoweth how He is except Him. I believe in what He is, though I neither know nor am capable of knowing it. This sufficeth as proof for those who remember, and this sufficeth as a path for those who believe in His unity.

O thou who gazeth upon the glories of the verses of majesty and dwelleth in the shadows of the dark regions of the paradise of beauty! Look with certainty and abandon the paths of investigation, for indications will veil thee from attaining unto certain knowledge. Today the paths of minute examination will profit thee not, for the dawn hath broken and its lights have shone upon all forms. On that Day, the workmanship of the Lord shall distinguish between the deeds of people. And among them are the people of the Covenant, when they awake to what God hath revealed unto them through the lights of His grandeur, they declare:

> "Glory be unto Thee! We have no knowledge save that which Thou hast taught us through Thy Book, and we are but a people who bow down in worship."

These are they who follow the signs of God, and these are they who are the triumphant ones.

And among them are the people of concord, who, when leg is wrapped around leg and the herald calleth with the destined decree, say:

> "Our Lord! We have heard a herald calling to that which was revealed in the Qur'an, and we have followed Thy path. Forgive us for what our hands have wrought, for we are truly a repentant people."

These are they whom God may forgive and absolve of their misdeeds, and admit them among His righteous servants. These are they who are rightly guided.

And among them are the people of discord, who, when it is said unto them: "Reflect upon the verses of this Servant who was struck down, then arose, bringing forth the pearls of creation and invention through what God hath placed in his hands of the wisdom of utterance," they say: "We have not heard of this among our forebears of old," and they fabricate against him as was fabricated against the Prophets of old. Say: Be patient, for God's appointed time shall come, and verily God shall expose the wrongdoers and reveal their inner nature, that His Cause might be distinguished between the believers among the people of the Covenant and the idolaters among the people of discord and hypocrisy. God hath destroyed them for what their hands have earned, and evil is that which they do.

By thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth! God will not accept any deed from anyone except after they follow God's Cause and become among the believers. This is but a drop from the vast ocean of glory and majesty, that the sovereign of signs might draw thee to the court of sanctity and beauty.

As for what thou hast asked concerning the names of God and what all have concluded thereof, know that the Name hath infinite ranks within infinite ranks. The truth in all stations is as Ali, peace be upon him, hath said: "The name is the mark of a thing," and it hath ranks. Among them is the name in realities, which in all its ranks is like a living being, such as man, indicating the named one. Among them are mirrors which indicate what is reflected in them through them. Among them are verbal names, inscribed names, angelic names, horizonal names, and names of the self, and among them is everything upon which the name of a name falls. All of this is in the station of creation and the portion of the servant.

The Essence, as indicated by all minds, brought by all Prophets, and declared by all verses and traditions, hath no name nor description, as Ali, peace be upon him, hath explicitly stated in his words: "The perfection of Divine Unity is the negation of attributes," as testified by the fact that the attribute is other than the described, and everything described is other than its attribute. There is no doubt that in the school of the Family of God, peace be upon them, what is meant by description is the name, as explicitly stated in the tradition narrated in Al-Kafi from the Imam, peace be upon him. This is witnessed by whoever hath gazed with the inner vision upon the reality of existence. The existence of the name is itself the greatest proof that He hath no name indicating God as He is, and as the Imam, peace be upon him, hath said: "He is too exalted to be known through His creation; rather, creation is known through Him." Thus have spoken the intimate prayers of the People of Infallibility, peace be upon them, as Ali, peace be upon him, hath said: "O Thou Who hast proven Thy Essence through Thy Essence!"

In his morning prayer, Ali ibn al-Husayn (peace be upon them both) said in his supplication to Abu Hamza al-Thumali: "Through Thee have I known Thee, Thou didst direct me unto Thyself, and called me unto Thee. Had it not been for Thee, I would not have known who Thou art." And his martyred father (may my spirit and the spirits of all who dwell in the kingdom of command and creation be a sacrifice for him) said: "None other than Thee hath any manifestation that Thou hast not, such that it could be the revealer of Thee. When wert Thou ever hidden, that Thou shouldst need a proof to lead to Thee? When wert Thou ever distant, that traces should have to lead to Thee? Blind be the eye that seeth Thee not ever watchful over it, and lost be the transaction of a servant who hath not been granted a share of Thy love."

Part 2: "This indeed is the ultimate station of creation…"

This indeed is the ultimate station of creation in the realm of possibility, for verily He cannot be known or described in His Essence. Rather, when He created creation for His knowledge, He revealed Himself to them through them, and described Himself to them through His names and attributes, that they might know Him thereby and worship Him, associating none with Him. In this matter have the feet of those possessed of insight slipped, and the minds of those endowed with vision been confounded. The Illuminationist philosophers have gone where the divine philosophers would not venture, speaking of that which they knew not regarding concept and referent, explaining the connection between creation and That which cannot be associated with creation in any state—neither in conjunction nor in separation. They spoke of that which hath no essential relationship between names, thus destroying themselves and those who followed them, while they thought themselves guided. They have indeed borne a grievous sin in discussing this matter. May God forgive them through His mercy, for He is the Generous, the Bountiful.

When the scholar-jurists did not take their religious knowledge from the traditions of God's pure Family, but followed their own desires in matters from which none can be saved except whom God willeth, following the judgments of the Peripatetics and some of the Transcendent philosophers—they went astray, all speaking what they wrote in their books. Like the Illuminationists, they did not grasp the truth of the matter and were not illumined by the divine light that shone upon all forms through its traces. Some of them have died, and those who live shall die, then all shall return unto God.

Indeed, Kazim after Ahmad (may God sanctify their dust) had indicated a drop from the ocean of this matter, whose living waters flow from the spring of the sea of destiny. Through the whisperings of the devil of the breasts, we have not unveiled the concealed, and people were promised until this my day, the day of the light of manifestation. Today, when God hath placed in my hand a brilliant proof of truth like unto the sun in the midst of heaven—which none among the Muslims can deny unless they disbelieve in what they believed before—namely the matter of verses that have filled the east and west of the earth, and pages that have filled all horizons, whereby I can write whatsoever I wish with innate divine power, without reflection or pause of the pen, verses and intimate prayers that have never flowed from any pen before, nor can anyone today produce them, even if all on earth were to gather together, they could not produce the like of a single verse, nor write in one day a page like unto it. This indeed is God's grace upon me, but most people are not thankful.

Alas, alas! What hath reached hath reached, what hath been cut off hath been cut off, what hath been prevented hath been prevented, and what hath occurred hath occurred. Unto God do I complain of my sorrow, and in God let the believers put their trust. By thy Lord, the people are as dead, for they know not and they fabricate falsehoods. Today, whoso addeth to or diminisheth from the law of Muhammad—upon Him be the blessing of God—by even a single letter, verily he hath disbelieved in that instant. God knoweth that I have desired naught save His love and act only according to His decree. I am possessed of clear proof from the Book of God. Some among the people deny out of ignorance, while others fabricate falsehoods after having attained certitude. God hath slain them for their misdeeds, and evil is that which they judge.

The mystery of this matter is that which I now indicate through the evidence of wisdom: No thing can be attributed to the Essence. And if thou sayest unto me that negation is derived from affirmation, I say yea—that upon which the name of Essence is bestowed is the Light which God hath made the station of His knowledge in expression. No vision can grasp Him, for He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed.

Know thou, if thou gazest upon the depth of Oneness, that there the Named One hath created that depth in the thicket of the Divine Nature, that the believers might be immersed in the immersion of such knowledge of Him as is possible to the contingent, and that the unitarians might be illumined by the radiance of His manifestation deposited within the realities of creation. Verily that station is not concealed by veils, nor can proofs encompass it, nor can one immersed in the darkness of the deaf, dumb and blind know it. Glorified be God, thy Lord, the Lord of the Throne, above all that they describe.

And if thou gazest upon aught besides that depth, know thou that every name hath one who is named, which is its existence in its rank, and every named one hath a name in the rank of its manifestation. The named one hath never ceased to be unconnected with the name, nor is there any link between them. The

One named by the name “God” is that Essence which all worship through the names wherewith He hath described His Self. Whoso associateth with Him a name or attribute hath indeed joined partners with Him, hath not worshipped Him, and is an unbeliever.

Recognize no essential relationship between them, for God hath created for everything the names of all things. Therefore hath God ordained that in the instant when there is no essential relationship between them, nor conceptual substantiality, nor existential reality—yet those who gaze upon the forms of limitation know not the stations of the All-Merciful’s manifestation of all through all.

Those who spoke of the relationship between the instance and the concept—if they gazed upon that Most Exalted Prospect, they spoke a word of truth. And those who say otherwise—if they gazed upon that Clear Horizon, they spoke a word of truth. And those who say “each acteth according to his own manner”—O thou who ascendeth to the sanctuary of holiness in the valley of grandeur! Deprive not thyself of thy portion of that which God hath ordained for the people of grace and perfection.

Recite thou that verse of the Qur’an: They said: “O Moses! In it are a people of exceeding strength; never shall we enter it until they leave it; if they leave it, then shall we enter.” Two men of those who feared God, on whom God had bestowed His grace, said: “Enter upon them through the gate, for when ye have entered, victory shall be yours.”

Verily that which We have caused to trickle down unto thee from the vast ocean of the decree of names and attributes is from the warbling of that Bird which rangeth in the atmosphere of the cloud of divine unknowingness. Then it penetrateth into the depths of those allusions which appeared and were made to appear, then revolved and were made to revolve, then stood and were made to stand, then assumed cubic form and were made cubic, then spoke and were made to speak, then stammered and were made to stammer, then gleamed and were made to gleam, then separated and were made to separate, then swooned and were made to swoon, then sobbed and were made to sob, then wept and were made to weep, and became confounded upon the dust like unto the fish—and he spoke only that which God permitted him to speak, from the utterance of his Lord.

O Lord! I complain to Thee of my condition. Set right my affairs and fulfill what Thou hast promised me. For verily Thou hast spoken, and Thy word is truth, and it was incumbent upon Us to help the believers. And lo, I read Thy Book and follow Thy commandments, and take refuge in Thy presence. I seek Thy intercession with Thyself, and I turn to Thee in repentance. By Thy mercy, accept my repentance through Thy grace. Verily Thou art the Ever-Forgiving, the All-Merciful. Glory be to Thee, O Lord of the Throne, above what they attribute. And peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00226: Answer to Siyyid Ahmad-i-Aqazadih

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who hath sent down the Book upon whomsoever He willeth among His servants, that He may raise them up on the Day of Reckoning. I bear witness before God, from my station amidst these

mountains, that there is no God but Him, alone without partner, even as His Essence hath testified to His Essence in the loftiness of His Being. The attributes of essential realities cannot describe Him, nor can the praise of contingent beings reach the Dayspring of His Divine Unity, nor can the light of created things attain unto the Beauty of His Oneness. Glorified and exalted is He! None knoweth how He is save Him, nor where He is save Him, nor what He is save Him, the Mighty, the Ancient of Days.

I bear witness unto Muhammad, His servant, who is detached from all things and sanctified above any likeness to humankind. God hath not placed within his being aught save the sign of His unity, such that none can comprehend his knowledge save Him. He is indeed the Ancient, the Most High.

I bear witness unto the Manifestation of His beloved Self that which none can testify to save God, and none can comprehend His knowledge save Him. He is indeed the Munificent, the Bestower.

I bear witness unto my own grievous sins and great transgressions, which are encompassed by God's knowledge. My mention in utterance does not benefit the visible realm, for these sins in the station of signs are good deeds for the people of glory, and these transgressions in the station of tokens are manifestations for the people of wrath. For my mention is the unity of the Lord—all sin; and my confession of sin is all grace. This is from God's bounty—He bestoweth His mercy upon whomsoever He willeth. He is indeed the Munificent, the All-Giving.

Thereafter, all thy letters have reached me and I have understood what thou didst intend in thy words. I beseech God to enable thee to attain the summit of His good-pleasure. He is indeed the Munificent, the Most High.

As for what thou didst ask regarding the interpretation of His exalted words "When he saw the moon rising in splendor, he said: 'This is my Lord"'—it hath infinite meanings which no tablet of possibility nor pen of exposition can contain. However, I shall indicate a trace of wisdom: In every Manifestation, the name "Lord" is truly applicable. The most exalted and greatest of meanings is God's revelation unto thee through thee, such that whenever thou turnest toward Him in consciousness, thou sayest "God is my Lord." When thou considerest the realm of contingent being, thou sayest He is too exalted to be known through aught else or approached by any of His creatures, for instruments point only to their like, and contingent being exists in the realm of creation. The pure, unmixed Essence and the most holy, unadulterated Camphor cannot be approached by anyone, for vision comprehendeth Him not, and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed. Therein thou findest the decree of eternity.

If thou seekest the essential meaning, it is the unity of worship in the station of the sun, the unity of deeds in the station of the moon, and the unity of attributes in the station of the star—for these return to the station of the unity of the Essence through the negation of all else. This is the meaning of His exalted words regarding the beginning and the return.

Verily, in the station of inner meaning, this verse possesseth a subtle and delicate significance. The "star" is the first pillar of the Name al-Basít; the "moon" its second pillar; and the "sun" its third. All this hath been set forth for the time when these should appear. Yet, in the station of limitation wherein I speak unto them, I make mention of their manifestations only in relation to that Hidden and Treasured Name,

whereunto the chosen ones turn their faces unto God—exalted be His remembrance—even as He, blessed and glorified, hath said: "I have turned my face unto God…" and the like.

Thus, according to that profound meaning and that subtle mystery, thou shalt discern that from the time of Adam until the time of Muhammad—may the blessings of God be upon Him—mankind were in the rank of the manifestation of "There is no god but He," which is the rank of the body, and this is the station of the "star." And when it set, the "moon" of prophethood arose, which is the station of the intellect. And when it, in turn, waned, the "sun" rose, which is the station of authority [wilayat] and of the soul. And when it was veiled, there appeared the Name of the Invisibles, and it filled the pillars of existence, that the Lordship of the Eternal—standing beyond the bounds of negation and of assimilation—might be made manifest. And this is the secret of the "three" within the appearance of the "four."

And I know that thy purpose, in seeking the interpretation of this verse, was none other than to attain the recognition of the Bearer of the Cause. Yet I say: in the station of the "star," certain people said, "This is the Educator of creation"; and in like manner, in the station of the "moon," they said, "This is the Educator of mankind…"

Today the people of understanding say what the people of truth said before. Soon after the setting of the sun they will say what God has ordained for them, and each shall have their portion of what God has decreed. Know thou the truth of these allusions and conceal them except from those worthy, for we are God's and unto Him do we return. Be assured that the Lord of Lords is the Holy Essence, exalted be His mention, and that the name "Lord" for all else is but shadows and similitudes, just as God, mighty and glorious is He, has said: "Satan made him forget to remember his Lord." Undoubtedly in that instance the intended meaning was not the Lord of creation but rather the lord of the prison. All that I have indicated to you regarding the mention of the Lord follows this pattern and is established by this evidence. I beseech God, my Glorious Master, at the time of return to the path.

You asked about the ruling concerning the bat, for it is a bird that Jesus created by God's leave, and therefore does not emerge in daytime for fear of other birds. There is no explicit ruling about this in the traditions, yet the bird is pure because it was created by God's leave as manifested in Jesus. For in relation to God's pure leave, which is the station of divine action, it is as nothing, mentioned only as a shadow compared to this Greatest Kingdom. Therefore it fears for itself, and God made manifest this fear in it to distinguish between pure creation and creation manifested through the agency of His servants. This is a sealed decree from the All-Knowing, the All-Wise.

As for your seeking permission to visit the tomb of Husayn, God granted you permission a thousand thousand years before your existence. Attain to this greatest bounty, for a single soul upon that earth is greater in my sight than the dominion of the first and the last, for there lies the nearness to the court of the Divine Presence and the manifestation of the Tree of Sinai. Seize this opportunity, O thou soul that art well-pleased! For this world has no permanence, and the Hereafter is indeed the true life, did people but know.

As for what you asked regarding subsidiary religious matters, inquire about what you need from the people of remembrance. I shall, God willing, elaborate on some matters that people need. Refer to that Book, for it is a promise that shall not prove false.

Regarding what you asked about the ruling for your pure sister in the Holy Land, I had previously granted her permission to depart, and no trials shall befall her there. She is, in my sight, a goodly leaf whose heart has been purified from the defilement of limitations for her Lord. God's mercy be upon one who recognizes her worth and causes her not the slightest harm, for today she is an honor to her kindred and nobility to those who obey her in God's decree. Ask God to grant her petition and bestow His bounty upon us. Verily He is the Generous, the Bestower.

Glorified be God, thy Lord, the Lord of Might, above what they attribute to Him. Peace be upon the Messengers. And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00013: Sahifih of 33 prayers

To be typed.

BB00040: Kitabu'sh-Shahadah

Introduction

> "He is the Mighty. O my Lord and my Support! God knoweth my recoil from that which I sought to attain in times past. I beseech Thee, by the right of Him Whose Bab-hood thou hast claimed, to implore God the Most High to send forth His Proof into the world. Verily my heart yearns that I may return from this journey, God willing, having fulfilled my needs, and that He may not put me to shame in the eyes of His creatures, and that He may protect me from the defects of this journey, God willing, and that thou mayest not forget me in thy noble thoughts, God willing, [O Ali]."

Answer:

In the Name of the Most High, the Most Great

Praise and thanksgiving befit that all-glorious Essence Who, from everlasting, hath remained sanctified above the description of aught besides Him; and glory and splendor are meet for the Manifestations of His justice—those before Whom the loftiest substance of all immaterial realities doth, at every moment, confess its utter severance and exclusion from attaining unto His knowledge. And when I beheld the trace of thy pen upon thy page, my being was shaken by the manifestation of the radiance of His countenance in thy address. God, verily, is exalted and immeasurably high above that His Book should be reckoned by the obedience of any servant who walketh in His path, or that causes should disclose aught of what pertaineth unto Him upon the throne of might and attributes. Wherefore do I beseech God—my Lord and

thy Lord—that He banish sorrow from thy heart, and gather me together with the people of His obedience in a land secure and sanctified. He, in truth, is the All-Powerful, the All-Wise.

In the Name of the Most High, the Most Great [the exordium is repeated in Arabic:]

Verily, praise and thanksgiving are the due of the Eternal Essence, Whose Presence hath ever been sanctified above the description of all else besides Him; and glory and beauty are the right of the Manifestations of His justice—He Whom the highest essences of the immaterial realms recognize, at all times, as wholly cut off and barred from the court of His knowing. And when I beheld the trace of thy pen upon thy book, I trembled through the disclosure of the effulgence of His countenance in thy words. God is, indeed, more exalted and more glorious than that His Book should be numbered by the obedience of a servant who walketh in His way, or that causes should be made to run so as to reveal what He is in the throne of might and of attributes. Wherefore do I implore God—my Lord and thy Lord—that He remove sorrow from thy heart, and gather me together with thee in a land secure and holy. He, verily, is the Omnipotent, the All-Wise.

From all the people's books, and since today the mention of the confirmation of some of the well-known learned ones has become the cause of submission of those whose clay God created from the clay of the exalted ones, and the manifestation of the polytheism of those whose clay God created from the clay of the debased ones, and it has become the cause of salvation for some of the doubters, I shall mention the book of eight souls from among those who have submitted, who are people of wisdom and knowledge, so that the interpretation of God's word regarding the bearing of the throne of confirmation in the horizon of the trustworthy may become manifest [in] that clear Book:

> "And eight shall bear thy Lord's throne above them on that Day,"

and no excuse shall remain for anyone in their denial and hesitation regarding what Ali, Commander of the Faithful, peace be upon him, commanded in his sermon concealed for the hidden Name, and it shall be […] purification for the believers, and honor for the rememberers, and glory for the righteous ones, and nobility for the foremost ones, and retribution for the opposers, and torment for those who hesitate, and a door for those who arrive.

And no one shall say on the Day of Resurrection before God,

> "Had two just ones from among the learned followed that Command, I would have followed Thy decree and would have been among the believers."

And I counsel all people not to incline towards the life of this world, for the abasement of this world is better than the torment of the hereafter, and verily the one who repents of his sin is like one who has no sin. […] God lest pride take hold of you in your denial of God's Command or your hesitation regarding God's decree, for that is the way of the people of ignorance, and you are not superior to these men in the station of knowledge, faith, nobility, utterance, wisdom and certitude.

Therefore have mercy upon yourselves, for from the day of the appearance of that Command until this day, no person of insight among the people of the world and religion has remained except that they have

submitted to the Command with the reality of certitude in the station of firm knowledge and remembrance, that I was indeed an unlettered servant whom God taught through His grace whatsoever He willed in the Book, and that I am indeed among the believers. And today there is no honor for the righteous ones except in salvation from the torment of the Lord of the worlds, and after that I am indeed among the grateful ones to them [for that]. Fear God, O people, and be not content with the shame of your souls more than that before the firmly-grounded learned ones and […] the rightly-guided ones in this world and on the Day of Resurrection before God and His angels, then His Prophets and His Messengers, then all people together.

If you are from among the learned ones of the knowledge of Ahmad, may God's mercy be upon him, you are not more learned than he who [the scholar] confirmed among them [in the land of Qaf], and if you are from among the learned ones of the knowledge of Kazim, may God's mercy be upon him, you are not more learned than he who […] among them [the first scholar of the Book], and if you are from among the learned ones of the knowledge of Mulla Sadra the Philosopher, you are not [more precise in view and more subtle in insight than the scholar of that land] more learned than he who […] among them, and if you are from among the learned ones of eloquence and utterance, you are not [more expansive […] than them] more learned than he who was designated among them [from the scholar of the land of Ta], and if you are from among the learned ones of jurisprudence, you are not more learned than he whom [the scholar of the land of Tus] the people curse among them, and if you are from among the learned ones of principles, you are not more learned than [the scholar of the land of Ha in Sad].

And verily today the abasement of denial and hesitation has encompassed most of the people. Heedlessness hath encompassed most of humanity. If they return not unto God's Cause and repent not before Him, they shall fall under the judgment of this verse: "And when they had forgotten that whereof they had been reminded, We opened unto them the gates of all things, until, even as they were rejoicing in that which they were given, We seized them unawares, and lo! they were plunged into despair." Then His exalted Word: "And verily hell shall encompass the unbelievers." By thy Lord, O questioner! If on this day anyone possessed of the spirit of life, even should he be of the children of this world, were to read that blessed manuscript, he would surely say: "Would that I had died before [thee] and been […]" Then he would say: "Oh, woe is me for what I neglected in regard to God!"

And none who mentioned those Books ever conceived that I desired martyrdom, for God sufficeth as a witness unto His servant, and God is sufficient as a witness unto me. And verily the first of those Books is the Book of the first believer who opened the gate of pilgrimage and its verses and its tokens and its evidences and its allusions and its manifestations and its conditions and its stations. Then the last of the Books is the Book of him who sealed the proof through the rising of .. and Kaf, and thus was the mystery of the Book revealed in truth through them.

By the dawning of the Sun of Imprecation in the darkest, blackest, blindest, most gloomy night of hell's obscurity, then wrote the three from the lineage of the Tree of Prophethood who, after being questioned and having seen, answered the Cause of Truth. Then wrote the three of those who believe in the unseen merely upon beholding the words, verses and signs, and they are indeed followers in the realm of religious jurisprudence where none can deny their scholarly rank save the stubborn denier. And should

anyone among the people witness the decree of that copy or hear it and not afterwards believe in the Cause of Truth, there is no doubt that they shall be among the lost. And verily I say [my Lord] "Glory be to Him Who has subjected this unto us, for we could never have attained to it."

Book One

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate. Praise be to God Who is the Manifester of ages and the Director of all affairs, Who revealed Himself to His creation through His creation and drew near to them through them for the witnessing of the Manifestation, and Who withdrew from His creation through His creation and veiled Himself with rays of light from the gaze of the jealous. Thus did He appear through light upon light, and sent down light through light upon the Mount, making it the inscribed Book on an outstretched parchment. He sent down through the Most Great Name the inscribed Book and established it in the hearts of the pure ones circling round His throne unto the frequented House. Through His glorious might He returned hearts in the innermost mysteries of the unseen, through sincere profession of Divine Unity and realization of His oneness, unto the breasts that they might find rest and testify that there is no God but Him, the Most High, the Most Great, the Ancient Guardian, the All-Merciful, the Most Generous, the Compassionate, the All-Forgiving.

He made the sun a brightness whereby He illumined the day, and made the day a means of sustenance for mankind that they might seek bounty from their Appreciative Lord. And He illumined the luminous moon in the blackness of dark night—yea, the pitch-black night—that they might know the number of years and reckoning and the detail of all things. He transcended the emanations of fanciful thoughts through His mystery and concealed Himself in the hidden. He drew near and called His creation unto Himself through diverse tongues and different languages and dependent beings from every deep valley and from mountain peaks and ocean depths and bird songs, saying "Verily I am God, there is no God but I, Lord of Light and Master of Manifestation and Ordainer of affairs and Maker of shade and heat and Controller of the swelling sea and Revealer of the mighty Criterion and the noble Qur'an and the Torah and the Gospel and the Psalms."

And may God's blessings be upon Muhammad, the structure of gladness, possessed of renowned glory and … honor, who in his praiseworthy station is praiser and praised, lover and beloved, rememberer and remembered, thankful and thanked; and upon his successor through whom He dispelled darkness and evil and broke the might of every proud boaster and every treacherous ingrate; and upon his family, the guided guides who are guidance upon guidance and light upon light and light above light and light beneath light and light by which every light God created for those who love them is illumined through love for them from the shadow of their love—the Abode of Joy and the Laws of the Age and the Pivot of Time and the Companions of the Gathering and the Guardians of Authority and the Standard-bearers of Praise on the Day of Resurrection.

Thus is Thy word fulfilled in truth and justice. None can change Thy words or reverse Thy signs through their Seal and their Qa'im, the Hidden One concealed from their worlds and the habitations of the evil-doing oppressors. May God hasten his relief for the revival […] Bless them, O my God, while birds warble

from the boughs of the eternal Tree, and bless those pure and goodly followers who adhere to their leaders in truth and certainty, and who acknowledge their station before the Lord of the Worlds.

Book Two

In the name of Him Who is the Most Effulgent Light, the Resplendent Radiance, the Piercing Star that appears by night, the Standard of Light in the depths of darkness, the Station of the Most Great Name, the Perfection of the Most Ancient Mystery, the Most Perfect and Most Upright Word, the Hidden Symbol, the Possessor of the Most Luminous Brow, the Most Brilliant Cheek, and the Illumined Countenance, the Bearer of the Left Pillar and the Crimson Light, the Manifestor of the Justice of the Most High, the Effacer of the traces of the secondary and the sterile, the Manifestor of the inner meanings of His Most Pure Grandfather's Law—Muhammad, the Most Great Lord—and the Reviver of the traces of His Most Great Father, the Lion-like Lord, Who calls from around the joyful one, Who summons with eloquent voice to answer the inspired one, the Helper of Truth through Truth and from Truth with Truth, the Confirmed, the Victorious, the Seer and the Seen with the All-Seeing Eye, protected by God's outstretched hand from the evil of night and day's vicissitudes, concealed and hidden in the cloud of oneness.

O God! O Thou Who separatest day from darkest night, O Thou through obedience to Whose command the graves yield up their dead! O Light of Lights! Grant me, by Thy mighty glory, to be among those who draw nigh and attain martyrdom before the Lamp of Light. Cast upon me from it a perfect love that will draw me to the station of manifestation and turn me away from all save Thee among the jealous ones. I beseech Thee by the Name which Thou hast enshrouded in veils of light—the Light of the heavens and earth by which the vision of them that gaze upon Thee with the eye of light is illumined—to cast into the hearts of Thy righteous servants and into my heart such might and awe and dignity and tranquility thereof as Thou desirest from us, O Thou Who knowest what is in every breast!

Make us of them who hearken to His Word and exalt His Cause above every cause, for I am Thy servant and the son of Thy servant, in need of Thy mercy and forgiveness, O Forgiver, O Forgiver, O All-Forgiving, O Mighty, O All-Thankful! Make us through Him supreme and transcendent above Thine enemies, for verily Thou art powerful over all things. Through Thee I ward off Thine enemies at their very throats, and I seek refuge in Thee from all evil. There is no might nor power except through Thee, through God, the Most High, the Most Great.

Thou hast said—and Thy word is the truth: "If We willed, We could send down upon them from heaven a sign, before which their necks would remain bowed in submission." And Thou hast said—and Thy word is truth: "And We desire to show favor unto those who were brought low in the land, and to make them leaders and to make them inheritors." And Thy word is truth: "We are the messengers of thy Lord; they shall not reach thee. So go forth with thy family in a portion of the night, and let not any of you look back, except thy wife. Lo! that which smiteth them will smite her also. Lo! their tryst is for the morning. Is not the morning nigh?" "God hath decreed: 'Verily, I and My messengers shall prevail.' Verily, God is Strong, Mighty." "O Moses! Draw nigh and fear not; for thou art of those who are secure."

We beseech Thee by Thy mighty glory to grant us detachment from the abode of delusion, righteousness and prosperity, blessing and well-being in all affairs, a goodly end, and triumph in the abode of joy. Verily, Thou art our Protector in all matters and the Knower of what lies within hearts and breasts.

To continue: His exalted, irrevocable command, His supreme, decisive decree, and His conclusive address which is not mean, has been issued to the servant of His servants, without doubt Ramin ibn Abdullah Muhammad Hussein, who beseeches God thereby for deliverance from every base nature and rust, liberation from every doubt, salvation from the fears of both worlds and the perils of both existences, for himself, his parents, and the brethren of both East and West. Amen, O Lord of the Worlds, by the right of Hassan and Husayn, bring together that which hath emerged from the hidden treasure-house of the unseen and hath shone forth from the Dayspring of Revelation and hath flowed from the fountain of light—that is, whatsoever hath streamed from His exalted Pen in the tablets of lines—for the awakening of those who are heedless of the reality of this hidden mystery, whether they be from among those who are far or near, and the loved ones….

Peace be upon thee, O Ultimate Goal, O Best of Creation, O Lord of Creation! My spirit be a sacrifice unto thee, and my body be thy protection! We bear witness unto God to that which He hath testified concerning Himself, and those endowed with knowledge among His servants, that there is none other God but Him, the Mighty, the All-Wise; and unto His Messenger and Beloved Muhammad, may the peace of God be upon him and his family, with respect to his Messengership; and unto Ali and his eleven descendants with respect to their Imamate; and unto thee, O my Lord, concerning that which thou dost testify regarding thy station, both manifest and hidden. And I bear witness that he hath not gone astray, nor deviated, nor doth he speak out of desire. I am innocent of those who denied thee after knowledge had come unto them, out of spite among themselves.

I seek thy permission to depart, and according to thy command I shall do what I can, wherein I see righteousness and wisdom. There is no power nor strength save in God, the Most High, the Most Great. As for the verses corresponding to the number of letters in the Bismillah, with thy permission I shall request them from the faithful brother, for they are my covenant and my protection. If thou seest it fitting, grant permission that they be delivered to me exactly. Peace be upon those who draw nigh unto thee.

Book Three

He is the Mighty. O my Master and Support! God knoweth my aversion to that which I was pursuing in times past, and now I beseech thee by the right of him whose Gateship thou hast claimed, that thou wouldst ask God, exalted be He, to remove the love of this world from my heart, and that I might return from this journey, God willing, having fulfilled my needs, and that He not expose me in the sight of creation, and that He protect me from the difficulties of this journey, God willing. Forget me not in thy noble thoughts, God willing.

Book Four

He is! O Guide of the Perplexed! Through Thy remembrance do I seek assistance. May my father and mother be a sacrifice unto thee, O my Master! How can one reach felicity when between us lie mountain peaks, and beyond them perils, while feet are bare, and I have no mount, and hands are empty, and the path is frightening? O son of manifest proofs! O son of conclusive arguments! O son of decisive verses! O son of the Ultimate Paradise! O Ultimate Goal of thanksgiving! O Savior! Would that I knew when we shall arrive at thy wellsprings of healing and be satisfied! When shall we benefit from thy sustenance, for long hath been the thirst! When shall we behold thee and be comforted and guided! When shall we see thee, when the earth hath been filled with equity and justice, and we shall say:

> "Praise be to God, Remover of harm and affliction, the All-Merciful, established upon the throne!"

O God! We are Thy servants, yearning for Thee and for Thy guardian and his gate, whom Thou hast made for us a protection and refuge, and whom Thou hast appointed and established for us as a proof and shelter, and made him for us a guardian and leader. O God! Convey to him from us greetings and peace, and grant us thereby honor and dignity, and assign us with him a fixed abode and station. O God! Send blessings upon him and upon his pure forebears—blessings that have no limit in number and no end in duration.

And upon his pure forebears bestow blessings infinite in number and endless in duration. Hasten his appearance, make wide his path, and through him establish Thy suspended ordinances and Thy neglected and altered laws. Through him, show mercy to the poor among the believers and to their widows, until truth appears with him and falsehood and its followers perish. O God, make us among those who cling to his mantle and abide beneath his shade, and help us fulfill the rights of allegiance to him and strive in rendering obedience unto him. Favor us with his good pleasure, grant us the grace to obey him and to love him. Turn Thy gracious countenance toward us and give us to drink from their fountain a draught sweet and wholesome, O Thou Most Merciful One! The two requests are not hidden; my hope from His Lordship's presence is a reply in His blessed handwriting. And peace be a goodly seal.

Book Five

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate. Peace from the Source of Peace, and through peace unto peace returneth peace. There is no God but Him, the Worshipped One, unto Whom all creation must return. Then peace from the Presence of Creation, the Ancient Remembrance, unto all the people of submission and peace. Praise be unto Him! There is no God but Him, for He hath made us know the decree of creation through invention and made us among those who remember. Thanks be unto Him! His bounties upon us through the opening of the galaxy for the descent of mercy from them, even though we were not among the believers. For the Lord, glorified and exalted be He, changeth not what is with a people until they change what is within themselves.

What would He do with our punishment if we were among the thankful for His bounties? O God! Make us among those who acknowledge Thy unity—there is no God but Him—and who are humble before Thy

signs, who worship the All-Merciful and prostrate themselves before Him as Thou hast commanded. The people of the highest heaven obeyed Thee, while the creatures of hell turned away from Thy command and showed enmity. Thanks be unto Thee, O Thou Who art thanked! Thou hast inspired us with knowledge of the Tree and its fire, and the oil pressed from it, and the appearance of the lamp, and the matter of the glass, and the completion of the Word through the revolution of the Point, and Thou hast made us among those who submit.

After this, the Messenger delivered what he was commanded, and we heard his command and we were among those who behold the Tablets. God, glorified and exalted be He, honored us through observing in the Tablets the knowledge of the pillars of unity, and guidance became distinct from error, and we, God willing, are among those who obey His command. And concerning what was unclear to us from the allegorical verses, we submit to the command of His Supreme and Great Remembrance, being among those who submit, that God may inspire us with knowledge of His mystery after a while or before a while. We beseech the Lord, the High, the Great, to hasten relief for the oppressed, by the right of the Family of God upon Him and His right upon the Family of God, all of them. Blessings and peace from the Lord, exalted is He, upon the fourteen infallible ruby reeds, and after them upon the poor among their submitting followers, and their beloved awaiting devotees, and upon all hearts that yearn toward them among the scattered and the tested ones. O God! Bless Muhammad and his Family and [hasten] their relief by their right, O Generous One!

Book Six

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate. Glory be to God, the One, the Unique, Who is alone in Essential Oneness. All besides His Majestic Essence has no essential reality and is null and void before the dominion of His Essence, such that His pre-eternity is His Essence, His post-eternity is His Essence, and His everlastingness is His Essence. He has no pre-eternity other than Himself, likewise no post-eternity other than Himself, and no everlastingness—rather He is He without a "He," for "He" is an indication, and our Lord is exalted above being indicated. Glory be to God Who created me for His knowledge and worship! The path to His knowledge is confined to His signs, for it is impossible to know His Essence by His Essence, as none knows Him as He truly deserves to be known except Him. Indeed, there is no way to truly know His signs as they are, so that the inability to truly know His signs is the clearest proof of the inability to know Him.

O my God! The nearest of Thy signs to my soul is my own soul, and my soul's inability to know its own true essence is among the most self-evident facts to my soul. So with what audacity could I claim to truly know another, be it higher than me, then higher still, then highest, then there is no height beyond the Most High above all that is high, and the Manifestation of Thy glory, O Thou the All-Glorious! Therefore I beseech Thee, O my God, by Thy signs and the effulgence of Thy grace and Thy mercy and Thy guidance, to expand my breast through knowledge of Thy signs in Thy Book and in Thy earth and Thy heaven, and especially the Seven Oft-repeated Verses and the Great Qur'an.

Therefore, O God, send Thy blessings upon Muhammad and his pure household, Thy friends of the true Faith and Thy guides on the straight path—nay, they are themselves the true Faith and the straight path.

O my Lord and O Thou in Whose hands lie the reins of my affairs! Verily Thou knowest that the most beloved of things to me is Thy love, and the nearest of all approaches to me is nearness to Thee, and the sweetest of all delights is the delight of intimacy with Thee, and the most cherished of all comforts is repose beneath the shadow of Thy love. Take my hand and have mercy upon my weakness, my helplessness and my deficiency, for Thou art the Most Merciful of the merciful.

Sufficient is my deficiency and helplessness that I am not I except that Thou hast made me so, and I am not I but rather I am Thou. Blessed am I, then again blessed am I! Thus Thou doest what I do, and I wounded not when I wounded, but God did.

O my Lord and my God! Thou hast entrusted Thy servants to themselves and their striving, and hast said "Those who strive in Our cause, We will surely guide them to Our paths," and Thou hast said "Man receives naught save what he strives for," and Thou hast preferred those who strive over those who sit idle. Thou hast made the victory of the Prophet (peace be upon him and his family) and the Imam (peace be upon him), and the might of Islam, and the triumph of truth, and the vanquishing of falsehood dependent upon their journeying forth and leaving behind their children and possessions. Thou hast given them choice in staying or traveling according to their own judgment and consideration of benefit, and hast made every soul responsible for what it earns, saying "To its benefit is what it earns and against it what it acquires." Thou hast established this firm decree with Thy words "There is no compulsion in religion," thus placing the reins of affairs in the hands of the monotheists to invalidate the doubt of compulsion and delegation with clearest explanation, so that people would have no argument against God, but rather God's is the conclusive argument.

Yes, my God and my Helper! This is from Thy grace upon me and Thy generosity toward what I have, through the manifestation of Thy kindness, O Kind One, upon Thy poor, estranged and weak servant. But O my God, my Shelter and my Succor! I beseech Thee by Thy Most Holy Essence and Thy Sanctified Name, and by Thy Name the Most Great, the Most Mighty, the Most Glorious, the Most Noble, and by the right of Muhammad and his pure family (God's blessings be upon them all)—that Name by which when a servant calls upon Thee, Thou dost answer him, and when a distressed one beseeches Thee, Thou dost respond to him—not to leave me to my forgetful self and my hardened heart for the blink of an eye, ever, for I have tested myself in the private and public aspects of my affairs and found it to be deceitful, fraudulent, and immersed in the seas of heedlessness. Praise be to Thee for showing me the faults of my soul, whereby I witnessed the effects of its error, mistake and misguidance in all my limbs and faculties, outwardly and inwardly, such that no trust remains in myself.

Therefore I implore from Thy presence clarification of Thy command and prohibition, and explicit statement of Thy decree in all that benefits my religion, my worldly affairs, my hereafter, my brethren, and all Muslims. O my God and my Helper! Thou knowest my poverty and the poverty of my loved ones, our debts, the strength of our adversaries and their wealth, and the inclination of rulers and worldly people toward them. Given all this, dost Thou command me to move or to stay still, O Remover of anxieties and Dispeller of sorrows? Thou hast indeed gladdened my heart by manifesting the rising sun of mutual imprecation from the dawning-place of origination. I beseech Thee by Thy right to increase joy

upon joy by clarifying its time, manner, and fruits—whether the source is restricted to the masters or if it can proceed from servants and subjects, even from the least of the least and lowest of the low.

O God! Hear this intimate prayer from the abject, insignificant, poor, destitute, and humble servant who possesses for himself neither benefit nor harm nor death nor life nor resurrection; O God, send blessings upon Muhammad and his pure family, and their chosen gates, and the chosen gates of their gates, and their beloved followers, and those who dwell at the door of Thy mercy and bounty; and curse their enemies and the enemies of their gates and their deputies and their vicegerents and their followers among the first and the last ones, forever and for all ages, O Thou Who art the severest of avengers.

Book Seven

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate. Peace be upon you, O son of the Messenger of God, and the mercy and blessings of God be upon you. Since the family of God and their followers—peace of God be upon them—have accustomed us to beauty, we therefore hope from them abundance. [My question is nothing other than a request for the return of my greeting. There is no further scope for inquiry, nor room for extended speech. Rather, I ask of you the return of the salutation—by way of reply and acceptance. Yet] since the kindred of God and their Shí'ih—may the peace of God rest upon them—have ever accustomed us to what is fair and gracious, we therefore hope to receive from them what is bountiful and abundant. [Wherefore, if ye would, through the august favor of God, vouchsafe unto this lowly servant a seemly bestowal and a munificent kindness, grant me that I may utter, with the tongue alike of state and of speech, in secret and in public, in all ages and cycles, these words of the kindred of God—upon them be the peace of God, the Sovereign, the All-Forgiving.]

O my God! Make us of those in whose hearts the trees of longing for Thee have flourished in the gardens of their breasts, and the ardor of Thy love hath seized the essence of their hearts. They take refuge in the nests of contemplation, and graze in the meadows of nearness and revelation. From the pools of love they drink with the cup of grace, and they frequent the springs of pure friendship. The veil hath been lifted from their insight, and the darkness of doubt hath been dispelled from their convictions and inner consciousness. The taint of uncertainty hath been removed from their hearts and their innermost being. Their breasts have been expanded through the realization of true knowledge, and their aspiration hath been exalted to the highest degree of glory through their precedence in felicity.

Their drink hath become sweet from the spring of divine knowledge, their secret hath become pure in the assembly of intimacy, their company hath found security in the abode of praise, their souls have found peace in returning to the Lord of lords, and [their spirits have found joy] in attaining success and prosperity. Their eyes have been gladdened by gazing upon their Beloved, and their resolution hath been established through understanding [divine wisdom] and attaining their goal. Their trade hath prospered in selling this world for the next. I dare not add more for fear of discourtesy. O Lord, answer the prayer of those whose hearts are broken. Praise be to God, first and last, inwardly and outwardly.

Book Eight

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate. Praise be to God Who caused the sun to appear for the mystery of praise, and through it made the morning dawn for the mystery of subsistence after extinction. He ordained light for the morning after darkness, and the pleasing radiance for the manifestation of glory from the world of the unseen. He illumined the light upon Mount Sinai with a brilliance throughout all creation, both seen and unseen. He ordained the dove to warble upon its branch with melodies that render the dwellers of earth and heaven unable to hear them. He commanded man to manifest less than a needle's eye of the light of grandeur upon the people of the unseen, whereby the Sinaitic souls in the Supreme Concourse, among the people of the first and last ages, would swoon and die.

He darkened the pitch-black night through the decree of destiny for the appearance of the light of day in this dark abyss. He removed it and brought forth the day through establishing the manifestation of the Eternal Sun in the midst of heaven, until it filled the desert of attributes and names with all manner of perfect manifestations, endlessly unto endless time, from beginning to end. He caused all creation between to be enslaved to the mystery of origination, to distinguish the wretched from the blessed, raising these to the highest degrees of the gardens of glory and casting those to the lowest depths of the levels of earth—all this for the glory of His unity in grandeur and eternity, and the sanctity of His uniqueness in glory and praise.

Glorified, glorified be He! How great is His station, how perfect His handiwork, how wise His command, how manifest His light, how lofty His beacon, how luminous His proof, how clear His exposition, how exalted His place, how supreme His sovereignty—until hearts and minds among created things have proven powerless to comprehend His unity and uniqueness, tongues have grown weary in conversation of describing and praising Him, pens have broken in attempting to write of His glorification and praise. Nay, all things, in their entirety, proclaim with utmost inadequacy and deficiency, from beginning to end, in ways infinite and boundless, their praise of Him. His is all praise—praise that is transcendent, resplendent, abundant, and overflowing—for the perfection and completion of His bounty, for the excellence and perfection of His handiwork, for the manifestation and proclamation of His power, for the completion and conveyance of His proof, for the reformation and guidance of the inner being through showing the path and enabling the attainment of its aims, and for granting insight through beholding its Creator in its ultimate ends.

And the most excellent prayers, the most perfect salutations and greetings be upon the sources of the Manifestations of the suns of creation, origination and invention, and their Originator; upon the Manifestations of those suns rising from the heaven of divine acceptance upon the lands of receptivity, and their Illuminator; upon the Manifestations of that praise, glory, radiance, grandeur and majesty in the realms of attributes and names, and their Source; upon the pillars of the declarations of unity of all contingent and created things, and the meanings of their names; upon the gates of infinite bounties to all creatures, both high and low, and their Guide; upon the leaders of all existing things and their guide to the highest degrees of Paradise and lowest depths of hell; upon the primal essences of the causes of all things and their origins—their efficient and material causes, their purpose and form—Muhammad and

His pure, chosen, and righteous Family, so long as the celestial spheres of the lights of guidance revolve and their suns shine upon their lands.

Then upon their gates and the gates of their gates, and the manifestations of their lights and their appearances in all cycles and ages among their followers from the beginning of creation to its end—for their holy might and their exalted station is above direct contact with creatures, both spiritual and material—from among their pillars and chiefs, and those guided by their guidance, both guide and guided.

And then especially upon the Most Great, Most Supreme, Most Magnificent Name; the Most Noble, Most Distinguished, Most Glorious Symbol; the Most Exalted, Most Revered, Most Honored, Most Perfect Sign; the Most Hidden, Most Glorious, Most Veiled, Most Great Mystery; the Fourth Line inscribed in the mystery of the Tablet by the reality of the Pen; the Concealed, Hidden, yet Unconcealed Secret for all who follow and submit to Him; the Second Inner Meaning penetrating the depths of all inner meanings from this vast ocean; the Third and Fourth Manifestation, the Penitent, the Bowing, the Prostrating, the Known, the Most Ancient, the Most Enduring; the Most Upright, Most Exalted, Most Precise, Most Perfect Support; the Most Straight, Most Just, Most True, Most Steadfast Path; the Firm, Noble, Strong, Well-established Pillar; the Noble Branch and Ancient Root from the Most Noble Branch and Most Ancient Root; the Most Luminous, Most Brilliant Light that dispels all darkness; He Who appeared on the Mount with the mystery of Manifestation upon the dispositions of all the people of the world; the Hand of God extended with bounties; the very Eye of God watching over the nations; the Side of God, whose negligence leads to loss and regret; the Most Kind with perfect, all-embracing, sweetest, most complete kindness; the Most Compassionate, Most Merciful, Most Generous from the Most Compassionate, Most Merciful, Most Bountiful; the Sympathetic, Kind, Gentle Intercessor for all who have sinned and transgressed; He Who is truly intended by the House and Sanctuary; the First House established among the people for all who have answered the call of Truth and entered into consecration; the Gate through whom all who believe in God and submit are tested and sifted; the Great Company and the Supreme Trial in the depths of this darkest night; the Moving Ship that saves from the tumultuous waves of this vast ocean; the One Who fights based on spiritual interpretation in God's path without fear of blame; the Appointed, Inevitable, Most Decisive Term; the Firm, Perfect, Decisive, Most Conclusive Decree; and the Deputy […]

To the noblest progeny of the children of Adam, and the sovereign nation that guides all nations—upon him and his family be the prayers of God and His peace—in the most noble, perfect and complete lineage; and the lofty, transcendent gate to their knowledge and manifestations for all who came before and after; the opener, originator, perfecter, completer, and seal of seals; the most learned, most accomplished, most perfect, most eloquent, most articulate, and untutored sage; who manifested the white, yellow and green light through the red light in the redness of the banner and the greenness of the standard; the bird soaring in the realm of the divine cloud, stunning all the people of ancient times; the blessed, pure martyr through the mystery of annihilation in divine unity, immersed in seas of blood, raised up from the most just and noble of Persian lands; the resplendent light and illuminating lamp; the just and mighty sovereign; the pure and quenching fountain; the manifest guiding master and the hidden ripening guide; the devoted, calling helper; the glory and traces of the Prophet and the Successor—upon

them be God's prayers; the one who arose by command of the Guardian—upon him be peace; the one who by His exalted permission brought destruction upon their enemies; the radiant, graceful youth of the lineage of Muhammad, Ali and Fatima—God's blessings upon them; the Arab of Mecca and Medina; the Qurayshi Hashimi of East and West; the one who called out around the shrine in clear, eloquent voice to answer the distressed, oppressed seeker of victory through the subtle, penetrating call; he before whose majestic light hearts and minds were bewildered, and intellects and imaginings proved incapable of comprehending even a needle's eye of description; tongues grew weary, pens broke, seas were exhausted and tablets disappeared in explaining but a portion of the manifestation of his word.

Sufficient proof of this is the saying of the All-Knowing King: "Say: If the ocean were ink for the words of my Lord, the ocean would be exhausted before the words of my Lord were exhausted, even if We brought another ocean like it as assistance." Therefore silence is more fitting and submission is better than attempting to dive into the seas of his description, glorification and exaltation. He who combines the two names from the highest sides, encompassing the two glories, light of the two luminaries, the Most Great Gate after the two gates, crown of the two sanctuaries, ruler of the two worlds of existence, the Light of God and His Proof, the Radiance of God and His Praise, the Remembrance of God and the remembrance of His Messenger and the Imams from his progeny—God's prayers be upon them with two "upon".

O God, instill for him in our hearts awe and dignity that draw us and connect us to him, that we may sacrifice ourselves in his path without difficulty or shame, through Muhammad, Ali, Fatima, and the two Hasans, and the rest of the chosen Imams—God's prayers and peace be upon them as long as the moon rises and light shines.

Now then, when night let fall its veils and darkness dimmed its boundaries, and injustice yellowed its mask and error called its followers who answered from every side, and every oppressor and usurper attacked, that Greatest Remembrance, that Magnificent Mystery observed this. Then arose the sun of his complete and universal mercy, and his perfect, comprehensive, and complete compassion upon his orphans and the orphans of the pure and righteous family of Muhammad—upon them be the peace of the Almighty King. So he stood upright around midday between the two risings at the beginning of the victorious month of Safar, in the presence of the two witnesses, to perfect the blessing upon the righteous and deliver the proof against the wicked and manifest vengeance upon the corrupt, turning toward the Kaaba in complete steadfastness. Then he commanded me by God's exalted, firm, perfect and decisive command to stand with him and to intertwine my lowly right fingers with his noble, elevated right fingers to manifest the word of truth upon all that is seen and unseen, may my spirit and the spirit of all the worlds be a sacrifice for Him, He revealed the Word of Certitude upon His noble tongue with utmost attentiveness seventy times in such manner as none before Him had ever revealed.

Glory be to God! How perfect was His command, how sure His wisdom, and how tranquil His heart! Then rose what was to rise, and gleamed what was to gleam, and shone what was to shine, and reached what was to reach, and appeared what was to appear. His is the praise and gratitude so long as any rising star shall rise or any thief shall steal forth.

BB00072: Letter to Haji ’Abd al-Wahhab

Introduction

And furthermore: O thou man! O thou man! Peace be upon thee from the Dawning-Place of the Sun of Utterance unto the throne whereon the All-Merciful is established! This is a station from the All-Merciful that knows no bounds. I have read thy letter written in crimson ink, and verily it is the color of my liver, for I know the words of the polytheists. For I was exalted in myself to such a degree that I had heard no word from anyone before. And now, after that Great Proof, thou shalt see what We see, and witness what We witness, and hear what We hear. Be thou for God’s sake a zealous lion until God judgeth with justice and bringeth about for Me thereafter a matter.

Fear not the onslaught of the satans, for they are but uprooted shadows having no proof, neither in the Book of Truth, nor before the Truth, nor even in their own words. Their likeness is as the likeness of a dog: if thou attack it, it panteth, and if thou leave it alone, it panteth. Stop their excessive panting with a mighty gift that thou mayest be freed from their evil. Draw not nigh unto those who have wronged, lest their chastisement touch thee, for they have no life. Associate with them only for thy purpose in God’s religion, for this is lawful for the believers in God’s Book, even as Ibn-i-Yaqtin did in the time of the Imam, peace be upon him. For today the support of one of them is more beneficial to the believers than the support of many seekers. Guard thou the Cause of God, conceal the mystery of God, and be patient in what befalleth thee, for the world shall pass away and the hereafter shall endure by God’s leave, and unto our Lord shall we return.

On the seven verses, follow what is indicated to thee

As for what thou asked about the seven verses, follow what is indicated to thee by God’s leave in the inner meanings of those words, for the mirror after mirror is a gentle companion.

The first query was about the dark spots on the moon. Know that the first to ask this question was the Prophet Khidr, peace be upon him, when he came to the door of the house of the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, in Medina after His ascension to heaven. He saw that Ali, peace be upon him, was standing by the door with great sorrow visible upon his countenance due to the cessation of revelation and the ascension of the Prophet, peace be upon him and his family. He asked him about these spots on the moon, meaning the change in the appearance of its face. He answered him, may my soul be his sacrifice, with the well-known verse from the Qur’an. And the spots on this moon of heaven corresponded to the moon of authority. Those possessed of understanding know that what is there cannot be known except by what is here, and these described spots are indeed a station of the answer. It is what God has written by His hands of power on the face of the two moons:

> “There is no God but God, Muhammad is God’s Messenger, Ali is God’s Friend.”

This is the inner path.

As for the outer aspects, I ask thee: the face of the moon is a clear mirror, and the spots are reflections of great things above the earth such as seas, mountains, and land masses. Even as the Christians, when they

mounted their aerial vessels, had with them a wondrous glass through which they looked at the moon and then observed what was on earth reflected in the moon, even to the trees. Indeed, were the glass clear and the eye subtle, one would see what is on earth reflected in the moon, even human faces. And that renowned island, betwixt thee and [Yanaqid], hath borne witness, for the Christians therein became apprised of this woman's ordinance concerning the "mole of the moon"; and verily this is a decree from the Pure One.

As to the reality of the matter, when the Will became attached to destiny, there appeared in the garments of Will the form of the lunar phases when it was joined with the sea of destiny and reflected in its face the multiplicities which God had placed in the sea of destiny. And verily the wretched are wretched in its womb and the blessed are blessed in its womb, and all act according to their disposition according to how the lunar phases of the moon of Providence turned from the forms of the sea of Power. This is an aspect of interpretation, and in every chain of the second chain there befits for the lunar phase of its moon an aspect of interpretation. Nay, for the number of all things, if God so willed, there would be an interpretation not from the prayer niches of men but from the prayer niches of the people of the Bayan and the perfect ones among humanity. Sufficient is what I have mentioned in those Tablets regarding the decree of the lunar phases as a remembrance and explanation.

On the confined sea, I send you the entire tradition

As for what you asked concerning the confined sea, I send you the entire tradition that you may witness God's decree in all its verses. However, in the language of the people of the Bayan, the overflowing sea refers to the water that has risen above the water without any place above it, and the confined refers to the sea of equality to the extent of the circle of the place. This is God's decree concerning the two seas according to the outward path, and as for the inward paths, they are limitless. Whatever God wishes, He sends down, and what He does not wish remains preserved in the treasuries of His Command—glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

As for what you saw in the verses of my teacher—peace be upon him—concerning the decree of the eight paradises, seven of them are in the heavens and one of them is empty of heaven, and heaven is created from it. This is the Paradise of Oneness—God made its heaven the very essence of its earth and decreed its earth to be the essence of its heaven. God has not ordained for it any shadow or description. Whoso enters it does not leave by God's leave, and whoso is outside cannot enter due to God's grandeur. It has neither location nor likeness. The seven paradises are atmospheres beneath the Throne, and their heaven was the Throne of the All-Merciful.

And His saying—God's mercy be upon him—that every paradise is in a heaven is true. And in the school of the Family of God—peace be upon them—there are endless applications for it. You can reconcile all contradictions through the mystery of destiny, for at the time when the heavens are folded and descend by God's leave upon the ground of gathering, their inhabitants will be in them in heaven and in the paradises like the mosquito that was in your hand, and it lives in God's kingdom, for God has created for it all that He created for the greater world. If you say it is in your right hand, it is true; if you say it is in heaven, it is true; if you say it is in the paradises, it is true—while it has settled upon an atom of your

body. Such is God's decree regarding all things. The folding is like a scroll that is rolled up. When God desires to gather all things, He folds the heavens and brings them down around the gathering. Then an angel calls out from before your Lord:

> "O company of jinn and men! If you can penetrate the regions of the heavens and earth, then penetrate them! You cannot penetrate except with authority."

Even now I call out as God will call out on that Day, for the heaven of verses has encompassed all such that none can escape therefrom. Indeed, what has been mentioned regarding the dimensions of the heavens and the journey of five hundred years in the words of the Family of God—may my spirit be sacrificed for them—is truth.

Return then to the mystery of destiny and the light of God will shine upon thee. Pay no heed to the words of the learned concerning necessities and traditions, for they know not the reality of the matter. All the laws of God are truth, and whosoever denies any of them is as though he has denied them all, and likewise is the judgment reversed. Truth is self-evident in its proximity to the light of God, such that none need reflect upon it, while falsehood is theoretical in its distance from God's nature and requires contemplation therein. This is contrary to the judgment of the logicians, yet it is the truth in reality.

On the Day of Gathering, the earth shall be transformed into other than this earth, becoming a single plain of perfect levelness. Upon it God has placed the Bridge, wherein are fifty stations for some people, and some shall remain at each station for a thousand years, this period being distinct from the duration of the Day of Resurrection. Today I see people standing upon the Bridge by God's decree—whomsoever God wishes to save shall be saved, and whomsoever God wishes to destroy shall be destroyed. God wrongs no one in aught, and He is the All-Sufficient, the All-Knowing.

On the words of Ahmad

As for what thou asked regarding the words of Ahmad—peace be upon him—yes, when man enters Paradise, he remains in the first station of the letters "There is no god but God"—the station of the body—for twelve thousand years. He advances from this station in less than the twinkling of an eye to the highest station, like his stay in the first station. This stay of twelve thousand years is equivalent to thy utterance "There is no god but God." When that Word descends from its station to the world of years, the indicated word appears. The crimson and emerald pavilions are stations among the stations of Paradise, each according to its measure. He who stands in the highest station of Paradise beholds what is below and delights in its blessings, but those below cannot see the blessings of those above, as God has removed grief from them, though they know of the higher station and are content with what God has ordained for them, having neither grief nor sorrow.

The people of Paradise advance eternally in Paradise through God's grace, as there is no end to His bounty's effusion. The servant never becomes independent in any condition, and God has created things for permanence, His bounty having neither suspension nor exhaustion. The cause of the servant's advancement in the Hereafter is that he should perpetually purify his intention in his deeds for God, in

accordance with his Lord's eternity. When he purifies his intention in this way, he advances in the stations of Paradise by God's command, without end. And thy Lord God is powerful over all things.

On the state of the spirit and its conditions, know

As for what thou asked regarding the state of the spirit and its conditions, know of a certainty that the dream world is equivalent to the spirit and like unto the sun in its station; nothing hath departed from the body. Nay rather, by its light whatever is in the heavens and the earth may be witnessed. Were a devout believer enabled to see all things by this divine agency, still would he reap the fruit of his belief, and naught can alter it; and were an unbeliever enabled to see all things upon the reflected forms, still on account of his unbelief would he reap, in justice, its fruit, and naught can alter it.

Verily, God hath created the dream in His servants that they may be assured of the existence of the worlds hereafter and the life everlasting. As the life of this world becometh transformed after death, in the same manner regard what is seen in the dream: when thou ariseth nothing more of it is seen, save the effect of its interpretation.

Exalted is God above those who lay all their hopes in this world and dread the abode hereafter and its felicity. Glory be unto Thee, O Lord, My God that the days of Thy meeting are near. This world bringeth me sorrow and its people reject me. Although we have been abandoned, Thou abandeth us not. Lord, distinguish between me and them, and suffer those near unto Thee to join me in Thy service.

The desire of the spirit and its inclination are to return to the Supreme King, for it was sent forth from His Command. In truth, every soul is a mirror in which may be seen the beauty of Husayn, the son of ʿAlí, upon them be peace. When the hour of death arrives, the Sovereign Lord observeth that which hath appeared upon the mirror, all its shortcomings and all its worthy conditions. When a faithful servant ascendeth to Him in spirit, should the hosts of heaven and earth attempt to prevent him, they shall not succeed, and he returneth unto God. And though the infidel fleeth before His awful Majesty, yet must he submit to the judgment of God, even should the hosts of heaven and earth combine to assist him. All things shall perish save the face of Thy Lord, the All-Glorious, the Most Generous

On God's words about the angels' prostration and Iblis's pride, where

As for what thou hast asked concerning God's words about the angels' prostration and Iblis's pride, where He, exalted be He, said "Wert thou haughty or wert thou of the high ones?", observe with the eye of origination. God has created in all things three signs: a sign from Himself, which is the sign that there is no god but Him and these are the high ones; a sign from His angels, which is the conditions of true servitude in every station according to its reality; and a sign from the severed essence for the preservation of His worlds according to what it has accepted for itself without command or compulsion. Take the meaning of the verse referring to the Will to the ultimate station of sovereignty. All the angels prostrated to Adam save Iblis alone, and this is God's decree in His Book. Do not imagine that those who do not prostrate to Adam in the station of divine authority are more numerous than those who do prostrate to him, for those who do not prostrate, despite their numbers, are like an uprooted tree without roots. And he who

prostrates, even if alone, since his manifestations are beyond enumeration in the Book, is like the angels of heaven and earth who all prostrate.

Today if thou alone acknowledge this Cause while all on earth turn away from it, this verse would be fulfilled in thy right: “So the angels prostrated, all of them together, save Iblis; he refused and waxed proud, and was of the unbelievers.” Understand this allusion, for it was revealed from beyond seventy thousand veils, as He, glorified be He, indicated: “Verily We have sent down the Reminder, and We shall preserve it.” The prostration of the angels was only to God alone, just as thou prostrate to God through the dust of Husayn, peace be upon him, and the prostration of the angels was like that. Whoever prostrates to anything besides God has associated partners with his Lord and is among the unbelievers.

On the Chiefs [nuqaba’] and the Nobles [nujaba’]: Yea, knowledge

As for what thou hast asked about the Chiefs [nuqaba’] and the Nobles [nujaba’]: Yea, knowledge of them is obligatory upon all, and the pillars circle round the body of Fatima, the blessings of God be upon her, and the Chiefs circle round the heart of the Pillars, and the Nobles circle round the Chiefs. The Pillars look upon all things yet see naught but God alone. The Chiefs look through all things and see the Lord with them. The Nobles look through all things and see the Lord beyond them. Such is God’s decree concerning them. The number of Chiefs today is thirty, subject to increase or decrease, but at the time of the presence of the Imam, peace be upon Him, their number must be three hundred and thirteen souls.

These are the people of certitude who will pledge allegiance to the Proof of God in the Sacred Mosque on the day of His manifestation. But as for the Nobles, they have no fixed number, and most of them today are the people of this Cause who possess certitude. They are the bearers of religion and the vessels of knowledge. Were it not for them, the heaven would not send down its rain, nor would the earth yield its vegetation, nor would My pen trace a single letter of the verses. May God grant Me their meeting in a land of security and glory. They are people who, had they the means, would gladly turn their lifeblood into golden ink with which to write the verses of God and aid His Cause.

They are a people whom, should all the inhabitants of the earth gather to oppose, no tempest could move them, nor could the signs of storms affect them. They are like Mount Uhud in their steadfastness upon the earth. The blessings of God be upon them so long as the sun of creation rises and sets through creation. Exalted be God above what they describe. Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00098: Tafsir-i-Hadith-i-Ma’rifati Nafs

Part 1: “He said, may God preserve him: What…”

“He said, may God preserve him: What is the meaning of the tradition transmitted from ʿAlí (peace be upon him):”Whoso hath known his own self hath verily known his Lord’?”

Know, O brother—may God have mercy upon thee—that I counsel thee, before commencing the explanation, with counsels which, if thou accept from me, will make attainment easy for thee; otherwise,

the matter will be difficult for thee, and there is no path to knowledge except through knowing these counsels:

First, thou must purify thy heart from every principle thou hast received from thy scholars, for they have drawn from turbid springs flowing one into another, some rejecting others. Hast thou not seen those who have changed God's bounty—that is, knowledge of Him—into disbelief and caused their people to dwell in the abode of perdition—Hell, wherein they burn; how evil a resting place! Soon they shall meet with destruction though they reckon they are doing good. Nay! From their hearts flows the abyss upon their tongues—the fire of polytheism and the poison of unbelief—yet they perceive not. If thou art fair to thy Lord, fearful of His station, and restrainest thyself from vain speech, thou wilt know that I am among the truthful ones. By God, I am indeed solicitous for thee and loving.

Second, compare not the words of thine Imams with the speech of creation, for speech is a manifestation among the manifestations of the speaker's action, mirrors reflecting what is in his heart. Just as their souls are conclusive proofs and decisive signs from God, glory be to Him, unto all worlds, so too are their words. Just as if all creation were to gather to produce the like of a single verse of the Qur'an they would be unable, so too are their words God's proof upon creation, and they are the perfect gatherer, for they issue from the source of purity. From a single one of their words emerges all religion, nay all existence is but the trace of a letter of His Word.

Behold in truth that God, exalted be He, is eternally One, none beside Him, never changing from His single state, now as He was, His Self His Self, and creation dwells in the plane of His dominion. When He willed—and God's Will is His bringing into being, not from anything—He did not beget anything but rather created things through Will, and created Will through itself. Will is the first point mentioned in contingent existence, and it is the First Remembrance whereby God remembered Himself:

> "Verily I am God, there is no god but I. I was a hidden treasure and I loved to be known, so I created creation that I might be known."

And God, glory be to Him, created from the evidence of this Word, which is the final degree of the Point, the water whereby all things live—though with its Creator it is but a letter, and its Creator is from God's Manifest Self that gleamed forth. Were it eternal, change would be necessitated, but He, exalted be He, never changes from His single state. Will exists in the station of thingness, which is the realm of absolute contingency, while pre-existence is His Self alone, His Self alone—no remembrance here, no trace here. The remembrance and trace we have described is His Will, which is an attribute of inference, not an attribute uncovering Him. His evidence is His signs, which are Will, and His existence is His proof, which is the sign of Oneness.

After Muhammad there is no limit to His Will, no end and no finality. All things point to Him, and He alone points to God, for in this station there is no direction for Him, and because they are the Self of God—whosoever knows them knows God—meaning the knowledge possible in the contingent realm. To them belongs creation and command, and unto them do all affairs return, for command and creation are both contingent and return not to the Ancient One, but rather return from attribute to attribute, while

sovereignty endures in sovereignty. The created ends with its like—the path to eternity is barred and the quest rejected. His proof is in His signs and His existence in His confirmations.

Indeed all actions from them are from God, glorified be He, as clearly stated by the Proof in his visitation to Muhammad ibn Uthman al-Amri: "Your striving in God possesses God's Will." Similar statements abound in verses and traditions. Everything from them is from God, for they speak not from desire—it is naught but revelation revealed. Their words are the words of God. Whoever asks why' or how' has disbelieved, for His word encompasses all things, flowing through all worlds according to the languages of their people. In His word there is no simile, for the likened would be identical to that which it is likened to, no metaphor and no allegory, for metaphor and allegory are devices of the powerless, while He is the All-Powerful, the Mighty.

God taught Adam the names of all beneath his station, and this Adam, our father Adam, is a thousand thousand Adams removed from the First Adam, yet he cannot know the names of the Imams, for even Jesus, noblest of prophets, admitted this, as God relates his words: "I know not what is in Thy Self." What is related in traditions that God taught Adam the names of the Five for his repentance—Muhammad, Ali, Fatima, Hasan and Husayn—such that none calls upon God through them but God must answer, that knowledge was at Adam's station, and nothing surpasses its source. Let this suffice you in not comparing speech.

And third, interpret not the words of the Infallible Ones as deficient, but rather as sublime and noble—"Houses which God has permitted to be raised, wherein His name is remembered." To remember from inability is lies and fabrication against God. The Imam said: "Has God permitted you, or do you fabricate against God? The fabricators—their abode is the Fire and they have no helper." Accept my counsels, and God is thy Guardian. As for the meaning of Ali's words, know and plant firm thy feet upon the Path.

God the Exalted said:

> "We shall show them Our signs in the horizons and within themselves until it becomes clear to them that it is the Truth."

And God the Exalted said in the Gospel:

> "Know thyself and thou shalt know thy Lord—thy outward is for annihilation and thy inward am I."

And the Messenger of God said: "He among you who best knows himself best knows his Lord."

And Ali, when asked by a bedouin about the higher realm, said:

> "Forms devoid of matter, free from potentiality and capacity, upon which He shone forth and they became illumined, and which He beheld and they became radiant. He cast into their essence His image, and thus His acts were manifested through them."

Husayn, peace be upon him, said in his prayer on the Day of Arafah:

> "Has any other than Thee a manifestation that Thou lackest, so that it would be that manifestation that revealeth Thee? When wert Thou ever hidden, that Thou shouldst need proof to lead to Thee? And when wert Thou ever distant, that created things should lead us to Thee? Blind be the eye that seeth Thee not!"

Ali ibn Husayn said in his dawn prayer, known as the Prayer of Abu Hamzah:

> "Through Thee I knew Thee, and Thou didst direct me unto Thee and called me to Thee. Had it not been for Thee, I would not have known what Thou art."

as-Sadiq said:

> "Servitude is a substance whose essence is Lordship. What is lost in servitude is found in Lordship, and what is hidden in Lordship is attained in servitude."

The Imam said in his prayer for the month of Sha'ban:

> "O my God! Grant me complete devotion to Thee, and illuminate the vision of our hearts with the light of their looking toward Thee, until the sight of the hearts penetrates the veils of light and reaches the Source of Grandeur."

Part 2: "The Proof said in the prayer…"

The Proof said in the prayer for the month of Rajab, indicating this station:

> "There is no difference between Thee and them, save that they are Thy servants and Thy creation. Their analysis and synthesis are in Thy hands. Their beginning is from Thee and their return is to Thee. They are supports and witnesses, manifestations and opposites, guardians and pioneers. Through them Thou hast filled Thy heaven and earth until it became manifest that there is no God but Thee."

Look, then, with the eye of thy heart upon what hath been imparted to thee, and know with certainty that God, exalted be He, is eternally One, having neither name nor form. His Essence is His Essence, and no wings of hearts can soar to His presence, nor can any mind conceive of His holy might. He is as He Himself hath said: "No vision can grasp Him." He is One, alone, with none beside Him. There is no God but He.

When He desired to create all contingent beings, He created them in the image of His action, creating them from nothing by His power. His Will was their origination, nothing else. When He created contingent beings by His Command—and the contingent is unable to reach or ascend unto Him, and the Truth, glorified be He, is too glorious and great to be known by anyone, for knowledge is contingent upon conjunction, which is an attribute of contingency, while He, the Truth, is far more exalted and mighty than this—divine wisdom necessitated that He describe Himself to contingent beings, though His description is His origination from nothing.

This description, which nothing in creation resembleth, God made the way to know Him and the sign of His oneness, that the contingent might reach the ultimate outpouring possible in the contingent realm. God made this description the reality of the servant, and it is the Lordship of the Lord, exalted and glorified be He. It is His self [nafs] and heart [fu'ad]. God described Himself to everything through everything, and cast into the essence of everything His own likeness, until He became known; and in all things there is a sign indicating that He is One. That description is the sign of the Lord and the reality of the servant. And this description has as many stations as there are breaths of the creatures. All souls are as mirrors, and He is manifest to the mirrors through the mirrors. He is the One, the sign of God and His description. And for all things this soul exists—whoso knoweth it hath known his Lord.

The meaning is that there is no way unto God except through recognition of this soul, which is the same as the recognition of the Lord, for a thing cannot be comprehended beyond its source. Whoso knoweth his own self through the attributes of his Creator knoweth Him, and that description is the description of the Lord—there is nothing like unto Him, and He is the Most Exalted, the Most Great.

Therefore did the Imam say:

> "Know God through God, the Messenger through his Message, and those endued with authority through their bidding to what is right and their forbidding what is wrong."

This description from the Truth, from God to the servant, hath four stations through four manifestations:

First, the description of the indication of God, the One, the Single, the Eternal, Who begetteth not nor is begotten, and there is none like unto Him. This is the station of pure unity and absolute oneness—its beginning is identical with its end, and its manifestation identical with its concealment. There is no way unto Him save through what He hath described of Himself. He is the sign of God, the Ancient, Who is the Knower but hath no known thing, the Hearer but hath no heard thing, the Seer but hath no seen thing. The way unto Him is barred and the quest rejected. Second is the manifestation of His attributes, which is Prophethood. Third is the manifestation of His names, which is Divine Authority. Fourth is the manifestation of His deeds, which is the followers.

The expression of manifestation through four descriptions is outward, and God the Most High hath no description save through His deeds. Though the way of knowing Him is through the breaths of creation, it is confined to eight worlds in succession, and these are their universals: First, the world of the Point, the Alif, the Letters and the Word—this is the world of Muhammad and his household. Second, the world of the Prophets and Trustees. Third, the world of man. Fourth, the world of the jinn. Fifth, the world of angels and devils. Sixth, the world of animals. Seventh, the world of plants. Eighth, the world of minerals.

The description of each subsequent world describes the nature of the world before it unto the end of its station. Therefore it is related in the tradition that the ant claims for God two lordships, and that description which is in everything is God's lordship over it thereby. "Is it not enough that thy Lord is witness over all things?"—meaning, present in thy absence and presence. This is the pillar of light which the Imam beholds and turns toward, and through which he becomes aware of the deeds of creation. Were he to desire, he could manifest it in everything from everything, just as He manifested from Moses' staff what He manifested, and the Imam pointed to the image of the lion and it became a living creature.

Through this door are opened the difficulties of most traditions, such as the saying of the Imam in the visitation prayer for the supporters of Husayn (peace be upon him): “May my father and mother be sacrificed for you.” For the vision of the Imam is a sign of God within him—he sees naught but the light of God and hears no voice but His voice. There is no difference between this description of the servant and the declaration “There is no god but God”—both are created signs that point to God, for temporal existence and its attributes, insofar as they are effects of God’s action, are signs of God Almighty in consciousness, without regard to their individual identity and temporal nature, meaning they are lifted up by God’s leave.

At this stage, the tree of essence has no mention—it is an evil tree, uprooted from above the earth with no stability. Indeed, this description is God’s judgment upon essence as it truly is, and He is not unjust to His servants. Know the essence as He made it, as Ali (peace be upon him) indicated in the Sermon of the Camel’s Foam, that the tree of unbelief—meaning essence—should know that my position in relation to it is like that of the axis to the millstone. Through knowledge of itself it denied and disbelieved, yet the description is not unjust to the servants.

This tree has an effect from its shadow through the existence of light—look at the sun: when it rises its light shines upon everything, and when it falls upon the tree it creates a shadow. When the shadow rises in the shade, the shadow has neither mention nor portion before the sun. Thus does denial find its limit before recognition.

I seek God’s forgiveness for excessive definition. When the Sufis reached this station they claimed they had reached God, and they wrote in their books mighty words at which the heavens almost burst and the earth split asunder. In our school this was considered unbelief—I seek refuge in God from Satan’s stain. Glory be to God, far exalted is He above what the wrongdoers say!

Here the pen has stopped, yet we do not fall short in explanation. He who knows has known, and he who is ignorant remains ignorant. Give not to the foolish your wealth. Indeed, we belong to God and to Him we shall return. And praise be to God, Lord of all worlds.

BB00151: Tafsir-i-Hadith-i-Haqiqat (Commentary on the Tradition of Truth)

Part 1: “One day Kumayl ibn Ziyad al-Nakha’i(Following…”

One day Kumayl ibn Ziyad al-Nakha’i[1] rode behind Ali[2] (peace be upon him) on his camel.

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[1] (Following is an experimental AI-generated gloss—limited to eight footnotes per paragraph—with instructions to explore the relevant antecedents in both Sufi and Shi’ite literature.) Kumayl (d. ca. 82/701) is famed in Shi’i tradition as a close companion of Imam Ali and transmitter of Du’aʾ Kumayl. The present dialogue is widely circulated as Hadith al-Haqiqa (“Tradition of Reality/Truth”), often cited in later Shi’i and Sufi metaphysical discussions.

Kumayl asked, “O my master, what is Truth?”[3] Ali replied, “What have you to do with Truth?”[4] Kumayl said, “Am I not a confidant of your secret?”[5]

Ali answered, “Indeed you are, but that which overflows from me only trickles upon you[6].” Kumayl said, “Would one such as you disappoint a seeker?”[7] ʿAli (peace be upon him) replied, “The removal of the veils of glory without indication.”[8]

Know that His word encompasses all things[9] and flows through all worlds, for speech is a manifestation among the manifestations[10] of the Speaker. God, exalted be He, made it the manifestation of His

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[2] The Arabic uses ardafahu (“made him ride behind him”), a motif of intimate companionship and esoteric instruction. Comparable adab-scenes occur in Sufi manuals where a disciple accompanies the shaykh on a journey, signaling transmission (talqin) of inner knowledge rather than public preaching.

[3] “Truth” renders al-haqiqa, a key term in Sufi triads (shari’a–tariqa–haqiqa) and in Shi’i irfan for the inner reality of faith. The question echoes later Sufi treatments of haqiqa as unveiling (kashf) rather than discursive definition.

[4] The rebuff (ma laka wa’l-haqiqa) functions pedagogically: in Sufi literature it resembles the shaykh’s “testing” of the murid’s capacity (isti’dad). In Shi’i hadith, it parallels the theme that certain ma’arif are restricted to those who can bear them (tahammul al-ilm).

[5] “Confidant of your secret” translates sahib sirrik. The sirr (inner secret) is central in Sufi psychology (sirr as an interior faculty) and in Shi’i imamology, where the Imam entrusts esoteric knowledge to select companions; compare the recurrent motif of “bearers of the secret” (ashab al-sirr).

[6] The Arabic contrast is “that which overflows from me” (yatfah) versus “trickles upon you” (yarshah). This imagery is common in Sufi accounts of fayd (effusion) and spiritual capacity: the disciple receives according to preparedness, while the source (wali/imam) overflows with superabundant knowledge.

[7] Kumayl’s appeal frames him as saʾil (“seeker/asker”), a term resonant with Sufi suluk. In Shi’i adab, it also evokes the etiquette of questioning the Imam: insistence is permitted when grounded in loyalty, yet answers may remain allusive to protect the unready.

[8] “Removal” renders kashf; “veils of glory” translates subuhat al-jalal, recalling the famous Prophetic motif of divine “veils” (hujub) and the Light Verse’s imagery of layered luminosity. “Without indication” (min ghayr ishara) aligns with apophatic Sufi language: haqiqa is tasted (dhawq) beyond sign and description.

[9] Cf. Qurʾan 4:126; 65:12 on divine ihata (encompassing). In Shi’i hadith, God’s knowledge and command are said to encompass all things; compare formulations in al-Kulayni, al-Kafi (kitab al-tawhid) on ihata and ilm. The Arabic uses muhit/ihata explicitly.

[10] This is tajalli (theophany): kalam as a tajalli of the mutakallim. Compare Ibn Arabi’s doctrine of divine self-disclosure (Futuhat; Fusus) where attributes and “speech” appear as modes of manifestation, and Qunawi’s discussions of tajalliyat al-asmaʾ. The Bab echoes this Sufi metaphysics in Shi’i idiom.

encompassing nature^[On “Word” as locus of divine disclosure: compare the Shi’i identification of the Imam as “kalimat Allah” and “hujja” (e.g., al-Saduq, al-Tawhid; al-Kafi), and the broader Qurʾanic motif of “His Word” (kalimatuhu).

The Arabic: ja’alahu mazhar ihatatihi wa-tajallihi.] and His revelation, and of all His appearances, for the Essence alone encompasses itself[11], and He is the Encompasser and nothing encompasses Him. The station of conjunction[12] is the station of His action and His manifestation, which is a creation created by its Maker through Himself^[“Created by its Maker through Himself” recalls Shi’i reports on creation “by the will” (bi’l-mashiʾa) and the first creation as a mediating reality (al-Kafi on mashiʾa; al-Saduq).

In Sufi terms, it parallels emanation through the divine command (kun) and the first determination (ta’ayyun awwal).] and established in His shadow[13]. All expressions in the station of knowledge express His station, and the encompassing nature of His word is the encompassing nature of the Word of God—nothing escapes from beneath His shadow[14].

When you understand this introduction, know that Kumayl’s state is revealed through his answer[15]—that he was not perfect in the station of servitude[16], else he would not have asked about Truth^[The critique of “asking about al-*haqiqa*” echoes the Hadith of Kumayl’s own structure (questioning the *haqiqa* and receiving graded answers).

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[11] A negative-theological axiom: only the divine dhat is self-encompassing; nothing contains it. Compare Shi’i apophatic statements on God’s unknowability (al-Saduq, al-Tawhid; Nahj al-Balagha sermons on tanzih) and Sufi discussions of the dhat beyond relation (Ibn Arabi; al-Jili).

[12] Arabic maqam al-iqtiran (“conjunction/correlation”) evokes the barzakh or isthmus where divine act and created manifestation meet. Compare Ibn Arabi’s barzakh doctrine (Fusus, “Hikma Isma’iliyya”) and Shi’i cosmologies of intermediary realities (alam al-mithal; the Imam as wasita).

[13] “Shadow” (zill) is a common Sufi metaphor: the cosmos as zill Allah, dependent and derivative (cf. Ibn Arabi, Futuhat). Shi’i devotional language also uses zill for the Imam or divine protection. The Arabic: astaqarruhu fi zillihi; nothing lies outside this zill.

[14] Echoes Qurʾanic omniscience/omnipresence: “not absent from Him is an atom’s weight” (10:61; 34:3) and “He encompasses all things” (41:54). The Bab’s phrasing aligns with Shi’i tawhid traditions stressing that no thing “escapes” (la ya’zub) divine knowledge and governance.

[15] Kumayl b. Ziyad is the addressee of the famous Hadith of Kumayl (Imam Ali’s discourse on al-*haqiqa*). The commentator infers from Kumayl’s questioning a deficiency in *ubudiyya* (servitude), a common adab-theme in Sufi manuals: the perfected knower does not seek what is already present.

[16] *Maqam al*-ubudiyya** is a key term in both Shii and Sufi ethics: the servant’s annihilation of claim (*dawa*) before God. Compare Sufi discussions of *ubudiyya* as the summit of realization (e.g., al-Qushayri’s *Risala*) and Shii devotional emphasis on *ubudiyya* in dualiterature.

In Sufi epistemology, the Real (al-*Haqq*) is not an object of discursive inquiry but of *dhawq*/*mushahada*; cf. al-Hujwiri and Ibn Arabi on the self-evidence of the Real.], for that which is asked about is Truth itself, and it is not other than itself[17]. Rather, it is more evident than to be asked about[18], as the Prince of Martyrs^["Prince of Martyrs" (Sayyid al-Shuhada) refers to Imam Husayn.

The citation is from DuaArafah*, a foundational Shii devotional text with strong theophanic language, widely commented upon in later Shii* irfan* and also appreciated in Sufi circles for its metaphysics of presence.] said in the prayer of ʿArafah: "Can anything other than You have a manifestation[19] that You lack, so that it would be that which manifests You? When wert Thou ever hidden, that Thou shouldst need an indication to lead to Thee?

When wert Thou ever distant, that traces should lead to Thee? Blind is the eye that sees Thee not[20] ever watching over it! What a losing bargain he has made who has not taken a share of Thy love!"

Had Kumayl not seen himself as riding alongside him[21], he would not have ventured such speech with him. Had he known himself, he would not have presumed to ride alongside him, for his reality is but a trickle[22] of what overflows from His glory.

How can a ray ride alongside the orb of the sun?[23] That is impossible, for a thing cannot surpass its source[24]. Kumayl erred when he saw himself riding alongside him and imagined his own self and reality, so

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[17] This is a strong non-dual formulation: the sought (al-*haqiqa*) is identical with itself and not "other" (*ghayr*). It resonates with Sufi language of identity (*huwa huwa*) and Shii philosophical-theosophical treatments of the Real as self-manifest (e.g., later *irfan* and hikma traditions).

[18] The claim that God/Truth is "more evident" than inquiry recalls the maxim "the Real is more manifest than creation," common in *irfan*. It parallels Sufi arguments that the Real is the most evident (*azhar*) and that veiling comes from the seeker's heedlessness, not from divine absence.

[19] This line articulates a doctrine of divine self-manifestation: nothing "other" can disclose God, since all manifestation is His. It closely aligns with Sufi theophany (*tajalli*) and Ibn Arabi's critique of taking created things as independent "signs," while also echoing Shii duaidioms of God as the sole *muzhir* (manifesting agent).

[20] The "blind eye" motif is a standard topos in both traditions: spiritual blindness results from veils of the self, not from God's absence. Compare Sufi discussions of *basira* (inner sight) and Shii supplications that lament the loss of witnessing (*mushahada*) and one's "share" (*nasib*) of divine love (*mahabbah*).

[21] Alludes to the Hadith of Kumayl, where Kumayl rides behind Imam Ali and asks about al-Ḥaq={i}qa (Truth/Reality). The commentator reads the physical "riding together" as a symbol of spiritual parity claimed by the disciple, a common trope in Shii adab of discipleship.

[22] Arabic: "rashḥa ṭafḥ min jal={a}lihi" (a mere spray/overflow from His majesty). Compare Sufi accounts of created being as a "drop" from the divine ocean (e.g., Ibn Arab={i}'s imagery of tajall={i} and fayḍ). The point is ontological dependence, not identity.

he asked about Truth^[“Truth” translates al-Ḥaq={i}qa, a key term in Sufi triads (shar={i}a/ṭar={i}qa/ḥaq={i}qa).

In Shii usage here it is tied to Imam Ali’s esoteric authority: inquiry into ḥaq={i}qa requires annihilation of self-claim (daw={a}).]. He (peace be upon him) said “What have you to do with Truth?”[25] meaning that you are in the station of duality[26], and that is association more distant than the two Easts, while He is closer to you than your jugular vein[27]—what have you to do with Truth?

When the servant heard and recognized the association within himself[28], he feared before his Creator and his dark self became subtle. He said, “Am I not a confidant of your secret?”[29]

He (peace be upon him) said “Indeed,” showing kindness so as not to extinguish the fire of his love[30], and that which overflows trickled upon him. He made known to him through his words “that which overflows

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[23] The ray/sun simile is widespread in Sufi metaphysics to mark the asymmetry between manifestation and source (shă/shams). It parallels Shii theosophical language in later *ḥikma* (e.g., Mull={a} Ṣadr={a}) distinguishing contingent “lights” from the Necessary Light.

[24] Echoes the principle that the effect (mal={u}l) cannot exceed its cause (illa). In Sufi terms, the servant cannot “outrun” the divine origin; in Shii kal={a}m and philosophy, it resonates with causal priority and the impossibility of the contingent transcending its mabda.

[25] A rebuke found in versions of the Kumayl report: the Imam redirects the seeker from conceptual curiosity to spiritual preparedness. Comparable to Sufi pedagogical “repulses” (zajr) in manuals like Qushayr={i}’s *Ris={a}la*, where the shaykh blocks premature claims to marifa.

[26] Arabic: maq={a}m al-ithnayn={i}ya (duality). In Sufi metaphysics, duality marks persistence of “I/Thou” before fan={a}and tawḥ={i}d al-shuh={u}d. In Shii irf={a}n, it signals remaining nafs={a}niyya that veils the Imam’s disclosure of ḥaq={i}qa.

[27] Quran 50:16 is invoked to deny spatial separation: divine proximity is immediate, so “association” (shirk) is the illusion of otherness. Sufi commentators read it as nearness by knowledge and presence; Shii exegetes often connect such nearness to wil={a}ya as the locus of divine guidance.

[28] “Association” renders shirk; the inward recognition of shirk in the nafs is a common Sufi topos (mushahadat al-nafs) and in Shi’i ethics (muhasabat al-nafs). Compare the Kumayl tradition’s movement from confession of incapacity to unveiling, and the Imams’ emphasis on purifying tawhid from subtle shirk.

[29] “Confidant of your secret” echoes the Shi’i motif of the Imam as sahib al-sirr (bearer of the divine secret) and the graded disclosure of esoteric knowledge (sirr, sirr al-sirr). In Sufi usage, sirr denotes the innermost faculty receptive to tajalli; cf. discussions of sirr in early manuals and later Akbarian psychology.

from me only trickles upon you"[31] that your reality, O Kumayl, is a trickle from the station of the Prophets^["Station of the Prophets" evokes the hierarchy of maqamat: prophetic reality as the source of saintly/initiatic shares.

Sufi literature often speaks of inheriting from the prophets (waratha) and of the Muhammadan Reality. Shi'i sources similarly present the Imams as inheritors of prophetic knowledge and light, with companions receiving only partial shares.], and they are what overflows from me. In other words, the station of your reality about which you ask is a trickle of what overflows from his reality. When Kumayl heard the servant's question, he established himself in the station of servitude[32] and became humble before his master, saying "Would one such as you disappoint a seeker?"

Then the veils were rent and he became capable of beholding the lights of the beauty of His reality, which was His manifestation of it through it at the beginning of its existence through His words "O fire, be coolness and peace!"[33] He said: "The removal of the veils of glory without indication," O Kumayl, so remove all veils for God created them. Their Creator is established in the ocean of glory without indication to me or to thee, for indications are among the veils, and veils are pure coverings and absolute obscurity.

They represent the station of names and attributes, while glory is the station of the Named One and the negation of attributes manifests His divinity[34]. Know that Truth is eternal and contingent beings are created. Truth is too exalted to descend to the realm of possibility, and possibility is prevented from ascending to eternity.

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[30] The "fire of love" (nar al-mahabba) is a standard Sufi image (shawq/ishq consuming the lover) and here is framed as pedagogical mercy: disclosure is moderated lest love be quenched. Shi'i devotional literature likewise treats mahabba/walaya as a burning attachment sustained by the Imam's lutf (gentleness).

[31] The "overflow/trickle" (fayd/rashh) idiom recalls Neoplatonic emanation as adapted in Islamic philosophy and Akbarian metaphysics: higher realities "overflow" while recipients take only a "sprinkling." In Shi'i imamology, the Imam mediates divine knowledge/light to companions by measure, paralleling graded fayd through the Prophet and the awsiyaʾ.

[32] Maqam al-ubudiyya is central in both traditions: Sufis treat it as the summit of realization (ubudiyya preceding rububiyya in witnessing), while Shi'i hadith and du'a (including the Kumayl supplication's tone) stress humility and neediness (iftiqar) as the condition for receiving ma'rifa and kashf.

[33] Allusion to Qurʾan 21:69 (Ibrahim). Mystically, "fire" becomes the ordeal of love or the burning of the nafs, transformed into salama by divine tajalli. Sufi commentaries read it as the cooling of passions under tawhid; Shi'i exegesis often links it to divine protection of the friend (wali) amid trial.

[34] This is apophatic theology: tanzih via nafy al-sifat. In Shi'i kalam and hadith, God is known by negating likeness and limiting attributes; in Sufism (especially Akbarian), the Names/Attributes are veils relative to the Essence (al-dhat), and "negation" marks the passage from ta'ayyunat to sheer ahadiyya.

Therefore, divine wisdom requires that the Eternal Truth describe Himself to creation[35] so that creation may know its Creator and contingent beings may reach their ultimate purpose through His eternal outpouring. This description is created[36], incomparable to any description, and an identity to which nothing can be likened.

This description is the reality of the servant—whoever knows it knows his Lord[37], as indicated by the Imam: I knew Thee through Thee[38], Thou guided me to Thee and called me to Thee. Were it not for Thee, I would not have known what Thou art.' And he said: Know God through God^["Know God through God" (i'rifu'Llah bi'Llah) resonates with Shi'i epistemology: God is known by His own self-disclosure, not by analogy.

Compare apophatic passages in Nahj al-Balagha and al-Saduq's al-Tawhid. Sufi analogues include the principle that ma'rifa is a divine gift, not acquired by discursive proof alone.].' This is the description expressed in some stations as the heart[39], and this description is the Lordship which is the essence of servitude and the sign which God showed in the horizons and within souls[40] until it becomes clear to creation that He is the Truth.

Look with the eye of thy heart: thy reality is the Lordship of thy Lord for thee through thee—thou art He and He is thou, except that thou art thou and He is He. He has a station of unity, His identity is pure

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[35] On divine self-disclosure (tajalli) and self-description (wasf) as a created "relation" enabling knowledge: compare Ibn Arabi's doctrine of the divine names manifesting in creation (Fusus al-Hikam; Futuhat) and Shi'i discussions of knowing God via His signs (ayat) and names (e.g., al-Kulayni, al-Kafi, Kitab al-Tawhid).

[36] The Arabic states "this description is created" (wasf makhluq): a classic apophatic safeguard akin to Shi'i kalam on the createdness of divine "attributes of act" (sifat al-fi'l) and to Sufi cautions that theophanies are contingent forms, not the divine Essence (dhat) itself (cf. al-Qushayri, Risala; Ibn Arabi on tajalli).

[37] Echoes the widely cited maxim "whoever knows himself knows his Lord" (man arafa nafsahu…): prominent in Sufi adab and metaphysics (al-Ghazali; Ibn Arabi) and also invoked in Shi'i ethical and gnostic compilations, though its hadith status is debated; here tied to the servant's "reality" (haqiqat al-abd).

[38] A Shi'i devotional topos: ma'rifa by God through God (araftuka bika). Compare Imam Ali's reported prayers and the Imams' teachings on ma'rifat Allah bi'Llah (e.g., al-Saduq, al-Tawhid; al-Kafi, Kitab al-Hujja). In Sufism, parallels appear in Junayd's emphasis on divine initiative in gnosis.

[39] Arabic specifies "in some maqamat as the fuʾad" (inner heart). In Sufi psychology, fuʾad is a subtler faculty than qalb, locus of witnessing (mushahada) (cf. al-Tirmidhi, Khatm al-Awliya; al-Qushayri). Shi'i irfan likewise uses "heart" as the organ of certainty (yaqin) and unveiling (kashf).

[40] Alludes to Qurʾan 41:53 ("We shall show them Our signs in the horizons and in themselves…"). Both Sufi tafsir (e.g., al-Sulami, Haqaʾiq al-Tafsir) and Shi'i exegesis read this as an itinerary from cosmic signs to inner self-knowledge culminating in recognition of al-Haqq (the Real/Truth).

essence[41]—no mention, no indication, no expression of this station except through inability, and this is the perfection of unity through negation of attributes and Lordship, which when there is no object of Lordship has no mention, no encompassing, no manifestation. Through this awareness He knew Himself, detached from names, attributes and deeds, and through this awareness is unveiled through reasoning the knowledge of names, attributes and deeds from God, glorified be He.

Part 2: "Verily, God, exalted be He, is manifested unto…"

Verily, God, exalted be He, is manifested unto thee through thee[42], observeth thee through thee, and encompasseth thee through thee[43]. This is thy highest Paradise^["Highest Paradise" corresponds to the Arabic "jannatuka al-a'la," evoking Qurʾanic al-Firdaws/al-Illiyyun and the Sufi interiorization of paradise as a state of proximity (qurb) rather than a locale.

Shi'i devotional texts likewise speak of the "paradise" of ma'rifa (gnosis) and wilaya.] and thine utmost sanctuary—the Furthest Mosque[44]—for the denizens of the Garden of Ridvan[45] possess naught save the Remembrance of God, the Most Great[46], and the Name of God, the Most Mighty, the Most Bountiful.

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[41] The "station of unity" and "pure essence" (dhat al-buht) with no mention or indication evokes radical tanzih: the Essence beyond names and attributes. Compare Shi'i apophatic theology (Nahj al-Balagha; al-Saduq, al-Tawhid) and Sufi formulations of the "hidden treasure" and the unknowability of the Dhat (Ibn ʿArabi; al-Jili).

[42] The triad "manifested/observeth/encompasseth … through thee" echoes Sufi formulations of divine self-disclosure (tajalli) in the servant, especially Ibn Arabi's doctrine of the Perfect Man (al-insan al-kamil) as the locus of manifestation (mazhar). In Shi'i theosophy it resonates with the Imam as the mirror of the divine Names.

[43] "Encompasseth" recalls Qurʾanic "He encompasses all things" (ahata bi-kulli shayʾ) and the hadith "I was a hidden treasure…" often cited in Sufi metaphysics to ground tajalli. The Arabic uses "muhit laka bika," stressing immanence without collapsing transcendence.

[44] Identifying the "utmost sanctuary" with "the Furthest Mosque" (al-masjid al-aqsa) re-reads the Mi'raj topography inwardly, as in Sufi commentaries where the Aqsa becomes the heart's farthest limit. Shi'i Mi'raj traditions also treat the Prophet's ascent as unveiling stations of walaya and divine Names.

[45] "Garden of Ridvan" (jannat al-ridwan) alludes to Qurʾan 9:72 ("God's good-pleasure is greater"). In Sufi usage, rida (contentment) is a maqam beyond desire for reward. Shi'i ethics similarly ranks rida among the highest virtues, linked to acceptance of divine decree (qadaʾ).

[46] The Arabic "dhikr Allah al-a'zam" and "ism Allah al-a'azz al-akram" recall Sufi discussions of dhikr as the sole "provision" of the realized, and Shi'i traditions on al-ism al-a'zam (the Greatest Name) associated with the prophets and, in Imamology, with the Imams' inherited knowledge.

This station may not be indicated by indication[47]: in the perfection of its nearness it is far, and in the perfection of its farness it is near. No veils conceal it. He is above all things—hidden by the mystery, veiled by the secret, secreted within the secret—and naught availeth for the knowledge of Him but the secret[48].

Unto this point alludeth the report from Ali—upon him be peace—addressed to Kumayl[49]: "A soul of the kingdom (nafs malakutiyyah)[50], endowed with a divine potency (quwwah lahutiyyah)^["Lahut" (divinity) as a level beyond malakut is widely used in Sufi and Shi'ite gnosis to denote the divine aspect manifest in the Perfect Human.

Compare the Sufi schema of lahut/jabarut/malakut/nasut and Shi'ite discussions of the Imam's "divine" authority (wilayah) as a theophanic potency.], a simple essence, living by its very self; its root is the Intellect (al-aql)[51]. From the Dawn of Pre-Eternity[52] it took its beginning, by it it summoneth, unto it it pointeth, and unto it doth it return when perfected and made like unto its source.

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[47] "No indication" (la yushar ilayha bi'l-ishara) is a classic apophatic trope: the Real is beyond pointing, concept, or delimitation. Compare Junayd's sobriety and Ibn ʿArabi's insistence that the Essence (dhat) is unknowable. Shi'i kalam likewise denies grasping God's essence, affirming knowledge through Names/Attributes.

[48] The repeated "secret" (sirr) matches the Arabic "al-mustatir bi'l-sirr… al-mustasir… la yufid… illa'l-sirr." In Sufi psychology, sirr is the innermost subtle faculty (latifa) where gnosis occurs. In Shi'i esotericism, sirr marks the batin of walaya and the Imam's guarded knowledge.

[49] The passage is framed as part of the Hadith of Kumayl (Kumayl b. Ziyad's esoteric dialogue with Imam Ali). Shi'ite sources preserve multiple recensions of this report; later Akhbari and Shaykhi/Babi authors often cite it for doctrines of walayah and the hierarchy of being.

[50] The triadic cosmology of nasut–malakut–jabarut is common in Islamic Neoplatonism and Sufi metaphysics (e.g., al-Ghazali, Ibn Arabi, and later Illuminationist and Shi'ite theosophers). Here "nafs malakutiyyah" signals an intermediate, imaginal/angelic soul mediating between sensible and intelligible realms.

[51] The primacy of al-aql recalls the "First Intellect" of falsafah and Ishraqi thought, and also Shi'ite hadith on the creation of aql (e.g., traditions in al-Kulayni's al-Kafi, Kitab al-Aql wa'l-Jahl). The Bab's commentary aligns the soul's origin with the intelligible principle.

[52] "Subh al-azal" (Dawn of Pre-Eternity) evokes Sufi imagery of the primordial "morning" of manifestation and the Shi'ite notion of the pre-temporal covenant (mithaq/alast). It also resonates with Illuminationist symbolism of light's first dawning from the intelligible realm.

From it have beings come forth, and unto it do they return in consummation." [Report attributed to Ali for Kumayl] It is the Most Exalted Self of God, the Tree of Tuba[53], the Lote-Tree of the Extremity (Sidrat al-Muntaha)[54], and the Garden of Refuge (Jannat al-Maʾwa).

Whoso knoweth it shall never be wretched; whoso is ignorant of it shall stray and be undone. He that attaineth unto Majesty shall not be miserable; but he that is drowned in the Ocean of the Effulgences (as-Subuhat)[55] and thereby veiled from the encounter with the Reality, that one wandereth and is astray.

These intimations pertain to the unveiling of the "Effulgences,"[56] and these indications are for the attainment unto "Majesty."[57] When, therefore, the lights of Beauty are unveiled^["Lights of Beauty" (anwar al-jamal) evokes tajalli al-jamal in Sufi manuals: theophany as light unveiling.

In Shi'i theosophy, recognition (ma'rifa) is tied to divine Names and Attributes; the Bab frames self-unveiling as the condition for ma'rifat al-Rabb, resonant with the maxim "who knows himself knows his Lord."] from thyself, thou wilt recognize thy Lord, Possessor of Majesty and Bounty.[58] Another meaning:

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[53] Tuba is a paradisal tree in Qur'anic and hadith lore (cf. Q 13:29 and related reports). In Shi'ite exegesis it is often linked to the Prophet's household and the Imam's wilayah; in Sufi readings it symbolizes the locus of felicity and the branching of divine gifts in the Garden.

[54] Sidrat al-Muntaha (Q 53:14–18) marks the boundary of created knowledge in the Mi'raj narrative. Sufi commentators treat it as the limit of angelic ascent and discursive cognition; Shi'ite theosophy often associates it with the Muhammadan Reality and the Imam as the supreme barzakh of divine disclosure.

[55] "Subuhat" (effulgences/brightnesses) recalls the famous hadith: "God has seventy veils of light and darkness; were He to remove them, the splendors (subuhat) of His Face would burn all." Sufi manuals use it for overwhelming tajalli; Shi'ite gnostics warn of veiling by lights as well as by darkness.

[56] "Effulgences" renders subuhat (cf. hadith: "God has seventy veils of light and darkness; were He to remove them, the splendors (subuhat) of His Face would burn…"). The Bab reads kashf al-subuhat as unveiling luminous veils, a theme shared by Sufi discussions of hujub/veils and tajalli.

[57] The pairing of Beauty (jamal) and Majesty (jalal) is a standard Sufi polarity (e.g., Ibn Arabi on jalal/jamal as modes of divine self-disclosure). Here the Arabic contrasts "isharat" (allusive indications) with direct arrival at jalal, echoing the Sufi movement from sign (dalil/ishara) to witnessing (mushahada).

[58] Alludes to Qurʾan 55:27, "Dhu'l-Jalal wa'l-Ikram" (Possessor of Majesty and Bounty). Shi'i devotional literature frequently invokes this divine epithet in duʿaʾ; the Bab links it to experiential unveiling, aligning Qurʾanic naming with mystical recognition (ma'rifa) rather than discursive proof.

the unveiling of the Effulgences is the entering of the City—Majesty—[59] without "indication,"^[Arabic: min ghayr ishara—without allusive pointing.

In Sufi epistemology, ishara marks symbolic teaching for novices, while the realized know by dhawq (tasting) and iyan (direct seeing). The Bab's "without indication" implies immediacy: jalal is accessed when signs fall away.] that is, when its people are heedless.[60] Another meaning: thy very reality is Majesty—it is the Face of thy Lord[61]—but not a "facedness" that is pointed to.

In sum: Kumayl could not bear the state[62]. Either he rose and sought a further epiphany[63], or he was confounded^["Confounded" corresponds to hayra (perplexity), a classic station in Sufi manuals (maqam al-hayra) and in Akbarian thought as the apex of knowing God through the collapse of conceptual determination.

Shi'i mystical commentaries likewise treat hayra as the mind's arrest before the Imam's unveiled realities and the divine Names.] and knew not how to speak. He said, "Increase me in exposition[64]." He replied:

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[59] "City" recalls the Shi'i/Prophetic topos "I am the City of Knowledge and Ali is its Gate," widely used in imamological and Sufi chains alike. The Bab re-reads "entering the city" as entry into jalal itself, suggesting an initiatic passage from mediated knowledge to direct encounter with divine majesty.

[60] Arabic: hin ghaflat ahliha. "Heedlessness" (ghafla) is a key Sufi diagnosis of the unawakened; entry "when its people are heedless" suggests an esoteric passage unnoticed by the exoteric majority. Shi'i esotericism similarly contrasts the elite of walaya with the heedless public (amma).

[61] "Face" (wajh) evokes Qurʾan 28:88 ("everything perishes save His Face") and 55:27. In Shi'i hadith, the Imams are called "the Face of God" (wajh Allah) by which He is approached; Sufi metaphysics also treats the "Face" as the locus of tajalli. The Bab denies a spatially pointable "facedness."

[62] Kumayl b. Ziyad is the addressee of the celebrated Shi'i "Hadith of Kumayl," often read as an initiatic disclosure from Imam Ali. The motif of incapacity to "bear the state" parallels Sufi discussions of tahammul al-hal (enduring spiritual states) and the danger of disclosure beyond one's preparedness.

[63] "Epiphany" renders tajalli (here: tajalliyan akhar). Tajalli is central in Sufi metaphysics (e.g., Ibn Arabi's doctrine of perpetual self-disclosure, tajaddud al-tajalli) and in Shi'i theosophy where divine manifestation is mediated through the Imam's walaya. The alternation of ascent and renewed disclosure evokes graded unveilings (kashf) rather than a single vision.

[64] The request "zidni bayanan" echoes Qurʾanic and devotional idioms of seeking ziyada (increase) in knowledge and certainty. In Shi'i hadith culture, it also reflects adab toward the Imam as the locus of bayan (authoritative elucidation). Sufi pedagogy similarly frames the disciple's demand for bayan as a controlled unveiling under a shaykh's supervision.

“The effacement of the imagined (mahw al-mawhum)[65]—that is, the effulgences^[”Effulgences” glosses subuhat (often: luminous splendors/veils).

In Sufi literature, subuhat can denote dazzling lights that both reveal and veil, recalling the hadith of God’s “veil of light” (hijab al-nur). Shi’i gnostic texts likewise speak of luminous veils surrounding the divine presence and the Imam’s light (nur).]—and the soberness of the known (sahw al-ma’lum)[66]—that is, Majesty^[“Majesty” renders jalal, commonly paired with jamal (beauty) in Sufi theologies of the Names. The passage’s identification of sahw with jalal suggests a transition from luminous “splendors” to awe-inspiring divine rigor.

Shi’i devotional and philosophical traditions likewise emphasize jalal in relation to divine transcendence and the Imam’s commanding authority (hayba).].” The Reality is one, though expressions—however many in words—are one in meaning, understood only by the people of hearts.

Wherefore Kumayl, after explanation and after saying “Increase me,”[67] found it not and attained not that which he sought. He said, “Increase me in exposition.” He replied: “To rend the veil[68] through the ascendancy of the secret.”

This is the meaning of the former and the latter: “He hath known it who hath known it[69], and he hath ignored it who hath ignored it.” Thereupon Kumayl, with the tongue of secrecy, uttered, “Is there yet more?”[70] and with speech said, “Increase me in exposition.”

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[65] Mahw (effacement) is a technical Sufi term paired with ithbat (affirmation) and contrasted with sahw (sobriety). Here it targets mawhum (the merely imagined), i.e., the mind’s projections. The move resembles Shi’i apophatic theology (tanzih) that negates anthropomorphic imaginings, and Sufi “fanaʾ of attributes” as the erasure of conceptual idols.

[66] Sahw (sobriety) is classically opposed to sukr (intoxication) in Sufism (e.g., Junayd’s “sober” path). “Known” (ma’lum) suggests stabilized ma’rifa after the passing of dazzling subuhat. In Shi’i esotericism, this resonates with returning from unveiling to measured articulation (bayan) under the Imam’s guidance.

[67] The request for ziyadah (“increase”) echoes the Kumayl/Khidr motif of seeking further disclosure beyond initial bayan. In Shi’ite transmission, the Hadith of Kumayl is linked to Imam Ali’s esoteric instruction; in Sufi adab, it parallels the murid’s repeated talab for mazid (cf. Q 50:30 “hal min mazid”).

[68] “Rending the veil” (hatk al-sitr) is a standard Sufi image for kashf/unveiling: the removal of hijab by overpowering sirr (“secret”). Compare al-Qushayri’s Risalah on sirr and kashf, and Ibn Arabi’s Futuhat on hijab as a function of perception rather than distance from God.

[69] This aphoristic formula (“’arafaha man arafaha…”) is characteristic of Shi’ite hadith style about ma’rifah: recognition is self-authenticating, while denial stems from incapacity. It recalls Imam Ali’s and Imam al-Sadiq’s dicta on ma’rifat Allah as a light cast into the heart, also resonant with Sufi “dhawq” (tasting) as non-discursive certainty.

He answered: “The attraction of Oneness (al-ahadiyyah)[71] unto the attribute of Unification (at-tawhid)[72]. O Kumayl! Oneness draweth thee unto the unity; for thy witnessing by God’ (bi’Llah)^[”Bi’Llah” signals the Sufi triad: bi’Llah / li’Llah / ma’a’Llah, and the station of fana’ and baqa’ where acts and perception are “through God.”

Shi’ite sources similarly speak of seeing “with God’s light” (nur Allah) and of the Imam as the locus of divine guidance enabling such witnessing.] unveileth the veils and coverings.” In the first, Reality is Majesty[73]; in the second, it is the Known; in the third, it is the Secret; in the fourth, it is the Oneness.

When the questioner had not yet attained, he said, “Increase me in exposition.” He replied: “A light that hath dawned from the Dawn of Pre-Eternity; its traces gleam upon the frames of unity.” (That is, he desired Kumayl to know that the stations of theophany of act and its effects are from the eternal dawn; the Sun of pre-eternity is Muhammad; “its indication” pointeth to the two Hasans; “it shone forth” pointeth to the Imams; and “the light” unto Fatimah. The “frames of unity” are the Prophets and the successors; its “effects” are their station and the station of the Shi’ah.) Then, after this, he sought increase and said, “Increase me in exposition.” He replied: “Extinguish the lamp, for the dawn hath risen.”

He intended: O Kumayl! Extinguish the small lamp by which thou walkest in the darknesses of intellect, soul and spirit, now that the heart—the dawn—hath broken for thee. And he pointed to a true meaning in this world: “O Kumayl! Extinguish the lamp; I am the dawn. Speak not, but keep silence, for I desire to pray.” Know the indications, and be assured that this station abideth in thine absence and thy presence; it sufficeth thee—or “Is it not sufficient that thy Lord is witness over all things?” (Qur’an 41:53). And thou, under His all-seeing eye, hast looked unto Him, and He looketh upon thee by means of thee. Naught is nearer unto thee than thy very reality. This station hath neither beginning nor end; “He is the First and

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[70] “Hal min mazid?” explicitly evokes Q 50:30, often read by Sufis as the soul’s infinite receptivity to divine tajalli. The Arabic gloss (“with the tongue of secrecy”) aligns the Qur’anic “more” with sirr rather than ordinary speech, a move common in Ishari tafsir and in Shi’ite esoteric hermeneutics (ta’wil).

[71] Ahadiyyah vs. wahidiyyah is a classic Sufi metaphysical distinction (notably in Ibn Arabi and later Akbarian tradition): ahadiyyah denotes absolute non-relational unity beyond attributes, while wahidiyyah concerns unity as manifest in names/attributes. The passage’s “attraction” (jadhb) frames the ascent from tawhid of discourse to tawhid of witnessing.

[72] Tawhid here is not merely doctrinal affirmation but experiential unification. Sufi manuals distinguish tawhid al-ammah (verbal) from tawhid al-khawass (realization). In Shi’ite kalam and hadith, tawhid is likewise tied to negating tashbih and affirming tanzih, while the Imams’ teachings often present tawhid as inseparable from ma’rifah and wilayah.

[73] The fourfold mapping (Majesty, Known, Secret, Oneness) resembles Sufi gradations of disclosure: jalal (majesty) and ma’lum (the known) as epistemic poles, sirr as the interior locus, and ahadiyyah as the apex. Comparable schemata appear in discussions of lata’if (qalb, sirr, khafi, akhfa) and in Shi’ite esoteric tiers of ilm and ma’rifah.

the Last, the Manifest and the Hidden" (Qur'an 57:3). It is the loftiest of thy stations and the most exalted of thy degrees.

This Reality is a originated, created sign—like thy saying, "There is no God but God," for it pointeth to the oneness of God; even so is thy reality, and there is no difference whatsoever between them. Know it, therefore, according to its measure, and conceal it from all save its people. Verily we are God's, and unto Him shall we return.

BB00183

In the Name of God, the Most Compassionate, the Most Merciful

Blessed is He Who hath made this day a festival day that endureth forever. At the midnight hour the sun entereth the sign of Aries. The sun of creation hath dawned at the beginning of days in perfect balance. On the night when the two spheres met, a sun from the All-Hearing joined with Gemini.

Blessed then be the All-Merciful among you, O ye people of patience that endure forever. From His trusted ones upon you is bestowed the true peace in the mystery of majesty made lawful. And from the scattered particles among you, O people of sorrow, from weariness—from Him descend the divine fragrances at every moment like abundant rain.

From Me to you, O people of thankfulness, beyond compare in similitude—verily God will reward you with the most excellent thanks on the Day of Judgment as a bounty. The spheres have revolved with the new creation upon the mention of the Ancient One in majesty. And on that day some of the believers shall meet the people in beauty.

O Lord! How beautiful is that which hath come between me and those who seek me! All enter and some depart, and the gate was in weariness. The Festival of the New Creation—and Thou, O my Lord, honor Thy servants with new garments. Make their inner mysteries sweet with Thy remembrance, O Thou the Ever-Bountiful!

The most glorious of garments was a garment of new robes. My inner being is sweet through my knowledge of Thy love for me, which endureth forever through Thy might. The fragrance in the vial is twofold, and I am not ashamed. For from the right unto the right, and the meaning of the right is not capable of receiving. My excuse apart from the right and its manifest mystery would be greater than theirs due to helplessness at the appointed time.

Verily Thy riches, O Lord, suffice them, and Thou art forever the Lord of Bounty. If Thou wouldst teach me the unseen, I would multiply blessings in hope. O Lord! Bless Thy day for those who circle round Thy majesty forever. Thou art nearer to the believers than their own selves, though today all are in ignorance. Thy grace forever through Thy bounty continueth to be bestowed. Thy generosity in every matter, by Thy command, descendeth unceasingly.

In the Name of God, the Most Compassionate, the Most Merciful

Peace be upon Muhammad and the Family of God from God, then peace be upon God, exalted be His glory, from Muhammad and the Family of God, then peace from creation upon the Presence of Creation, then peace from the Gate of Creation unto the glory of detachment, then peace once in the horizon of Sinai upon the Hidden Name, Ahmad, may God's peace be upon him, then in the inscribed Book upon the Word of Revelation, Kazim, may God's peace be upon him, then peace from the Light unto the Light, the Hidden Secret and the Manifest Symbol, dawning from the horizon of Sinai with the countenance of the Manifest One, rising in the dome of time with the face of Revelation, speaking on Mount Hadith of the Ever-Living, the All-Forgiving, and manifesting above the Ark of Testimony with clouds of light, veiled from the gaze of the jealous ones by the people of joy—a peace that bestoweth peace upon the people of joy and inflicteth punishment upon the people of evil from the Ancient, Praised One, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Today, the Day of Festival, when the two celestial bodies met by God's leave, there came unto me in the night a letter from him to whom I had previously sent My letter. Its verses did not sadden Me, but today, as it was a festival for non-Arabs, I read thy letter and its verses saddened Me, for thou wert troubled regarding thy religion. Art thou unlettered that thou readest not the Book of God, or dost thou, like Abraham, seek assurance for thy heart?

O questioner! I consider no man learned unless he seeth himself in Paradise, reclining upon couches due to his certitude in God's religion, for My Cause is more evident than the sun at its zenith, and My proof is a verse which all people have read. Through that proof, were I to do all that I desire, I would be in the right, and none would have any proof against Me. All contradictions, traditions and doubts are nullified before all people by My proof, and none may question My judgment with "why" or "how." Indeed, the proof is nullified only when one naturally produces its like.

Read the Book We have sent down of nine hundred decisive verses, and traverse the east and west of the earth—if thou seest or hearest from anyone the like of one verse, then turn back from My Cause and seek what thou willest. Otherwise, God's conclusive proof is upon thee, just as the truth hath ever been conclusive through it. This is a proof none among God's creation can withstand. The balance that distinguisheth truth from falsehood is pure nature, power in all things, and strength over whatsoever He willeth. If thou seest anyone with such attributes, then be certain the proof is nullified; otherwise, the proof of My truth remaineth until the Day of Resurrection, and God will render void the work of the corrupt ones in that Hour. It is a proof that nothing in the heavens and earth can equal.

I see all people in the shadow of the fire save the few who are certain of God's signs, follow God's command, strive in God's path, nullify the works of devils, and fear not in God's religion any mighty one. Those who deny God's Cause are obliged to produce a book like unto My Book. If they do so—and they shall never do so—they were in error; and if they do not—and they shall never do so—yet still deny God's Cause, such is their portion of unbelief, lower than Pharaoh's portion of ignorance, for when he wished to reject his Lord's command, he resorted to sorcery, while these people bring forth nothing and yet deny God's Cause, thinking it an easy matter.

Nay, by my Lord! It is a sign of truth inherent in human nature that proclaims all the prescribed verses, and by this proof the deeds of the masses are rendered null through clear evidence. Woe, then woe unto

those who know not God's purpose and follow their own desires, thinking I sought the station of the divines in independent judgment [ijtihad] and legal decree [fatwa]. Nay, by God! It is incumbent upon all the learned of the earth to believe in God's religion according to what was revealed to mankind in the Book, and to recite at death the prayer of belief, and if they do not utter at their final breath these words of justice:

> "I bear witness that Ali is the servant, the remnant of God"

in every preserved tablet, they shall not escape the bounds of judgment and shall enter into an ocean of sorrow. Whosoever wishes may accept, and whosoever wishes may turn away. God and His loved ones are independent of all things.

As for what you asked about Abraham's vision, peace be upon him, of the kingdom of the heavens, and how the Imam removed the veil from the eye of the beholder of the kingdom of the heavens and earth—this is truth, for the heavens are folded in His right hand and the earth entirely in His grasp, and from this matter there is no escape. Verily the station of one who has seen the kingdom of the heavens and earth is too great not to see the kingdom of the earth, for Abraham, peace be upon him, saw the kingdom of the heavens multiple times and therein witnessed the entire kingdom of the earth. When others saw the kingdom of the heavens, due to their weak vision they could not witness the kingdom of the earth within the kingdom of the heavens, and thus did their Master remove the veil in the earth to its kingdom.

That which God will reveal to the Qa'im, peace be upon him, could not possibly be revealed to anyone before his appearance. Among these are verses which God has made the sword of His proof against all enemies. Of the eight letters of the Greatest Name, four are in the air and God will soon reveal them to His Proof after his appearance. The four that have descended are the words of Unity, Prophethood, Guardianship and Following. Today its fourth is the name of its third, and the name of its third comes before its second, and God will not accept any deed from anyone except through knowledge of Him.

As for what you asked about how the subject can be more knowledgeable than the ruler—yes, the followers are the final cause in creation while the three elevated ones precede them in legislation, and in all worlds this is one command. O Lord, inspire him with what I have fallen short in answering, and reveal to him what I have concealed in my response, for every matter has its appointed time. Keep God's Cause concealed and draw not near to discord, for I am God's servant and I say:

> "God suffices me, and there is no god but He; in Him do I trust, and He is the Lord of the Mighty Throne."

And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00219: Bayan dar Jabr wa Tafwid (fi bayan-i-mas'alati'l-Qadar)

God, exalted be He, saith: "Who hath created and balanced all things, and Who hath fixed their destinies and guided them." And the Truthful One [Imam Ja'far as-Sadiq] hath said: "There is neither compulsion nor delegation, but rather a position between the two positions." Know thou that regarding this question,

God hath veiled its knowledge from minds, souls and spirits, and the Imam hath withheld from the servants its understanding, for when he was asked about it, he said: “It is a deep ocean—enter it not.” And when asked a second time, he said: “It is a dark path—traverse it not.” And when asked a third time, he said: “It is God’s secret—unveil it not.”

The Imam hath said:

> “There is neither compulsion nor predestination, but rather a position between them vaster than what lieth between heaven and earth. None knoweth it save the Knower, or one whom the Knower hath taught. This is specifically for the people of inner vision.”

For minds with their keenest perception, thoughts with their deepest contemplation, and vision with its most subtle observation and movement, have not comprehended things in their limitations. Indeed, the philosophers and most of the learned have confessed their inability, and all who have explained this matter have not escaped either compulsion or delegation, save a few who have entered through the gate of the heart.

That station is devoid of limitations and analogies, sanctified beyond change or suspension, removed from the bounds of contingency, severed from all names and attributes—an impenetrable mystery that none in the realm of multiplicities can comprehend. It is veiled without a veil and concealed without a covering, hidden from all the worlds by the exaltation of its glory, yet most manifest beyond all things through the majesty of its station. For destiny is the essence of possibility, and it is vaster than what lieth between the heaven of receptivities and the earth of acceptances. All things move within it yet perceive it not, for it is hidden by the intensity of its manifestation and concealed by the greatness of its light.

None discovereth it save one who hath rent asunder the veils of light and reached the source of grandeur. Then doth he behold things through the eye of God as they truly are, and the truth of the tradition becometh manifest:

> “None knoweth it save through the might of the Eternal and the greatness of the Light.”

The reality of the Eternal is the Identity of God, the One, the All-Compelling.

After what I have intimated to thee concerning the knowledge of the heart, know that God alone is pre-existent; naught existed with Him in pre-existence. He originated Will, which is the Point of contingency, from nothing, through the very act of origination. When He created His creation through volition—and volition accompanieth existence, for the question “Am I not your Lord?” applieth only to one possessed of choice, and the question itself is the answer—and since the Creator is possessed of choice and is just, His creation must needs be through volition. When creation was created, its Creator created it according to what it would be, for God, before their existence, knew their choices and created them in the form they would assume as a recompense for their qualities. “And thy Lord is not unjust to His servants,” for His knowledge of things before their existence is like His knowledge after their existence, and He giveth every possessor of right his right in the station of their possibilities and their coming into being.

Nothing can don the garment of existence save through choice in genesis and law, for the cause of choice is choice itself. This is evident to one whose heart's eye God hath opened and who seeth all things through the eye of God and by what all things are for things. For He, glorified be He, is the Self-Sufficient Who wrongeth not, while the contingent being is absolute poverty that sufficeth not. In all its states of realities, attributes and deeds, it needeth its Creator as it needed Him at the beginning of its existence. God, glorified be He, created it and sustained it in what it is through what it is as it is, in its realities, attributes and accidents.

"And God is not unjust to His servants" and hath not dealt with them but through their free will, and He is the Just, the Most Exalted. When philosophers pondered this with their minds, they were cut off from understanding it and found no path for themselves except through fixed essences or predestination. This was because they did not learn from the Manifestations of infallibility, but relied on what they grasped through their own intellects, not realizing that if their intellects were true intellects and not merely nominal ones, they would have attained a station wherein if they had approached even a fingertip closer, they would have been consumed by fire. As a result, they unwittingly placed themselves under the tree of polytheism.

Know that the condition of things in the realm of possibility is like their condition in the realm of creation, such that when they are asked, they respond, and the question itself is the answer according to their reality. Thus whoever said "yea" became of the people of Paradise, and whoever said "nay" became of the people of the Fire. In this station, words fall short of explanation, and the most perfect expression is "There is no power nor strength except through God, the Exalted, the Great." So drink from this water, recognize its value, and conceal it except from its people, for in it is sufficiency for one who has understanding and insight.

Remember with beautiful remembrance in your heart until you see nothing except by choice. Indeed, the station of your reality, which has no limitation in any place, were you to connect with it, is your highest Paradise, your furthest Mosque, your days of martyrdom and meeting with your Lord, your Kaaba, your qiblih, your sacred monument, your aspiration, your days of honor after casting off the veils of glory, your day of pilgrimage, your circumambulation around your own essence in seven circuits through your seven ranks, the station of your existence through God and your annihilation in God, the station of your manifest existence through yourself, the station of your love, your beloved and your loved one, the station of the unity of your word with the Word of your Creator, the station of your establishment upon the throne with all your names, attributes, signs and tokens, the giving of every right its due, the station of your firstness and lastness—for you are the first of the first in names and attributes and the last of the last, the first without beginning and the last without end, the station where your outward manifestation is identical with your inward reality and your inward reality is identical with your outward manifestation, the station of the necessity of your existence for all beneath you from among the other manifestations of your names and the dawning-places of your attributes and signs, and the station of your identity where you are He and He is you, except that He is He and you are you.

When you reach this station, what Ali said to Kumayl ibn Ziyad when asked about Reality becomes manifest to you: "That which overflows from me trickles upon you." So know the greatness of your

Master, the Pure Family of God. When you reach this station and the veils are removed, your essence becomes purely and sincerely devoted to God the Most High. Your reality should enter the place where His glory overflows, in the shadow of those days. When the Qa'im (may God hasten his appearance) appears, this station will be manifested to his followers, though only a few of them will remain, and that is the station of the complete servitude of the Shi'ih to the Imam. And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00237: Fi Tafsir-i-Kalimiy-i-Aqul (Commentary on a statement of Siyyid Kazim)

In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful

Our Master Ali, upon him be peace, said in the Sermon of Tutunjiyyih—upon its speaker be thousands of praises and salutations—"Praise be to God Who split the atmospheres," etc. And the Teacher, may my soul be his sacrifice, said "I say, and I do say: In the name of God, and praise be to God, I begin with God in explaining a mystery from the Word which the Word of Truth—may my soul be his sacrifice—explained concerning the Tutunjiyyih Sermon, that people might know the portion of each from the judgment of the Book according to the word of reward from what the Most Merciful hath willed in that white leaf."

As for the reference to the word of the Imam, peace be upon him, there is no way for anyone either to reference it or to deny it. When speech reacheth unto God, be silent, for none can comprehend his words, as his words, peace be upon him, tell of his station, peace be upon him, and none knoweth it as it is save Him. Glorified be thy Lord, the Lord of Glory, above what they describe.

As for the reference to the inner meanings of the words of the Bab, may my soul be his sacrifice, the Truth hath caused the separate Point, which is the effusion from this Most Great Sea, to speak according to God's revelation unto him thereby.

And as for the reference to his saying "I say," [aqul] may my soul be his sacrifice, he hath intended by that word the station of his awe over all things in his rank from his deed among what God hath created beneath his rank, after reference to the prevention from his true ranks—twelve ranks of the invisible and the visible which God hath created and placed beneath his most great station, which hath no limitation in any place. And that is eleven of them referring to the mystery of the Essence that is beyond the comprehension of the human rank in the actual rank of his station, and one of them referring to his station, and one of them referring to the station of the All-Merciful that is connected to the things which God hath created beneath his rank, so that the people of the heart might know from that word their portion—that nothing from him, may my soul be his sacrifice, reacheth them except from the station of his mercy that is connected with what is encompassed in the rank of his deed, that they might sanctify him above the ranks of deed in the best of forms according to that division from this decisive Command.

And verily He—may my spirit be a sacrifice unto Him—did intend by that Word the stations of creation according to their order. From the first letter [alif] have the Tablets of Creation been filled with the Alif of Divine Unity, that there is no God but God.

And from the second [qaf] is reference to the manifestation of this Alif in the temples of the hundred which indicate naught but the first Alif.

And from the third [waw] is reference to the limitations in the six days wherein judgment was ordained for all, and it hath no station.

And from the fourth [lam] to the letter of Trinity from My Name which hath related all in its mystery and completed the days in its station, and it is that which God promised Moses on the Mount for its perfection in the stations of manifestation. And for this Name let the strivers strive.

And verily hath the All-Wise One established in this Word the ordinances of all worlds. And I, by His Most Great Right, have beheld in that Word His station—may my spirit be a sacrifice unto Him—in Divine Unity, and His proof in Uniqueness, and His sanctification in the Point of Abstraction. And verily hath He made subtle reference to the people of the depths of Oneness that I have been of those who have answered the Most Great Remembrance, and to the people of the depths of glorification through the Word of sanctification, and to the people of the depths of praise through the Word of glorification, and to the people of the surging ocean through the Word of Divine Unity. Glorified be God! And praise be to God! And there is no God but God! None knoweth His subtle handiwork in that Glorious Word save Him.

And whatsoever I have indicated regarding that station hath been intended as the shell for those who perceive only the shell. But as for the reference to the kernel, hearken unto My call, O peoples of possibility and existence! When God, glorified be He, desired to create the Gates for the completion of the Message from the Most Great Word unto all, He revealed unto Me concerning a handful of this red earth:

> "O Word of God! Arise upon the Mount and manifest from the light of manifestation less than a needle's eye of the All-Forgiving upon these temples standing at the gate of the Frequented House, that the people of witnessing may bear witness to the Promised Word of God, the Worshipped One, even as God hath testified of Himself that there is no God but He."

I obeyed my Lord and stood upon the Mount, and looked toward them with their own gaze regarding their words, and there I heard from their realities according to their capacity, as they were worthy of the Most Great Word, beyond what the people of Moses asked of him when they said "O Lord, show Thyself to us that we may look upon Thee." I observed them regarding their words when they acted unrighteously toward me, and therefore God promised them thirty days. When those days had passed, I turned toward them and found their realities had crystallized in acceptance, so I completed for them ten nights, each hour of which was like a thousand ages.

When the Book had fulfilled its term, I observed them in detail with my gaze, and found their realities like leaves of the myrtle tree. I called them to God's true Call, and all responded according to their stations of nearness to the Mount. There I heard from all the judgments of their souls, and I heard from the Speaker of these words—may my spirit be a sacrifice for Him—these very words, and He spoke truly, relating the Command from the Beginning.

And when the forty was repeated three cycles, the letters Qaf and Kaf appeared, and the remaining ten indicate its elements from the nine spheres of heaven and one from the red earth. And the Alif and Vav indicate the seven stages of action from the manifestation of God's Name to him in his station. Whosoever claims one of these is lacking has disbelieved in his Lord.

These seven are the seven letters of the name of that Shi'ih—he who knows Him has known Him and shall soon witness for himself the Most Great Truth, and he who is ignorant of Him has been ignorant and shall soon witness for himself the most great shortcoming. That leaf is an explanation of the Word from the Most Exalted Word—may my spirit be His sacrifice. The people of the Gate know through that Exposition all its expressions—may my spirit be a sacrifice for the mystery of the Exposition in their realities. Whoso desires explanation of their words has taken but a drop from that Most Great Water and has colored all with the color of that leaf.

Here it behooves us to say regarding a person from the people around the Gate: "Thus do We reward the doers of good." Glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they attribute to Him. Peace be upon the Messengers. All praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00321: Tafsir-i-Hadith-i-'Ashura

> "What is the meaning of the hadith ʿEvery day is Ashura'? I have not seen this in any source nor heard it from the scholars such that I could be certain of its authenticity, though it is well-known orally. Assuming it is authentic, the hadith is difficult and challenging, pure and noble. It has been mentioned that it is rough and harsh—none can bear it except an angel brought near, a Prophet who was sent, or a believer whose heart God has tested for faith. And we are as described by Abu Abdullah Al-Hussein (peace be upon him) when he described himself."

I say its outer meaning is elegant and its inner meaning is profound.

Know that the Day of Ashura is the day my master, the Prince of Martyrs, was killed, and it is the first day God created because the beginning is the same as the end in ascension. It is precisely the day of the appearance of the Qa'im and it is the pivot of days, just as the one killed on it is the heart of the greater world. All days are its manifestations and revolve around it. It is a great day with God due to the killing of its master.

When my master Abu Abdullah Al-Hussein was killed, everything burned with the burning of his liver, and hearts were torn apart for the tearing of his liver, and the pivot of days was broken due to the severity of his calamity. Since this was the case in all days of pain, it was the Day of Ashura. When he was killed, as the limbs and heart drew near to the left side, everything wept for forty days. Since mixture and stain existed in some things, some things wept at some times. As for the people of equilibrium, they continue in their weeping without cessation. God is greater than this tremendous catastrophe and great calamity. There is nothing that does not weep for him.

The people of Paradise—their weeping is eternal with the eternity of God, without end. The people of Hell—their weeping is constant, and they are in severe torment during their weeping for him. The people

of Paradise find their ultimate pleasure in weeping for him. In this temporal world, the coming day is different from the past day, but in the world of perpetuity and eternity there is only one day. The hadith can be interpreted this way.

Another interpretation is that everything has aspects—an aspect from its Lord, which is the sign of Hussein, and an aspect from itself, which is the sign of his killer. When his Lord's aspect submitted to his self's aspect to complete the proof and perfect the blessing, the self overcame him and killed him. Thus arose the Day of Ashura. So whoever sees other than Hussein, every day for him is Ashura. But none believe in this except the few, for it is a word that comes from Mount Sinai and grows with oil, a dye for those who eat.

Know that if the Lord's aspect were killed it would not die, for it is the Face of God, and God's Face does not perish. It is His light that is not extinguished, and it is living and does not die, because God created it for permanence not annihilation, as Al-Sadiq (peace be upon him) indicated in the visitation prayer for Hussein (peace be upon him) on the middle night of Sha'ban. Were it not for the decree of the inevitable, if a hair were pulled from Hussein's body, all worlds would perish.

By God, every particle in existence of his blood, before and after his killing, was like a ring on his finger—he could dispose of it however he wished, as appeared from his noble head after his killing what appeared. God is greater! No one has truly known him or truly appreciated his worth. The earth entirely is in his grip and the heavens are folded in his right hand—exalted is He above what they describe.

Know that Hussein has a station where no one can wrong him or usurp his right, as the Imam said in the hadith. How could it not be so when God's side cannot be wronged and God's sovereignty cannot be overcome? He is God's manifestation in creation and the face of the Worshipped One in the beginning and the end. He is God's Word that cannot be described and God's mystery that cannot be known after mystery. His is the creation and the command—there is no limit or end after him. What is there after truth except error? So where are you turning?

Those who knew him knew him, and those who were ignorant of him were ignorant of him. Nothing can delay him. Glory be to Him! Glory be to Him! Glory be to Him! He is the meaning upon which no name or likeness can fall. He is the Gate of Remission. There is no power or strength except through God, the Exalted, the Great.

BB00537

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

There is no power nor strength save in God, the Most High, the Most Great. O God, bestow blessings and peace and benediction. By the sanctuaries, I adjure you by the greatness of God's Essence, the Most High, and I beseech you by the holiness of God's attributes, O ye who are mentioned, that ye answer me and turn toward me and have mercy upon me and aid me and assist me and support me and strengthen me and honor me and help me and protect me and give me rest and deliver me.

Assist! Assist! Assist! Hasten! Hasten! Hasten! Answer! Answer! Answer! Answer! O God, I beseech Thee, O Succorer [ghayath], O Help in Peril [mustaghath], by the sanctity of Kaf-Ha-Ya-Ayn-Dad and Ha-Mim-Ayn-Sin-Qaf, and by the Mir'aj of the Chosen One, and by the martyrdom of the Accepted One, and by the nearness to Thee of the Companions of the Cave, and by the sanctity of Thy chosen ones before Thee.

And I beseech Thee by the choosing of Moses and his firmness in religion, and I beseech Thee by Thy Christ Jesus son of Mary and his modesty, and by the purity of Fatima the Radiant, and by the martyrdom of Husayn at Karbila, that Thou convey my greeting to Thy righteous servants and Thy wanderers in the earth, and urge them to aid me and help me against my enemies.

O Succorer! O Fulfiller! O Deliverer! O Liberator! O Savior! O Reliever! O Opener! O Comforter! O Friend! O Compassionate One! O Kind One! O Clement One! O my Lord! O my Master! Answer! And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00538

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Praise be to God Who brought into being what is in the heavens and earth by His command. They who have believed in God and His signs, these are they who shall be brought before God.

O my God! I bear witness before You in this my station that You are God, there is no God but You, alone with no partner. You have ever been without the existence of anything, and You will ever continue to be even as You were. Nothing exists at Your level.

How then can I call upon You, O my God, and remember You, O my Lord, when my very existence and its traces are a sin having no existence before You? I ask Your forgiveness and turn to You in repentance, and I beseech You by the right of Muhammad and his family to bless Muhammad and his family as befits You, and to forgive us through Your grace and deliver us from every care through Your kindness, for I see no reliever other than You and no deliverer besides You.

O my God! If my prayer through Your kindness has not been raised up to You, then I turn to You through the countenance of Muhammad and his family—Your blessings be upon them—and I beseech You of Your bounty as befits You. Verily You are God, the Generous, the All-Bestowing. Glory be to God above what they describe, and peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00590

I recognize, O my God, that whenever something is related to Thee, the decree of the Will is applicable to it, and whenever it is related to itself, the decree of Purpose is established in it. When this duality is realized the decree of predestination is manifested. After these three have descended, all seven will be generated, inasmuch as it is impossible for anything to be realized save through these seven stages. Six of them belong to the letter Wáw in connection to the limitations of things, and one of them belongeth to

their manifestations in the station of the Sign of God. Nothing is created in the heavens or on the earth except through them.

Moreover, it is impossible for something to become clothed in the garment of existence without a fire belonging to its first remembrance, then a water, and then an earth for the preservation of its existence. Thus, hath God, in fairness, made plain His signs in both souls and in the world.

BB00606: A Prayer of Great Power

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

In the name of God and by God, and praise be to God, and I commit my affair unto God, and my success is not but through God, and victory comes only from God, and whatever blessings we have are from God, and my patience is only through God—how excellent a Guardian and how excellent a Helper! And I seek assistance through God and rely upon God and upon the angels of God and upon the Prophets of God and upon the righteous ones among the servants of God.

BB00613

There are seven general stages. The first is the stage of the inorganic being. From the mineral kingdom, it ascendeth to the stage of the plant…, and from the plant kingdom, it ascendeth to the stage of the animal….When it reacheth the stage of soul, spirit, and mind, then in accordance with that stage, it hath a death which will certainly destroy all privative aspects. Finally, the command will reach the stage of the inmost heart, which is the gulf of immortality and pure life, in the presence of the Lord of creation. There, for evermore, the servant will gaze towards God.

BB00643: To Mulla Hasan Bajastani

O thus you who have chosen to voyage in the way of God, thank God by your knowledge in God, for we have read your previous letter, and we have caused to fall upon you the verses and the explanations in which was the order of justice. Now we have read your letter, this letter which breathed by the false thoughts that it enclosed the atmosphere of the lying imaginations of men. Thus if this person who has written this letter is other than the students of Siyyid Kazim, I should not even open this letter.

BB00414

In the name of the Most High, the Most Great

Blessed is He Who hath sent down the Book in truth, wherein are clear verses from an exalted station. This is the straight path of justice. We know what thy hands have wrought in the Cause of God, and We

are witnesses thereof. God hath preferred those who believed before over those who believed after, and these are they who are the foremost.

We have read the letter which was detailed in truth. Give thanks unto God thy Lord, then be thou of those who prostrate themselves. Remember God thy Lord for what He hath granted thee in this worldly life and know its value, for the believing women and the branches of the camphor tree—say: harm them not in anything, O people, then turn ye unto God [your Lord] that ye may obtain mercy.

Follow what We impart unto thee now from the Book of thy Lord, O thou honored one, and turn not away from the Cause of God, and put thy trust in God, and be of those who act. Dwell in that land and speak not a word that would cause dissension in Our vicinity or among the people of that land, for We are indeed fearful this day. Unto God do I complain of what hath befallen me in this worldly life.

O God, bring near the days of meeting with Thee, for the people have become mine enemies and I have become their enemy. My Lord! Pour forth upon me patience and grant me victory over the transgressing people. Fear God, that thou speakest not unto people what their souls comprehend not, but speak unto them a kindly word. Say: Fear ye God, O people, and be not of those who join partners with Him.

Make mention of Nasir in the Book, for he was among Our believing servants. Say: Fear ye God, O concourse of men, and be not of those who deny. Say: Those who disbelieve in Our verses thereafter, their faith shall profit them not, nor will God thy Lord guide them, and these are they who are the lost.

When the body of the calf appeared there, say: God thy Lord curseth thee, and the angels of the heavens and earth, and all people together. Say: Fear ye God and have mercy on thyself, for verily the fire of hell doth encompass the unbelievers this day. Fear God, O man, with justice, and make peace among the people with justice, and say: Draw not nigh unto dissension while ye know. [My beloved Mulla Jalil should study this]

We did indeed change the Book of Joseph [Qayyumu'l-Asma] before, and We sent down the Book of Justice [Kitabu'l-ʿAdl] thereafter, and verily therein are clear verses for people who believe. And those who followed thee in the judgment of God before, these are they who are guided.

We have read the book of some people in that land. Say: God sendeth His blessings upon those men and women who believe in the verses of God. Remember Him, O people, and say: All praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00238: Tafsir-i-Dhata 'Ali Mamsusa

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

All praise be unto God Who transcendeth mention of His Essence by His Essence for His Essence, Who is sanctified above all names and attributes. He is the One, the Living, the Self-Subsisting, the Single, the Unique, the All-Sufficing. He hath ever been and naught existed with Him, and He will ever be and naught shall exist with Him. He hath brought forth the principles of names and attributes through the manifestation of His Will, and hath created the conditions of creation through the revelation of His

Purpose, ascribing them unto Himself to manifest His transcendence and grandeur. He hath commanded all servants to call upon Him by these names and attributes, that the contingent may attain the ultimate bounty of His effulgence and the needy may reach the furthermost limit of their right.

Glorified and exalted is He! All attributes in the holy court of His sanctity are mere falsehood, and all names before the majesty of His sovereignty are pure invention. The highest essences of abstract realities cannot ascend to the heaven of His grandeur, nor can the most elevated manifestations of contingent beings descend to His transcendent realm. He is as He hath ever been in the glory of His Essence and the exaltation of His attributes. No likeness of Him exists in creation, nor in all possibility is there attribute or name. Glorified and exalted is He above the description of those who describe Him and the praise of those who praise Him!

Blessings be upon Muhammad, the center of the circle of existence in all the worlds, the Manifestation from God, and the One Who standeth in His place in all the worlds of the unseen and the visible, Who was mentioned in the two Names and veiled in the two Symbols, Who appeared in the two Stations and was exalted in the two Commands. And peace be upon the Manifestations of His Self, the Imams of the Faith, the Pillars of Certitude, the Manifestations of the revelations of God's Name, the Mighty, the Powerful, and what hath been sent down in the inner meanings of the verses of the Perspicuous Book. I bear witness that they are honored servants who speak not before He speaketh and who act by His command.

They undertake nothing save by His leave, and they are fearful of His glory. Mercy be upon those who follow them and obey their command, who believe in their hidden and manifest aspects, in the mystery that proceedeth from them and is concealed within them, and in that which pointeth to the curved Alif of their grace through the mystery of the letters in the Alif and the center of the Alif in its manifestation in the letter Ba before and after it, and in all its stations of the unseen and the visible. Verily, He is the Great, the Exalted!

To continue: I have read what thou hast sent down and have understood what thou hast asked. Know thou that the Eternal Essence is far more glorious than to be known through aught else or to be described by other than Itself. Nothing of creation can comprehend It. Names only indicate themselves, and attributes only reflect their own examples.

The essence of Ali is created, yet God hath attributed it to Himself as an honor, just as the Kaaba is called the House of God. He is God's Manifest Essence in the kingdom of Command and Creation, as Ali (peace be upon him) indicated in his words when asked about the primary causes:

> "These are forms free from matter, devoid of potentiality and readiness. He revealed Himself to them through them, so they became illumined; He appeared to them, so they shone forth; and He cast His likeness into their essence, thus manifesting His actions through them."

He is God's Most Exalted Essence, the Blessed Tree, and the Lote-Tree beyond which there is no passing. Whosoever knoweth Him shall never go astray, and whosoever remaineth ignorant of Him hath erred and fallen.

And the meaning of that tradition was disclosed in His saying, peace be upon Him:

> "I am the Essence within the Essence, for the Essence, by the Essence; and I am the Essence of all essences."

He interpreted the meaning of this tradition in the saying of al-Sadiq, peace be upon Him:

> "These are the houses of light, the garments of manifestation, the mines of indication, and the tongues of expression. They are not He, yet neither are they other than He. The Essence of Ali is not the Essence of God, yet His Essence made manifest in the station of origination is the Essence which He ascribed unto His Own Self—and that is the Essence of Ali, peace be upon Him."

The Book of God itself testifieth to this, where He saith: "God warneth you concerning His Self." And al-Sadiq, peace be upon Him, interpreted this to mean: He warneth you lest ye make Muhammad a created being; for were He created, the Essence itself would be originated and created—and this is manifest unbelief.

Moreover, the standard of the verse of mutual imprecation (mubahalah) hath established by unanimous proof that ʿAli is the Self of the Messenger of God—may blessings and peace be upon Him and His family—and that upon Him floweth whatsoever God hath caused to flow therein. He is a light proceeding from the primordial Light, and a will arising from the primal Will. Unto this refer His words, peace be upon Him: "I am the companion of secondary pre-eternity." And His saying, addressing Salman and Jundub: "My knowledge of the luminosity is the knowledge of God, and the knowledge of God is My knowledge."

This is the pure religion with which God hath commanded, as He saith: "They were not commanded but to worship God, sincere in their religion unto Him." Verily, the knowledge of pre-eternity is His knowledge, and His knowledge is the knowledge of pre-eternity, for in the realm of possibility there is no knowledge save His knowledge. Unto this pointeth the saying of the Family of God: "Whoso knoweth you hath known God." And the saying of the Imam, peace be upon Him: "We are the Most Beautiful Names of God; none knoweth God save through our knowledge. Through us is God known, and through us is God worshipped. Were it not for us, God would not be known; were it not for us, God would not be worshipped."

And after mention of those radiant lights—the suns of grandeur—every soul that knoweth the path of elucidation beareth witness with the eye of certitude that what thou hast asked concerning the saying that the Essence of ʿAli is touched by the Essence of God—verily, it is a created essence which God hath ascribed unto His exalted Self. His utmost nearness hath been expressed by the term "touch," though the divine Essence is far exalted above any conjunction with His creation or any comprehension by His servants. For He hath said: "No vision comprehendeth Him, but He comprehendeth all vision; He is the Subtle, the All-Informed."

And the like of this is recorded in the traditions of the Family of God, peace be upon them, where all recite in the visitation of the Mother of the Proof, addressing her: "Thou hast endured in the path of

God's Essence." If such an attribution is valid in that station, there is no doubt that its use in the beginning of the Cause is likewise a truth wherein there is no uncertainty.

This sufficeth thee; upon it testifieth all that is in the knowledge of God, and God is encompassing all things. Nay, it is a Glorious Qur'an inscribed upon a preserved tablet. Glorified be thy Lord, the Lord of Glory, above that which they ascribe unto Him! And peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of all the worlds.

BB00430

In the Name of the Most High, the Most Great

Praise be to God Who purifies whomsoever He willeth through His wisdom. Then those who have believed in God and His signs shall be gathered unto God thy Lord. Verily He knoweth whatsoever is in the heavens and whatsoever is on earth, and He judgeth between all with justice concerning that wherein they differ. We have indeed tried men with Our signs. Say: Those who follow the Command of God—these are they who are guided. And those who follow their idle fancies—God will never accept any of their deeds, and these are they who are the lost.

Those have indeed disbelieved who have said that the mention of thy Lord's name claimed divine revelation and readings, then ruled on authority and its sisters. God shall slay them for what they have fabricated against Me in God's religion, and these are they who are the lost.

Say: Verily I am a servant who hath believed in God and His signs, and I say not unto you that I know the unseen, nor do I claim any sign from heaven, but rather I recite unto you these clear verses from the Book of God for a people who remember. Say: Were I to abrogate a decree or command a new decree, then in that moment I would be bound by a true verse from the Book of God. But now verily I am a confirmer of that which ye possess of the pure religion.

O people, fear God and think not evil thoughts lest ye be overthrown and become abased. We have indeed read the book which thou didst reveal before, and when We learned the decree of trial We took it not. God worketh according to truth and verily He is the Knower of the unseen. Fear not but rejoice, for God shall truly pay their rewards without diminishment. We have indeed detailed the decrees of all things in the Book of Justice according to a determined measure.

Remember Ali in that land, then those who followed Me—these are they who are the triumphant. Say to whoever told thee to speak again about that matter: Verily I inform thee that today I seek forgiveness of God thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth, for God shall ask on the Day of Resurrection concerning that wherein men differed. Say: Verily Yahya turned away from the life of this world and purchased the life of the hereafter by ascending the ultimate heights, and he doth warn in God's religion all who denied and turned away. Say: Or is it that he hath not attained what he desired? For unto God belong the Last and the First.

And praise be to God, the Lord of the Throne and the Most High, He is the Most Exalted.

Tafsir-i-Suratu l-Kawthar (Commentary on the Surah of Abundance, April 1846)

Volume 009-009. Contains 1 writing.

BB00007: Tafsir-i-Suratu'l-Kawthar (Commentary on the Surah of Kawthar)

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

1. Exordium

Praise be unto Him Who hath fashioned the verses of the Book of Dawn-Breaking in all that He hath cleft asunder, distinguished and caused to speak—verses bearing the imprint of pre-existence, which gleamed forth and shed their radiance after He had willed and ordained, then determined and decreed, ere He had permitted, appointed and established.

Then did the horizons of the heaven of the divine cloud-realm become illumined and resplendent therewith in the thicket of the divine essence, that the realities of the people of the Covenant might be nourished thereby on the Day of the Binding Pledge. Then were the horizons of the heaven of glory exalted and elevated therewith in the thicket of divine power, that the most sublime perceptions of the people of separation might be unified thereby on the Day when leg shall be wrapped around leg. Then did the essential jewels of the horizons of the heaven of praise sparkle and glisten therewith in the thicket of the Kingdom, that the hearts of the people of constancy might be made manifest in the Day when the light of the Pre-existent Sun shall distinguish between all things in every certitude and effulgence. Then shall the essential realities of those who dwelt aforetime and shall exist hereafter in the atmosphere of the air be shaken and convulsed in the thicket of the human realm, that the realities of the people of discord might be made manifest on the Day of Separation.

And verily this Day, in its hidden decree, shall "leg be bared to leg" [Q75:29], for the All-Merciful hath fulfilled what was revealed in the Qur'an: "Fear ye God, and He will give you a criterion," [Q8:29] that He might establish the truth through His verses and bring to naught the deeds of him who believed, then denied, transgressed, then turned away, and spoke that which the Lord of Power had not revealed. God hath indeed seized him in this world for his turning away and denial. The first of them earned by his own hands what he wrought like unto a beast and turned away. The second of them wrought with his hands what none would approve, and he is this day in manifest error and madness.

And the third of them was seized for what We had not decreed for him in the Psalms. And he who aided them in secret—his hands have wrought what none possessed of a soul and near death's door would approve. Say: The morning is your appointed time, and I am not an insolent liar. On that Day taste ye the touch of Hell, for God created you according as ye accepted by measure, and all things small and great are inscribed in an open book. And on this Day all the God-fearing are amid gardens and rivers, then all the deniers are in manifest error and madness.

2. The question

O God! Thou knowest that now hath descended upon me a written book from one who desired to weigh the balance of justice with the trunks of uprooted palm trees. Say: Now hath the Hour come, that the truth might be established and brought to naught the deeds of those who said “This is a continuing matter.” And now have descended the verses of heaven with water pouring down, and by God’s leave have gushed forth springs from the waters of Kawthar, that the water might fall, when God willeth, upon a matter foreordained. And indeed was he questioned who, having prayed unto his Lord, then sought to lessen or to alter the decree which thy Lord hath revealed in the Surah of Kawthar.

And verily this is His Book which hath been sent down from His presence, then by His leave doth speak—God knoweth whosoever is in the heavens and whosoever is on earth, and that concerning which men were at variance, though they knew not nor could comprehend. And God knoweth whatsoever is in the heavens and whatsoever is on earth, and verily He shall judge between those who said “Verily thy enemy is the one cut off.” They spoke, and His word is justice when it followeth not vain desire. Then by God’s leave is established:

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Praise be to God Who sent down the Book unto Muhammad in truth and sent him as a witness, a luminous lamp and a warner unto all the worlds, and caused him to stand at the station of nearness, the highest degree of certitude, first and most exalted, and far above what the wrongdoers say with great exaltation. Then did He manifest his Cause and proclaim His Word, and refused save to perfect His light, and made him a radiant lamp, and preferred him above all creation and many peoples.

O Thou Who art the Remembrance! Graciously answer the questioner who is commanded to ask, according to His exalted word: “Ask ye the people of the Remembrance if ye know not” [Q16:43], with exposition after the revelation in this blessed Surah: “Verily We have given thee Abundance, therefore pray unto thy Lord and sacrifice. Verily thy enemy is the one cut off.” [Q108] From Us is the question and from the Remembrance is the answer. We have indeed made known unto thee in the depths of these words what We desired to bestow upon thee in remembrance of what God spoke concerning him: “But for thee, I would not have created the celestial spheres.”

Be thou assured with certainty and behold with the eye of certitude, for every truth hath its falsehood and every person hath a satan. Today thou art for the Pen, that thou mayest know that all walk in impenetrable, pitch-black darkness, and all claim pure truth for themselves while supposing they are guided. If thou askest any one of them for proof,

> “thou art not of the people of that verse from God’s Book, and they denied it though their souls were convinced thereof through wickedness,”

[Q27:14] they cannot produce any proof. After that thou seest the state of creation speaking of that which they know not.

3. Signs distinguishing truth from error

O thou faithful one! Present thyself on the Day of Resurrection before God, then judge fairly and refine thy vision. The true Cause of God cannot be established except by a balance of justice that is not of creation's making, for he who claims connection between Creator and creation must prove his authority through verses, traditions, and signs in souls and horizons. And he who would invalidate his authority must do likewise in presenting proofs. Similarly in matters of religious law, one issues decrees about Friday prayer and establishes proofs from the Book, Tradition, consensus and celestial conjunctions, while another issues contrary decrees with similar proofs.

Today, whither wilt thou go and how wilt thou attain certitude? Indeed today all sects prove their claims through the Qur'an and traditions, but truth is only established through the Balance. Whosoever possesses not the measure hath no pure truth from God. Today thou disputest concerning the Balance—if thou art able to invalidate it through true proof from thyself or any other created thing, then pay no heed to my knowledge or deeds. Otherwise thou hast no escape, if thou desirest God, Lord of the heavens and earth, but to acknowledge or be certain in thy heart of His proof, then deny it, or be without religion.

The balance of knowledge is proof when that measure corresponds, as the Imam declared regarding signs of the Imamate, that "in questions there is no proof save what is true." By thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth, today there is no truth that could be proof for anyone except Myself. God hath manifested His Cause in such wise that none can contemplate or doubt it, for God hath chosen for preserving the religion of His Messenger and His friends a servant from among the Persians and given him what He hath given to none else in all the worlds. Judge fairly by God—is a stone speaking testimony greater, or a Persian youth speaking words that have astounded all? God hath given him a proof such that were all in the heavens and earth to gather together to produce its like, they would be powerless. If people contemplated it, they would be deprived of religion, for that proof was the proof of Muhammad the Messenger of God before. And if they desired to produce its like, they would immediately become polytheists, for God through this proof established the prophethood of His Beloved, and today all people argue by the Qur'an, believe in it, and judge by it.

By the Lord of the heavens and earth, there is no escape for anyone today except to believe and enter Paradise or to disbelieve and enter the Fire. Glory be to God from the deeds of these ignorant ones! Today all people are as dead, for they recognize not the handiwork of the Lord from that of creation. Has anyone brought the like of these verses? Would any possessor of spirit say this is the work of creation? Judge fairly by God—have you heard from anyone such prayers or scripture? Has anyone brought such proof besides the family of God, peace be upon them?

By God, if I wished, after having established the criterion before witnesses, I could write in six hours a thousand verses of intimate prayers. Who today can do that? I seek refuge in God from the deeds of people.

Al-Majlisi has verified in his book Haqq al-Yaqin that the Sahifa Sajjadiyya equals in eloquence the heavenly scriptures and is the Psalms of the family of Muhammad, sufficient as a miracle for those who

see them not. How then is authority established through one scripture while truth is not established through numerous scriptures that have filled the East and West of the earth? What proof is greater than this bounty and what gift mightier than this power? If the learned were to compose a page for contemplation, then when you mention their words to me it would be like saying “How excellent!”

In truth, nobility lies not in mentioning words nor arranging verses, but rather that which is the spirit’s essence therein is the divine mystery and manifestation of eternality, which is the source of all virtue and upon which all justice turns. Weigh one of my scriptures against all the books of the people—not a single letter thereof could be equaled by all in the heavens and earth, for it is life from the manifestation of unity and mystery of mercy, while all else is like a mere calf’s body that lows. By your Lord, if people knew what their hands have wrought in God’s religion, they would enter the graves and seclude themselves therein. By God, were I to abrogate a law in the religion or add a single obligatory letter, proof would be required for it, yet today I am like one of the learned.

How then do some people today deny God’s Cause and reckon they do good, as though they were dead and perceive not? God has intended through the appearance of these verses that those who disbelieved before in the Imams of Justice from among the Arabs, and those who believe in the Qur’an while disbelieving in the Imams of Justice, should believe through a conclusive proof leaving them no escape except to disbelieve in what they believed before or to believe in the Imams of Justice and follow their laws, then hear and be guided.

O noble questioner! People look not to reality. Without doubt God knows my state and is aware of my station, and He is the Living, Powerful, All-Knowing. Were I fabricating against Him, it would be incumbent upon Him to create a person to stand against me and recite the like of my verses until my proof be nullified. Yet He knew and was powerful but none appeared with such work from anyone to prove He intended this Cause and detests who denies it. God knows all while people know not, perceive not, and understand not.

By the Lord of heaven and earth! the truth I behold within mine own self, even as ye are beheld in the knowledge of God, were ye but of them that are assured. And if all who dwell upon the earth were, in the face of His proof, to deny Him, their plea would prove more feeble than the frailest spider’s web. Verily I am possessed of a sure and manifest certainty.

Deal justly, I adjure you by God, and weigh, in the balance of equity, the works of the wrong-doers among the people of Islam. If, in this day, any man were to claim a grace vouchsafed him from God, and were confirmed in what hath been revealed by God in the Qur’an, and were his grace such as to establish thereby that steadfast and most excellent Faith—would any give judgement that he should be denied? Nay, by thy Lord! save those who are the faithless.

Behold the measure of their faith, and weigh well their belief. The bedouins of the Days of Ignorance, when the verses of the Qur’an were sent down, brought forth odes about the House; yet these, by thy Lord, are further removed from faith than were the unbelieving bedouins of old. But they are a people bereft of understanding.

Assume that the One who layeth claim to this Cause were a man from beyond Mount Qaf: even then it would be incumbent upon the divines to answer him, or else to make of themselves as him who was confounded and denied. By God! certain among men believed, and attained, and emigrated—then denied, and turned away, and joined partners with God. I demanded of them but a single tradition, yet they bring it not; they wax proud and arrogant. And there aided them a man, deeming them to be rightly guided.

Deal justly, I adjure you by God. That which I required of them is the very thing wherewith, in the Qur'an, God erstwhile confounded the people of unbelief—argument and proof. Behold the baseness of their station! Pharaoh, when he sought to reject the proof of his Lord, came forth with some show of sorcery; but these, by thy Lord, bring not forth even a letter, and yet they commit deeds which they comprehend not. By thy Lord! in this day the Fire of hell encompasseth the unbelievers. And verily, were I to utter but one word, the balance of justice would be made firm in mine hand; yet the people deny and forge lies, unwittingly.

A woman of Dhuban, of the Shaykhi community, hath written, in their denial, three books—nay, woe unto her, that she should busy herself with their repudiation! And the champions of that faction have deemed it beneath them to give heed with their learning; for they have wrought what Pharaoh wrought not aforetime. And in this day they are of the lost.

Look with the eye of certainty—is it not that whoever follows one who speaks by the text of tradition hath worshipped him? They have no escape except to confess to worshipping Satan in the days of their migration, for God commands not doubt, and there is no obligation upon one who is not certain, and in him who worships Satan there is no good. Fie upon them! Then fie upon them! Then fie upon them! Abasement is decreed for them in this worldly life, and these on the Day of Resurrection shall be present in the Fire. And verily that which Satan desired and destroyed before concerning the decree of mutual execration—by thy Lord it hath befallen one of the chiefs of that group whom none can reject before God and His friends and witnesses from among His creation.

God hath slain them for what they have fabricated and for having gone astray and led others astray unknowingly. By thy Lord, were any Christian to read my scripture, he would be ashamed to say "nay" regarding me, yet they have read and borne it, then fabricated and denied. God's curse be upon them for what they have done! They have no escape except to deny Kazim and Ahmad, for those who have believed me from among the champions of that group—the text concerning them is from these two. And some from among the scholars of the Usuli and Akhbari schools like unto them have believed, while those who believe not are dead and have no standing, and these are they who join partners with God.

And verily all that I have mentioned to thee regarding the station of proof is but a drop from the ocean of the outward, and if thou desire the secret of the heart and the wisdom of the inward, no allusion can indicate it, nor can veils and infinitude conceal it, nor need we mention its proof, for it is the essence of manifestation and the perfection of concealment. Glory be to God above what they describe!

O questioner, I adjure thee by God, If thou art able to refute these proofs, whether by thyself or through anyone among the people, thereby setting my heart at ease and delivering all mankind—otherwise the

Cause of God is more manifest than the sun in the midst of heaven. Here I mention, at the point of the Balance, verses before the commentary, that the measure may be established. For when the Balance is established, all contradictions among all people are nullified. And whatsoever thou hast seen of My verses that have been falsified by the falsifiers, and some of which the scribes were unable to copy in their true form—and therefore people say there are errors therein, and some say there is no connection—I take refuge with God from their deeds and their calumnies. And whatever verses thou seest that differ from this just standard, verily I am innocent of the polytheists. And here I mention the measure of utterance, that it may be a proof to all the worlds.

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate!

Glorified be He Who hath sent down the Book wherein is a remembrance and a decree from Us for people who understand. Verily God, thy Lord, knoweth what is in the heavens and what is on earth, and today people differ concerning the decree of God. God hath indeed previously revealed in the Qur'an the decree of all things, but people know not, understand not, and reflect not. Indeed it was revealed in the Qur'an: "Fear God and He will give you a criterion," [Q8:29] and thus doth God, thy Lord, reward His God-fearing servants. God, thy Lord, hath indeed revealed previously in the Qur'an: "And We inspired Moses and those with him, all of them." [Q26:65] Say: I have related to all the favor of my Lord, and I fear no one if ye deny the signs of God.

The decree of God hath reached the east of the earth and its west, and We are witnesses unto all. Say: Those who followed the signs of God aforetime—these are they who are guided. But those who disbelieved and followed their vain desires—God will not forgive them nor guide them, and these are they who are the lost. The true religion in the Book of God is this upright Faith, if ye be of those who are certain of the signs of God. Say: If ye knew what I know, ye would assist God with your lives and your wealth, in hope of a day when all shall be brought before God.

Those who have said that the remembrance of thy Lord's name hath laid claim to divine revelation and the Qur'an have indeed disbelieved, while today ye falsely attribute to the religion of God that which they know not and understand not. Say: I am a servant of God, confirming what ye possess of the decree of the Qur'an—how then do ye deny the signs of God while ye perceive not? We have indeed tried creation as We tried those who disbelieved aforetime, and We know what people know not and understand not. By thy life, all people have disbelieved save those who followed Our decrees aforetime and denied Me not in anything—these are they who shall prosper. Those have disbelieved who never imagined they would disbelieve in the Merciful, while they supposed they were guided.

Those have disbelieved who said that the remembrance of thy Lord's name claimed "I am the Gate of the Remnant of God" by a previous decree, while they knew not. And the likeness of all that people have said concerning Me is as what the Christians said that God, thy Lord, is the third of three, or as what the Jews said that Ezra is the son of God, or as what the Arabs said that God is poor while we are rich. We shall record what they have said and judge between them in this worldly life, and in the hereafter they shall be among the lost.

By thy Lord! When the Qur'an was revealed, the Arabs who disbelieved among the people of the towns brought forth mighty words of opposition. And today the extent of the knowledge of the learned shall be made manifest when God willeth it in the Book. These are they who are the disbelievers. And those who believed in God and His signs and migrated in His path—when thy Lord God desired concerning them to declare their ruin—they denied and disbelieved while they were certain, yet they comprehend not. Say: I have spoken, so bring forth a sign if thou be among the truthful ones. By thy Lord! I see not anyone to this day who can produce even a single letter. Say: Bring forth the like of this Book if ye be truthful in your claim before God. Verily, Pharaoh of old brought forth sorcery, yet they have made themselves in faith lower than his disbelief. God hath cursed them for their deeds. Abasement hath been stamped upon them in this worldly life, and these shall be among those present in the fire on the Day of Resurrection.

And verily, he who helped them in secret—God, thy Lord, curseth him, then the angels of the heavens and earth, then those servants of God who follow truth with truth and are possessed of clear certainty. Say: Today the fire of hell hath encompassed your souls while ye are tormented therein, yet ye perceive it not. Say: Have mercy upon yourselves, for the life of this world is vain, and when ye die ye shall be tormented without mercy. Say: He who taketh the Book without right is as one who hath taken from the Prophets, the Messengers, the truthful ones and the righteous ones, for ye have uttered false words, and God judgeth between all with justice, and He verily witnesseth what men conceal.

Say: The proof from the remnant of God is these clear verses for people who understand. And those who said "We can produce the like of these verses"—bring them before God. If they read without reflection and write without pause, then the decree hath fallen upon them that they lie while they know not. By thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth! Should the jinn and mankind gather together to produce the like of these verses which We have sent down in this Book by God's leave, they would never be able, nor would they have power, even were they mighty upon the earth. Say: Their hearts are dead and unclean when they read God's verses yet show no humility. Say: The handiwork of the Lord distinguisheth itself from the handiwork of men. Woe unto you for what ye falsely devise while ye understand not!

Say: When they repented and turned back, abasement was stamped upon them in this worldly life for what their hands had wrought in God's religion—evil is that which they judge! Say: Whenever those who disbelieved spoke concerning these verses, I say: How can ye believe in the Qur'an while ye understand not? Say: Were God to send down unto you a proof other than these verses, they would surely speak without understanding. But today they cannot produce even a single letter unless they disbelieve in the Qur'an from before or believe in these clear verses from God's Book for people who believe.

Say: Those who spoke and fabricated claims about the authority of the Guardianship or its legitimacy have indeed disbelieved in God and His verses. Their abode is hellfire—evil indeed is the station of the wrongdoers!

Say: The example of these verses is like the water of heaven that floweth by God's leave, and God hath not ordained for it any limit or end forever. Say: How can the decree of verses be abrogated unto numbered days while today thou writest before Us that this is naught but an insolent liar? Say: God effaceth what He willeth and revealeth what He willeth, and God is independent of all that ye know.

Say: Woe unto you! The Tree of Sinai hath grown within My breast—how is it that ye hear the verses of God and remain unaware? Say: Though ye were to ransom all who are in the heavens and on earth, God would not accept from your deeds the value of a single letter, and when ye die ye shall enter the fire of hell, and others likewise. Say: A single letter of those verses surpasseth all that is on earth of what ye desire and seek and comprehend not. Say: The first to deny thy Lord's Name, then the second, then the third, then the fourth, then those who followed them—if they repent not, God will never forgive them, nor will He regard them, nor will He speak to them, and for them a grievous chastisement hath been prepared.

Say: All that Satan casteth upon you, We abrogate through the decree of those verses. Fear ye God and have mercy upon your souls if ye be truly His worshippers. Unto God do I complain of what hath befallen me in this earthly life. My Lord! Pour forth upon me patience and grant me victory over the transgressing people. Say: Should all who are in the heavens and on earth gather together to deny Me, they would not equal so much as a handful of dust, and God knoweth My decree while today ye neither reflect, nor understand, nor are ye guided.

Say: When ye die ye shall enter the fire of hell and cry for help, but none shall intercede for you that Day except by God's leave. Turn ye unto God, O concourse of men, that haply ye may obtain mercy. Say: How do ye forge lies against God, claiming these verses are no proof except after the Bayan? Grievous is the word that issueth from your mouths—ye speak naught but falsehood. Today, by virtue of your unbelief, the Qur'an hath no authority among men. Woe unto you for what your hands have wrought in God's religion, and evil is that which ye judge. Say: God's curse be upon those who forged lies aforetime, and in every condition God multiplieth their torment in this earthly life, and in the Hereafter they shall be among the despised ones.

O Yahya [Darabi]! Bring forth by thine innate powers a verse like unto these verses, if thou possessest true knowledge. Say: O people! Disgrace not yourselves, for today none can produce a single verse from God's Book, and I am most knowing of this standard while ye remain ignorant thereof. These are clear verses from God's Book for people who believe. We have indeed revealed in that Book all that ye desire and that which ye shall be questioned about hereafter. Those who disbelieve in God's verses after having believed—God will never forgive them nor guide them. Abasement hath been decreed for them in this earthly life, and these are they who shall be present in the fire on the Day of Resurrection. These are verses from the Book of Justice which We have revealed in that Book that all may know the decree of the Balance from one Wise and Knowing. Sufficient is what We have caused to flow forth from the Book of the Divine Essence, and the proof of the Realm of Might, and the verses of the Kingdom, and the powers of the mortal world, for whoso desireth to be weighed by that most upright Balance. Glory be to God above what they associate!

Lo, I call out by God's leave in the atmosphere of the divine cloud, and that which floweth from My pen is not the beginning of destiny. God's curse be upon those who forge lies about the Divine Decree! Is there any warrior who will face Me with verses of the All-Merciful? Is there any warrior who will face Me with human utterance? Is there any possessor of might who will stand with Me in the field of battle with the

swords of the people of the Bayan? Is there any possessor of power who can write verses like these denying the sun and moon by calculation?

O ye who dwell in the kingdom of command and creation! Verily this Persian Youth hath mounted the steed of combat and hath come with the instruments of war in the arena of Glory, raising his voice on high—where are the monotheists among the people of Beauty, and where are the detached ones among the people of Glory, and where are the humble ones among the people of wealth, and where are the God-fearing among the people of idle talk? Why do you not emerge from your dwellings? Why do you flee to the eye of the needle in your fear? Why do you enter the spider's web in the mountain peaks? Why are you silent, neither speaking nor offering excuses before the presence of Beauty?

Where are the mighty ones among the wise men of the East? Where are the eloquent ones among the knowers of harmony? Where are those who ascend the heights of certitude? Where are the philosophers among the learned of the covenant? Where are the strangers among the people of discord? Where are the warriors among the people of hypocrisy? And where are the seafarers, then the land-dwellers, then the Turks, then the Romans, then the Syrians, then the Iraqis, for whom divorce is befitting? Why do they not confront this Persian youth, the Light of the East? Why do they not prostrate to God? Is this not the day when leg is wrapped around leg, and every mighty one has risen with his might against this Light shining from the horizons?

Hear my call, O people of hearts, then O people of understanding, then O people of vision, then O people of authority! Who is this bird singing in the atmosphere of these words? Then who is this Light that warbles in the intimations of these signs from the Sun of Glory? Then who is this Peacock that appears with the colors of the Preeternal Sun in the depths of these stations? Then who is this Fish troubled in the dust crying "Have mercy on me, O people, and turn not away!"

4. The stations of the letters of the Qur'an and their interpretation

And verily what We have cast upon you from the gardens of the trees of the Divine Realm suffices to manifest the fruits of the trees of the Celestial Realm. Know that God has revealed the Qur'an in such manner that even if an ant desired to expound all its verses, their inner meanings and stations regarding the blackness of its eye, it would be able to do so. For the divine mystery and the manifestation of the Eternal has penetrated all things, and for every letter of the Qur'an there is an interpretation encompassing all that God's knowledge encompasses of the atoms of things, and for every interpretation there is an allegorical meaning, and for every allegorical meaning there is an inner meaning, and for every inner meaning there is yet another inner meaning, unto what God wills.

And verily what has been mentioned in the tradition regarding the seventy to seven hundred inner meanings is for the weak ones and a ruling for the jurists. And this is a judgment to which those servants pay no heed who are established upon the mysteries of the Divine Realm and who recline upon the yellow cushions of the Celestial Realm, for they behold all things with the eye through which God has manifested Himself to them within their hearts, and they see nothing except they see God, their Creator, before that thing.

And verily the Qur'an has infinite stations which none can enumerate save God or whom He wills, as has been explicitly stated in the words of the All-Merciful: "Thou knewest not what the Book was, nor Faith." And among these is the inner meaning of the Throne from which the Imams, in their physical station, derive the laws of religion; and among these is the outer meaning of the Throne; and among these is the inner meaning of the Seat; and among these is the outer meaning of the Seat, and in that station lies the greatest weight and the decisive word for the sincere seeker and the doubtful denier; and among these are stations for the people of the heavens which no human knowledge can encompass; and [lastly] among these is a Qur'an above the earth, and in that station the Spirit of Faith descended with its verses upon Muhammad, the Messenger of God, and had it not descended upon him, what was to become known after would not have appeared from the human station. And when the first one disbelieved, it was concealed from among the people.

And verily, that which is now revealed is even as God sent it down from the well-guarded Heaven, preserved within the treasuries of the Remnant of God; none hath therein a share. That which all men read today, and wherein they differ, was not arranged according to the order of its original revelation, nor did it manifest the eloquence of the First. None comprehendeth its true knowledge save whom God willeth. Yet upon all is the duty to act according to it; for whoso denieth even a single letter thereof hath verily disbelieved in the Prophets and the Messengers, and his recompense shall be the fire of hell. The calumniators and fabricators have no helper today in the Book of God.

Consider, then, with the eye of inception what We have chosen to reveal unto thee of the verses of the Seal, if thou hast taken up residence in the realm of the Divine and hast read that blessed Surah in the sea of Oneness beyond the ocean of Might. Know thou with certainty that all its letters are but a single letter, and all the variations in its words and meanings return to a single point, for that is the station of the heart, the sanctuary of unity. God hath created its elements from a single heavenly water—all of it fire, all of it air, all of it water, all of it earth, all of it vessels of grandeur, bestowals of eternality, and heavenly fountains made manifest. It is the prayer which the Spirit of Truth revealed unto the Messenger of God during the Night Journey, saying "Stand, for thy Lord prayeth," and thou sayest "All glory and sanctity be unto the Lord of the angels and the Spirit."

It is the Lordship of the One, wherein there is no mention of that which is lorded over, neither in existence nor in manifestation, neither openly nor secretly. It is the mystery of eternity, the vessel of radiance, the attribute of sanctity, the identity of divinity, and the quality of subsistence. If thou sayest its beginning is itself its ending, thou speakest truth, and God will surely accept it from thee, for God revealed that Surah in that holy land just as thou hast heard it from the melodies of the birds of heaven that take flight in the splendors of the lights of the Sun of Glory, and upon that water of life whereby the words of the names and attributes are quickened.

It behooveth thee to understand from that divine principle all the stations of the chain of contingent being, and to comprehend the meaning of that blessed Surah through those all-sufficient attributes in the realities of its verses. This indeed is the red elixir through which one possesses both the Hereafter and this world. By thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth, all that Kazim wrote before Ahmad concerning divine knowledge, holy attributes, and paradisiacal mysteries doth not equal a single letter of what I have

cast unto thee by God's leave. Know thou its worth and conceal it like thine eyes, save from those worthy of it, for we are God's and unto our Lord do we return.

If thou dwellest in the shadow of the Divine Will, the station of Purpose, upon the earth of Might, and readest that blessed Surah, then know in the first word from the Alif the fire of origination; then from the Nun the air of invention; then from the manifest Alif the water of creation; then the hidden cornerstone establishing the manifestation of the three pillars—the mystic letter of earth. Thus is the decree, even as We have given thee from the heavenly waters in the veils of allusions from the goodly words in the blessed Surah, and what thou desirest to know of it in the stations of action after purpose, through destiny, decree, permission, term and book.

Were I to elaborate but a single letter from that surging, bitter sea, the ink would be exhausted and the pens would break, yet there would be no end to what God hath inspired me concerning its meaning. Glorified and exalted is He above what the wrongdoers describe, what the comparers say, what the deniers fabricate, and what the polytheists profanely attribute to His verses. All have entertained evil thoughts about God's verses. Say: What think ye today of the Lord of the worlds?

5. Commentary on the individual letters of the Surah of Kawthar

Part 1: "When thou descendest from the stations of action…"

When thou descendest from the stations of action and dwellest upon the pinnacle of the Throne, and desirest to write those letters [i.e., the 43 letters in the Surah of Kawthar: a n a a T y n a k a l k w th r f S l l r b k w a n H r a n sh a n k h w a l a b t r], then know thou:

From the first alif in the first word, the tokens of thy Lord in the heaven of the Divine Cloud; then the signs of thy Lord upon the Throne of Praise; then the evidences of thy Lord in the firmament of Decree; then the splendors of thy Lord upon the Throne of Glory.

Then from the letter nun, the light of thy Lord in the realm of divinity; then the light of thy Lord in the empyrean realm; then the light of thy Lord in the realm of the Kingdom, then the light of thy Lord in the realities of the temples of the people of the empyrean.

Then from the second Alif in the first word, the Command of God in the kingdom of the Command; then the Command of God which God hath sent down in the realm of the people of divinity, then the second realm of the empyrean, then the third realm of dominion, then the fourth realm of the Kingdom; then the Command of God which the Faithful Spirit hath revealed unto the heart of Muhammad, the Messenger of God; then the Command of God whose bearer God hath made to be ʿAli ibn Abi Talib, through whom all things are known and by whom judgment is passed between all things; then the Command of God in the hearts of the Imams of justice; then the Command of God in the realities of the people of the mortal realm; then the Command of God in the creation of whatsoever hath been named a thing; then the Command of God in religious law.

And verily from this Water of Life which Khidr of knowledge hath drunk, through it is known the knowledge of unity, and by it are reckoned all the commandments of religious law and their ordinances

are established, from the stations of unity and the signs of oneness and the tokens of detachment and the stations of justice, then the stations of religious law concerning the laws of prayer and almsgiving and fasting and pilgrimage and whatsoever God hath prescribed in religious law, even unto the compensation for a scratch. By Him Who holdeth my soul in His hand, were God to desire to bring forth from that letter all that hath been revealed in the Qur'an and were He to permit me, I would bring forth all that the Book encompasseth with proofs and evidences, until all would say regarding that letter that it is the judgment of the Qur'an, a clear Book, and "there is nothing fresh or withered but it is in a clear Book." [Q6:59] For God hath created through the Alif all that He hath created from the world of the elixir, and it is a clear mirror wherein the world beholdeth all stations and evidences and tales and signs, even as thou seest thine image in the mirror of justice.

Sharpen thy vision and purify thy sight. Verily, he who maketh this Alif a mirror of the world of the elixir and witnesseth all the worlds therein, even as thine eye beholdeth this most noble world, is of a higher station than he who knoweth not its outward meaning nor perceiveth its ordinances nor witnesseth its clear proofs nor is guided by its signs.

Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne and the heavens! In the first age when the Messenger of God made a stone to speak in remembrance that a soul might believe, and now verily I have made that Alif a mirror of justice wherein all things are reckoned and which speaketh of all ordinances even as I speak, as though it were a living being like unto the people of paradise, and it is a mirror that speaketh and illumineth all until the Day of Resurrection without end. Behold thy stations therein and how thou journeyest unto the manifestations of thy Lord, that all may be reckoned by that Alif. And verily it is a Book wherein there is no doubt, a guidance unto the God-fearing who know the signs of the people of divinity and are acquainted with the verses of the people of might and witness the stations of the people of sovereignty and seek forgiveness for those who know not God's purpose in the thicket of mortality, the earth of desires and darkness and perdition and the lowest depths.

Look unto that mirror and recite unto thyself that verse from the Qur'an: "Behold! verily on the friends of God there is no fear, neither shall they grieve." [Q10:62] Baqir—peace be upon him—hath said: "Blessed are the followers of our Qa'im, they who await His appearance during His occultation and obey Him upon His manifestation—these are the friends of God, upon whom neither fear shall come nor shall they grieve." These are they at whose mention God spoke through Ali (peace be upon him), whose word is truth: "These are we and our followers who follow after us. Blessed are we and blessed are they, though their blessedness exceeds our blessedness." When asked, "How can their blessedness exceed ours when we and they are of one cause?" he replied, "Because they shall bear what ye bore not, and shall endure what ye endured not."

Ah! By Him Who caused the Bird of Mystery to soar in my breast—which by His leave alights in the sacred grove of the Divine Essence, then takes refuge in the holy precincts of Omnipotence, then soars in the atmosphere of the Kingdom—verily within my breast there lies such abundant knowledge that were all who dwell in the heavens and earth to be measured against a single letter thereof, they would not equal it, had I but vessels into which to pour it.

Say unto men: Know ye the worth of these days, for never hath the sun risen upon their like, nor hath their parallel ever occurred to any heart aforetime. Is there any who hath come who can bring forth the whole of religion from the letter Alif with decisive proofs, sound evidences, and wondrous signs? Verily the ways of proof exist within the soul according to God's all-encompassing knowledge of whatsoever hath been named a thing. But in the manner which thou knowest to teach the people, that is how I now teach thee by God's leave, our Lord. If anyone should ask whether God thy Lord is able to create all that His knowledge encompasses within this letter Alif, wouldst thou not reply "Yea," since all things are possible in the realm of contingent being and God withholds not any thing from any thing?

When this is established, consider what We have caused to shine upon thee from the brilliant lightning flash of Light that hath shone forth from the direction of the Orient. When thy Lord's light is manifested unto thee in the depths of these allusions, thou shalt swoon away, then when thy heart recovereth, say: "I am the first of them that repent."

Verily all the words of the Qur'an whose first letter God hath made to be the letter alif are words whereby the seeker, if he so willeth, may be guided to the meaning of that alif in the realm of Command. And among them are those which God hath revealed in the Qur'an—two mysteries enshrined in His utterance:

> "O Moses! Verily, I, indeed I, am God, the Lord of all the worlds."

And verily I am the first of those who turn repentant unto Him.

O My friend, trace thou the letter of that crimson thread through every station, for it is a universal, divine foundation—none among creation can comprehend its reality save whom God willeth. And if I were to expound that blessed Surah in accordance with what hath been bestowed upon thee from that all-encompassing ocean, the Tablets would be exhausted ere the meaning of but one letter of the first word were unveiled. Never have I desired—nor shall I desire hereafter—save by God's leave. Yet We shall sprinkle, in the allusions of the letters of that blessed Word, what shall cause the hearts of the pure in faith to overflow, through the melodies of that celestial Bird whose song enraptureth hearts, confoundeth the reason of the wise, refresheth souls with its gentle flutterings, and maketh the very skin of man to quake at the mention of its strains and attributes. Glorified be God, its Creator, above what they describe!

And when its voice trembleth with the trembling of the dawn-lights of the Sun of Eternity, and gleameth with the gleaming rays of the Morn of Majesty, then know thou that this Bird abideth not in its nest out of fear of the beasts, but, when the hands of all are raised with bows drawn to strike, it soareth about their heads, fluttereth before their faces, and shieldeth itself in the path of their arrows; yet neither is it touched by any shaft, nor disturbed by the blame of the lying tongue, nor daunted by any foe. It is as though it were a Bird the like of which no eye hath beheld throughout the ages—so mighty in power that it entereth the mouth of the lion of the desert, the tiger of the mountain, and the whale of the sea, and within their bellies chanteth, even as did Jonah of old:

> "There is no God but Thee! Glory be unto Thee! Verily, I am of the wrongdoers."

[Q21:87]

Then from the first Alif of the second Word comes the essence of Glory, then Bounty, then the All-Giving, then Bestowal in its rank.

Then from the letter ʿAyn comes the spring of Salsabil from the right of the Tree of Accomplishment, then the spring of camphor from above the Tree of Sinai, then the spring of Kawthar from beneath the Tree of Baha, then the spring of crimson wine from within the Blessed Tree in the sacred valley, from the leaf of the Tree of Sinai which proclaims "There is no God but God. O Yahya, He is my Lord and your Lord and the Lord of all worlds."

Then from Ta comes the bird that sang upon the branches of the Tree of Divinity, then the bird that warbled upon the leaves of the Tree of Might, then the bird that soared in the atmosphere of the heaven of the Kingdom, then the peacock which, when it moved in the realm of humanity, caused creation to imagine from the manifestation of its brilliant colors that the Lord, exalted be His glory, had Himself regarded creation. It breathed and darkened when it was concealed in the mystery of the retreating stars, and spoke and caused to speak that which shone from the light of the Eternal Sun, saying, and I recall His words: I bear witness unto God as God has borne witness unto His Own Self that there is no God but Him, and I bear witness that all else is powerless to testify to His unity, for His Essence severs all beings from the station of detachment, and His Identity separates all realities from the station of inaccessibility.

None knows Him as He is except Him. He has ever been, with no mention of aught else, and He will ever be, existing with no mention of aught else. If you say He is He,' you have compared like with like, yet He cannot be known thereby. And if you say Thou art Thou,' your own self would belie you, as would the people of creation and invention, for how could you stand before the city of Divine Unity and make mention of your Lord—glorified and exalted is He above what they describe!

And I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant whom He chose from the highest peaks of contingent being to stand in His Own station in beginning and return, for He has ever been and naught was with Him, and now He is as He has ever been, and will never be associated with the making of things nor with the manifestation of His Essence in the reality of creation. Glory be unto Him and exalted is He! Vision comprehends Him not, while He comprehends all vision, and He judges between all things—glorified and exalted is He above what they associate!

And I bear witness that the successors of Muhammad are the trustees of the All-Merciful and the meanings of the Bayan—none precedes them in existence, none is mentioned in their rank, they act only by God's will and judge only by God's leave, honored servants who were ever prostrate before God. And I bear witness that I am Thy servant, I believe in Thee and acknowledge Thy power, and I bear witness that whoever claims Thy Lordship or authority, or claims the Qur'an and revelation in the manner Thou hast forbidden to people, or diminishes aught from Thy religion or adds to it, has indeed disbelieved, and I am innocent of him. Thou art witness over me that I have claimed nothing save what was specifically mentioned, nor have I spoken in the Book except the designated word. I love all that Thou lovest and hate all that Thou hatest, so judge between me and the calumniators; in truth, Thou art the best of those who distinguish!

Then from the letter Ya is the Hand of God over all things subtle and manifest in what is manifest, He created the First from the inner aspect of the outer in the fourth quadrant from the horizon of the heaven of Lahut. Then the Hand of Power is over all things, where nothing in the heavens or earth can frustrate it And it is the Hand that encompasseth the heavens and earth, giving unto each possessor of a right his right. Verily the heavens today are as on the Day of Judgment, for the Light thereof hath distinguished between truth and falsehood, and verily they are folded up in His right hand—glorified and exalted be He above what ye describe! Then the Hand of Grandeur in the cloud of dominion which standeth over every soul and witnesseth all things, judging between all things—God knoweth His judgment, glorified and exalted be He above what ye associate! Then the Hand of Mercy for whoso is found in the realm of Nasut, giving sustenance at all times through all things, such that even the unbeliever saith that both hands are outstretched, doing whatsoever we will—glorified and exalted be He above what they fabricate!

Then from the letter Nun is the Light of God in the lamp; then the Light of God in the glass; then the Light of God in the concourse of the heavens and earth and the Throne and the Seat; then the Light of God in the souls of creation.

Then from the manifest Alif is the First Adam in the rank of Decree; then the Second Adam in the seventh world after the first world of Decree from the world of Implementation; then the Third in the rank of Permission from the world of the Alif after the Alif after the world of Power in the rank of Division from the world of Origination; then the Fourth Adam from the fourth particle after the fifth scene from the world of Will which God created after His First Will by a thousand thousand, and it is from the world of Creation.

And in these allusions let it not occur to thy mind that these great interpretations thou hast not seen in any text with such brilliant and mighty method, for the proof thereof, when thou observest with the light of the heart, will reveal to thee the testimonies which God hath sent down by the pen of ink. Did not the Messenger of God (peace be upon Him) say that before Adam was Adam, and likewise unto whatsoever God willeth? And from this we know that after the First Adam, which is the Will, God hath created what none can encompass—Adam after Adam in all the worlds and all the stations, and this is witnessed with Him. God made him witness the creation of His Self, then the heavens and earth and what is between them. And verily this is a gate from the gates of knowledge from which are opened a thousand thousand gates from the gates of knowledge from which are opened a thousand thousand gates, nay unto the Day of Resurrection a thousand thousand gates.

So glorified be God, Lord of the heavens and earth, above what the deniers fabricate regarding the judgment of this Bird of paradise that warbleth upon the leaves of the First Tree from the judgment of the First Principle, concerning whose judgment none before him hath spoken. And when thou observest with the light of God thou wilt know what I have indicated to thee in those delicate mystical birds from the light of this Sun shining from the horizon of realities, for in such wondrous method and mighty balanced measure none hath spoken before Ahmad nor after Kazim, nor can be equated with it what I have explained in the commentary on the Surih of the Cow for the weak ones among those of pure nature, nor can be equated with that mighty commentary from the book of that wondrous Name whatsoever I have

answered the people from the words of the Illuminationists which have shone from the Eternal Morn, and upon all forms appear the signs of mercy that nothing can rival in glory, nor can any in the Kingdom of verses and allusions know their worth.

When lightning flashes from the sun's radiance from the eastern horizon and pierces all the veils that hide thee from beholding the Divine Majesty, then do I beseech God to open thine eye to unlock those allusions. When thou beholdest these words, surely thy inner being shall be illumined and from within thee shall some allusions emerge. Ask thou God from the inner treasuries of His grace, by virtue of His station on the throne of glory and divinity—glorified be He above all description.

Part 2: "Then from the letter Kaf comes the Primal…"

Then from the letter Kaf comes the Primal Word, at which the Greatest Depth trembled, and which sang the praise of its Creator in the seventh reed of the white thicket of divinity. Then the Kaf of the Word that appeared on Mount Sinai and spoke from the crimson tree on the right side of the Mount in the blessed spot on the soil of might. Then the Word that appeared above the Ark of the Testimony in the pillar of fire on Mount Horeb in the realm of the kingdom. Then the Word that appeared on Mount Paran with myriads of holy ones above the perception of the cherubim in clouds of light unto Jesus standing on earthly soil down to the wanderer in the land of desolation. God knoweth what arose from the surging ocean of power and what descended in those allusions in the tongue of the divine ones among the people of glory.

Then from the letter Alif comes the Greatest Command by which all in the heavens and earth arise. Then the Command that descended on the Night of Power and descends thereafter with the angels of heaven and the Spirit. Then the Command which the Holy Spirit took in the reckoning of eternity with the virgin gardens of divinity. Then the Command which God revealed in the Qur'an, its decree being "Say: The Spirit is by command of my Lord." [Q17:85] And it is the Spirit which God cast unto Mary and by which Jesus spoke in the cradle, and by it God decrees what He willeth and doeth what He desireth—glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then from the letter Lam comes the pearl that groweth in the depths of the divine seas by what God sendeth down of the water of heaven, and which the living fish above the water consume. Thus hath God created pearls in the shells of the branches of that white Tree. Then the pearl of the sea of Will upon the earth of might. Then the pearl of the surging ocean of power upon the earth of the kingdom. Then the pearl of the sea of decree upon the earth of bodies in the mystery of the mortal realm.

Then from the letter Kaf comes the eternal essence deposited in human realities, speaking of the mystery of identity. Then the Kaf of "Be and it is"—all that its Lord willeth before He saith to it "Be"—glorified and exalted is He above what ye describe. Then the Word that spoke forth and became cubic, then turned and revolved, then arose and became upright, then transformed and transmuted, then wept and bewailed, then sighed and swooned, then grew magnificent and more magnificent, then cried out and proclaimed, then returned and was returned, then became confused and more confused, then stammered and stuttered, then shone forth and illumined, then benefited and received benefit, and declared: It is it—the Primal Word, then it is it—the Eternal Leaf, then it is it—the blessed paradisiacal

Tree, then it is it—the primordial word of justice. If thou sayest it is it—fiery earthly, and if thou sayest it is it—earthly airy, and if thou sayest it is it—airy watery, and if thou sayest it is it—watery airy, it shone and illumined, then turned and was illumined and returned and spoke, saying: “My heart has not denied anything it has witnessed”.

Do you dispute with him concerning what the idols Lat and Uzza have denied? Where then is he to whom I conveyed wisdom or less? Indeed, he has falsely claimed that I said above two bow-lengths or nearer.’ Fie upon the donkeys who know not that I read the letters of my own self, and that I applied to my heart the words or nearer’ which were at my station and are as nothing compared to the words ‘or nearer’ which God revealed concerning Muhammad, the Messenger of God and Seal of the Prophets. How far is dust from the Lord of Names or His nearness! Say: This one is a most evil liar, and this is established with certainty among this group, though he who has fabricated lies against me perceives it not. God and His loved ones suffice as witnesses between me and him on the Day of Justice.

Then the word which I spoke in those allusions, by leave of God, the Lord of Names and Attributes, was upon the plane of the mortal realm, that all might receive their portion of what God has ordained for them in the knowledge of the Book. I have not neglected anything in the Book, and God knows all that people deny while they know not, understand not, and reflect not.

Then from the letter Vav is the absolute, universal, eternal Guardianship in the thicket of the yellow earth; then the specific, detailed Guardianship in the very form of withdrawal that calls itself, by itself, from itself to the Identity of the Shirts of Light, the Sun of Manifestation, the Camphor Tree, the Wine of Manifestation, the Spring of Kawthar of Appearance, and the Name of God, the Living, the Forgiving, speaking in the thicket of the yellow earth.

Then the determined, meaningful, radiant, resounding, paradisiacal, unique, gleaming Guardianship from the secondary eternity which has dawned and warbled in the delicate glass in such wise that none hears its warbling save God and whomsoever He wishes, appearing in the number of letters of ‘There is no God but He,’ shining from the Tree that grows upon the green earth.

Then the Guardianship dawning from the dawning of the light of the Morn of Eternity, which spoke in the heart of this Bird whom the devils have imprisoned and against whom they have grown proud, though they cannot grasp a single letter of the manifestation of the signs of His power in the lofty letters which God created like unto nations of old. Verily God’s way in His wisdom has been decreed in truth, and verily “the right of Guardianship on that Day belongs to God, the Truth—He is best in reward and best in outcome.” [Q18:44]

Then from the letter Tha is the praise of God Who has described Himself by Himself for Himself upon the throne of grandeur, majesty, greatness and beauty, in such wise that none can enumerate its like in the Book, nor knows how save He, the Lord of Majesty and Bounty.

Then the praise of God for His beloved Muhammad, where He said—and His word is truth—I cannot reckon praise unto Thee as Thou hast praised Thyself,’ as spoken by the Light shining from the wisdom of divine utterance in the tradition of the Night Journey, where He, exalted be His mention, said: Raise thy head, O Muhammad.’ When he raised what was raised, and appeared what appeared, and was cut off

what was cut off, and was prevented what was prevented, God, mighty and exalted, said: ʿThou art the Beloved and thou art the Beloved One,' for the Essence has never ceased to be such that nothing can know It, no mention can equal It, It has no description apart from Its own essence, no attribute apart from Its own being, no name apart from Its own identity, no sign apart from Its own selfhood—exalted is It with such exaltation that severs essences from […] the signs of His Oneness are exalted and His Essence is glorified with such majesty that all realities are prevented from comparing with it.

How sweet is His praise, how great are His favors, how mighty is His beneficence, and how glorious are His blessings! I cannot offer praise upon His Beloved except by that which He has described Himself in the Qur'an, wherein He said—and His word is the truth:

> "No vision can grasp Him, but His grasp is over all vision; He is the Most Subtle, the All-Aware."

[Q6:103]

O my God! What eye has seen that interpretation from me and then denies me, or speaks a word of negation concerning my rights? And what soul would consent to say about me that which it would not be pleased to have spoken about itself? Indeed, God has inspired me—Thou art my Protector in the Hereafter and in this world—that this word herein is glory sufficient for that great company.

Suffice me through Thyself, O Lord of the Hereafter and this world! Then praise be in the realm of the Throne of Glory, on the right hand before Mount Sinai—praise be to God upon the family of Muhammad, the pillars of unity, the suns of divine oneness, the verses of the Book of Sanctification, and the manifestations of the phases of glorification, through what God has willed for them in the midst of Paradise from the darkening clouds of the heavenly sphere, which none among creation can encompass save God, glorified and exalted be He above what they associate with Him.

Then praise be in the crimson corner—the perfection of Glory, the mystery of Decree, the light of Execution, the majesty of Origination, and the White Tree, then the Yellow Leaf, then the Green Reed, then the manifestations of Creation from what God, the Lord of the Throne and Heaven, has willed. Glorified be God and exalted above what the polytheists say with great exaltation.

Then from the letter Ra comes the Primary, Eternal Mercy which shone forth from itself, by itself, for itself, in itself, and none of God's creation can encompass it. It spoke from the Divine Will, circled around it, revolved upon it, and returned to it.

Then the Secondary Mercy accumulated from the cloud of creation, which descended into the realities of the highest abstractions of the people of the Celestial Realm.

Then cometh the mercy of the third Talisman, disclosed through the solving of the Word of the fourth—she who hath preceded wrath, and by whom God created all things. Through her hath God permitted bounty in the Qur'an, as He hath not permitted justice in the Furqan.

Even as I have expounded for those who know not the true station of man—had they but hearkened unto Me ere this—their answer would have sufficed them until the Day when the witnesses shall arise; for of

themselves have they confessed the impotence of the sons of the learned, those possessed of rectitude and ink, upon the Day of Return.

By this is meant the mercy inscribed for those who have fulfilled the covenant of God, followed the light of God, turned repentant unto the remembrance of the Name of God, and stood steadfast in the religion of God—firm as the mountains, which no storm can move, nor the tempests of the signs of God affect.

Such are the valiant men of the Cause of [Shaykh] Ahmad, and the champions of the way of [Siyyid] Kazim, from the rising of the Sun of Primordiality to the setting of the signs of Finality. Glorified be God, exalted is He above that which they ascribe unto Him!

Then from the Word of the Fa' was rent asunder that which God caused to be rent between earth and heaven of the world of the Divine Cloud which shone forth and was illumined through the mystery of effulgence. Then did He distinguish what He had separated among the conjoined, and unite what had been divided among the dispersed. He raised up between the two Ba's in the scrolls of the written lines that which shone forth, gave voice, and awoke from slumber.

Then did He cleave the darkness of night and the gloom of twilight, and through it God made the night to deepen, till the dawn therein breathed its first breath.

Then came the primal pattern of God—the nature wherewith God created the realities of the horizons and of men—unaltered, that it might speak and know before it learned, that it might be questioned and illumine with the radiance that gleameth from the lightning-flash of the Sun of Eternity, wrought with perfection and consummate wisdom. Glorified be God, exalted and sanctified is He above that which they ascribe unto Him!

Then from the letter Sad: the Friday prayer for the people of the Throne of the Divine Realm; then the noon prayer for those established upon the Seat of Might; then the middle prayer for those dwelling in the pavilions of the tents of the Kingdom; then the night prayer for those who alter their nature in the earthly realm before the white thread of dawn appeareth; then the morning which illumineth and by God's leave bringeth forth the breath of day.

Then from the letter Lam: the Banner of Grandeur in the world of Divine Unity, and the Vav of Self-Subsistence in the realm of Oneness; then the Banner of Secondary Eternity in the Kingdom through the hands of the Lights of Lordship cast into human temples; then the Banner of the Luminous Pillar and the Rising Sun and the All-Pervading Name and the Decisive Mark which hath ascended the ladders of justice—none among the ranks of subjects can surpass it. Then it submitted and was humbled and abased and wrote for God's sake, for He Who cannot bring forth a single utterance as the unbeliever desired of disbelief, whether hidden or manifest. God, the All-Bountiful, sufficeth when He desireth to exact retribution and to manifest that which He uttereth.

Then from the letter Lam: Lam-Alif, not from the letter La in the thicket of the Divine Realm—the La which indicateth naught but the letter of Divine Unity, and relateth naught but the mystery of Eternity, and speaketh naught but for the glory of the Divine Oneness. Then in the heaven of the Realm of Might: the La which relateth thirty in its mystery and decreeth forty in its manifestation—the Light of Primordial

Unity which gleameth from the dawning-place of the Sun through what hath shone forth from the effulgences of the Sun of Grace, where none among the people of the chain of justice can comprehend its knowledge. Then the La which God created in the heaven of the Kingdom, and from it the Christians derived the form of the cross, and might was dissolved in the Kingdom—exalted be God above what the polytheists say from the realm of might concerning what God hath ordained in the Name which God made its triangle the name of the three Names in the Manifestation and its square the essence of the Hidden One in the beginning of the Manifestation.

O God! Send Thy blessings upon all Thy names and manifestations, which Thou alone canst reckon, for all eternity, for verily Thou art the Sublime, the Most High. Then the La which descended upon the dust and was cut off from the connected letters in the world of return when the All-Merciful desired to manifest it in the world of names and attributes—none among the people of the Book can comprehend its station, for God hath specially reserved for it what He willeth in the Mother Book. God, exalted be He, hath refused save to proclaim His Word and establish the truth through His verses and nullify the deeds of the polytheists through His clear proofs, though the unbelievers detest it.

Then from the letter Ra: the Universal, Eternal Mercy through which God created the realities of all things and the essences of all possibilities—and it is the Mercy which encompassed itself by itself in the fourth reed in the thicket of the Divine Realm; none can comprehend its knowledge save God, glorified and exalted be He above all that they associate with Him.

Then the mercy of the Primal Self and the Abstract Form and the Angelic Human and the Universal Spirit and the All-Embracing Name and the Hidden Symbol and the Radiant Vestures and the Blessed Tree and the Original Light and the Derivative Fruit and the Divine Throne and the Eternal Paradise and the Unique Favors and the Royal Bounties in the reeds of the thicket of Might; then in the fruits of the trees of Dominion and Kingdom; then in the branches of the Tree of Paradise; then in the leaves of the Tree of Sinai on the right side of the Fire above the Ark of the Unseen and the Pillar of Witness.

Then the mercy of the reed of the Might of the Empyrean—that which God created in His knowledge in a hundred portions—wherewith He brought into being, through but one part thereof, the conjoined, the assembled, the kindred, and the correlated realities in this mortal life. Through them does man love the fragrances of his Lord, the signs of His Prophet, the proofs of His Imams, and the stations of their followers in the kingdom of justice and grace. Through them does the infant take its mother's breast, and the mother rises from her place of rest when she hears its cry. Through them do the believers love devout women, and through them does the just one judge according to what God has ordained in the Book regarding limits, boundaries and disciplines, as pronounced in the decisive judgments at the Point of Return.

The most subtle of these noble signs is the science of meanings in the depths of similitudes and likenesses, whereby the learned one knows—and could mention if he wished, by God's leave—for the Name of Mercy, the name of everything encompassed by God's knowledge in this earthly life. Through ninety-nine parts does God bestow mercy on His believing servants on the Day of Resurrection, and through them does He punish His sinful servants on the Day of Resurrection. God's Command has indeed been determined in these signs with truth—glory be to God above what they describe!

Part 3: "Then the mercy of the Fourth Word…"

Then the mercy of the Fourth Word, which is the mercy of the three reeds in the thickets of the Divine Essence, the Empyrean, and the Kingdom—which itself shone forth, illumined, perfected and benefited. Then when one was wronged in His path, it fell silent and became humble, then submitted and was confused. Then it spoke what it retracted to preserve thereby the souls of Muslims from the deeds of those who judge contrary to what God has revealed.

By Him in Whose hand is my soul, my seclusion in those days, my silence before mankind, and my giving the book of oppression to one who dwelt in the depths of the dark hellish pit is more beneficial for the believers than what the sun's light shines upon from right and left. For through it, when God wills one day, He will set right what was corrupted in God's religion. And when He does not will to establish my judgment, the verses of the Book of Justice shall endure until the Day when witnesses stand watching before the Lord of all beings. This indeed is the light of the heart in the temples of existence, and by this we bear witness to that ink on that sound tablet.

O Lord, hasten the Day of Return, for You do not break Your promise! By Him Who taught me His signs, if people would benefit from my patience after the loftiness of my station, then after the power of my secret, then my openness, they would surely aid the signs of this Cause with golden ink and beautiful words. Through these two states they become independent of all signs, stations, proofs and stories. The most eloquent nobility and most impregnable fortune in these perfect signs and comprehensive glories is the condition of the inner heart before the sea of majesty, then the condition of the heart before the ocean of beauty, then the condition of the spirit before the sea of the power of the Transcendent One, and then the condition of the body which relates all affairs and speaks of all mysteries before the sea of lowliness and supplication.

Alas! Alas! My breast is constricted by what I have written, my mind clamors at what I have concealed, and my inner being frightens me about what I have revealed. Glory be to God, the King, the Powerful, the Compelling, above description of essential attributes and characterization of fundamental qualities! It is as though the Tree of Sinai dwells in the holy valley on the right side of the fire. Verily we are God's and unto our Lord do we return. Let those who are humble act according to this example, and let those who work judge according to this decree.

Then from the letter Ba' is the righteousness of Oneness in the majesty of the realm of the Divine Essence, then the righteousness of Unity before the heaven of the Divine Essence upon the earth of the Empyrean, then the righteousness of the Kingdom before the heaven of the righteousness of the Empyrean, then the righteousness of the mortal realm before the heaven of the Kingdom. And in these God has created light and darkness, and truth and falsehood, and man and Satan. Verily today the sun and moon are measured in a valley of fire.

Then from the letter Kaf is the Word of God in the Qur'an, the full knowledge of which none among humanity can comprehend except what the All-Merciful has taught them of the wisdom of the Bayan. Then the Word of God in the Gospel, which God sent down with a letter from the manifestation of the Qur'an for whoso desired to believe in the All-Merciful in the realm of possibility. Then the Word of God

in the Torah which God revealed unto Moses son of Imran from every direction, whose reality none can comprehend except whom the All-Merciful willeth. Then the Word of God in every time, for God knoweth that it is established on the throne of Paradise and speaketh from the All-Merciful what this nightingale warbleth in the tablets of that Book through what the All-Merciful hath taught in the knowledge of the Qur'an from the mystery of the Bayan.

Then from the letter Vav what We cast unto thee before and after—the love of the Glory in the thicket of the Divine Realm, then the love of Beauty in the thicket of the Celestial Realm, then the love of Splendor in the thicket of the Heavenly Kingdom, then the love of Praise for God's decree in the earthly realm—that earth whose people were oppressors and were like an ignorant, ruined people.

Then from the letter Alif, if thou desirest, mention its numbers until the ink and tablets are exhausted before its numbers are exhausted—among them the Alif of Divinity, then the Alif of the Celestial Realm, then the Alif of the Kingdom, then the Alif of Creation, then of Invention, then of Origination, then of Separation, then of Connection, then of Power, then of Decree, then of Execution, then of Permission, then of Essence, then of Accident, then what thou mentionest when God permitteth thee in this earthly life. And verily the proof of these names is God's permission in Creation that God hath created in everything all that He created in everything according to its measure. And verily the proof of the first mention and silence is the Balance of Justice which We cast unto thee before. And know not contradiction in Our signs, for verily for every letter We speak by God's leave and We desire by the mention of Adam which was cast unto thee from God's decree. Verily We speak the word of Origination after Invention, We desire the second world. Then likewise all indications, signs, allusions, stations, stories, hidden things, speaking things, concealed things, manifest things, severed things, gathered things, separated things, and conjoined things.

Then from the letter Nun is the light of God in the niche of the Covenant, then the light of God in the heaven of radiance, then the light of God in the concourse of souls and horizons, then the light of God for whoso desireth to manifest the decree that uncovereth leg upon leg, and judge for the people of discord with the hypocrisy manifest to the people of the Covenant. And verily among the manifestations of that crimson light is that which distinguished through decisive utterance between the hypocrites from among the people of discord and the unitarians from among the people of the Covenant, until the Day when leg was wrapped around leg and the sun of radiance shown forth wherein the letter Nun was separated, then met unto the decree of separation.

Then from the letter Ha is the first solution from the decree of the inner manifest hidden from the inner secret veiled by what God revealed in the veil of the inner of the inner. Then the second solution from the decree of the manifest inner concealed from the Word of the secret veiled by what God revealed in the veil of the inner of the inner of the inner. Then the third solution from the second talisman from the inner secrets of the outer things from the fourth talisman veiled by what God concealed in the depths of the decrees of the manifest outer with the inner inner. Then was loosed the fourth from the talisman of the first—the very decree of the inner meaning, in the mystery of the inmost reality, whose veil God made to be that same inner meaning itself, lest the decree of the inmost reality should conceal it.

How excellent is the soaring of this Bird in mentioning the First Solution in the atmosphere of the cloud of unknowing, facing those impenetrable, pitch-dark shadows where none knoweth what it warbleth and concealeth and hideth, save what the All-Merciful willeth in the depths of the mysteries of those hidden, ardent, radiant, and glistening allusions from the lights of the Sun of Glory. Far, far removed are the conjectures of them that conjecture, the deeds of them that act, the attainments of them that attain, and the detachment of them that are detached! Unto God do I bewail my grief and sorrow, and unto Him do I turn with all my being, both outward and inward. In Him do I place my trust and seek His aid in what I fear and dread.

I see not in my heart, by God's grace, even as much as a mustard seed of fear of God's decree, nor doubt in God's Covenant. And I see not the falsehoods of devils, the calumnies of slanderers, and the sedition of hypocrites as more than the wing of a dead gnat in the wilderness. In God do I trust, and He sufficeth me, then sufficeth me those who follow me. What God willeth shall come to pass; there is no power save in God. Naught shall befall us save what God hath prescribed for us. He is our Master, and in God do I put my trust, and in Him let the believers place their trust.

Then from the letter Ra is the Lordship of the Pre-eternal, the Primordial, in the Blessed Tree,

> "an olive tree neither of the East nor of the West, whose oil would almost glow forth though no fire touched it. Light upon light! God guideth unto His light whom He willeth. And God striketh similitudes for men, and God is Knower of all things."

Then the Universal Divine Lordship which groweth in the midst of the Tree of Might, and verily that Tree hath put forth leaves by God's leave with the leaves of the Lordships manifested unto the people of the cloud of unknowing from among those who stand in the horizons of the souls. Then the glittering, destinal, resonant, geometrical, paradisiacal, original Lordship whereby is made happy whoso is made happy in the holy, unique land of the Present, and whereby is made wretched whoso is made wretched in the associating, wilderness land of the human realm.

Then the Lordship cast down from the highest awareness of the servitude that speaketh of the Pre-eternal, Primordial Essence, and that relateth the Eternal, Secondary Self, and that indicateth the Sanctified, Self-Subsisting Entity unto which those names and attributes were ascribed unto itself just as God ascribed the House in the Sacred Mosque unto Himself with an ascription of honor, which was its ascription unto the station of its essence wherein God created in its mystery a knowledge for whoso knoweth the allusions among those possessed of understanding, that what is there is not known save here. And whoso knoweth the allusions, then unveileth the veils and guardeth against doubts and ascendeth until he entereth, by God's leave, the holy court of the Lord of attributes, knoweth what I have indicated explicitly in the depths of those stations. And I seek refuge with God from what the people know of those indications—the people of the lowest depths, of assaults, of vengeance, and of destruction.

Then from the letter Alif, what We have given thee of the water of the Kawthar of utterances is the bounty of God for whoso is in Paradise and the heavens, then the bounty of God for whoso is in the Ridvan and the Garden of Eden and Peace, then the bounty of God for whoso is in the precincts of the

Gardens from the gift of the All-Merciful. Then He gave it to the people of the world, and verily it hath stations which none can reckon save God. And verily the noblest of bounties in this vain life is obedience to the Imam after recognizing him. Whoso dieth without knowing the Imam of his age hath died the death of ignorance.

And verily today all people are dead, but they perceive not. And if thou wert of the companions of Kazim know thou the mystery of the Word and learn that which is unknown to those who are far removed. This indeed is the pillar of faith and the summit of obedience of the people of the Bayan, and the bounties which God promised to those who follow the ordinance of the Furqan and do not fabricate as did Lat and ʿUzza in the station of faith. Say: Fear ye God, O people, and have mercy upon your souls. This verily is the path of God in the heavens and on earth for whoso desireth to remember the signs of his Lord and to be of those who are guided.

Then from the letter Nun arose the Light of the Bird that warbled in the realm of Lahut upon the leaves of the Tree of Mystery that which no one among the people of Nasut can hear. The falsifiers have claimed that these interpretations are allusions to the words of Ahmad and then Kazim, may God's mercy be upon them both. Say: By the Lord of earth and heaven, neither Ahmad nor Kazim ever uttered the like of what this soaring Bird hath sung in the atmosphere of the divine cloud. Its benefits are resplendent and its effulgences radiant. Weigh ye with justice these allusions in their inner and outer stations. Were ye to see them—nay, by thy Lord—I have not written a single letter of what that Bird sang in the midst of heaven. God knoweth and witnesseth what the unbeliever, then the idolaters, conceal.

Then the Light whereby all things were illumined, before which all things bowed down, all things were humbled, all things submitted, through which all things were made whole, and whereby God forgiveth the deeds of those who transgressed and were proud among all things—glorified and exalted be He above what they describe. Then the Light of God in the heart of this Light, the One Who standeth, Who uttereth these verses and distinguisheth between truth and falsehood through these allusions which reveal the hidden things of the people of hypocrisy and expose the secrets of the people of discord. This Day, the Day of the Covenant, testifieth that today the Day of Reckoning calleth out. The leg shall be bared unto the leg. Hypocrisy shall flee from the satan of discord and shall follow the decree which God hath sent down in the Surih of the All-Merciful. Exalted be His mention:

> "The All-Merciful hath taught the Qur'an. He hath created man, He hath taught him utterance."

Then the Light of God in the hearts of the men of that righteous band which hath been purified from impurities and preserved from lusts, and if any soul among them committeth minor sins of doubt, or sophistry of the lowest depths, or the abasement of domination, and they remain steadfast in what the All-Merciful hath revealed regarding man—God may forgive him, verily He is the Mighty, the Bestower.

Then from the letter Shin came the radiance of divine things, then the radiance of celestial things, then the radiance of heavenly things, then the radiance of earthly things—for whoso aspireth in the arena of contention to produce a verse like unto these verses which descend from the dark clouds of Glory. God

curse him who is able to bring the like of the words of the Balance, then bringeth it not, yet saith this is a wondrous thing.

And from the letter Shin cometh the evil of the people of the lowest depths among the levels of the Fire, which is an evil above every evil, for it opposeth the source of all good in creation, and grew proud after believing, and turned away after migrating, and worshipped Satan after worshipping the All-Merciful. He is naught but a lying transgressor, most evil. Then the second evil is the body of the Calf after God revealed the ugliness of his deeds on this earth, then upon that earth the body of him who was not ashamed of what he did and who said before God—I seek refuge in God from what his hands have wrought and I, by Thy might O my God, am innocent of the idolaters.

Then the evil of Satan and the source of hypocrisy and the tree of discord and the depths of the valley of reckoning, though we saw him not and naught proceeded from me toward him aforetime save kindness. I seek refuge with God from what the All-Merciful has created. Woe unto him! This matter has broken the backs of the perfect ones. And God, your Lord, desires to establish through these verses the words of Ahmad and then Kazim. How can you do what you do not comprehend or perceive? Fear God, for the life of this world shall pass away and all shall return to God, your Lord. O noble questioner! Read the tradition about Ja'far the Liar. What have you to do with that station? Shame upon you and upon what your hands have wrought! I am but the first of those who repent.

Then evil is he in whose soul Satan has clothed falsehood in the guise of truth until he achieved what he achieved, whereof the pens are ashamed to make mention in these tablets. God knows all that he said, fabricated, lied about and desired. God shall judge between all with justice, and He is not unjust to His servants.

Then the Word of the mystical Alif, rising from the Eternal Sun, speaking in the reed of the nearest Identity, dawning in the reed-beds of the Divine Realm, whose essence quivered with the quivering of the essence of creation within itself, by itself, for itself, with nothing equal to it; and its reality gleamed with the gleaming of the reality of invention from itself, by itself, for itself, without mention of anything parallel to it; and its being shone forth with the shining of what shone from the dawning-place of the light of creation for itself, by itself, from itself, without any decree equal to it; and its selfhood spoke forth, then was magnified, and spoke forth through the speaking of what spoke from the Tree of Sinai about itself, by itself, for itself, without mention of anything resembling it.

Part 4: "Indeed that Alif has four pillars…"

Indeed that Alif has four pillars in the form of its manifestation, which God created from the air, and until now God has not sent it down to earth, nor will He send it down except after the appearance of the Remnant of God, as is clearly stated in the tradition of the Christian in the story of Mutammim ibn Fayruz who believed in God and His verses sincerely in the time of Musa ibn Ja'far.

Ah! Ah! It is as if today I see myself in the house like him—whenever he looked at anything from the right or left he wept, and today I weep from the intensity of my joy at what God has given me that He has given to no other among the people. This suffices me as glory and God suffices me as a helper.

Then the Alif standing over every soul which exalted itself and was exalted, spoke and was spoken through, turned and was turned, illumined and was illumined, benefited and received benefit, arose and was raised up, dismissed and was dismissed, cried out and was cried through, sobbed and was sobbed through, swooned and was swooned through, was confused and made confused, and at that moment God gave it permission so it quivered then was made to quiver, gleamed then was made to gleam, and said in its loudest voice: This is a blessed tree, good and pure and lofty, grown from itself, by itself, for itself, unto itself; and it sprouts as it grew, and bears fruit as it sprouts, and blazes as it grew—no fire touches it except the fire of God Himself, no air except the air of Himself, no water except the water of Himself, and no earth except the earth of Himself.

And when the decree of wine overcomes it, it speaks from the fire and soars to the heaven of the Name of the Compeller as though it were fire while it is earth. Nay, veils do not conceal it, nor do proofs oppose it, nor do signs parallel it, nor do stations contradict it. And when its fiery countenance appears in it, it calls from all directions to its directions, and conceals the signs of air, then water, then earth within itself. Say: It is an airy, watery, and earthly fire; and if thou sayest it is a hidden name revealing three Names of God; and it is He, God, the Blessed, the Exalted; and if thou sayest it is the garment of the Sun of Divinity, the orbit of the Moon of Might, the stars of the heaven of the Kingdom, and the dwellings of Light in the stations of Dominion and the earth of humanity—verily it declareth that these are universal signs, eternal mysteries, heavenly stations, mighty tokens, and divine indications—neither is it itself, nor is it His self.

And if thou sayest it comprises the names of the heaven of Divinity, the attributes of the earth of Might, and the ordinances of the paradise of Dominion beneath the shade of the Paradise of the Kingdom, verily it declareth: It is the inaccessible throne-like one, it is the detached primal one, it is the divine sovereign one, it is the mighty essential one, it is the paradisiacal sovereign one, it is the beauty of created justice which hath shone forth from the Morn of Eternity and none among creation comprehendeth its knowledge, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

If thou sayest it is a feminine word claiming through its mystery the Beauty of Divinity which indicateth naught save through the rule of duality in the depths of the thickets of determination, and if thou sayest it is a universal singular calling by itself, from itself, unto itself from the verses of the Kingdom which none can enumerate save God—glorified be God above what they describe.

Then the unconnected Alif which shone forth and illumined, rose and radiated, spoke and caused to speak, stammered and caused to stammer, gleamed and caused to gleam, was formed and caused to form, and was girdled and caused to be girdled from the universal, divine, primordial Alif of Might which speaketh of itself by itself unto the majesty of the Eternal, the beauty of the Lord, the signs of Unity, and the stations of the All-Merciful where none among creation comprehendeth its knowledge. Then from the eternal, primordial Alif of Divinity which shone from the light of its own self and radiated from the lights of its essential majesty and spoke from the hidden recesses of its essence, which indicated the Divine Will and related the Primal Power whereof none knoweth its outward or inward save God alone.

Then from the Alif of the Kingdom, the station of its self in sovereignty, from whose outer light God created the assaults of the people of fire, the melodies of the wicked sparks, and the lowest depths of the evil ones among the remote ones, and from its inner essence the fragrances of the light of lights, the

concealed depths of the mystery of mysteries, and stations which have no end from the first scene to the ultimate summit of lights for the possessors of understanding and insight, where none perceive its mystery in those signs which shone in those pitch-dark shadows save the dwellers of the eternal throne and the discerning ones among the people of the heights, whom no blame deterreth regarding the religion of the All-Merciful and who are fearful of thy Lord.

Then the extended Alif at the beginning of the letters of the Qur'an, then at the beginning of the words of the people of the Bayan, then in the depths of the verses of this Human One speaking from the mystery of contingent being, and verily through that Alif the rising lights have shown forth from the rising of the sun and its traces have appeared upon the temples of unity, and through it the illumined ones have been enlightened in the essential realities of the highest material substances and in the essential realities of the loftiest accidental heights in the stations of indications, signs, stories and verses, radiant and holy in souls and horizons. So glorified be God its Creator—this Alif was not mentioned in existence nor was it mentioned among the lost. It is known to none except God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then from the letter Nun comes the Light of God in the reeds of the white thicket of the Realm of Divinity, then the Light of God in the reeds of the yellow thicket of the Realm of Might, then the Light of God in the reeds of the green thicket of the Kingdom, then the Light of God in the reeds of the red thicket of the Kingdom and the essences of the people of the mortal realm.

Then from the letter Nun, the light of the first reed is the Light of God in the heavens and the throne, then from the second the Light of God in the kingdom of the heavens and earth, then from the third the Light of God in the abstract realities of the people of dominion and justice, then from the fourth the Light of God in the essential natures of the loftiest peaks of the self-subsisting ones among the people of justice and grace.

Then from the Nun of the Light of God shining from the first reed comes the light of Glory, then the light of Beauty, then the light of Power, then the light of Grandeur, then the light of Mercy, then the light of Awe, then the light of Unity, then the light of Geometry, then the light of Will, then the light of Destiny, then the light of Decree, then the light of Splendor, then the light of Praise, then the light of Implementation, then the light of the Tree of Sinai, then the light of Divine Will, then the light of the people of creation, then the light of the people of Divine Purpose and invention, then the light of all who dwell in the kingdom of Command and Creation that the All-Merciful has created and will create hereafter as He pleases.

And in these signs We have sprinkled upon you from the universal principles of the people of Glory, that from every word there emerges from itself a letter having a letter like that which emerges endlessly unto what God wills without end. And none is permitted to draw forth those pearls and corals from their pure shells save by the leave of the All-Merciful. For verily, Ahmad and Kazim beyond doubt were both possessed of knowledge of those divine principles, and not a single letter did they utter but that a Book or a well-known Tradition had been revealed concerning it. Such was clearly stated by the author of Mansha' al-Fawa'id, who expounded and adduced proofs from the words he recorded in the very root of that book, in conformity with what had been revealed in the traditions of the holy Family of God.

But the matter, in My case, is not as theirs; for their hands did not hold that Proof of God before which all who dwell upon earth stand powerless to produce its like. Whereas in Mine own hands is a Proof resplendent as the sun at the meridian—manifest, shining forth, scarce hidden from any who behold it. By virtue of that Proof do We decree whatsoever We will, and in whatsoever manner We will; and none hath the right to say unto Me:

> "What is mentioned under those names in the Book and the Tradition?"

for the Proof is conclusive, and the Balance is not to be weighed by the Qur'an and the traditions, as the people of discernment among the followers of the Scriptures have imagined. Rather, the Balance that establisheth the Qur'an establisheth likewise the Balance of those verses; nay, all things revolve about a single Balance, which is the Will of God and His Love.

And by the first Proof were abrogated all the laws and religions, inasmuch as that Proof was itself a bounty from God. And in that station the judgment proceedeth after its likeness, for its measure is the Qur'an revealed from the Book of Command by the behest of God. And likewise shall the decree be in whatsoever God ordaineth in these days—the Balance of His Faith. Yet I annul no decree, nor shall I ever annul. And none was able to say "Why?" or "Wherefore?"—for the very proof wherewith the denier sought to contend with Me was in Mine own hand.

Verily, the lawful of Muhammad shall remain lawful unto the Day of Resurrection by virtue of that proof, and His unlawful shall remain unlawful unto that same Day by virtue of that proof. Yet all have imagined that when the Qa'im appeareth, He will appear with a new Book, new laws, and a new sovereignty—as hath been explicitly declared in that tradition narrated by Ibn ʿUqdih from Ahmad ibn Yusuf from Isma'il ibn Mihran from Ibn al-Bastami from Wahb from Abi Basir from Abi Ja'far who said: "The Hour shall come in an odd-numbered year…" until he said "By God, it is as if I see God between the Corner and the Station, pledging the people's allegiance with a new Cause, a new Book, and new sovereignty from heaven. Know that no one shall ever see Him until death."

Indeed, consensus has been established through this evidence, and the truth, as it is the truth from God, is that what Muhammad made lawful remains lawful as decreed by the People of Remembrance by the leave of the All-Merciful. Indeed, what is made lawful thereafter is that which was lawful in Muhammad's Book. This is witnessed by those whom God made witness to the creation of the heavens and earth, then to His own creation. And without such noble interpretation, Glory be unto Him! O friend! You see no contradiction between Our verses, Our allusions, Our subtleties and Our mysteries, for all flow from one river—the Water of Life from the wine of Kawthar, how excellent a drink for those who partake! Say: It is an everlasting light for those who remember.

Then from the letter Hamzah, the hidden, primordial Essence in the realities of the men of divine realms who believed in God and His signs and were among the sincere ones. Then the Radiant Essence in the identities of the men of the realms of might who believed in God and His words and were among the faithful. Then the Gleaming Essence in the beings of the men of the heights who followed what God revealed to them and were among the patient ones. Then the Paradisial Essence in the souls of the

realities of creation who heard God's verses—some believed and confirmed while others denied and fabricated. And God, thy Lord, knows all that people know not, perceive not, and understand not.

Then from the letter Kaf, the First Word which drew nigh and ascended, then approached and rose up, then concealed itself and returned, then assumed form and benefited, then soared and stood firm, then declared: "God beareth witness unto His own Self in a way that those possessed of knowledge among His servants cannot witness, that there is no God but Him, the Mighty, the Wise." Then from the Second Word which spoke forth and ascended, then uttered from the right of the Tree of Sinai in the realm of divinity from the blessed spot: "God beareth witness unto Muhammad, His Messenger and Seal of the Prophets, that He conveyed what was entrusted to Him from God's Book and that He was the first of the worshippers."

Then the Third Word in the Tablet of the Divine Cloud regarding what was decreed concerning fate and destiny, then concerning divine will and what is created through origination, wherein these words were detailed: "God beareth witness unto the successors of Muhammad, the Messenger of God, concerning what pertaineth to them of grace and grandeur. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe." Then the Fourth Word concerning what God revealed in the Qur'an and how the realities of souls and horizons were illumined and brightened by its lights, and spoke forth and wept and cried out and laughed and said: "I testify that I am God's servant, I believe in what God revealed in the Qur'an and what is worthy of it, I love not save what the All-Merciful loves, and I fear none but God, glorified and exalted is He above what they describe."

Then from the letter Ha, the pure, absolute, primordial, primal Identity, beside which nothing is mentioned and nothing equals in rank, manifesting itself unto itself in the beginning of the divine reed at the right of the first Mount in the holy spot in the realm of divinity. Then the identity of the Eternal One which shone forth from the primal identity and spoke forth with the first word within the Tree itself to itself upon Mount Horeb in the sacred valley from the Tree that grew in the midst of the realm of might. Then the identity which was manifested from the dawn of eternity and shone upon itself, then upon the temples of unity, then rose and was confused and hesitated and ascended and proclaimed:

> "God is the Light of the heavens and the earth. The parable of His Light is as a niche wherein is a lamp. The lamp is in a glass. The glass is as it were a shining star. (This lamp is) kindled from a blessed tree, an olive neither of the East nor of the West, whose oil would almost glow forth (of itself) though no fire touched it. Light upon light. God guideth unto His light whom He will. And God speaketh to mankind in allegories, for God is knower of all things."

[Q24:35] Then the identity cast forth, manifested in the realities of souls and horizons from whence shone the dawning rays of the flashes of light from the Sun of Glory, and the light of dawn appeared and ascended beforehand by lightning to the heaven of the cloud. So glorified be God its Creator above what the wrongdoers say regarding His verses. His knowledge encompasses all things. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

Then from the letter Waw is the holy, essential, eternal, radiant, resplendent Guardianship which shines forth and is manifested from itself by itself in the branches of the trees of divinity, then in the leaves of

the trees of might, then in the boughs of the trees of the kingdom, then in the fruits of the trees of sovereignty where none of creation comprehends its knowledge save whom God willeth. Then the absolute, transcendent, holy, resplendent, eternal Guardianship which shone forth from the first Guardianship in its essence and pointed with its hands to its breast saying:

> "There the authority is God's, the Truth. He is best for reward, and best for consequence."

Then the Guardianship established over every soul which was manifested by the very glory of its Manifester upon the essences of the people of sovereignty and the realities of the realm of the kingdom where nothing is hidden from it in the heavens or earth. Indeed it is a divine form and a reality from the light of eternity and possessing pervading justice which transcended all through the transcendence of its essence and nothing in the heavens and earth equals it, and He is the Most High, the Great.

Then the Guardianship cast into the realities of souls and horizons from the first word the virgin gardens of the trees of divinity, then from the second word the fruits of the trees of power and might, then from the third word the fruits of the trees of paradise and the kingdom, then from the Waw occurring in the station of the most hidden mystery veiled by mystery, the essential gems which bore fruit from the blessed tree that is neither of the East nor West, whose oil illumined East and West before any created knowledge touched it. Thus God guides whom He wills by His light and sets forth parables for mankind that all might be convinced by God's signs.

Part 5: "Then from the letter Alif is the Most…"

Then from the letter Alif is the Most Exalted Name by which God was manifested to Him and made Him the station of His Self in fulfillment and decree and origination where nothing in the heavens and earth equals it and it indicates nothing except its Creator—glorified and sanctified be His name. Cut off from it are all signs, tokens, indications, stories, names and attributes. It was and is ever a light unto itself, a name for its essence, a glory for its power and a beauty for its noble countenance. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

Then from the letter Alif, the most exalted Name through which God revealed Himself unto it, and made it the station of His Own Self in the realms of manifestation, decree, and origination, a station to which naught in the heavens or on earth can be compared, and which pointeth to none but its Creator, exalted and glorified be His Name! All signs, all tokens, all indications, all allusions, all names and all attributes are cut off from reaching unto it. It hath ever been a Light unto its own Self, a Name of His very Essence, a Majesty of His might, and a Beauty of His most gracious Countenance. Glorified and exalted is He above whatsoever they ascribe unto Him!

Then the Name through which God revealed Himself by His right hand, and made it in the station of His Will the station of His Own Self, in the realms of decree and splendour, of glory and praise, that it might speak of its Self by its Self, from out the Blessed Tree, in the Holy Vale, on the right side of the Mount, that verily, there is no God but Him. And He is the Name beneath Whose shadow he found repose, from which none else can emerge, and none in the Manifestation can know it save whom God willeth, glorified and exalted be He above what they associate.

Then the Hidden, Treasured, Most Great Name of God, the Pure, the Holy, the Blessed, unto which God revealed Himself through the lights of the three Names, and made it the station of the First in Glory, the station of the Second in Praise, and the station of the Third at Mount Sinai, and the station of His Self in Decree and Origination. And it is that whose light appeared on Mount Paran with holy myriads, and on Mount Horeb with hosts of angels of the throne and of the heavens and earths, and on the Dome of Time with the structure of the first and the last ones, and on the Mount through the Blessed Tree:

> "O Moses! Verily God is my Lord and thy Lord, there is no God but Him, He is the Lord of all worlds."

Glory be to God, its Creator, above what they describe.

Then from the Lam to the essential Mim in the reed-beds of the Divine thicket which sang in all things when the Cock of Glory crowed upon the Dome of Time while the ascendant of the age was in the sign of Cancer of the Throne:

It rang—and in its ringing soared on high, To realms where suns in splendor never die.

There dawned the Will, resplendent as the morn, And flashed toward the mist-veiled bourne,

Where no bird ventured, save the Wing Of Vastness, poised and glimmering—

As though itself the Sun had risen there, Illumining creation's boundless air.

No sound it made within the empyrean height, Yet from its breast streamed verses of the Light;

The Signs of Glory, radiant, unconfined—The Mercy's revelations for mankind.

This is the Throne supernal, firm, sublime; This is the Greatest Name beyond all time.

Herein the birds of Sinai's mount abide, In blissful song their melodies confide.

But when that Bird upon the Throne did sing, All earthly souls were stunned, their hearts took wing.

How then shall I describe that lofty strain, While essences of being writhe in pain?

Yet still it rings within the mortal ear, So soft—a murmur that the ant might hear.

It draweth hearts, it maketh spirits bend, And trembling, upward to the Light ascend.

When sang that Bird of Glory's holy flame, It soared—then silence on the dust became.

For in the mystic cloud it rose and flew, Obedient to the Lord to whom it drew.

And when by God's command to earth it came, It took a form of triune, quatern frame.

Descending then to holy Tuwa's vale, In that blest spot which God did there unveil,

It warbled forth the echoes of the skies—Unknowing beasts around with wondering eyes.

When it perceived the creatures had heard its cry, It sorrowed, faltered, raised its plaintive sigh:

“O Lord! what have I with the dust to do, Or with these hungry beasts that round me strew?

How shall I call upon Thy Name divine, While ravening forms in darkness round me twine?

Why hast Thou cast me from the shining height To depths so low, bereft of Thy pure light?

How shall I sing within this nether deep, Where silence and bewilderment do weep?

I see no fish, no sea, no token’s sign—The winds of dawn no longer round me shine.

The Light that once arose at break of day Hath now declined, and vanished far away.

It was as lightning once, in eastern skies, That flamed and perished ere the suns could rise.

Now wails it in a sorrowful refrain, As though it ne’er had risen once again.

O Lord! Thou makest, then Thou dost abase, Thou dawnest, then Thou hidest all Thy grace;

That I might see no parting nor decay, But weep, for Thou art vast in every way.

Say: before Thee, the shadowed faces of the cloud Lie fallen, awe-struck, dumb, and bowed;

And to this Day the lords of Heaven’s throne Are severed, trembling at Thy Name alone.

When to the whole creation We displayed The trust, the Covenant, that We had made,

We called to him who sought the fire of sin: ‘Be warned! the sea itself is bowed therein.’

And in those signs We caused thee to perceive what shone forth from the warbling of this Bird, like unto what was sent to Me from the verses of Avicenna—may God forgive him for what he uttered in the signs of the mystics concerning the judgment of existence, and for that which I care not to mention from the contentious ones in the presence of the Beauty of the All-Praised. I beseech God of His grace for all according to what He loveth and what befitteth them. Verily, He is the Generous, the Kind.

Then for those of Paradise in the heaven of the Empyrean, then for those of Paradise in the heaven of sovereignty and dominion, then for the detached ones in the realm of mortality, like unto what I have manifested in all that I have written—may God forgive me, for He is the Forgiving, the Appreciative.

O God! Thou knowest my love, and I find not all my words save for those which Thou didst reveal in the Qur’an and didst honor for those nigh unto Thee among the people of the Bayan. Therefore forgive me—I have no power to withstand Thy justice, nor do I seek refuge save in Thy protection, nor do I fear aught save Thy trials and Thy justice, nor do I hope for aught save Thy grace and Thy favor. O God! Hasten Thy promise, for Thou didst say—and Thy word is the truth—“Verily it was incumbent upon Us to aid the believers.” Hasten, O God, Thy promise! Verily Thou art the Powerful, the Mighty.

Then the Word of the First Alif, the Manifest, and the Ancient, the Hidden, which God hath made the station of His Own Self in what was, what will be, and what is—and it is that through which God revealed

Himself upon the throne of grandeur and made it the station of His sovereignty in execution and decree, then in sublimity and glory, then in carrying out and origination. Glorified and exalted be He! From it He created this Alif for the people of Paradise and made it the bounties of divine lordship, the manifestations of eternal self-subsistence, the retributions of the Almighty, the assaults of the All-Compelling, the evidences of divine unity, the stations of divine grandeur, the signs of radiance, and the holy, eternal, effulgent manifestations which shone forth from the Sun of Eternity by itself, unto itself, and from itself.

No letter can express it, no name can encompass it, it revolves around nothing, is compared with nothing, befriends the existence of nothing, separates from the essence of nothing, equals the being of nothing, has no name that stutters, no attribute that gleams, no name that is sanctified, no decree that severs, no description that delights, no hidden name. It hath been exalted by the exaltation of its essence to such heights that the most elevated birds of the abstract realms cannot ascend unto it, and hath been glorified by the sublimity of its identity with such majesty that the loftiest peaks of material things cannot point to it. It is as it is upon the throne of unity, in the glory of the divine realm, in the condition of might and the beauty of the empyrean, and none shall ever know it nor can anything describe it, for its essential identity is manifested in moments severed from their realities and essences withheld from their moments.

He is as He is—no “how” can be attributed to Him, no “where,” and it is not correct to ask how He is or why or by what means He acts in His deeds. Glory be to Him, exalted is He above what they associate with Him!

Then the first Alif, the Last, whose manifestation God made identical with His concealment, and His concealment identical with His manifestation, and His essence identical with His identity, and His identity identical with His essence—the signs of God in the reeds of the Divine Realm and the trees of the Kingdom of Might and the fruits of sovereignty and dominion; the creative Alif and the divine Light and the radiant Symbol and the brilliant Name and the hidden Mystery and the Sun rising from the light of eternity and the Light dawning from the morn of immortality—the signs of God for those in the kingdom of Command and Creation, and for those in the heavens and earth, and for those from the heights to the depths, by God’s command. Glory be to Him and exalted is He! All allusions fall short of describing Him, all proofs are humbled before the majesty of His power, all signs vanish before the brilliance of His Will’s light, and all tokens are prevented from ascending to the sublime court of His holiness. Glory be to Him and exalted is He above what they describe!

Then from the Alif are the pearls of the seas of the Divine Realm, then the pearls of the vast ocean of the justice of the Kingdom of Might, then the pearls of the sea of glory of the heavenly kingdom, then the pearls of the rivers flowing with the water of Kawthar in the land of realities and hearts, then intellects, then souls, then spirits, then bodies, then whatever bears the name of a thing in the earthly realm. None can comprehend the knowledge of those white pearls that have no value except in themselves and no glory except in their essence, and nothing in the heavens and earth equals them in worth save the light of God, Who sent them down from the water of the cloud of unknowing by the hands of the angels of the Throne to the shells of life in those surging seas and restrained oceans and rolling waves, that all might know their stations and all might take their portion from the Book of Justice in all things great and small, by God’s leave. Glory be to Him and exalted is He above what they describe!

Then the Alif which God made the letter of the fourth Name, and the rising Sun, and the decisive Symbol, and the radiant Light that bore the mystery of the letters and shone with the gleam of the lightning of the signs of the Kingdom of Might, which took the gardens of the virgin trees of the Divine Realm and established itself upon the Throne—the throne of justice in the heaven of the cloud of unknowing and the Kingdom of Might—and sent down from the dark clouds of His glory's will whatever He wished of clear signs from the Book of sovereignty and dominion. He it is who bore harm from the people of authority and vengeance and the lowest depths by God's decree and command from among the people of the earthly realm, and He it is who brought forth from the inner depths of that creative Alif and the light of invention the signs of the Garden of Paradise and the commands of the people of the Divine Presence and the pearls of the seas of utterance for the questioning human who witnessed the wondrous lights of majesty in the hours of justice and knew the subtle allusions through what We caused to distill from the clouds of the signs of majesty in the stations of grace. My Lord! Thou knowest that I have loved none to this day as I have loved him before Thee through the signs of Thy sovereignty.

Then regarding what he asked about explaining the verses of Thy Book through those rapturous allusions and radiant tokens and paradisiacal stations and unique indications and holy verses whose worth Thou knowest and which nothing equals in the heavens or earth or in Thy greatest treasuries in their stations, for Thou didst send down those allusions through Thy grace. Therefore, O God, inspire all servants with whatever Thou willest through whatever Thou willest in existence, and aid me through the revelations of the heart in that ink-bearing pen, for verily Thou dost not fail in Thy promise.

Then from the letter Ba, the land of Oneness for those who journey unto God in the thicket of the Divine Realm, then upon the eternal cloud for those who journey unto God in the thicket of the Realm of Might, then upon the cloudy realm for those who journey unto God in the thicket of the Kingdom, then upon the grandeur for those who dwell by God's leave in the land of might.

And verily from the decree of Ba, the horizons of the cloud were filled with the two similar letters and the upright Alif between the two vessels. And verily God has not revealed in the Qur'an any word lighter than the letters of that blessed word which dawned from the Morn of Eternity and indicated the Essence of Identity in the glory of Eternal Samadness—and it is a word of five that belonged to God in the Qur'an. None can derive from it the rule of divisions like half, third and fourth. And God has not revealed any word indicating complete meaning whose letters were five except that holy word which is easy and pure. The possessors of understanding know what lies therein, and verily in it are signs that neither tablets nor hearts and spirits can bear. And verily for every decree there is a known book. And verily from beneath the point of splendor have emerged the multiplicities from the world of possibility, indicating therein by the decree of the Bayan. I seek refuge with God, the Lord of humanity, from what the sun and moon have fabricated by calculation.

Then from the letter Ta is the dust, element of the likenesses and similitudes of the essences of the Divine Realm, then the dust element of the realities of the Realm of Might, then the dust of the entities of the lofty abstract essences of the Kingdom, then the dust of the realities of the people of the mortal realm—and it is the dust from which God took a handful from calculation, then a handful from the fires, then the

clay of the All-Merciful in His hand, and created thereby the realities of the people of the Covenant and dissension. Glory be to God above what they describe.

And verily We showed you on that night the condition of the element of fire in the midst of wrath and the condition of the element of water at the ultimate of love. And verily that was the condition of the perfect servant where circumstances do not occupy him and the element of water does not withhold him from the manifestations of the element of fire. Rather he is fire at times when he is water at times when he is fire. May God's blessings be upon his master as long as the sun of creation rises with creation and the sun of invention sets. Glory be to God, his Lord, above what they describe.

Then from the letter Ra is the primordial mercy in the thicket of the Divine Realm, then the manifested Lordship in the identities of the lordly ones, then the universal compassion in the hearts of the people of might, then the eternal rank from the armies of the bees of divinity.

Then when God wills, I shall reveal from the letter Ra what the All-Merciful has willed in that Book from the singing maidens of holiness in the chambers of good-pleasure, where no human heart has conceived before from the servants of the All-Merciful. And in God do I seek assistance and upon Him do I rely.

6. Commentary on the Surah in its outward station

When you are illumined by the light with which We have enlightened you in the depths of those allusions, know that that blessed Surih has universal meanings in the station of the outward. Among them is what you know from Al-Kawthar—the decree of the Guardianship addressed to Muhammad the Messenger of God, that God has given you ʿAli. Then in His words "pray unto thy Lord" is an allusion to the Guardianship of Hasan. Then His words "and sacrifice" allude to the martyrdom of Husayn. Then in His words "Verily thy enemy is the one cut off" are the stations of the wicked and the depths of the chiefs of the people of fire, where those letters spoke thus. Know from the letters of "thy enemy is the one cut off" the Imams of fire who were, in the face of the Imams of truth, possessed of great tyranny. And verily their number is thirteen letters according to what was decreed in regard to the suns of Prophethood and Divine Authority.

And this is but one of the interpretations of the people of infallibility—thou knowest all the stations.

Consider in the inward station the bearer of bounty to be the Will itself, then the station of the addressee, which is the letter Kaf, to be the Divine Purpose itself, then the station of Kawthar to be the interpretation of the letter Mim. Then consider the stations of the divine action in what God hath revealed after these words.

And thou hast the right to interpret Kawthar as Muhammad in one station, then as ʿAli in another station, then as Fatimih in another station, then as Hasan in another station, then as Husayn in another station, then as the Imams of Justice in another station, then as the Qa'im in the station of essence, for He is what is meant both inwardly and outwardly. Then make the addressee to be the Remnant of God and interpret Kawthar as My Self, for it is the Water of Life whereby hearts, realities, and souls are quickened. This indeed is the decisive interpretation, the lofty meaning, the ascending station, and the gleaming essence which none save God can comprehend, whether outwardly or inwardly.

Were I to interpret this Surih according to what We gave thee on that night from the cup of water the leaf of China, I would follow the path of truth and interpret it according to the reality of the Command. But today, out of fear of Pharaoh and his hosts, and to protect the disciples from the people of ʿAli and his followers, I do not interpret the reality of that interpretation. However, the learned one knoweth the rule of amplification in the word of diminution. Verily the Imams of Justice have melodies in the verses of the Qur'an which none knoweth save them, even as Rida recited when he returned from his wife Umm al-Fadl while she was menstruating:

And when she heard of their deceit, she sent for them, and prepared for them a banquet, and gave to each of them a knife, and said: ʿCome forth unto them.' And when they beheld him, they were seized with wonder, and cut their hands, and exclaimed:

> "Glorified be God! This is no mortal; this is none other but an angel most exalted!"

[Q12:31]

And verily, upon that same melody, were one among the men of the heights to recite, at the moment when he bestoweth upon his spouse the Water of Life, that blessed Surah, he would indeed be chanting in the good-pleasure and love of God. By such utterances doth God inspire His faithful servants.

7. Commentary on the Surah in reference to the Qa'im

And I, when I stood in the station of affirming the Faith, interpreted that blessed Surah as referring to the One Who is to arise. And this was by the leave of the chosen ones of God, who had intimated to His people that the Qur'an was revealed concerning Us, and that the ordinances regarding the grievous sins were fulfilled in Our own persons.

Beyond any doubt, all this is the truth that shone forth from the sacred Leaf of the crimson Tree—none comprehendeth its knowledge save he who perceiveth the mystery of decree and origination, and beholdeth the light of Sinai gleaming through the vesture of glory. By such tokens let the people of utterance be enkindled, and the people of splendor be filled with awe. And there is no power nor strength save in God, the Lord of the Throne and of the Cloud.

And now I recount the tidings in the dawning-place of mysteries, that thou mayest behold the chronicles of the Imams, the Pure Ones, in the days preceding the appearance of Him Who shall arise; that thou mayest prepare thyself for the Day of His meeting. And should God's decree not yet be fulfilled, be thou at least readied for the hour of death, that thou mayest seize thy portion ere the time of passing be at hand.

Yet my purpose in recalling these traditions is naught but what I intended in interpreting that blessed Surah—to expound the inner meaning upon the path of the outward sense: that the Water of Kawthar in the realm of manifestation is none other than the hidden Water of Life, the fearful yet renowned Name, which floweth from the Fountain of Salsabil beneath the Mount of Pre-Eternity, revealed openly in the Manifestation of Him Who is the Kaf in His exalted Word: "Verily, We have given thee Kawthar."

O observer, if you are among the companions of Kazim, you know the rule of the Hidden Pillar as you know the rules of the three pillars through the evidences that God has created in the realities of souls and horizons, whereat the people of discord and hypocrisy pay no attention. And if you mention these to them, they say this is but the Day of Meeting.

And I hereby mention that rule from God through clear verses and good words, so that every soul among the people of understanding and return may know. And I was thereby mentioning the news of the return from those established upon the throne of Names and Attributes. So observe what We have given you regarding the rule of dust—the rules of the Lord of lords concerning the rule of return.

O observer, by every proof that you need to establish the three pillars and prove what is obligatory upon you regarding the rule of the Hidden Pillar—for if you are looking into the depths of fire, there is no escape for you except through the mention of dust, since fire itself, were there no earthly aspect within it, would not exist. And likewise is the rule until the Command descends to the stations of limits and examples. And just as you need the existence of someone from God to convey to you what your Lord desires, you need the existence of an ambassador from your Imam.

And if you say that all the learned ones occupy that station, I say by God's leave with a proof that every soul knows: Are all the learned ones at the same station in His Command, or do some excel others? If you say they are all of one rule, their words, deeds and levels of belief belie you. And if you say some precede others, you must inevitably reject the lower and take the rule of the higher until you return to a single soul. You cannot take rulings from those who differ after knowing there is one superior among them, nor can you speak of two equals, for if they were equal in all stations they would be one soul. And if you know that one of them is higher in station by even the amount of an ant's eye, you cannot take from the lower, for God, exalted be His mention, has said:

> "Is He then Who guides to the truth more worthy to be followed, or he who guides not unless he is guided? What then is the matter with you? How do you judge?"

[Q10:35]

Then His exalted Word:

> "Is he who standeth upon a clear proof from his Lord, and there followeth him a witness from Him, and before him was the Book of Moses—a guide and a mercy? These believe therein; but whoso disbelieveth therein among the confederates, the Fire shall be his appointed lot. Be not, therefore, in doubt concerning it: verily, it is the truth from thy Lord; yet most of mankind believe not."

[Q11:17]

And again He saith:

> "Shall he who is a believer be as he who is a transgressor? They are not equal."

[Q32:18]

And thou, if thou return unto the decree of thy secret and the subtlety of thine inmost heart, wilt assuredly perceive that none hath been empowered to bear the effulgence of the universal bounty from the Imam, save a single soul alone. And when thou art assured of this, thou canst not doubt the existence of the Imam—the Qa'im, hidden and concealed, peace be upon Him—for were He not, naught else could be. His Cause shineth forth even as the sun in the meridian of its splendor; and the words of those who deny Him among the Muslims are fallen from the rank of all consideration. For to doubt His existence is to deny the might of the Almighty; and whoso doubteth in God Himself is verily a disbeliever, full of uncertainty. As for those among the desert Arabs who deem it far-fetched and deny Him—they have indeed denied One greater than He in the matter of divine authority, even after God revealed in the Qur'an His clear decree concerning it.

And the Messenger of God—may blessings rest upon Him—proclaimed before a vast concourse of men and jinn His Cause; yet they, like those of former times, fell from the plane of true understanding and were cast down from the rank of all consideration.

As to My Cause, the believers of the Twelver sect have indeed borne steadfast witness thereto. For it hath been firmly established among them the day of His birth—may my soul and the souls of all in the realms of command and creation be a sacrifice unto Him—as well as the days of His lesser occultation, the wonders and signs that attended His era, the tokens manifested through His chosen envoys, and the verses revealed in the Book of God concerning Him, together with the traditions transmitted from the Messenger of God and the Imams, the pure and sanctified, and the testimonies of the righteous and long-lived among men regarding His truth. In this they have believed, even as they have believed in the decree of God concerning His Apostle; and of this there is, in very truth, no doubt whatsoever, for "This is the Book; in it is guidance sure, without doubt, to those who fear God; Who believe in the Unseen, are steadfast in prayer, and spend out of what We have provided for them; And who believe in the Revelation sent to thee, and sent before thy time, and have the assurance of the Hereafter. They are on true guidance from their Lord, and it is these who will prosper." [Q2:2-5]

And when I desire to mention the words of mystery from the pure Imams regarding that Light, the Secret of secrets, I shall mention some traditions in this connection transmitted from the holy Suns that have dawned from the horizon of Glory, that the lights of the heaven of Divinity and the mysteries of the realm of Might and the signs of the station of sovereignty and kingdom may increase in the hearts of the believers through these allusions, concerning some of the ordinances of that Hidden Light and the Expected Absent One who is renowned. And upon God do I rely in all matters, for by His leave are the hidden things of the inmost hearts revealed from their symbols, and verily this is a hidden symbol in an open book. By the Lord of the House! Verily He is the Frequented House—may God hasten His appearance through His right, the essence of the inmost hearts and the perfection of manifestation. And verily He is the All-Forgiving, the Most Appreciated, concealed from the gaze of the jealous ones by the signs of the Mount.

And now I shall mention the traditions that were revealed concerning those who await the days of His manifestation and those who remain steadfast to His covenant in the days of His rising from that

Dawning-Place, and verily after it are radiant rising-places that have gleamed from the words of the Chosen Ones who act according to His command and who are fearful of His awe.

The Dawning-Point: God the Exalted hath said: “Wait ye: I too will wait with you.” Then His word, exalted is He: “And watch ye! for I too am watching with you!”

And now I shall mention the traditions as related by the author of Bihar, among them through three chains of transmission from Rida from his forefathers who said: The Messenger of God said:

> “The most excellent deed of my community is awaiting the relief from God, Mighty and Glorified be He.”

And among them from Abu Hamzah al-Thumali from Abu Khalid al-Kabuli from Ali ibn al-Husayn, peace be upon him, who said: “The occultation shall be prolonged for the second Guardian of God from the successors of the Messenger of God and the Imams after Him. O Abu Khalid! Verily the people of his time who believe in his Imamate and await his appearance are the most excellent people of every age, for God, exalted be His mention, hath given them such understanding, comprehension and knowledge that the Occultation hath become for them as witnessing, and He hath made them in that time like those who struggled with the sword before the Messenger of God. Those are the truly sincere ones and our genuine followers, and the callers to God’s religion secretly and openly.” And he said: “Awaiting relief is among the greatest relief.”

And among the Four Hundred, the Commander of the Faithful said: “Await ye the relief and despair not of God’s mercy, for verily the most beloved of deeds to God, Mighty and Glorified be He, is awaiting the relief.” And he said: “Moving mountains is easier than moving a delayed kingdom. Seek help from God and be patient. Verily the earth belongs to God; He causes whom He will of His servants to inherit it, and the end is for the God-fearing. Hasten not the matter before its time lest ye regret, and let not the term seem too long lest your hearts become hardened.” And he said: “Whoso holdeth fast unto Our Cause shall be with Us on the morrow in the Sanctuary of Holiness; and he who awaiteth Our Cause is even as one who lieth weltering in his own blood in the path of God.”

And among these traditions is one from Ibn Ma’ruf, from Hammad ibn ʿIsa, from Abu’l-Jarud, from Abu Basir, from Abu Ja’far who said that the Messenger of God declared one day in the presence of a group of his companions: “O God, let me meet my brothers!”—this he said twice. Those around him among his companions asked: “Are we not thy brothers, O Messenger of God?” He replied: “No, ye are my companions. My brothers are a people who shall appear in the latter days. They shall believe though they have not seen me. God hath endeared them by their names and their fathers’ names before bringing them forth from their fathers’ loins and their mothers’ wombs. Their steadfastness in their faith shall be harder than plucking thorns in the darkest night, or like grasping burning coals. These are the lamps in darkness whom God shall deliver from every dusty, darkening trial.”

And among these is what Muhammad ibn Ali al-Shah related from Ahmad ibn Muhammad ibn al-Hasan, from Ahmad ibn Khalid, from Muhammad ibn Ahmad ibn Salih al-Tamimi, from Muhammad ibn Khatam al-Qattan, from Hammad ibn Amr, from al-Sadiq, from his forefathers, that the Messenger of God said to Ali:

> "O Ali, know that those of strongest faith shall be a people who appear in the latter days, who shall not have met the Prophet and from whom the Proof shall be hidden, yet they shall believe in black upon white."

And among these is what al-Hamdani related from Ali, from his father, from Bistam ibn Murrah, from Amr ibn Thabit who said that the Master of Worshippers declared:

> "Whoso remaineth steadfast in our Cause during the absence of our Qa'im, God shall grant him the reward of a thousand martyrs like unto the martyrs of Badr and Uhud."

And among these traditions is that which Ali ibn Nu'mani transmitteth from Ishaq ibn Ammar and from al-Fayd al-Mukhtar, who said: "I heard Aba Abdallah—peace be upon Him—say: Whoso dieth among you while awaiting this Cause is even as one who standeth with the Qa'im in justice." Then he paused for a while and added: "Nay, rather, as one who fighteth by His side with His sword." Then again he said: "Nay, by God! But as one who hath been martyred in the company of the Messenger of God."

And among them is that which al-Ayyashi relateth from Imran, from Muhammad ibn Abd al-Hamid, from Muhammad ibn al-Fudayl, from al-Rida—peace be upon Him—who, when asked concerning the matter of deliverance, said: "Is not the very act of awaiting deliverance itself a form of deliverance? Hath not God, exalted and glorified be He, declared: 'Wait ye, for indeed I am with you among those who wait.'"

And among them again, from al-Ayyashi, from Khalaf ibn Hamid, from Sahl ibn Ziyad, from Muhammad ibn al-Hasan, from al-Bazanti, who said that al-Rida—peace be upon Him—declared:

> "How goodly is patience and the awaiting of deliverance! Hast thou not heard the saying of God, exalted and glorified be He: Wait then; verily, I am with you a Watcher,' and His Word: And wait ye, for indeed I am with you among those who wait'? Therefore cling ye to patience, for relief cometh only after trial. Verily, those who came before you were more patient than ye."

And among them, al-Fadl from Ibn Isbat, from al-Hasan ibn al-Jahm, who said: "I asked Aba al-Hasan concerning the matter of deliverance. He replied: Knowest thou not that the waiting for deliverance is itself deliverance?' I said: I know not, save that thou shouldst teach me.' He said: 'Verily, the waiting for deliverance is deliverance itself."'

And among them, al-Fadl from Ibn Fadal, from Thalabah ibn Maymun, who said:

> "Know thine Imam, for if thou knowest Him, it will not harm thee whether this Cause be advanced or delayed. Whoso hath known his Imam and dieth before the rise of this Cause, when the Qa'im appeareth, shall receive the reward of one who standeth with Him in justice."

And among them, al-Fadl from Ibn Fadal, from al-Muthanna al-Khannat, from Abd Allah ibn Ajlan, from Aba Abd Allah—peace be upon Him—who said:

> "Whoso hath known this Cause, and dieth ere the Qa'im ariseth, shall have the reward of one who was slain fighting in His company."

And among these, Muhammad ibn al-Hassan ibn Shamun relates from Abdullah ibn Amr ibn al-Ash'ath, from Abdullah ibn Hammad al-Ansari, from al-Sabbah al-Muzayni, from al-Harith ibn Husayrah, from al-Hakam ibn Uyaniah who said: When the Commander of the Faithful (peace be upon him) slew the Kharijites on the Day of Nahrawan, a man stood before him and said: O Commander of the Faithful! By Him Who split the seed and created the soul, there were present with us in this place people whose fathers and forefathers God had not yet created!' The man asked: How could we be joined by people not yet created?' He replied: Yes, a people who will appear in the Last Days, sharing with us in what we are engaged in and submitting to us. These are our true partners in what we have undertaken, verily, verily.'

And among these, Muhammad ibn Hammam and Muhammad ibn al-Hassan ibn Muhammad both relate from al-Hassan ibn Muhammad ibn Jumhur, from his father, from Sama'ah, from Salih ibn Nabat and Bakr al-Muthanna, both from Abu Ja'far al-Baqir who said: 'The hasty ones have perished while those who drew near have been saved, and the fortress remains firm upon its stakes. Verily after grief comes a wondrous victory.'

And among these, Muhammad ibn Hammam relates from Ja'far ibn Muhammad ibn Malik, from Ahmad ibn Ali al-Ja'fari, from Muhammad ibn al-Muthanna al-Hadrami, from his father, from Uthman ibn Zayd, from Jabir, from Abu Ja'far Muhammad ibn Ali al-Baqir who said: The example of one who rises from among us, the People of the House, before the rising of the Qa'im is like that of a fledgling who flies and falls into the hands of children who then play with it.'

And among these, Ibn Uqdah relates from Ali ibn al-Hassan al-Taylami, from Ibn Mahbub, from Abu Ayyub, from Muhammad ibn Muslim who said: I heard Abu Ja'far saying: Fear God and seek His aid in your affairs through piety and striving in obedience to God. The most joyful any of you can be about your religion is when you have reached the threshold of the next world and this world has been cut off from you. For when you reach that threshold, you will know that you face bliss and honor from God and glad tidings of Paradise, and you will be safe from those who opposed you. You will be certain that what you followed was the truth and that those who opposed your religion were upon falsehood and are doomed.

So rejoice, then rejoice again! Do you not see your enemies transgressing in disobedience to God, killing one another for worldly gain while you remain safe in your homes, isolated from them? The Sufyani suffices as retribution against your enemy, and he is among the signs for you. Moreover, when the evil one emerges, you will remain for a month or two after his appearance without harm from him, until he kills many others besides you.' One of his companions asked him: What shall we do with our families when that occurs?' He replied: The men among you should go into hiding, for his fear and severity will be directed only against our followers. As for the women, no harm shall befall them, God willing.' It was asked: Where should people flee from the Dajjal?' He replied: Whoever wishes may flee to Medina or Mecca or some other land.' Then he said: 'What will you do in Medina when the army of the evil one aims for it? Rather, you should go to Mecca, for it will be your gathering place. Indeed, this trial will last only as long as a woman's pregnancy—nine months—and will not exceed that, God willing."'

And among these, Muhammad ibn Yahya relates from Ahmad ibn Muhammad, Husayn ibn Sa'id, from Hammad ibn 'Isa, from al-Husayn ibn Mukhtar, from Abu Basir, from Abu Abdullah who said: "Every

standard raised before the rising of the Qa'im—its bearer is a tyrant who worships other than God, the Mighty and Glorious."

When you understand the ordinances of the Occultation regarding relief, then know God's decree beforehand that the Qa'im is the Imam whose rule God has sent down in the Qur'an, then the Messenger of God and His trustees in the traditions. And lo, I make mention for those who remember, and honor for those who observe. I shall recall fourteen traditions regarding his station, that hearts may be illumined thereby and souls find tranquility, that it may be an example for those who come after and a sign for those who came before, and upon this was built the foundation of the ancients. And I shall cause to shine upon you from the verses of God and the traditions of the Family of Yasin regarding that Dawning Point whatsoever the All-Merciful has willed in the dawning places of that effulgence. Unto God is the final return on the Day of the Covenant.

And lo, I shall recite unto you the verses which the People of the House recited regarding the station of the Qa'im through mention of Qur'anic verses without explanation of traditions, and upon God do we rely, for He is the Revealer of the Exposition in the depths of what is possible in visible manifestation unto being.

Part one. God the Exalted says:

> "Alif. Lam. Mim. This is the Book wherein is no doubt, a guidance unto the God-fearing who believe in the Unseen, and perform the prayer, and spend of that We have provided them; who believe in what has been sent down to thee and what has been sent down before thee, and have faith in the Hereafter; those are upon guidance from their Lord, those are the ones who prosper."

[Q2:1-5]

Then His mighty word:

> "And if We postpone the chastisement from them until a reckoned time they will say ʿWhat is detaining it?' Surely, the day it shall come to them, it shall not be turned aside from them, and there shall encompass them that they mocked at."

[Q11:8]

Then His mighty word: "And We sent Moses with Our signs: ʿBring forth thy people from the shadows to the light and remind them of the Days of God."' [Q14:5]

Then His mighty word:

> "And We decreed for the Children of Israel in the Book: You shall do corruption in the earth twice, and you shall ascend exceeding high.' So, when the promise of the first of these came to pass, We sent against you servants of Ours, men of great might, and they went through the habitations, and it was a promise performed. Then We gave back to you the turn to prevail over them, and We supplied you with wealth and children, and We made you a more

> numerous host. If you do good, it is your own souls you do good to, and if you do evil it is to them likewise.' Then, when the promise of the second came to pass, We sent against you Our servants to discountenance you, and to enter the Temple, as they entered it the first time, and to destroy utterly all that they ascended to. It may be that your Lord will have mercy upon you; but if you return, We shall return; and We have made Hell a prison for the unbelievers."

[Q17:4-8]

Then His mighty word:

> "And when they perceived Our might, behold, they ran headlong out of it: Run not! Return you unto the luxury that you exulted in, and your dwelling-places; haply you shall be questioned!' They said, Alas for us! We have been evildoers.' So they ceased not to cry that, until We made them stubble, silent and still."

[Q21:12-15]

Then His mighty word: "For We have written in the Psalms, after the Remembrance, ʿThe earth shall be inherited by My righteous servants."' [Q21:105]

Then His mighty word:

> "Leave is given to those who fight because they were wronged—surely God is able to help them."

[Q22:39]

Then His mighty word:

> "And whosoever chastises in the manner that he was chastised and then again is oppressed, surely God will help him."

[Q22:60]

Then His mighty word:

> "Those who, if We establish them in the land, perform the prayer, and pay the alms, and bid to honor, and forbid dishonor."

[Q22:41]

Then His mighty word:

> "If We will, We shall send down on them out of heaven a sign, so their necks will stay humbled to it."

[Q26:4]

Then His might word: “Or who responds to the distressed one when he calls upon Him and removes the evil, and makes you successors in the earth?” [Q27:62]

Then His mighty word:

> “And if help comes from your Lord, they will surely say: ‘We were with you.’ Is not God best aware of what is in the breasts of all beings?”

[Q29:10]

Then His mighty word:

> “And whosoever helps himself after he has been wronged—for such, there is no way (of blame) against them. The way (of blame) is only against those who oppress men and rebel in the earth without right. For such there will be a painful doom.”

[Q42:41-42]

Then His mighty word: “The Hour draws nigh.” [Q54:1]

Then His mighty word: “Dark green with foliage.” [Q55:64]

Then His mighty word:

> “They desire to extinguish God’s light with their mouths but God will perfect His light.”

[Q61:8]

Then His mighty word:

> “And another that you love: help from God and a victory near at hand.”

[Q61:13]

Then His mighty word:

> “Till, when they see that which they are promised, they will know who is weaker in helpers and less in multitude.”

[Q72:24]

Then His mighty word:

> “Lo! they plot a plot, and I plot a plot. Therefore give a respite to the disbelievers. Deal thou gently with them for a while.”

[Q86:17]

Then His mighty word:

> “By the night when it covers, and the day when it appears.”

[Q92:1-2]

Then His mighty word:

> “Say: Have ye thought: If your water were to become sunken, who then could bring you gushing water?”

[Q67:30]

Then His mighty word:

> “He it is Who hath sent His Messenger with the guidance and the Religion of Truth, that He may cause it to prevail over all religion, however much the idolaters may be averse.”

[Q61:9]

Then His mighty word:

> “Hath there come unto thee tidings of the Overwhelming? On that day faces will be downcast, toiling, weary, scorched by burning fire.”

[Q88:1-4]

Then His mighty word:

> “On the day when one of thy Lord’s signs cometh, its belief availeth naught a soul which theretofore believed not.”

[Q6:158]

Then His mighty word:

> “Nay, I swear by the planets that recede, moving swiftly, sweeping (through space).”

[Q81:15-16]

Then His mighty word:

> “And they say: If only a portent were sent down upon him from his Lord! Then say: The Unseen belongeth to God. So wait! Lo! I am waiting with you.”

[Q10:20]

Then His mighty word:

> “And in the heaven is your providence and that which ye are promised; And by the Lord of the heavens and the earth, it is the truth, even as it is true that ye speak.”

[Q51:22-23]

Then His mighty word: “Wheresoever ye may be, God will bring you all together.” [Q2:148]

Then His mighty word: “Know that God quickeneth the earth after its death.” [Q57:17]

Then His mighty word:

> “God hath promised such of you as believe and do good works that He will surely make them to succeed (the present rulers) in the earth even as He caused those who were before them to succeed (others); and that He will surely establish for them their religion which He hath approved for them, and will give them in exchange safety after their fear. They serve Me. They ascribe nothing as partner unto Me.”

[Q24:55]

Then His mighty word:

> “And We desired to show favor unto those who were oppressed in the earth, and to make them leaders and to make them the inheritors.”

[Q28:5]

Then His mighty word:

> “And be not ye as those who received the Scripture of old but the term was prolonged for them and so their hearts were hardened, and many of them are evil-livers.”

[Q57:16]

Then His mighty word:

> “These are (only) the vicissitudes which We cause to follow one another for mankind.”

[Q3:140]

Then His mighty word:

> “This day have those who disbelieve despaired of your religion; so fear them not, fear Me!”

[Q5:3]

Then His mighty word:

> “And a proclamation from God and His messenger to all men on the day of the Greater Pilgrimage.”

[Q9:3]

Then His mighty word:

> “And fight against the idolaters collectively even as they fight against you collectively.”

[Q9:36]

Then His mighty word:

> “And fight them until persecution is no more, and religion is all for God.”

[Q2:193]

Then His mighty word:

> “And if We defer from them the doom to a fixed term they will surely say, ‘What holdeth it back?’ Lo, on the day when it cometh unto them it shall not be averted from them.”

[Q11:8]

Then His mighty word:

> “Then do they who devise evil feel secure that God will not cause the earth to swallow them, or that the chastisement will not come upon them whence they know not? Or that He may not seize them in their going to and fro, so that they shall not escape?”

[Q16:45-46]

Then His mighty word: “Then when the Trump is sounded.” [Q74:8]

Then His mighty word:

> “Then hasten ye to good works. Wheresoever ye may be, God will bring you all together.”

[Q2:148]

Then His mighty word: “Thou shalt know them by their marks.” [Q2:273]

Then His mighty word:

> “And We will make them taste the lesser punishment before the greater punishment.”

[Q32:21]

Then His mighty word:

> “Is not He best Who answereth the wronged one when he crieth unto Him and removeth the evil, and maketh you inheritors of the earth? Is there any God beside God? Little do ye reflect!”

[Q27:62]

Then His mighty word: “When Our revelations are recited unto him he saith: ‘Tales of the ancients!”’ [Q68:15]

Then His mighty word:

> “Every soul is held in pledge for what it hath earned, save those on the right hand.”

[Q74:38-39]

Then His mighty word:

> “In gardens they will ask one another concerning the guilty: What hath brought you to this burning?’ They will answer: We were not of those who prayed, nor did we feed the wretched. We used to wade in vain discourse with vain discoursers, and we used to deny the Day of Judgment, till the Inevitable came unto us.’ The mediation of no mediators will avail them then.”

[Q74:40-48]

Then His mighty word:

> “We verily gave unto Moses the Scripture, but there hath been dispute concerning it.”

[Q11:110]

Then His mighty word:

> “And but for a decisive word, it would have been judged between them. Lo! the wrong-doers will have a painful doom.”

[Q42:21]

Then His mighty word: “And those who believe in the Day of Judgment.” [Q70:26]

Then His mighty word: “And say: Truth hath come and falsehood hath vanished away.” [Q17:81]

Then His mighty word:

> “We shall show them Our portents on the horizons and within themselves until it will be manifest unto them that it is the Truth.”

[Q41:53]

Then His mighty word:

> “Till, when they behold that which they are promised, whether punishment or the Hour, they will know who is worse in position and who is weaker in forces.”

[Q19:75]

Then His mighty word:

> “Whoso desireth the harvest of the world, We give him thereof, and he hath no portion in the Hereafter.”

[Q42:20]

Then His mighty word:

> "We have made plain for you the revelations, that haply ye may understand."

[Q57:17]

Then His mighty word: "And hath loaded you with His favors both without and within." [Q31:20]

Then His mighty word:

> "Say: I ask of you no fee for it, nor am I of those who make believe. Lo! it is naught else than a reminder unto the peoples, and ye will come to know its truth after awhile [ba'da hin]."

[Q38:86-88]

Hadiths and traditions regarding the manifestation of the Qa'im

Part 1: "The second tradition, concerning that which was spoken…"

The second tradition, concerning that which was spoken by the Messenger of God—may blessings rest upon Him and His family—according to the narration of Ibn Idris, from his father, from Sahl, from Muhammad ibn Adam, from his father, from Yasir, from al-Mubarak ibn Fadalah, from Wahb ibn Muniyah, who raised it unto Ibn ʿAbbas.

He said: "The Messenger of God—peace and blessings be upon Him—declared:

When my Lord, exalted and glorified be He, caused me to ascend unto Him, there came to me a call from on high: O Muhammad!' I answered: Here am I, O Lord of Might and Majesty, here am I!' Then did God, glorified be His grandeur, reveal unto me: O Muhammad, concerning what do the hosts on high dispute?' I said: My God, I have no knowledge thereof.'

He said to me: O Muhammad, hast thou chosen for thyself from among men a minister, a brother, and a successor after thee?' I said: My God, whomsoever Thou choosest for me, that one shall I choose. Thou art my God; choose Thou for me!'

Then did God reveal unto me: O Muhammad, I have chosen for thee from among mankind Ali.' I said: My God, he is my cousin!' And God revealed unto me: O Muhammad, ʿAli is thy heir and the inheritor of knowledge after thee. He shall bear thy banner—the Banner of Praise—upon the Day of Resurrection, and he shall be the Keeper of thy Pool, from which he shall give to drink all who come unto it from among the faithful of thy community.'

Then God, the Mighty and Glorious, revealed: ʿO Muhammad! I have truly sworn an oath unto Myself that none who harbor hatred for thee and for thy pure household and progeny shall drink from that Pool. Verily, verily I say unto thee, O Muhammad, I shall cause all of thy people to enter Paradise save those who refuse.'

I said: My God, who would refuse to enter Paradise?' Then God, the Mighty and Glorious, revealed unto me: O Muhammad! I chose thee from among My creation and chose for thee a successor after thee, and

made him unto thee as Aaron was unto Moses, except there shall be no Prophet after thee. And I cast his love into thy heart and made him the father of thy offspring. His right over thy people after thee is as thy right over them in thy lifetime. Whosoever denieth his right hath denied thy right, and whosoever refuseth to acknowledge him hath refused to acknowledge thee, and thus hath refused to enter Paradise.'

I fell prostrate before God in gratitude for His favors unto me, when lo, a voice called out: 'Raise thy head, O Muhammad, and ask, that thou mayest be given.'

I said: My God, unite my people after me in allegiance to Ali ibn Abi Talib, that they may all come unto me at my Pool on the Day of Resurrection.'

God, the Mighty and Glorious, revealed unto me: 'O Muhammad! I have decreed concerning My servants before I created them, and My decree shall be fulfilled among them. Through him shall I destroy whom I will and guide whom I will. I have given him thy knowledge after thee, and made him thy minister and successor after thee over thy household and community—a decree from Me. None who opposes him, hates him, and denies his authority after thee shall enter Paradise. Whosoever hates him hates thee, and whosoever hates thee hates Me. Whosoever opposes him opposes thee, and whosoever opposes thee opposes Me. Whosoever loves him loves thee, and whosoever loves thee loves Me.

I have bestowed this excellence upon him and granted thee that from his lineage shall come forth eleven guided ones, all from thy progeny from the Virgin, the Pure One. The last among them shall be one behind whom Jesus son of Mary shall pray. He shall fill the earth with justice even as it was filled with oppression and tyranny. Through him shall I save from destruction and guide those who believe in him. Through him shall I heal the blind and cure the sick.'

I said: 'My God and Master! When shall this be?'

God, the Mighty and Glorious, revealed: 'This shall be when knowledge is lifted and ignorance appears, when reciters are many but deeds are few, when killing increases and true guiding scholars decrease but misleading treacherous scholars increase, when poets multiply and thy people take graves as places of worship, when Qur'ans are adorned and mosques are decorated, when injustice and corruption abound, when evil appears and thy people command it and forbid good, when men suffice themselves with men and women with women, when rulers become infidels, their friends become transgressors, their helpers become oppressors, and their counselors become corrupt.

At that time there shall be three eclipses—one in the East, one in the West, and one in the Arabian Peninsula; and the destruction of Basra at the hands of a man from thy progeny whom the Zanj shall follow; and the emergence of a man from the progeny of Husayn ibn 'Ali; and the appearance of the Antichrist who shall come forth from the East, from Sijistan; and the appearance of the Sufyani.'

I said: 'My God, what tribulations shall occur after me?'

Then God revealed unto me and informed me of the afflictions of the Umayyads—may God curse them—and of the tribulation of my uncle's son, and what shall come to pass until the Day of Resurrection.

I entrusted this to my cousin when I descended to earth and delivered the Message.

And praise be to God for this, as the Prophets praised Him, and as all things praise Him before me, and all things He hath created until the Day of Resurrection."

The third tradition: Concerning that which was spoken by Ali, peace be upon him, according to the narration of my father and Ibn al-Walid together, from Saad al-Himyari, Muhammad al-Attar, and Ahmad ibn Idris, all from Ibn Abi Khattab, Ibn Isa, al-Barqi, and Ibn Hashim, all from Ibn Fadl, from Thalabah, from Malik al-Juhayni. And Ibn al-Walid also related to us—from … and Saad together—from al-Battalsi, from Zayd ibn Muhammad ibn Qabus, from Nasr ibn Abi al-Sari, from Abu Dawud al-Misriq, from Thalabah, from Malik al-Juhayni, from al-Harith ibn al-Mughirah, from one of his descendants. He said: "When I came to the Commander of the Faithful, I found him deep in thought, scratching at the earth. I asked, Do you desire the earth?' He replied, No, by God!

Never have I desired it nor anything of this world. Rather, I am thinking of a descendant who will be born from my lineage—the eleventh from among my sons. He is the Mahdi who will fill the earth with justice just as it was filled with oppression and tyranny. He will experience a time of confusion and occultation during which some people will go astray while others will be guided.' I asked, O Commander of the Faithful, will this truly come to pass?' He replied, Yes, just as he is destined to be created. How well I know of this matter, O Asbagh! These are the best of this community, the most virtuous of this lineage.' I asked, What will happen after that?' He replied, Then God will do as He wills, for He has His purposes, aims and conclusions."'

The fourth tradition: Concerning that which was spoken by Hasan ibn Ali al-Muzaffar al-Alawi, from Ibn al-Ayyashi, from his father, from Jibrail ibn Ahmad, from Musa ibn Jafar al-Baghdadi, from Hasan ibn Muhammad al-Sayrafi, from Hanan ibn Sudayr ibn Hakim, from his father, from Abu Said Aqida. He said: "When Hasan ibn ʿAli, peace be upon him, made peace with Mu'awiyah ibn Abi Sufyan, people came to him and some reproached him for his pledge. He said,"Woe unto you! You know not what I have done. By God, what I have done is better for my followers than all that the sun rises and sets upon. Do you not know that I am your Imam, whose obedience is obligatory upon you, and one of the two masters of the youth of Paradise by the explicit statement of God's Messenger?"

They said, "Yes." He continued, "Do you not know that when Khidr damaged the ship, killed the youth and repaired the wall, it displeased Moses son of Imran when the wisdom behind it was hidden from him, yet it was wisdom and correctness in God's sight? Do you not know that there is none among us but that the pledge of allegiance to the tyrant of his time falls upon his neck, except the Qa'im behind whom Jesus son of Mary, the Spirit of God, will pray? Indeed, God will conceal his birth and hide his person so that when he emerges, he will have no pledge of allegiance upon his neck. He is the ninth from the children of my brother Husayn, son of the Mistress of Women.

God will prolong his life during his occultation, then manifest him through His power in the form of a youth of less than forty years, that it may be known that God has power over all things."

The fifth tradition: concerning that which was spoken by Husayn Ali al-Hamadhani, from Ali, from his father, from Abd al-Salam al-Harawi, from Waki ibn al-Jarrah, from al-Rabi ibn Sad, from Abd al-Rahman

ibn Sulayt. Husayn ibn Ali said: “From among us there shall be twelve Mahdis. The first of them is the Commander of the Faithful, Ali ibn Abi Talib, and the last is the ninth from my descendants. He is the Imam who will rise with the truth. Through him God will bring the earth to life after its death, and through him He will cause the religion of truth to prevail over all religion, even though the polytheists may detest it. He will have an occultation during which some people will apostatize while others will remain firm in the religion. These shall be persecuted, and it shall be said unto them: ʿWhen shall the promise be fulfilled, if ye be truthful?’ Verily, he who in the time of his occultation endureth patiently the hurt and the denial shall rank, in the sight of God, as one who fighteth with the sword before the face of the Messenger of God.

The sixth tradition: concerning what Ali ibn Al-Hussein ibn asam narrated from Al-Kulayni from Al-Qasim ibn Ala from Ismail ibn Ali from Ibn Hamid from Ibn Qais from Al-Thumali from Ali ibn Al-Hussein, that he said:

> “Regarding us was this verse revealed: And those who are kindred are nearer one to another in the Book of God,’ and regarding us was revealed this verse: ʿAnd He made it a word enduring in his posterity.’ And the Imamate shall continue in the line of Hussein ibn Ali ibn Abi Talib until the Day of Resurrection. And verily the Qa’im from among us shall have two occultations, one longer than the other. As for the first, it shall be six days, six months and six years. And as for the other, its duration shall be so long that most will abandon this Cause, such that none shall remain firm except those whose certainty is strong, whose knowledge is sound, who find no distress in what We have decreed, and who submit to us, the People of the House.”

The seventh tradition: Concerning that which was spoken by Muhammad ibn Ali al-Baqir: Abd al-Wahid ibn Muhammad, from Abu Umar al-Ya, from Muhammad ibn Masud, from Jibrail ibn Ahmad, from Musa ibn Jafar ibn Wahb al-Baghdadi, and Yaqub ibn Yazid, from Sulayman ibn al-Hasan, from Saad ibn Abi Khalaf, from Maruf ibn Kharbuz, who said: ʿI said to Abu Jafar, “Inform me concerning yourselves.” He said, “We are as the stars: when one star is concealed, another appears—security and peace, submission and faith, an opener and a key—until when the sons of Abd al-Muttalib are equal and none knoweth in whom your Companion shall be made manifest, then shall God, exalted and glorified be He, reveal him. Then praise God, exalted be He, for the best of the hard and the gentle.” I said, “May I be thy ransom—which of the two is chosen?” He said, “He chooseth the hard over the gentle.”’

The eighth tradition: From my father, from al-Himyari, from Ahmad ibn Hilal, from Ibn Abi Najran, from Fadalah, from Sudayr, who said: I heard Abu Abd Allah say: “In the Qa’im is a similarity to Joseph.” I asked whether through life or death. He replied: “What do you deny of this? This nation is like swine. Joseph’s brothers were tribes, children of prophets. They traded Joseph and dealt with him while being his brothers, yet they did not recognize him until Joseph said I am Joseph.’ What does this accursed nation deny that God may choose to conceal His Proof at times? Joseph was king of Egypt while between him and his father was an eighteen days’ journey. Had God wished to make his location known, He had the power to do so.

By God, Jacob and his sons traveled nine days from their home to Egypt upon receiving the good news. What does this nation deny that God may do with His Proof what He did with Joseph—that he may walk

in their markets and step on their carpets while they do not recognize him, until God grants permission for him to make himself known, just as He permitted Joseph when he said Do you know what you did to Joseph and his brother when you were ignorant?' They said Are you indeed Joseph?' He said I am Joseph, and this is my brother."'

The ninth tradition: Concerning that which was spoken by Musa ibn Jafar al-Hamadhani, from his father, from Muhammad ibn Ziyad al-Azdi, who said: I asked my master Musa ibn Jafar, peace be upon him, about the saying of God, exalted and glorified be He: "And He hath lavished upon you His blessings, both outward and inward." As for the apparent bounty, it is the manifest Imam, and as for the hidden bounty, it is the Hidden Imam. I asked him: "Will there be among the Imams one who will be hidden?" He replied: "Yes, his person will be hidden from people's sight, but his remembrance will not be hidden from the hearts of the believers. He is the twelfth among us.

God will make easy for him every difficulty, and make subservient every hardship. He will reveal to him the treasures of the earth, bring near what is distant, and through him distance every stubborn tyrant. He will destroy every rebellious devil. This is the son of the noblest of maidens, whose birth will be concealed from people, and whose name they are not permitted to mention until the Mighty and Glorious makes him manifest. He will then fill the earth with equity and justice as it was filled with oppression and tyranny." Al-Saduq said: "I did not hear this tradition except from Ahmad ibn Ja'far al-Hamdani when returning from pilgrimage to God's Sacred House. He was a trustworthy, religious, and virtuous man—may God's mercy and good pleasure be upon him."

The tenth tradition: Concerning what Ali ibn Musa related from Ali from his father from al-Harawi who said: I heard Di'bil ibn Ali al-Khuza'i say: "I recited to my master Ali ibn Musa ar-Rida my poem which begins: Schools of verses empty of recitation, and places of revelation now desolate.' When I reached the verse: The emergence of an Imam who will inevitably arise, standing by God's name and blessings, distinguishing among us all truth from falsehood, and rewarding for blessings and punishments,' ar-Rida wept intensely, then raised his head to me and said: O Khuza'i, the Holy Spirit has spoken through your tongue in these two verses. Do you know who this Imam is and when he will arise?' I said: No, my master, except that I have heard about the emergence of an Imam from among you who will purify the earth from corruption and fill it with justice as it was filled with oppression.' He said: O Di'bil, the Imam after me is Muhammad my son, and after Muhammad his son Ali, and after Ali his son Hassan, and after Hassan his son the Proof, the Awaited Qaim—obeyed in his appearance and anticipated in his occultation.

If only one day remained in the world, God would lengthen that day until he emerges and fills it with justice as it was filled with oppression. As for when—to specify the time—my father related to me from his father from his forefathers from Ali that the Prophet was asked: O Messenger of God, when will the Qaim from your progeny emerge?' He said: 'His example is like the Hour—none but He shall reveal it in its time. It weighs heavy in the heavens and the earth; it will not come to you but suddenly."'

The eleventh tradition: Concerning what Muhammad ibn Ali al-Jawad said, as related by Muhammad ibn Harun from al-Ruyani from al-Adhim al-Hasani who said: "I entered upon my master Muhammad ibn Ali intending to ask him about the Qaim—whether he is the Mahdi or someone else. He began speaking to me first, saying: O Abu Qasim, indeed the Qaim from among us is the Mahdi who must be awaited during

his occultation and obeyed during his appearance. He is the third from my descendants. By Him Who sent Muhammad with prophethood and distinguished us with the Imamate, if only one day remained of the world, God would lengthen that day until he emerges to fill the earth with equity and justice as it was filled with oppression and tyranny. Indeed God, blessed and exalted is He, will set right his affair in one night just as He set right the affair of His interlocutor Moses when he went to fetch fire for his family and returned as a messenger prophet.' Then he said: The best deed of our followers is awaiting the relief."'

Part 2: "The twelfth tradition: Concerning what Ali ibn Muhammad…"

The twelfth tradition: Concerning what Ali ibn Muhammad al-Hadi al-Hamadani narrated from Ali, from his father, from Ali ibn Sadaqah, from Ali ibn Abdul-Ghaffar, who said: When Abu Ja'far II passed away, the Shi'ah wrote to Abu'l-Hassan (peace be upon him) inquiring about the matter. He wrote back to them:

> "The authority is mine so long as I live. When God's decree comes to pass concerning me, my successor shall come to you. I assure you of a successor after the successor."

The thirteenth tradition: concerning what Al-Hassan ibn Ali Al-Askari (peace be upon him) said, as narrated by Sa'd from Musa ibn Ja'far Al-Baghdadi, who said: I heard Abu Muhammad Al-Hassan ibn Ali say:

> "It is as though I see you falling into disagreement after me concerning my successor. Verily, he who acknowledges the Imams but denies my son is like one who acknowledges all God's Prophets and Messengers but denies Muhammad, the Messenger of God. And he who denies the Messenger of God is like one who denies all the Prophets, for obedience to our last one is like obedience to our first one, and denial of our last one is like denial of our first one. Know that my son shall have an occultation during which people will doubt, except those whom God, the Mighty and Glorious, protects."

The fourteenth tradition: concerning what the Remnant of God said to Ali ibn Ibrahim:

> "I am the Mahdi. I am the Qa'im of the Age. I am he who shall fill the earth with justice as it has been filled with oppression and tyranny. The earth shall never be devoid of a proof, nor shall people remain without guidance longer than the period of the Children of Israel. The days of my appearance have become manifest. This is my trust upon your neck, so relate it to your brethren among the people of truth. Thus do the signs of God and the traditions of His proofs shine forth and become established upon the throne of certainty."

I will now mention to you that which God has willed concerning His manifestation. The traditions of the Imams of truth have come concerning this. Know that he is a righteous successor, whose kunyah is Abu'l-Qasim, and he is the one who shall arise by God's command, the proof of God upon His creation, the remnant from the family of God, and the Mahdi who shall guide people to a hidden matter. I do not wish for anyone to mention his name, as the Imam (peace be upon him) has said: M H M D. Indeed, the texts have come down from that Holy One where he said in his elevated directive: Whoever names me by name in a gathering of people, upon him be God's curse.' And his grandfather Al-Sadiq Abu Abdullah said:

The master of this affair is a man whom none shall name by name except an unbeliever.' The reason for this is that, in the time of his presence—peace be upon him—men sought concerning him what they had sought concerning the Imams of justice; and were the Cause to be made manifest upon earth, there would no longer be fear.

Therefore do I desire that, as his name is uttered in certain supplications, allusions to him be veiled thereby. This is witnessed by those whom God hath acquainted with the mystery of the Names and Attributes.

And now, as to the description of his bodily form—He whose form transcendeth description and likeness—I shall recount seven traditions in seven dawning-places. Their narration is no secret of mine, yet by their mention my heart is illumined. They shall be a sign unto the near ones, a vengeance upon the idolaters, a proof for the faithful, and a parable for those who come after. And upon God, my Lord, do I rely for aid.

The first tradition: concerning that which was related by Ibn Musa, from al-Asadi, from al-Barmaki, from Ismail ibn Malik, from Muhammad ibn Sinan, from Abu al-Jarud, from Abu Jafar, from his father, from his grandfather, who said: 'The Commander of the Faithful said from the pulpit: "A man from among my descendants shall arise in the latter days—fair of complexion with a tinge of redness, broad of belly, wide of thighs, great in the joints of his shoulders. Upon his back shall be two moles: one of the color of his forefather, and the other resembling the mole of the Prophet. He shall have two names—one concealed and one manifest. As for the hidden, it is Ahmad; and as for the manifest, it is Muhammad. When he shall raise his standard, its light shall illumine all between the East and the West. He shall lay his hand upon the heads of the servants, and no believer shall remain but that his heart shall become firmer than solid iron. God shall bestow upon him the strength of forty men. No soul in the grave shall remain but that joy shall enter upon it, and the dead shall visit one another in their tombs and rejoice at the rising of the Qa'im."'

The second tradition: According to what was related by Sa'd from Al-Yaqtini from Isma'il ibn Aban from Amr ibn Shimr from Jabir al-Ju'fi who said: I heard Abu Ja'far say that Umar ibn al-Khattab asked the Commander of the Faithful saying: "Tell me about the Mahdi and his name." He (peace be upon him) replied: "As for his name, my Beloved charged me not to reveal his name until God sends him forth." He asked: "Tell me of his attributes." He said: "He is a young man of medium stature, with a handsome face and beautiful hair that flows over his shoulders. The light of his countenance overtakes the blackness of his beard and hair. He is the son of the choicest of handmaidens."

The Third tradition: According to what was related by Muhammad ibn Hammam from al-Azazi from Abbad ibn Ya'qub from al-Hasan ibn Hammad and from Abu'l-Jarud from Abu Ja'far that he said:

> "The Master of this Cause is the one who is pursued, alone, seeking vengeance for his father, surnamed after his uncle, singular among his family, his name is the name of the Prophet."

The Fourth tradition: According to what was related by Ali ibn Ahmad from Ubaydullah ibn Musa from some of his men from Ibrahim ibn al-Husayn ibn Zahir from Isma'il ibn Ayyash from al-A'mash from Abu Wa'il who said: The Commander of the Faithful Ali looked at al-Husayn and said:

> "This son of mine is a master, as the Messenger of God named him a master, and God will bring forth from his loins a man named after your Prophet. He will emerge when people are heedless, when truth is dead and injustice is manifest. By God, were he not to emerge, his neck would be struck. The inhabitants of the heavens and their dwellers will rejoice at his emergence. He has a broad forehead, an aquiline nose, a large abdomen, and thick thighs. On his right thigh is a mole, and his front teeth are separated. He will fill the earth with justice just as it was filled with oppression and tyranny."

The fifth tradition: concerning that which was related by Ahmad ibn Hawdah, from al-Nahawandi, from Humayd ibn Hamad, from Abu Bakr, from Humran who said: ʿI said to Abu Jafar, "May I be thy ransom! I entered Medina with a pouch at my waist containing a thousand dinars, and I have made a covenant with God that I would spend them at thy door, dinar by dinar, if thou wouldst answer me concerning that which I ask thee." He said, "O Humran, ask, and thou shalt receive an answer—but love not thy dinars." I said, "I adjure thee by thy kinship with the Messenger of God—art thou the Master of this Cause, the One who shall arise therein?" He said, "No." I said, "Then who is he? May my father and mother be thy ransom!" He said, "He is the one of ruddy hue, with fiery eyes, arched brows, broad between the shoulders, with a mark upon his head and a trace upon his face. God have mercy upon Moses!"'

The sixth tradition: concerning that which was related by Abd al-Wahid ibn Abd Allah, from Ahmad ibn Muhammad ibn Riyah, from Ahmad ibn Ali al-Himyari, from al-Husayn ibn Ayyub, from Abd Allah al-Hathami, from Muhammad ibn Issam, from Wahb ibn Hafdh, from Abu Basir, who said: Abu Jafar—or Abu Abd Allah (the uncertainty being from Ibn Issam)—said:

> "The Qa'im shall be known by two signs: a mole upon his head, and a mark of scurf upon his scalp; and a mole between his shoulders, upon the left side beneath the shoulder-blade, fine as the leaf of the myrtle. He is the son of six and the son of the best of handmaidens."

The seventh tradition: concerning that which was related by a group, from al-Tala'kiri, from Ahmad ibn Ali al-Razi, from Muhammad ibn Ishaq al-Muqri, from Ali ibn al-Abbas, from Bakkar ibn Ahmad, from al-Hasan ibn al-Husayn, from Sufyan al-Jariri, from al-Fudayl ibn al-Zubayr, who said: I heard Zayd ibn Ali say that this Expected One is from the progeny of Husayn ibn ʿAli, from the lineage and descendants of Husayn, and he is the wronged one of whom God hath said: "And whoever is slain wrongfully, We have given his heir authority." He said: His heir shall be a man from his progeny, from his descendants. Then he recited: "And He made it a word enduring in his posterity." His authority shall not be excessive in killing.

He said: His authority is His proof over all whom God hath created, such that the proof shall be his over the people, while none shall have any proof against him. And verily those Dawning-Places are mentioned in a radiant light from the Messenger of God where he said—and his word is the truth: "The Mahdi shall be a man from my lineage, his color shall be that of an Arab and his body that of an Israelite. On his right cheek there shall be a mole like unto a brilliant star. He shall fill the earth with justice even as it was filled with oppression. The people of the earth and the people of heaven and the birds shall be well-pleased with his Caliphate."

O thou who asketh! We have indeed illumined thee in those [previous] sections with the lights of the rising Sun that hath shone from the gleaming horizon and hath been illumined by the Most Decisive Name, that which thou seeketh and what the people sought before and shall ask thereafter. Know thou that according to the decree of the Qur'an and the traditions that have descended from the Sun of Utterance, there shall appear a dark, blind and deafening trial before the rising of God's Proof, that those who are to perish may perish and those who are to prosper may prosper. May God have mercy on one who knoweth his worth, who holdeth fast to the Sure Handle and the Greatest Signs and that Momentous News, who turneth not away from the religion of Islam and departeth not from obedience to the Imam.

And now I shall mention unto thee at this juncture a drop from the vast ocean of that dark, blind and deafening trial, and the darkness of that hellish and gloomy well, that thou mayest remember thyself and the souls of the believers, that they may fear God's command and preserve themselves by holding fast to the cord of God. Even thus must the humble ones act.

This is a Dawning-Place that hath risen from the appearance of the Light of Creation, wherein shall appear the signs of newly-created trials. Then after it shall shine forth the dawning splendors of the Sun of Detachment, that all may know God's Cause in its utmost inaccessibility through such a Sun rising in the horizon of ascendancy. And I send blessings upon Muhammad and the family of God so long as light riseth and stars set in the heaven of creation.

The Dawning-Place of God's trials, exalted is He:

> "Do men think that they will be left alone on saying, ʿWe believe', and that they will not be tested? We did test those before them, and God will certainly know those who are true from those who are false."

[Q29:1-2]

And it was related by Muhammad ibn al-Himyari, from his father, from Ayyub ibn Nuh, from al-Abbas ibn Amir, from al-Rabi ibn Muhammad al-Muslim, who said: Abu Abd Allah said to me,

> "By God, you shall be broken as glass is broken! Yet, by God, the glass shall be restored and return as it was. By God, you shall be distinguished, and by God, you shall be tested, and by God, you shall be sifted as the chaff is sifted from the wheat."

And it is related from Ali, from his father, from Muhammad Al-Fadl, from his father, from Mansur who said: Abu Abdullah said:

> "O Mansur, this Cause shall not come unto you except after despair. Nay, by God, not until ye are distinguished! Nay, by God, not until ye are purified! Nay, by God, not until those who are to perish perish and those who are to prosper prosper!"

And it is related from Sa'd, from Ibn Abi Al-Khattab, from Ibn Buzay', from Abdullah Al-Asamm, from Al-Husayn ibn Al-Mukhtar Al-Qalani, from Abd Al-Rahman ibn Sabatah, from Abu ʿAbdullah who said:

> "How can ye remain without a guiding Imam, when some of you shall denounce others. At that time shall ye be distinguished, purified and sifted. And in those days there shall be differences in the years and signs from the beginning of the day."

And it is related from Al-Nasabri from Al-Barufi from Ahmad ibn Idris from Ibn Qutaybah from Ibn Shadhan from Ibn Abi Najran from Muhammad ibn Mansur from his father who said: We were with Abu Abdullah, a group conversing, when he turned to us and said:

> "About what do you speak? Alas, alas! By God, that to which you turn your eyes shall not come to pass except after despair. Nay, by God, that to which you turn your eyes shall not occur until the wretched become wretched and the fortunate become fortunate."

And it is related from Ahmad ibn Idris from Ibn Qutaybah from Ibn Shadhan from Al-Baranti who said that Abu'l-Hasan said: "By God, that to which you turn your eyes shall not come to pass until you are distinguished and purified, and until none remain among you save a few." Then he recited: "Do men think that they will be left alone on saying ʿWe believe', and that they will not be tested?"

And Ali ibn Ahmad relates from Abdullah ibn Musa from Musa ibn Muhammad from Ahmad ibn Abi Ahmad from Ibrahim ibn Hulayl who said: I said to Abu'l-Hasan, "May I be thy sacrifice! My father died believing in this Cause, and I have reached such an age—shall I die without thy telling me aught?" He said: "O Abu Ishaq, thou art hasty." I said: "Yea, by God, I am hasty! And why should I not be hasty when I have reached the age thou seest?" He said: "By God, O Abu Ishaq, this shall not come to pass until ye are distinguished and purified, and until none remain among you save the fewest." Then he made his palm small.

And Ibn Uqdah relates from Al-Qasim ibn Muhammad ibn Al-Husayn from Isa ibn Hashim from Ibn Jabalah from Miskin Al-Rijal from Ali ibn Abi'l-Mughirah from Umayrah bint Nufayl who said: I heard Al-Hasan ibn Ali say:

> "The matter which ye await shall not come to pass until some of you denounce others, until some of you spit in the faces of others, until some of you curse others, and until some of you call others liars."

And Muhammad and Ahmad, the sons of Al-Hasan, relate from their father from Tha'labah from Abu Kahmash from Imran ibn Maytham from Malik ibn Hamzah who said that the Commander of the Faithful said: "O Malik ibn Hamzah, how will it be with thee when the Shi'ih differ thus?"—and he interlaced his fingers. I said: "O Commander of the Faithful, there will be no good in that time." He said: "All good will be in that time, O Malik. At that time our Qa'im shall arise and shall bring forward seventy men who lie against God and His Messenger, and he shall slay them. God shall not unite them in one matter."

And Al-Kulayni relates from several of his companions from Ahmad ibn Muhammad from Mu'ammar ibn Khallad who said: I heard Abu'l-Hasan recite: "Do men think that they will be left alone on saying ʿWe believe', and that they will not be tested?" Then he said to me: "What is the test?" I said: "May I be thy sacrifice! According to us, the test is in religion." Then he said: "They shall be tested as gold is tested." Then he said: "They shall be purified as gold is purified."

And likewise Al-Kulayni relates from Ali ibn Ibrahim from Muhammad ibn Isa from Yunus from Sulayman ibn Salih, traced back to Abu Ja'far Al-Baqir who said: "Verily these traditions of yours make men's hearts recoil. Therefore cast them forth gradually. And whoso draws near to it, increase him, and whoever denies it, leave him. Indeed, there must be a trial in which every intimate one will fall and enter into it, until even those who can split a hair into two will fall into it, until none remain except us and our followers.

And Ahmad ibn Hawzah narrated from Abu Hirasah al-Babili from Ibrahim ibn Ishaq al-Nahawandi from Abdullah ibn Hammad al-Ansari from Sabah al-Muzayyin from al-Harith ibn al-Husayrah from Ibn Banatih from the Commander of the Faithful that he said: "Be like bees among birds—no bird but deems them weak, yet if birds knew what blessings were within them, they would not treat them thus. Mix with people with your tongues and bodies, but separate from them with your hearts and deeds. By Him in Whose hand is my soul, you will not see what you love until some of you spit in the faces of others, until some of you call others liars, until none remain of you"—or he said "of my followers"—"except like kohl in the eye or salt in food.

And I will give you an example: It is like a man who had food, so he cleaned and purified it, then put it in his house and left it there as long as God willed. Then he returned to it and found that weevils had infected it, so he took it out, cleaned and purified it, then returned it to the house. He left it as long as God willed, then returned to it and found that some weevils had infected it again, so he took it out, cleaned and purified it, and returned it. This continued until only a portion remained like a portion of wheat that weevils could not harm at all. Similarly, you will be distinguished until none remain of you except a band that trials cannot harm at all."

Part 3: "And Ibn Uqdah narrated from Ja'far ibn Abdullah…"

And Ibn Uqdah narrated from Ja'far ibn Abdullah al-Muhammadi from al-Tiflisi from al-Samandi from Ja'far ibn Muhammad from his father that he said: "The believers will be tested, then God will distinguish them in His presence. Indeed, God has not secured the believers from the trials and bitterness of this world, but He has secured them from blindness and wretchedness in the Hereafter." Then he said: "Al-Husayn ibn Ali and his companions were killed, piled one upon another, then he said: 'We were killed like the prophets and the family of the prophets were killed.'"

Ibn Uqdah also narrated from Muhammad ibn al-Fadl ibn Ibrahim and Sa'dan ibn Ishaq ibn Sa'id and Ahmad ibn al-Hasan ibn Abdul-Malik, all from Ibn Mahbub from Ishaq ibn Ammar who said: I heard Abu Abdullah saying: "This matter had an appointed time, and it was in the year 140, but you spoke about it and spread it, so God, the Mighty and Glorious, delayed it." Then he said: "O Ishaq, indeed this matter has been delayed twice."

Ali ibn al Husayn narrated from Muhammad al Attar from Muhammad ibn al Hasan al Razi from Muhammad ibn Ali from Ibn Jabalah from Ali ibn Abi Hazim from Abu Basir from Abu Abdullah that he said:

I said to him, "May I be sacrificed for you, when will the Qaim emerge?"

He said: “O Abu Muhammad, we, the People of the House, do not set times. Muhammad has said: ‘Those who set times lie.’

O Muhammad, before this matter there are five signs: the first is the Call in the month of Ramadan, the emergence of the Sufyani, the emergence of the Khurasani, the killing of the Pure Soul, and the sinking of the earth at Bayda.”

Then he said:

> “O Muhammad, before that there must be two plagues—the white plague and the red plague.”

I said:

> “May I be sacrificed for you, what is the white plague and what is the red plague?”

He said:

> “The white plague is rapid death, and the red plague is the sword. And the Qaim will not emerge until his name is called from the midst of the sky on the twenty third night.”

On the night of Friday he said: “How shall he be announced?”

He replied: “By his name and his father’s name. It shall be proclaimed: ‘Such and such son of such and such is the Qaim of the House of Muhammad—so hearken unto him and obey him.’

Not a single thing created by God containing a soul remains but hears the Call, which awakens the sleeper, who then emerges into his courtyard, brings forth the maiden from her chamber, and causes the Qaim to come forth when he hears it—and this is the Call of Gabriel.”

> “When thou knowest the ordinances concerning trials in thy days, then hold fast to the Cord of God and be certain that God’s Cause cannot be hidden and God’s religion cannot be veiled. And no one hath any argument against God, while God’s argument standeth against all the worlds.”

Indeed God hath chosen for the protection of His religion in the days of trials a servant whom none can deny rightfully. The limits descend on the day of his appearance through the tongues of the truthful Imams, that whosoever perisheth should perish by clear proof and whosoever liveth should live by clear proof. When God aided me through His grace with knowledge of wisdom, I turned neither to the traditions of God nor to the lights of the impossibilities of God’s Cause. I possess not books like the learned, for I was a young merchant. But now when I looked at a book containing lights of the Imams of justice, I mention to thee seven traditions in seven dawning-places, each of which sufficeth all people—being clear to the discerning, evident to the diligent, decisive against the stubborn, and protective for the strivers. Upon God, my Lord, do I rely, and He sufficeth me—how excellent a guardian!

The first tradition: concerning that which Ali mentioned explicitly in his sermon, in seven passages thereof. The proof of this is that which came to pass by the decree of God between Jumada and Rajab;

and no man of knowledge can say that this is the sign ordained for the appearance of the Qa'im. For he—peace be upon him—spoke of what would occur thereafter, of the decree of that Cause and of the signs of the Manifestation, whereby the discerning believer, illumined by the light of the Hidden One, shall recognize the truth.

And this is witnessed by those whom God made to behold the creation of the heavens and the earth, then brought into being their own souls. Sufficient indeed is the decree of that sermon as proof to the discerning ones; and what is mentioned in the Bihar contains both an exhortation and a description concerning the book of sermons attributed to our master, the Commander of the Faithful. Upon it is the handwriting of Sayyid Radi al-Din Ali ibn Musa al-Tawus, and it reads as follows:

> "This book was written by one who mentioned two men after al-Sadiq, so it may be that the date of its composition was after the two-hundredth year of the Hijrah, for he had passed away after the year one hundred and forty. Some of what it contains is transmitted from Abi ibn Faraj ibn Firq, from Masad ibn Sadaqah, from Jafar ibn Muhammad; and some of it from others."

In that book referred to, there is a sermon of the Commander of the Faithful called "al-Makhzun" ("The Hidden"). It is as follows—

Praise be to God, the One, the Praised—He Who hath made Himself one in His dominion and exalted Himself by His might. I praise Him for having made known the path of His guidance, inspired us with obedience unto Him, and disclosed to us the hidden depths of His wisdom; for He is to be praised for all that He bestoweth, and thanked for all that He testeth.

I bear witness that His word is justice, and His decree decisive; and that no tongue speaketh the word "was" but that He existed before the "was."

And I bear witness that Muhammad is the servant of God and the chief among His servants—the best of those born of the noblest lineage, the most excellent of those who came later. Whenever God caused creation to be divided into two groups, He placed him among the better of the two. No impurity touched him, nor was he tainted by the unions of the age of ignorance.

Verily God hath sent unto you a Messenger from among yourselves: grievous to him is your suffering, full of concern for you, compassionate and merciful unto the believers. Follow, then, the command of God that hath come unto you from your Lord, and take not other than Him for protectors—how little do ye remember!

For God hath appointed for goodly deeds their people, for truth its foundations, and for obedience its mighty support—through them He guardeth and establisheth His right in whom He pleaseth. He hath set for it summoners and guardians, who preserve it with strength and aid its friends through the portion entrusted to them of God's right.

Now then—verily the spirit of vision is the spirit of life; and no faith availeth save with the Word of God and belief therein. The Word is of the Spirit, and the Spirit is of the Light—the Light of the heavens.

In your hands hath been placed the cord that reacheth unto Him, the sign of His favour and His choice. The blessings of God are such that ye shall never be able to render due thanks for them. He hath singled you out for them, and chosen you for their sake.

> "These are parables We set forth for men, but none understand them save those endued with knowledge."

Rejoice, then, in a victory from God soon to come, and an easy triumph whereby God shall gladden your eyes and remove your grief.

Restrain yourselves from what others strive to take from you, for this is not hidden from you. At every act of obedience ye have aid from God—uttered upon the tongues, confirmed within the hearts. This is the succour of God to His chosen ones, manifest in the gentle workings of His grace.

The tree of life hath borne its branches for the people of piety, and God hath made a distinction between His friends and His enemies—a healing for the hearts and a manifestation of light—whereby God exalteth the people of obedience and abaseth the people of disobedience.

Let every soul, then, make ready its provision for that Day—its provision none other than insight and sincerity of purpose, and the submission of those who are pure in obedience. The scale of deeds is made weighty by wisdom, and wisdom is the judgement of vision against doubt; while disobedience leadeth to the fire—such are not of us, nor unto us, nor with us.

The hearts of the believers are folded upon faith. When God desireth to reveal what lieth within them, He openeth them by inspiration and planteth wisdom therein.

For everything hath an appointed term that it attaineth; God hasteneth not a thing until it reacheth its time and its fulfilment.

Rejoice, then, in the glad tidings ye have been given; acknowledge the offering that hath been brought nigh unto you; and hasten to claim the promise vouchsafed unto you.

Verily among us is a pure invocation through which God shall make manifest His conclusive proof, perfect His former bounty, and bestow His surpassing grace.

Whoso holdeth fast unto it hath grasped a portion of His wisdom; through His mercy hath God brought it unto you. From His mercy is the light of hearts; by it He hath lifted from you the burden of sin, hastened the healing of your breasts, rectified your affairs, and bestowed upon you a lasting salutation of peace—whereby ye shall remain secure throughout the cycles of time and within the abiding dwellings of the wombs.

For God hath chosen for His Faith a people whom He hath set apart for its upholding and its defense. Through them was made manifest the word of Islam, and by them were sustained the guardians of the Qur'an and the enjoiners of obedience, in the Easts of the earth and its Wests.

Then did God single you out for Islam and elect you unto it, for it is the name of peace and the sum of honour. God hath chosen its path, made clear its proofs, exalted its unity, and adorned it with His praise.

He hath made it pleasing as He hath described it, set forth its qualities, revealed its degrees, confirmed its covenant, both outward and inward—sweetness and security together.

Whoso attaineth to its outward form beholdeth the wonders of its vistas in their sources and returns; and whoso perceiveth its inward depths beholdeth the hidden treasures of wisdom and the marvels of its parables and ordinances. Its exterior is fair, and its interior profound—its wonders unending, its mysteries unfailing.

Within it are the springs of bounty and the lamps that scatter darkness. None unlock the treasuries of good save by its keys, and none dispel the shadows save by its lights. Within it are distinctions and connections, and the clarification of the two supreme Names which are united and made one—names that are known when pronounced, described when revealed, joined in perfection, each complete in the other.

Their course is established in their appointed stations. They have stars, and above their stars are stars beside them, guarding their sanctuary and tending their pastures. In the Qur'an is the exposition of it, its limits, its pillars, and the measures of what is stored in its treasuries and weighed in its balance—the balance of justice and the judgment of decision.

The heralds of the Faith have distinguished between doubt and certainty, and have brought forth manifest truth. They have expounded Islam with clarity, laid for it firm foundations and enduring pillars, and borne witness to it with proofs and signs—tokens sufficient for the seeker and healing for the one who thirsts for knowledge.

They guard its sanctuary, call to its pastures, preserve what is to be preserved, shun what is to be shunned, and love what is to be loved, by the decree of God and through His bounty and His mighty command and remembrance.

They are united by mutual devotion, meeting in the beauty of speech, drinking from the cup of reflection, tending one another with loving care, with hearts pure and natures noble, in peace serene—wherein no baseness is tasted nor backbiting permitted.

Whoso hideth aught contrary to this concealeth a trait of nobility, but hath severed his bond and exchanged his abode for abasement, breaking a covenant entrusted to him, and a pledge sealed upon him in righteousness and piety and in preferring the path of guidance.

Upon this foundation were they created; in this brotherhood were they joined. By it they love one another, and through it they are united. They are as a field of grain: its growth endures, some of it is reaped, and some remains; what perishes He reneweth by election, and what endureth He perfecteth by purification.

Seize, then, the opportunity of His command during the brevity of its days and the shortness of its stay in its dwelling, before He transfer it to another abode and changeth its condition. Blessed is he whose heart is pure, who obeyeth him that guideth him, and shunneth that which leadeth him astray; he shall enter

the abode of honour and attain the path of peace, seeing with clear vision and obeying the Guide of his command.

Verily, the most excellent guidance and the lifting of the veil of ignorance that misleads and distracts lie herein. Whoso desireth to ponder or to remember, let him examine his thought, and go forth into the light of guidance while its gates are yet open and its means yet accessible.

Let him accept the counsel of him who adviseth in humility and reverent submission, in the safety of Islam and under the call of perfection.

Peace—enduring peace—be upon the humble and the lowly, who vie with one another in faith and are united in the justice of the Balance. Let him receive this command and this honour with acceptance, and beware lest the calamity strike before its appointed time.

For our Cause is verily a mighty and momentous one—none can bear it save an angel near unto God, a prophet sent, or a servant whose heart God hath tested with faith.

It is a tradition safeguarded within impregnable strongholds, within faithful breasts, within minds steadfast and tranquil.

O wonder of wonders! All wonder between Jumada and Rajab!

Then a man from among the troops of the Thursday guard said, “What is this wonder, O Commander of the Faithful?”

He replied,

> “How should I not marvel, when the decree of God hath already gone forth among you, and yet you understand it not?”

The second tradition: concerning the tradition mentioned in that book, from the Messenger of God, from God—exalted be He—wherein He alluded to it through the signs that shall appear before the Return, in His exalted words regarding the coming forth of a man from the lineage of Husayn ibn Ali.

God knoweth His own intent, while I know not a single letter thereof. But as for the rising, what I understand of it is the rising through wisdom and proof, and none other. Whoso interpreteth it otherwise, I am not of his kind.

Verily, God, His angels, and His chosen ones are free from the liars and the falsifiers who seek to sow discord without right—these are indeed the wrongdoers.

The third tradition: concerning the tradition of the servants who hold fast to the Cause of God—these are the ones who shall attain salvation.

And it was related by Ibn al-Mutawakkil, from al-Asadi, from al-Barmaki, from Ali ibn Uthman, from Muhammad ibn al-Furat, from Thabit ibn Dinar, from Said ibn Jubayr, from Ibn Abbas, that the Messenger of God said: “Ali ibn Abi Talib is the leader of my community and my successor over them after me. From

his lineage will come the Promised Qa'im, through whom God, mighty and glorious, will fill the earth with justice and equity just as it had been filled with tyranny and oppression. By Him Who sent me with the truth as a bearer of glad tidings, those who remain steadfast in their belief in him during the time of his occultation will be more precious than the rarest red sulfur." Then Jabir ibn Abdullah al-Ansari stood up and asked: "O Messenger of God, will there be an occultation for the Qa'im from your progeny?" He replied: "Yes, by my Lord! And God will surely test those who believe and destroy the deniers. O Jabir, this is a matter from God's matters and a mystery from His mysteries, concealed from His servants. Beware of doubting God's matter, for that is absolute disbelief."

Part 4: "The Fourth tradition concerns what Ali indicated…"

The Fourth tradition concerns what Ali indicated in his sermon and speech, wherein the people of understanding recognize some aspects of the matter, and verily unto our Lord do we return. Mas'ada ibn Sadaqa related: I heard Abu Abdullah Ja'far ibn Muhammad say that the Commander of the Faithful delivered a sermon to the people in Kufa. He praised and glorified God, then said: "I am the master of the elderly, and in me is a likeness to Job. God will gather my family for me just as He gathered Jacob's scattered household. This will happen when the celestial sphere completes its rotation and you say, 'He has died or perished.' Nay, clothe yourselves beforehand with patience and turn to God in repentance.

You have indeed cast aside your holiness, extinguished your lamps, and entrusted your guidance to one who possesses neither hearing nor sight for himself or for you. Weak indeed is both the pursuer and the pursued. Had you not neglected your affair, had you not failed to support the truth among you, and had you not weakened in subduing falsehood, those who are not your equals would not have grown bold against you, nor would the strong have risen against you to usurp authority and remove it from its rightful possessors among you. You have become lost as the Children of Israel became lost in the time of Moses. I tell you truthfully, your wandering after me and the persecution of my offspring will be twice that of the Children of Israel's wandering.

"If you have completed your drinking and been filled to satiation from the authority of the accursed tree mentioned in the Qur'an, you have indeed united against us in misguidance and hastened to falsehood. Then you made excuses to the caller of truth, cut off the nearest of the people of Badr, and connected with the most distant of the sons of the first wars. What they possessed has melted away. The time of trial for recompense has drawn near, the cover has been removed, the period has ended, the promise has approached, the star has appeared to you from the East, and your moon has risen full as in the middle of the month and its night.

> "When this becomes clear, then return in repentance and cast off sin. Know that if you obey the one who rises from the East, he will lead you on the path of God's Messenger. Then you will be cured of deafness, healed of muteness, spared the burden of hardship and seeking, and the heavy weight will be cast off your necks. God casts none far off except those who reject mercy and abandon protection. Those who wrong will come to know what fate they will meet."

Also, the Commander of the Faithful said from the pulpit of Kufa: “Behind you are dark, blind, and eclipsing trials from which none will be saved except the sleeper.”’ Someone asked, “O Commander of the Faithful, what is the sleeper’?” He replied: “The one who knows the people while they know him not. Know that the earth is never void of God’s proof, but God will blind His creation to him because of their oppression, tyranny, and their excesses against themselves. If the earth were to remain without God’s proof for a single hour, it would swallow its inhabitants. But the proof knows the people while they know him not, just as it was with Joseph.” The people know yet deny Him. Then He recited: “Alas for the servants! There cometh not a messenger unto them but they mock at him.”

The Fifth tradition concerns what Abu Abdullah indicated regarding the manifestation of their Cause before the rising of the Qa’im, as related by Abd al-Wahid ibn Abdullah from Ahmad ibn Muhammad ibn Riyah from Ahmad ibn Ali al-Himyari from Husayn ibn Ayyub from Abd al-Karim al-Khath’ami from Muhammad ibn Isam from al-Mufaddal ibn Umar who said: I was with Abu Abdullah in his gathering along with others when he said we should not make mention, meaning of the name of the Qa’im. I saw he intended others besides me, then he said to me: “O Abu Abdullah, beware of making mention. By God, he shall remain hidden for years until it will be said he died or perished or which valley did he traverse.

The eyes of the believers shall overflow with tears for him and he shall be tossed about as a ship is tossed upon ocean waves until none shall be saved except those with whom God made His covenant and inscribed faith in their hearts and strengthened them with a spirit from Him. And twelve ambiguous standards shall be raised such that none can distinguish one from another.” I wept, and he said: “What makes you weep?” I said: “May I be sacrificed for you! How can I not weep when you say twelve ambiguous standards shall be raised such that none can distinguish one from another?” He looked toward a window in the house through which the sun was shining in his gathering and said: “Is this sun bright?” I said: “Yes.” He said: “By God, our Cause is brighter than it.”

The Sixth tradition concerns what Abu’l-Hujjah and his son (peace be upon them) indicated to those who understand the signs in their words and are rightly guided thereby. It is mentioned in the book Al-Mukhtasar by al-Hasan ibn Sulayman, student of the Martyr (may God’s mercy be upon them both), who said it was reported that there was found in the handwriting of our master Abu Muhammad al-Askari what follows: “We have ascended the realities with the feet of prophethood and guardianship…” until he said: “And the springs of life shall be established for them after the flames of fire, upon completion of Alif Lam Mim and Ta Ha and the Ta Sins in years.” And his son (may my soul be his sacrifice) said in his noble pronouncement which I shall mention God willing in that book thereafter, until he said: “When Jumada al-Ula comes in this year of yours, take heed of what occurs therein and awaken from your slumber for what shall happen in that which follows it.

And there shall occur in the land of the East that which brings grief and anxiety. And thereafter groups of Islam shall dominate Iraq, deviating ones whose evil deeds shall restrict provisions for its people. Then time shall be relieved after that by the destruction of a tyrant from among the wicked ones, at whose destruction the righteous God-fearing ones shall rejoice. And there shall occur for those intending pilgrimage from distant lands what they hope for regarding the respect of their predominance and agreement. And We have a role in facilitating their veils according to their choice and accord—a matter

that shall appear in order and meeting. So let each one of you do what brings him closer to Our love and avoid what brings him near to Our dislike and anger, for Our Cause shall come suddenly, unexpectedly, when repentance shall not benefit nor shall regret for sin save from Our punishment. And God inspires you with guidance and graces you with success through mercy."

The Seventh tradition concerning the mention of servants whom God shall send before the rising of the Qa'im to seek vengeance for Husayn, as related by the group from Sahl from Ibn Shamun from al-Asamm from Abdullah ibn al-Qasim al-Batal from Abu Abdullah regarding the words of the Most High:

> "And We decreed for the Children of Israel in the Book: Ye shall work corruption in the earth twice"

[Q17:4]. He said: The killing of Ali ibn Abi Talib and the stabbing of Hasan, and ye shall surely exalt yourselves with great pride. And he said: Husayn was slain. When the promise of their first comes to pass, when help comes for Husayn's blood, we shall raise against you servants of Ours of terrible might who will enter your very homes—a people whom God will send before the appearance of the Qa'im, who will not leave any enemy of Muhammad's family unless they slay them. This was a promise fulfilled. The appearance of the Qa'im: Then We gave you back the turn to prevail over them. The return of Husayn with seventy of his companions wearing gilded armor, each helmet having two faces, making known to the people that this is indeed Husayn returned, so that the believers will not doubt that it is he and not an impostor or devil. And the Proof will be manifest among them. When recognition is firmly established in the hearts of the believers that it is indeed Husayn, the Proof will come. It will be Husayn ibn Ali who will wash him, shroud him, prepare him, and bury him in his presence, for none but a successor can attend to a successor.

When these signs become confused, and the explicit meaning of these traditions cannot be determined, I have revealed to you a drop from the esoteric knowledge. Beyond these traditions are many signs, as spoken in the words mentioned in an ancient book, which is this: Know that sovereignty is cut off—command belongs to God, the Bestower of blessings and bounty. God has distinguished him with signs, sent to creation, both white and black. Beyond these signs are horizonal signs that cannot be hidden, universal signs that cannot be counted, mystical indications that cannot be mentioned, and traditions from the pure Imams that cannot be enumerated.

I have not seen anything beyond what I have mentioned to you, but I heard in a tradition referring to him that in his voice is laughter. Then in another tradition that he intended a matter and God caused change to occur twice, and on the third time decreed what God willed for him. And in a tradition mentioned in the Book of the Perfection of Religion and Completion of Grace, al-Sadiq said, exalted be his remembrance:

> "It is as if I see the Qa'im on the pulpit of Kufa, surrounded by three hundred and thirteen men, the number of the companions of Badr. They are the people of authority and they are God's rulers over His creation on His earth, until he brings forth from his standing a book sealed with a golden seal—a covenant from God's Messenger. Then they will scatter from him like sheep scatter, until none remain with him except the vizier and eleven chiefs, as remained

with Moses son of Imran. They will roam the earth and find no refuge from him, so they will return to him. By God, I know the words he will speak to them, at which they will reject him."

But since I see no mention for myself nor any significance to my existence, I do not know the reality of my affair nor am I certain about what God has willed in these revealed traditions. But I am certain between myself and God my Lord that I desire nothing but God's religion, and that God has honored me with His blessing as He willed, how He willed. And I, despite my weakness, harm, inability and poverty, wish to manifest the religion of God's Messenger through what God has revealed in the Qur'an and what is confirmed by the traditions of the People of the Bayan through this blessing, if God so wills and desires. These signs suffice as a reminder and proof for you and the believers.

And as I have mentioned some ordinances of the days of the Qa'im, I will mention, God willing, some signs of his return and after his return, and the return of his chosen forefathers in three manifestations. And upon God my Lord do I rely, and to Him does all command return. Glory be to Him, exalted is He above what they describe. When you witness the lights of justice, know that in your Ancient Master is fulfilled some of the traditions of the Prophets and Messengers. For the reflections in a mirror cannot appear except by what is in the mirror itself, and thus have descended the tidings from the Suns of Light.

And I shall mention to thee a beautiful account that may affect thy heart concerning what Al-Sadiq (peace be upon him) did and said, as related in Al-Kafi by Muhammad ibn Ali ibn Hatim, from Ahmad ibn Isa Ali Al-Rida Baghdadi, from Ahmad ibn Tahir, from Muhammad ibn Yahya ibn Sahl, from Ali ibn Harith, from Sa'd ibn Mansur, from Ahmad ibn Ali Al-Basri, from his father, from Sudayr Al-Sayrafi who said:

"I entered, along with Mufaddal ibn Ali, Abu Basir, and Aban ibn Taghlib, upon our master Abu Abdullah. We found him sitting upon the earth, wearing a rough Khaybari cloak with no collar, shortened at the sleeves. He was weeping as one bereft of his child, with a heart consumed by grief. Sorrow had transformed his cheeks, and change was manifest in his countenance, tears flowing from his eyes, as he was saying:

"'My Master! Thy disappearance hath banished my sleep, narrowed my resting place, and deprived my heart of its ease. My Master! Thy disappearance hath joined my calamity with the calamities of eternity. The loss of one after another hath dispersed our gathering and our number. How sweet the tear that riseth within Mine eyes! How soothing the moan that issueth from My breast—both ascending from the bird of affliction and the locks of calamity, emblematic of the most grievous trials, the most piercing tribulations, and the sorest misfortunes, mingled with Thy wrath, O Lord, and compounded with Thy displeasure.'

"Sadir saith: 'our reason was confounded, our hearts were rent with anguish at that dread calamity and that overwhelming event; we deemed it the token of some ominous misfortune, some far-reaching woe that Time had brought to pass.' Then I said:"May God not cause thine eyes, O son of the Best of men, to weep! For what happening dost thou shed such tears and pour forth such sorrow? What event hath enjoined upon thee this mourning and lamentation?"

"Thereupon al-Sadiq heaved a sigh so deep that his breast was expanded, and fear seized his soul, and he exclaimed: Woe betide you! This very morn I gazed into the Book of Jafr—that Book which containeth the

knowledge of destinies and tribulations, of afflictions past and to come, even unto the Day of Resurrection—a Book which the Almighty, exalted be His Name, hath entrusted to Muhammad and to the Imams after him. In it I contemplated the birth of our Qa'im, His concealment, His long delay, and the trials that shall afflict the faithful in those days—the doubts that shall arise within their hearts by reason of the length of His absence, and the apostasy of the greater part of them, who shall cast away from their necks the bond of Islam, of which God, glorified be His remembrance, hath said: And every man—We have fastened his fate upon his neck' [Q17:13], meaning the Covenant of allegiance. Thereupon tenderness overcame Me, and sorrow held sway over My heart. Then we said: O son of the Apostle of God! Thou hast honoured and ennobled us by sharing with us somewhat of that which thou knowest.'

"He replied: 'Verily God—blessed and exalted be He—hath ordained in our Qa'im three mysteries which He likewise ordained in three of His Messengers. His birth resembleth the birth of Moses; His concealment, that of Jesus; and His prolonged absence, that of Noah; and He hath appointed thereafter the life of the righteous servant, meaning Khidhr, as a sign of His own enduring life.'

"Then I said: 'Disclose unto us, O son of the Apostle of God, the meanings of these mysteries.'

"He said: 'As to the birth of Moses: when Pharaoh was apprised that the downfall of his dominion would be brought about by his hand, he commanded that the soothsayers be assembled, and they informed him of his lineage—that he would arise from among the Children of Israel. Whereupon Pharaoh ceased not to order his minions to rip open the bellies of the pregnant women of that people, until he had slain in his quest for him more than twenty thousand newborns; yet he failed to reach Moses due to God's protection of him. Likewise, when the Umayyads and Abbasids discovered that their kingdom and the authority of their princes and tyrants would end at the hand of our Qa'im, they showed enmity toward us and drew their swords to slay the Messenger of God and exterminate his lineage, hoping thereby to kill the Qa'im. But God refuses to reveal His Cause to any oppressor until He perfects His light, though the polytheists may abhor it.

"'As for the occultation of Jesus, both Jews and Christians agreed that he was killed, but God, exalted be He, denied their claim with His words:"They did not kill him, nor did they crucify him, but it appeared so unto them." [Q4:157] Similarly with the occultation of the Qa'im, for the people deny it. Some, without guidance, say he was never born; others claim he was born and died; others disbelieve, saying our eleventh was childless; some err in saying it extends to thirteen or more; while others disobey God, exalted be He, claiming the spirit of the Qa'im speaks through another form.

Part 5: "'As for Noah's delay, when he called down…"

"'As for Noah's delay, when he called down punishment upon his people, God sent the Faithful Spirit with seven date stones, saying:"O Prophet of God, the Blessed and Exalted God says to you: 'These are My creatures and servants, and I will not destroy them with My thunderbolt except after confirming the Call and completing the proof. Return and strive in your calling with your strength, for I shall reward you for it. Plant these date stones, for in their growth, maturity, and fruition lies your relief and deliverance.' So give glad tidings to the believers who follow you." When the trees grew, flourished, branched, matured, and

bore fruit after a long time, he sought God's promise. God commanded him to plant from the stones of those trees, to renew his patience and effort, and to complete the proof against his people.

He informed his believing followers of this, but three hundred men apostatized, saying, "If what Noah claims were true, there would be no breach in his Lord's promise." God continued to command him to replant each time, until he had planted seven times. Groups of believers continued to apostatize, one after another, until only seventy-some men remained. Then God revealed to him: "Now dawn has broken from night before your eyes, as truth has emerged in its purity, and the matter of faith has been cleansed of impurity through the apostasy of those of wicked nature. I shall destroy the unbelievers and keep those who apostatized from the groups that had believed in you, for I had previously promised the sincere believers among your people who held fast to the cord of your prophethood that I would make them successors in the earth, establish their religion, and transform their fear into security, so that worship would be purely for Me with doubt removed from their hearts.

How could succession, establishment, and the transformation of fear into security come from Me to them, when I knew the weakness of certainty in those who apostatized, the wickedness of their nature, and the evil of their inner thoughts, which were the products of hypocrisy and the occurrence of error? Had they but inhaled a breath of that dominion which shall be bestowed upon the faithful at the hour when I appoint them as My vicegerents, after the destruction of their foes, they would have perceived the fragrances of His attributes. Yet their inmost hypocrisy would have waxed firm, the phantoms of error in their hearts confirmed; they would have unveiled their enmity toward their brethren, contending with them for primacy and dominion, and striving to claim for themselves alone the right to command and forbid.

How, then, could establishment in the Faith or the diffusion of the Cause among the believers be possible amidst the tokens of sedition and the outbursts of war? Nay, rather—"Build thou the Ark beneath Our eyes and through Our inspiration."'

"Al-Sadiq—peace be upon him—said: 'Even so shall it be with the Qa'im. The days of His concealment shall be prolonged, that pure truth may be distinguished from falsehood, and faith be purified from hypocrisy—through the defection of all whose clay is of evil nature, among those of the Shi'ah whose hearts would be seized by hypocrisy were they to perceive the signs of succession, establishment, and the universal security that shall prevail in the day of the Qa'im.'

"Mufaddal said: O son of the Messenger of God, the Nawasib claim this verse was revealed about Abu Bakr, Umar, Uthman and Ali.' He replied: May God not guide the hearts of the Nawasib! When was the religion which God and His Messenger approved firmly established with security spreading among the community, fear departing from their hearts, and doubt being lifted from their breasts during the time of any of these? And Ali's time saw the apostasy of Muslims, seditions arising in their days, and wars breaking out between the unbelievers and them.' Then al-Sadiq (peace be upon him) recited: 'Until when the apostles despaired and thought they were denied, Our help came to them.'

> "As for the righteous servant Al-Khidr, verily God the Blessed and Exalted did not lengthen his life for any prophetic mission ordained for him, nor for any Book to be revealed to him, nor for

any Law to abrogate the Laws of previous Prophets, nor for any Imamate requiring His servants to follow it, nor any obedience made obligatory to him. Rather, since God the Blessed and Exalted knew beforehand what He would ordain regarding the age of the Qa'im during his occultation, and knew how His servants would deny such longevity, He lengthened the life of this righteous servant without any necessary cause except as evidence for the age of the Qa'im, thereby cutting off the argument of the obstinate ones, lest people have any argument against God."

When you consider what was revealed about him, know that he had two occultations by God's permission. A number of people whose count none knows save God were in his presence. In the Lesser Occultation he had trusted representatives and close deputies. Its duration was completed in seventy years and forty days numbered. In those days his deputies (may my soul be his sacrifice) were: Uthman ibn Sa'id al-ʿAmri, his son Abu Ja'far Muhammad ibn Uthman, the trusted Shaykh Abu'l-Qasim Husayn ibn Ruh, then Ali ibn Muhammad as-Samarri. During his Lesser Occultation they were the sources of command and prohibition, and the Shi'ihs referred to them regarding divine ordinances and holy matters emanating from the sacred quarter. Whoever did not accept them and denied them was an infidel by the explicit text of the Proof.

In their days some human-like creatures fabricated lies against God and His friends by claiming their station through attributing themselves to the Imam, the Remnant of God (may my soul be his sacrifice). The first of them was Al-Hasan ash-Shari'i, then Muhammad an-Numayri, then Hilal al-Karkhi, then Muhammad al-Bilali, then Husayn al-Hallaji, then Muhammad ash-Shalmaghani—may God punish them as they deserve according to God's Book. Indeed edicts were issued to the designated gates and curses from the Remnant of God upon the fabricators. The mention of those blessed edicts regarding the transgressing opponents suffices as evidence for the perfect believers.

Although wondrous signs appeared from the four gates, and from the imposters grievous iniquities, yet in the Book of God they are not equal to a single letter from the resplendent epistles radiating with the light of glory, for one letter thereof is greater in the sight of those who stand upon the heights than all the miracles to the transgressors and all retributions to the slanderers. And I hereby mention three of the holy missives regarding the truth of the Four and the refutation of those who slander their rights, and these suffice as proof for those who remember.

The first epistle which issued forth from the sacred precincts concerning Uthman ibn Sa'id and his son—and it is a epistle from him (peace be upon him) that came through al-Amri and his son, related by Sa'd ibn Abdullah. Shaykh Abu Abdullah Ja'far, may God be pleased with him, said: "I found it written in Sa'd ibn Abdullah's handwriting: May God grant you success in obeying Him and make you steadfast in His religion and make you happy through His good pleasure."'

"We have received what you both mentioned about al-Maythami informing you of al-Mukhtar and his debate with whom he met, and his argument that there is no successor other than Ja'far ibn Ali, and his verification of him. I understood all that your companions wrote about him. I seek refuge with God from blindness after sight, from misguidance after guidance, from ruinous deeds and devastating trials. For verily He, glorified and exalted be He, says: Do men think that they will be left alone on saying"We

believe", and that they will not be tested?' [Q29:1-2] How they fall into trial and waver in perplexity, going right and left! Have they apostatized from their religion, or are they in doubt, or do they oppose the truth, or are they ignorant of what has come through truthful traditions and authentic reports? Or do they know this but choose evil? How poorly they understand! Indeed the earth is never devoid of a proof—whether manifest or concealed. Do they not know the succession of their Imams after their Prophet (peace be upon him), one after another, until by God's command the matter passed to al-Madi—meaning al-Hasan (peace be upon him).

Then he arose in the station of his forefathers, guiding unto the truth and unto a straight path. He was as a shining light, a radiant moon. God, exalted and glorified be He, chose for him that which was with Him; thus did he pass away upon the path of his forebears, step for step, faithful to the covenant he had bound and to the testament he had entrusted to his successor—whom God, exalted be He, concealed by His command until an appointed time, veiling his abode according to His will, in fulfillment of the foreordained decree and the irrevocable destiny.

"His station abideth among us, and his excellence pertaineth to us. And were God, exalted be He, to permit that which He hath restrained, and to remove the ordinance which He hath decreed, He would assuredly reveal unto them the truth resplendent, adorned with the fairest of vestures, manifest with the clearest of proofs and the most luminous of signs; He would disclose His own identity and stand forth with His testimony. But the decrees of God, exalted be His glory, may not be contended with, nor His will opposed, nor His succor outstripped.

> "Let, then, the followers of vain desire renounce their passion, and let them stand fast upon the foundation whereon they once stood. Let them not pry into that which God hath veiled from them, lest they bring upon themselves remorse; nor rend asunder the covering which God, exalted be He, hath drawn over His secret. Let them know assuredly that the truth is with us and within us. None uttereth this save a liar and a forger; none claimeth it save one who is astray and deluded. Let them, therefore, content themselves with this brief allusion, without seeking explicit declaration, and be satisfied with intimations rather than with plain disclosure—if God so willeth."

The second epistle that shone forth from the sacred precinct was addressed unto Abu'l-Qasim al-Husayn ibn Ruh, and it is as follows:

> "Know thou—may God prolong thy days, make thee acquainted with every good, and seal thy deeds therewith—that among those of our brethren in whom thou confidest in faith and findest repose in companionship, may God perpetuate their felicity, is Muhammad ibn Ali, known as al-Shalmaghani—may God hasten upon him His retribution—has apostatized from Islam and departed from it, transgressing the bounds of God's religion. He has made claims through which he has disbelieved in the Creator, Mighty and Exalted. He has fabricated falsehoods and lies, and spoken great calumny and grave sin. Those who equate others with God have lied and strayed far astray, incurring manifest loss. We disavow him before God the Exalted and His Messenger and his family—may God's blessings, peace, mercy and benedictions be upon them. We curse him with successive curses, outwardly and inwardly,

> secretly and openly, at all times and in all conditions, and likewise those who follow him and support him. When our declaration reaches anyone who continues to maintain allegiance to him thereafter, know that our position regarding him is like our position regarding his predecessors among his like, such as al-Shari'i, al-Numayri, al-Hilali, al-Bilali and others. God's way—exalted be His praise—before and after remains beautiful to us. In Him we trust, His aid we seek, He suffices us in all our affairs and is the best Guardian."

The third epistle concerning what shone forth from the Sun of Eternity and appeared upon the temple of Ali ibn Muhammad al-Samari is as follows:

> "O Ali ibn Muhammad al-Samari! May God increase the reward of your brothers concerning you, for indeed you shall die within six days. So gather your affairs and do not appoint anyone in your position after your death. For indeed the complete occultation has begun, and there shall be no appearance except after God's permission, exalted be His remembrance. And that will be after a long time when hearts become hardened and the earth becomes filled with injustice. And there shall come from among my followers those who claim to have seen me. Behold, whoever claims to have seen me before the appearance of the Sufyani and the Sacred Cry is a lying impostor. There is no might nor power except through God, the Exalted, the Great."

When you recognize the station of the Gates, know with certainty that they only attained their station through obedience to him—may my soul be his sacrifice. Know that after recognizing him, even common people are greater than the elite, for he himself kindles the fire of love for knowing and obeying him. After the command and the divine appointment, he endured. Undoubtedly, those specifically designated by his authority during the Greater Occultation are those about whom God spoke and about whom he—may my soul be his sacrifice—said (and his word is truth):

> "Have you not read the word of God, Mighty and Glorious: ʿAnd We placed between them and the towns which We had blessed, towns easily visible.' [Q34:18] By God, we are the towns which God has blessed, and you are the visible towns."

There is no doubt that for every Proof of God there must needs be an emissary, as hath been uttered by the son of the fifth Imam. The station of him who speaketh by His command is clearly set forth in the traditions, wherein it is recorded—and His word is truth—"Look ye unto one among you who hath transmitted Our sayings and pondered Our lawful and Our forbidden. Accept him, then, as your judge, for I have appointed him as ruler over you. Whosoever rejecteth his judgment, when he judgeth according to Our decree, hath verily treated with disdain the judgment of God, and hath turned away from Us; and he that turneth away from Us hath turned away from God Himself, and such a one is verily as one who joineth partners with God."

They are the keepers of the Faith, the summoners unto knowledge. But for them, none would arise to champion the Cause of God; and these are they who shall attain salvation.

As to those who, in the time of the Greater Occultation, assert before men that whoso claimeth to have seen Him hath lied—they have indeed spoken falsely, if in truth they speak falsehood. Yet if God so

willeth, none may gainsay His decree, nor may any turn back His command. None shall recognize Him save he whom God willeth thereafter—though there have been those aforetime, as hath been recorded and transmitted by Majlisi in his book, whose accounts none may repudiate.

Once, while I was in the Sacred Mosque, standing near the House of God by the Yemeni corner at the hour of afternoon prayer, I beheld a youth of medium stature and radiant countenance, seated upon the ground beneath the place where men circumambulate the House, facing the Yemeni corner in an attitude of reverence and humility. His gaze was fixed upon the Kaaba; he turned not toward any man, nor did I see anyone near him. Upon his head was a white turban like unto that worn by Persian merchants, and over his shoulders a woolen cloak such as is used by men of distinction among traders. Yet in him there shone an awe, a majesty, a dignity, and a light that words cannot tell.

Between us were but a few paces, the number of which I know not. What stirred within my heart, God alone knoweth. Shame withheld me from drawing near unto his presence, and I busied myself with prayer. I said within my soul:

> "If he be indeed the One I seek, he will summon me unto his presence."

Yet my heart was melted with yearning, and my limbs trembled with fear.

When I had finished my prayer, I looked again—but he was no longer in his place. I walked through the precincts of the Sacred Mosque, yet nowhere could I espy his form. What then stirred within me, God knoweth best. During all the days I sojourned in Mecca, by day and by night, I cast my gaze in every direction, hoping once more to behold him. But God permitted it not.

Nor do I claim with certainty that I beheld him, for I know not what God intended thereby. Perhaps it was not he in outward form, but that through the vision my heart might be quickened with remembrance of that exalted station, and that my love for his Cause might be renewed. For assuredly, whoso attaineth unto true knowledge of him is one who holdeth a high station in his sight, as was explicitly affirmed in the rescript revealed concerning al-Mufid—may God hallow his resting-place.

And now I shall make mention, in this connection, of four letters, that they may serve as a glory to the sincere, an honor to the beholders, a token to the faithful, and a word unto the rest. Upon God, my Lord, I call for aid—at all times, ere time began and after time shall end.

The first letter concerneth that which was revealed and shone forth from the effulgence of the Sun of the sacred precinct, regarding the believers who have acknowledged the oneness of God—Abu'l-Shaykh al-Jalili, may the mercy of God be upon him—that all might recognize from that exalted rescript the lofty station of those believers who judge by the leave of God, who follow the command of God, and who stand in awe before the justice of God. It is this: Mention is made of a letter that came forth from the sacred precinct—may God guard and exalt it—in the latter days of the month of Safar, in the year four hundred and ten, addressed unto Shaykh al-Mufid, Abu Abd Allah Muhammad ibn al-Nu'man—may God sanctify his spirit and illumine his resting place. The bearer related that he had received it from a place connected with the Hijaz. Its copy was addressed to the faithful brother and righteous guardian, Shaykh

al-Mufid, Abu Abd Allah Ja'far ibn Muhammad ibn al-Nu'man—may God prolong his glory—from the repository of the Covenant taken upon His servants.

Part 6: "In the name of God, the Most Compassionate…"

"In the name of God, the Most Compassionate, the Most Merciful.

"Now then—peace be upon thee, O thou who art devoted to the Faith, distinguished among us by certitude. We praise before thee God—there is no God but He—and beseech Him to send His blessings upon our Lord and Master, our Prophet Muhammad, and upon his pure and stainless kindred.

"We inform thee—may God perpetuate thy success in championing the Cause of Truth, and abundantly reward thee for speaking on our behalf with sincerity—that leave hath been granted us to honor thee by correspondence, and to entrust thee with that which thou shalt convey from us to our beloved ones in thy region—may God strengthen them in obedience to Him, protect them by His care, and guard them beneath His shelter.

"Stand thou, therefore—may God aid thee through His might against His rebellious foes—upon what we now make known unto thee, and fulfill in conveying it to those whom thou trustest what we here enjoin, God willing.

"Though we dwell apart, far removed from the habitations of the oppressors, as God the Exalted hath shown us what is meet for our welfare and for that of our faithful followers—so long as the dominion of this world remaineth in the hands of the wicked—yet our knowledge encompasseth your affairs, and naught of your conditions is hidden from us.

"We are fully aware of the afflictions that have befallen you since many among you have inclined toward that from which the righteous of former times kept far aloof, and have cast behind their backs the covenant that had been taken from them, as though they knew it not.

"Know that we are neither heedless of your care nor forgetful of your remembrance. But for our watchful regard, tribulation would have befallen you, and your enemies would have utterly destroyed you.

"Therefore, fear God, exalted be His glory, and aid us against your own offspring in the trial that hath drawn near unto you—a trial in which he whose term hath come shall perish, and he whose hope endureth shall live. This is a sign of the nearness of Our movement and of your separation from Us by Our command and prohibition. God will assuredly perfect His light, though the polytheists detest it.

"Take firm hold of dissimulation [taqiyyah], lest the fire of ignorance, kindled by the kindling of Umayyad passions, should consume you. It is I who pledge salvation for all who keep aloof from its hidden places and tread the path of prudence and restraint.

"When Jumada al-Ula of this year hath come, take heed of what shall occur therein, and awaken from your slumber for that which shall follow it. There shall appear to you from heaven a manifest sign, and from the earth another like unto it. In the lands of the East there shall arise that which will bring grief;

thereafter shall factions apostatize from Islam and prevail over Iraq, so that by their evil deeds the livelihood of its people shall be straitened.

“Then shall the distress be lifted through the downfall of a tyrant from among the ungodly—whose destruction shall rejoice the righteous and the pious. And for those who seek to perform the pilgrimage from distant lands, there shall be ease and fulfillment, through the overcoming of their hardships and the spending of their wealth. For Us, in the facilitation of their pilgrimage among the chosen and the steadfast, there shall appear a matter wondrously ordered and harmonious.

“Let each of you, then, act in such manner as may draw him nearer to Our love, and avoid whatsoever would estrange him from Our pleasure and expose him to Our wrath. For he who delayeth his repentance until the hour cometh when repentance shall avail him not, and remorse for sin shall deliver him not from Our chastisement—verily, he shall find no escape.

“May God inspire you with right guidance and favor you with the blessings of His grace and mercy.

“A copy of this letter, written by the exalted hand—upon its possessor be peace—is our letter unto thee, O brother beloved, loyal in devotion, sincere in affection, and steadfast in support.

“May God guard thee with His eye that sleepeth not. Keep this writing safe; show it not to any who may covet the sight of Our script, nor reveal its contents save to those in whom thou dost repose thy trust. Charge them all to act in accordance therewith, if God so willeth.

“And may the blessings of God rest upon Muhammad and his pure family.”

The second letter, concerning what has shone forth from the lights of the Holy Region as a remembrance for the monotheists and retribution for the slanderers who claim authority without right—and these are the liars. And it is this:

“In the Name of God, Most Merciful, Most Compassionate

“Thy letter hath reached me—may God preserve thee—and likewise the writing that thou didst forward with it. My knowledge hath encompassed all that it contained, despite the diversity of its words and the repetition of its expressions. Hadst thou pondered it well, thou wouldst have discerned some of what I discerned therein. Praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds—praise that hath no partner—for His bounty toward us and His grace upon us. God, exalted be He, refuseth to leave the truth unperfected or falsehood unvanquished. He is witness over me concerning what I declare, and over you concerning what I say, when we are gathered for the Day whereof there is no doubt, and He shall question us regarding that wherein we differed.

“Verily, the author of that letter hath not been granted, over him to whom it was written—nor over thee, nor over any among mankind—any divinely ordained leadership, obedience, or covenant. Yet I shall set forth for you a covenant sufficient unto you, if God so willeth.

“O thou, may God have mercy upon thee: God, exalted be He, created not the creation in vain, nor abandoned them to futility. Rather, He created them by His power, and bestowed upon them hearing,

sight, hearts, and reason. Then He sent unto them prophets as bearers of glad-tidings and as warners, commanding them to obey Him, forbidding them to disobey Him, and teaching them what they had been ignorant of concerning their Creator and their faith.

“He revealed unto them a Book, and dispatched angels between Him and those whom He had sent, bearing His grace unto them. He granted them manifest proofs, luminous evidences, and lofty signs. Among them were those for whom He made the fire cool and safe; among them, those with whom He spoke directly; among them, those whose staff He turned into a serpent plain to see; among them, those who revived the dead by God’s permission and healed the blind and the leper by His leave; among them, those to whom He taught the language of the birds and who were given of all things.

“Then He sent Muhammad as a mercy unto the worlds, perfected through him His bounty, and sealed through him His prophets. He sent him unto all mankind, and manifested through him tokens of truth, signs and evidences beyond count. Then He took him unto Himself—praised, beloved, and well-pleased—and appointed the charge after him to his brother, his cousin, his legatee and heir, Ali ibn Abi Talib. Thereafter the authority passed to the appointed successors from among his descendants, one after another, whereby God revived His religion and completed His light.

“He established between them and their brothers, their cousins, and their near kindred a clear distinction, whereby the proof is known from the one proved against, and the Imam from the one led—inasmuch as He preserved them from sin, purified them from defilement, freed them from fault, and cleansed them from all uncleanness. He made them the treasurers of His knowledge, the repositories of His wisdom, and the dwelling-place of His mystery. He strengthened them with signs and proofs, that men might not be left alike, nor might every claimant pretend to the authority of God. For had it not been for these tokens, none could distinguish truth from falsehood or the learned from the ignorant.

“But this deceiver and imposter hath falsely attributed to God that which he hath claimed. By what right or merit doth he hope that his claim should stand? Is it by knowledge of the Faith of God? By God, he discerneth not lawful from unlawful, nor distinguisheth error from righteousness. Is it by learning? He knoweth not truth from falsehood, nor the decisive from the ambiguous, nor the limits of prayer and its times. Is it by piety? God beareth witness that he hath abandoned the prescribed prayer for forty days, alleging sorcery as his pretext. Perchance his tidings have already reached you—of his drunken assemblies and his open rebellion against the Almighty.

“If he possess a sign, let him produce it; if a proof, let him establish it; if an evidence, let him bring it forth. God, exalted be He, hath said in His Book:

“‘In the name of God, the Most Compassionate, the Most Merciful. Ha Mim. The revelation of the Book is from God, the Mighty, the Wise. We created not the heavens and the earth and all that is between them save in truth and for an appointed term; yet those who disbelieve turn away from that wherewith they are warned. Say: “Show me what those whom you invoke beside God have created of the earth, or have they a share in the heavens? Bring me a Book before this, or some remnant of knowledge, if you are truthful.” Who is more astray than he who calls, apart from God, upon one who answers him not till the

Day of Resurrection, and who is heedless of their call? And when mankind are gathered together, they shall be their enemies and shall disown their worship.' [Q46:1–6]

"Take, therefore, from this—may God grant thee success—the measure I have set forth for thee. Test him concerning the verses of God's Book: can he interpret them? Ask him regarding a prescribed prayer: can he expound its limits and its obligations? Thus shalt thou know his state and his measure, and his falsehood and deficiency shall be made plain to thee.

"God is his reckoner. God hath preserved the truth for its people and established it in its appointed seat. He hath forbidden that the Imamate should be in two brothers after Hasan and Husayn. When God permitteth us to speak, the truth shall be made manifest, falsehood shall vanish, and its shadow shall be lifted from you.

"Unto God I turn for sufficiency, for gracious bounty, and for guardianship. God is sufficient for us, and excellent is He as a protector.

"And may the blessings of God be upon Muhammad and the family of Muhammad."

The third letter concerns the status of men who were honored by meeting the Qa'im during the Lesser Occultation. God knows their number, and I shall mention one of them that it may be a remembrance for the longing ones and an honor for those who draw nigh. And praise be to God, Lord of the worlds.

"And concerning what was mentioned, Al-Husayn Ali ibn Musa ibn Ahmad ibn Ibrahim ibn Muhammad ibn Abdullah Musa ibn Ja'far ibn Muhammad ibn Ali ibn Al-Husayn ibn Ali ibn Abi Talib related to us, saying: I found in my father's book—may God be pleased with him—and Muhammad ibn Ali ibn Mahziyar related to us, saying:"I heard my father say: I heard my grandfather Ali ibn Mahziyar say: I was sleeping in my bed when I saw in a dream someone saying to me: Perform the pilgrimage this year, for you shall meet the Master of your age."'

'Ali ibn Mahziyar said: "I awoke joyful and happy, and remained in prayer until the dawn broke. When I completed my prayer, I went out asking about the pilgrims and found a group preparing to depart. I hastened to join the first to leave, and continued thus until they departed and I departed with them, heading for Kufa. When I arrived there, I dismounted from my riding beast and entrusted my belongings to reliable brothers and went out inquiring about the family of Abu Muhammad. I continued thus but found no trace nor heard any news.

'I left with the first group departing for Medina. When I entered it, I could not help but dismount from my riding beast and entrust my belongings to reliable brothers and went out asking for news and following traces, but heard no news nor found any trace. I continued thus until people departed for Mecca, and I left with those who departed until I reached Mecca. I dismounted and secured my belongings, then went out asking about the family of Abu Muhammad, but heard no news nor found any trace.

'I remained between despair and hope, contemplating my affair and reproaching myself. Night had fallen and I wanted the face of the Ka'bah to be empty so I could circumambulate it and ask God to make known to me what I sought therein. While I was thus, and the face of the Ka'bah had become empty for

me, I stood to perform the circumambulation, when behold, I saw a youth with a beautiful face and sweet spirit, wearing a cloak draped with another, who had wrapped his cloak around his neck.

I approached him and he turned to me saying: “Where is the man from?”

I said: “From Ahwaz.”

He asked: “Do you know Ibn al-Khatib there?”

I replied: “God’s mercy be upon him, he was called and he answered.”

He said—may God have mercy upon him—“Verily, by day he was one who fasted, and by night one who stood in prayer, reciting the Qur’an, devoted to us in loyalty.”

ʿHe then asked, “Art thou Ali ibn Mahziyar?”

ʿI replied, “I am.”

ʿHe said, “Welcome, welcome, O Abu’l-Hasan! Knowest thou the two sanctuaries?”

ʿI said, “Yea.”

ʿHe asked, “And who are they?”

ʿI answered, “Muhammad and Musa.”

ʿHe said, “And what of the token between thee and Abu Muhammad?”

ʿI replied, “It is with me.”

ʿHe said, “Bring it forth.”

So I brought forth a fair ring, upon the stone of which was engraved Muhammad,’ and upon the other side ʿAli.’

ʿWhen his eyes fell upon it, he wept long and bitterly, saying:

> “May God have mercy upon thee, O Abu Muhammad! Thou wert indeed a just Imam, son of Imams, father of an Imam. May God cause thee to dwell in the highest paradise beside thy forefathers.”

ʿThen he said,

> “O Abu’l-Hasan, return to thy lodging and make ready for the journey. When one-third of the night hath passed and two-thirds remain, come thou unto us—for then shalt thou attain thy desire.”

ʿI, Ibn Mahziyar, turned back to my tent, my heart fluttering with eagerness. When the appointed time drew near, I rose, prepared my mount, loaded my packs, and set forth. When I reached the mountain pass, lo, the youth was there awaiting me.

ʿHe said,

> “Welcome, O Abu’l-Hasan! Blessed art thou, for thou hast been granted permission.”

Then he set forth, and I went with him.

ʿWe journeyed past Arafat and Mina until we reached the lower slopes of Ta’if. There he said, “O Abu’l-Hasan, alight, and make ready for prayer.”

ʿHe descended, and I descended with him. When he had finished his prayer, and I mine, he said, “Prepare now for the dawn prayer.”

ʿHe turned his face toward a certain direction, gave the greeting of peace, and then bowed his face to the earth in prostration. Thereafter he mounted, and bade me mount also.

ʿWe continued our journey until we ascended the summit. Then he said, “Look! What dost thou see?”

ʿI looked, and beheld a verdant plain, abounding in grass and herbage. I said, “My master, I see a meadow rich in greenery.”

ʿHe asked, “And what is upon its height?” I looked again, and behold—a sandhill stood there, upon which was pitched a black tent, radiant with light.

ʿHe said, “What seest thou?”

ʿI replied, “I behold such and such.”

ʿHe said,

> “O Ibn Mahziyar, rejoice and be at peace, for there lieth the hope of every hopeful soul.”

ʿThen he said, “Come, let us go with light,” and he went on and I went with him, until we reached the foot of the hill.

ʿHe said, “Dismount—for here every hardness is made soft.”

ʿSo he dismounted, and I dismounted. Then he said, “O Ibn Mahziyar, loosen the bridle of thy camel.”

ʿI said, “Unto whom shall I leave her? There is none here.”

ʿHe answered,

> “This is a sanctuary: none entereth it save a friend of God, and none departeth from it save a friend of God.”

ʿSo I let go the bridle, and followed him. When we drew near to the tent, he went before me and said, “Wait here until thou art granted leave.” After but a brief moment, he came forth saying, “Blessed art thou, for thy desire hath been granted.”

Part 7: "'I entered into his presence, and found him…"

ʿI entered into his presence, and found him seated upon a cushion, resting against a red leather pillow. I offered my salutations, which he returned, and I beheld his countenance, which was like unto a segment of the moon—neither rough nor impetuous, neither excessively tall nor diminutive. He was of medium stature, with a broad forehead, arched eyebrows, and deep black eyes. His nose was aquiline, his cheeks smooth, and upon his right cheek was a mole. When I gazed upon him, my mind was overwhelmed by his attributes and description.

ʿHe said unto me, "O son of Mahziyar, how didst thou leave thy brethren in Iraq?" I replied, "In straitened circumstances and affliction, for the swords of the sons of Shaysaban have been wielded against them in succession." He said, "May God destroy them! How deluded they are! It is as though I see these people slain in their own homes, with the decree of their Lord overtaking them by night and by day."

ʿI said,

> "When shall this come to pass, O son of the Messenger of God?"

ʿHe replied, "When ye are barred from the road to the Kaaba by a people who have no portion in God—of whom God and His Messenger are quit—and when redness appeareth in the sky, covering a third thereof, with pillars of silver-like light gleaming therein.

ʿ"Then shall the Shardisi arise from Armenia and Azerbaijan, seeking beyond Rayy the Black Mountain, yoked with the Red Camel, near the mountains of Talqan. Between him and the Marwazi there shall be a mighty battle, fierce as thunder, wherein the child shall turn grey and the old shall perish; slaughter shall rage between them.

ʿ"When these things are fulfilled, expect thou his appearance in the land of Zura. Yet he shall not remain there long before he arriveth at Mahan, and thereafter at Wasit of Iraq, where he shall abide six days or less. Then he shall go forth to Kufan, and between Najaf and Hira and al-Fara there shall be a great and dreadful battle that shall confound all reason.

ʿ"Then shall both hosts be laid waste, and unto God shall belong the harvest of those who remain."

Then he recited: In the name of God, the Most Compassionate, the Most Merciful. Our command came by night or by day, and We made them as a harvest mown down, as though they had not flourished yesterday.

I said,

> "My master, O son of the Messenger of God, what is meant by Our command'?"

ʿHe replied,

> "We are the command of God, exalted be His glory, and His hosts."

ʿI said,

> “My master, O son of the Messenger of God—hath the hour come?”

ʿHe answered, “The Hour hath drawn nigh, and the moon hath been rent asunder.”“

The fourth letter concerns the mention of servants who saw the Qa’im during his Greater Occultation. And I, for My part, shall make mention of one among them—that it may serve as a remembrance unto those who remember, an honor unto those who are assured, and a proof unto the doubters who utterly deny the possibility of such nearness, even among those specially chosen and drawn unto His presence. Sufficient indeed is the account of Mir Shams al-Din, which alone standeth as a remembrance for the faithful. And praise be to God, Lord of the Worlds.

This is what was related to me by some virtuous and reliable scholars. He said: I was informed by someone I trust, who relates from someone he trusts, who said:

ʿWhen Bahrain was under European rule, they appointed a Muslim man as governor to develop it and improve its people’s condition. This governor was from the Nawasib (enemies of Ahl al-Bayt), and he had a minister who was even more hostile, showing enmity to the people of Bahrain for their love of Ahl al-Bayt, seeking to harm and destroy them by every means.

ʿOne day the minister entered upon the governor carrying a pomegranate, which he gave to the governor. Written on it was “There is no god but God and Muhammad is the Messenger of God; Abu Bakr, Umar, Uthman and Ali are the caliphs of God’s Messenger.”

ʿThe governor examined it and saw the writing was inherent to the pomegranate in a way that seemed impossible to have been made by human craft. He was amazed at this, and the minister said:

> “This is a clear sign and strong proof invalidating the Rafidi (Shi’a) doctrine. What do you think about the people of Bahrain?”

ʿHe replied:

> “May God guide you. These people are fanatics who deny proofs. You should summon them and show them this pomegranate. If they accept and return to our doctrine, you will have great reward. But if they insist on remaining in their misguidance, give them three choices: either pay the jizya tax in humiliation, or provide an answer about this clear sign which they cannot escape from, or their men will be killed, their women and children taken captive, and their property seized as spoils.”

ʿThe governor approved his opinion and sent for the scholars, virtuous ones, noble elites and righteous sayyids of Bahrain. He brought them in, showed them the pomegranate, and informed them of what would happen if they did not provide a satisfactory answer—death, captivity, seizure of property, or paying the jizya tax in humiliation like non-believers.

ʿThey were bewildered by the matter, could not provide an answer, and their faces changed color. Their limbs trembled, and their leaders said:

> “O Prince, grant us three days’ respite that we might bring you an answer that will satisfy you, or else judge us as you will.”

ʿHe granted them respite, and they left his presence, fearful, terrified, and bewildered. They gathered in council and deliberated on the matter, and agreed to select ten of the most pious and ascetic men of Bahrain. This they did, then from the ten they chose three.

ʿThey said to one of them:

> “Go out tonight into the desert and worship God there, and implore our Imam, God’s proof over us, that he might show you a way out of this overwhelming calamity.”

ʿHe went out and spent his night in devoted worship, humbly calling and weeping, beseeching God and imploring the Imam until morning, but saw nothing. He returned and informed them.

ʿOn the second night they sent the second man, but he returned like his companion with no good news, which increased their anxiety and distress.

ʿThey then brought forward the third man, who was pious and virtuous, named Muhammad ibn Isa. He went out on the third night, barefoot and bareheaded into the desert on a dark night. He prayed, wept, and besought God the Exalted to deliver these believers and remove this trial from them, and he implored his master.

ʿToward the end of the night, a man addressed him saying:

> “O Muhammad ibn Isa, why do I see you in this state, and why have you come out to this wilderness?”

ʿHe replied:

> “O man, leave me be, for I have come out for a momentous matter and grave concern which I will mention only to my Imam and complain of only to one who can remove it from me.”

ʿThe man said:

> “Yes, you have come out concerning what troubles you about the pomegranate, what was written on it, and what the prince threatened you with.”

ʿWhen I heard this, I turned to him and said:

> “Yes, my master, you know what has befallen us, and you are our Imam and our refuge, capable of removing this from me.”

ʿHe said: “O Muhammad ibn Isa, the minister—may God curse him—has a pomegranate tree in his house. When that tree bore fruit, he fashioned something from clay in the shape of a pomegranate, split it in two, wrote some of that writing inside each half, then placed it on the pomegranate while it was small and bound them to it, causing it to grow thus.

‘”When you go to the governor tomorrow, tell him you have brought the answer but will only reveal it in the minister’s house. When you go to his house, look to your right and you will see a chamber. Tell the governor you will only answer in that chamber. The minister will refuse this, but insist upon it and accept nothing less than ascending to it. When he ascends, go up with him and do not let him go ahead of you alone. When you enter the chamber, you will see a niche containing a white bag. Go to it and take it—you will find in it that clay model he made for this deception. Place it before the governor with the pomegranate in it to expose his trick.

‘”Also, O Muhammad ibn Isa, tell the governor we have another miracle: this pomegranate contains only ashes and smoke. If you wish to verify this, order the minister to break it, and when he does, the ashes and smoke will fly onto his face and beard.”

‘When Muhammad ibn Isa heard this from the Imam, he rejoiced greatly, kissed before the Imam, and returned to his people with glad tidings and joy. When morning came, they went to the governor, and Muhammad ibn Isa did everything the Imam had commanded him. And all that he foretold came to pass.

‘The governor turned to Muhammad ibn Isa and asked him, “Who informed you of this?”

‘He replied, “Our Imam of the Age and God’s proof upon us.”

‘The governor asked, “And who is your Imam?” So he informed him of the Imams one after another until he reached the Master of the Command.

‘The governor then said,

> “Extend your hand, for I bear witness that there is no god but God and that Muhammad is His servant and messenger, and that the immediate successor after him was the Commander of the Faithful, Ali.”

‘He then acknowledged the Imams to their last one, and his faith became pure. He ordered the minister to be executed, apologized to the people of Bahrain, showed them kindness and honored them. It is said that this story is well-known among the people of Bahrain, and the tomb of Muhammad ibn Isa is known there, visited by people.’

And I shall mention, after what I have previously mentioned, fourteen traditions regarding those manifestations concerning the signs of the Return and what comes before and after it, that it may serve as a reminder for all who remember. If you desire detailed signs, look to the Sermon of Gathering composed by Ali, for I found in those heavens in the treasury of the Ridvan.

The first tradition, regarding what Majlisi related, where he said that traditions have come mentioning signs of the time of the rising of the Qa’im, the Mahdi, and events that will occur before his rising, and signs and indications:

Among them are the emergence of the Sufyani, the killing of the Hasani, and the dispute among the Abbasids over worldly kingdom; the eclipse of the sun in the middle of Ramadan and the eclipse of the moon at its end contrary to normal occurrences; the sinking of the earth in Bayda, in the West, and in the

East; the sun standing still from noon until mid-afternoon, its rising from the West; the killing of the Pure Soul behind Kufa along with seventy righteous men; the slaughter of a Hashimite man between the Corner and the Station; the destruction of the wall of the Kufa mosque; the approach of black standards from Khurasan; the emergence of the Yamani; the appearance of the Maghribi in Egypt and his taking control of it; the descent of the Turks upon the Peninsula; the arrival of the Romans in Ramlah.

There shall also be the rising of a star in the East, shining like the moon, then bending until its ends nearly meet; redness appearing in the sky spreading across its horizons; a fire appearing in the East for a long time, remaining in the air for three days and seven nights; the Arabs throwing off their reins and taking control of the lands and their exit from Persian rule; the people of Egypt killing their leader; the destruction of Syria and the dispute of three standards therein; the entry of the standards of Qays and the Arabs into Egypt and the standards of Kindah into Khurasan; the arrival of cavalry from the West until they are tethered in the courtyard of Hirah; the approach of black standards from the East towards it; the bursting of the Euphrates until water enters the streets of Kufa.

There shall arise sixty imposters, each claiming prophethood, and twelve from the family of Abu Talib, each claiming the Imamate for himself. A man of great status from among the Abbasid partisans shall be burned between Jalula and Khafiqayn; a bridge shall be constructed adjacent to Karkh in the City of Peace; a black wind shall rise there at the beginning of the day, and an earthquake shall strike until much of it sinks; fear shall encompass the people of Iraq and Baghdad, and widespread death shall overtake them, along with a decrease in wealth, lives, and fruits.

Locusts shall appear in and out of season until they consume crops and yields; growth shall be scarce in what people plant; conflict shall erupt between two Persian factions, and much blood shall be shed between them; slaves shall rebel against obedience to their masters. Their masters shall slay them, and some of the people of innovation shall be transformed into apes and swine; slaves shall gain dominion over the lands of their lords; and a call shall resound from heaven which all the people of earth shall hear, each in their own tongue.

A face and chest shall appear to mankind in the eye of the sun; the dead shall be raised from their graves until they return to this world, recognizing and visiting one another. Then this shall be sealed with twenty-four consecutive rains that shall revive the earth after its death; its blessings shall be known, and thereafter every affliction shall be removed from the true believers among the followers of the Mahdi.

They shall then recognize His appearance in Mecca and shall turn towards Him to aid Him, as the traditions have foretold. Among these events, some are inevitable and some are conditional, and God knows best what shall come to pass. We have mentioned them according to what is established in the principles and contained in the transmitted traditions. In God do we seek help.

In the second tradition, it is related from Ali ibn Ahmad from Ubaydullah ibn Musa from Muhammad ibn Musa from Ahmad ibn Ahmad from Yaqub ibn Siraj who said: I asked Abu Abdullah: “When will relief come to your followers?” He said: “When the children of Abbas differ and their authority weakens, and those who had no designs upon them become covetous of their power, and the Arabs cast off their reins, and every possessor of might displays his might, and the Sufyani and Yamani appear, and the Hasani

moves, the Master of this Cause shall emerge from Medina to Mecca with the heritage of the Messenger of God." I asked: "What is the heritage of the Messenger of God?" He said: "His sword, his armor, his turban, his mantle, his staff, his horse, his shield, and his saddle."

In the third tradition, Ibn Uqdah relates from Humayd ibn Ziyad from Ali ibn al-Sabbah from Abu Ali al-Hasan ibn Muhammad from Jafar ibn Muhammad from Ibrahim ibn Abdul-Hamid from Abu Ayyub al-Kharraz from Muhammad ibn Muslim from Abu Jafar al-Baqir who said: "The Sufyani is red, blonde, blue-eyed, has never worshipped God, and has never seen Mecca or Medina. He shall say: 'O Lord, my vengeance! My vengeance! O Lord, my vengeance! My vengeance!"'

In the fourth tradition, it is related through his chain from Uthman ibn Isa from Bakr ibn Muhammad al-Azdi from Sadir who said: Abu Abdullah said to me: "O Sadir, stay in your house and remain seated among those who sit, and be still as long as the night and day are still. When you hear that the Sufyani has emerged, then come to us, even if you must crawl." I said: "May I be sacrificed for you, will there be anything before that?" He said: "Yes," and pointed with three fingers toward Syria and said: "Three banners: a Hasani banner, Umayyad banners, and a Qaysi banner. While they are thus, the Sufyani shall emerge and mow them down like the harvest—never have I seen the like of it."

In the fifth tradition, it is related from Abdul-Ala al-Halabi who said: Abu Jafar said: "The Master of this Cause shall have an occultation in one of these mountain passes"—or he pointed toward the direction of Dhi Tuwa—"until two nights before his emergence, when the master who shall be before him shall go forth until he meets some of his companions and asks them: How many of you would there be if your Master were to come to you?' They shall reply: By God, if he were to take refuge in the mountains, we would take refuge with him.' Then he shall come to them in the afternoon and say to them: 'Point out to me your elders and your informed ones, ten of them.' They shall point them out to him, and he shall take them until they come to their Master, and he shall promise to meet them the following night."

Then Abu Jafar said:

> "By God, it is as if I can see him, having placed his back against the Stone, then adjuring God by his right, then saying: 'O people! Whosoever disputes with me concerning God, verily I am the nearest of all people to God. O people! Whosoever disputes with me concerning Adam, I am the nearest of all people to Adam. O people! Whosoever disputes with me concerning Noah, verily I am the nearest of all people to Noah. O people! Whosoever disputes with me concerning Abraham, verily I am the nearest of all people to Abraham. O people! Whosoever disputes with me concerning Moses, verily I am the nearest of all people to Moses. O people! Whosoever disputes with me concerning Jesus, verily I am the nearest of all people to Jesus. O people! Whosoever disputes with me concerning Muhammad, verily I am the nearest of all people to Muhammad. O people! Whosoever disputes with me concerning the Book of God, verily I am the nearest of all people to the Book of God.' Then he proceeds to the Station where he offers two prostrations, then beseeches God for his right."

Part 8: "Then Abu Ja'far said: "By God, he…"

Then Abu Ja'far said:

> "By God, he is the distressed one mentioned in God's Book, where God says: ʿOr, Who answers the distressed one, when he calls upon Him and removes the evil, and He makes you successors in the earth.' And Gabriel shall be at the Balance in the form of a white bird, and he shall be the first of God's creation to pledge allegiance to him, followed by the three hundred and thirteen men."

Abu Ja'far said: "Whosoever is tried in the journey shall meet him in that hour, and whosoever is not tried by the journey shall be taken from his bed." Then he said: "By God, this is the meaning of Ali ibn Abi Talib's words concerning those who will be missing from their beds, and it is God's words: Vie, then, with one another in good works. Wheresoever ye be, God will bring you all together.' These are the companions of the Qa'im, the three hundred and thirteen men." He said: "By God, they are the numbered community mentioned by God in His Book: If We delay the penalty for them until a numbered community.' He said they shall be gathered in a single hour like autumn clouds."

Then he shall cry out in Mecca, calling people to the Book of God and the tradition of His Prophet. A small group shall respond to him, and he shall appoint a governor over Mecca. Then he shall depart, but news shall reach him that his governor has been killed, so he shall return to them and slay the fighters, adding nothing more to that—meaning no captives. Then he shall proceed, calling people to the Book of God and the tradition of His Prophet and allegiance to Ali ibn Abi Talib and disavowal from his enemies, not naming anyone specifically, until he reaches Al-Bayda'. The army of Sufyani shall come against him, but God shall command the earth to seize them from beneath their feet. This is the meaning of God's words: If thou couldst see when they shall be seized with fear, but there shall be no escape, and they shall be seized from a place nearby. And they shall say, "We believe in him"'—meaning the Qa'im of the House of Muhammad—though they had rejected him before'—meaning the Qa'im of the House of Muhammad—to the end of the verse.

None shall remain of them except two men called Watr and Ruwaytrah from Murad, their faces turned backward as they walk backwards, informing people of what befell their companions. Then he shall enter Medina, and at that time the Quraysh shall hide from him, taking a single position. They shall be slaughtered group after group, with all they possess and all that the sun rises or sets upon.

Then he shall cause an event, and when he does this, the Quraysh shall say:

> "Let us go out against this tyrant. By God, if he were truly of Muhammad's lineage he would not do this, and if he were truly of Ali's lineage he would not do this, and if he were truly of Fatima's lineage he would not do this."

Then God shall give him power over them, and he shall slay the fighters and take captive the offspring.

Then he shall proceed until he reaches Al-Shaqrah, where news shall reach him that they have killed his governor, so he shall return to them and inflict such a slaughter that the massacre of Harrah shall seem as nothing in comparison.

Then he shall proceed, calling people to the Book of God and the tradition of His Prophet and allegiance to Ali ibn Abi Talib and disavowal from his enemies, until when he reaches Tha'labiyyah, a man from his own father's lineage shall stand against him, being one of the strongest in body and bravest in heart save for the Master of this Cause, and he shall say:

> "O you! What is this that thou doest? By God, thou art scattering the people as scattered cattle! Hast thou, then, a covenant from the Messenger of God, and by what token?"

The Master to whom the allegiance hath been sworn shall reply,

> "By God, I shall either bring them to obedience, or smite the place where thine eyes now rest!"

The Qaim will then say,

> "Silence, O so-and-so! Yea, by God, I bear with Me a covenant from the Messenger of God. Bring hither that man, that I may take from him the pledge of allegiance."

Then they bring him the covenant from the Messenger of God. Then he says: "May God make me your sacrifice! Let me kiss your head." So he offers his head, and he kisses between his eyes. Then he says: "May God make me your sacrifice! Renew for us the pledge of allegiance." So he renews their allegiance.

Abu Ja'far said: "It is as if I see them ascending from Najaf of Kufa, three hundred and some ten men, their hearts like blocks of iron. Gabriel is on his right and Michael on his left, with awe proceeding before him. They are martyrs whom God will support with five thousand marked angels, until they ascend Najaf." He said to his companions: "Worship during this night of yours." So they spend the night between bowing and prostrating, beseeching God. When morning comes, he says: "Let us take the road to Nukhayla." Around Kufa there is a dug trench. I said: "A dug trench?" He said: "Yes, by God, until he reaches the mosque of Ibrahim in Nukhayla and prays two rak'ahs there. Then God will expel those in Kufa from among its deserters and others from the army of the Sufyani." He says to his companions: "Draw them out!" Then he says: "Attack them!" Abu Ja'far said: "By God, not one of them shall cross the trench to tell the tale."

Then he enters Kufa, and no believer remains except that he is in it or inclines toward it. This is the saying of the Commander of the Faithful, Ali. Then he says to his companions: "March against this tyrant!" They call to the Book of God and the tradition of His Prophet. The Sufyani offers him allegiance peacefully, but a dog who is among his maternal uncles says to him: "What is this you have done? By God, he will never pledge allegiance to you on this basis!" He says: "What shall I do?" They say: "Face him and he will accept you." Then the Qa'im says to him: "Take care, for I have fulfilled my duty to you and now I shall fight you." He cries out and fights them, but God grants them victory over him. They capture the Sufyani and he slaughters him with his own hand.

Then he sends a detachment of cavalry to the Romans to bring forth the remaining Umayyads. When they reach Rome, they say: “Hand over to us our co-religionists who are with you.” They refuse, saying: “By God, we shall not do it!” The detachment says: “By God, if we were ordered, we would fight you!” Then they return to their master and present this to him. He says: “Go and bring forth their companions to them, for these have come with great authority.” This is the word of God: “When they perceived Our might, behold, they ran from it. Run not! Return to that wherein you lived at ease, and to your dwellings, that you might be questioned.” [Q21:12-13] He said this means the treasures they were hoarding. They said: “Woe to us! We were indeed wrongdoers!” That remained their cry, until We made them as reaped corn, extinct. Not one of them remains to tell the tale.

Then he returns to Kufa and sends the three hundred and some ten men to all horizons. He strokes between their shoulders and they never tire in judgment. No land remains except that there is proclaimed in it the testimony that there is no god but God alone, Who has no partner, and that Muhammad is the Messenger of God. This is His word: “Whosoever is in the heavens and the earth has submitted to Him, willingly or unwillingly, and to Him shall they be returned.” The master of this cause will not accept the poll-tax as the Messenger of God accepted it. This is the word of God: “Fight them until there is no persecution and religion is wholly for God.”

Abu Ja’far said: By God, they will fight until God is unified and nothing is associated with Him, and until the weak old woman can travel from East to West and none will stop her, and God will bring forth seeds from the earth, and rain will descend from heaven, and people will carry their taxes upon their necks to the Mahdi. God will grant abundance to our followers, and were it not for the happiness that will reach them, they would rebel. While the Master of this Cause will be ruling with certain laws and speaking of certain traditions, a group will emerge from the mosque intending to rise against him. He will tell his companions to pursue them, and they will catch them in the date-palm gardens and bring them as prisoners. He will then order their execution, and this will be the last uprising against the Qa’im of the family of Muhammad.

The sixth tradition, regarding what Abu Abdu’llah said: “I can see the Qa’im on the outskirts of Najaf, wearing the armor of the Messenger of God, which first shrinks upon him, then expands to fit him perfectly. He covers the armor with a garment of brocade and mounts a piebald horse with a radiant mark between its eyes that illuminates every land he approaches, serving as a sign for him. Then he unfurls the banner of the Messenger of God, and when he does so, it illuminates everything between East and West.

“The Commander of the Faithful said: I can see him crossing from the Valley of Peace to the stream of Sahla on a horse bearing a luminous mark. He supplicates, saying in his prayer: ʿThere is no god but God, in truth, in truth. There is no god but God, in faith and conviction. There is no god but God, in worship and servitude. O God, Exalter of every lonely believer and Humbler of every stubborn tyrant! You are my shelter when paths confound me and the earth, despite its vastness, closes in upon me. O God, You created me though You had no need of my creation, and were it not for Your support, I would be among the vanquished.

O You who brings forth mercy from its sources and blessings from their mines! O You who has distinguished Yourself with the height of elevation, so that Your friends are strengthened by Your might! O You before whom kings place the yoke of humility upon their necks, living in fear of Your power! I beseech You by Your Name through which You created Your creation, and all submit to You. I ask You to bless Muhammad and the family of Muhammad, to fulfill my affair, to hasten my relief, to suffice me, to grant me well-being, and to fulfill my needs this hour, this hour, this night, this night. Verily, You have power over all things."'

The seventh tradition, as related by Majlisi after the detailed account, Shaykh Hasan ibn Sulayman hath transmitted in his book Muntakhab al-Basa'ir the following narration:

"The righteous and faithful brother, Muhammad ibn Ibrahim ibn Muhsin al-Mutarrabadi, told me that he had found in the handwriting of his father—the pious man Ibrahim ibn Muhsin—the tradition which I shall now recount, and he showed me his own script, from which I copied it. It is the narration of Husayn ibn Humran. He continued the report to the point where it saith:

"'It is as though I behold them mounted upon grey steeds, spears in their hands, rushing toward battle with the eagerness of wolves. Their commander is a man from the tribe of Tamim, named Shu'ayb ibn Salih.

'Then Husayn—peace be upon him—shall turn to them, his face radiant as the full moon, and men shall be struck with awe by the beauty of his countenance. In the wake of the darkness he shall shine forth; then shall the small and the great, the lowly and the noble, take up the sword.

'With those banners he shall set forth, returning to Kufa, wherein the greater part of the people of the earth shall have gathered, and he shall make it his stronghold.

'Then tidings shall reach him and his companions of the Mahdi—peace be upon him. They shall say,

> "O son of the Messenger of God, who is this that hath encamped in our plain?"

'Husayn—peace be upon him—shall reply,

> "Come forth with me unto him, that ye may behold who he is and what he desireth,"

—though, by God, he knoweth full well that he is the Mahdi, and that it is only by divine decree that he summoneth them thus.

'Then Husayn—peace be upon him—shall go forth, accompanied by four thousand men, each bearing the Qur'an upon his neck, clad in garments of wool, and girt with their swords.

'Thereupon Husayn—peace be upon him—shall be slain, until he draweth near to the Mahdi. And the people shall say,

> "Ask concerning this man—who is he, and what doth he seek?"

'Then some companions of Husayn will go to the army of the Mahdi (peace be upon him) and say:

> “O army present here, who are you—may God preserve you—and who is this master of yours and what does he want?”

ʿThe companions of the Mahdi will reply:

> “This is the Mahdi of the family of Muhammad and we are his helpers from among the jinn, humans and angels.”

ʿThen Husayn (peace be upon him) will say: “Let me be alone with this one.”

ʿThe Mahdi who is between the two armies will come forth to him. Husayn (peace be upon him) will say:

> “You are the Mahdi of the family of Muhammad? Then where is my grandfather the Messenger of God’s staff, his ring, his cloak, his shield, his grey turban, his horse, his she-camel Al-Ghadba, his mule Duldul, his donkey Ya’fur, his mount Al-Buraq, his crown, and the Qur’an which the Commander of the Faithful compiled without any change or alteration?”

ʿThen he will present to him the chest containing all that he asked for. Abu Abdullah said that everything was in the chest, including the relics of all the Prophets—even the staff of Adam and Noah, the legacy of Hud and Salih, the collection of Abraham, Joseph’s measuring vessel, Shu’ayb’s measure and scale, Moses’ staff and the ark containing what remained of the family of Moses and Aaron carried by the angels, David’s armor and ring, Solomon’s ring and crown, Ali’s saddle, and the inheritance of the Prophets and Messengers in that chest.

ʿAt that point, Husayn will say:

> “O son of the Messenger of God, I ask you to plant the staff of the Messenger of God in this solid rock and ask God to make it grow”

- intending only to show his companions the virtue of the Mahdi so they would obey him and pledge allegiance to him.

ʿThe Mahdi will take the staff and plant it, and it will grow, rise, branch out and sprout leaves until it shades Husayn’s army. Then Husayn will say “God is Great! O son of the Messenger of God, extend your hand so I may pledge allegiance to you.”

ʿThen Husayn and all his army will pledge allegiance except for four thousand of the companions with copies of the Qur’an and hair shirts, known as the Zaydis. Some of them will say “This is nothing but great sorcery.”

ʿI say: then he continued the narration up to the words,

> “If ye deal justly with your own souls and with him alike…”

—and thereafter he recorded nothing further.’

The eighth tradition: Sahl ibn Ziyad hath transmitted, from Ibn Mahbub, from Ibn Fudayl, from Sa’d al-Jaddab, from Jabir, from Abu Ja’far, that Husayn addressed his companions before he was slain and said:

“Verily the Messenger of God hath told me, ‘O my son, thou shalt set forth toward Iraq—an earth whereupon prophets and the trustees of prophets have met; it is the land called Amuza—and there thou shalt be martyred, and with thee there shall be slain a company of thy companions. They shall not find aught but the sting of iron.’

> “And we entreated and cried: ‘O fire, be cool and safe for Abraham!’—and thus shall the war be a shelter and a salvation for thee and for them. Rejoice, then, for by God, if they slay us, we shall be avenged in return for our Prophet.”

“Then he added: I shall abide as God willeth; and I shall be the first for whom the earth will rend asunder, and forthwith shall he issue whose rising shall coincide with the rising of the Commander of the Faithful, and with the advent of our Qa’im, and with the quickening of the Messenger of God.

“A deputation shall descend upon me from heaven—sent from God—which hath never before come down to earth; Gabriel and Michael and Israfil, and hosts of angels shall descend; and Muhammad and Ali and I and my brother and all whom God hath favored shall come in battalions borne upon chargers of the Lord—steeds of light unmounted by any creature.

Part 9: “Thus shall Muhammad cast down his standard…”

“Thus shall Muhammad cast down his standard and raise it up to our Qa’im, together with his sword. We shall remain thus for as long as God willeth. Then God will cause to flow forth from the Mosque of Kufa a spring of gold, a spring of water, and a spring of milk.

“Then the Commander of the Faithful will give unto me the sword of the Messenger of God and dispatch me to the East and to the West. I shall not encounter any enemy of God but that I shall spill his blood, nor shall I pass by any settlement but that I shall burn it, until I reach India and conquer it.

“Then Daniel and Joshua will come forth unto the Commander of the Faithful saying: ‘God and His Messenger have spoken the truth.’ And God will send with them to Basra seventy men who will slay their warriors, and He will dispatch an army to Rome, and God will grant them victory.

“Then I shall surely slay every creature whose flesh God hath forbidden, until there remaineth not upon the face of the earth save what is pure. And I shall give the Jews and Christians and all other peoples the choice between Islam and the sword. Whoso accepteth Islam, I shall show him favor, and whoso rejecteth Islam, God shall spill his blood.

“And there shall not remain any of our followers but that God will send down an angel who shall wipe the dust from his face and make known to him his spouses and his station in Paradise.

“And there shall not remain upon the face of the earth any blind person, nor any crippled one, nor any afflicted one, but that God shall remove his affliction through us, the People of the House. And blessings shall surely descend from heaven to earth until trees shall bend with whatsoever fruits God willeth, and ye shall eat winter fruits in summer and summer fruits in winter.

> “This is the meaning of His words, exalted be He: ʿAnd if the people of the towns had believed and feared God, We would have opened upon them blessings from heaven and earth, but they denied, so We seized them for what they were earning.’ [Q7:96] Then God shall bestow upon our followers such honor that nothing in the earth shall be hidden from them, to such extent that when one of them wisheth to know about his household, he shall inform them with knowledge of what they are doing.”

The ninth tradition: In what was related by Sa’d from Ahmad and Abdullah, the sons of Muhammad ibn Isa, and Ibn Abi’l-Khattab, all from Ibn Mahbub, from Ibn Ayyub, from Baghdadrah who said:

ʿI was reluctant to ask Abu Ja’far directly, so I devised a subtle question to achieve my purpose. I said: “Tell me about one who is killed—has he died?”

ʿHe said: “No, death is death and killing is killing.”

I said: “I do not understand your words, for God distinguisheth between killing and death in the Qur’an, saying whether ye die or are killed’ and ʿif ye die or are killed, unto God shall ye be gathered.”’

He said:

> “It is not as you say, O Baghdadrah. Death is death and killing is killing. God, glorified and exalted be He, hath said: Verily God hath purchased from the believers their souls and their wealth in return for Paradise—they fight in the way of God, so they slay and are slain, a promise binding upon Him in truth.’ [Q9:111]”

I said: “But God, glorified and exalted be He, saith Every soul shall taste death’ [Q3:185]—what then of one who is killed, has he not tasted death?” He replied: “One who is killed by the sword is not like one who dies in his bed. Verily, one who is killed must return to this world to taste death.”’

The tenth tradition: In what was related by Sa’d ibn Hashim from al-Barqi from Muhammad ibn Sinan who said: Abu ʿAbdullah said: The Messenger of God said:

> “My Lord, glorified and exalted be He, took me on the Night Journey and revealed unto me from behind a veil what He revealed, and spoke unto me what He spoke. And among what He spoke unto me was that He said: O Muhammad! Verily I am God, there is no god but I, Knower of the unseen and the visible, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate. Verily I am God, there is no God but Me, the King, the Holy, the Peace, the Inspirer, the Guardian, the Mighty, the Compeller, the Proud. Glorified be God above what they associate with Him! Verily I am God, there is no God but Me, the Creator, the Maker, the Fashioner. To Me belong the Most Beautiful Names. All that is in the heavens and earth glorify Me, and I am the Mighty, the Wise. O Muhammad! I am God, there is no God but Me, the First before Whom there is nothing, and the Last after Whom there is nothing, and the Manifest above Whom there is nothing, and the Hidden beneath Whom there is nothing. And I am God, there is no God but Me, the Knower of all things. O Muhammad! Upon the first from whom I took the covenant among the Imams, may God’s blessings be upon them. O Muhammad! Upon the last whose spirit was taken from

> among the Imams, and he is the Creature that speaks to them. O Muhammad! Upon what I have made manifest unto thee of all that I have revealed to thee—thou art not to conceal anything from him. O Muhammad! Upon what I have kept hidden which I confided in thee—for there is no secret between Me and thee apart from him. O Muhammad! Upon Ali is the knowledge of all I have created of the lawful and forbidden."

The eleventh tradition mentions what is related in the Book of Sulaim ibn Qays al-Hilali, may God's mercy be upon him, which was narrated by Aban ibn Abi Ayyash who read all of it to our master Ali ibn al-Husayn (peace be upon him) in the presence of a group of notable companions including Abu al-Tufayl. Zayn al-Abidin (peace be upon him) confirmed it saying "This tradition of ours is authentic." Aban said: "I later met Abu al-Tufayl in his home and he related to me regarding the Return, from people who fought at Badr, and from Salman, al-Miqdad, and Abu Ka'b." Abu al-Tufayl said: "I presented what I had heard from them to Ali ibn Abi Talib, God's blessings and peace be upon him, in Kufa. He said: This is specialized knowledge which the community cannot afford to be ignorant of, though its full understanding rests with God.' Then he confirmed everything they had told me."

Ali (peace be upon him) read much of it and explained its interpretations until I became more certain of the Return than I am of the Day of Resurrection. Among what I asked was: "O Commander of the Faithful, tell me about the Prophet's Pool—is it in this world or the Hereafter?" He replied: "Rather in this world." I asked: "Who will prevent access to it?" He said: "I will, with my own hands. I shall allow my friends to approach it and turn away my enemies from it."

I said: "O Commander of the Faithful, concerning God's words And when the Word befalls them, We shall bring forth for them a creature from the earth that shall speak unto them, because mankind had not faith in Our signs' [Q27:82]—what is this creature?" He said: "O Abu al-Tufayl, leave this matter be." I said: "O Commander of the Faithful, tell me about it, may I be your sacrifice!" He said: "It is a creature that eats food, walks in the marketplaces, and marries women." I asked: "O Commander of the Faithful, who is he?" He said: "He is the master of the earth by whom the earth is made stable." I asked: "O Commander of the Faithful, who is he?" He said: "He is this community's Truthful One, its Distinguisher, its master and its possessor of authority." I asked: "O Commander of the Faithful, who is he?" He said: "He is the one of whom God has said and a witness from Him recites it' and he who possesses knowledge of the Book' and he who brings the truth and he who confirms it' while all other people deny it." I said: "O Commander of the Faithful, name him for me!"

He said:

> "Verily, I have named him for thee, O Aba al-Tufayl. By God! Were I to enter in unto the multitude of My Shi'ah—those by whose aid I wage war, who profess obedience unto Me, who call Me the Commander of the Faithful, and who deem it lawful to strive against those that oppose Me—and were I to acquaint them with but a portion of the truths I know from the Book which Gabriel, upon him be peace, revealed unto Muhammad, the Messenger of God, they would assuredly scatter and disperse, until there remained with Me but a small company of the people of truth—thyself and those like unto thee among My Shi'ah."

Then I said:

> "O Commander of the Faithful! Would I and those like Me forsake Thee, or would we remain steadfast by Thy side?"

He replied: "Nay, ye shall remain steadfast."

Then, turning toward Me, He continued:

> "Our Cause is verily a mighty and most hidden mystery; none can know it nor draw nigh unto it save three—an angel nigh unto God, a prophet sent forth, or a faithful servant whom God hath tried and proved in the crucible of faith. O Abu'l-Tufayl! When the Messenger of God passed away, all went astray in error and ignorance except those whom God protected through us, the People of the House."

The twelfth tradition: In what has been related from Ali (peace be upon him) in his noble sermon known as "al-Makhzun," of which we have mentioned previously, until he said: "O people! Ask me before there breaks forth an eastern tribulation, trampling in its wreckage after death and life, or before a fire is kindled with western wood in the west of the earth, trailing its skirts, crying O woe is me!' with its entry, or something similar. When the celestial sphere turns, it will be said: He died,' or He perished—in which valley did he traverse?' On that day will be the interpretation of this verse: Then We gave you back the turn to prevail against them, and aided you with wealth and children and made you more numerous in man-power.'

For this there are signs and tokens: The first of them is the siege of Kufa with observation posts and trenches, the burning of corners in the streets of Kufa, the closing of mosques for forty nights, the appearance of three banners around the Great Mosque resembling guidance—the killer and the killed being in the Fire—extensive killing, widespread death, the killing of the Pure Soul behind Kufa among seventy, the one slaughtered between the Corner and the Station, the killing of the victorious lion in patience in the covenant of Islam along with many of the human devils, and the emergence of the Sufyani with a green banner and a golden cross, whose commander is a man from Kalb, and twelve thousand reins from those who carry the Sufyani heading towards Mecca and Medina, whose commander is one from the Umayyads called Khuzayma, blind in the left eye, with his glance inclining to the world, whose banner will not be turned back until he descends upon Medina.

He will gather men and women from the family of Muhammad (peace be upon him) and imprison them in a house in Medina called the house of Abu'l-Hasan the Umayyad. And he shall send forth horsemen in pursuit of a man from among the kindred of Muhammad, peace be upon Him, around whom a band of the downtrodden shall have gathered in Mecca, their leader being a man of Ghatafan. And when they reach the white plain of al-Bayda between Mecca and Medina, the earth shall swallow them up, leaving none to escape save one man, whose face God shall turn backward upon his neck, that he may bear warning unto them and become a sign unto those who come after. On that day shall this verse be fulfilled:

> “If thou couldst but see when they are seized with terror and are taken from a place near at hand.”

Then shall the Sufyani send forth one hundred and thirty thousand toward Kufa. They shall encamp at al-Rawha, al-Faruq, and the place of Mary and Jesus near Qadisiyya. From among them shall eighty thousand advance until they reach Kufa, to the site of the tomb of Hud, peace be upon Him, at al-Nukhayla. There shall they be assailed by the young and the fierce on the day of Zaniyya. And the leader of the people shall be a tyrant, obstinate and proud, whose name is the Soothsayer, the Magician.

He shall go forth from a city called al-Zawra, accompanied by five thousand diviners, and on the bridge thereof shall seventy thousand be slain, until the waters of the Euphrates run red for three days with blood, and the stench of the bodies fills the air. From Kufa shall captives be taken—maidens whom no hand nor veil hath been lifted from—and they shall be borne upon litters between al-Tawba and al-Gharbayn.

Then shall there march forth from Kufa a host of one hundred thousand, idolaters and hypocrites alike, until they reach Damascus; none shall hinder them from it, that city of Iram, the one adorned with lofty pillars. And from the East shall banners arise—neither of wool, nor of flax, nor yet of silk—sealed upon the spearheads with the signet of the Most Exalted Lord. Their bearer shall be a man from the family of Muhammad, peace be upon him. The day he appears in the East, his fragrance shall be found in the West like the strongest musk. Terror shall travel a month before him, and his son Sa’d the Water-bearer shall succeed him in Kufa, seeking vengeance for their fathers’ blood, they being sons of the transgressors, until the cavalry of Husayn, peace be upon him, shall charge upon them. They shall race as if they were the two horsemen of Ibn Sha’th, without mourners or lamenters when striking.

The last one shall say in an assembly after this day of ours: “O God, where are the penitent ones, the humble ones, those who bow and prostrate?” These are the Substitutes whom God, mighty and glorious, hath described: “Verily God loveth those who turn unto Him, and He loveth those who cleanse themselves.”[Q2:222] And the purified ones are their peers from the family of Muhammad.

And a man shall come forth from the people of Bahrain, a monk responding to the Imam, and he shall be the first of the Christians to respond. He shall destroy his monastery and break his cross. The friends and the weak among the people and the cavalry shall go forth and proceed to Nukhayla with banners of guidance. The gathering of people from all the earth shall be at Al-Faruq, which is the path of the Commander of the Faithful, between Al-Bars and the Euphrates.

On that day, three million Jews and Christians shall be slain between East and West, some killing others. This shall be the interpretation of this verse:

> “And that cry of theirs ceased not till We made them as a field that is mown, as ashes silent and quenched.”

By the sword and under the shadow of the sword.

And there shall follow from the sons of Ash'hab the Rebuker of Fortune a people not of his father, in troops, until they come seeking refuge in the trees. On that day shall be the interpretation of this verse:

> "So when they felt Our might, lo! they began to flee from it. Flee not, but return to that wherein ye delighted, and to your dwellings, that ye may be questioned."

[Q21:12-13] Their dwellings are the treasures they seized from people's wealth.

On that day shall come upon them sinking, pelting and transformation. This shall be the interpretation of this verse: "And it is not far from the wrongdoers."

And a herald shall cry aloud in the month of Ramadan from the direction of the East at the rising of the sun, saying: "O people of guidance, assemble on the morrow at noon!" Then shall the sun be eclipsed and become dark and blackened. And on the third day the truth shall be distinguished from falsehood by the appearance of the Beast of the Earth.

Then shall the Romans advance to a village upon the shore of the sea, near the cave of the youths. And God shall send forth from that cave unto them two of the youths—one named Malikha and the other Kamilina—both of them martyrs and true believers in the Qaim. One of the youths shall be sent unto the Romans, but shall return without effect; the other shall be sent forth and shall return with victory. On that day shall this verse be fulfilled:

> "And unto Him shall submit whosoever is in the heavens and the earth, willingly or unwillingly"

[Q3:83].

Then shall God raise up from every nation a company, that He may show them that which they were promised. On that day shall this verse find its fulfilment: "And on that Day We shall gather from every nation a company of those who denied Our signs, and they shall be held in check" [Q27:83]. And that "being held in check" is the trembling of their hearts.

Part 10: "Then shall the Greatest Siddiq advance beneath…"

Then shall the Greatest Siddiq advance beneath the banner of guidance, bearing the sword Dhu'l-Fiqar and the staff of authority, until he descend twice upon the land of the Hijrah, which is Kufa. There shall he demolish its mosque and rebuild it upon its first foundation, and he shall overthrow the palaces of the tyrants round about it. Then shall he journey to Basra until he overlook its sea, bearing with him the Ark and the Rod of Moses.

He shall utter a single cry over Basra, and it shall become a stormy sea, leaving nothing therein save its mosque, standing like the prow of a ship upon the waters. Then shall he move on to Khurur and consume it with fire; then pass through the Gate of the Banu Asad, and cry out in Thaqif—a cry that shall be as the vengeance upon Pharaoh. Thereafter shall he go unto Egypt, and ascend its pulpit to address the people.

Then shall the earth be gladdened by justice; the heavens shall bestow their rain; the trees their fruits; and the soil its verdure. The earth shall adorn herself for her dwellers; the wild beasts shall dwell in

safety, grazing upon the borders of the earth as the cattle of men. And knowledge shall be cast into the hearts of the believers, so that no believer shall have need of aught that is with his brother.

On that day shall be fulfilled the meaning of this verse: “He will enrich all from His abundance.” The earth shall yield up its treasures, and He Who shall arise shall say: “Eat in happiness for what ye did in days past.” The Muslims on that day shall be people of right religion, permitted to speak. On that day shall be fulfilled the meaning of this verse: “And thy Lord shall come with angels, rank on rank.” [Q89:22] God shall accept on that day none but the true religion—verily, the pure religion of God. On that day shall be fulfilled these verses: “See they not how We drive water to the barren land and bring forth thereby crops whereof their cattle and they themselves do eat? Have they not vision? They say: When will this victory come, if ye speak truth?’ Say: On the day of victory, faith will not profit those who disbelieve, neither will they be reprieved. So turn thou away from them and wait; they too are waiting.’ [Q32:27-30]”

From the time of his appearance until his death shall be three hundred and some years. The number of his companions shall be three hundred and thirteen, among them nine from the Children of Israel, seventy from the jinn, and two hundred and thirty-four from mankind—among these seventy who were angered for the Prophet when the idolaters of Quraysh assailed him, and who sought permission from God’s Prophet to respond, whereupon permission was granted when this verse was revealed:

> “Save those who believe and do good works, and remember God much, and vindicate themselves after they have been wronged. Those who do wrong will come to know by what a (great) reverse they will be overturned!”

[Q26:227] And twenty from the people of Yemen, including Miqdad ibn al-Aswad, and two hundred and fourteen who were by the seashore near Aden, to whom God’s Prophet sent a message and they came as Muslims. And from the various peoples, two thousand eight hundred and seventeen, and from the angels forty thousand, of whom three thousand are marked ones and five thousand are followers.

Thus the total of his companions is forty-seven thousand one hundred and thirty, of whom nine are chiefs, each chief having four thousand angels. Of jinn and men, the number is as on the day of Badr. With these shall he fight, through these shall God grant victory, through these shall he triumph, through these shall victory arise, and from these shall come the victory of the earth.

I have written it as I found it. And in it are missing letters.

The thirteenth tradition, as related by Al-Hussein Muhammad from Al-Mu’alla from Abu’l-Mufaddal from Ibn Sadaqa from Al-Mufaddal ibn Umar from Abu Abdullah, who said:

> “It is as though I see a throne of light that has been placed, over which has been erected a dome of red ruby adorned with jewels, and as though I see Al-Hussein seated upon that throne, with ninety thousand green domes around him, and as though I see the believers visiting him and greeting him. Then God, mighty and glorious, says to them: ‘O My friends, ask of Me, for long have ye been persecuted and humbled and patient. This is the day when ye shall not ask Me for any need of this world or the next but I shall grant it to you.’ Their food and drink shall be from Paradise. This, by God, is the honor.”

The fourteenth tradition, as related by my father and Ibn Walid together from Sa'd and Al-Himyari together from Ahmad ibn Al-Hussein ibn Umar ibn Yazid from Al-Hussein Al-Ras' from Muhammad ibn Ishaq from As'ad ibn Tha'laba from Umm Hani, who met Abu Ja'far Muhammad ibn Ali ibn Al-Hussein and asked him about this verse: "By the retreating stars, the planets that move and hide!" [Q81:15-16] The Imam shall retreat in his time upon the completion of his knowledge in the year 260, then shall appear as a blazing meteor in the darkness of night. Should you witness this, your eyes shall be consoled.

Look with geometric precision to the holy signs radiating from the suns of the infallible ones in the depths of those words that have dawned from the light of the Eternal Morn and shine upon the temple of unity with their traces. And of these signs, some are irrevocable while others God may efface as He willeth. I am indeed fearful of Bada and, gazing upon the Tree of Destiny, shall not mention any of these to thee, but rather entrust their judgment to the Book of God—"He effaceth or confirmeth what He pleaseth, and with Him is the Mother Book". [Q13:39]

Therefore, O friend, when thou hearest the call of the All-Glorious, hasten, hasten! Then mount, mount! Be not like him whose throne received a mere body, whereof God, glorified be He, hath said: "We did try Solomon: We placed on his throne a body, then did he turn (to Us). He said: ʿO my Lord! Forgive me, and grant me a kingdom which will not belong to another after me: for Thou art the Grantor of Bounties."' [Q38:34-35] For the life of this world, by thy Lord's grandeur, hath no permanence, and its ultimate bounties and blessings are, in the sight of God and the people of the Heights, like the black of an ant's eye, dead and profitless.

Therefore work for God with joy and fragrance, prepare thyself for the days of thy Lord in the Bayan, labor for God, the All-Merciful, curse the sun and moon in their calculated courses, and purify thyself for the meeting with thy Lord. For the life of this world is as God hath said concerning it: "naught but a brief enjoyment." Therefore occupy thyself with deeds for God, the One, the All-Compelling.

Reflect on those who preceded thee among the near ones, such as Abraham and Noah, then Moses and Jesus and Muhammad, the Apostle of God and Seal of the Prophets—all forsook their comforts and detached themselves from their beloved ones, and now, by God's leave, they delight in the verdant pavilions. And among the idolaters, such as Nimrod and Shaddad and Haman and Pharaoh and Qarun—all left their gardens and were cut off from their wealth and children, and now they are brought to thy Lord's torment.

O friend! As I indeed love thee, I counsel thee: forget not God's Bada, despair not of God's grace, keep death before thine eyes, and aid God's Faith as though thou hadst not existed in this world less than nine-tenths. Be among the perceptive people of the concealment, companions of the retreating traditions. Remember death twenty-five times every day and night, remembering Him as though in that very moment—yet fear not, neither grieve, for the abode of the Hereafter is indeed Life, wherein all that thy soul desireth shall be before thee, before God saith to it "Be!" and it is.

Therefore rejoice in obedience to thy Lord, for verily ʿAli was content in this world with but two garments for eating and two for wearing, until he took with spirit and contentment a handful of dust and said:

> “I have succeeded, by the Lord of the Ka’bah! From it did We create you, and into it shall We return you, and from it shall We bring you forth once again.”

Look with certainty, for the hearts of some people in their bodies are dead while they perceive not, though were they alive they would perceive and understand. Therefore, take particles of air from the mirrors of thy heart at all times through remembrance of death, for thereby is the mirror purified and the crystal refined, and the realities of the Most Exalted Realm are therein reflected. In that station thou dost interpret the Surah of al-Kawthar with the very ink that floweth from thine own pen, and beholdest that subtle and wondrous interpretation upon the fathomless ocean of divine utterance, even as in its revelation. None can alter the words of God; and verily, God is the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing.

And concerning this interpretation, that ink is the water of Kawthar which flows from the spring of Salsabil, and that paper is the ground of the highest Paradise, and the one addressed in the letters is that Pen concerning which judgment was revealed in the Qur’an:

> “Nun. By the Pen and by what they write, thou art not, by the grace of thy Lord, a madman.”

[Q68:1]

And verily God’s command reaches it, signified by its prayer in my hands, meaning its dissolution as We move it as We wish, however We wish. And We recognize in all its stations what man performs in religion, as he offers four prostrations at noon while at home and two while traveling. Thus dost thou witness upon it every sign of that hovering bird in its course. And know God’s words “and sacrifice” [wa anhar] as the splitting of the pen, for were it not split, the ink would not flow as God hath willed in the decree of the heart.

And those who read the decree of these words and know through the mention of these signs, were they to speak concerning the decree of the Word with “why” and “wherefore,” they would be among those of whom it is said: “Verily, he that hateth thee shall be the one cut off.” [inna shani’aka huwa al-abatar]

And upon this just path and this excellent balance, know thou all the signs and the course of the meaning of that Surah in all indications, tokens and stations, even unto the movement of an ant upon solid rock in the darkest night.

And were it not for My grief at what the hands of men have wrought, thou wouldst witness more elevated than My hand that bird which hath ranged in the depths of the air of signs. When anyone heareth its song, he acteth as the verse hath spoken in their decree: “When she heard of their scheming, she sent for them and prepared for them a banquet, and gave each one of them a knife, and said [to Joseph]: Come forth unto them.’ And when they saw him they exalted him and cut their hands, and said: God preserve us! This is no mortal! This is none other than a noble angel!”’ [Q12:31] Yea, in the realm of souls and minds was the decree thus.

And I have brought forth a drop from the vast ocean of the knowledge of God’s family concerning the Qur’an. But were anyone else to open this door, he could not prove it to the people, for in the traditions what hath been revealed is by allusion, not by clear statement. But since God hath placed in My hands a

brilliant proof, I shall interpret all that is established in the leaves of the divine trees, the reeds of the thicket of might, and the songs of the holy birds upon the branches of the tree of dominion and kingdom, for God hath created in all things the signs of all things in their rank.

This is the most exalted station of the servant: that he should raise things to the stations of their abstraction and unity. Indeed, in these days some of the letters and names and their namesakes shall enter, by God's leave, into their paradise, but most people are not grateful and do not know.

O man! The attributes of the people of the Bayan are not to be confused with the attributes of all contingent beings, for they are specially endowed with divine gifts that none can comprehend save the All-Merciful. They are a people whom God hath created from a single element, and He permitteth them, in the station of the body, when He willeth, to manifest His light in the heart.

And this Cause is such that neither the heavens nor the earth are capable of upholding it. Verily, it is the Most Great Elixir, the Most Glorious Symbol—that which is beyond the influence of the signs of the Godhead, the attributes of the Dominion, the tokens of the Kingdom, or the chastisements of the peoples of Power and of the world of Man. In every realm they stand in the same station: they mirror forth the oneness of God and manifest His majesty. Blessed, then, is he who hath known their worth, rejoiced at the sight of their countenances, and gloried above all men in sitting in their presence and serving at their feet.

By thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and the earth! Should one expend all that is upon the earth and strive with Me in the utmost discipline and spiritual exertion, surpassing all who have gone before him, yet seek thereby to attain the state wherein I beheld thee with Mine own eyes on that night, he would never succeed, nor would he attain unto any share thereof.

And the trembling of my body which thou witnessed there was but one aspect of the manifestations of "two bow-lengths or closer" in relation to the revelation of the Manifestation. Great was that state, for all knowledge and conditions before it are diminished. It is like unto the manifestation of thy Lord in the heart, for in the element of fire it points only to air, and in earth only to water. Thus dost thou know all the conditions of the people of the Bayan, for the light of glory in relation to them was equal.

By thy life! If people knew the glory of that state, they would willingly spend all that God had given them, even their own souls, to behold with their own eyes that state in my being. Woe, then woe unto those who witnessed with the eye of certainty, then turned away from the truth of certainty. Soon shall come a day when they will say, "Oh, the regret for what we neglected in regard to God!" And that is the day which you were promised. Verily God hath created within the men of the heights such conditions that if He should permit any one of them, and his promised day should come, he would manifest through God's might and power whatsoever God willeth for him. Nothing could prevent him, nor would poison harm him if he should consume it, just as Ali before him partook of it, and his state would not change; rather, his pallor would turn to redness as God willeth. There is no might nor power except through God, and glory be to God above what they describe.

By thy life, O questioner, the people today are as dead, for they show no gratitude for what hath been sent down in God's Book concerning them, and they imagine of themselves what they know not. He

about whom it was revealed in the traditions that whoever looketh upon him, God recordeth for him the reward of a thousand complete readings of the Qur'an, is today imprisoned in his house, while those who place themselves in the station of that decree have no portion thereof, and they are among the heedless. Glory be to God, from the deeds of the learned and the judgment of the wise! Soon will God gather them on the Day of Resurrection and question them with piercing questions.

O Jalil! Counsel some of them and recite to them what Muhammad ibn Ali al-Jawad said to his uncle: "There is no God but God, O uncle! Great will it be before God if tomorrow thou shouldst stand before Him and He should say to thee: Why didst thou give verdicts to My servants about that which thou knowest not, when there was in the community one more learned than thee?" Today thou art able to speak among people however thou wishest and whenever thou wishest, saying "I am, I am." Though I be incapable of properly thanking thee for thy kindness in following the pure religion of God, yet I mention to thee, in fulfillment of thy right, what Ali ibn Musa wrote in his own hand to Ali ibn Mahziyar, one of his sincere followers who was certain of his authority—and this is sufficient as a beautiful remembrance:

"In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

"O Ali! May God reward thee with the choicest of His recompense, cause thee to dwell within His Paradise, and shield thee from disgrace in this world and the next. May God gather thee in our company, O Ali!

Part 11: "I have tried thee and found thee steadfast…"

"I have tried thee and found thee steadfast in counsel, obedience, service, reverence, and in the discharge of whatsoever was incumbent upon thee. Were I to say that never have I seen one like unto thee, I would hope to speak the truth. May God reward thee with the gardens of Paradise as thy resting-place!

> "Nothing of thy station hath been hidden from Me, nor of thy toils in heat and in cold, by night and by day. Therefore I beseech God, when He assembleth the multitudes on the Day of Resurrection, to enfold thee in a mercy that shall make others envy thee—for verily He is the Hearer of prayers."

O man! Fear God and know the measure of thyself, for the Cause of God is the truth, and religion in every aspect is like unto the disciples of Jesus, the son of Mary. Cast what I have cast unto thee from the fire of hearts among the people, for that sign is a sign sent down from heaven, before which the necks of all creation have bowed.

Know thou that God hath ever been self-sufficient, with no partner unto Him. His loved ones in every dispensation have been adorned with His attributes, have spoken from His presence, have obeyed His command, have been content with His decree, and have feared His judgment. They are a people who, when they lie upon the earth, behold the throne of attributes, and when they are silent in the realm of utterance, they commune with themselves in the inner sanctuaries of divine unity. May God grant me to meet them in a land of security and glory, for they are the sincere ones, they are the humble ones, they are the near ones.

They are a people whom nothing on earth can grieve if they fail to attain it, but when they learn a decree from God's Book concerning themselves, they will fulfill it even if they must crawl upon their chests over ice, for they see glory and sovereignty in obedience to God, and abasement and poverty in disobedience to Him. This sufficeth as a reminder for those believers who understand the signs of Our verses and dwell beneath the shadow of Our signs—these are they who are rightly guided.

The mention of letters and explanation of symbols pertain to the realm of signs and tokens, but true honor in the divine realms of infinity lies in the pure reality of the manifestation of the Mount, which is the essential Face in all beings and the definitive Presence in all essences. And upon that path, in the realm of those divine signs, words fail to encompass, stations cannot portray, nor do indications reflect the mysteries thereof. It beseemeth not, in such a theme, to make mention of the realms of being or of essence, of soul or of selfhood, of paradisical realities or celestial glories, of the veiled or the radiant, of the resplendent or the interceding, of the aspiring or the orienting, of the reflective or the withdrawn, of the inspired or the concealed, of the encircling or the all-gathering, of the diffused or the ascending, of the cosmic poles within the groves of the divinities, or of the flaming canopies within the thickets of the dominions, or of the shimmering congregations within the groves of the kingdoms, or of the sanctified spheres within the meadows of the powers—save only of the Manifestations in the world of man and of the effulgent attributes in the realities of created being and beyond them the ineffable sanctuaries of the unknowable realm—things which no word can unveil through allusion.

Such is the path of the dwellers in the lofty chambers of the Ridwan of God; for the servant—by the testimony of all that beareth the name of a thing—can never know the Essence of the Eternal, nor point toward Him, nor describe His life, nor depict His holy Being.

And what I recount unto thee, in the station of mystical knowledge for the manifestation of exposition, is the revelation of God unto thee by thine own self—His ascription of the tranquility of the hearts of His creatures unto Himself, even as He hath ascribed the Kaaba unto His own Being. Thou sayest,

> "He is my Creator, my Provider, my Ordainer, my Fashioner—there is no God but He."

And God hath accepted from His servants this relation unto Him, for aught else is impossible in the realm of contingency. In its very truth and essence, this is the relation of creation unto creation and the judgment of the possible within the possible, even as ʿAli (peace be upon him) indicated in his Khutabtu'l-Yatimiyyah:

> "If thou sayest whence is He?', He hath distinguished Himself from all things, for He is He. If thou sayest it is it itself', the conjunction in his words is a quality proving it, not a quality revealing Him. If thou assignest Him a limit, the limit pertaineth to other than Him. If thou sayest the air is His relationship, the air is of His creation. One returneth from attribute to attribute, the heart is blinded from understanding, understanding from perception, perception from deduction. Dominion persisteth in dominion, the created endeth with its like, glory seeketh its kind, examination leadeth to powerlessness, explanation to loss, outcry to despair, proclamation to severance. The way is barred, the search repelled. His proof is His signs, His existence His establishment."

Through such explanations there ariseth in man's mind that after the way is barred and proof prevented, how can the Divine Essence be unified, the attributes sanctified, and the All-Merciful be worshipped with the essential nearness in contingent being? Nay, such judgment is impossible, forbidden. How then, O Possessor of Glory, can that which is impossible in this state be achieved?

Yea, I shall acquaint thee with what thou knowest not from the Book: The unification of the Essence and knowledge thereof is impossible for contingent being. God hath commanded thee only to attain the utmost bounty of God in contingent being, which is the station of knowing the All-Merciful in all things. None may delve into knowledge of that vast, abundant, surging ocean. For when thou gazest in mirrors, if thou art heedless of them thou findest thy face therein without mention of them. Thou art not that which is in the mirrors, and that which is in the mirrors is thine image which thou hast revealed unto them through them in the mirrors themselves, and they reflect thy countenance and indicate thy presence while the mirrors remain.

Likewise thou knowest the portion of contingent being, that if thou turnest not unto it with mention of contingency, thou shalt see naught but the pure revelation, the absolute Essence, and the definitive Presence in all whereupon falleth the name of a thing.

The claim of knowledge through discovery and proof returneth to a single point, for God hath created in contingent being a station and related it to Himself, and commanded people to worship none but His Most Holy Essence alone. Thy mention of His Most Holy Essence is His manifestation to thee through thee in thyself, where it indicateth naught but thy Lord. Other than this is impossible in contingent being. Whoso worshippeth Him through mention of aught else or His manifestation through His creation hath joined partners with Him and hath not worshipped Him. Whoso worshippeth Him saying the object of worship is His manifestation while He is other than it hath disbelieved in Him and hath not worshipped Him, due to the existence of separation and the impossibility of encompassment, for that which He maketh His manifestation is He, yet He is above that manifestation.

It beseemeth not the servant to worship a manifestation while pointing to One Who is higher than His manifestation. Glorified be God, the Single, the Worshipped! He is the absolute Essence, the Single, the One, the Eternal, the Ancient, Whom none but He can know, none but He can unify, and none of His creation can worship, for in His reality naught was with Him, and now He is even as He was.

There was nothing with Him, so how can one who does not bring Him into existence worship Him, or how can one who does not unify Him know Him? The verses of detachment in the station of orientation and unity are like your saying "There is no God but God." Just as this is a contingent word indicating God and His unity, so too is the reality of your essence and the being of your mystery. Those possessed of understanding know not what is there except through what is here.

O observer of these signs, do not contemplate, for the manifestations are ever renewed in contingent existence. In the moment when you make the manifestation of the Essence the portion of contingent existence, in that moment God reveals Himself to you through you by the manifestation of the Essence. You unceasingly know the portion of sovereignty, and He unceasingly reveals Himself to you through you by the manifestation of the Essence. Thus has God created all things in the world of contingency.

O questioner of the true explanation, interpret all the letters of that sacred verse through what We have caused to shine upon you from the manifestations of the ocean of glory, for that is humanity's portion in the station of paradise. Unto God, my Lord, do I complain of the action of the sun and moon by reckoning.

> "Lord, Thou knowest all things and hast power over all things. Deal with those who know Thy wisdom yet turn away from Thy Cause as they deserve before Thy face. By Thy might, I am innocent of all Thine enemies and love all Thy friends. By the balance Thou hast honored me with in the Bayan, we distinguish between the wretched and the blessed, and judge between them in this earthly life according to what their hands have wrought. Lord, forgive those in whose nature is the clay of love for Thy friends, and punish all those in whose nature is the clay of enmity toward Thy loved ones. Thou art the Almighty, the Powerful."

When thou hast understood what We have explained to thee of the laws of Return, know with certainty that the Bearer of God's Cause must come during an interval between Messengers, though there has never ceased to be among people a proof from Him, as Ali said: "The earth is never void of one who stands for God with His proof, whether manifest and renowned or fearful and hidden." God's way has been ordained before as it will be ordained after, as the Messenger of God said: "By Him in Whose hand is my soul, you will follow the ways of those who came before you, step by step and inch by inch, until you neither miss their path nor does the way of the Children of Israel pass you by." Among these is what God revealed in the Qur'an: "O my people, enter the holy land which God has prescribed for you, and turn not back, for then you will be losers." [Q5:21] Their number was six hundred thousand, some say forty thousand, and there remained only the cause of Moses and Aaron and his two sons and Joshua son of Nun and Caleb son of Yephunneh. They wandered for forty years because of their disobedience.

Likewise was the Cause of the Messenger of God—when He passed away, none remained firm in God's Cause except Ali, Hasan, Husayn, Salman, Miqdad and Abu Dharr. Thus dost thou know God's Cause in many hidden matters. When people read the verse of the Qur'an:

> "They said: O Moses! In it are a people of exceeding strength, and we shall never enter it until they depart from it; then if they depart from it, we will enter. Two men of those who feared, on whom God had bestowed His grace, said: Enter upon them through the gate, for when you have entered it, you will surely be victorious"

[Q5:22-23]—this is a matter witnessed by the believers, for when you enter the gate you will overcome all through a manifest and brilliant proof like this sun in the midst of heaven, even if you are killed while having truth on your side—then you are the victorious ones. But if you prevail and act beyond what God has permitted, then you are surely among the lost.

You need not worry about the meaning of the tradition that was recited to you—for how could God decree a matter for a people and not have it come to pass? Indeed, the law of divine nonfulfillment (bada') precedes destiny by four degrees, and the Book is at the seventh level of action. Yes, it is said that knowledge is of two kinds: knowledge that God keeps hidden, which none of His creation has access to, and knowledge that He has taught His angels and messengers. What He has taught His angels and

messengers will surely come to pass, for He does not belie Himself, nor His angels, nor His messengers. And from His hidden knowledge, He brings forward what He wills, guides whom He wills, and establishes what He wills.

In the apparent meaning of the tradition, it veils the first tradition and closes the door of its meaning. But when you look at it through the lens of possible divine revelation that is inseparable from anything and recognizes all stations of action like knowledge itself, it lifts the veil and removes the impossibility.

I counsel you and all who follow me to recite the Surah of the Children of Israel every Friday night, for the Truthful One (peace be upon him) said:

> "Whoever recites that Surah every Friday night will not die until they meet the Qa'im and become one of his companions."

His statement (may my soul be sacrificed for him) implies either meeting or seeing him without recognizing him.

So blessed are those who gaze upon his countenance, for that is indeed the great triumph. And that which this Gate hath imagined is none other than He Who manifested Himself upon Mount Sinai, when God, thy Lord, sent down His judgment in the Qur'an and ascribed it to the revelation of His own Self, where He saith—and His word is the truth—"And when his Lord manifested Himself to the mountain, He made it crumble into dust, and Moses fell down in a swoon" [Q7:143].

For He was one among the Shiah of Ali, as al-Sadiq—peace be upon Him—hath said, according to what is related in the Basair:

> "The cherubim are a people from among our Shiah, belonging to the first creation. God placed them behind the Throne; were but one ray of light from any of them divided among the people of the earth, it would suffice them all."

Then He said:

> "When Moses besought his Lord, he asked of Him but a matter belonging to one of the cherubim. Whereupon God manifested Himself unto the mountain and made it crumble into dust."

Consider, then, the majesty of the manifestation of thy Lord! The people of Moses were seventy thousand in number. From among them Moses chose seven thousand; from them again seven hundred; and from them yet seventy men for the appointed tryst with His Lord. He set them upon the mountaintop, and the thunderbolt seized them because of their wrong, for they had asked that which God had not permitted them to ask. They perished, and when Moses besought his Lord, God revived and raised them again. Thus was the decree of God, both before and after.

And for those who draw nigh unto God there is, in the Book of God, a Day of Encounter with Majesty, as Ja'far ibn Muhammad—peace be upon Him—hath intimated in his saying. When he was asked, "Doth the believer behold God on the Day of Resurrection?" he answered, "Yea, and they have indeed beheld Him

before that Day." It was said, "When?" He replied, "When He asked them, Am I not your Lord?' They said, Yea, verily!"' [Q7:172].

Then he paused awhile and said, "And verily the believers shall behold Him in this world ere the Day of Resurrection. Hast thou not beheld Him in thy station?" I said, "Shall I relate this from thee?" He said, "Nay; for if thou shouldst relate it and one ignorant of its meaning were to deny it, deeming it anthropomorphism, such a one would fall into unbelief. For the vision of the heart is not as the vision of the eye, as men know them; for both the eye and the heart are created things in the Book of God. And the heart cannot behold the Essence of the Eternal, even as the eye can never do so."

His—may my soul be a ransom unto Him—intention was the vision of His manifestation unto every soul in its own station. For the heart, in the measure that its capacity encompasseth, perceiveth of that manifestation what the eye cannot perceive, for the eye is bounded. This belongeth to the station of grace. But if thou desirest the decree of justice, then know that the heart, even as the eye, is limited by the confines of creation. Indeed, creation beholds creation, and they shall never be capable of beholding the Lord, exalted be His glory. He who understands the signs in the depths of these words, indications, symbols and stations knows—and none can know the signs except through the negation of signs, nor can the negation of signs be known through signs or through their negation. Around these deaf, dark, blind, pitch-black, gloomy, hellish words revolve the spheres of the cloud of unknowing, glory, praise, decree and origination—and this is the letter Ha' before the station of Vav in the realm of names and attributes.

8. Commentary on the Surah in the stages of the manifestations of the water of Kawthar

Part 1: "If you have understood what We have taught…"

If you have understood what We have taught you, and become illumined by what We have caused to shine upon you, and enlightened by what We have bestowed upon you, and stirred by what We have stirred within you, and brightened by what We have brightened you with, and filled by what We have given you to drink, and have drunk from the Kawthar we have granted you—then pray unto your Lord and sacrifice. For he who hateth thee shall be the one cut off. Otherwise submit, and you shall be safe through what has dawned, what has shone forth, what has gleamed, what has illumined, what has brightened, what has appeared on the horizon, and what has been spoken. Glory be unto Thee! I turn unto Thee, and I am the first of the believers.

What I have indicated in these signs and detailed in these tokens is the portion of those like you among the people of understanding, who know the decrees of origin and return in the hidden revelations of the spheres of names and attributes.

And since God has assigned to every letter the decrees of all things, I hereby indicate in this station certain of the manifestations of the Water of Kawthar, that those who dwell beneath the shadows of the radiant tabernacles of Paradise may drink, in this mortal life, from the fountain of water unpolluted. Then shall those who repose upon the couches of the Pavilion in the midst of Paradise drink from the fountain of pure milk; and those who recline upon the resplendent couches beneath the shade of the Tree of the Throne, within the Canopy of Time, shall drink from the fountain of clarified honey; and those who walk

upon the earth, by the leave of God, in the temple of majesty and beauty, of dominion and glory, shall drink from the fountain of wine, a delight unto the drinkers.

O thou who gazest upon that luminous and melodious dove from the Tree of the Cloud! Follow the mention of the queens of the sovereignty of the divine bees in the essences of those manifestations; then hearken to the beating of the dove of power in the realities of those states; then observe the qualities of the birds of the Kingdom in the "I-ams" of those allusions; then hearken to the sound of the spreading of the peacock's wings and what the ocean of meanings rehearseth in the psychic realities of those stations. For verily the Water of Kawthar of manifestation now floweth in the depths of those rivers.

Bear witness, then, with the secret of thy heart, to that divine foundation—that the Water of Kawthar is the pure water of the manifestation of the Theophany, which the people of utterance describe, in the station of the outward, by the visible pillars of creation. He maketh each pillar thereof a river: the first, the water unpolluted, white and shining—its inward reality the Fire of pre-existence, its outward form the Water of Eternity. It is a river that hath no beginning but itself, and no end but its own essence. God hath caused it to flow from Himself unto Himself, without the mention of aught beside Him. It is the river of unity, the water of detachment, and the ocean of singleness, flowing by the permission of God, revealing the manifestation of God.

If thou shouldst say that the bed of the river is of its water, and that the ship which floateth thereon is of its water, and that the mariner and all that abideth upon it are of its water, and that the waves and all that move within the water are of its water—thou wouldst have spoken the truth. For that water revealeth not its outward save through its inward, nor its inward save through its outward; its concealment through its manifestation, and its manifestation through its concealment. The wayfarer in it and the drinker from it behold naught save the pure manifestation of the essential Theophany, which pointeth only to Him Who is manifested thereby. It is the fountain from which the names and attributes are diffused.

And the allusions are the portion of the people of sanctity; yet he who gazeth upon the Lord of attributes beholdeth that water amidst the thickets of the divine bamboos, in the manifestations of the reality of His own being—at every moment, before every moment, and after every moment. He is sustained in every condition according to his station in the degrees of action and passion.

Turn, then, with the eye of thine heart to the station of the ultimate effusion of creation within thine own self; for it is the river of the Water unpolluted from the Kawthar in the station of Divinity, reminding thee to say, "There is no God but God." And in every condition thou utterest this, yet neither the outward changes nor the inward is altered. Thus hath been the decree of God in the celestial world; and none among those endued with understanding comprehendeth what is there save by what is here.

And beneath that station there are for thee degrees without end, leading to that which hath no limit, until the beginning of manifestation reacheth the station of the body—the utmost degree of created being in descent. And thou, in that most excellent station, movest not save as the Water of Kawthar floweth in thy inmost heart. Thy drinking of that water in this mortal life is but a sustenance from God for

thy body, that He may teach thee, through that outward bestowal, of His inward bounty within thy soul—lest thou be heedless, even for an instant, of the presence of His sustaining Lordship.

And if thou shouldst lift up thine inner sight, thou wouldst behold the river of the Water unpolluted, and all that God hath prepared for thee in the Ridwan, in this very station and this very hour, even as the Imam, the Father of the Proof, revealed unto whomsoever He willed. And it is even as hath been revealed in the tradition. Husayn Muhammad related from al Mualla, from Muhammad ibn Abd Allah, from Muhammad ibn Yahya, from Salih ibn Said, who said:

"I entered the presence of Ali ibn al Husayn and said, 'May I be thy ransom! In every matter they have sought to quench thy light and belittle thy station, even to the point that they have lodged thee in this vile inn—the inn of the destitute.'

He replied, Art thou here, O son of Said?' Then He motioned with His hand and said, Look!' And lo, before me were meadows exquisite and gardens fair, filled with fragrant maidens gleaming like hidden pearls, and birds melodious, and rivers gushing forth. My sight and hearing were confounded, and my eyes were astonished.

He said, 'Wherever we may be, this is ever prepared for us. We do not dwell in the inn of beggars! How then could I hint at the secret of the Cause? Verily, it is far mightier than men conceive. For that which shall appear on the Day of Resurrection of the bounties of Paradise, its stations and what God hath prepared therein—all live by that Water; for the cause is none other than His own Self.

Consider this tree: it springeth from the earth by means of the water which God created for it, whereby it bringeth forth fruit. Even so, know thou all the stations in this world and in the next. Yet fear God, lest thou knowest a station above the limit for which God created it.

That Water unpolluted, when it is mentioned in the outward station of Will, signifieth naught but that which God hath bestowed through Muhammad alone—no share hath any other therein. Then, in its inward station, naught but that which God hath bestowed through the living Imam—none other hath portion therein. Then, in the outward station of Purpose, naught but that which God hath given through Ali. Then, in its inward, naught but that which God hath granted through Ali ibn al Husayn.

Then, in the outward station of Decree, Judgment, Permission, Destiny, and the Book, it is that which God hath given through Fatimah, Hasan, Husayn, Musa, and Jafar. And in the inward of those holy manifestations, naught but that which God hath granted through Muhammad al Baqir, and thereafter through Ali, Muhammad, Ali, and Hasan—peace be upon them. None hath a share in that Water unpolluted from which they drink.

Likewise is it with the ordinances of the outward. Whoso supposeth that the Imam drinketh of the same water as other men hath verily denied the power of God concerning them. For the secret of the matter is that the manifestation of the Water unpolluted is their mystery. When it is realized in the world of limitation, it becometh affirmed among men at the time of recognition, even as their bodies are sometimes confused in the eyes of others in the station of Imamate.

But he who knoweth their true rank knoweth that God guardeth what He hath realized for their sake upon the earth, and none else hath any share therein, though it be mingled with that which is subject to men's control. Even as al Baqir—peace be upon Him—declared, when He showed the questioner the Tree of Tuba from heaven and the Tree of Zaqqum from earth: all take their portion therefrom."

And likewise is the decree within the chain of the eight: the noble cannot drink of the water of the elect, though both drink from one and the same stream. Such, too, is the law that governeth the signs and realities, the manifestations and tokens, the stations and verses, the modes and essences, the beings and "I-ams," the souls and beginnings, the ends and finalities, and that which lieth beyond them of infinities unto that which hath no end, in a manner unending—such that none among creation can encompass the knowledge thereof, save as God willeth. Exalted is He above that which they ascribe unto Him!

When thou knowest, then, the mystery of the Cause, thou shalt be assured that the river of the Water unpolluted is the Paradise of the People of God in this world, reserved unto them alone even as is the hereafter. None beside them are able to comprehend their portion of what God hath decreed for them in Paradise, for all others have ever dwelt within the domain of action; and when others are mentioned, they are mentioned only in the shadow of the rank of action.

And when the Pen runneth to mention the station, behold, I now behold thee amidst the gardens of the people of creation, wherein floweth that Water unpolluted through the depths of possibility. Know, then, that the utmost degree of Paradise for all things is the station of the rising of divine unity within the Presence of detachment; this is the beginning of the station of "Thou," and whatsoever lieth beneath the rank of the Unity of Essence pertaineth to the world of names and attributes.

Thus did Ali—peace be upon Him—command that in the perfection of unity the servant should deny all names and attributes within the sacred court of the Manifestation of the Divine Essence. And all the realities of the world below, and the other manifestations of existence, flow beneath that Water of life—from the beginning of the detachment of the detached, which is the end of the station of forms, accidents, and bodies.

And when the light of certitude glimmereth and the secret of possibility is stirred, know that God, exalted and glorified, hath manifested Himself to the eye of the spirit in the world of limitation even as He manifested to the Water unpolluted in the world of pre-eternal divinity, and hath placed His Paradise within the precincts of His own Paradise, in the inmost core of His reality.

And when the eye of the spirit openeth toward the first white pillar of the Throne—beneath which floweth the river of the Water unpolluted in the station of origination—it speaketh of the manifestation of Will; then, in the station of Invention, it speaketh of the manifestation of Purpose; then, in the station of Formation, of the manifestation of Decree; then, in the station of Occurrence, of the manifestation of Judgment. Yet the similitudes become confused to him who gazeth upon the ocean of the white radiance.

Therefore I now bring down the matter from the world of abstraction unto the station of letters within forms, that all may know the stations of the eightfold series in the words, even as God hath created them within the essences of the verses. Make, then, the point within the letters the appearance of the indistinct within the first Paradise; then the alif opposite the city of the might of Purpose in the station of

the second Paradise; then the extended alif opposite the city of the depths of the Sea of Decree in the station of the third Paradise; then the letters freed from composition in the city of the Ocean of Judgment in the station of the fourth Paradise; then the perfect word opposite the Paradise of Permission; then the compounded words in the station of Destiny, the sixth Paradise; then that which is realized from the effect of the words opposite the seventh Paradise.

Rise, then, and contemplate the reflections of the rivers of those degrees within the abyss, the eye of the spirit opposite the manifestation of the might of Will; then the eye of the right hand opposite the city of the might of Self-subsistence; then the eye of Tabariyyah opposite the city of the might of Oneness; then the eye of Barhut opposite the city of the might of Mercy; then the fountain of Masidan opposite the sea of Permission; then the fountain of Ifriqiyyah opposite the sea of Destiny; then the fountain of Nahrawan opposite the Greatest Book.

And as in every station one of the heavenly realm beareth the effusion of universality, so also in the mirrored forms of the abyss is one that beareth the chastisement of universality. The first bearer of the universal effusion in the rank of the outward Will is Muhammad, and in its inward reality, He Who shall arise by the command of God—the living Imam.

Then, in the rank of Will and the five degrees thereof, its outward and its inward are the Imams of religion—twelve souls in number. Hence is each one of them a universal cause in the origination of the possible and the invention of existence, by the permission of God—glorified be His Name.

And in the lower world, the bearer of the outward aspect of the first universal retribution is the First—may the curse of God be upon him—and in the inward, it is he who shall wage war against the Remnant of God at the dawn of His manifestation.

And in the degrees of the outward, the bearers of the waters of the spring of the right hand, and of Tabariyyah, and of Barhut, and of the fountain of Masidan, and of the fountain of Ifriqiyyah, and of the fountain of Nahrawan, are the Imams of the Fire—those who attained the life of the Imams of the Unseen.

And thou knowest that in every series there is correspondence between the worlds above and below, even as hath been cast unto thee—from the rank of meanings unto the station of the noble ones in the judgment of reckoning, and from the series of the eight unto its ultimate end in the station of exposition. All this is but a sprinkling from the water of that river—the Water unpolluted—which, when thou drinkest thereof, draweth thee unto the station of nearness and intimacy, and leadeth thee unto the rising of the pure theophany in the sanctuary of might and holiness.

And verily, in that station, when certain sages journeyed therein, the signs of the manifestation of the Essence in Its very being became confused within their own souls. Therefore did they expound in their writings the mystery of unity in existence and the rising of the Unseen in the outward form of the existent, yet they failed to recall the saying of Ali—peace be upon Him—in his sermon, wherein He declared, exalted be His mention:

> "And sovereignty endureth in sovereignty; the created being endeth in his like; aspiration returneth to its semblance; inquiry leadeth unto helplessness; explanation unto loss; striving unto despair; attainment unto severance. The path is barred and the quest rejected. His signs are His proofs, His being the evidence of His existence."

Part 2: "Now, certain of men, supposing the rank…"

Now, certain of men, supposing the rank of honor to consist in the servant's heedlessness of that station, have argued from His saying, exalted be He: ʿThey entered the city while its people were heedless'—yet this is true only after one hath known the degree of contingency and the absence of direct perception. For prior to the recognition of contingency alone, the foot of the wayfarer stumbleth in seeking to comprehend the rising of the attributes through the manifestation of the Essence.

Hence did Ali—peace be upon Him—indicate this in His saying:

> "Thy power hath been made manifest, O my God, yet Thy form hath not been revealed; wherefore have they likened Thee and taken some of Thy signs as lords besides Thee. Thus have they failed to know Thee."

This, then, is the straight path of justice in the way of the Imams of excellence: that the servant, whensoever he ascendeth, forgetteth not himself, nor supposeth that in the realm of possibility aught can exist beyond its appointed limit. Glorified be God, the One, the Peerless, above the descriptions of the possible and the qualities of the existent! For He, as He is, none knoweth Him save Himself, nor doth any unify Him but He. Exalted and glorified is He!

This is the remembrance of the Water unpolluted, within My heart and upon My tongue—it speaketh of the manifestation of His creative act within Me. Exalted be He above what they describe!

When thou drinkest of the Water unpolluted—the Kawthar—flowing through the veins of those leaves that sprout from the Tree of Divinity, then know the meaning of the pure milk in the yellow quarter of the Throne: that river which floweth beneath the degree of Will, endlessly unto endlessness. It is a river determined by the determination of thingness before the delineation of meaning. It is a living water; and if thou wouldst drink thereof in this mortal life, then tread the path of justice upon the point of grace—for this is the universal guardianship, radiant, sanctified, exalted, and effulgent.

By raising its inward reality above its outward river—the first—there is an increase in the mingling of the clay which preserveth the warmth of fire. To this He alluded in His saying that its taste changeth not; it is the river of longing, attraction, love, and nearness.

Therefore, when He was established upon the throne of majesty, He called, both openly and in secret, unto the rising of beauty, and proclaimed the divinity in the center of earth, the dominion upon the orb of names and attributes, and the sovereignty by likening it to the signet upon His hand—whereof He spoke, exalted be His remembrance, in that station what He spoke.

This is witnessed by those who have lifted the veils of holiness from the rising of majesty and have known Him in the point of balance—the extremity of the summit of the manifestation of the Most High.

Thus did Ali—peace be upon Him—utter in His own soul that which Muhammad, the Messenger of God, had before proclaimed: for the fountains of the milk whose taste changeth not flow by the mention of His determined reality, whose color is that of whiteness.

And in the first rank, the Water unpolluted hath no color by reason of the intensity of its purity, the splendor of its station, and the nearness of its secret unto the rank of its Manifestation. Yet it shineth forth with whiteness in the station of its limit.

And he who drinketh of that spring hath the right to extol the People of God at all times, for God hath manifested Himself unto him through the knowledge of them, and hath decreed in the hidden realm for them that their beings are those through which the beings of all things are sundered from the mention of the Essence in the essences; their essential realities are severed from the dominions in the mention of the attributes within the attributes; their "I-ams" are withdrawn from the kingdoms in the mention of the names and the rising of the pure theophany; and their souls are veiled from the worlds of spirit in the mention of the beginnings and the ends.

Through them all that moveth hath been set in motion within the ocean of justice, beneath the shadow of the radiant tabernacles of Paradise. And through them all that is tranquil was stilled, in the ocean of grace, at the right hand of the Fountain of Ifriqiyyah, beneath the shadow of the Tree of Jarsum in Paradise. The allusions are veils in their description, and the indications are darknesses in their praise. God alone knoweth their true worth and measureth their praise; none besides them can comprehend their rank. And if others should seem to know, their knowledge is but as that of the ant concerning the earth upon which it walketh. I seek the forgiveness of God for even this comparison, which constraineth the boundless within the many.

And if thou wouldst drink of the milk of that river, it behoveth thee to behold within it three living rivers, each as the likeness of man—just as that man to whom Ali ibn al Husayn gave of that water said:

> "I beheld in the cup four rivers. When I would approach the wine, three went before it, as though they were living beings rising in harmony with what moved within my heart."

So is the case with the honey, the milk, and the water unpolluted.

In truth, if thou considerest the matter aright, the Water unpolluted standeth over against the Fountain of the Spirit; the milk over against the Fountain of the Right Hand; the honey over against the Fountain of Tabariyyah; and the wine over against the Fountain of Barhut in the earth of man. The change lieth only in the realm of multiplicity after unity.

And thou hast within this station a hidden symbol, whose veil I now lift, that thou mayest behold with the eye of thine heart, as though thou sawest a ruby-red gem in thy palm. When thou lookest toward the degree of descent, thou shalt see that the river of the Water unpolluted precedeth the three, even as it appeareth in the kingdom. From the day of Adam, the wondrous Word of Will hath caused the Water unpolluted to flow for the remembrance of unity—that there is no God but He. Then, from the day of the mission of Muhammad, the Messenger of God; and again, on the Day of Ghadir, God caused to flow the

Fountain of clarified honey for the testimony of souls to the guardianship of the People of God—the Imams of religion, those honored servants who "speak not before Him, and by His command they act."

And from the day of the rising of that wondrous Cause, God, glorified and exalted, caused to flow the river of wine, a delight unto the drinkers, for the hearts' acknowledgment of that which God had decreed for them in the dawning of the human form—the image of manifestation pre-eternal and concealment everlasting. This pertaineth to the station of descent.

But if thou seekest the decree of ascent, the first of its degrees is the Fountain of wine, then the Fountain of honey, then the Fountain of milk, then the Fountain of water. And when the worlds of descent and ascent meet, the two fountains of wine flow together from the manifestations of guardianship and prophethood in a single essence; this is a token of the secret of the heavenly realm. Know, then, the truth of that wine: in the station of descent it is the secret of the heart; in the station of ascent it is the dust's beginning—the station of bodies.

And the possessors of insight who dwell upon the throne of names and attributes know not what is in the manifestations of divinity, the effulgences of dominion, the disclosures of sovereignty, and the breaths of the kingdom, save through what is here in the world of man. All that I have illumined thee with of the stations of origination and of those rivers is of this kind; for in the station of revelation these mysteries shall not appear save after the return of the People of God—peace be upon them—for "on that Day shall the earth shine with the light of her Lord."

That Day hath its appointed time. When thou hast known the ordinances of the Water of Kawthar, know thou that it is one water: in every station it is mentioned by a name. When it descendeth into the grove of divinity, it is remembered by its name; in the grove of power, by its mention; in the grove of sovereignty, by its designation; in the grove of the kingdom, by its title; in the realm of cloud, by the name of cloud; in the realm of decree, by the name of decree; in the realm of fulfillment, by the name of fulfillment; and in the station of origination, by the name of origination.

The words may seem confused to him who gazeth upon the effulgences of the attributes; yet the sum of all allusion in these tokens is this: thou shalt see no living thing but by the Water of Kawthar. The names and attributes are its marks and its signs. Look upon the Water of Kawthar in the Qur'an: it liveth thereby, flowing from the Fountain at the right hand of the heart of Fatimah—inwardly and outwardly.

And let it not occur to thee that, because manifestation correspondeth to concealment, it must have a single mode or end; nay, the inner realities have manifold outpourings. Among them is the rank of oneness, unaccompanied by aught beside it—this is the utmost depth of inwardness within the inner. From the first river appeareth the inward of the Name of God, the Withholder, through the secret of the rank of fire; from the river of milk whose taste changeth not, the outward of the Name of God, the Living; from the river of clarified honey, the inward of the Name of God, the Quickener; and from the river of wine, a delight unto the drinkers, the inward of the Name of God, the Causer of death.

Thus was Hasan related to the Messenger of God, and Husayn to his Father—this is the secret of that tradition of which thou didst ask Me on the first night. And when thou hast drunk but a single drop of that Water, be assured that the servant attaineth not unto the perfection of his existence in all its degrees

until he is able to cause those four rivers to flow within the world of utterance. Thus did God bestow upon Me, in the station of exposition, the manifestations of the four rivers—indeed, the likeness and the reality are one and the same in the station wherein all flow, by the leave of God, from the Water unpolluted. These are the divine signs, the most exalted of stations in the exposition of the Words, and the supreme proof unto those who abide in the ocean of the names and attributes.

Because of the purity of their manifestation and the loftiness of their inward reality, men have not been able to comprehend them nor draw nigh unto them. Therefore they hear, and flee. This is but due to the remoteness of their station from the primal dawning of manifestation; for had any remained unchanged in his primordial nature, he would have found no sweetness in aught beside it, nor been drawn to any but the love of God with that same attraction which draweth the soul toward Him. That is the Water unpolluted, pure unto God—exalted be He.

Since no admixture of multiplicity entereth into it, it revealeth and reflecteth naught but the effulgence of the Manifestation in the appearing of Him Who is manifested. It is the tongue of the people of that Paradise which hath no shadow; none enter therein save by it. Whoso desireth to enter that Paradise hath no path thereto until he attain unto that station and drink from the Water unpolluted—the mystery of those signs. And he whose heart hath not been opened by those words shall not enter that Paradise save if God so will.

Every realm of being possesseth its rightful rank, so long as the conditions of existence remain unchanged; yet God hath refused to manifest it within the chain of creation save under two names. Had He willed, He could have done otherwise.

In the rank of prophethood, the true flowing of the Water of this river appeared not in its reality, for God granted not His Messenger leave to reveal it, by reason of the incapacity of the people of that age. But today the Water of that river floweth from My tongue and My pen by the will of God—without cessation or decline. It is the Water of the Fountain of the Spirit, of which the Imam said: “The believer is rarer than the red sulphur.”

And verily the matter is so: for through the mere emanation of the Water of that river none hath entered the religion of God save one whose being is rarer than red sulphur. These are the chosen ones, who have reached the summit of detachment. May God grant Me to meet them in the land of holiness, without remembrance of separation or veil.

Because the people have not drunk from the Water of that river, they have been unable to know its station. Each of the other three rivers correspondeth to the nature and love of its drinkers—they drink thereof and praise their Lord. But the pure believer drinketh, before the three rivers, only from that one; for the three are in truth but the names of that river. Indeed, they live by the life of that Water, as God—exalted be His mention—hath said:

> “And We made from water every living thing; will ye not then understand?”

(21:30).

And I, had I not beheld with Mine own eyes the glance of those who see, would interpret that Surah by the flowing of the Water unpolluted. Yet one such as thyself, endowed with vision, knoweth the Cause of God in the Greatest Outlook. Therefore do I beseech God of His bounty to strengthen the hearts of men, that they may drink of that living Water, whereby the trees of Paradise bear fruit and put forth leaves in their degree.

Ah, alas! were men but to know the worth of that Water, they would be content to sacrifice all that is upon the earth in the path of God, that they might drink but a single drop from that river—from My hand, from which it floweth by God's permission. But today most men give no thanks.

And when thou hast understood the ordinance of that river in the ordinance of that Surah, then know also the ordinance of the river of milk whose taste changeth not: it is the Water that floweth in the depths of communion and in the recesses of supplication. It is the fresh milk, the manifest secret, that reflecteth inwardly the Water unpolluted and outwardly the pure milk. It is the water of the spirit of devotion, whereby the servant ascendeth unto the pinnacle of holiness and resteth in the paradise of intimacy.

Thus, when the servant reciteth those prayers in the state of pure absorption, he is drawn unto the court of nearness by an attraction which none can encompass save whom God willeth. And from the swiftness of the flowing of the milk of that river it proceedeth from My pen, filling in six hours a tablet of supplication. This is the supreme honor in the station of the signs, for the secret of the outward pointeth to the secret of the inward.

And this is a matter hard and most difficult: all men know it to be impossible for any save whom God hath willed. For the honor lieth not in the composing of those words, but in the journey of the servant through the kingdom of the names and attributes—swifter than the twinkling of an eye.

By thy life! Were men to taste but the sweetness of that milk, they would gladly rend their bodies limb from limb with their own hands, that they might recite but one of those supplications in solitude. For within them the spirit of divinity pulsates, the mystery of self-subsistence flashes forth, and the ultimate awe of servitude before the justice of God is revealed.

Part 3: "Behold the station of him of whom Ali…"

Behold the station of him of whom Ali ibn al Husayn spoke concerning his own fear, where he said—that saying well known among the men of the heights—that, may my soul be his ransom, he made manifest the matter in the secret of servitude within the bounds of limitation. And in that station he passeth, in many degrees, from the world of limitation unto that which is without end—endlessly unto endlessness—and this honor none may equal in all the realm of names and attributes.

As for me, in that station, I am pure dust—naught but sin—beside a single letter of what Ali ibn al Husayn uttered; for my being hath been consumed by the radiance of the light of his act—may my spirit be sacrificed for him! What, then, is dust compared with the Lord of the firmament of names and attributes?

It behoveth one such as thyself, possessed of that noble rank, to make known unto the people the import of those supplications; for they are pure glory unto the possessors of insight who have attained unto the abode of return. It beseemeth not one of thy station to remain silent among men, nor to allude to the Cause through the veils of those who are distant. For might and honor lie not in such things.

Let not the heed of men nor their conduct grieve thee, for the best of creation was reviled from the pulpits for a thousand months, though the Imam was present, endowed with power, mastery, and dominion—He Who, had He but willed, could have annihilated all that is in the heavens and the earth ere the thought of it arose within His heart. Even as was declared in that tradition wherein the wondrous mysteries of the Paradise of Jarsum are treasured and the marvellous manifestations of the realm of Paradise are inscribed—the tradition transmitted by Ibn Yazid al Jufi, who said:

When the caliphate passed to the sons of Umayyah, they shed the sacred blood, cursed the Commander of the Faithful from the pulpits for a thousand months, disavowed him, and slandered the Shiah in every city. They uprooted their foundations from the world for the sake of the fleeting vanities of this life. The people throughout the lands were filled with fear; whosoever failed to curse the Commander of the Faithful and disavow him was slain, whosoever he might be.

Jabir ibn Yazid al Jufi said:

> "I complained of the sons of Umayyah and their partisans to the manifest Imam, the purest of the pure, the adornment of the worshippers, the chief of the ascetics, the vicegerent of God among His servants—Ali ibn al Husayn, peace be upon him. For they had cursed him from the pulpits, on the towers, in the markets, and along the roads; they had disavowed him openly. Indeed, they would gather in the Mosque of the Messenger of God and curse Ali, peace be upon him, in public, and none would forbid them or speak against them. If any among us protested, they would fall upon him as one body, saying, This man is a Rafidi, a partisan of Abu Turab,' and they would seize him and bring him before their ruler, saying, This man has spoken well of Abu Turab!' They would strike him, imprison him, and then kill him."

When the Imam, peace be upon him, heard this from me, he raised his gaze toward heaven and said:

> "Glorified art Thou, O my Lord! Thou hast given Thy servants respite in Thy lands until they have thought Thou wouldst grant it forever. Yet all this is before Thine eyes; Thy decree none can overcome, Thy determined plan none can reverse. Thou doest as Thou wilt, and Thou knowest better than we."

Then he, peace be upon him, called his son Muhammad and said: "O my son." He answered: "Here am I, my master." He said: "When the morrow cometh, go unto the Mosque of the Messenger of God, and stir the thread gently—gently, not violently—for if thou stir it with force, all the people will perish."

Jabir continued: "I was amazed at his words, and I pondered them through the night, not knowing what to think. When morning came, I went to Muhammad, eager to see the thread and its movement. I was mounted upon my beast when the Imam came forth. I dismounted, greeted him, and he returned my greeting. He said, What bringeth thee here? Thou art not wont to come at this hour.' I replied, O son of

the Messenger of God, yesterday I heard thy father say,"Take the thread, go to the Mosque of the Messenger of God, move it gently, and move it not violently lest all men perish."'

He said: ʿO Jabir, were it not for the appointed time, the fixed term, and the decreed fate, by God, I would cause this perverse creation to be swallowed up in the twinkling of an eye—nay, in a moment, nay, in an instant. But we are honored servants; we do not speak before Him, and by His command we act.'

I said: ʿO my master, why didst thou not do this when I came yesterday and the Shiah complained of what they endure from the accursed Nawasib and the deficient Qadariyyah?'

He said: ʿIndeed, O Jabir, I sought to strike fear into them that perchance they might awaken; I had wished that a portion of them might perish, that God might cleanse the land of them and bring rest to His servants.'

I said: ʿO my master, how canst thou strike fear into them, when they are more than can be counted?'

He said: ʿCome with me to the mosque, that I may show thee a token of the power of God Most High, which He hath bestowed upon us, and the favor with which He hath distinguished us above mankind.'

Jabir continued: *"So I went with him to the mosque. He prayed two rakahs, then laid his cheek upon the dust and spoke certain words. Then he raised his head and drew from his sleeve a slender thread, from which issued the fragrance of musk; it was finer to behold than the thread of a needle. He said, Take it.' I walked slowly. He said, Stand still, O Jabir.' So I stood, and he moved the thread softly—so softly that I could scarcely see its movement. Then he said, Give me the end of the thread.' I handed it to him. I asked, What hast thou done, O son of the Messenger of God?'

He said: ʿWoe unto thee! Go forth among the people and see what hath befallen them.'

I went forth from the mosque—and lo! cries and wailing rose from every quarter and street. There was a great shaking and trembling; the city quaked, and more than thirty thousand men and women perished beneath its ruins. The houses were overturned, and the people poured forth, weeping, crying aloud, bewailing the calamity. Some said, It is the earthquake!' others, It is the thunderclap!' others, It is the convulsion!' and others, It is the Resurrection!' Most of the people perished.

Groups came running toward the mosque, saying to one another, ʿHow should the earth not swallow us up, when we have forsaken enjoining good and forbidding evil, and wickedness and corruption abound, fornication and hypocrisy and the drinking of wine and abominable acts have increased? By God, worse than this shall befall us unless we amend our ways!'

Jabir continued:

> "I was astonished; I watched them weeping, crying, and running in confusion toward the mosque in crowds, until I was moved with compassion for them—and, by God, I wept for their weeping. They knew not whence the punishment had come upon them."

Then I returned to the Imam al Baqir, peace be upon him. The people had gathered around him, crying:

> “O son of the Messenger of God! Seest thou what hath befallen us and the sanctuary of the Messenger of God? The people have perished and died—pray to God, the Exalted, for us!”

He said to them: “Turn to prayer, almsgiving, and supplication.”

Then he said to me: “O Jabir, what is the state of the people?”

I said:

> “O my master, ask not, O son of the Messenger of God! The houses and palaces have been struck down, and the people have perished. I beheld them without mercy, and I was moved to pity for them.”

He said:

> “May God never have mercy upon them! Verily, there remaineth in thee still a trace of softness; were it not so, thou wouldst not have shown pity to our enemies and the enemies of our friends.”

Then he said:

> “Away, away! Far removed be the people of iniquity! By God, had the thread been moved but a little more, they would all have perished; the highest of them would have been cast down, the lowest raised up, and not a house nor a palace would have remained. But my Lord and Master commanded me not to move it with violence.”

Then he ascended the minaret while I watched him, though the people saw him not. He cried out in a mighty voice: “O ye erring and deniers!” The people thought it a voice from heaven, and they fell upon their faces, their hearts trembling within them, crying out in their prostration: “Mercy! mercy!” They heard the cry of truth, but saw not the speaker. Then he motioned with his hand—I beheld it, though the people saw it not—and again the city quaked, though not as before; many houses were overthrown. Then he recited: “And that is how We recompensed them for their wrongdoing.”

After descending, he continued: “And when Our command came, We made its uppermost part its lowest, and rained upon them stones of baked clay, marked by thy Lord for the extravagant.” And he recited: “Then the roof fell upon them from above, and the punishment came upon them from whence they knew not.”

Jabir said:

> “During the second earthquake, the veiled women fled from their chambers with uncovered heads; children were crying aloud, yet no one heeded them. When al-Baqir beheld this, he stretched forth his hand, gathered the thread into his palm, and the trembling ceased. He then took me by the hand—none of the people saw him—and we went out of the mosque.”

“There was a crowd gathered at the door of the blacksmith’s shop, many people saying, Did you not hear that murmuring just now?’ Some said, Yes, much murmuring indeed’; others said, Yes, by God, it was

voices, speech, cries—but by God, we could not make out the words.' The Imam al-Baqir looked at me and smiled, saying, O Jabir, this is our way and their way: when they wax proud, exult, rebel, and commit tyranny, we strike terror into them and burn them; if they repent, well; if not, then God's command is executed against them."'

Jabir said: "I asked, O son of the Messenger of God, what is this thread that holds such power?' He replied, This is a remnant of that which the family of Moses and Aaron left behind, borne unto us by the angels. O Jabir, we have before God a rank and a station exalted indeed. Were it not for us, God would not have created earth nor heaven, nor Paradise nor Hell, nor fruits nor moon, nor land nor sea, nor plain nor mountain, nor moist nor dry, nor sweet nor bitter, nor water nor plant nor tree. God created us from the light of His own Essence. No human can be compared with us. Through us hath the Almighty saved you; through us hath He guided you. By God, we are those who raised you above your Lord—stand firm, then, by our command and our prohibition. Reject not whatever proceedeth from us; for verily, we are greater, mightier, more exalted, and higher than all that cometh unto you. Whatever ye understand thereof, praise God for it; and whatever ye comprehend not, commit its meaning unto us, and say:"Our Imams know best what they have spoken.""'

Then the governor of the city arrived, riding with his guards, and they cried out to the people:

> "O people! Come forth unto the son of the Messenger of God, Ali ibn al-Husayn, and draw nigh unto God through him, that haply God may avert from you this chastisement."

When they beheld Muhammad ibn Ali al-Baqir, they hastened toward him, saying:

> "O son of the Messenger of God! Seest thou what hath befallen the community of thy grandsire Muhammad? They have perished to the last! Where is thy father, that we may beseech him to come forth to the mosque and intercede with God, that He may lift this calamity from the people of thy grandsire?"

Muhammad ibn Ali said:

> "God will do as He willeth. Reform yourselves, repent, humble yourselves, and refrain from what ye do; for none feeleth secure from the plan of God but the lost."

Jabir continued: "Then we went to Ali ibn al-Husayn, who was in prayer. We waited until he finished, then he came toward us and said: O Muhammad, what news of the people?' He replied: They have seen of the power of God that which hath left them amazed.' I said: Their ruler hath sent to ask thee to come to the mosque, that the people may gather and pray and beseech God to remove from them what hath befallen.' The Imam smiled and recited: Did not My messengers come unto you with clear proofs? They said,"Yea." He said, "Then pray, for the prayer of the disbelievers is but in vain."' And again he recited: ʿEven if We were to send down unto them the angels, and the dead were to speak unto them, and We were to gather all things before them, they would not believe unless God willed; yet most of them know not."'

Then he said: “Aye, they know not whence this befell them.” And he recited: “This day We shall forget them, even as they forgot the meeting of this their day, and as they denied Our signs.” He said: “By God, these are Our signs, and this is one of them; by God, it is Our guardianship of which God hath spoken in His Book: ʿNay, We hurl the truth against falsehood, and it smiteth it, and lo, it vanisheth. And woe unto you for what ye forge!”’

Then Jabir said:

> “What sayest thou, O son of the Messenger of God, of a people who have extinguished our way, befriended our enemies, violated our sanctuaries, wronged and angered us, revived the customs of the oppressors, and followed in the path of the corrupt?”

He replied:

> “Praise be to God, Who hath bestowed upon Me abundant honor in that He hath exalted you and guided Me to your obedience—to love your friends and hate your foes.”

The Imam said:

> “O Jabir, knowest thou what true knowledge is? It is this: first, the affirmation of divine unity; second, the knowledge of the meanings; third, the knowledge of the Gates; fourth, the knowledge of the Imam; fifth, the knowledge of the Pillars; sixth, the knowledge of the Elect; and seventh, the knowledge of the Chosen.”

Verily, He—exalted be His mention—hath said: “Say: If the sea were ink for the words of my Lord, the sea would be exhausted before the words of my Lord were exhausted; and even if We were to bring the like thereof as a supplement, the words of my Lord would not be exhausted.” And He likewise said: “And were all the trees on earth pens and the sea (itself) replenished with seven seas behind it, the words of God would not be ended; surely God is Mighty, Wise.”

O Jabir, the establishment of Divine Unity and the knowledge of the meanings—these are two things. As to the establishment of Unity: it is the knowledge of God, the Ancient, the Hidden, Whom vision cannot grasp, yet Who taken in all vision; He is the Subtle, the Well-Acquainted. [Q6:103] He is a Hiddenness that shall be apprehended in the manner He hath described of Himself.

Part 4: “As to the meanings—behold, we are…”

As to the meanings—behold, we are His meanings and we are His manifestation in you. We were created from the light of His Self, and unto us He hath entrusted the affairs of His servants. By His leave we do whatsoever We will; when We desire, God willeth, and when We will, God ordaineth. He hath appointed for Us this station and chosen Us from among His servants, and made Us His proof in His lands. Whoever denyeth aught of this and turneth it back, hath thereby turned back against God—exalted be His Name—and hath denied His signs, His prophets and His messengers.

O Jabir, he who knoweth God by this attribute hath established Unity; for this attribute accords with what is revealed in the Book: “He it is whom the eyes cannot grasp, and He grasps the eyes; and there is none

like unto Him; and He is the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing." And He saith, "He is not questioned concerning what He doeth, while they are questioned." (21–23).

Jabir said, "O my master, how few are my companions!" He answered, "Far be it! Dost thou know how many of thy followers there are upon the face of the earth?" I replied, "O son of the Messenger of God, I supposed in every town from a hundred to two hundred, and in some places from a thousand to two thousand; yea, I even thought there might be more than a hundred thousand at the extremities of the earth."

He—peace be upon him—said, "Thy thought is mistaken and thy view too contracted: those whom thou reckonest as companions are deficient and are not truly thy companions." I asked, "O son of the Messenger, who are the deficient?" He replied, "Those who have failed in the knowledge of the Imams and in the recognition of that which God hath enjoined upon them of His command and His Spirit." I asked, "O my master, and what is the knowledge of His Spirit?" He said, "Whomsoever God chooseth and endoweth with that Spirit, unto him He hath entrusted His command: he createth by His leave, quickeneth by His leave, knoweth the hidden things of the hearts, and knoweth what hath been and what shall be until the Day of Resurrection. This Spirit is of the affair of God; he whom God hath thus singled out with this Spirit is perfect and without lack; he doeth whatsoever he will by God's permission. He traverseth from East to West in a single moment by God's leave; he ascendeth with it unto the heavens and descendeth with it unto the earth and doeth whatsoever he willeth."

I said, "O my master, show me the proof of this Spirit from the Book of God, and that it is of that affair which God hath specially bestowed upon Muhammad." He said, "Read this verse: And thus We inspired into thee a Spirit from Our command; thou knewest not what the Book was, nor what faith was; but We made it a light whereby We guide whomsoever We will from among Our servants.' And His saying, Those in whose hearts is faith, We strengthen them with a Spirit from Us."'

I rejoiced at his words and prayed God to make me firm in the knowledge of His Self and of the Cause. Then I said, "O my master, are many of our partisans remiss? For I know not among my companions one who possesseth this attribute." He replied, "O Jabir, if thou knowest none among them, yet I know of a small company who come and salute and learn from Me Our secret and Our hidden knowledge." I said, "Such-and-such, son of so-and-so, and his companions are of that character, God willing; for I have heard from them some of your secrets and the inner aspect of your knowledge, and I judge that they are perfected and have attained."

He said, "Call them tomorrow and bring them with thee." I did so. They came, greeted the Imam, drew near and revered him, and stood before him. He said, "O Jabir, they are indeed thy brethren, and there remaineth a trace of them upon them. Know ye, O band, that God doeth whatsoever He willeth and determineth whatsoever He will; none can reverse His decree nor repel His judgment, nor is He questioned concerning what He doeth while they are questioned." They answered, "Yea, God doeth whatsoever He willeth and determineth whatsoever He will." I said, "Praise be to God, they have perceived and attained." He said, "O Jabir, be not hasty with what thou hast learned."

I remained perplexed. He said, “Ask them whether ʿAli ibn al-Husayn can become in the form of his son Muhammad.” I asked them, and they fell silent. He said, “Ask them whether Muhammad can be in my form.” They were struck dumb. He looked upon me and said, “O Jabir, this is what I told thee: a remnant remaineth with them.” I said to them, “Why do ye not answer your Imam?” They were silent and afraid. He looked upon them and said, “O Jabir, I told thee there remaineth with them a remnant.” Then al-Baqir said, “Why are ye speechless?” They looked upon one another and said, “O son of the Messenger of God, we have no knowledge.” He taught them, and then the Imam, the Master of the Worshippers, Ali ibn al-Husayn—peace be upon him—looked upon his son Muhammad al-Baqir and said to them, “Who is this?”

They answered, “Thy son.” He asked, “Who am I?” He answered, “Thy father, Ali ibn al-Husayn.” Then Muhammad spoke words we could not comprehend—and lo! Muhammad was in the appearance of his father, Ali ibn al-Husayn, and Ali was in the likeness of his son, Muhammad. They cried: “There is no God but God,” and the Imam said, “Marvel not at the power of God: I am Muhammad and Muhammad is I.” Muhammad said, “O people, marvel not at God’s affair: I am Ali and Ali is I, and we are all one from one light, and our spirit is of the command of God—our beginning Muhammad and our end Muhammad; we are all Muhammad.”

When they heard this, they prostrated, saying, “We believe in your guardianship, your secret and public manifestations, and we acknowledge your exclusive prerogatives.” The Imam Zayn al-ʿAbidin said, “O people, lift up your heads, for now are ye the knowing, the winners, the enlightened, the perfect and the reached. By God, do not cleave unto the remiss and the weak, to what ye have seen in Me and in Muhammad, lest they cast slander upon you and deny you.” They answered, “We hear and we obey.” Then they departed rightly guided and perfected.

I said, “O my master, what of him who knoweth not this matter in the manner Thou hast wrought and declared it, yet possesseth his proof and uttereth: ʿBy your virtue, I disavow your enemies’—what shall be his state?” He said, “He is in good stead until he attain.” I asked, “O son of the Messenger of God, is there aught that may abase them?” He said, “Yea: if they fail in the rights of their brethren and do not share with them of their wealth and their secrets and public honours, and seize the trifles of this world for themselves to the exclusion of their brethren, then there shall be established for them virtue that shall be torn away from them, and they shall be smitten by the calamities of this world—loss of recompense, dissipation of their band—because they failed in the duty of kindness to their brethren.”

I became overwhelmed with grief and said, “O son of the Messenger of God, what is the right of a believer upon his believing brother?” He answered, “He rejoiceth in his joy, sorroweth in his sorrow, accomplisheth all his affairs for him, and coveteth not of the fleeting things of this world save only that he assist him so that they may both partake of good and evil together.” I said, “O my master, how hath God enjoined upon the believer all these rights towards his brother?” He replied, “Because the believer is the brother of the believer by their Father and Mother; thus he is most deserving of his brother in all that he possesseth.”

I said, “Glory be to God! Who can accomplish this?” He said, “He who desireth to strike the gates of Paradise, embrace the fair houris, and be gathered with Us in the Abode of Peace.” I said, “Alas! By God, O son of the Messenger of God, I have failed in the rights of my believing brethren.”

When thou hast beheld those effulgent lights and discerned the unveilings of the hidden mysteries, then know the ordinance of the River of Pure Honey; for it floweth, by the leave of God, through the domain of orations and discourses, and is sweeter than all allusions among the tokens of the dwellers in the realms of holiness. For these have borne the veils of divine permission beyond the River first and second; hence did the enemies of God—despite their remoteness and denial—acknowledge the summit of eloquence in the third Ha?iyyah sermon, where God magnified His vengeance in His Book, though they grasped not a single letter of Our intimations. Yea, even when they discerned, they rejected, though inwardly assured and knowing, for the matter hath been revealed in the sermons with a majesty such that the deniers of justice bear witness to excellence. The pride of the Arabs was ever that the excellence of oration was confessed even by those who disowned the scrolls of truth.

That River is, in the hidden realm, opposed to the Spring of Tabariyyah in the manifest world; whoso drinketh thereof shall perceive the emanations of the Divine Being in their signs and behold the dawning of the attributes in the manifestations of power and the luminous tokens of might. He shall delight in the sweetness of the Pure Honey, in the remembrance of the essences of kingly being and the corporeal forms of the spiritual dominion. This is a divine potency in the eyes of the knowers, for the eloquence of the discourse proceeding from invincible might is the portion of the most eloquent of Arabs, and none of the sages, save by God's will, can attain thereto.

Suffice it to mention: within the words is a sermon, within the signs an architecture, within the supplications the rising of servitude, and within the verses the revelation of Lordship cast into the reality of servitude. Thou, by thine own witnessing, knowest all this through the attributes of the human kind. The emergence of the River of Pure Honey in the attributes is the greatest and loftiest of manifestations—higher than the appearance in the paradisal words, the hallowed theophanies, the creative realities, the universal verses, and the African springs—for all these proceed from the domain of beauty. And verily it is of greater worth than the remembrance of attributes and names. So did God chastise those who wronged thee by His decree; unto God is the complaint, for unto Him belongeth the beginning and the end. Glorified be He above that which they ascribe unto Him.

Among the rivers is the River of Crimson Wine; whoso drinketh but a drop thereof is drawn into the station of holiness and nearness—without intoxication, without pain, without swooning, without veil; it is spirit within spirit, from spirit unto spirit. Whoso drinketh thereof recalleth the first river in the station of attributes, the second in the station of supplication, and the third in the station of discourse, and his own station through the intimations of divinity, the tokens of omnipotence, the degrees of sovereignty, and the evidences of the spiritual kingdom. From that river drink most men, for knowledge none can deny; hence mankind loveth the manifestation of that station. This is a flowing from the River of Wine, whose end is without end—it is the most delightful of draughts, the might of words in the world of holiness.

This is an ordinance of justice, like the three rivers; none among creation confoundeth it. Shouldst thou desire to behold the mystery of this matter, direct thy gaze toward Our purpose, and then interpret; thou wilt behold My interpretation therein unlike thine, for the descent of the words floweth from beneath the Mountain of Pre-Eternity, manifest in the heart. The ink's stream floweth without end or cessation.

By thy life! Within My breast there lieth knowledge abundant—purer than the Water unpolluted, subtler than the pure milk, sweeter than the clarified honey, and more delicious than the crimson wine. Had I found vessels or hearts made pure, I would have poured it forth, by God's permission. Yet the veil of the people profiteth not from this knowledge, nor hath any share therein save the sincere among the people of insight. For men perceive not what I behold in the signs, nor see what I see in the words, nor discern the places of the tokens. Were any other than thee to inquire of Me, I would not have unveiled these intimations, for they are to Me dearer than the philosopher's stone.

Yet, though in some instances I have refrained from mentioning the depths of the ocean for fear of the alien gaze, and have clothed the words in the dark garments of air for those who discern not the rising of the attributes amid those thick, black, blind and desolate veils, lest any of the wicked pry into the true mysteries of the Family of God and sow corruption in the earth without the leave of the righteous—still, I withheld not the bounty from thee. I bound Myself to make manifest what I was commanded in thine address. Were one to know but a single letter thereof and act upon it purely for the sake of God—One, peerless, incomparable—he would profit thee more than all else. For thy question concerning that commentary hath opened the gate of the galaxy for the descent of that mercy upon the heads of humankind.

Pray, then, that God may dispel the veil of sorrow through the rising of the Sun of Harmony, and restore what men have corrupted through the bounty of His power—for He is the Bestower of grace.

And when thou hast grasped these ordinances, lift the gaze of thy heart unto that hidden cipher, that minute mystery, that supreme talisman: that the truth of Divine Unity is unattainable to any soul save when the light of the Countenance of the Manifested One shineth forth in all His stations and signs, in His motions and stillness, His glances, allusions, tokens, and proofs—until, even as the heart is the pure disclosure of the Unity of the Essence, so shall the element of dust within the heat of the attributes mirror it, that the body itself may proclaim by its very substance what the tongue declareth in word.

When the soul attaineth unto that rank, there streameth forth from his very frame the same effulgence that shineth from his heart—the theophanies of purity, the manifestations of constancy, the mysteries of the essences, the dawnings of the attributes. He becometh an image of the world above, a reflection of the universal light, the secret of the Divine, the manifest sign, the radiant token, the universal Tree. These are the degrees of the appearance of action in the rank of passion. Blessed, thrice blessed, is he who attaineth that station; and all hail, all glory, to him who abideth upon that carpet and beholdeth the Light of God above the canopy of justice in the very midst of its expanse.

That is the utmost reach of the servant in the degree of dust among the worlds of divine manifestation: the realms of Deity, of Power, of Dominion, of Sovereignty, and of Humanity. Pray God to raise thee and me unto that most exalted and uplifted station, for if the servant attain not thereto in this life and yet would enter the court of the holiness of majesty, he shall find no way save if God so willeth—in the stations of return, in the isthmuses of intermediate being, in the conditions of resurrection. For He is the Bestower, the Gentle unto His servants; He granteth unto whom He willeth, as He willeth, what He willeth. None can repel His command or alter His decree, and unto Him returneth every affair, both first and last.

9. Commentary on the Surah in the degrees of descent and ascent

And when thou hast borne witness in that answering House by the ordinance of return, prepare thyself for the spreading of the peacock's wings before the Throne of Holiness; for the Dove of Mystery even now flieth in mid-heaven, chanting an interpretation most wondrous of that Surah, at whose melody heaven and earth are thunderstruck, knowing its tone. It maketh every Surah a hymn of praise unto God for Himself; therein lieth the true interpretation, the sign of unity, the image of abstraction—yea, they are one and the same, without likeness, in the correspondence of their stations.

Even as the Prince of Martyrs, peace be upon him, interpreted the Surah of Unity, saying: "The meaning of ʿHe' is He, God." Thus, unto the end of the stations of names, the Surah unfoldeth in the remembrance of attributes, tokens, stations, and proofs. So is it in the sight of God and of those who dwell in the Ocean of Singleness and the Abyss of Abstraction, that blessed Surah whose meaning is "I am He, He is I." This correspondence is perfected when the appointed term of self's Sinai is complete after the number of forty—the number of the letters of Huwa. And if thou wouldst apply the reckoning of all its letters one by one, thou couldst accomplish it; and when thou beholdest the multitude of numbers, increase them through the aid of the Spirit of Faith within thee, by the leave of God.

And when the Pen moved to send down that galaxy, opening the gate of that commentary, I poured forth in that station a sprinkling for whoso loveth thee and seeketh to drink of that living Water of Kawthar. But were the adversaries to seek to drink thereof, God would forbid them the draught of the dwellers in Paradise, and would exchange it for vessels of phantasmal semblance—more grievous to them, more tormenting to their souls than the fire of Gehenna itself, if they did but understand.

And if thou desirest the interpretation upon the plane of descent, then take the Surah of Unity as the balance of exposition, and cast upon it the letters of the Surah of Kawthar. For the letters of Ana Huwa after taking the ten degrees from the worlds of Deity, Power, Dominion, and Sovereignty, the last letter remaineth itself—Ana—which is itself the letter Huwa in this world. This is a sign of the world above, for the people of insight among the possessors of the Names and Attributes know not what is beyond save by what is here. And whoso hath recognized the places of the attributes within this earthly image, this divine shadow, this garment of pre-eternity, this radiant effulgence, he hath reached the resting-place of knowledge in the secret of reality, unveiled the inner mystery, and perceived the manifest sign and the ordinances of the Law.

Know, then, as I have known, but conceal what I have concealed; for the matter belongeth unto God—He doeth what He willeth, as He willeth, by what He willeth. Glorified be He above that which they ascribe.

And when thou hast borne witness to the letter Ana and to the letter Huwa, then know that in the depths of the Name of God is mirrored the vessel of Prophethood in the rank of the word Qul—after subtracting the letters of unity, which are the ha' and the lam, and the ocean of "Inna attaynaka." Thus doth it correspond in the numbering of the alphabetic letters; and verily this is a vast knowledge—he who pondereth it shall cause springs of the Water of Kawthar to gush forth, whose number none knoweth save God. And this indeed is the knowledge of the true decree—he who hath been given thereof hath been granted the very wisdom of certitude.

And verily, that is the knowledge of the true decree—he who is granted thereof hath been given abundant good. Then set the measure in correspondence with the ocean of Oneness, and balance the abyss of multiplicity with the Water of Kawthar. For the letters of Ahad (the One) are the hidden degrees of action—seven in number—and their outward manifestation, without mention of the station of Will, is six.

In the rank of these seven hidden ones—each, when it turneth unto the first degrees of the hundred letters that are the letters of Prophethood in the word Qul—with the reckoning of each of the seven joined to the remaining five, it correspondeth with the number of the alphabetic letters. The added letter Alif is the sign of Unity after the meeting of the two seas: it is the barzakh between them, dividing the ocean of Oneness from the gulf of multiplicity, that nothing of this entereth into that, nor of that into this. Thus hath God established the order of the world above in correspondence with the world below.

But let not there arise in thy heart the thought of what the Sufis—may God magnify His vengeance upon them—have uttered, saying that "existence is one," and that it is the existence of the Essence of the One, defined in manifestation when the Sun of inwardness hath set; for such a notion is sheer unbelief according to the doctrine of the Family of God. Nay, the Ahad entereth not into number; it is a name created by God. Its correspondence lieth in the aspect of its namehood, which is created, like Kawthar itself; otherwise, in the station of the indication of its essential reality, it is joined with nothing, described by nothing beneath it, for it is a sign of God—exalted be He above what the wrongdoers assert.

The Wahid (the One) is the beginning of multiplicities in the realm of names and attributes. When the waves of the ocean of multiplicity surge against the expanse of the attributes and the dawning of the Essence, then consider the Word of the Almighty: Allahus-Samad—"God, the Eternal." Thus recite the servant's words, "Qul", which is the decisive utterance. The additional Alif in the balance pointeth to the secret of Oneness within the radiance of Eternity, wherewith the servant prayeth in remembrance of Him. Whoso drinketh of the Kawthar that floweth in those rivers over the depths of those words, he is enabled to worship wholly God, the Eternal; and that indeed is a mighty thing.

When thou ponderest what hath shone forth, bear witness to His word li-Rabbika in relation to His saying, lam yalid—"He begetteth not"—and add thereto the number of one hundred and forty, of which one hundred and twenty-eight allude to the remembrance of Husayn, for he appeared in the fourth station; and twelve thereof allude to the letters of La ilaha illa'Llah in the inscribed numbers, which are twelve and no more. Thus, understand in the domain of majesty the verse lam yulad—"nor is He begotten"—and the verse wa anhar—"and sacrifice."

Interpret the one hundred and thirty-nine additional letters in wa anhar as the number of the name ʿAli ibn al-Husayn, for he is the bearer of the Cause of Husayn. Then add the number of the letters of the Name of God, the Living, and then of Huwa (He); thus doth it correspond in the balance. Then bear witness to His saying wa lam yakun—"and there is none"—for the remaining letters in correspondence are those hidden in the unseen knowledge of God, being the number of the name Muhammad Rasul Allah—ninety-two. The thirteen additional letters are a sign of the appearance of the Family of God—peace be upon them—after the mention of Muhammad, the Messenger of God—may blessings be upon Him and His family.

In this station have I alluded to a fine cipher and a sealed talisman—thou shalt know it if thou ponder. Glorified be God, Lord of the Throne, above what they ascribe.

And in like manner, understand His word lahu—"unto Him"—in correspondence with sha'nuka—"thy station." Compute together the number of lahu with the number of the name Ja'far, the Imam of justice, after subtracting sixteen, which is an allusion to the manifestation of the name al-Jawad and the letter ba' in al-ʿata' (the gift), in the world of the first manifestation—the pillar of unity—and the fourth pillar, the red pillar, the station of glorification. These have stations too great for the Pen to describe, for the devil and his hosts have defiled them. Unto God is the complaint in the hereafter and the herebefore.

And the matter, as known among the discerning, is outwardly clear; for were the Possessor of this earth to behold what hath transpired upon it, he would ask its inhabitants a question confirming what hath been witnessed in this Cause. Then understand, in the domain of majesty, the narration transmitted by Abu Ja'far al-Tusi, from a group, from al-Tal'akbari, from Ibn Hammam, from Jamil, from al-Qasim ibn Isma'il, from Ahmad ibn Ribah, from Abu'l-Farah Aban ibn Muhammad known as al-Sindi—we recited it from its source.

He said:

> "Abu Abd Allah (Ja'far al-Sadiq), peace be upon him, was performing the pilgrimage in the year when Abu Abd Allah came to the House and stood beneath the water-spout, praying. On his right was Abd Allah ibn al-Hasan, on his left al-Hasan ibn al-Hasan, and behind him Ja'far ibn al-Hasan. Then came Abbad ibn Kathir al-Basri and said: O Aba Abd Allah!' He was silent. He said it a second and a third time. Then the Imam said: Speak what thou wilt, O Aba Kathir.' He said: I have found in one of my books the knowledge of this proof: that a man shall demolish it stone by stone.' The Imam said: Thy book lieth, O Aba Kathir! Nay, by God, he shall be yellow of foot, lean of leg, black of head—standing by this corner,' and he pointed to the Yemeni Corner, forbidding the people to circumambulate until they are driven away. Then God shall raise against him a man from me,' and he pointed to his breast, who shall slay him with the death of Ad and Thamud and Pharaoh of the Stakes.' Then Abd Allah ibn al-Hasan said: By God, Abu ʿAbd Allah speaketh the truth!' And they all assented together."

Glorified be God, Lord of the Throne, above what they ascribe! And peace be upon the messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds.

The Bab—Middle Writings of the second period (Shiraz, April-August 1846)

Volume 010-010. Contains 16 writings.

BB00021: Tafsir al-Ha I (Tafsir-i-Alifayn: Commentary on the Letter Ha')

To: Abu'l-Hasani'l-Husayni

Date: unknown (late Shiraz)

Part 1: "Praise be to God Who hath made…"

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who hath made the embellishment of the Tablets of Creation to be the embellishment of the upright Alif between the two letters, which hath shone forth and radiated through that which was compassionate and articulate. Then God made it a sign unto Himself by Himself without the fire of His Essence touching it. Verily it was willed before it was determined, ordained after it was decreed, executed when it was ordained, then set forth and permitted and made firm. Then the horizons were filled therewith.

And praise be to God Who hath formed that letter with the two letters through the shining forth of that which shone from the light of the Sun of Eternity, which was determined after it was willed, and ordained after it was decreed, and brought near when it was set forth and reckoned. Then through it He revealed Himself unto all who dwell in the kingdom of Command and Creation, until he who was thunderstruck at the first Mount recovered and awakened.

Praise be to God Who hath joined through His Command between that letter through the existence of the point beneath the Ba, then through the creation of the Ba after the Alif, that He might distinguish between all according to their station in the Cause, and make happy those who are made happy through their faithfulness to the Covenant, and make wretched those who are made wretched through following their desires and going astray on the Day of the Covenant. For on that Day shall the leg be bared by the leg, and God shall judge between all according to what their hands have wrought, and thy Lord is not unjust to His servants. Verily He shall recompense all for what their hands have done on the Day of Meeting.

Praised be God—He from Whom there shone forth that which dawned, and from Whose radiance burst the light that cleft the firmaments from the Realm of the Cloud; that it might be enfolded, after the ranks were arrayed, in the thicket of the Godhead as the Bird of Destiny, in the grove of Might as the Cock of Praise, and in the gardens of the Kingdom and the Dominion as the Peacock of Glory—there to quiver with its melodies upon the branches of the Tree of Manifestation, and to sound its peals amid the hosts of the bees of Sinai. Every thing abideth in its station; and all shall hear the clamour of that which gleamed forth from the light of the morn of pre-eternity—whatsoever great or small upon which the name "thing" hath fallen. Praised be God!

And praised be God—He from Whom that which was uttered found its rising, Who showed compassion upon that which dawned, Who shed radiance upon that which was dispersed and drawn together, and Who assigned unto it a governance and a tenderness which became manifest and exalted after abasement, after kindling and submission; which grew mighty, glittered, trembled, separated and conjoined, aided and opposed, confronted and distinguished—according as it stood firm, proclaimed, revolved, illumined, became evident, willed, was thunder-struck, was established, surged, flashed, blazed,

was recalled, gasped, proclaimed again, was made weak and revived—until it cried, like a bewildered fish cast upon the dust:

> "There is no God but Thee! Glory be to Thee! Unto Thee have I turned in repentance, and I am the first of those who repent."

And now—there hath descended unto the remembrancer the wondrous Remembrance from One of lofty lineage and exalted rank, of surpassing honor and inviolable might. Such was not its form in the Book; He is the Mighty. O my Lord! Bestow upon me the grace of lifting the veil from the countenance of the Cause, by whatsoever face Thou willest; for my plight hath grown severe, and by God, my purpose is naught but the unveiling of the state. Here stand I before God, saying: Peace be upon Thee, as long as the Sun of creation riseth by creation, and the sun of invention setteth by invention.

I have read that which thou didst send down from the clouds of the heaven of Thy Will, and I have discerned that to which Thou didst allude in the inward recesses of Thy verses—as though Thou didst intend, by the unveiling of the secret, to disclose the countenance of that which is concealed. Otherwise, that which is hidden in the lines lay before Thee like a parchment spread open. If the secret be a secret whose veil may be lifted from its face, then verily it standeth, between the lines, disclosed before Thy dawning like the light of manifestation. But if it be a secret enwrapped—benefited only by secrecy, profited only by concealment, and whose countenance the subtleties of allusion cannot unveil—how then can I point unto it? For the first station of its disclosure is the denial of all allusion to it.

Today I possess no unveiling of that secret, no command, no means, save what was taught to Kumayl in secret in the prayer of Khidr:

> "Lord, forgive him who possesses naught save prayer, for Thou doest what Thou willest. O Thou Whose Name is healing, Whose remembrance is cure, and Whose obedience is wealth! Have mercy on him whose capital is hope and whose weapon is tears! O Bestower of blessings! O Repeller of adversities! O Light of those who are lonely in darkness! O Knower Who art not known! Bless Muhammad and the family of Muhammad, and do with us what is worthy of Thee! Thou art worthy to be feared and worthy to forgive!"

And since every letter of Thy Book hath, in the path of knowledge, infinite outer and inner meanings, I indicate with a drop that which overflows from the ocean of the elixir through what God hath graciously bestowed upon me. Though I know that these recorded principles and known allusions are unveiled before thee, yet perchance God may reveal in the inner meanings of the allusions that which floweth from the pen of ink in such wise as to draw thee to the holy precincts of the heart. I seek God's forgiveness for what the Book recordeth before the All-Merciful. Verily we are God's, and unto our Lord do we return.

O my God! How can I praise Thy praise or speak before the presence of Thy grandeur? Thou hast ever been, without the description of aught, and wilt ever exist, without the attribute of aught. None shall ever know Thee as Thou art, and naught shall ever describe Thee as Thou deservest, for Thy very Essence cutteth off all substances from expression, and Thy very Being preventeth all realities from knowing Thee. If I say "Thou art Thou," I have likened the similar to the similar, and Thou at once beliest me—nay, all

created things—for how can that which was brought into being through creation describe That which cannot be described by the attributes of invention? And if I say “He is He,” I have indicated the Oneness of Thy Will and the Reality of Thy Purpose, which are cut off from Thee by Thy creation of them from nothing, and are prevented from knowing Thee by their need, at every moment, of something. Thus whenever I ascend toward Thee, I see no means for myself save descent into despair and prevention; and whenever I fall silent and seek forgiveness, I find naught but a sin greater than the first.

By Thy might and Thy majesty! I perceive no path, nor do I find for proof any abiding place; and Thou art indeed a forgiving and august Lord. Forgive me, then, for Thou art the All-Forgiving, the All-Merciful. O God! I call Thee to witness by that wherewith Thou bearest witness unto Thine own Self, and by that whereunto Thy Book testifieth—according to that which Thy knowledge hath encompassed, and according to that which hath even now descended upon me in a Book inscribed and a parchment spread open, and from a Book endowed with manifest authority—seeking thereby to unveil the secret that is concealed, to tremble at that which was revealed upon Sinai, and to drink of the pure Water of Kawthar amid those deaf, dark, and impenetrable gloom-filled shadows, through the balance of exposition bestowed by a forgiving Lord, from the hands of a servant whom He appointed on that Day as the twofold witness within a hidden House.

O my Lord! Nothing escapeth Thy knowledge, nor is aught in the heavens or on the earth too great for Thee. Thou art, verily, the Knower of all things and the Almighty over all things. Confirm, then, O God, his heart upon Thy religion as Thou willest; and I am content with whatsoever Thou willest—verily Thou art the Mighty, the All-Powerful.

O man! I have borne witness unto that which flowed from thy pen, and have discerned that which thou didst intend in the allusions of thy words. No doubt God is thy true aim; yet in this Day one such as thou doth not cleave unto one such as I, save whomsoever God may choose to assist by His command and make a guardian of His ordinance. Nevertheless, when I behold the fluctuation of thy state and the disquiet of thy inmost being concerning the Cause of thy Lord, the sea of my stillness is stirred, by reason of my love for thee and the sincerity of thy service unto God, thy Creator—though I perceive the veil that lieth between thee and me. Yet I hope from God, exalted be He, that He will decree for me that which He willeth and will give me rest through His promise. Verily He is the Generous, the Merciful.

O thou who ascendest unto the ladder of inner realities, and who gazest upon those subtle splendors! That which thou dost seek at this moment is the majesty of glory in its beginning and its end. The truth can never be attained save by the negation of all else beside it; and the essential realities of the verses of knowledge profit not him whose desire is the station of his Lord, through the removal of veils and allusions, signs and indications. Thus hath it been plainly declared by Him Who dwelt in the deep of names and attributes: that truth is the unveiling of the veils without allusion. That station abideth within thy hidden being and within thy presence; nay, thou hast no manifestation save through it.

And since the minds of the followers of Mulla Sadra were confounded, and the feet of some divine philosophers faltered in explaining this station, I shall indicate through wisdom’s proof the reality of this supreme creation: God hath ever been, and there was naught else besides Him. And now God is even as He was; nothing existeth at His level. Whoso claimeth to know Him through the existence of aught else—

his knowledge is rendered void, for He hath never been associated with His creation nor can He be described through His servants.

Whoso desireth to proclaim His unity doth at that very moment associate partners with Him, for as He is, none but He can know Him, and none but He can proclaim His unity. All that His near servants have claimed regarding His knowledge is but knowledge of His creation through which He hath manifested Himself to it in the realm of His dominion. This is the utmost knowledge possible to contingent beings, for they can never ascend to the holy court of their Creator.

As ʾAli—peace be upon him—hath declared in the Orphan Sermon:

> "If thou sayest He is He, thou hast distinguished Him from all things, so He is He. And if thou sayest He is He, the letters 'He' are but attributes by which to prove Him, not attributes that reveal Him. If thou assigneth Him limits, such limits pertain to other than Him. If thou sayest the air is His relation, the air is of His creation."

Thus description returneth unto description. The heart is blinded from understanding, and understanding from comprehension, and comprehension from deduction. The dominion is established in the kingdom, creation returneth unto its like, and seeking findeth its form. Investigation leadeth unto impotence, exposition unto loss, striving unto despair, and attainment unto severance. The way is barred and seeking rejected. His proof is His signs and His existence His affirmation.

Verily God created the Will through itself, not from anything else. Then through it He created whatsoever beareth the name of a thing. The cause of its existence is itself and naught else. Whoso maintaineth that the Divine Essence was the cause of creation hath unknowingly associated partners with his Lord, for as He is, He cannot be associated with anything, nor doth anything exist with Him. It hath been established in wisdom that between cause and effect there must needs be similarity. Therefore did the Imam say that the cause of things is His handiwork, and He hath no cause. Some philosophers have stumbled in explaining this station according to their beliefs, which God hath not intended in His Book. May God forgive them through His grace, for He is the Forgiving, the Merciful.

Whoso maintaineth a connection between Truth and creation hath followed his idle fancy as did the first. This is error in the doctrine of the people of infallibility, for if the connection be the Essence itself, this hath no place in the doctrine of the family of God and is association according to what was recited unto thee before. And if it be creation, the people of the Bayan have no need to prove it. Therefore did the Imam, peace be upon him, say:

> "Truth and creation, with no third between them, nor any third besides them."

This is witnessed by whomsoever God hath caused to witness the creation of the heavens and earth. Then He created His own self, and God sufficeth Me as witness.

Whoso maintaineth the existence of fixed archetypes in the Divine Essence to prove His exalted knowledge, as most have done save whom God willeth, this is pure association in the doctrine of the family of God. For mention of their otherness in existence testifieth to separation and indicateth division.

God is the Eternal who hath ever been in one state. If the archetypes be the Essence itself, it changeth not eternally and unity would be impossible even for itself. All such essential abstractions have no existence with God, exalted be His mention. I seek refuge with God from what Muhyi'd-Din al-'Arabi maintained—may God hasten His vengeance.

Verily God is the Eternal who begetteth not nor is begotten. He hath no likeness in creation nor proof in contingent being, for proof is proof for that which indicateth not itself by itself. Description is for that which describeth not itself by itself. Glory be to God above what they who liken Him to creation have falsely claimed about the unity of existence! God witnesseth no word more remote than their saying, for mention of the non-existent is subsidiary to the existent. The Essence hath ever been free of His creation, and His creation when they came into being had no mention with Him.

That which compelled the philosophers to speak of fixed archetypes and the uncompounded reality is their station of affirmation in the knowledge of God, glorified be He. The uncompounded reality is their affirmation in the knowledge of God, glory be to Him, the Most High. Indeed, to affirm that God's knowledge comes from creation is falsehood and untruth, for God's knowledge has ever been for Himself alone, and there was no object of knowledge with Him, and none knoweth how He is save Him. Whoso desireth to comprehend His knowledge hath at that moment denied his Lord, for how can one who hath found his reality through His creation, which was created from nothing, hope to know the knowledge of his Lord? He hath ever been All-Knowing, and there was naught with Him, and now He is All-Knowing, and there is naught at His level.

Part 2: "The mention of power, knowledge, and all names…"

The mention of power, knowledge, and all names and attributes are but signs for His creation and a means of sweeping away the vain imaginings of His servants, lest they doubt aught about their Creator. His knowledge is His Essence, free from His creation, and none can encompass His knowledge. The knowledge He hath attributed to Himself, which those who reason have deduced in the station of His justice, is the reality of creation, and its relation to Him is but an honorific relation, like the relation of creation to Him.

Otherwise, O thou who gazest from the most exalted perspective and dwellest in the supreme horizon, when thou lookest with the eye of truth, God hath no attribute apart from His Essence and no description apart from His presence. He knoweth all things as they are, whether universals or particulars, substances or accidents, after their creation just as on the day He had not created them. He knoweth them because knowledge is life, and just as God, glory be to Him, is Ever-Living in the eternity of eternities, and needeth not the existence of any living thing to prove His life, He was All-Knowing of all things without there being any object of knowledge.

Glory be to Him and exalted is He! He was ever All-Knowing when there was no object of knowledge, and now God is as He was, All-Knowing of all things, though no object of knowledge existeth at His level. The reality of knowledge at the level of the contingent is the object of knowledge itself, as al-Sadiq (peace be upon him) clearly stated in his words, exalted be his remembrance:

> "Knowledge is the perfection of what is known, and power and might are the perfection of action."

Were the universals of wisdom not complete in their inward and outward aspects, wisdom would not be perfect from the All-Wise, even were He powerful.

When thou considerest this exposition and knowest the reality of what exists in creation through this explanation, thou wilt be convinced that the secret reality mentioned in the traditions, by which the learned excel one another in explaining mysteries, is but a created and contingent sign unto which God hath manifested Himself through it, making it a sign of Himself that one might thereby advance toward His knowledge and attain to the reality of what is possible in contingent existence through God's grace. It is a contingent sign like the letters of "There is no god but God," which, while being assembled letters, indicate God.

Likewise is the sign of thy reality when thou hast removed from it the veils and allusions, and entered the house of majesty through the effacement of vision and the sobriety of station, and the attraction of oneness and stillness in the ocean of eternality. Then hast thou attained to the ultimate bounty of God in contingent existence, and I find no suspension in God's bounty. Verily, the matter which thy presence hath been granted in the Book through mercy is the mystery of obligation and the ultimate station of recognition. Were I to interpret but one letter of thy allusions, all the seas of ink would be exhausted, for God hath created within everything the wisdom of all things. And he whom God, glorified be He, hath aided through His grace, is not veiled by anything in the heavens or on earth from the wisdom of any thing. The first letter of thy book is the letter "Ha" and I shall now indicate in its interpretation that which God hath written for me, and I beseech thy pardon for aught else.

Know that the letter "Ha" is the fifth rank of the manifestations of divine unity and the conditions of abstraction, and it is the letter of unity in the heart. And when it revolved in the four temples through the four witnessings, the letter "Kaf" appeared, which is the first word of the Command whereby all things were established. God, glorified be He, created the stations of unity in the letter "Ha." Among them is the station of the Point, which is the station of Muhammad, the Messenger of God, where he dwelt in the station of unity from the realm of creation, retaining no mention of self beside Him. In this station he is unique, without likeness, exalted above any similitude, and detached from all connection and separation.

This is the station which God specially reserved for His Beloved and chose for His Prophet, making him in this station the manifestation of His Self in expression, inasmuch as God was and is eternally unconnected with the creation of things. He standeth in the station of true divine unity wherein none in all contingent existence can possibly attain save him, nor hath any other any portion of that wherewith God hath honored him and guided him. In that station he is absolute poverty incarnate and pure manifestation in the station of dust. Therefore my spirit and all who dwell in the kingdoms of Command and Creation glory in his poverty before all who dwell in the kingdom of names and attributes. This is the station of the mention of that Reality which no veils can conceal, which no proofs can match, which no signs can depart from, and which nothing among the verses can approach.

Glorified be its Originator! The eye of creation hath never seen the like of Muhammad, the Messenger of God, in all existence. All that others have said in his description is falsehood in his holy court and calumny against his sanctified glory. He is as God said on the night of the Ascension: “Thou art the Beloved and the Loved One.” And he himself said concerning his station: “None knoweth me save God and thou, O Ali.” And Ali, peace be upon him, said concerning him in his sermon on the Day of Ghadir and Friday: “And I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant and His Messenger, whom He chose in pre-eternity above all nations, unique without similarity or likeness among the sons of his kind or peers.

He established him in His station throughout all His worlds in expression, since vision comprehendeth Him not, nor can thoughts of mind encompass Him, while He comprehendeth all vision, and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed.” This is the station of the Primal Will in contingent existence, where God manifested Himself to it through it for itself, and made it the sign of His kingdom that those who reflect might take lesson in the mention of the Most Beautiful Names and the Most Exalted Attributes—though all these are detached from His presence and withheld from His station. For He is as He is, none knowing how He is save God Who created him. So glorified be God above what they describe!

And among them is the station of the gentle Alif, and the mystery of eternity, and the divine reed, and the heavenly leaf. The Celestial Leaf and the Heavenly Tree and the Universal Guardianship through which God is known in the second station, and after the station of Muhammad, the Apostle of God, peace be upon Him, there is no true unity save through ’Ali, peace be upon him. All others know God as would an ant—nay, I seek God’s forgiveness for even this limitation. There exists no unity save his unity, as he himself, exalted be his remembrance, hath said in his last sermon:

> “I am the meaning upon which no name nor likeness can be placed, and I am the Gate of Remission, and there is no power nor strength save in God, the Most High, the Most Great.”

And verily he, may my spirit be a sacrifice unto him, as the Most Great Lord hath testified, is known only to God and to himself. Sufficient proof of his excellence is that were it not for him, none like him would exist. And glorified be God, his Creator, above all description.

And among them is the station of Divine Unity, of the extended Alif; this is the station of the letters of “There is none other God but He”—eleven souls, the Imams of justice, the honored servants, who act not save by the command of God and who, in their fear of Him, are filled with awe. Verily, they do magnify the unity of God through stations pertaining unto ’Ali, peace be upon him, and none save themselves can attain unto them. All who are beside them are, in their sight, mentioned only through that unity whereby they themselves bear witness unto God.

Sufficient testimony to the excellence of their remembrance is that which shone forth from the holy precinct unto ’Uthman ibn Muhammad al-’Amri, in the visitation of the Family of God, where He Himself hath said concerning the irrevocable decree and the effacement:

> “The fixed decree is that which your will hath reserved unto itself, and the effacement is that which your practice hath reserved unto itself.”

And every mention joined with the mention of others is, before their presence, but calumny against their holiness and falsehood in the face of their power.

Yet, since it hath ever been God's wont to show forth beneficence, while the condition of contingent being is helplessness and want, God hath, through the bounty of His grace, accepted in behalf of the friends of those hallowed names. Otherwise, no one would have any portion in the knowledge of them, nor would any created thing possess any share in making mention of them. Glorified be God, their Creator, above all that they describe.

Among these is the station of the combined letters, which is the station of unity of Fatimih, the blessings of God be upon her. She speaks of God and indicates God through what God hath revealed to her through numbered mirrors. Through her light were created the realities of the Prophets, and through her were brought into being the essential gems of the successors from among God's chosen ones and His Messengers. None among the Prophets and successors below her station have any share in her unity. The deeds of her physical form are purer and more elevated than the hearts of the Prophets and the essence of the successors. None knoweth her as she truly is save God and the Letters of Unity. Glorified be God above all description.

Among these is the station of the Words, which is the station of unity of the Prophets and the believers among humanity, who indicate God through the shadow of the light of Fatimih's physical form, the blessings of God be upon her. They enter the sea of Oneness and the depths of Eternity and the Throne of Glory and Grandeur through the excellence of Fatimih's remembrance, the blessings of God be upon her. None save them has any share in their unity and their knowledge of God, glorified be He. These are the cherubim of whom al-Sadiq spoke, saying:

> "They are a people from among our followers from the first creation whom God hath placed behind the Throne. Were the light of but one of them to be divided among the people of the earth, it would suffice them."

When Moses asked of his Lord what he asked, He commanded one among them, and He revealed Himself to him in the measure of a needle's eye, whereupon the mountain crumbled and Moses fell down in a swoon. These five degrees all return to the negation of unity from unity, and though each of these degrees hath four stations which return to a single point. Among these is the unity of the Essence, in that as He is what He is, none knoweth Him save Him, and none can prove Him save Him, and none can say He is He save Him, for whatsoever is besides Him, should it speak or describe, pointeth to the station of its own self and telleth of the limits of its own geometry. And He, as He is in Himself, hath no name nor attribute, nor can anything prove Him, for proof is contingent upon conjunction, and all describe their own selves and adduce evidence of their own reality through their own signs. Glorified be God above what they describe!

And among these is the unity of attributes, in that God hath no attribute apart from His Essence, and no name apart from His presence, by the testimony of His Essence unto His Essence that He cannot be described by the attributes of His creation, and by the testimony of His creation unto His creation that the attribute, by its own testimony unto itself, returneth to the station of limitation. The existence of

description itself is the greatest proof that God hath no attribute nor description. All names are signs of His Will, all similitudes are likenesses of His Purpose, all attributes are tokens of His Dominion, and all proofs are stations of His Grandeur. Thus glorified and exalted is God Who hath described Himself as having no description, and Who hath described Himself to His creation through what He hath revealed in His Book that they might know Him thereby and worship Him, not associating anyone with His worship.

And among these is the unity of deeds, wherein all feet have stumbled in understanding the matter between the two matters, which is the mystery of destiny, and whereby the servants recognize their Creator in the station of deeds. All who have addressed the question of destiny, whether through compulsion or delegation, including all the philosophers who have confessed their powerlessness to explain the reality of this matter—this indeed is the true state of affairs. For the philosophers desired to explain God's command regarding the matter between the two matters through rational proof, which is impossible, since reason, even at the utmost degree of its abstraction, comprehendeth naught but that which is limited. And until the servant reacheth the summit of the heart's portion, whoever sitteth upon the throne of reason's sovereignty must needs confess either to delegation or compulsion, for that which lieth between them—the matter between the two matters, the station more expansive than what lieth between the heaven of receptivities and the earth of acceptances—can only be comprehended by the heart which God hath created for the knowledge of His unity and the sanctification of his Lord.

The servant recognizeth God's unity in the station of deeds and becometh certain of the truth of that verse from the Most Exalted: "Is there any Creator other than God who provideth for you from heaven and earth? There is no God but He!" "This is God's creation; now show Me what those beside Him have created." Nay, the wrongdoers are in manifest error.

Without this awareness, the servant comprehendeth not what is incumbent upon him in wisdom. Therefore did the Imam say:

> "Destiny is a secret among God's secrets, a protection among God's protections, raised up in God's veil, concealed from God's creation, sealed with God's seal, foreknown in God's knowledge. God hath relieved His servants of its knowledge."

God has lifted His knowledge above His servants and raised it above their testimonies and the extent of their minds, for they cannot attain it through divine reality, nor through eternal power, nor through luminous grandeur, nor through the might of oneness. It is a surging, overflowing sea, purely for God, the Mighty and Glorious. Its depth extends between heaven and earth, its width between east and west, black as the darkest night, full of serpents and whales, rising at times and sinking at others. In its depths shines a sun which none should seek to discover except the One, the Single. Whoever attempts to discover it has opposed God, the Mighty and Glorious, in His wisdom, contested His sovereignty, unveiled His secret and His covering, and has incurred God's wrath—his abode is hell, an evil destination.

Part 3: "The secret of the matter is that none…"

The secret of the matter is that none should see the manifestation of things' actions as they truly are except the soul that manifests the choices of things as they are and as they continue infinitely in what has

no end. None should see any light except His light, nor any decree except His decree, for nothing exists in the heavens or earth except through seven stages which are the stations of the Family of God, peace be upon them. The servant, at the time of action, acts through the action of destiny from One All-Knowing and All-Wise, for God, glorified be He, has always known the choices of all and how they proceed therein, recompensing them according to their qualities and giving them their due.

This choice accompanies the existence of things, and nothing exists except through its choice, for at the time of the choice's existence when God the Exalted said "Am I not your Lord?", had there not been choice, the response "Yea" would not have been given. Similarly is the decree in every aspect and every matter. If the observer truly looks, he sees the manifestation of "Am I not your Lord?" only in himself through the mention of "Yea" or in manifestation through the mention of "Nay"—and it is a mystery. They see no influencer except God, witness no command except God's command, worship nothing alongside Him, and believe regarding the right of the Family of God neither in delegation nor in suspension. Rather, God has never ceased to create what He wills, how He wills, through what He wills. He has no partner in His action, no protecting friend in His command, and He is as He is in His action—none knows how He is except Him.

God has taught in the Qur'an through His exalted word: "Whatever good befalls thee is from God, and whatever evil befalls thee is from thyself. We have sent thee as a Messenger to mankind and God suffices as a witness." Then His exalted word: "Say: All is from God." This indeed is the secret of the unity of actions. God has not revealed any verse mentioning this truth more perfectly and completely than the words "There is no power nor strength except through God." Glory be to God above what they describe. And from this comes the unity of worship, where God, exalted be His mention, said: "Say: I am but a mortal like you. It is revealed to me that your God is one God. So whoever hopes to meet his Lord, let him do righteous work and not associate anyone in the worship of his Lord." And this unity is identical to the unity of the Essence.

That Unity is itself the unity of Essence, Attributes and Deeds. Whosoever uniteth God through unity of Essence hath indeed unified Him according to how He hath described Himself in the station of Attributes, Deeds and Worship. And whosoever worshippeth God through attribute or name hath not worshipped Him and is indeed a polytheist. And whosoever worshippeth Him through mention of His Self is like unto the first, a polytheist. And whosoever worshippeth God according to how He hath described Himself through His names and attributes which God hath revealed in His Book, hath worshipped Him in the manner possible within the bounds of contingent existence. Otherwise, as He is in Himself and as beseemeth Him, none besides Him hath known Him so as to worship Him. He hath ever been beyond description through signs, beyond characterization through tokens, and none but He can indicate His own Self.

Verily the servant cannot worship God in any way save as He willeth. In God's Cause there is the decree of Bada, and in God's Book it hath two stations: the Bada of justice, which departeth not from the essence of anything, and from which nothing is secure—it is God's Cause which all things fear, and if God desired to destroy all creation, by this Bada would He destroy it instantly, and none can resist His Will, none can question His deed, none can thwart His decree, and none can comprehend His purpose. He doeth what

He willeth through what He willeth, and nothing in the heavens or earth is too great for Him, and He is the Mighty, the Wise. And the Bada of grace is in the rank of destiny, and it is grace and favor for the believers whereby God changeth their evil deeds to good deeds and eraseth from the pages of their works the bounds of transgression, bestowing upon whomsoever He willeth whatsoever He willeth, and He is the Self-Sufficient, the All-Praised.

Verily these four ranks are in truth a single manifestation in five stations, and in the fifth rank wherein the Prophets, people, believers and angels affirm His unity, it is as al-Sadiq, peace be upon him, indicated in his words, exalted be his remembrance: "We are the root of all good, and our branches are all righteousness, and of righteousness is the unity whereby God is unified." The Imams, peace be upon them, have derived from the manifestation of Fatimih's form, God's blessings be upon her, and thus the Imam was attributed to His Cause for it is the first station of deed. And this station was revealed through the four stations of unity in His words, exalted be His remembrance: "Our Cause is the mystery, and mystery enshrouded in mystery, and mystery veiled by mystery, and mystery that only mystery can reveal." Then His words, exalted be His remembrance: "Our Cause is the truth, and truth of truth, and it is the manifest, and manifest of the manifest, and hidden of the hidden, and it is the mystery, and mystery of mystery, and mystery enshrouded in mystery, and mystery veiled by mystery."

And all this pertaineth to the stations of limitation and the path of the limited. But for those detached unto God in the depths of oneness, and those dwelling upon the throne of might and eternality, verily the inscribed enshrouded mystery is the manifest witnessed sign, and the unseen with them is the very essence of witnessing, and none knoweth them in this station save God. They are a people who look not upon anything except through the gaze of the Lord, judge not anything except through His judgment, and alter no decree save by His leave. These are the ambassadors of the Faith.

That which they ordained was not changed except by His leave, and these are the ambassadors of the Faith and pillars of certitude. Were it not for them, no rain would descend from heaven nor would vegetation spring forth from the earth. May God grant me their companionship in the gardens of Eden, and those who are righteous among their fathers and their offspring, through His grace—verily He is the Mighty, the Forgiving.

We have indeed alluded in the depths of these allusions that the matter which thou didst desire cannot be realized except through the negation of allusions. Nay, the veil is more subtle than that, and the mirrors of reality more delicate than that glass. The negation of allusion is itself a form of allusion. Today, if thou dost not cast away what is in thy right hand and thy left of the veils of subtleties and signs of delicacies, thou canst not journey unto God in the land of the crimson sand.

For one such as thee, this matter is indeed difficult and arduous, for the darkness of the words of the people of veils hath encompassed thy inner being. Though such deeds may be counted as good deeds for the believers and blessings for the distressed, yet since thou hast desired this greatest path and mightiest station, I have ventured to mention these words unto thee, that the holy fragrances might draw thee to the summit of attributes and these allusions might free thee from what thou hast perceived from the allusions of the people of veils.

When thou turnest unto God, the Lord of lords, the allusions, veils, signs and stations are unveiled, and in the moment of heedlessness therefrom, thou enterest the Throne of Glory. This station, despite its grandeur and majesty, is nearer than the twinkling of an eye and more subtle than the closest glance. This indeed is the honor for one who was at the Greatest Scene when the Hour drew nigh and the moon was cleft asunder.

Verily God hath placed honor in the knowledge of this station and in deeds performed in its vicinity, as al-Sadiq indicated in his words—exalted be his remembrance—when asked about the vision of God in the hereafter. He said: "Nay, the believers shall see Him before the Day of Resurrection." It was asked: "How is this so?" He replied: "When He said 'Am I not your Lord?' Then the veil was lifted." He said: "Dost thou not see Him at this very moment?"

And Ali's indication in his Tutunjiyyih sermon where he said—and his word is the truth: "I saw God and Paradise with the eye of certainty." By his vision—may my spirit be a sacrifice for him—he meant the vision of His manifestation unto him through Him at every moment, as al-Sadiq explained in his renowned tradition: "Servitude is a substance whose essence is Lordship," until he said "Present in thy absence and thy presence." And his martyred father indicated in his prayer on the Day of Arafah: "Other than Thee has an appearance that Thou hast not," until he said: "Blind is the eye that seeth Thee not, while Thou art ever watchful over it, and at loss is the servant whom Thou hast not granted a share of Thy love."

This station is indeed the ultimate portion of contingent being at the point of conjunction, where God manifests Himself to the servant through Him in every moment with what pertains to might and glory. O thou who gazest upon the countenance of glory, magnify the Cause of God within thyself and observe thy Lord's mercy toward thee, for thy need in every condition is like unto thy need at the beginning of thy existence, when thou wert not even mentioned. Verily God manifesteth Himself unto thee through thee at every moment, just as He manifested Himself on the first day, for the servant's need for sustenance hath never ceased nor shall it ever be lifted.

Verily, God revealeth Himself unto thee, through thine own self, in every instant, with a revelation like unto His revelation on the First Day; for the servant's need of sustaining grace hath ever been, and shall never be, removed. And God, in every state, revealeth Himself unto every state, through every state, with a revelation like unto His revelation unto them, through themselves, on the First Day. Nay rather, were man to behold the mystery of Reality, he would behold his own self—and indeed all his states—as a creation of the First Day. He would perceive in no state any light save His Light, nor any decree save through His Justice, nor any affliction save by His Ordainment, nor any Origination (bada') save by His Sanction.

Indeed, were the servant to remain steadfast in this condition, the attributes of divine lordship would flow through him, even as revealed in the sacred tradition: "My servant draweth nigh unto Me through supererogatory acts until I love him; and when I love him, I become the ear wherewith he heareth, and the eye wherewith he seeth, and the hand wherewith he graspeth. When he calleth upon Me, I answer him; when he asketh of Me, I grant his request; and when he is silent before Me, I initiate discourse with him." Thus are all his conditions, both hidden and manifest. His self becometh His Self, his deed His Deed, his command His Command, his prohibition His Prohibition, his obedience His Obedience, his

disobedience His Disobedience, his love His Love—and likewise all that is attributed to him, even as the Sacred House is attributed to God, without similitude, for that which is being compared becometh identical with that to which it is compared, as indicated in the mystery of the tradition: “He revealed Himself to her through her, casting His image upon her essence, thus manifesting His acts through her.”

Blessed, then, is he whom God hath raised unto Himself, freed from the conditions of his self and the transgressions of his days, and preserved upon the throne of His oneness, seeing none besides Him, asking naught save through His remembrance, finding solace in none save His nearness, seeing no glory save in His good-pleasure, no wrath save in His punishment, no spirit save in His splendor, no tranquility save in His praise. And thou, O noble one, knowest well the paths of remembrance and guidance, and I fear not for thee when thou findest intimacy in the sacred precincts with thy glorious Lord.

Verily this matter possesseth such subtlety that none can reckon it save God. If thou art veiled from it by the slightest hint, thou shalt be removed from it to a degree none knoweth save God. Even as when Kumayl questioned Ali (upon him be peace), he, may my spirit be his sacrifice, turned him away for that which he asked, since He about Whom he inquired was nearer to him than himself. How can one who perceiveth not the Light that encompasseth his inner and outer being—such that no other light existeth—possibly behold Reality through Reality and witness the mystery of Divine Unity through the Eternal Light? Verily this is as manifest to one such as thyself as the sun at its zenith.

And since God knew that some people, through their love for that station wherein whoso standeth hath stood by God’s command, created for those who gaze upon His countenance in the eternity of eternities and who abide with Him at every instant, signs and tokens whereby may be distinguished him in whom that station is confounded from him who standeth in certitude in the Sacred Mosque, lest people be removed from the effulgences of the glory of His sovereignty and all might know the revelations of His mighty power, and none might say “Had God acquainted me with His signs, I would surely have been among the thankful.”

When thou art certain of this matter, look to the proof and be patient concerning the signs of the All-Glorious, for the mystery of this ocean is profound, most profound, and the wisdom of that mystery is exquisite, most exquisite, and the veil of that Cause is subtle, most subtle, and the attributes of that servant are delicate, most delicate. And when thou didst desire in that station the mention of the Balance and the measure of utterance and the proof of man in utterance, I loved that thou shouldst be endeared with the knowledge thereof. Wherefore look unto what We have sent down in explanation of the Kawthar to him who hath turned and given thanks, and warn every one who hath waxed proud and disbelieved.

But I adjure thee by God to look upon Our signs with the eye of love and insight, for the proof of that Cause is naught but the truth and none can uphold it save whom God willeth. Forget not what God hath ordained for thee, for today thou knowest My weakness and art able to remove My distress. I do not complain to thee, but since I know what lieth beyond that Cause, I desire that thou shouldst be as God created thee, and be unto God’s creation as God hath been unto thee.

Part 4: “I know that these forms of knowledge…”

I know that these forms of knowledge and contrary conditions grieve thee and keep thee from attaining unto divine decrees and the mystery of eternity and the sign of oneness in the word of the All-Merciful. But read some of Our pages, for through thy communion with God thou shalt find what hath never occurred to the heart of any mortal, and thou shalt know divine knowledge that no pen hath ever recorded in the chain of creation. And whatsoever doubts and accidents occur to thy heart, dispel them through the Balance of the measure, for God hath created utterance for man, and had God known anything more noble than speech He would have made it the means between Him and His Messengers.

Glorified be God! How perfect is His favor, how great His proof, how mighty His Call! He accepteth from His servants what none else would accept. Verily, I was aforetime in such condition that I knew not a letter of what I know this day. God hath made the proof such that none can turn away from it save by submission, and should they desire to turn away, it would be as though they turned away from that which they believed before, for the handiwork of the Lord cannot be confused with the work of creation, and the proof of the Book cannot be nullified by the lies of men.

For in God Who created all things is the sign of His unity in the reality of all things. The Christians say “the third of three,” and some people today are like unto them in the station of worship, for they see a deity, then themselves, then an attribute, and verily this deed is the saying of the Christians where divinity entered into humanity. Exalted is God above what the wrongdoers say! And for every light there must needs be darkness, but God promised aforetime in the Qur’an that He would vindicate the truth through His signs and bring to naught the deeds of the idolaters though they be averse.

Verily, I have spoken to men only of the favor of my Lord, of what God hath honored me with of verses, prayers, sermons and realities of knowledge through what God hath ordained behind the veils. Verily, I have not denied a single letter of the Faith, nor added thereto a letter, nor have I said aught save what God said aforetime in the Qur’an: “Fear God and He will give you knowledge of distinction,” and His mighty Word: “Fear God and God will teach you.” People have indeed fabricated falsehoods, following their idle fancies, and they speak naught but lies.

Verily that which God hath bestowed upon him who contendeth for the Faith against those who deny the Leaders of Justice from the Mother City and its environs consisteth of four signs in the realm of outward manifestation.

The first is the station of verses which I recite without reflection and write without pause of the pen according to the will of God, my Lord. This is a proof which none can withstand, nor can any bring forth the like thereof. Were God to know that I abide not in His love and good-pleasure, He would create another being who would recite as I recite from the Book of God—and God sufficeth as a witness.

The second is the station of prayers and supplications unto God, the All-Glorious, whereby, should He will it, there would flow from My pen in six hours less than a thousand, without thought or pause of the pen.

The third is the station of sermons, the like of which none but I have ever uttered.

The fourth is the station of knowledge, whereby there hath flowed from My pen in times past numerous pages, recorded epistles, and preserved books. The glory in these words lieth not in the words themselves, nor in their allusions and correlations, but rather in the divine mystery and the manifestation of the eternal which is the source of all good within My soul and upon which every matter turneth. This matter sufficeth for this Faith, and God sufficeth as a guardian. And should […?] command Me to unveil a mystery from this Cause, were I not to desire to interpret but a single letter "ha" at the beginning of the Book, what I would mention in that word would be such that all the seas of the heavens and earth would not suffice to contain it, should God choose to reveal its interpretation through one of His servants. Yet I shall mention concerning the mystery of the letter "ha" some interpretation of what I intended.

Know thou that a mystery remaineth ever concealed, and if revealed, it ceaseth to be a mystery. Knowledge in the station of mysteries is, as commanded by 'Ali ibn al-Husayn, peace be upon them both, unto Jabir, in seven degrees, as he said, exalted be his mention: "O Jabir, knowest thou what knowledge is? Knowledge is first the affirmation of Divine Unity, second the knowledge of meanings, third the knowledge of the Gates, fourth the knowledge of the Imam, fifth the knowledge of the Pillars, sixth the knowledge of the Chiefs, and seventh the knowledge of the Nobles." This is in accordance with His words, exalted be He: "Say: If the ocean were ink for the words of my Lord, the ocean would be exhausted before the words of my Lord would be exhausted, even if We brought another ocean like it as support."

He also recited: "And if all the trees on earth were pens, and the ocean, with seven more oceans to aid it, were ink, yet would not the words of God be exhausted. Verily God is Mighty, Wise." O Jabir! The affirmation of Divine Unity and the knowledge of meanings—as for the affirmation of Divine Unity, it is the knowledge of God, the Ancient, the Ultimate, Whom vision comprehendeth not while He comprehendeth all vision, and He is the Subtle, the All-Informed. He is the Hidden, the Concealed; thou shalt know Him as He hath described Himself. As for the meanings, We are His meanings and His manifestation among you, created from the light of His Essence.

We created from the light of His Essence that which is manifest among you, and He delegated unto Us the affairs of His servants. We act by His leave as We please, and when We will, God willeth, and when We desire, God desireth. God the Almighty hath established Us in this station and chosen Us from among His servants, making Us a proof in His lands. Whoso denieth aught thereof hath denied God, glorified be His name, and disbelieved in God and His Prophets and His Messengers…

These seven are themselves the stages of action and the manifestations of creation, as He, exalted be His mention, hath said: Nothing existeth in earth or heaven save through seven: through Will, Purpose, Destiny, Decree, Permission, Term, and Book. Whoso claimeth that God can dispense with even one of these hath indeed disbelieved. Most people have perished through their failure to comprehend what God hath ordained for them. He hath judged through the tradition of His chosen ones, in the station of the inner meaning, that whoso diminisheth one of these hath disbelieved. I seek refuge with God from the misleading trials and beseech God through His grace for the inner meanings of the traditions.

The mystery in the Bayan pointeth to the knowledge of God, glorified be He, and He is His own mystery, His very Self and none other, for God's mystery is identical with His outward manifestation, and His outward manifestation identical with His being, His beginning identical with His end, and His eternity

identical with His perpetuity. None knoweth His mystery save Him, and He hath no mystery apart from His Essence, no attribute apart from His presence. Glorified be God, Lord of the Throne, above what they describe.

As to the mystery of the meanings, it is to know what was previously detailed concerning the decree of the Point in the station of unity, and what floweth by God's leave from the water of that spring—the water of life—and it is the Unknown whereof God, exalted be His mention, hath said: "None knoweth the Unknown save He." Glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

As for the mystery in the station of the Gates, it is the mystery in the universal Guardianship whereof God, glorified be He, hath said:

> "Here guardianship belongeth unto God, the Truth. He is best in reward, and best in consequence."

It is the mystery of manifestation, the camphor tree, the purifying water, the frequented House, the garments of light, the pure zealous Essence, the lofty witnessed Glory, the hidden concealed Symbol, and the Fire borrowed from the Mount, which is the mystery of the First and the First is none other than He, and God maketh no distinction between them save the distinction of attribute not separation, even as God hath placed between motion and rest, or between the Kaf and the Nun, and between separation and union. None knoweth His mystery save He, and glorified be God above what they describe.

As for the mystery of the Imamate, it is the mystery of the letters of "There is no God but God" in the inscribed lines, then in the Scriptures and Verses, then in the reeds of the Divine Realm and the Throne of Names and Attributes, then in the thicket of the Realm of Power and the Seat of Glory and Kingdom, then in the mention of essential realities, material things, the separate, the connected, the united, the severed, the manifest, the concealed, the radiant, and the darkened, where none comprehendeth their knowledge save the pure Family of God, the signs of abstraction, the pillars of unity, the tokens of glorification, and the proofs of praise. Glorified be God, their Creator, above what they describe.

As for the mystery in the station of the Pillars, it is the light manifested from the sun of Fatimih's form, the blessings of God be upon her, in the realities of the Prophets; it is from the mystery of the manifestation of the Prophets.

And as for the mystery in the station of the Chiefs, it is from the mystery of the manifestation of the Prophets, and they are thirty souls who were in the presence of the Imam, as that tradition explicitly states, saying:

> "How excellent is this goodly station, and there is no loneliness with thirty."

Verily, recognition of them and acknowledgment of them is obligatory, for they are the bearers of grace in creation and legislation. Their mystery is the mystery of the Imam, and whosoever today turns to anyone besides them is truly among the ignorant ones.

As for the mystery in the station of the Nobles, it is from the manifestation of the light of the hearts of the Chiefs. Were they to discover the mystery of the Chiefs, they would surely slay them, as is explicitly stated in the tradition wherein He, exalted be His mention, said:

> "If Abu Dharr knew what was in Salman's heart, he would surely have slain him."

Verily that mystery exists, is witnessed, and is hidden in all seven ranks, and God does not judge concerning these mysteries in those verses except according to what their souls have accepted. God will surely reward all through His grace, and there is no God but Him, the Possessor of great bounty.

The mystery in these seven ranks is the reality within them whereby they know the unity of God their Creator. The proportion of God's manifestation through all of them is equal. The dwellers in the depths of the Bayan know God's unity, and He unifies them through the unity of His own Self. None of creation precedes them, nor have they any veil save their own existence, nor any book save their own souls. He who knows God's unity in the station of meanings knows the seven mirrors of the Bayan, even if he perceives not those mirrors, yet knows his station as one who beholds God in the second mirrors. Likewise are the servants who know God's unity in the five mirrors—each knows God's unity according to what pertains to unity, might, glory, divinity, power and dominion.

They behold no mirrors between them in the state of unity, but God, from behind them, knows their stations and bears witness to what their hands have earned. Though this station has no likeness, I allude to what is most subtle in the realm of physicality: Consider the manifested form of a standing Alif, and before it mirrors, then before those mirrors more mirrors until reaching seven. Do the seventh mirrors reflect aught but the form of the Alif? Nay, by thy Lord! All call upon God, indicate Him, judge by His greatness, fear His dominion, rule by His leave, act by His command, and intercede by His permission.

The difference is that what is reflected in the seventh mirrors resembles proportionally what is reflected in the sixth mirrors, and thus some excel others. There is no greater nobility in the perfection of good qualities and virtuous attributes, for that is the station of the effect of the deed. The station of the essence of the servant is what I have indicated to thee in the series of seven, which flows in a series of eight from the world of Command to the world of Creation. All the worlds are confined to these eight, for the first determination of the first Kaf is the station of Muhammadhood, which is the Garden of Eternity wherein through manifestation it entered and has not emerged, and whereunto He hath never entered from without. Then verily that Paradise is the portion of the Family of God, who are the Imams of Justice, and no one among creation hath any share therein.

And the second is the station of the unity of the Prophets, and the third is the station of the unity of humanity, and the fourth is the station of the unity of the jinn, and the fifth is the station of the unity of the angels, and the sixth is the station of the unity of animals, wherein the ant supposeth that God hath two antennae, just as man supposeth that He hath knowledge and power and likewise all attributes and names. And just as people invalidate the unity of the ant, so too doth he who standeth in a rank above invalidate their unity. And the seventh is the station of the unity of plants, and the eighth is the station of the unity of minerals. And verily that rank revealeth what is above it save what is in its outward manifestation.

And verily the eight paradises which God hath created for those who love Him are these stations indicated. The wayfarer beholdeth in the land of the highest heaven all his stations and witnesseth the bliss of the hereafter which hath been tasted from the fruit of the mystery of Reality in this world, in a station as though he were in the land of the Paradise of Glory and under the shade of the darkened Paradise of Beauty. And verily one such as thee understandeth these allusions, and there is no need in exposition to mention the evidences, the verses, the signs, and the stations, for the Command of God in all things is nearer than the twinkling of an eye, and the Beginning of God upon all things is through the Greatest Vision.

Part 5: "And verily I intended not in mentioning these…"

And verily I intended not in mentioning these words save to manifest the divine attributes to the people of glory. And verily one such as thee is more exalted in station than to look upon them and mention therein the decree of differences. And when thou art apprised of that which was not with thee from the decisive verses, then pardon thyself, for verily that water floweth by the leave of God, the Lord of Names and Attributes. I seek forgiveness of God, my Lord, then I ask pardon of thee for what the Pen hath set down in mentioning the allusions in the depths of these words, for the station of the servant is that of the element of dust, and these allusions befit not the presence of Him Who possesseth the Names and Attributes. Glory be to God, thy Lord, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe.

And since the matter was concealed in words, and the glories in the world of indications are not unveiled save through the mention of stations, I make mention in that station that shouldst thou arrive, thou wouldst witness the lights in the reality of mysteries. And it is that when the servant arriveth at the station of Reality, which is the station of the manifestation of the knowledge of God to him through Him, he witnesseth all things as they are and seeth naught in the countenance of multiplicities save the manifestation of the unity of the Essence.

And verily that station is thy Most Holy Sanctuary, and thy Most Exalted Paradise, and the station of thy love and thy beloved and thy Best-Beloved, and the station of the unity of thy word and the word of the Act of God in thy mystery, and the station of thy subsistence in God, and the station wherein all thy attributes and thy names and thy manifestations appear from what was beneath the rank of thine essence, and the station of thy existence through God and thy effacement in God, and the station of thy circumambulation around thine essence through the seven ranks of thine act, and the station of thy putting on the garment, and in the station of casting off the pebbles of thine intimations, stations, indications, signs and verses, and in the station through which was manifested what was manifest in thy rank, and was concealed what was hidden in thy mystery, and rose what rose in thy reality, and gleamed what gleamed in thine essence, and shone what shone in thy spirit, and was magnified what was exalted in thine identity, and dawned what dawned in the station of thy physical being—where no veils can conceal it and no verses of scripture can equal it—it is the first light wherewith God revealed Himself to thee through thee, and at every moment He revealeth Himself to thee through thee by that light when thou didst behold the Tree of Sinai in the presence of the Frequented Fane.

And these intimations are the portion of the heedless who see not the Truth in the darkness of night. Otherwise, one like thyself seeth all words as one Word, and all differences as a specific geometry, and all intimations as a single indication, and all verses as a clear mirror that telleth of the oneness of the Essence and proclaimeth divinity upon the throne of names and attributes.

And for one like thyself the indications cause no confusion, for the Command of God in all things is one, and the decree of God reacheth all things. Verily those who veil themselves from recognition of the Glory in the mystery of wealth are certain of God's Cause yet deny it unjustly through what their hands have earned aforetime.

And from one like thyself is not concealed what hath occurred before. Unto God do we complain, then unto Muhammad, the Chosen One, and unto Him returneth the judgment of the Hereafter and of former times. And verily He is in the Most Exalted Horizon, speaking on behalf of the Lord Most High. The heart lied not in what it saw. Will ye then dispute with Him concerning what He saw? He speaketh not from mere impulse. It is naught but a revelation revealed.

And verily I have unveiled from the face of mystery the decree of mystery and the intimations of the Command, and this is truly mystery upon mystery, where today none can raise it save the mystery, and naught can benefit it save the unveiling. In God do I trust, and I say:

> "Naught shall befall us save what God hath decreed. He is our Master; in Him do we trust, and in Him let the believers place their trust."

And what I have interpreted of the interpretation of the letter Ha is a mention from the praise of the Tree of Glory, whereby the people of divine decree know through the principle of origination in the crimson pillar. And verily it is the mystery of creation, for the element of fire in the world of origination cannot exist save through the element of earth, for naught besides God exists independently in its essence except that it is compound.

When the decree of duality is established, the decree of connection is established, for a thing is not a thing except through its existence, which is the aspect of revelation therein, and through its identity, which is the aspect of receptivity, and through the connection that occurs between the conjunction. These three ranks are the rank of trinity in the first name God chose for Himself.

From this the Christians took the form of the cross and the indwelling of divinity in humanity. Exalted is God above what the people of the human realm know of the warbling of the birds of the divine cloud upon the branches of the Tree of Divinity. And that is the decree of the triangle of modality in the Name of the Eternal, Radiant, Holy Providence which points at every moment to His breast and says by God's leave:

> "There the sovereignty belongeth unto God, the Truth. He is best for reward."

By God's leave He says: There is the divine authority which belongs to God, the Truth—He is the best in reward and the best in punishment. Indeed, the three primary names in the beginning of action are Will, Purpose and Determination, which the people of the Bayan interpret in their exposition as Creation,

Origination, Invention, Bringing into Being, and Generation. Nothing can exist except through the indicative elements, even if the Command itself were within the Will, for contingent existence is impossible except through two pairs. Once duality is established, the mention of attributes extends infinitely with what has no end.

The element of earth which is interpreted at the level of Will is of the nature of its realm, which is the pillar of the acceptance of the fire of existence after these: the fire of non-existence and the water of ink. In this pattern has God created all things and decreed in every world according to that pattern.

Look at Purpose, which is the primal Eve of Adam and the Throne upon which Will was established through the All-Merciful, how God created it with four pillars—among them the pillar of Destiny which is the element of fire and the manifestation of the First Cause. Its color is white due to pure simplicity from the attributes of multiplicities, indications and signs. From it was whitened what was in the thicket of the Divine Realm from unpolluted water from the rivers of Paradise. The word of glorification was found in the realm of Might, and through it all whiteness in the thicket of Dominion, then Kingdom, then the mortal world is raised and lowered. The attributes of that pillar are not encompassed by the knowledge of any created being—among them the Sacred House of God, the Sacred Month, the mention of glorification at the ground of the Sacred Monument and Station, and the obligation of the pillar of Unity in the words "There is no God but God" where whoever did not say "yea" in the Primal Scene was not brought into being. Through one such as yourself endowed with insight are known the attributes of that pillar which none can encompass save whom God wills—verily there is no God but Him, the Possessor of tremendous grace.

And among them is the pillar of Permission which is the element of air and manifestation of the Material Cause. Its color is yellow from what is appointed, and from it yellowness became yellow in all things, and by its light does God provide sustenance to all things, for the First Pillar which is the Efficient Cause is the cause of life, as God, exalted be His mention, has said:

> "He it is Who created you, then provided sustenance for you, then causes you to die, then brings you to life."

The bearer of that pillar is the Exalted One, and thus appeared the yellow color in his countenance at the time of his passing, and that is evidence for the day of his beginning, for the Seal is precisely the Beginning according to the people of the Bayan. And whoever curses the sun and moon in their calculated courses—that is the station of praise and the pillar opposite the Yemeni pillar. It has attributes in limited examples, existing geometry, numbered signs and lost knowledge. The one who gazes upon the Countenance of Glory surely recognizes the attributes of that pillar as God has willed—verily He is the Possessor of ancient grace.

And among them is the pillar of the Appointed Time which is the element of water and manifestation of the Formal Cause and the Primal, Eternal Reed and the third leaf from the Divine Tree which is neither of the East nor of the West, its color is green, and from it everything has derived its verdancy, and through it God causes all things to die in the third manifestation, and it is the highest lower pillar of the Throne and the manifestation of His mention in the rank of creation and the word of unity, and thus multiplicities

appeared in that rank as do the multiplicity of letters in the mention of “There is no god but God.” And it has infinite aspects with infinite manifestations, wherein the one who gazes upon God witnesses all that the All-Merciful has willed in that pillar. And if one possessed of true insight wished to correlate what has been ordained by the Imams with the letters of “There is no god but God,” he would be able to do so, and that would not be difficult for Us if God should will it and permit it, and I am but a penitent servant.

And one of its pillars is the rank of the Book, and it is the element of earth and the manifestation of the final cause in the world of names and attributes, and its color is red, and from it everything has derived its redness, and geometry has been established in the mystery of all things, and destiny has been determined in the decree of all things, and through it the earth is quickened after its death, and the earth shines with the light of its Lord, and on that Day the earth shall relate its tidings, for thy Lord will have inspired it. And through it God quickens in the fourth manifestation the changing hearts, the determined souls, the dead spirits, and the corrupt bodies, and makes them living beings like unto the steadfast hearts, the firm souls, the good spirits, and the pure bodies.

And today God desires this matter for mankind because the pillar of finality, which is the fruit of creation and the mystery of invention and the manifestation of the three causes in origination, has appeared like unto some of the aspects of the three pillars with the supreme proofs of knowledge and the most great holy manifestations, whereby one whose nature is human nature knows that these aspects could not have been fashioned by man except by leave of the All-Merciful. For one who speaks a word and says that if all were to gather together to produce the like thereof, they would not be able to do so and would never succeed—this is no simple matter nor light utterance, for the letters of the alphabet are in everyone’s possession, so how is it they cannot do it, and if they could do it, why have they not done so?

Nay, by thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth, were all those on earth from the chain of subjects to gather together, they would not be able to produce a single verse like unto what I read and write. And this is witnessed by every just one, that the work of creation allows for human endeavor, while the work of the Lord Himself is distinguished from the work of creation, and people today cannot say a word concerning this proof except that the same word is found in the Qur’an, so that truth may be established by God’s command, even though the polytheists detest it.

And God, glorified be He, through His subtle craftsmanship and His mighty favor, has manifested the mystery of that hidden pillar among the non-Arabs, lest it be difficult for anyone to acknowledge Him and His Cause, that He is the servant of God, confirming what was in the Book and the Tradition, even letter by letter. And God has made this matter clear through one whom no one ever imagined was among those possessed of knowledge and clear and decisive verses and evident proofs. Through him God has tested the souls of the believers, just as occurred what occurred after what was manifested was manifested, and they stand firm in their obedience to God’s religion like mountains. Through this Cause, those who were destined for felicity in the first particle are made happy, and those destined for wretchedness in the fourth particle are made wretched.

According to what has been revealed in the traditions from the mines of mysteries, during the Occultation of the Proof (peace be upon him) there must needs be a dark, blind, deaf and hellish test, so that those created from the clay of light may be purified and those not of that clay may be condemned by

the decree of the wicked. This is clearly stated in that sacred verse of the Qur'an: "Do men think that they will be left alone on saying 'We believe' and not be tried?" And the Imam, exalted be His mention, said: "By God, you shall be broken as glass is broken, but glass can be restored as it was. By God, you shall be broken as pottery is broken, and pottery cannot be restored as it was.

By God, He shall surely distinguish! By God, He shall surely sift as darnel is sifted from wheat!" Then the words of al-Sadiq, exalted be His holiness: "The Master of this Cause has an occultation, and one who holds fast to his religion during it is like one who grasps thorns." Then His words, exalted be His glory, to Mansur: "O Mansur! This Cause shall not come to you except after despair. Nay, by God, not until you are distinguished! Nay, by God, not until you are tested! Nay, by God, not until the wretched are made wretched and the fortunate are made fortunate!" As spoken in the traditions: "The people shall be so tested that nine-tenths of them shall fall away." As He, exalted be His mention, said: "This shall not be until they are distinguished and tested, until none remain among you save the fewest"—then He made His palm small.

Part 6: "And there is no doubt that trials shall…"

And there is no doubt that trials shall not appear until people curse one another and disavow one another, as is clearly stated in His words, exalted be His glory:

> "The matter which you await shall not be until some of you disavow others, and some spit in the faces of others, and until some curse others, and some call others liars."

God and His chosen ones have spoken truly. I complain of my grief and sorrow to God, and I am innocent of the polytheists. There is no doubt that in this trial God's Cause is clearer than the sun at high noon, otherwise God's proof would not be complete upon His servants.

And by every proof that people use to establish the existence of the Imams, they establish the existence of an emissary from the Proof who held in his hands evidence from his Master that none could match. And there is no doubt that in the Greater Occultation, whoever claims to have seen him claiming to be the Gate, his claim is false, as was clearly stated in that sublime directive from that Holy and Elevated One which shone forth from the eastern direction to the fourth of the four gates, Ali ibn Muhammad al-Samarri:

> "Hear—may God increase the reward of your brethren through you—you shall die within six days. So gather your affairs and do not appoint anyone to take your place after your death, for the complete Occultation has begun. There shall be no appearance except by God's permission, exalted be His mention, and that shall be after a long time when hearts have hardened, when the earth is filled with oppression. There will come from among my followers those who claim direct witness—but whosoever claims direct witness before the appearance of the Sufyani and the Call is a lying impostor. There is no power nor might save in God, the Exalted, the Great."

Yet there is no doubt that he—may my spirit be his sacrifice—has deputies on earth and nobles in authority. But by the evidence of wisdom and the nullification of gaps and the avoidance of sudden leaps,

these close ones must necessarily return to a single soul who was the bearer of universal grace, specific ordinances, holy attributes and new subsidiary matters. Today there is no doubt that some of the learned claim this station, and there is no question that the world has not abandoned the virtuous when his virtue becomes apparent. There is no doubt that in every age there must be one who excels all others. By the proof that negates any gap in divine unity, the following of the lower is nullified unless the higher is recognized. Otherwise the earth would surely not be devoid of an ambassador standing by God's command, to whom the elevated returns and whom the follower joins—one who serves as the balance of justice, able to answer all the world's scholars if he wishes and nullify the work of the negligent.

When doubt arises in religion, he can dispel it with decisive proofs, firm evidence, clear verses and established signs, such that people need nothing else and doubt nothing. Those scholars whom the Imam commanded to follow and learn from, whose denial he made equivalent to denying God and whose obedience he made equivalent to obeying God—these are upon truth when they follow that single soul, for pure truth appears at the time of proof only through a single soul. The mystery in reality was thus, as the philosophers maintained regarding the origin of abstraction—that from the One proceeds only one. This is evident by the wisdom through which truth is established by truth and falsehood is nullified by truth, as is witnessed by one such as yourself, with no need to mention proofs or evidence against independence.

One such as yourself, possessed of proofs from among the people of wisdom and discourse, knows that in mentioning these allusions I intended only God's decree in the world of names and attributes. By your life, if you were certain of the mystery of majesty, witnessed the decrees of the Day of Reckoning, turned away from those who seek mere words and arguments, and became aware of what decree has befallen me from the Lord of Glory and Beauty, you would sigh deeply for my sake and weep for God's good pleasure over one imprisoned in his house without sin or dispute.

Lord, had I been patient in the presence of the might of Your Medina it would have been from my weakness, but with one like You being all-powerful, I did not remain patient. Your dominion and decree confined me. No, by Your might, despite my weakness, were I not to witness Your deed I could neither be patient nor have any power therein. But when I knew that time had decreed paradise in this world for one who denies Thee, and for one who believes in Thee two dates sweeter than I desire—I seek only Thy good pleasure and see no glory except in praising Thee by night and by day, and abasement only in disobeying Thee when Thou hast ordained Thy decree.

Through Thee, O my God, I am content with all besides Thee, and I desire naught save what Thou hast desired for me. Indeed, Thy knowledge of my contentment in remembering Thee is dearer to me than the dominion of both worlds. Thou knowest that in all conditions I fear Thy justice. And how should I not fear, when if Thou didst will to chastise me with all Thy punishments eternally, without end, by the perpetuity of Thine Essence, I would still deserve it even in my good deeds? Thou art praised in Thy deeds, obeyed in Thy command, and sovereign in Thy dominion.

For my very profession of Thy oneness is before Thee the greatest sin, since it derives from my existence. Sufficient is it as my sin that I should make mention of my existence before the dawning of Thy countenance, the majesty of Thy being, the beauty of Thine essence, the glory of Thy self-subsistence, the

praise of Thy nature, the power of Thy reality, the encompassing nature of Thy mercy, the justice of Thy oneness, and the grace of Thy might. Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou! I confess my sin even as Thy knowledge encompasseth all things, and I seek Thy forgiveness and turn unto Thee. Verily, Thou art the Munificent, the Merciful.

When thou hast understood what I have confessed before God, thou wilt surely know that all people have falsely accused me, even while they imagine themselves to be guided. Should anyone today claim authority beyond the authority of the Qur'an, or make statements outside the paths of the people of the Bayan, none should consider such a one human. Rather, it is incumbent upon all to choose for themselves what God hath chosen for them and what He hath pronounced in His judgment before He manifested it through 'Ali, peace be upon him, in his hidden sermons, then in the "Speechless Sermon" with its strange allusions and beautiful intimations.

If man were to be fair before God, he would not need mention of proof and evidence, for he who came with the command of the Glorious One, were he to change a decree, would need to present proof, and since he confirmed what all the true sect believed, nothing is required of him while all are obliged to derive their paths of knowledge from the Tree that speaketh in his breast. For the knowledge of people today containeth all contradictions and embraceth all opposing views, but he whom God hath taught the knowledge of the Bayan from His presence—his judgment floweth not as floweth the judgment in the sciences of all. This indeed is the evidence for those who gaze upon the throne of holiness and majesty.

In thy present state, these proofs benefit thee not unless thou effacest from around thy heart the paths of reasoning from all sources, for there is no end to matters of knowledge, and no limit to the ways of reasoning. This is in regard to when thou makest the balance in forms of knowledge, but when thou makest the balance the mystery of divinity, the manifestation of eternality, and the resplendent, shining verses that gleamed from the Morn of Eternity, the veils shall be lifted from thee and nothing shall withhold thee from the scrolls.

In these words, I desired naught for thee save the rending of veils, that the raptures of holiness and the breaths of justice might establish thee at the summit of grace and attributes. And when thou didst mention before, in the depths of allusion, the interpretation of the first letter of thy book, I mention an aspect from the forms of the knowledge of the Bayan: that the letter Ha is the spirit of the letter. The ultimate purpose of the servant's remembrance of the Beloved is like unto the letter which is the red elixir among letters, purifying all words, symbols, signs and allusions. Through it is established the unity of God and negated the law of multiplicity. The people of understanding, since they can know naught of that realm save through what is here, deduce through this letter in all the worlds. It completes the numerical value of the Word than which God hath revealed none lighter in the Qur'an, and it is identical with it in the world of manifestation.

The inmost reality of that Word is completed because the origin of all letters is the Point, and when the Point was divided it became an Alif, and when the Alif bowed before its Lord it became the letter Ba itself, hence the Point was found beneath it. That Word was naught but an Alif between two Bas, and it is a sign of God's command between two Names. Should one of insight contemplate the reality of that Word, he would know what no one else has conceived.

Therefore God hath not assigned to that Word, as with other words, a half, third or quarter, for it is the manifestation of the light of the Divine Eternality from which nothing emerges. God hath ordained the Fifth (Khums) for wisdom, and due to the glory of the numerical value of that Word, He hath attributed it to Himself. God hath created within that Word matters which none can comprehend save whom He willeth. Among these is that He made two letters in that Word from the dark letters, lest people become confused about the law of unity except in the station of the Alif in its state of oneness, for it is from the luminous letters. Glory be to God, how great is His power and how mighty His proof!

Should you open the door of the knowledge of letters in that Word, you would discover from the lights of the heaven of Divinity, the effulgences of the Throne of Might, and the fragrances of the heaven of sovereignty and dominion that which no limited knowledge can encompass. For the spirit in words is like the spirit in bodies, and between them is an essential relationship when considering their essences and accidents, and pure severance when describing God, the Lord of all names and attributes. For names have infinite ranks, and the named of all things is in its own rank.

Behold the spirit of the people of God and their bodies, then look at their words. Though all may utter the word 'justice', when God, exalted be His mention, speaks it, it is that justice which was the source of justice's existence in the Divine Will. When it descends from on high it indicates the named, hence it is written in the Law that none shall touch it save the purified ones. Were all to gather to produce the like of this form of justice, they could not, for what they bring forth from the letters 'ayn, dal and lam is but its body at their rank, while its spirit is non-existent compared to the justice which God hath brought forth for Himself.

Likewise is the decree of justice uttered by the Messenger of God, for its spirit was from His spirit and its utterance from His body. Were all to gather to speak like the word spoken by the Messenger of God, they could not, for its spirit was at His station and its body like unto His, yet most people know not and are powerless.

Such is the decree in every series of eight, for the word 'justice' spoken of by the Gates is its spirit, while its body was in their station. Neither its body nor its spirit can attain to the Word uttered by him who dwelt in the realm of inner meanings, and likewise he who dwelt in the realm of inner meanings in relation to him who spoke in the Bayan from the All-Merciful.

Observe all the letters as you observe people, and recognize the words of the Imams, the Pillars, the Chiefs, and the Nobles just as they have been distilled from the Ocean of Glory upon those signs from the vast sea of majesty. Through knowledge of that station, one recognizes the miracle of the Qur'an and the paths of the people of the Bayan and exposition from among the people of vision.

Most people are dead in the knowledge of that station, as they recognize and hear all words through similar forms, and that is pure polytheism in the religion of the Family of God. For God said "Verily I am He," which indicates His eternity, and that Word in letters is the primordial essence of letters. Nothing resembles Him in the heavens or on earth, and all who uttered that Word did not attain to His presence in what God said, for words are like bodies.

Just as no one can be like the body of the Imam, peace be upon him, no letter can be like the letters spoken by the Family of God in the Bayan, even if the forms appear similar in shape. Rather, it is as I have imparted to you—all are in human form, but the Imam is the most abstract form and the divine light that calls from its essence to its essence, proclaims divinity, and speaks from the realm of might. Such is the decree regarding letters.

By thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth, were all to gather to produce the like of an alif that came from ʾAli, peace be upon him, in letters, they would be powerless. Nay, the alif they produce has no existence in the presence of His alif. Thus do you recognize all deeds, conditions, letters and signs in the series of eight.

Today, were people to gather to produce the like of a single letter of what was written in that Tablet, they could not, for he who brought it—his spirit and body were in his station, and he through whom I spoke—his spirit and body were in the station of one whom God aided through His grace.

Through knowledge of these details, the witness recognizes the greatness of the words of the Family of God and their followers, for they were like their bodies which no creation resembled and no mention equaled. So glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what the speakers describe. He is beyond what the mystics know and independent of what people do. Peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00029: Tafsir al-Ha II (Tafsir sirr al-ha) (Commentary on the Mystery of Ha')

Date: unknown (late Shiraz)

Part 1: "All praise be to God Who hath sanctified…"

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

All praise be to God Who hath sanctified His own Essence above the comprehension of the most exalted abstracted realities of the Divine Realm and all that resembleth them. All praise be to God Who hath transcended in the sublimity of His Being above the description of the most lofty pinnacles of existence and all that compareth with them. All praise be to God Who hath distinguished Himself in the uniqueness of His Identity above all mention of contingent being and whatsoever existeth through creation in the depths of the Realm of Might and all that equalleth them. All praise be to God Who hath magnified Himself in the grandeur of His Self above the judgment of outward vision concerning contingent beings and whatsoever resembleth His judgment therein without mention of aught that accompanieth it.

Glorified and exalted be He! He hath created the Will from naught through the existence of contingent things, then Purpose for the determination of essential realities, then Destiny for the geometry of material things, then Decree for the judgment of origination in beings, then Term for the limits of quiddities, then Permission for the manifestation of universals and particulars in the world of names and attributes, then the Book to encompass all that His knowledge hath encompassed in the realm of possibility.

Exalted be the Most Merciful Who created the Point and made it the ornament of the tablets of creation and invention, which determined what was detailed, decreed what was appointed, permitted what was established, and made manifest what was illumined. Then through it was made to speak what was made to speak, and was made joyous; was elevated what was elevated, and was made sublime; was made distinct what was made distinct, and was made beneficial; was joined what was joined, and was separated; was made successive what was made successive, and was made non-existent; was magnified what was magnified, and was made mighty; was made resplendent what was made resplendent, and was made to sob; was struck down what was struck down, and was made pure; was made to cry what was made to cry, and was confounded what was confounded.

And it declared that the signs in the essential realities of the Divine Realm are cut off in their being from inference, and that the evidences in the material things of the Realm of Might are prevented in their essence from independence, and that things crying out are in themselves witness to their severance from the knowledge of identities, and that the radiant things are in themselves witness to their prevention from mention of the explanation of selfhoods.

Exalted be God their Originator, Who cannot be described by where, nor qualified by how, nor indicated by other, nor worshipped in His Essence, for His Being in the very Eternity hath severed the separate things from conjunction, and His Self in the very Eternality hath prevented the disparate things from separation, and the Identity of Oneness in the very Self-Subsistence hath distinguished essential realities from derivation, and the Selfhood of the Identity in the very Lordship hath directed material things from utterance.

Glorified be God, the Originator of creation, above mention of what He hath split between the atmospheres, and what is mentioned by praise and radiance, then decree and execution, then origination and cloud, by all the people of creation, for verily He, as He is He, none knoweth Him save He, and none is able to praise Muhammad or the Family of God before Him according to what He hath determined and encompassed concerning their station. Verily, He is the Most Great, the Most Exalted.

Thereafter, when what God my Lord willed was detailed in the interpretation of the letter Ha' in the first copy, I desired to interpret concerning its mystery through some of what I interpreted concerning its outward meaning, that it might be light upon light for whoso hath settled upon the carpet of manifestation and desired to drink the water of purity from the decree of the right hand of the Tree of Sinai. Verily we are God's, and verily unto our Lord do we return.

I have mentioned in the signs of before that the Cause in truth, were it not complete in its outward manifestation, would not be complete in its concealment, from the All-Wise from Whose knowledge nothing escapeth and Who is never powerless to create one thing from another, though He is indeed the All-Powerful.

Strange it is that people of understanding should imagine that that which can proceed from none save by God's command could be attained through extreme asceticism, the attractions of possibility, power of memory, or study of revealed books. This is naught but the conjecture of the discerning and the

speculation of the perspicacious regarding the signs of knowledge. Otherwise, concerning the judgment of verses, invocations and sermons, such thoughts would never occur to them.

This assumption is a grievous sin, for reason itself rebels against its own kind in maintaining that if the station of verses could proceed from anyone without God's leave and command, then from the Day of Resurrection until now someone would surely have produced such words and proven them to be of human origin. How then could the judgment of the Qur'an stand as the supreme proof?

This is among the contentions of the people of disputation, but for one like thee among the people of spiritual states, thou wouldst see that whoso claims God's Cause and His judgment, then His verses and His command—were he not acting with God's good pleasure, God would be obligated to raise up another with similar proof, for God is the Ever-Living, the All-Powerful, the All-Knowing, and He is the Protector of His religion and His judgment. When this is not the case, there is no doubt that the Cause is established through God's knowledge and power, not through the impotence and schemes of creation.

Concerning this proof, were God to manifest it, I would not wish to mention to thee in this book aught save what I would read in thy presence when God lifteth the fear and the veil, that thou mayest know with thine own eyes that human proof is naught but from the All-Merciful in the manner of the Bayan. Previously I mentioned in the explanation of Kawthar, at the balance of justice, a true sprinkling to manifest what God hath created in existence unto vision.

By thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth, were I to recite God's verses or what was revealed in the Book, there would be none closer to me than the most excellent judgment of knowledge among the people, yet most people are not grateful. O man! This Cause is not dubious to anyone, nor can anyone flee from it, for none came with such proof save Muhammad the Messenger of God, and every proof in every station is established through this proof from God.

None can utter a word concerning it unless he wisheth to deny his Lord, for one who speaketh a word which all on earth combined could not produce the like thereof—this is not the creation of creatures but rather the creation of God. Show me then what those who are called upon besides Him have created.

Mighty is God's Cause, for the proof of this Cause is like unto the supreme proof of God's Messenger, and through this proof God nullified the deeds of the people of the towns and the divines who exchange truth for falsehood. If thou wouldst today look with the eye of truth, thou wouldst see those who spread corruption in that land without right are in the fire. Indeed, thou wouldst recite unto them the verse of the Subduer:

> "Did ye but know with certainty of knowledge, ye would behold the Hell-fire, then would ye see it with certainty of sight, then on that Day shall ye be questioned concerning the delights."

For those who committed it aforetime performed, in the sight of God, a deed more base than the deed of Pharaoh and of the bedouins of pagan ignorance. For when Pharaoh purposed to deny the proof of his Lord, he brought forth a kind of sorcery; and the Arabs, in the early days of Islam, composed odes about the House. Yet these men deny the Cause of God at the very time they imagine themselves rightly guided.

God confound them! Evil indeed is that which their hands have wrought, and grievous is that which they do.

O man! How shall I unveil this Cause, which in its grandeur is like unto the pillar of Prophethood? It possesseth proof in the Bayan even as God revealed unto Muhammad in the Qur'an. Belittle not the Cause of God, doubt not the power of God, and follow not the forms of learning lest they lead thee astray from the path of God. For I swear by thy life, I have not read a single letter of that outward knowledge, nor do I know today a single rule from the principles of the people of the Bayan. I possessed no books of learning beforehand from which to memorize words, nor had I any means to this bestowal from the All-Merciful save through God's grace and bounty. Indeed, were one such as thyself to question me today concerning the technical matters of learning recorded in books, by thy Lord, I would know not—nay, not even grammar and syntax. In this do I glory, and by this will God adduce proof against all on the Day of Resurrection, for he who is aided by God's grace is more worthy to be followed than those who are unable to comprehend His wisdom and His signs.

It behooveth one such as thyself to arise with the balance of the Bayan, to be convinced by the proof of the All-Merciful, and to observe in that Bayan through the light of clear vision the mystery of all created things. Though I be in fear today of Satan and his brethren, yet by thy Lord, the Lord of the heavens and earth, were all to gather with all their might to deny Me, I would not see it as even equal to the blackness in the eye of a dead ant, than which nothing smaller exists in mention among created things. For the proof is in My hand like unto this sun at high noon, brilliant and radiant. Yea, were anyone, even an infidel, to read a verse in its pristine nature, My back would be broken—though this is impossible, I mention it only to unveil souls and cleanse hearts, like unto His words, exalted be His mention: "Call your witnesses besides God if ye be truthful."

Indeed, such utterance from one like Me is not befitting, for its time hath not yet come. But since I see thee among those who desire the pure religion, I have sprinkled from that surging ocean a sprinkling of that which was about to overflow from Me. Though My fear for that land is evident to thee, yet since My hope in God exceeds My fear of them, I have mentioned what thou knowest. Conceal that which God hath commanded to be concealed until they witness what they were promised. Say: Their appointed time is the morning—is not the morning near? Sufficient unto them is the mention of deeds in this world and religion.

Know that it is obvious to you that in the science of allusions and realities, the heroes of Ahmadiyya and the mystics of Kazmiyya have risen up against me more than other divines, since some of them have ascended the ladder of allusions to such a degree that they can split hairs, yet they have recognized the Cause of God. I do not think that you know any of their leaders except the one who came before to that land, and he is today truly a vast ocean of knowledge, as both the Shaykh and the Siyyid—may God sanctify their dust—have explicitly acknowledged his excellence and diligence.

Although one such as I should not cite his writing as evidence, I have sent his letter to you so that you may know that he became certain merely upon seeing the verses. Most of the divines who possessed a human spirit have acknowledged this wondrous Cause, this brilliant honor from this religion. Those who deny this Cause are dead—their deeds have no validity, for one who believes not in God's Cause has no

standing, nor does one who fears not knowledge. It is as though they perceive not what their hands have wrought.

O God! The compiler of the Seas has mentioned, regarding the miracle of the Family of God, the Sahifih-i-Sajjadiyyih, saying that all agree it resembles the heavenly scriptures and the psalms of the Family of Muhammad in composition, and this treatise suffices as praise for whoever wishes to believe in them. How then can the authority of the Wilayat be established through a decisive treatise, yet my servitude to the Family of God not be established through numerous treatises that have filled the East and West of the earth?

Nay, were God to will it and lift the veil, I would show you my power in composition, such that my pen could produce a treatise in mere hours. What proof could be greater than this power, what blessing greater than this gift? Such is the majesty of its allusions that none can distinguish between them and the supplications of the Family of God, and such is the grandeur of its stations that none can comprehend their outer meanings.

The proof against me would only be valid if I had abrogated a law of the Shariah. Otherwise, since I believe in the decree of the Qur'an and the allusions of the people of the Bayan and that resplendent proof in the Bayan, how could anyone be content to deny me based on evil suspicions and the calumnies of the deluded ones?

Lord! I complain to Thee and cry out before Thee, and Thou knowest my sorrow in this worldly life. Pour upon me patience and grant me victory over the wrongdoing people.

O man! How can I not complain of the children of the human race, whose lot God has made only impotence and submission, for they have fabricated against me what they fabricated not against the ancients, claiming that I have claimed the station of the Wilayat and its conditions. I seek refuge in God from their deeds and am innocent of what they have fabricated against me in their souls.

It is not for me to claim that I am a servant of the Remnant of God, for my existence before the dawning-place of His Essence is non-existence, and if it were mentioned it would be like the mention of an ant presuming to know its Lord's unity and recognize its Imam—it sees only the limits of itself and reads only the letters of its own book. So glory be to God from the deeds of people, and I seek refuge in God from what the slinking whisperer whispers in people's breasts.

The divines of both the masses and the elite have all maintained that Ali's words in his sermons are a miracle of eloquence, and none can utter their like in exposition due to their sublime eloquence. And none can speak like it in exposition due to the height of its eloquence, the grandeur of its rhetoric, and the majesty of its allusions therein and its indications in its depths, where the people of meaning and exposition mention regarding his sermon that which the people of vision cannot comprehend except after explanation.

Part 2: “Indeed, the reality of the science of exposition…”

Indeed, the reality of the science of exposition is the noblest of stations and the most sublime of degrees, for God does not present any proof to His creation except through His Word, as He, exalted be His mention, said: “Say: Bring forth a discourse like it, if ye be truthful.” And this is evidence of the greatness of its rank and the majesty of its reality, that God chose from among all that He created and fashioned to manifest the beauty that lies in His Word through the mention of exposition.

And though the creation of the heavens and earth and all between them is greater, He presents no proof except in exposition. This is evidence of the mystery of contingent existence, that God has placed the secret of the subtlety of all He created in the heavens and earths and what lies between them in exposition. Therefore God presents no proof through anything else, and it is greater than the creation of the heavens and earth and weightier than them to one who looks with vision to the reality of contingent existence and knows the power of the All-Merciful in the creation of exposition.

Glory be to God! Some people realize that in early Islam, if a stone had spoken, a soul would have believed in God. And now one who was born among the Persians and raised among the nations speaks like those sermons, and from his pen flow seas in mention of every station and grandeur, yet none perceives it except one from whom God took a covenant on the first day and the four witnessings. This has been God’s way from before, as when God sent down the Qur’an among the eloquent Arabs of the Hijaz, they all mocked it saying “These are but tales of the ancients,” and some said “These are but stories of the ancients,” until ten years passed and none believed in it except Ali. And this is indeed a vast knowledge that none encompasses save whom God wills.

But today is not like early Islam—all have read the Qur’an and know the station of exposition and have found proof in exposition through the mystery of vision. And whoever reads Our verses and knows Our allusions will know the wisdom of exposition. But the copies that were among the people contained fabrications and lies from those who disbelieve in God’s verses, and these are the lost. If you wish to observe the station of exposition, seek the sermons from the men and reflect on their allusions—how could one born among the non-Arabs speak with such station?

And all this exposition and what was mentioned in the books is the station of flight, for people cannot bear to carry the pinnacle of mysteries and arrive at the court of holiness and majesty. Otherwise God’s Cause has no veil, God’s religion has no cover, God’s light has no shadow, and God’s love has no displeasure in it—glory be to Him and exalted is He above what they describe.

The cause of most people’s confusion is their lack of recognition of the stations when they witness the signs of the Divine in the realm of humanity and do not distinguish between the affairs of might from the indications of the kingdom. And in the school of the family of God, peace be upon them, there is a universal principle through knowledge of which doubts are lifted from the people of glory and opposing things are brought together under harmonious judgement. This principle is that one should see all things as they truly are, just as Muhammad, the Messenger of God, taught all people when he said “O Lord! Show me the realities of all things as they are.”

The knowledge of this station is not fully manifest except through understanding destiny and the judgement of the Ordainer, for man cannot perceive the reality of things merely through their form, since he cannot know the whole, as all things share the human form and divine temple in this world. How then can man distinguish between the Word of God, the words of Muhammad the Messenger of God, the words of the Family of God, the words of their followers whom God has placed in their station, and the words of people according to their ranks and stations—all in a single word? For the form of the phrase "There is no god but God" spoken by those in the chain of eight is outwardly the same, though in truth the rank of the first is as lord in relation to the second in all its stations.

Through this principle one can distinguish between the forms of the exalted ones in clear explanation and recognize the falsity of base forms in expression. Through knowledge of this station, one understands the degrees of unity in words, verses, signs and stations. Whoever claims that the word of unity spoken by Fatima, peace be upon her, is the same as that spoken by the prophets has associated partners with his Lord.

Indeed, you could expound further on this matter, but since most people are veiled from knowledge of this station and associate partners with God and His signs due to their ignorance of this exalted rank, I will indicate a drop from this vast ocean of knowledge, so that all may be illumined by the glorious lights of the divine sanctuary and all may resound with the reverberating lights of the heaven of divine unity in the throne of the paradise of beauty.

O observer of the throne of glory and praise! Know with certainty that the aspects of the primal chain are essentially distinct from all else in their station and their realities are unreachable by others in their domain. Every letter uttered by the Primal Tree has sovereignty over all else, such that a single letter of the Qur'an cannot be equaled by anything in the kingdom of names and attributes. Consider the word "Command" in the Qur'an—though others may attempt to reveal similar words, none can match it, for its form exists in the rank of its spirit, and just as its spirit is the cause of all things, so too is its form the cause of all causes.

For the letter through which God said "Be!" unifies through its spirit all that exists and will exist infinitely, and its form is the cause of everything named. Even if all were to say "Be!", their spirit would not resemble its spirit, nor their form its form.

Similarly, you can understand this principle in the chain of meanings, then the gates, then the Imams, then the pillars, then the angels, then the chiefs, then the nobles. Just as the spirit of the letters Kaf and Nun in the station of the chiefs has sovereignty and dominion over the spirit of Kaf and Nun in the station of the nobles, so too is this true of their forms, though all say "Be!"

But the word "Be" which the Messenger of God (peace be upon Him) spoke is like His utterance between all the Kaf and the Nun, unique among its kind, and in the Book it has transcendent glory and impregnable majesty. Likewise are all the deeds from the second chain, for the works of the second chain, both universal and particular, are but accidents and similitudes in relation to the first chain.

Through knowledge of this rank one recognizes the truth of the words of the Family of God and their followers who speak by their leave. And through knowledge of this station one witnesses that if all were

to gather to speak like unto a single letter of the words spoken by Salman, they would be powerless, for weakness is like unto spirits—just as his body preceded all subjects in the rank of bodies, likewise were his words the lord of words among the letters and scriptures of others. Never did God send down upon anyone in the chain of subjects the like of a letter spoken by Salman.

The decree in every station is that the second station sees the Manifested One in its mirror through the first mirror. Likewise in the decree of the letters, the phrase "There is no God but God" when spoken by one of the nobles reflects God in the seventh mirror, and when spoken by one of the pillars reflects God in the fifth mirror. The observer of the extremity of the heart sees their difference and judges between them and bears witness to them. God will gather them on the Day of Resurrection just as they were gathered on that day.

If you would sharpen your vision and purify your sight, you would see the letters spoken by the Messenger of God in the first Paradise and the letters spoken by one of the nobles in the seventh Paradise, and between them was a distance as God had ordained, which none can comprehend save whom God willeth. The distance between the Orient of Beginning and the Occident of Ending is as nothing in His sight, for beginnings in manifestations have no beginning and endings in extensions have no end.

But those veiled from meeting the Manifested One in this worldly life see the form of "There is no God but God" as equal in all stations, and this is pure infidelity in the sight of the pure Family of God, for this Word in letters when spoken by the Manifestation of the Bayan is in the letters of the Word of the Bayan, then in the rank of meanings it is the Word of meanings, then in the rank of the Gates it is the Word of the Gates, then in the rank of the Imamate it is the Word of the Imamate, then in the rank of the Pillars it is the Word of the Pillars, then in the rank of the Chiefs it is the Word of the Chiefs, then in the rank of the Nobles it is the Word of the Nobles.

The decree of knowledge which 'Ali ibn al-Husayn (peace be upon them both) commanded Jabir in the tradition which was read to you in that Book—his rank cannot be fully known except through its conditions, signs, manifestations, stations, tokens, indications, words, and what encompasses beyond these of that which none can comprehend save Him. Through knowledge of this station the learned excel one another, as 'Ali (peace be upon him) clearly stated in his words:

> "Names are either manifest or hidden, or neither manifest nor hidden. The learned ones only surpass one another in their knowledge of that which is neither manifest nor hidden"

—which is the mystery of divine decree to which I alluded before.

According to this firm decree, if anyone were to say "I have uttered that word in the same way as he uttered it," God would not place him above his station, and he would be considered an unbeliever at once, for though the words "There is no God but God" which the Shi'ih utter may appear the same in form as the words uttered by one of the family of God, peace be upon them, yet the decree applies similarly to deeds. Thus the Prophets were unable to perform any deed like unto the deed of the body of Fatimih.

Likewise, all knowledge and conditions of the lower hierarchy are not mentioned in relation to the higher hierarchy. Therefore, from the lower hierarchy emerge, in the form of the word of the exalted one, all ranks and conditions. And at the time of reversal was the station of the manifestation of the Essence in the countenance of the attributes, where in the interpretation of the letter "Ha" all its letters would be most great and its meanings most glorious and subtle.

This indeed is the nobility of which al-Sadiq spoke, saying:

> "Whoso attaineth unto the stations of the attributes hath attained unto the resting-place of true knowledge. And whoso recognizeth the sign in the proof needeth not the sign in the account. And whoso knoweth separation from union will know that to which I have alluded in these proofs."

And he who gazeth upon the Lord of attributes will be freed from mention of the glories, the proofs, the accounts, the stations, the tokens and the signs, by the decree of his Lord—verily there is no God but He, the Possessor of great bounty.

Among the stations for explaining this mystery are those which have never occurred to the hearts of some people, nor are they befitting to their station. But since I see thee among those endowed with knowledge and exposition, I shall allude to a drop from this deep, abundant, surging, wave-tossed ocean, that it may be a gateway to the knowledge of that station.

It is that thou shouldst see no multiplicities having existence before the sign of the Essence, and shouldst regard them as on the day when none of them was worthy of mention. And in that condition, when thou art established in the truth, thou wilt see the mystery in the countenance of the One revealed—the manifest itself being the mystery in the presence of revelation.

And thou shouldst not rejoice in knowledge of anything, nor in thy power over anything, nor in thy possession of what God hath placed in thy grasp, nor in spirit, nor in fragrance, nor in mention, nor in exposition, nor in the blessings of Paradise, nor in knowledge thereof. And when thou rememberest any of these things, thou shouldst not pause in its mention nor in its mystery save to behold the countenance of thy Revealer, and thou shouldst see Him manifest and existent where nothing was with Him, nor is anything mentioned in His rank.

And to this did 'Ali, peace be upon him, allude in his prayer on the day of Sha'ban:

> "My God! Grant me complete severance unto Thee and illuminate the vision of our hearts with the light of their gazing upon Thee, until the vision of the hearts penetrates the veils of light, attaining unto the Source of Grandeur, and our spirits become suspended in the glory of Thy sanctity. Make me one of those whom Thou didst call and who responded to Thee, whom Thou didst behold and who swooned before Thy majesty, and who conversed with Thee secretly while working for Thee openly."

And if thou hast reached before, or wilt reach hereafter, unto the station of grandeur and the mystery of identity and the identity of oneness and the manifestation of eternality and the beauty of divinity, thou

shalt recite all remembrances in the manner He, exalted be His mention, hath interpreted in His prayer following the Witr prayer:

> "Thou art God, the Support of the heavens and earth, and Thou art God, the Beauty of the heavens and earth,"

unto what he, peace be upon him, hath said.

Blessed then is he who drinketh the water of living wine in this earthly life and maketh himself even as God created him without imposing hardship upon himself.

God hath prescribed for him who ascendeth to the station of His knowledge and love ordinances that none can comprehend save His knowledge. Among these, it is prescribed for him who journeyeth from the Truth to creation in the Most Great Hope that he should not fear for himself, even should he bear every sin encompassed by God's knowledge, for God is the Self-Sufficient, possessed of expansive mercy, forgiving whom He willeth as He willeth. None can reverse His judgment or repeal His command.

Part 3: "And among these, it is prescribed for him…"

And among these, it is prescribed for him who journeyeth from creation to the Truth that he should not feel secure in himself, even should he know every good, for God is possessed of perpetual justice, and were He to desire for something the decree of justice, the heavens and earth could not withstand it. His is the power to change in the kingdom of command and creation. Sufficient unto thee in this path is what Abu Abdullah hath indicated in his address, exalted be his mention:

> "O Isaac! Fear God as though thou seest Him, and if thou seest Him not, verily He seeth thee. If thou believest He seeth thee not, thou hast disbelieved, and if thou knowest He seeth thee, yet still committest disobedience before Him, thou hast made Him the least of those who observe."

I bear witness in this path, O noble one, that if thou fearest thy Lord, all people will fear thee, as indicated in His address, exalted be His mention: "Whoso feareth God, everything feareth him, and whoso feareth not God, God maketh him to fear everything." Then He said, exalted be His mention: "Whoso knoweth God feareth God, and whoso feareth God detacheth himself from the world."

Verily the servant attaineth not perfection in the station of servitude until he feareth not the people and seeth all things, compared to God's decree, as like unto the black of the eye of a dead ant, and praise to him is God's good pleasure and blame His displeasure, as indicated by al-Sadiq in his saying that love of eminence dwelleth not in the heart of one who is fearful and in awe.

Verily the wayfarer unto God on the white path and the crimson pillar in that journey reacheth not the station of his homeland save through empty hands from what is in people's possession and what is attributed to them. The most knowing of people regarding God and His signs are those most content with His decree. It behooveth the wayfarer in that station to fix in his heart the decree of that tradition wherein He, exalted be His mention, saith:

> "I marvel at the Muslim who, whatever God—exalted and glorified be He—decreeth for him is good for him: if he be cut with scissors it is good for him, and if he possess the east and west of the earth it is good for him."

And he witnesseth his contentment with death in all his conditions, for the servant's heart is not content nor doth he detest the world save in the state of death, and it behooveth the sincere believer to remember death twenty-five times each day and night, for He, exalted be His remembrance, hath said that whosoever doeth this, God will record for him the reward of one who is martyred in His path. If the servant were to refine his vision, he would see no glory save in the love of God, for the cause of people's love for pearls and gold is that their love originates in the love of God, and therefore all people love them. Likewise, the opposite holds true for its opposite. Ask God to take the hands of His servants upon that path, for it is rugged, bare, and harsh, from which none can escape save those whom God willeth. Verily those who enter the fire enter it only by this path. Therefore have I ventured to make these allusions, hoping for forgiveness from him whose heart is saddened by reading these intimations.

Among these is the obligation upon one who journeys from Truth to Ultimate Truth not to retain within himself any limited ego, for if his possible ego is mentioned with him, he is not of the people of that path. This station is reserved for the family of God and for whomsoever God willeth among those who recline upon couches in the gardens of the Divine Realm, who drink pure water from the cup of grandeur in the gardens of might, and who delight in tender meat in the gardens of sovereignty and dominion. These allusions are not hidden from thee, for they have no remembrance save the remembrance of God. Though at their station mention be made of attributes, names and blessings, these are but the sweepings of vain imaginings.

They are pure signs, absolute manifestations, definitive appearances, and conditions of the essences and qualities of God, Creator of names and attributes. Thus did Ali, peace be upon him, allude to their station in himself, saying: "Verily, I am the Essence of essences, I am the Essence within essences for the Essence." And the poet said in his praise: "O Substance through whom existence standeth firm, all people after thee are but accidents." And Abdul-Hamid ibn Abil-Hadid addressed him thus: "Thy attributes are names, and Thy essence here is a substance 'free of meanings from the attributes of substances,' beyond accidents, quality and time, 'greater than comparison with the elements.'"

All of these are but names and attributes in exposition of their exalted remembrance and majesty. The servant entereth not the depths of Oneness unless he journeyeth from it unto it and maketh its remembrance and its bliss itself and naught else. This is the Paradise that hath no shadow, and none entereth it save its people. Therefore have the hells become seven and the paradises eight, though it entereth not into numbers even if mentioned among them. O man! The secret whereby thy heart findeth rest is thy arrival at those depths. Deprive not thyself of thy portion in this worldly life, though it is vain and hath no standing with the people of truth. Turn wholly unto God, forget all else in thy love for Him, and journey from Him unto Him upon that Most Great Path and Most Enduring Way. For if thou performest a deed in those depths, the seven paradises and all that God hath created therein equal it not. Belittle not the right of that path, for thou hast not valued it as it should be valued except when thou enterest it by God's leave. And when thou enterest it, thou canst not depart from it.

Belittle not the right of that Path, for thou hast not esteemed it as it should be esteemed until thou enterest therein by God's leave. When thou hast entered it, thou canst not depart from it, nor speak therein except by thy Lord's command, nor dwell except through Him, nor utter except through His power, nor take delight save in His countenance which is manifested unto thee through thee, nor point to aught besides Him, nor canst thou desire anything, for desire belongeth to the realm of action, while that station is the station of thine essence, from which are severed all names, deeds, manifestations and attributes. When thou attainest unto it, thy innermost reality shall speak forth all that Ali—peace be upon him—spoke forth openly, including what he said in the Tutunjiyyih Sermon: "I saw God and Paradise with mine own eyes."

Verily the Truth intended not the Essence of the Lord, due to its inaccessibility and state of severance, but rather meant His Identity which was manifested unto him through him in his station, concerning which he spoke in his words about the supreme realm: "He was manifested unto it through it, and it became illumined; He appeared unto it, and it shone forth; He cast His likeness into its identity, and His deeds were made manifest through it."

The decree of that Path is not due to the absence of proof. He is God, sufficient unto me in that Path. He is the Lord—how excellent a Majestic One! He is the Lord—how excellent a Beauteous One! He is the Lord—how excellent a Friend! He is the Lord—how excellent a Guardian!

Among its requirements is that one who journeyeth from creation with the eye of Truth, or vice versa, must see no light except His light, and no creation except His creation. All the affairs of that station revolve around that Word. The wayfarer on that Path beholdeth along his way the wonders of dominion and the vicissitudes of time in every world according to what God hath ordained therein. Were I to lift the veil, thou wouldst say concerning me that which the decree determineth in its inception: "This is naught but a wondrous thing!"

The wayfarer in these journeys must needs know the letter of each world among the inscribed letters, lest any decree veil him from all things. He must perceive the correspondence of the worlds to this world.

I have known from human wisdom that in the station of abjad, alif is the letter of the Universal Spirit, ba is the letter of the Universal Soul—therefore did he who is referred to in the Qur'an as "ourselves" say "I am the point beneath the ba"—jim is the letter of Universal Nature, dal is the letter of Universal Matter, ha is the letter of Universal Form, waw is the letter of Universal Body, zay is the letter determining the directions of the crystalline sphere, ha is the letter of the sphere of the Throne, ta is the letter of the sphere of the zodiac, ya is the letter of the sphere of the mansions, kaf is the letter of the sphere of Saturn, lam is the letter of the sphere of Jupiter, mim is the letter of the sphere of Mars—therefore did the poet say in the oration: "Until the ha of its descent from the mim of its center connected with the essence of the neck vein; the tha of heaviness clung to it, and it became the most humble between the landmarks and heights"—nun is the letter of the sphere of the Sun, sin is the letter of the sphere of Venus, 'ayn is the letter of the sphere of Mercury, fa is the letter of the sphere of the Moon, then sad for fire, and for air, water and earth.

These are the stages of the journey of one who travels from Truth to creation, and in the ascent, its first station is the letter Ta, which is the letter of mineral, then the letter of plant which is Tha, then the letter of animal which is Kha, then the letter of jinn which is Dhal, then the letter of angel which is Dad, then the letter of human which is Za. And to this end are the ranks of letters in the decree of ascent and descent.

And all that I indicated in the interpretation of Ha, the first letter of your mighty Book, for unveiling the mystery—I have no knowledge that unveils the veil from the face of the mystery, rather the veils increase through mention of indications, decrees of signs, allusion of verses and intimations. And here I am with my transgressions before God, and unveiling the veil from the face of the mystery, I commune with God my Lord with these words of my tongue, that God may answer my prayer regarding you and bring you to the station of your address in your Book, and that your soul may pardon me for what you have discovered of my offenses, and that you may seek forgiveness from your Lord for me and for those who follow me, for I am indeed the Ever-Relenting, the Forbearing.

And let this be the musk-scented conclusion of these words, for herein let the competitors compete. O Friend! Know thou the truth of these days, for the sun has never risen upon their like, and for each is a portion in the Book of thy Lord, and God will recompense all according to what their hands have earned, and nothing escapes His knowledge in the heavens or on earth, and He is independent of what people do.

And it is the right of everyone who knows the Truth to proclaim it and nullify the work of those who wish to extinguish the light of God with their mouths, but God refuses except to perfect His light, though the polytheists may detest it.

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate. Praise be to God Who bestows favor in the Book upon those who believe in God and His verses, that He may admit them to Gardens of perpetual residence as secure dwellers.

O my God! I bear witness before Thee to that which Thou dost witness for Thyself when nothing existed besides Thee, that Thou art God, there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thy Essential Reality has never been known save through Thine eternal Essence, and Thy Being cannot be described save through Thine Own Oneness, for Thou hast never been known through other than Thyself, nor associated with Thy creation, nor described by other than Thee, nor can any description or attribute of anything encompass Thee.

For the Essential Reality of Thy Power severs all essences from knowing Thee, and the Being of Thy Will prevents all material things from describing Thee, and the Reality of Thy Creation separates all beings from explaining Thee, and the Identity of Thy Innovation limits all geometries from mentioning direct vision.

Glory be to Thee, O my God! If I say “Thou,” then likeness has imitated likeness, yet Thou canst not be described thus. And if I say “He is Thou,” then majesty has indicated majesty, yet Thou canst not be characterized thus.

For Thou didst create Will before all things from no thing, by itself, without connection to Thy Essence, nor association with Thy Being, nor reflection from Thy Reality, nor knowledge from Thine Identity, but

rather through Thy Power which Thou manifested to it thereby, causing it to shine forth without how or where or indication.

Then Thou didst establish creation in its course that the radiant ones might shimmer with the knowledge of separation in the midst of union, and that the hesitant ones might stammer with the knowledge of prevention in the being of separation.

Glory be to Thee! When I discovered creation in Thy Countenance and invention in Thy Presence, the contingent beings became confused in their recognition of Thy power through Thine own Self, and therefore they described Thee—had they truly known Thee they would not have described Thee. Therefore, O my God, they do not sanctify Thee. Glory be to Thee, Glory be to Thee, O my God!

Thou art He Who cannot be unified through Thine essence, nor sanctified through Thy Countenance, nor described through Thine Identity, nor characterized through Thine eternity, nor indicated through Thy Being, nor worshipped through Thy Self, for Thou hast ever been without the mention of anything, and Thou wilt ever be as Thou wert in the eternity of eternities.

Nothing existed at Thy level, and when Thou didst create creation for Thy knowledge, Thou didst describe Thyself to them according to their capacity, that all might receive their portion and creation might attain to the ultimate purpose of the outpouring of Thy creation and the existence of Thine invention. And Thou didst characterize Thy chosen ones with what Thou hadst ordained for their station.

And now that Thou hast created me and provided for me, I acknowledge before Thee that Muhammad was Thy servant whom Thou didst choose from the midst of eternity above all peoples, distinguished among the sons of men above all humanity, and made him the station of Thyself in the execution and origination of every decree and destiny, for Thou canst not be perceived by sight though Thou wert at the Greatest Vista. And I bear witness regarding the fruit of his heart and his successors to what Thou hast specially bestowed upon them of Thy bounties, of which none knoweth save Thee. And I beseech Thee, O Creator of names and attributes, to send blessings upon Muhammad and the family of Muhammad through the essences of the divine realm in creation, and the realities of the realm of might in glory, and the identity of the heavenly kingdom in praise, and the being of the earthly kingdom in sublimity, and the geometry of the subtle ones in decree, and the luminosity of the radiant ones in origination, and the reflection of the illumined ones in the manifestations of the fragments of the tablets of ruby in execution, the wonder of the sanctified ones in the conditions of the human realm from the people of the cloud. Verily Thou art God, the Great, the Exalted.

Part 4: “O my God! How can I call upon…”

O my God! How can I call upon Thee when my very existence is a sin, and it hath acquired without right what Thou didst not permit of errors and sins which have come between it and Thee, and clothed it in the garment of abasement before Thy face, and rent asunder what Thou didst place between it and obedience to Thee of the veils of Thy mercy and the pavilions of Thy oneness? The sins have encompassed it from every direction such that it cannot emerge from them save to enter into them

again. And Thou, O my God, knowest its station and art able to remove its affliction, and unto Thee alone is the complaint, there is no God but Thee.

And how can I call upon Thee when Thy mercy hath encompassed all things and Thy providence hath surrounded me from every direction, and verily Thy deed indicateth Thy grace toward me? It is as though Thy knowledge hath not encompassed any evil from me, nor Thy book any offense from myself. Glory be to Thee! How excellent is Thy deed and how great is Thy handiwork regarding me! Thou didst create me when I was nothing, and nurture me through Thy Will without seeing any good from me. Glory be to Thee! Exalted and sanctified is Thine Essence from my praising Thee according to what Thou art in might and unity and majesty and power, for praise from me would be according to my incapacity and poverty, and it befitteth not Thy presence nor ascendeth to Thy holy court, for whatsoever is besides Thee is not mentioned before Thee.

Naught can ascend unto the realm of Thy sanctity, for whatsoever existeth besides Thee is never mentioned in Thy presence, and if mentioned, hath no standing to describe Thee, as all things were brought into being from nothingness by Thy creation.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! I see no portion save in obedience to Thee, and no honor save in Thy love, that I might venture before Thee to praise Thine own Self, perchance my heart might be cooled like snow before the vast ocean of Thy Self-Subsistence, and my soul find tranquility like a mountain before the sea of Thy Divine Unity, lest I be as the cattle among Thy servants.

Glorified, glorified art Thou! I testify that there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thou hast ever been, when nothing else existed, and wilt ever remain as Thou hast been. Nothing existeth at Thy level, for Thy Essence hath no description—it is in itself beyond all expression of substance, and Thy Being hath no attribute—it is in its reality beyond all material comprehension.

None save Thee shall ever know Thee, and none but Thyself shall ever unify Thee, for knowledge implieth conjunction and unity implieth separation, which is impossible in the realm of certitude, as Thou hast ever been with no description possible, and wilt ever remain as Thou art with no attribute in existence.

If I say “Thou art Thou,” I have merely compared like with like, and if I say “He is He,” Identity itself would draw near to creation and Providence to invention, which in itself separateth creation from Thy Being and preventeth all from the path of Thy knowledge.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! If I say Thou art All-Knowing, I mean but to declare Thy sanctity from the existence of any known thing in relation to Thy knowledge, and if I say Thou art All-Powerful, I seek but to proclaim Thy holiness from mention of anything ruled alongside Thee. Thou art as Thou art—no description, no attribute, no quality belongeth to Thy Court, no measure, no name to Thy Being, no mark, for Thy Essence is known through Thy Being and Thy Being described through Thine Essence.

This is the station of Thy Self and none other, and Thy creation hath no portion in knowing Thy Self save through the negation of all else, for Thine Essence hath no path in the realm of expression, nor Thy Being any attribute in existence. I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy might, to bring me to the most radiant light of Thy creation and sever me from all else through the manifestation of Thy attractive power, that I might

attain through Thy Will the station of Thy holiness and enter the depths of the sea of Oneness through the splendor of Thy countenance.

Glorified art Thou, O Beloved! Thou art He Who hath made Thyself known to all things through the manifestation of Thy creation and hath transcended all things through the appearance of Thy invention. None can point to Thy Being, for nothing hath existence at Thy level nor mention with Thee in Thy grandeur.

Glorified and exalted art Thou! When Thou didst manifest Thyself to all contingent things through the appearance of Thy creation, essences took on their essential nature by Thy command, and thus they described Thee in ways incapable of knowing Thine Essence. Glorified art Thou, O my God! Had they known Thee, they would not have described Thee, and thus, O my God, they have not unified Thee.

I beseech Thee therefore, O God, O my God, by the might of Thy Being, the sanctity of Thine Essence, and the uniqueness of Thy Celestial Dominion, to bring me to the highest station Thou hast ordained in creation and of what Thy knowledge hath encompassed in the realm of invention. Lo, I seek refuge with Thee, turn repentant unto Thee through Thy grace, and beseech Thee through Thine Own Self, for I have no refuge save in Thee.

Teach me, then, what lieth concealed within Thy knowledge, and aid me through that which is treasured in Thy mystery, for I am poor and in need of Thy mercy, while Thou art self-sufficient, having no need of my chastisement. Nothing in the heavens or on earth can overwhelm Thee, for Thou art the Self-Sufficient, the All-Praised.

O my God! I bear witness before Thee and before those who stand in Thy presence that even if Thou shouldst cause the manifestation of Thy power in contingent being to become as molten iron, and shouldst enlarge my body through Thy might until it filled all space like unto an iron ingot, and shouldst maintain me in that fire through the eternity of Thy might, the holiness of Thy Self-Subsistence, the glory of Thy Most Merciful nature, and the majesty of Thy grandeur—sustaining me at every moment with a new spirit—yet would I acknowledge, by Thy might, that Thou art praiseworthy in Thy deeds, obeyed in Thy decree, and just in Thy judgment. I would have no argument to ask “Why, O my God?” or “How, O my Lord?” For I truly deserve this as recompense for having mentioned my own self—a consequence of my misdeeds and transgressions which none save Thee can encompass.

Alas, alas for what Thy knowledge hath decreed and what Thy Book hath recorded concerning the mention of my transgressions! Were I to mention but one of them, it would suffice to condemn all who dwell in the kingdoms of heaven and earth, and none, after learning of it, would dare approach the might of Thy sovereignty and the power of Thy grandeur.

Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou art He Who created me, Who blessed me, Who gave me life, Who causeth me to die, Who sustaineth me, Who inspireth me, Who honoreth me, Who giveth unto me, Who strengtheneth me, and Who exalteth me. Not a thing escapeth Thy knowledge, nor can aught be concealed from Thy countenance.

Alas, alas! How can I say "I," when this is the greatest sin and the most ancient transgression, which no sin in Thy knowledge can equal, nor can any error in Thy Book compare with it in rank, for it springeth from the tree of self, speaking "I" in Thy presence. Alas, alas! I am the one who was content before Thy face to speak of myself saying "I," who bore to utter before the presence of Thy court the word "I," who was neglectful in my duty toward Thee by mentioning "I," who disobeyed Thy presence by mentioning that selfhood which Thou hadst forbidden any to approach before the glory of Thy Lordship, and who said "I" and felt no shame before Thy face to cease saying thereafter in Thy presence that I am I.

Alas, alas! Were I to weep throughout eternity over what my soul hath borne, my heart would not be relieved, nor my inner being quieted, nor my outer being find rest. Yet when I witness how Thou dealest with the sinners among Thy servants, I am assured that Thou wilt not withhold from me the majesty of Thy mercy, nor wilt Thou be wroth with me through the sovereignty of Thy grace and might. For though I disobeyed Thee, I meant not to disobey, nor did I deny the signs of Thy mercy. Rather, my passions overcame me when they found love in Thy bounties, and destiny aided me in this when I desired to manifest Thy self-sufficiency through the free will of Thy servants.

O my Lord! Destiny hath aided me in this, for Thou didst desire to manifest Thy bounty through the choice of Thy servants. Were it otherwise, my desires would not prevail over the love of Thy Will, for it standeth sovereign over every soul according to its deserts, and nothing in the heavens or earth can overpower it. Thou knowest, O my God, both my secret and manifest thoughts. In all things I have desired naught but Thy love and good-pleasure, and wished only what Thou wishest. If Thy knowledge of me showeth otherwise, then by the greatness of Thy Being and the sanctity of Thy glory, it was not to deny Thy Lordship, nor to reject Thy Unity, nor to be heedless of Thy power, nor to rely on aught save Thy mercy. Rather, since Thou didst create within my soul the means of power, and it desired what it was inclined toward, it exceeded its bounds through what Thou bestowed of Thy generosity. Though this may be pure disobedience in Thy Book, it arose only from its love of itself, without knowing Thy love in aught else, or waiting for the days wherein Thou wouldst send down what Thou hadst promised it.

Glorified and exalted art Thou, O my God, that I should say Thou art Thou, or that I could bear separation from the court of Thy nearness, or remain silent and offer no excuse before the presence of Thy countenance. As I find no remembrance with Thee save the remembrance of Muhammad and His family—Thy blessings be upon them—I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy remembrance of them in every condition, to bless Muhammad and the family of Muhammad, the repositories of Thy knowledge, the treasuries of Thy bounty, the seats of Thy Lordship, and the pillars of Thy unity—the Imams of religion and guides of the people of certitude. These are the servants whose will Thou hast made identical with Thy Will in creation, whose desire is one with Thy Desire in origination, whose decree is Thy Decree in bringing forth, and whose judgment is Thy Decision in invention. All that is attributed to them is the supreme attribution through its relation to Thee alone, Who hath no partner.

I beseech Thee by their right that Thou make us among those who are certain of their virtue, patient under their decree, mindful in their remembrance, yearning for their countenance, awaiting the days of their return, holding fast to their cord, seeking forgiveness through them, taking refuge in their presence, established in their love, relying upon them, seeking their intercession, content with their judgment, and

obedient to their commands. O Thou Who art the Lord of bounty and beneficence, of proof and exposition!

Thou knowest that I desire to know naught but Thy love. Therefore, send down unto me the means that will bring me to the station of nearness to Thy names and attributes. I declare: God is sufficient for me, then Muhammad the Messenger of God is sufficient for me, then the Family of God and the Imams of justice are sufficient for me, then those who believe in their truth are sufficient for me—and Thou art behind them all—then the Qur'an is sufficient for me. Upon Thee do I rely, and upon Thee let the believers rely.

O God! Forgive the one who taught me this prayer, and who seeth naught else, then myself, then those who love to be mentioned before Thee. Verily, Thou art the Mighty, the Merciful. Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. Peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

In His Name, the Most High, the Most Great! All praise and glory befit the Eternal One, Whose Holy Presence is sanctified above the description of all else, and all magnificence and splendor befit the Manifestations of Justice, through Whom are known in every age the highest essences of abstract realities with certainty. Glory and splendor are due to the Manifestations of justice Who recognize, in all times, the highest spiritual essences among abstract realities through absolute detachment from the realm of their own knowledge.

When I beheld the trace of your pen in your letter, I was moved by the radiance of your countenance reflected in your words. Indeed, God is too exalted and sublime for me to enumerate His Book through the obedience of a servant in His path while the means have not flowed for him as befits the throne of glory and attributes. I beseech God, my Lord and your Lord, to remove sorrow from your heart and to unite me with the people of His obedience in a land of security and holiness. Verily, He is the Powerful, the Forbearing.

Praise be to God that I have read your letter, which speaks from your countenance as though the Holy Spirit were breathing its spirit therein. Exalted is the station of my Lord, the Possessor of Glory and Honor, above being known through the love of any of His servants while the means have not flowed for him in what is better for him than aught else. I beseech God on your behalf for that which He loves and with which He is well-pleased. Verily, He is the Mighty, the Wise.

BB00073: Letter to Mulla Muhammad Ja'far Kirmani

Date: 1262 (mid to late) [1845-1846]

Part 1: "Praise be unto God Who caused the letter…"

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be unto God Who caused the letter Kaf to speak of Him, through Him, unto Him, before His Book was fulfilled by His leave. Then He established it in the station of Command as accepted by His Own Self, that thereby the signs of the divine realms might be distinguished from the vengeance of the mortal world, and that through it might be proclaimed the signs of the Fourth Citadel in the thicket of the Realm of Might, and the goodly leaf from the Third Tree in the grove of sovereignty and dominion. Glory be unto Him! How great is His power and how noble His proof! He hath sent down a Criterion and made it a distinction between His friends and His enemies, wherein are the signs of Manifestation and the evidences of the Tree of Sinai, that it might be a healing for hearts and an appearance of the hidden Light, and a fulfillment of what the All-Forgiving promised concerning those who fabricated lies and came with falsehood and calumny, that all might know that the Hidden Manifest One is the Zealous Lord.

And He hath sent down all that creation desired in a recorded Book and an outstretched parchment, and verily it is the Frequented House in the horizon of Manifestation, and through such as this doth God expose the deed of the weary lie.

God's blessings be upon Muhammad and his family, the root of the Tree of Light and all Manifestation, by that which causeth the surging ocean to glorify Him by leave of God, the Most High, the All-Forgiving.

O God! I bear witness before Thee and all who are in Thy presence that I believe in Thee as Thou art in Thyself. I love naught save for Thy love's sake, I hate naught save through Thy hatred, I fear none save Thy justice, I desire naught save Thyself, and I see naught but as Thou seest in the presence of the mirror of Thy might which Thou hast caused to be reflected in my soul. Thou knowest that a letter hath come unto me from one about whom Thou knowest more than I, and this is a copy of his letter which he wrote with knowledge and a preserved scripture:

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Peace be upon thee, O Gate of God, through whom the people are guided—whoso cometh unto him is saved and whoso turneth away from him perisheth. Here am I come unto thee, O my Master and my Lord, acknowledging my limitations and confessing my shortcomings, yet taking refuge with thee, relying upon thee, seeking support through thee, hoping from thee, beseeching from thy presence that thou wouldst intercede for me with God that He might make me among those who recognize thy rights and who attain unto thy bounties, and that He might endear to me every deed, word, or act that draweth me near to thee, and might protect me from every deed, word, or act from which I fear an evil consequence and fear thy displeasure concerning it, lest Thou turn Thy noble face away from me and I thereby deserve a diminution of my portion with Thee, O Kind One, O Merciful One!

O my Master, O my Lord! I beseech Thee not to deprive me of one glance from Thy glances, and not to turn me away from Thy gate, for even if I deserve none of this, yet Thou art of the people of generosity, bounty, and forgiveness. O my Master! I beseech Thee by Thy right and Thy holiness to make my times, night and day, filled with Thy remembrance, connected to Thy service, and my deeds accepted before Thee, until all my deeds and devotions become one single devotion and my service to Thee eternal.

O thou precise questioner! Verily a light hath broken forth from the direction of the East, as though it were the light of the steed of light which derived its radiance from the light of the Eternal Morn that

gleamed upon the temples of all, among them are the people of concord, who, when they inquire into the letter standing between the two B's and contemplate deeply, witness the Day whereon God shall reveal that 'the leg shall be bared' on the Day of Meeting. And when they awaken to the light of the Bayan, they say:

> "Glory be to Thee! There is no God but Thee, and we are but a people who turn unto Thee."

And among them are the people of the Covenant, who, when they become established at the point beneath the letter B and immerse themselves in what God hath placed within that letter of the light of Glory, witness the Day when the Herald shall call forth from the chains of bondage, and they say:

> "Glory be to Thee! There is no God but Thee, and we are but a people who fall prostrate before Thee."

And among them are the people of discord, who, when they hear a verse, turn away as though they forget the Day when the leg shall be bared by the leg, and they are veiled from the light that hath filled all souls and horizons. They fear not the Covenant's bond, nor do they look to the letters of utterance, nor perceive the deeds of the people of concord. I seek refuge with God from the evil that hath rent asunder discord and hypocrisy, by the Lord of Daybreak, from all He hath created and revealed concerning the transgressors.

I beseech God of His bounty to transform the realities of the people of discord into the deeds of the people of the Covenant, by Muhammad and His family, the lights of the Eternal Sun that hath illumined the cloud and all who dwell in the kingdoms of earth and heaven, of souls and horizons.

O thou who dost gaze upon the subtle splendors, who dost ascend unto the ladder of inner realities, and who dost cast from thy hands the veils of light and the claims of understanding! Attain unto a certitude luminous and unclouded—nay, as though thou wert standing within the very eye of certainty—like unto this rising sun. If thou be of the companions of Kazim—may the blessings of God rest upon him—I beseech thee, O my lord, to have mercy upon me, lest I be numbered among those who, in thy presence, have presumed, and thereby exposed themselves to thy wrath. Verily I cherish hope in thy bounties—thou who didst dispatch the pages and other gifts—and, through thy grace, suffer not my hope to be cut off, O my desire and my refuge. Deal with me as befitteth Thee, and not as befitteth me….

If thou seekest the outward path concerning the Bearer of this radiant Pillar, it hath been established by the consensus of this community that none can be its Bearer save from the lineage of God's Messenger, as Kazim and Ahmad before him explicitly stated. He must be free from physical defects that would repel hearts, possessed of strength, modesty, dignity and reverence, endowed with beautiful names and sublime attributes, showing signs of knowledge and piety, and manifesting tokens of supreme justice—all of which the people of discernment recognize through the light of their hearts.

When God knew that Satan would whisper in the hearts of His friends to rise against His trustees, God granted me what He had given to no one before: The Book of Justice, wherein are detailed verses of decisive proof such that should all humans and jinn gather to produce the like of a single verse thereof, they would be unable, even if they all assisted one another. And from it are the scrolls of intimate prayers

that have, by God's leave, filled the East and the West of the earth in a manner none before me hath spoken. As the Balance is established, there flow from my hands a thousand verses every six hours when rendered in proper Arabic—a proof none in the heavens or earth can match.

As the compiler of the certain truths hath declared that all scholars have agreed that the Sahifah Sajjadiyyah is the Psalms of the House of Muhammad and sufficient as proof for those who see not their miracles, this indeed is the certain truth. For none save the Family of God have brought forth such supreme proof. The nobility therein lies not in the arrangement of words or allusions, but in the celestial spirit God created therein, which warbles in every state and soars in the thickets of divinity without qualification or indication. My intimate prayers to God suffice as proof in this world and the next.

As for the scholarly matters and sermon-verses that none, not even Ahmad and Kazim (God's blessings upon them both), could surpass—behold what We have revealed in the commentary on Surah al-Kawthar, for verily a single letter thereof equals not all the books of former times, nor what We revealed in the commentary on al-Baqarah for the weak among the believers. Therein, by the verses of the Qur'an and the reports of the People of God, I have established mention of this Cause wheresoever thou dost will, in the heavens and on the earth; and verily it is exalted, full of wisdom.

And thou hast heard that he wrote, for the "calf-body"—that lowing thing—some few letters. By thy Lord! I asked of him two proofs—nay, a single hadith—and he brought it not. Thereafter he bore the wrath of God, laden with the anger of God; and for him is a painful chastisement. Behold the champions of that band and their wolves who turned not unto any of the perfect ones. How they believed and testified and proclaimed and stood firm upon the path like an encompassing mountain—neither storms could move them nor signs of tempests affect them. They are the bearers of religion and the guardians of knowledge. Were it not for them, God would not have revealed a single verse of the Book, nor would a letter flow from My pen. May God grant Me their meeting in a seat of truth before a mighty King. From Him are the conditions of piety, the attributes of holiness, the manifestations of divinity, and the traces of servitude which none can comprehend save as fire in the essence of water, or as air in the presence of the element of earth. Glorified be God, their Creator, the Lord of the heavens and earth, above what they describe.

Part 2: "O thou who art endowed with insight! Purify…"

O thou who art endowed with insight! Purify thy vision and refine thy sight. Verily God hath manifested the Cause from a station that hath never occurred to any heart, and He was unlettered in respect to those verses, prayers, addresses and allusions, for He saw no teacher for Himself except what the All-Merciful promised in the Surah of the All-Merciful: "The All-Merciful hath taught the Qur'an, created man, taught him clear expression." And that is the word of the All-Merciful: "Fear God and He will give you discernment." This honor sufficeth for that band, for He Who appeared by nature, aided by God's grace, was none other than the confirmer of Ahmad, then Kazim, then their followers—may God's blessings be upon them both—as long as the sun of creation hath risen and set in creation.

If thou wouldst purify thy vision, thou wouldst see today all the deniers in the fire, and thou wouldst read unto them the verse of the Almighty: "Verily hell shall encompass the unbelievers." For God hath

completed His proof with a true proof wherein was the Shi'ih sect, and today there is no escape for them except to either deny what they believed before, or believe in what hath been revealed afterward as they believed before, or become stones glorifying without religion. For the Cause is like this sun rising, and the handiwork of the Lord cannot be confused with the handiwork of creation, for He Who came with those verses readeth in all things, when He willeth, what was revealed in the Book of Justice without thought, and writeth without reflection. And whatever people said about Him, the word returneth upon them in the Qur'an, letter for letter. And from the day He manifested His verses, none hath produced a verse, and all denied and were amazed, while some believed and acknowledged their impotence. By thy Lord! There is no escape for anyone except through belief or through denying what they believed before in the All-Merciful.

I take refuge in God! Is He Who revealed the Book of Justice more worthy to be followed, or one who cannot produce a verse? And if he were able, why did he not send to Me the like of My letter to him, and wrote like what the Roman followed, as though he had not read the Book? "Thou canst warn only him who followeth the Reminder and feareth the All-Merciful in secret; so give him glad tidings of forgiveness and a noble reward." Then His word, exalted be His station: ["It beseemeth him not to speak poetry"]. Far, far be it from those who think evil thoughts about God! Upon them be the evil turn of fortune, and God's wrath be upon them, and His curse, and He hath prepared Hell for them—a woeful destination.

This is a manifest matter—were anyone able to produce even a single verse, let him present it to me. The people are as dead, though they perceive it not. Look thou to God and His power, and turn away from all people. God knoweth this matter without doubt, and were He to know that I speak without His leave, He would create someone to stand against me and recite verses like mine to invalidate my proof. Nay, by thy Lord! God hath not created any learned one who doth not love these verses and proclaim His Cause, though the idolaters detest it.

Think not this is an easy matter. Nay, by thy Lord! God hath used similar proofs in the Qur'an. This is a matter that would render powerless all who are in the heavens and on earth, save whom God willeth.

That group hath emerged from the abasement of mere words, for now the proof is in their hands through union, unlike the time of Ahmad and Kazim, God's mercy be upon them both. Though the corrupt ones seek to abase them today, they stand upon truth. Even if all should oppress them, they shall never be truly abased, for might belongeth unto God and unto all the believers.

Whenever I raise my voice in the realm of heaven with words of praise, is there any challenger who would challenge me with clear verses like those whereby God formerly established the religion of His Messenger, peace be upon him and his family? None hath answered me, until my breast was straitened and my cries multiplied, as though every particle of dust I walked upon was proclaiming similar words, as if they were beings illumined by God's light.

And if anyone were in the field of utterance to challenge Me, let him arise with Me and bring down a book of justice with all his might. But since I have heard from no one, I am certain that all are powerless, confounded, and in denial. They can neither respond nor make excuses, nor do they find a way.

Glory be to God! The Islamic clergy have fallen into such depths of ignorance as were not reached by Pharaoh of old nor by the pagan Arabs. For when Pharaoh sought to deny the proof of the Lord, he at least produced some sorcery, and the pagan Arabs would compose poems and display them around the House. But behold the condition of the clergy and the extent of their knowledge! Having failed in every way, they resort to slander, saying these verses do not follow the rules of the people and lack proper connection. May God destroy them! They are more astray than cattle.

They said all this about the Qur'an before, and all perished and entered the fire of hell, and today they have no intercessor forever. Say: The abasement of this world is better than the punishment of the next, for one passes away while the other endures.

I have claimed neither authority nor its opposite, neither revelation nor the Qur'an. I have not opposed the Law by a single letter, nor have I broken any of it. Rather, these verses are a blessing from my Lord. I have spoken to people what God has permitted in the Qur'an, that God's religion might triumph over those Arabs who denied the Imams of Justice. Woe to those who know not God's purpose and spread corruption in the land without right, saying "We are but reformers!" Nay, they are the corrupters, but they perceive not.

By your Lord, most people know not the reality of this Cause, else they would have no escape but to acknowledge it, for they cannot establish any criterion except by that Balance. And by that Balance do I act, and I act only according to what has been revealed in the Law. I am upon truth, and none can say why or how, for whoever seeks to argue against this proof must doubt the proof of God's Messenger before, and whoever seeks to produce a verse has sought to war with God and His Messenger and deny the judgment of the Qur'an.

Glory be to God! God is Most Great! What heedlessness has seized the people! God has taken them to a station where they cannot reflect, much less deny, contemplate, slander or harm. O Lord! Judge between all with justice and hasten the days of meeting You, for people have become my enemies through evil thoughts. I am an enemy to all Your enemies and am innocent of them, as if I desired their station.

By Him in whose hand is my soul, if God were to subject all the kingdom of this world to me, it would not equal a single letter of these verses, nor a word glorifying before the Divine Majesty. The highest stations of this world are to me but like the wing of a dead gnat.

Know, O people, the truth of these days, for the sun has never risen upon their like. Aid God's Cause with your souls and wealth, revere it and honor it, and deprive not yourselves of your portion in this worldly life. For, if God wills, I shall assuredly ascend there; while ye shall say:

> "Alas for us, for how we have failed in our duty to God!"

On this day no decree shall avail you; and when ye have died, unto God shall ye be gathered.

O inquirer! If you are among the people of justice, it is incumbent upon you to possess the Book of Justice and the Commentary on Kawthar, both written in the finest calligraphy and craftsmanship. No one is permitted other than excellent workmanship therein, and God knows all that people know. By Him Who

created me! If God were to transform every atom within His knowledge into living beings and place in their hearts the hardness of the murderer of my grandfather Husayn, peace be upon him, and bestow upon them the power of all who are in the heavens and earth, and if they were to gather together with drawn swords to deny my proof and harm me, it would not diminish my certitude in the least. I would see them all in their falsehood as insignificant as the black spot in a mosquito's eye, for truth with its clear proof is in my hand. And if they should prevail through oppression, God would be my Consoler and Helper, and I would still triumph over them, even as it is revealed in the Qur'an:

> "God hath written, 'Verily I will prevail, I and My Apostles.' Verily God is Powerful, Mighty."

Alas! Alas! What was to reach hath reached, what was to be prevented hath been prevented, what was to occur hath occurred, and what was to be cut off hath been cut off. We read His Book in every condition:

> "Nothing shall befall us save what God hath decreed for us. He is our Master, and on God let the believers rely."

God sufficeth me; there is no God but Him. In Him I have placed my trust, and He is the Lord of the mighty throne. And praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds.

BB00644: To Mulla Ahmad Mu'allim Hisari

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praised be God—He Who commandeth no one to attain unto the recognition of the Dawning-Place of His own Essence, nor to make mention of the Presence of His Being, nor to celebrate the beauty of His Selfhood, nor to describe His "I-ness." From everlasting He hath never conjoined His reality with created essences, nor hath He been described by names and attributes; for the Manifestation of His "I am" confesseth the incapacity of material things to utter His praise, and the Presence of His Essence forbiddeth created substances from attaining unto His knowledge. The splendor of His Selfhood hath cut off all contingent beings from certitude, and the exaltation of His Being is sanctified above the sensible attribution of existent things.

Even as He is, He shall not be known by identity, nor described by oneness, nor indicated by self-subsistence, nor characterized by eternity; for the very essence of creation beareth witness to its severance from His description. How then can He, beside Whom in the beginning of beginnings there existed no peer, be said to be "He is He," or "Thou art Thou"? Exalted and glorified is He beyond my power to reckon His praise, beyond my knowledge to comprehend His station; nor can any one affirm His oneness, nor attain unto His Presence. Even as He hath revealed in the Qur'an, in the station of exposition: "Vision perceiveth Him not, but He perceiveth all vision; and He is the Subtle, the All-Aware."

And I invoke blessings upon Muhammad, the Messenger of God, and thereafter upon His Family—His honored servants—who precede Him not in speech and act by His command; through the verses of the Godhead, the signs of the Realm of Might, the evidences of the Kingdom and the Dominion, and the true stations manifested within the materials of the human realm; and through the breaths made luminous in

fragments of ruby, according to that which God hath known and ordained for them. Verily He is the Most High, the All-Thankful.

And I offer greeting unto Ahmad, from the shore of the right-hand Valley, in the blessed Spot, above the Ark of Testimony, on the right of the Fire; and unto Kazim, from the Tree of Sinai upon the dome of time, from the Dawning-Place of Oneness made manifest through the Being of Light; and unto the Hidden Name, the concealed and veiled, the secret and inscribed symbol—the fearful yet awaited, the renowned—who removeth from inner sight the clouds of light, who speaketh among men with the same authority as Sinai, and who judgeth by the leave of God between the faithful zealot and him veiled from light amid those dusky darknesses. O my Lord! Pour upon me patience, for Thou art indeed the Forgiving, the All-Thankful. And peace be upon those who followed Him beneath the sombre shadows of the Garden of Beauty, and within the effulgences of the Germ of the Paradise of Majesty, according to God's will at the beginning and at the end. Verily He is the Most High, the Exalted. We implore forgiveness through His Book, out of bounty; verily He is the Compassionate, the All-Forgiving.

And now—thy letter hath descended in the likeness of a lowly spirit; and by reason of that House, its decree is at this hour uplifted, as though it were a star that waneth not. That which once summoned utterance from the rising-places hath been eclipsed; that which dawned upon the lofty horizons hath withdrawn; and that which lay silent within the essences of beginnings hath spoken—crying aloud, humbled and imploring—calling: Where are the radiant lights upon the heights? Where is he who ascendeth unto the ladder of exaltations? Where is the shining one from the horizon of profit? Where is the one who uplifteth the useful from the depths of holiness and elevation?

O thou trustworthy and lowly seeker! God hath confirmed thee by that which He bestowed upon thee of His grace, and hath raised thee, His servant, unto His presence. Thy letter I read aforetime and answered thee with a prayer, declaring that the unseen belongeth unto God, and that I of myself know nothing in the heavens nor on the earth save as God willeth. Abide, then, within the House, and sorrow not.

Now have I read thy letter anew and discerned what thou didst intend in the path of religion concerning the knowledge of the Kaf. Know thou that the Kaf is the appearance of the effulgences of the Ha in the grades of the oneness of Essence, of attributes, of acts, and of worship. In every state it turneth upon itself and draweth sustenance from itself by itself—not from aught else—after the manner of itself; for God created the Will by itself, from nothing, without cause other than itself. It moveth upon itself with the motion of succession unto itself—not upon its Lord—from the beginning without beginning: first, the causalities of agency in the essences; then the material causalities in being; thereafter the formal causalities in selfhood; and finally the final causalities in identity—according to that which God's knowledge hath encompassed. And with a motion other than succession, for the existence of the many from the infinite unto the finite, in both stations doth the Kaf—which is the rank of the Will—revolve upon itself, receiving in every moment its aid from God, not from aught else: by itself, for itself, from itself. God sustaineth it by itself, for itself, from nothing else—even as He created it on the first day without cause beyond itself, and without any mention equal to it.

If thou wouldst apply the revolution of the Kaf to the totalities of the eightfold chain, thou wouldst be right; and likewise in particulars thou wouldst be truthful—even unto the ink itself—for it, too, turneth

like the Kaf upon itself and speaketh of the Greatest Depth whereunto God revealed Himself. Recognize, then, the truth of that elixir; quicken thereby whatsoever thou desirest; behold that interpretation in the creation of the heavens and the earth; and let thy heart be at rest in the existence of Being, without distinguishing the absent from the present. This allusion sufficeth thee upon the path of exposition by way of union in summary. And shouldst thou love the path of separation in detail, drawn from the splendors of majesty, then consider what We have revealed in the commentary on al-Kawthar; for it is indeed the Water of Life that issueth from the Fountain of Salsabil, drawing the signs unto the court of nearness and beauty—without mention and without proof.

Yet I counsel thee: rejoice not at the confirmation of any from among the people of perfection, nor be grieved at the denial of any from among the people of idle talk. We have known the way of all: whoso willeth, let him believe; and whoso willeth, let him disbelieve. God, thy Lord, is verily the Self-Sufficient, the Most Exalted. And as to what thou hast mentioned of fear of the people—leave them to their plunging; turn not toward them; sorrow not over the deeds of the disputers. Study the verses of the knowledge of Majesty; for today there is no escape for him whom God willeth—and for His loved ones—save to enter that House. Be not heedless of the fruits of the Tree of Justice, nor of the ordinances of the Household; deal kindly in their laws; forget not their command.

Convey from Me greetings unto them; and say to her who did well in her deed: I have known that which thou didst send, in the path of God, of the holy earth and the pure perfume; God willing, when it reacheth Us, We shall send thee of the purified clay whatsoever thou desirest. Fear God and be patient; verily God is the Truth, Possessor of the Glorious Throne. And as for that which thou desirest in the path of God—be patient, and depart not from that House until We command one of the leaders of that company to enter it by God's leave.

It is incumbent upon thee and upon all who follow Me to visit the Imams of Justice—there is from Me a right—then the resting-place of Kazim, peace be upon him, so long as the Sun of creation riseth by creation and the sun of invention setteth by invention. Observe the ordinance of prudent dissimulation; write of that which the people do upon that land in matters of essential geometry and accidental affairs. Greet the community of the Shi'ah; and say unto 'Ali: We sent unto thee a Book before; and unto Ibrahim, in that which was revealed in the first Book; and greet him again in that which hath been revealed secondly from His presence. Greet the people of justice; preserve their names; greet the beneficent one in the Sanctuary of Moses, peace be upon him; then Bashir in the Sanctuary of 'Ali, peace be upon him; and greet those who followed Me. Verily God blesseth you, and the angels of the heavens and the Throne also, saying: Give thanks unto God, and say: Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00477: To Azim

To: Azim

Date: 1262 [1845-1846]

In the Name of the Exalted, the Most Great.

Praise be to God Who sendeth down the Book unto whomsoever He willeth among His servants. Verily, there is no God but Him, the Mighty, the Wise. We have indeed read the books that were sent down unto Us, and We bear witness to what transpireth upon the earth, and God is the All-Knowing, the All-Informed. Say: For whomsoever it hath been sent down this day, permitted unto thee is the food of those who have disbelieved among the People of the Book. If thou art able to set aright what people corrupt—yet say: Fear ye God lest tribulation arise through what thou hast intended, for We this day were among the fearful. And indeed the Book which he sent down hath been revealed, and if God had willed He would have made firm his heart upon a straight path. We have read the book of Joseph and then his brother.

Say: Work ye in the religion of God, for this is the path of God in the heavens and on earth, calling the people unto the decree of a manifest balance. Verily I desired not to call thee, but for all things there is an appointed time. I have sought forgiveness for him who desired in the Book, and at night I desired to attend their house, but God ordained not a known decree. Therefore intercede for whomsoever desireth the religion of God and fear not, for verily We shall overtake them. We have read the book of the land of Sad.

Say: Attend thou the throne of the remembrance of thy Lord's name, for God preserveth what He willeth by His command, and He is verily the Strong, the Mighty. Write thou unto whomsoever desireth the decree, and follow the remembrance of him who followeth God's command and performed pilgrimage to the Sacred House. When thou hearest the decree of justice, verily the decree of the oppressors this day shall diminish. Greet the servants who follow God's command and say: Be ye patient, for soon shall I sit before you if ye fear God, and say: Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds. And verily on the night of the middle hath been sent down the book of the letters of the countenance.

Say: God forgiveth the believing men and believing women among thy kindred, and verily there is no God but Him, the Lord of mighty grace.

BB00585: To Azim

To: Azim

Date: 1262 [1845-1846]

In the Name of the Most High, the Most Great

Praise be to God Who bestows His favor upon whomsoever He willeth through His command. Say: The end belongs to the God-fearing.

We have indeed read the letter which thou didst send down by God's leave, and We have learned of the mention of the name of Abraham and then of him who sent down the oil. Say: God will recompense the doers of good.

And verily what was said regarding Moses in the Qur'an is the truth, and in like manner God, thy Lord, doth teach His servants who are possessed of certitude.

Say to those who desire to strike thee for love of the mention of God's name: Strike ye him who hath come between the people, and be patient, for unto everything there is an appointed time.

Send some copies to that land and say to those who follow Me: Fear ye God and be patient and say: Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00548: To Azim

To: Azim ?

Date: 1262 [1845-1846]

He is the Mighty

Praise be to God Who aideth with His victory whomsoever He willeth among His servants. Rejoice and be patient, for the end belongeth to the God-fearing.

We have now sent down unto you this letter. Conceal the Cause of God and follow His decree that ye may prosper. Fear God and mention not your own conjectures regarding the religion of God, and be of the people who possess knowledge.

We have commanded in this letter that Taqi and then Ali should present themselves before the one possessed of manifest wisdom when He summoneth you according to God's decree. Be ye among those who preserve the Cause.

And We have commanded the one who readeth this letter unto you both with commandments in the religion of God. When He commandeth you with a command, know that He speaketh naught except by My command. Preserve the Cause of God and make peace with Him. Be not heedless of dissension and wait, for We are waiting.

Say: Fear God, O concourse, and doubt not in the Cause of God after ye have believed in it. O Ali, thou trusted one, extend greetings to those servants who follow Me and say: Give thanks unto God for having guided you and say: All praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00121: Prayer for Haji Isma'il

Date: 1262 [1845-1846]

In the Name of God, the All-Merciful, the Compassionate.

Praise be to God Who created me by His behest, then nourished me through His bounty, then gave me to eat after I hungered. There is no God but He, the Almighty, the All-Wise.

O my God! How shall I call upon Thee, when the utmost end of my supplication returns unto my own soul, plaintive over the vile deeds I have wrought? And how shall I not call upon Thee, when my heart

hath been ever enraptured with Thy love, unable to endure Thy separation, to be silent from communion with Thee, or to remain far from the seats of Thy nearness?

O my God! Thou art the Beloved, there is none besides Thee, and Thou art the Intended One, there is none other than Thee. I have known Thee through Thee and called upon Thee through Thy love for me. Were it not for Thee, I would be nothing, neither could I remember Thee, nor drink from the pure wine of Thy love, nor dwell in the precincts of Thy bounty, nor be established upon the throne of Thy sovereignty, nor mention Thy favors before Thy favored servants.

All good is from Thee and in Thy grasp. From the first day Thou didst honor me with every favor, with the sweetness of Thy remembrance and the beauty of Thy beneficence. Thou art God, there is none other God save Thee. Thy handiwork hath ever been perfect, Thy generosity forever all-embracing. If I say, "I praise Thee," in that same moment it is Thy remembrance that enables me to praise Thee, and Thy mercy that encompasses me, and Thy bounties that surround me; for hadst Thou not remembered me, I had not remembered Thee; and hadst Thou not shown me gratitude, I had not shown Thee thanks; and hadst Thou not unveiled Thyself to me according to Thy Will, the core of my heart had not found rest in the presence of Thy Self-Sufficiency. Thy justice hath, from everlasting, encompassed me; Thy trials abide within my inmost being; the chastisement of Thy equity hath, before now and at every moment, stood before mine eyes.

Alas! Alas! Shouldst Thou will my punishment, or desire my chastisement, or resolve to call me to account, or determine to seize me—glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou!—then, when I behold Thy dealings with Thy sincere and unified servants, my heart is set at rest, my breast is emptied of disquiet, my secret is stilled, and my soul entreateth Thee:

> "O my God, admit me to Thy neighborhood among the near ones; cheer me with the meeting with Thee among the triumphant; give me to drink the water of Thy mercy from the goblet of Thy care among the pure in heart; and honor me with Thy favors among the faithful."

Verily, Thou art God, my Lord and the Lord of all the worlds.

But when I behold Thy vengeance upon the idolaters, the pillars of my heart are shaken; the very flesh within my breast is confounded; my skin shuddereth; my eyes and bowels weep; and my inmost being crieth out: "How could I enter the fire? And if I were to endure therein, how could I endure to be parted from the meeting with my Lord?" Nay, by His might! I have no endurance, nor can I bear it. And if Thou dost cast me therein, I shall cry out among its folk such cries as shall cause them all to gasp; I shall burn therein in such wise that the people of torment shall be struck down; and I shall cry: "O my Lord, my Master, my God!

Thou art independent of my punishment; I am poor for Thy good-pleasure and Thy forgiveness. If Thou forgivest me and deliverest me from the fire, naught of Thy dominion is diminished; and if Thou feedest me with the fruits of Thy Paradise, naught in the heavens and the earth addeth aught to Thee." I am he who is afflicted by his sin, O my God; I am he who confesseth his trespasses, O my Master; I am the negligent, the derelict, who felt no shame before Thee in solitude, nor watched for Thee in the assembly.

I am he who disobeyed Thee after Thou hadst made me to know Thy vengeance; who sinned in Thy presence, though aware that Thou seest me and beholdest my station. I am he who waxed heedless of the stations of them who draw nigh, though not even for a fleeting moment didst Thou withhold from me Thy promptings, Thy attracting breath, Thy sweet savors, and the tokens of Thy intimacy.

With what tongue, then, shall I confess my sin? With what eye shall I read my offences inscribed in the scrolls of the angels, before Thy face? With what pen shall I record my deeds? With what heart shall I survey my trespasses while life yet remaineth in me? Hallowed be Thy Name, hallowed be Thy Name!

Thou knowest, O my God, my condition; Thou lookest upon my misdeeds; Thou countest my works. I am he who banished his own self from Thy neighborhood; I am he who debarred himself from the meeting with Thee; I am he who, through ignorance, turned away from Thy promises. I bartered the life of the hereafter for this first life that perisheth; I busied myself with its trappings and adornments after I had read in Thy Book the bounties of Thy Paradise and heard from Thy near ones that "they who purchase the life of this world with the hereafter—their chastisement shall not be lightened, nor shall they be helped."

Alas! Alas! I am he who offended the Lord of heaven and earth; I am he who transgressed against the King of Paradise and the Throne; I am he who denied the signs of the All-Compelling, Lord of the kingdom of the heavens and the earth. I am he who repented unto my Lord, then sinned again; who sought Thy forgiveness, then relapsed; who lamented his crimes, then returned unto them. I yearned for Thy unity, yet by that very yearning I recalled my own self in the presence of Thy wrath; I desired to worship Thee, and thereby I set my soul before Thy might; I sought to remember Thee, and my remembrance proved but a remembrance of myself, veiling me from Thy Countenance; I would exalt Thy holiness, and thus I likened Thee to an attribute of Thy creatures; I would proclaim Thy transcendence, and thus I described Thee with what ill befitteth Thy sanctity in the realm of Thy might.

I would glorify Thee, yet by my glorification I ascribed a partner to Thee—after Thou hadst taught me that none describeth Thee but Thyself, none knoweth Thee save Thee, none can conjoin with Thy Essence, none comprehend the core of Thy Being; that Thou canst not be worshipped by a selfhood like mine, nor pointed to by an identity such as mine; that naught can match the majesty of Thy Will, nor any thing depart from the beauty of Thy Self-Sufficiency.

Glorified art Thou! I would intend Thy praise, yet by so doing I rehearsed for Thee the qualities of Thy creation, after Thou hadst taught me that Thou hast eternally been without the mention of aught, and wilt forever be without the description of aught; that Thou hast, from everlasting, been such that naught ascendeth unto Thee; and wilt, unto everlasting, remain such that naught is lifted up unto Thee; that the ultimate goal of such as seek Thee leadeth back to the station of Thy origination; that the end of the journey of the unitarians halteth before the beauty of Thy splendor; that the highest essences of being, in the days of their ascent, are returned unto the court of Thy invention; and that the loftiest summits of possibles revolve, like unto the letter Kaf about itself, when they intend Thy gate, and descend into the abyss of the ocean of Thy signs.

Glorified art Thou! I would assert Thy oneness, yet by that claim I regarded my own self in the presence of the majesty of Thy singleness—after Thou hadst inspired me that unity cannot be established by the

twofold realm of mention; that the word of justice cannot be contained within the two names; that the mystery of meeting cannot be mirrored in two mirrors; that Thou art too exalted to be known by Thy creation, or described by Thy servants, or indicated by Thy signs, or affirmed in Thine indivisible unity by aught that is of Thy Names. Thou art He Who, in the pre-eternal eternity, is unknowable; in the flux of time, indescribable; unto Whom no sign may be lifted; upon Whom no token may bear testimony; Whose essential mirror no thing can confront; from Whose essential justice no thing can depart—inasmuch as Thou hast manifested Thyself unto them in the realm of indication, descended upon them from the heaven of signs, looked upon them in the kingdom of the Cloud, of the Names and the Attributes, with a gaze no one among the denizens of endless realms and hallowed veils can compass.

Glorified art Thou! I would magnify Thy Self, yet thereby I made small Thy greatness, reducing it to a thing my feeble soul can behold—weak is the seeker and the Sought! Woe is me for that which I have accounted of Thy majesty: my soul is lowly, my vision paltry. How, then, can I extol the grandeur of Thy glory with the weakness of my soul and the littleness of my deeds? Thou alone canst know the greatness of Thine own Self; for all besides Thee—what is the utmost of their portion save the point of denial? what is the farthest reach of their favor save the point of severance?—are, and all they conceive of magnifying Thy majesty is, small before Thy glory and naught before Thy beauty.

I know not, O my God, how it is that I stand a stranger before Thee, addressing Thee with such words that, were any other to comprehend them, he would say of me what ʼAli, son of al-Husayn—Thy Proof, son of Thy Proof—said regarding one in his day; or, should I attain the court of Thy nearness and drink of the cup of Thy sweetness, I find myself unable to ascribe aught to Thee: if I would glorify Thee, the bounds of my being rebuke me; if I would sanctify Thee, the limits of my station strike fear into me; if I would affirm Thy unity, my estate chastiseth me; if I would magnify the majesty of Thy Being, those in heaven and earth make me small until I am as though I were not, as a mote, and they upbraid me, saying: “With this littleness thou magnifiest thy Lord and feelest no shame before His court!”

Alas, alas! The right was with them, the sin with me. How shall I say, “I am he who sinned, and Thou art He Who forgave”? How shall I say, “I erred, and Thou didst conceal”? How shall I say, “I forgot Thy remembrance,” when Thou hast ever remembered Thy fearful servants? How shall I say, “I grew distant,” when Thou art nearer unto me than all things? Nay, by Thy might! I will not say “I,” nor blush at the avowal thereof; rather will I say: Thou art my God and my Beloved; Thou art my Master and my Desire; Thou art my Lord and my Summoner; Thou art my Chief and the end of all my hopes; Thou art my Possessor and the goal of my longing.

If I say, “From everlasting Thou hast ever been—Thou, Thou,” the sweetness of Thy remembrance will not affright my heart; nay, at every recurrence I taste a second rapture of love that no memory can compare with that first remembrance. Blessed then am I, and yet again how blessed, how peerlessly blessed, by Thy grace and the sweetness of my communion with Thee!

I praise Thee for that Thou hast silenced me in the Abode of Eternity within Thy neighborhood, and given me to drink of the wine of nearness from Thy two hands, O Beloved of those who know, O Companion of the desolate, O Goal of the seekers! If Thou hast made me oppressed in the hands of the transgressors, yet, from Thy bounty, Thou hast inspired me with such supplications as wherein I find repose in Thy

neighborhood and patience in my meeting with Thee. By Thy might! A single letter thereof, with me, is more glorious than were all who are in heaven and on earth subjected unto me, and I then made a witness over all that are on earth, and Thou didst exact vengeance upon my enemies altogether, to the delight of mine eyes—for these invocations shall remain in the Tablets of them who draw nigh; and they—if God will—shall recall me after my passing by chanting them before Thee; and Thou, after my death, shalt glory in these prayers amidst Thy righteous servants, and shall send down upon me, at every instant, the recompense befitting Thy generosity and grace.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Thine be praise, in the kingdom of Command and Creation—praise that transcendeth the praise of all beings and is exalted above the praise of all besides Thee: a praise gleaming, radiant, resplendent, hallowed, scintillating, ringing forth—everlasting, eternal, perpetual—as Thou lovest and art well-pleased; as Thou art, in Thine exaltation, Thy oneness, Thy majesty, and Thy might—beyond the reach of all comprehension.

BB00547: To Ibn'i-Va'iz

To: Ibn'i-Va'iz

Date: 1262 ? [1845-1846]

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate.

Praise be to God Who doeth whatsoever He willeth through His command. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

O my God! Thou art God Who hath testified concerning Thyself before all things that Thou art God, there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thou hast ever been the Knower of all things before their existence, and powerful over all things after their manifestation. I beseech Thee, O God, by the right of Muhammad and his family, to bestow upon this soul who beareth these words that which befitteth Thy majesty, glory, grandeur and beauty. Verily, Thou art God, the All-Bountiful, the Most Exalted.

O my God! Thou art He Who ordaineth not any trial for anyone except that Thou hast ordained for him a reward through Thy grace and bounty. Therefore, pour forth upon him, O Lord, patience and deliver us from every affliction through Thy grace. Verily, Thou art God Who bringeth together Thy servants when Thou willest according to Thy wisdom, and verily Thou art God, the All-Bountiful, the Most Merciful.

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate. O God! Forgive the one who seeketh prayer from Thee and let Thy mercy and care continue to rest upon him. Verily, Thou art God, the All-Bountiful, the Most Generous.

BB00113: To Muhammad Hasan al-Natnazi

To: Muhammad Hasan al-Natnazi

Date: 1262 [1845-1846]

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who caused to shine forth that which illumined the essences of material things and permitted it to radiate when it spoke forth, and Who spread enlightenment without cause or decree from the people of the Covenant.

O God! Thou knowest that one of Thy believing servants hath beseeched me to bestow upon him an eloquent word and all-embracing mercy concerning the visitation of the chosen ones who act according to Thy command.

O thou who wouldst do good! When thou desirest to bestow beneficence upon the servants of the All-Merciful through the Word of exposition, then before thou manifestest what is within thy being to outward view, purify thy outer self such that no excess hair remaineth upon thy face, and thy inner self such that thy heart remaineth unattached to any of thine affairs therein. Then perform ablutions and don the finest raiment with which God hath favored thee in this earthly life, apply perfume and walk upon the earth with tranquility, glorifying the name of thy Lord within thyself until thou approachest the portico.

When thou arriveth there, magnify God, thy Lord, thirty times. Then walk with spirit and grace, mindful of origin and justice, until thou drawest nigh unto the shrine.

When thou standest before His Majesty say “Allah’u’Akbar” forty times within a space of five feet, and stand in silence until your soul returns to you. There the light of your Lord descended upon the cloud, with angels surrounding Him, and the matter was decreed, and the promise was fulfilled. Say: In the name of God, and by God, and unto God, and in the path of God. O God! Thou art Peace, and from Thee cometh peace, and unto Thee returneth peace, and Thou art the Mine of peace, and the Lord of peace in the hereafter and in this world.

O my God! Here am I, standing at Thy gate, seeking refuge at Thy threshold, and uttering Thy praise through Thy names by which Thou hast revealed Thyself to me and described Thy Self. There is no God but Thee. Glorified art Thou, O my God! I am unable to praise Thee, for if my praise were to match Thy glory, it could not proceed from me nor befit my station, and if it were according to my capacity, it would be unworthy of Thy gate and could not ascend to Thy presence.

Glorified, glorified art Thou! Here am I, uttering Thy praise as Thou art in Thyself, though I can neither comprehend nor know, nor can any of Thy creatures encompass it with their knowledge. I know that Thou desirest nothing less from creation, nor accepteth less from anyone, for this is the primary station of my existence which Thou created from nothing by Thy power. And now it returns to the station of nothingness, as though it had never been mentioned.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! How sweet is Thy praise, how resplendent Thy glory, how exalted Thy station, and how hidden are Thy favors! I bear witness that there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Nothing is like unto Thee, and nothing in the heavens or earth equals Thee, and Thou art God, the Lord of the worlds.

O my God! As I know I have no share in praising Muhammad and His successors—Thy blessings be upon them—before Thee, lest I be silent in describing them, O God, praise Thou Muhammad and the family of Muhammad, the places of Thy knowledge, the pillars of Thy unity, the mines of Thy sanctification, and the manifestations of Thy glorification, with the might, divinity, grandeur, and power that belongeth to Thee, which none but Thee can comprehend. Verily, Thou art the Lord of the worlds.

Peace be upon you, O Family of La, this Book containeth remembrance and justice for the devout! Peace be upon you, O leaves of the Divine Tree, fruits of the holy and glorious trees, fruits of the Tree of Sinai and of the Kingdom, gardens of the Tree of Justice, and pearls of bounty in the thicket of the human realm, and the mercy of God and His blessings! Peace be upon you, O ye whom God hath chosen for His religion, accepted for His wisdom, elected for His Cause, and made successors to the best of His creation, and the mercy of God and His blessings! Peace be upon you, O ye whom God hath selected for the knowledge of the Qur'an, taught the inner meanings of the Furqan, chosen for the mystery of the people of the Bayan, and protected from the steps of Satan, and the mercy of God and His blessings!

Peace be upon you, O ye whom God hath created to preserve His revelation, manifest His Word, exalt His glory and His hidden grace, and the mercy of God and His blessings! Peace be upon you, O ye whose words God hath joined with obedience to His loved ones, whose knowledge with the knowledge of His trusted ones, whose love with the love of His chosen ones, and whose friendship with the friendship of the best of His servants, and the mercy of God and His blessings! Peace be upon you, O pillars of religion, support of the believers, stronghold of the God-fearing, and refuge of those who fear, and the mercy of God and His blessings! Peace be upon you, O tidings of the ancients, example to those who come after, and the Word of those who follow, and excellence of those who preceded, and the mercy of God and His blessings!

Peace be upon you, O pillars of the cornerstone of unity, branches of the Tree of oneness, virgin gardens of the Tree of detachment, and verses of the letters of the Word of praise before glorification and after declaration of unity and at the time of magnification, and the mercy of God and His blessings!

Peace be upon you, O ye whose utterance is God—whose obedience is obedience unto His chosen ones, whose recognition is the recognition of His trusted stewards, whose love is love for His purified friends, whose affection is affection for the noblest of His servants. And the mercy of God and His blessings be upon you.

Peace be upon you, O stronghold of the Faith, support of the believers, firm handle of the God-fearing, refuge of the fearful; and the mercy of God and His blessings be upon you.

Peace be upon you, O Tidings of the ancients and Pattern of the latter days, O Word that followeth after the words—conjoined and crowned, the excellence of the forerunners; and the mercy of God and His blessings be upon you.

Peace be upon you, O pillars of the Pillar of Oneness, branches of the Tree of Singleness, first fruits of the gardens of the Tree of Detachment, signs of the letters of the Word of Praise—before the glorification, after the declaration of unity, and at the moment of magnification; and the mercy of God and His blessings be upon you.

I call God to witness—His angels, His Prophets, and His chosen ones—that ye are the foremost; that ye are the elect, the elect; that ye are the sincere, the sincere; that ye are the first, the first. Through you hath shone whatsoever hath shone in the Kingdom of the heavens and the earth; through you hath dawned whatsoever hath dawned in the inward lights of the Footstool and the Throne; through you hath appeared whatsoever hath appeared in the orbits of the heavens and the Throne; and through you hath been illumined whatsoever hath been illumined in the depths of the Kingdom of command and creation. How sweet are your names, how manifest your words, how exalted your being, and how hidden your "I-ness."

Unto God belongeth the right for the kindness of your beneficent ones; unto God pertaineth the remembrance of your majesty; unto God is the thanksgiving in your praise; and unto God is the justice for your adversaries. Through you did the Holy Spirit take up abode, in the gardens of al-Saqurah, the orchards of manifestation; through you did the Trustworthy Spirit descend upon Sinai with a Book laid open; through you did the Spirit of Command take its place in Paradise with a Book inscribed; and through you did the Spirit and the angels descend, by God's leave, from the Frequented House.

Thus every just one today dealeth justly among mankind by your judgment; every possessor of grace today speaketh your praise; every ruler today ruleth by your permission; and every doer today acteth for God, out of love for you. Through you was the Word made complete, mercy was sent down, division was reconciled, and the Word was distinguished. How sweet is your remembrance, how exalted your station, how resplendent your glory, and how hidden your days.

May my father and mother be a sacrifice unto you! Through you did the Light speak and then taste, through you was Moses thunderstruck and then recovered, through you did Jonah glorify God in the belly of the whale and then was delivered, through you did Jesus speak in the cradle and then was established. Whosoever desires God finds your Cause, whosoever seeks Him recognizes your truth, whosoever unifies Him bears witness to your justice, and whosoever knows Him learns of your bounty. You are the Way and the Guide to Muhammad and the Family of God. Through you were revealed the hidden traditions, erased the manifest seditions, magnified the signs of the people of wisdom, and perfected the trials for the people of tribulation.

May my father be a sacrifice unto you! You are the Way in the heavens and on earth. Through you does the sky send down its water, the earth bring forth its vegetation, and people relate their tidings that their Lord, the All-Merciful, has inspired it.

May my father be a sacrifice unto you! You are the rising suns, the illuminating moons, the brilliant stars, and the orbiting spheres.

May my father and mother be a sacrifice unto you! Through you do moving things move, written things become written, manifest things become distinguished, and scattered things become gathered. I cannot count the radiance of your praise, nor reach the pinnacle of your attributes, nor can any bird's wing ascend to the atmosphere of your glory, nor can the essence of any allusion rise up to you, so great is your praise and sanctification.

May my father and mother be a sacrifice unto you! I cannot enumerate your praise in the manner that you yourselves know your own station. I bear witness before you that when God desired to manifest Himself to Moses and those with him on the Mount, He revealed a light from your majesty whereupon the mountain was crushed and Moses fell down thunderstruck. And God, through the essence of the mountain which became animate from the manifestation of the light of one of you, created the life of all existing things, placing some in the earth for the life of those therein, some in the water for the life of aquatic creatures, and some in the air—and I witness in this atmosphere the life of humanity and all those on earth and in the air together. How manifest is your light, how exalted your station, how great your worth, and how noble your beneficence! Were it not for you, neither I nor any living soul on earth would exist.

May the blessings of God, His angels, His Prophets, and His chosen ones be upon you according to what God has willed concerning your right, and what Muhammad the Messenger of God has established regarding your right, and what the Family of God has ordained concerning your station. You are purified in your inner and outer being, and I hereby bear witness that I believe in you and in your outer manifestation, and I believe that you have manifested the decree of the Family of Ta-Ha and Ya-Sin, then Ta-Sin-Mim and Alif-Lam-Sad.

By the wise Qur'an! I bear witness that those who have believed in you are more blessed than those who believed in the Imams of Justice, and those who have shown patience during your dispensation are more excellent than those who showed patience in the days of the Imams of Grace.

The deeds of those who act without obedience to you shall profit them not, for God has made obedience to you identical with obedience to the Imams who are guided by His command. He has joined the knowledge of you with knowledge of them, and disobedience to you with disobedience to them. Whosoever opposes you has opposed them, and whosoever wages war against you has waged war against them. Whosoever advances before you or lags behind you has advanced before them or lagged behind them. They have gone astray who harbor thoughts of ignorance concerning you or speak of you in terms other than servitude. He who knows you not has no path to God, and he who submits to your Cause shall find no barrier in God's decree. They have indeed denied the truth who have transgressed against you, or denied your rights, or rejected your grace, or shown enmity to your friends, or befriended your enemies.

I seek refuge in God and His words, then in you, from the deeds of those who have wronged you, betrayed your Cause, obeyed what you forbade, and denied your rights. Through you do I hold fast in exalting your word, the word of mercy for your friends, and the word of vengeance and wrath for your enemies.

Thus do I beseech God for your victory and await your sovereignty, certain of God's promise concerning you. You have ever been those who act according to God's command and will, who hope for God's grace and promise, and who fear God's justice and decree. I am with you, and you are for God, and all shall return to God. Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. Peace be upon the Messengers. And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00320: To Siyyid Buka’ and Haji Muhammad-i-Kharraz

To: Siyyid Buka’ and Haji Muhammad-i-Kharraz

Date: 1262-07-15 [1846-Jul-9]

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

O God! I bear witness before Thee to that whereby Thou bearest witness to Thine Own Essence before the creation of all things, and to that which Thou art in Thine Eternal Identity which none knoweth save Thee. Thou art God, the Single, the Self-Subsisting, the One, the Most Exalted.

O my God! How can I praise Thee and call upon Thee when my knowledge of Thine Essence hath cut me off from praise, and my remembrance before the court of Thy Self-Subsistence causeth me to be forbidden by decree? I have no path, O my God, except through Thy remembrance of me, Thy manifestations unto me, and Thy breathings in my inmost being and my outward self.

I beseech Thee, O God, by the might of eternity and the majesty of everlastingness, to send Thy blessings upon Muhammad and the family of Muhammad with the divine verses, the celestial signs, the heavenly stations, and the earthly proofs, in such wise that none save Thee can encompass their knowledge. Send down upon them in every condition Thy breathings, Thy manifestations, and Thy will through the ultimate reaches of Thy power, the furthest extent of Thy purpose, and the endless expressions of Thy Command, such that none can encompass any portion thereof save through Thy knowledge. Verily Thou art God, the All-Knowing, the Ancient, the Powerful, the Wise, Who brought creation into being from nothing through Thy creative power, and Who sustaineth them at every moment as at the first instant. Thou art He Who made known to them the path of Thy will and the way of Thy love, and revealed unto them in Thy Book all that they need for their journey toward Thy good pleasure, lest any soul go astray except after having recognized Thy truth and become certain of Thy decree, and lest anyone say “Had God made known His power unto me, I would have been among the believers.”

O my God! The paths of supplication leading to Thy holy court descend from above, and the essences of petition rise up toward the heaven of Thy grandeur. Thou knowest that this night is the middle night of this sacred month of Rajab, which Thou hast honored above many other days through the excellence of Thy will over the degrees of Thy adornments, and which Thou hast magnified through the signs of Thy love for those who follow Thy good pleasure.

O God! I beseech Thee by the Great Birth and the Ancient Name and the Noble Origin whom Thou didst create for Thyself, chose for Thy Cause, selected for Thy will, and elected for Thy good pleasure—he who standeth by Thy Command, is absent by Thy leave, is concealed within Thy veil, awaiteth Thy promise, and seeketh forgiveness for Thy loved ones—by all that Thou art in might and majesty and grandeur and beauty. O my God! Grant unto me and unto all Thy servants from the treasuries of Thy mercy that which befitteth the presence of Thy grandeur and the majesty of Thy Self-Subsistence.

O God! Thou knowest that affairs have reached their ordained severity. Show us his concealed countenance in these dark nights, for verily Thou art God, the All-Forgiving, the All-Appreciating. O God! I

cannot reckon the praise due to Thy Proof who standeth by Thy Command, nor the praise due to any of his infallible signs, the completers of religion and guides of all creation. O God! Through Thy bounty, praise them with all Thy breathings, verses, favors and signs, by all that Thou art in unity and might and glory. Forgive us through their right, relieve us through their grace, cause us to die in obedience to them after having recognized them, bring us to life in their return, make us secure in their dominion, steadfast in their rule during their absence, thankful for their bounties, content with their decree, patient under their trials, mindful of their traditions, following their traces, and keeping their secrets—through Thy favor and bounty, O my God and God of my forefathers: Muhammad, Ali, Fatima, Hasan, Husayn, Ali, Muhammad, Ja'far, Musa, Ali, Muhammad, Ali, Hasan and the Proof, the Qa'im—God's blessings be upon them and upon their cherubic followers.

And may Thy unity, the settings of Thy sanctification, the signs of Thy praise, the tokens of Thy glorification, and the proofs of Thy transcendence be through all that Thou art in splendor and praise and cloud and radiance and decree and change and execution. Verily Thou art God, Lord of creation. Nothing in the heavens or earth is too great for Thee. Thou art God, the Most High, the Most Exalted. Glory be to God, Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. Peace be upon the Messengers. And praise be to God, Lord of the worlds.

BB00337: Ziyarat

Date: 1262 ? [1845-1846]

I bear witness that there is no God but God, alone without partner, even as His Essence hath testified unto His Essence that there is no God but Him, the Mighty, the All-Wise. And I bear witness that Muhammad is Thy servant whom Thou didst choose for Thyself, and didst fashion for Thy Cause, and didst select for Thy good pleasure, and didst make him to stand in Thy stead in both initiation and response, for Thine Essence transcendeth all description of substance, and Thy Reality surpasseth all material knowledge. Verily Thou art God, the Mighty, the Bestower.

Peace be upon you, O essence and core of religion, ultimate goal and reality of the Cause, fruit and quintessence of creation, secret and reality of invention, and the mercy of God and His blessings.

O Family of Mercy and Letters of the Word! I cannot reckon your praise nor can I comprehend the description of your power, for all attributes fall short before the court of your nearness and all descriptions are false before the might of your sanctified being. If I say you are unity itself and the signs of abstraction, I have only described my own state and testified to my heart's incapacity, for your reality ever transcends mention of names and attributes, and your being has always surpassed reference to similitudes and essences. Too glorious is the majesty of your reality for me to indicate it through created attributes, too lofty the elevation of your being for me to compare it to existential descriptions.

I beseech God to raise me to the summit of detachment through nearness to your countenance, to grant me perpetual connection to your service, engagement in what draws me closer to you, contentment with what descends from the clouds of your power, certitude in what God has revealed in the Qur'an

concerning your station, acceptance of what the transmitters of your traditions have spoken about you, drawing near to your friends and dissociating from your enemies—those who would deceive God and His chosen ones, and from what God has decreed concerning them.

I call God, His angels, His Prophets and His Messengers to witness that when you will, the Will manifests by God's leave among all wills, when you intend, intention dissolves into its goals, when you determine, things are determined in the kingdom of names and attributes. No decree is established except through your sanction, no erasure occurs except through your alteration. So glory be to God your Creator! None knows your measure for it is God's measure, nor your station for it is God's station. None can encompass your description for it is God's description, nor your attributes for they are God's attributes. Glory be to God your Fashioner! Whoever knows His oneness bows before your countenance, whoever recognizes Him submits at your gate, whoever stands firm upon His holy carpet humbles himself before your command, whoever acknowledges His justice and grace bears witness to your deed.

For those sheltered beneath the dark shadows of Paradise and those reclining upon whitened thrones in the gardens of Paradise, when they reached the depths of majestic justice and drank from the spring of pure water and became detached unto the nearness of beauty's countenance, they bore witness through you to the praise of your power, even as the angels and those possessed of knowledge among God's servants bore witness to Him in the primal scene. Glory be to God! None knows what He has bestowed upon you save Him, none can describe you save Him. Here I stand in this station bearing witness to what God has ordained concerning you of the signs of power and divinity and unity and might and grandeur and sovereignty and glory and dominion, and that which none save Him can encompass in knowledge.

I seek forgiveness of God, my Lord and your Lord, for my shortcomings in knowing you and my soul's remoteness from the nearness of your presence, and for what your knowledge encompasses of my transgressions which none knows save you and none can alter save you. I turn unto God in repentance from my existence and what I have acquired before you, certain that after my confession of incapacity I shall not be questioned about any sin.

Therefore I say: Glory be to God, Lord of the Throne, above what they describe! Peace be upon the Messengers! Praise be to God, Lord of the worlds!

BB00341: Du'a Tawassul

Date: 1262 ? [1845-1846]

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who sends down whatsoever He willeth by His command. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

O my God! How can I praise Thee, knowing that all are cut off from knowing Thee? And how can I not call upon Thee when my heart finds no rest save in Thy remembrance? I testify that Thou art God, the Beloved, Whom nothing can know and none can find a way unto, for Thy Essence is the Camphor-like

Reality which by its very nature severs all substances from expression, and Thy Being is the Simple Reality which by its very nature prevents all material things from knowing Thee.

Glorified art Thou! Having realized there is no way for me to reach Thee, I turn to Thee through Muhammad and the Family of Muhammad, the loci of Thy knowledge, the seats of Thy grace, the signs of Thy oneness, and the manifestations of Thy mercy. O God! By their right in Thy Book and their station in Thy knowledge, I beseech Thee to bless them with all Thy revelations, breezes, manifestations and stations which know no cessation, and to fulfill this need of mine now, now, now! For hope has been cut off from all else besides Thee, and necessity has reached the ultimate degree of impossibility.

Thou art my Lord, my God, my Master, my Protector and my Trust. If Thou dost not have mercy upon me, who will have mercy upon me? And if Thou dost not answer me, who will answer me? O God! I adjure Thee by the countenance of Thy Being and the glory of Thy might to make all that is in Thy knowledge the means of fulfilling this need, and to grant it to me without my experiencing any sorrow in Thy path or fear from Thy enemies. Thou, O my God, art powerful and all-knowing. Nothing can frustrate Thy power; nothing exists except through Thy Will, the design of Thy Purpose, the limits of Thy decree, and the execution of Thy judgment. Thou hast not ordained in the realms of creation anything less than this. Thou encompasseth all things. When Thou willest something, nothing in Thy dominion can prevent it, and in that instant it exists before Thee.

How can I be patient, O my God, when Thou knowest my condition? How can I cry out, O my Master, when Thou hast power over all things? How can I fear Thy justice when I hope in Thy grace? How can I not hope for Thy good-pleasure when I know that Thou hast both beginnings and endings? And how can I not be certain of the fulfillment of my need when I have sought the intercession with Thee of Muhammad and his Family? Far, far be it that such should be my thought of Thee! This was never known of Thy grace and way.

I am certain that whoever relies upon them, Thou art sufficient for him; whoever holds fast to their cord, Thou art his support; whoever takes refuge in their presence, Thou art his shelter; and whoever beseeches through them, Thou art his answerer. Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee! Praise be to Thee—praise radiant, brilliant, sanctified and exalted above the praise of all else—for having taught me the path of Thy love, inspired me to seek the mediation of the loci of Thy Will, to rely upon the dwellings of Thy blessings, and to hold fast to the cord of the seats of Thy grandeur.

O joy unto me, then joy unto me, for I am content with Thee in all Thy doings! Make my state before Thee like one who has no will when Thy Will is manifested, lest I love to hasten what Thou hast delayed or delay what Thou hast hastened. Rather, let my private and public self be like a corpse in the hands of the washer before the vast ocean of Thy decree and destiny.

Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee! How great is Thy beneficence and how magnificent Thy favors! I see no portion for myself except in my inability to offer Thee thanks and my confession of falling short in praising Thee adequately. Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee! I confess before Thee what I deserve, seek Thy forgiveness, turn unto Thee in repentance, and ask of Thy generosity as Thou art worthy, for

Thou art the Lord of righteousness and forgiveness. Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe! Peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds!

BB00385

Date: 1262 [1845-1846]

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

O God! Thou art God, Creator of the heavens and earth. Thou createst whatsoever Thou willest by Thy command and exaltest whomsoever Thou willest by Thy wisdom. There is no God but Thee, my God and the God of all things. Glorified art Thou! Exalted and sanctified is Thy Countenance and Being from having the highest essences of material things ascend unto it, and elevated is the Face of Thy Identity from having the loftiest manifestations of essential realities rise up to it. For Thou hast ever been and wilt ever be. Verily Thou art even as Thou wert in the beginning that hath no beginning. Nothing throughout eternal manifestation shall ever know Thee, and no spirit throughout endless ages shall ever worship Thee.

For the Countenance of Thy Self transcendeth all possible things, and Thy Being surpasseth all existent things. Forever hath there been no description for Thee save the face of Thine Identity in the mystery of Thy Presence, and forever shall there be no attribute for Thee save the face of Thy Being in the presence of Thy Manifestation. If I say “Thou art He,” in that moment the Countenance of the Divine Realm is revealed in the depths of the signs of dominion and kingdom, that Thou art God, Lord of might and power. And if I say “He is Thou,” in that moment the face of Thy revelation speaketh forth in the presence of unity that there is no God but Him, Lord of the Command in the inmost mysteries of the Divine Realm and Creator of creation in the depths of the signs of geometry and the verses of command in the Countenance of Power.

Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou art He Who hath made Thyself known to all things through themselves and Thy command through Thy creation. Thou hast revealed Thyself to all things through the countenance of Thy origination and presence of Thine invention, that those who are perplexed might be confounded by the revelations of the signs of the depths of the ocean of Thy oneness, and those who are radiant might shine forth through the breaths of the signs of the surging sea of Thy mercy. None doubteth the Divine Countenance revealed within himself, nor the Presence of the Eternal that severeth all from description of It.

O my God! Grant me complete detachment unto the court of Thy nearness, and the mystery of attraction through union unto the station of the revelation of Thy presence, and the light of joy unto the station of the light of Thy countenance, and the ultimate invention unto the manifestation of the sanctity of Thy power, that I might be a knower of Thee, standing before the Most Glorious Light, praising Thee, turning away from all else save Thee, occupied with Thy glorification and speaking in thankfulness for Thy favors, such that I might not dwell in any condition save through nearness to Thy presence, intimacy with Thy

countenance, the beauty of Thine essence, the majesty of Thine identity, the splendor of Thine eternity, the praise of Thy power, the station of Thy Self and the sovereignty of Thy Being.

May I not witness in the countenance of essential realities aught save the revelation of Thy presence of origination, nor in the depths of material things aught save the manifestation of the countenance of Thine invention. May I not see all multiplicities in every condition save as in that Day wherein nothing mentioned existed. Thou, O my God, hast made known to all Thy oneness and established all in the path of Thy Lordship, and chosen for them the signs of Thy might and stations of Thy sovereignty, that the existence of multiplicities might not distract them from Thy countenance, nor the mention of non-existent things from Thy presence.

Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou, O my God! How sweet in my heart is Thy remembrance, and I have no portion save through the manifestation of Thy attraction unto the court of Thy grandeur.

BB00473

Date: 1262 [1845-1846]

In the Name of the Most High, the Most Great

Glorified be He Who hath sent down the verses in truth in a perspicuous Book. He it is Who vindicateth the truth through His verses, though the idolaters be averse. We have indeed favored thee with what thou hast mentioned in the Book, that thou mightest remove thy sandals, for thou art in the sacred valley, and We are indeed witnesses. We have indeed known what hath proceeded from thy hands—verses of the Kitabu'l-'Adl. God willing, He will preserve it from the deeds of the ignorant. He is the Forgiving, the Appreciative.

Say: To him whom God hath made his hands to be outstretched in the Book, let him write unto Him as We have sent down in the Book—clear verses from Our presence for people who understand. Say: Fear God and deprive not thyself of thy portion in this worldly life, for We this day are not able to judge, and God is the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing.

We have indeed known what thou hast discovered regarding the laws of the letters of the Qur'an, and We have expounded therein that which none before this could encompass in knowledge. As to those who ask about the verses of their Book, say: Be patient, for what We do is better for your souls than what ye knew not. Fear God in these days lest sedition arise around Us, and say unto the believers: Peace, peace.

We have indeed fulfilled in the Book what We promised before concerning John, and he is indeed among God's near-servants, witnessed before Us. Empty thy heart, O thou trusted one, of what We commanded thee before, and look upon what hath been sent down in the Kitabu'l-'Adl. God willing, He will empty thy heart through His wisdom, and unto our Lord shall we return.

And if thou hast decided concerning what We decide for thee in the Book of the non-Arabs, then mention some of what We related on that night before God, and admonish the people, for it is indeed a decree from One possessed of severe might. Trust in God, O concourse, then be in God's religion like the

apostles before, for We are indeed witnesses this day. Unto God do I complain of what Thou knowest in my secret thoughts, and I am indeed the Forgiving, the Wise.

BB00503

Date: 1262 (Shiraz) [1845-1846]

In the Name of the Most High, the Most Great

Glorified be He Who hath sent down the Command in this time according to an established decree. That which was detailed unto Us hath indeed been sent down today, and We are witnesses unto all. Verily in the morning We sent down an epistle unto him who previously confirmed thy Lord's Cause, saying: Stand firm in that land and reform the deeds of those who spread corruption therein while claiming "We are the reformers."

As for what My friend Yahya desired—and thou art all people—God knoweth that I would love that, were God to will it and permit Me. But God doeth what He willeth by His command, and there is no God but He, the All-Powerful, the Mighty. Say: Fear ye God and despair not of God's grace, and make these verses the measure, then learn the Qur'an, and place your trust in God that ye may obtain mercy.

And regarding this man's matter, I beseech God of His grace to make firm his heart when He shows him. Say: O Yahya, recite unto him what God hath permitted thee and kindle him with thy Lord's fire, and fear not, for truly the Messengers fear not before Me. But fear God lest thou cause him temptation by speaking of these things. And if thou seest no good in him, turn away from him and trust in God and say:

> "God sufficeth me, there is no God but He; in Him do I trust and in Him let the believers place their trust."

Say unto him who came and his companion: Trust ye in God and speak not of any matter, for the people were sanctified.

The Bab—Tafsir va l-Asr and Nubuwwat-i-Khassih Isfahan late 1846

Volume 011-011. Contains 2 writings.

BB00010: Tafsir-i-Surah wa'l-'Asr (Commentary on the Surah of the Afternoon)

1. Exordium

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

All praise be to God Who hath manifested Himself unto all created things through the revelation of the signs of His creation in the kingdom of Command and Creation, that the essential realities of all existing

things might be illumined by the effulgent rays of the divine verses, and that the very essence of all abstract realities might resound with the reverberations of the signs of His dominion through the manifestations of the verses of His kingdom, that all might bear witness in every station of Command and every sign of Consummation to that whereunto God Himself hath testified in the primordial eternity that there is none other God but Him. He hath ever been, and no thing existed with Him. He shall ever be even as He hath been. He is the Single One, the Unique, Who hath no description in creation, no attribute in invention, no mention in origination, and no decree in innovation.

He is the Single One, the Self-Subsisting, Who hath brought the Will into being from naught before all things, by itself and for itself, without any mention accompanying it, nor decree parallel to it, nor attribute resembling it, nor description equaling it, that through its existence might be established in the realities of souls and horizons the unity of His eternity, which He hath deposited in the essential natures of the most exalted abstract realities of creation, that all might acknowledge in the station of the manifestation of His revelation that which He hath desired in bringing all things into being.

Then He brought into existence Volition for the manifestation of the essence of Will in the First Particle after the appearance of the First Scene in the degree of Will, that all might know in the stations of essences, realities, souls, accidents, substances, moments, stations, indications, allusions, signs, verses, beginnings and ends, that which God hath desired for His creation in the station of knowledge of the degrees of action and the manifestations of passion, that all might be distinguished at the beginning of the mention of duality from the manifestations of unity and from the sign of multiplicity.

Then, after the manifestation of the creation of Volition, He brought forth the surging ocean of Decree for the manifestation of that which is decreed, and made it the connection of causality in the station of effect and the manifestation of objectivity in the station of trinity and the degree of that which is made, that through the manifestation of its signs in the worlds of contingency and the manifestations of entities might be distinguished the degrees of the choices of the atoms of contingent beings, and that he who is to be wretched might be wretched through the manifestation of that degree in the Third Scene, and he who is to be blessed might be blessed through the manifestation of the signs of that causality gleaming from the manifestation of the First Degree, and that all might be distinguished according to what the atoms deserve and the existences accept and the moments choose from what God hath desired in the Book and hath desired in the beginning and the return.

Then God originated, after the manifestation of these three degrees, the degrees of manifestation of the descent of those stations, and He sent down their names in the world of Names in accordance with what God hath sent down in the Book through the mention of Decree, Permission, Term and Book, that the creation of all things might be completed through the manifestation of those seven from all directions, and that what God hath detailed in the stations of the world of Names and Attributes might become clear in the degree of dust, until each hath taken its portion in all stations according to what God hath ordained for it in the mention of beginnings unto what God hath ordained for it without end in the degree of address. Thus hath prospered whosoever hath prospered, and thus hath lost whosoever hath desired judgment without proof or Book.

2. The questioner and the question

And now, when the Command hath descended from His Eminence of lofty and exalted lineage, of transcendent and sublime glory, of high and noble descent, possessed of the most excellent attributes and praiseworthy qualities, the Sultan of the Learned—may God perpetuate the shadow of his kindness over those who dwell beneath the shade of His mercy—to interpret the blessed Surah which God hath revealed in the Qur'an "By the declining day [wa al-asr]! Verily man is in loss, except those who believe and do good works, and exhort one another to truth and exhort one another to steadfastness." [Q103:1-3]

Since his command is to be obeyed and his decree is decisive in manifesting this exposition, I have sought God's assistance and proceeded to reveal that which God has created in existence, bringing it forth into visible reality, so that through the commentary on this blessed Surah there might be distinguished the station of one who is aided by God's grace in that station from others, and that the reward of whoever understands any part of it may remain with his eminence until the Day of Return.

I beseech God of His grace to preserve the eyes of those who gaze upon the allusions revealed in that Book from objection, and to inspire all with the decree of justice regarding the stations of the significances of the words revealed in that station for this most delightful cause. Verily, I place my trust in God for manifesting the reality of the mystery of contingent existence through that which God has placed in existence by bringing it forth into visible reality. There is no power nor strength save in God, the Most High, the All-Bountiful.

3. Regarding distinguishing the true from the false

Before I mention a single letter in the station of interpretation, I beseech his most delightful eminence—may God perpetuate the shadow of his kindness—to pardon my soul should any error flow from my pen, for the station of the servant in every condition is that of sin. I hope that God will establish, through the mention of certain stations for those who dwell in the stations of the world of names and attributes, that which God has ordained for them in the decree of the Book. Verily unto God returns all judgment and command, in the beginning and in the return.

Before I mention the exposition of a single letter from the inner meaning of that sacred Surah, I shall mention certain signs whereby truth may be distinguished from falsehood, and the sincere from the heedless. Yet I desire by this nothing save knowledge for whoever wishes to become aware of the realities of abstraction, recognize the signs of divine unity, and become established upon the throne of uniqueness and detachment.

Among the signs which it behooves the fair-minded one to recognize is the knowledge of the forms of the exalted ones from the debased, for judgment is neither established in the Law nor made manifest in Reality except through recognition of that sublime rank.

And that matter cannot be known except through knowledge of reality, for the forms in this world are similar, and one who, in the world of multiplicities, turns toward the Countenance of the Divine Essence

in that station cannot be distinguished except through the negation of allusions and veils in the world of origins through negation of names and attributes.

Since this matter was difficult for certain souls, God has established for every truth its reality and for every matter its clear evidence, lest anyone follow another merely due to outward forms and manifest conditions, for true honor lies in the divine mystery and the manifestation of the light of eternality in all aspects of the servant.

In this world, since the two natures are mixed, God has commanded all with that whereby all may be distinguished upon investigation, such that none can harbor doubt therein beneath the zenith of certainty in the manifest horizon. Were that balance not established in the exposition of the scale, the decree of the answer would not be clear in following the most delightful command.

After these allusions, there is no doubt that today all people claim truth and establish within themselves proof for what they claim. Yet in reality complete proof is not in the possession of all—otherwise they would not differ regarding the realities of the manifestations of divine verses, the conditions of the realm of might, the signs of sovereignty, the tokens of the kingdom, and the stations of limitation in the chain of the human realm. And after this there is no doubt that God's proof in every time is conclusive for all things, and God's command and His words are complete. Were it not so, God would have no proof over anyone—glorified be He far above what those who liken Him to creation assert in great exaltation! When it is established in the path of truth that pure truth is not proven except by a true balance from God, to which all differences among all peoples return.

And since today if the balance were the Book of God it would not remove differences because all sects derive proofs for their claims from it—and likewise is the case with traditions, practices of the companions, and signs in the souls and horizons, for differences in all ranks are evident—God refuses that judgment be by difference or that He should reveal it in His Book or accept it from anyone. For God created all things by His command and made the cause of the appearance of all things His very decree. Therefore the decree must needs be one from Him, as is clearly stated in the judgment of the Qur'an where He, exalted be His mention, says "And Our command is but one".

And that which is like unto it must needs be one, and this is a just decree that speaks in the station of unity and the sign of abstraction, where the people of divine unity recognize through the word of glorification. When it is established that the balance is not complete in these true signs, it behooves man to make the measure of the Cause that to which the high must refer and the low must follow, whereby forms of falsehood are distinguished from truth. And this measure must needs be from the Creator, for in the station of fruition and deriving results, a single decree is not established.

Since this is the case, your honor witnesses the existence of a just balance whereby decree was previously established and none can oppose it or question it with "why" or "how". And this is the glory which God gives to whom He wishes among His servants, and by it He punishes and establishes, and concerning it all shall be questioned on the Day of Judgment. And this is the glory which all are powerless to resist in its manifestation. And since the matter was veiled behind veils, and for every mention there is a station in mentioning the proofs, and since establishing the balance is not in the station of that exposition, I ask of

your honor to observe the measure of exposition in the stations which I wrote before you. And similarly it was established in the commentary on Al-Kawthar for whoever wishes to remember or take warning.

4. Commentary on the individual parts of the surah

And now I shall explain what God intended in that station regarding the interpretation of that blessed Surah in the station of limitation for those who distinguish separation from union. And from your honor the paths of the outward and inward are not hidden, and verily the matter in reality is not concealed from you, rather He desired to remind of certain traditions and the appearance of lights and the word of mysteries for certain righteous ones.

And since the matter comprised numbered stations, I shall point out some of its wisdom, which is that every letter of the Qur'an hath manifold stations. Indeed, God hath created within a single verse the reality of all things upon which the name of a thing hath been conferred—signs of all things, lest it prove difficult for anyone to recognize the manifestations of the signs of His grace and the revelations of His justice in all things. And one beholdeth in all things the manifestation of His sovereignty in the creation of all things, visible and existent, to such extent that one seeth nothing except that he seeth it before that thing.

Among these is the station of the Point in the stations of divine action, whose reality none can comprehend save him whom God hath made the station of His Self in the first world—the station of justice. This station is exclusively reserved for Muhammad, the Apostle of God, and none else hath any portion therein. In that station, He is a manifestation from His presence in the reality of that letter, and all allusions fall short of His mention, and all goals are circumscribed at the dawning of the lights of His glory. The mention of that station is not of the paths of knowledge, rather it is of the light of exposition which God hath created in the reality of all things for the exposition of all things. The mystery of this matter is unveiled before thee and requireth no elaborate mention. For others, I see no way for them to know it.

Among these also is the station of the soft alif, which is the second rank among the stations of divine action. This is the station where the first letter is made manifest in the revelation of divine action. God, through His subtle wisdom and supreme grace, hath made this station exclusively reserved for the successor of His beloved, Ali. None hath any portion in the knowledge of that letter, for it reflecteth His countenance as a mirror and indicateth His beauty, as the Apostle of God hath explicitly stated in the celebrated tradition: "None knoweth it save God and his own self." None besides him hath any way to know that letter, for he determineth it from his own essence in the essential realities of the kingdoms of the heavens and earth. He standeth in the stations of unity that follow the station of the Point in the station of that letter, and none knoweth God's handiwork regarding him save He, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Among these also is the station of the hidden alif, the pure everlasting, the divine light, the letter of the manifestation of the Divine Identity, and the sign of Oneness in human essence. In that station it relateth to the station of Hasan and indicateth the manifestation of trinity in the station of Power. Concerning this matter all have differed in the ranks of the choices of existence. From the wisdom of this letter in the

station of manifestation, the Christians took the form of the cross and declared the infusion of divinity into humanity—exalted be God far above what the wrongdoers say, with great exaltation!

Among these also is the station of the unbent alif, which is the station of the manifestation of God's name "the Slayer" in the ranks of divine action, and the beginning of the cause of destiny for the manifestation of alteration after execution. God hath made the bearer of this letter in that station Abu Abdullah Al-Husayn. Therefore he—may my spirit and all who dwell in the kingdoms of command and creation be a sacrifice for him—refused to give allegiance and cut himself off entirely unto the Creator of humanity, accepting martyrdom through the manifestation of universal authority in that letter.

Before attesting to the manifestation of the Universal Guardianship in that Letter—may my spirit be a sacrifice unto Him—in that station He reflects the stations of the three Letters from the simplicity of the Point, the immediacy of the Will, and the indication of the Hidden Alif behind the infinite veils that have no end, unto the limit that hath no bound in contingent existence. Thus did al-Sadiq (peace be upon Him) indicate in His visitation prayer for the night of mid-Sha'ban:

> "No one is abased whom God exalteth, and none is vanquished whom God aideth."

And verily He—may my spirit be sacrificed for His sake—in that station indicateth naught save the Manifestation of the Divine Essence in the realm of attributes, and likewise is the decree for that Letter of the Qur'an. Were the seas of the heavens and earth to become ink for explaining that Letter of the Qur'an, they would be exhausted ere a single explanation of that First Letter could be revealed, for God hath chosen it for Himself and selected it for His love. Verily it is the Letter of the Command through which the heavens and earth were established. None knoweth how it is save God and those whom God hath created above its rank from among His grandfather, His father, and His brother—the blessings of God be upon them so long as creation endureth.

Verily my mention in that station was naught save like my mention in the station of the Essence in both stations. I found no existence for myself in that rank, but since God created some signs of His power in the reality of my heart, I indicated it through a subtle hint for thee, shouldst thou desire to observe the rank of the non-existent in the existent.

Among them is a Letter in the station of Permission, which is the station of the Letters, and this is specific to the Suns of Grandeur—the blessings of God be upon them—and none hath any share in the knowledge of that Letter, for it relateth their majesty and indicateth their presence, and was a gate for knowing the stations of their power. Exalted and glorified is that Letter above explanation and utterance.

And among them is a Letter in the combined Letters, which is the rank of the Term and the station of the light of the Remnant of God in the essences of the realities of the Divine Realm, the entities of the signs of the Realm of Might, the indications of the stations of sovereignty and dominion, and the conditions of the incidental manifestations of the human world. God alone knoweth the decree of that Letter, and none of the Prophets or Messengers hath any share in the knowledge of that Letter of the Qur'an. Upon God do we rely concerning the decrees of the beginning and the return.

And among them is a Letter in the station of the Word, which is the rank of the Book in the decree of the Address. Verily God hath ordained the decree of that Letter for Fatimih—the blessings of God be upon her—and none among those whom God hath created beneath her rank hath any share in its knowledge. And were all else to know a single decree from that Letter which God created in the station of the immediacy of that Letter in rank—verily the paths are blocked and the ways are barred, neither can the proof be mentioned in the path nor can the path be established by the proof. Glorified be its Creator above what they describe.

When some stations of the Letters of the Qur'an were manifested, it is not hidden from thee that after those ranks, which are the fundamental cause in the origins of causes, there are many stations, among them in the station of the effect of the Will, and among them in the station of the manifestation of the effect of the Divine Purpose, and among them in the stations of passivity in the act itself, and among them are stations at the inception of attributes, and among them are in the realm of infinity in the station of manifestations of the Essence, and beyond that in the station of negation of names and attributes, and among them in the inner station of the Throne, and among them in the outer station of the Seat, and among them in the signs of the heavens.

And verily what is in the earth, were it to be released, would be but a portion in relation to the stations which have been detailed before thy presence. And verily one such as thyself knoweth the stations when the veils are lifted from the station of the countenance of attributes in the manifestness of the light of the Essence. And verily upon that difficult path and arduous way doth the observer recognize the stations of the Qur'an and beareth witness to this through the judgment of the Bayan, and interpreteth all that he willeth by what God hath revealed in the Qur'an.

And verily what hath been mentioned in the traditions that the Qur'an hath inner meanings unto seventy or unto seven hundred is due to the inability of creation to bear it, otherwise the judgment of the letters of the Qur'an and its Command is greater than that, to the number of all that God's knowledge hath encompassed of the mention of the Essence, the limitations, the Names and the Attributes. And for it there is an interpretation, and for every interpretation an interpretation unto infinity with what hath no end.

God knoweth the greatness of His Book, and just as there is nothing fresh or withered except it is in a Clear Book, and it is assumed that all believe in this, likewise the judgment is true in every letter thereof, such that if the Imam desired to extract the judgments of all hidden things and manifest things, of beginnings and endings from the letter Alif in the Qur'an, he would be able to do so. And God hath placed in it, as the Imam Sadiq hath clearly stated in the interpretation of 'the Eternal', and verily this is the judgment in reality and the manifest path.

And when this explanation is established, how then can any letter of the Qur'an be interpreted? Nay, none can do this save Him upon Whom God hath sent it down, nor is it possible in contingent existence, for the outpouring is ever renewed through the existence of creation, and verily this is a judgment that hath no end in invention. And God knoweth all things, and verily unto Him alone returneth the judgment of the Qur'an, for from Him was it sent down in truth alone, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

5. Commentary on the first letter of the surah (waw)

And verily after this explanation, there are unveiled before thy presence indications of certain verses in the Qur'an, and verily the interpretation of that blessed Surih as it is, according to what God hath sent down upon His Beloved, conformeth to what God hath ordained for His Cause. And verily in the inner station, for each letter thereof there is an interpretation, and verily I hereby indicate the interpretation of the first letter of that Surih that it may be a path for the recognition of all verses and words by the people of vision. And it is that the first letter was the Vav, and it hath infinite stations:

Among them it is a name for the universal Guardianship and the first Divine Rod and the gleaming, eternal, creative Countenance, and verily in that station it is the first letter from the stations of the manifestation of the Ha', and it existeth with the people of the cloud of unknowing, and in its essence is the letter Ha' in creation, and they deduce its outward from its inward and its inward from its outward, and its mystery from its manifestness and its manifestness from its mystery, and it is the Guardianship before whose presence of might all essential things are cut off. And this is the Walayat by which all essences are cut off from the threshold of His might, and all beings from the nearness of the splendor of His mercy, for it, by its very essence, separates all realities from the station of attributes and bars all things from mention of Names and Verses. God alone knows its wisdom and none can comprehend it.

And from it stems the outward Walayat from the station of the Blessed Primal Reed and the Divine Tree which is neither of the east nor of the west. This is the Walayat manifest in the station of Will. God created it in the station of justice—the station of Purpose—and in the station of grace at the level of His Self. This is the Walayat which, by God's leave, was established upon the throne of bounty, giving each with right their right and conveying to each soul its provision, whereto God indicated its station in the Qur'an saying:

> "There, the Walayat belongs to God, the Truth. He is best in reward and best in outcome."

And in that exalted station and glorious sign all differences are distinguished, all gatherings are separated, all that is scattered is united, and all multiplicities are confirmed beneath the shadows of the darkening paradise of Names and Attributes. Thus did al-Sadiq indicate in the tradition of Mufaddal, when asked about recognition of the station of that universal Walayat and its bearer, that it is the house of light, the garment of manifestation, the sign of the Forgiving Lord—neither is it Him nor other than Him.

The difference is that the first Walayat speaks of God in the primal mirrors which have no cause before them and no separation between them and the station of Manifestation, which is God's creation in their essence. Through it are confirmed the sign of Oneness, the divine lights, the sea of eternality, and the everlasting glory. It has no shadow in its essential station and no mention in its rank of aught else. This is the eternal Walayat indicating God through the indication by which God revealed Himself to it and caused it to shine, making it the station of the manifestation of His countenance, that all might unify His Oneness through the sign of that Walayat and glorify through it His eternality, thereby becoming knowers of their Lord's right and praisers of their Creator's praise in the beginning of causes and their end.

Through knowledge of this exposition the servant distinguishes the first station through the light of eternity and the second station through the manifestation of the rank of Will. There is no doubt that Walayat in the first rank is established, and that in the second it has no manifestation in the first rank except through the manifestation of Will, and that in the ranks of that Walayat all signs are established through the manifestation of contingent being, and that mentions, stations, indications and tokens, were they to be mentioned in that second rank, would be in the station of the ray in relation to the first rank.

And among the stations of interpretation of the letter waw is the resplendent, radiant, brilliant Walayat which determined, brought into being, ordained, decreed, permitted, glorified and perfected in the essences of its realities, the beings of its stations, the signs of its oneness, the manifestations of its indications, and what God ordained for it in the stations of creation and command. And this Walayat is that which speaks of the second Walayat in the rank of destiny, and in the station of that Walayat appear the hidden ranks of formation, the realities of the determination of composition, and the essential natures of the manifestations of divine unity in the realm of the one who stands gazing upon a clear truth.

And for whosoever desires to become acquainted with the reality of the appearance of that Authority, it behooveth him to contemplate the stations of the manifestation of that Authority, that his heart may be strengthened and his soul be assured by that which God hath sent down concerning the ordinances of religion and the signs of the Manifest Book, and that which God hath ordained regarding the Day of Judgment, and that which God hath willed and commanded concerning the stations of Paradise and the depths of the Fire, and that which God hath willed in all things for all things. And verily these signs are witnessed before thee, otherwise the mention of proofs before thee would be naught but an elaboration of the manifestation of Words and the appearance of that which God hath willed in the Book. And verily unto God do all beginnings and endings return, in origin and return.

And among the stations of the interpretation of the letter Vav is the Authority in the manifestation of the rank of Decree and Origination, then Implementation and Praise. And by it is established the ordinance of Authority which God hath sent down in the Qur'an in the station of manifest vision, and it is the Authority which God, glorified be He, hath bestowed upon the people of infallibility, may God's blessings be upon them. And verily by it they judge as they will through what they will, and they will naught save that which God willeth. And verily it is the Most Exalted in the expanse of the Imamate, in the beginnings of the beginning and the end.

And verily in the station of Reality these signs are in the interpretation of Vav in the station of the inner meaning, and therefore this matter flows in the inner of the inner unto the ultimate ranks which, if thou desirest to become acquainted with their reality, shall not be hidden from thee. And verily in some stations, when it is desired that the interpretation of Vav be manifested, it is not fitting at this time, as its time hath not yet come, for those stations which are witnessed before thee, as no one is able to know and become acquainted with the reality of what hath occurred.

And when the Pen floweth with mention of the interpretation of the inner meaning, I mention in that Book a principle from among the principles of the true philosophers by which the learned one may know the inner meaning of verses and traditions from the outward meaning. And it is that God hath established creation in the first scene for the mention of His unity, then in the second scene for the Prophethood of

Muhammad the Messenger of God, then in the third scene for the Authority of the people of infallibility, may God's blessings be upon them, then in the fourth scene for the followers of the divines of religion and the callers to certitude.

And that is in the rank of descent, and when anyone desireth to know the balance of the science of the inner meaning, it behooveth him to return the judgment to those stations and to interpret all verses in the rank of ascent with the inner of the inner, and conversely with the outer of the inner, as is indicated by the famous tradition which Al-Kulayni hath related in Al-Kafi from As-Sadiq, peace be upon him, and which Al-Kazim, peace be upon him, spoke to Mutammim ibn Fayruz.

But the science of the inner meaning is difficult for most people as they cannot bear the apex of the matter, but for thee it is easy if thou desirest to become acquainted with it. And if God were to will, it would be possible that I interpret regarding the interpretation of Vav with some ordinances of religion from the known signs and recognized tokens, but now the matter doth not flow due to what thou hast become acquainted with concerning the detail of stations and the multiplicity of signs. But I indicate some stations thereof lest anyone forget its ordinance:

God hath created all things as they are, according as they are. The Command hath descended from the primal causes in all things until it reached the station of letters. In that station God made the name of the letter of unity and its mystery His Word, corresponding to the higher realm. Those possessed of understanding know not what is there except through what is here. God, through His subtle handiwork, hath joined the letter Vav with Ha, as no specification can be seen in the letters themselves, and it is closest to the Source. The number of that letter exceeds the letter Ha by only one, and that is the letter of Being which God created to preserve its station.

The stations of unity in that letter return to the reality of unity and the mystery of detachment. It is the single letter that in every condition indicates God, glorified be He. All letters in every station, of the spirits and the bodies, return to the letter Vav, and it returneth to the letter Ha, which is the letter of detachment in the depths of praise. From this exposition branch forth lofty stations that minds are bewildered to comprehend, and their reality cannot be revealed. Now is not the time, as the heart's awareness cannot fully express it. Among the stations of the interpretation of that letter is the station of the appearance of Qur'anic meanings, from the stations of allusions to the ultimate ends of endings, and what God hath ordained in the knowledge of the Book for those possessed of understanding among the people of return.

The wayfarer, in the journey from creation to Truth, seeth that very letter as the station of stillness in the depths of Oneness which God hath ordained for him in the journey from creation to Truth, for the seal is itself the very beginning. The recognition of the Essence is not valid in the journeys enumerated in the knowledge of the Book except through negating indications from the court of the nearness of attributes, as ʿAli, peace be upon him, indicated in his sermon where he said, exalted be his mention: "The beginning of religion is His recognition," until he said, "and the perfection of unity is the negation of attributes from Him, testifying that every attribute is other than the One described, and every One described is other than the attribute."

This is the most subtle of the stations of unity in the manifestations of detachment. There is no nobility above it, no mention, and for one who attaineth not unto it, no glory or good.

Sufficient are these allusions in interpreting the first letter of the blessed Surih. It hath levels in the station of forms that man should be certain of their reality, namely:

That the spirit of the word Vav which God revealed at the beginning of that Surih in its station is sovereign over all verses in the souls and horizons, and likewise was the decree in its form. Should all who are in the heavens and earth gather together to produce the like of that Vav as the first letter of that word from the Qur'an, they would never succeed, for just as God made its spirit sovereign over all indications and verses, likewise was the decree in its form. However, most people are confused about the forms, not having understood the reality of the Qur'an's mystery. Just as the forms of people in human temples are one, though one among them may be a proof among them, likewise is the decree regarding the forms of the letters, for all that the people speak and that enters their hearts concerning the composition of letters does not equal either the spirit or body of that letter Vav from the Book of the All-Merciful. Indeed, this is evident in thy presence, requiring no further explanation after what hath been made clear.

6. Commentary on the letters of the surah in their inner aspect

Part 1: "And whereas some stations of the letter Vav…"

And whereas some stations of the letter Vav have been established through these allusions, I shall mention for every letter of that Surih an aspect of its inner interpretation, as thy noble presence hath commanded regarding the station of exposition, in accordance with the commentary on Al-Kawthar in the Tibyan. Permission hath come through the Suns of Prophethood and Mystery in the traditions that all names, both praiseworthy and otherwise, pertain to the people of infallibility, and that which its outward form doth not equal its inner mystery—God hath revealed concerning the Imams of fire a mention for every letter of that Surih as God hath willed and desired in that Book, and unto Him do beginning and end return.

Verily the first letter is Vav, and it is the allusion to the stations of Universal Guardianship in the realm of Lahut, then in the throne of Jabarut, then in the evidences of dominion and kingdom, then in the signs of the stations of every soul's guardianship which God's knowledge hath encompassed. Beyond the judgment of these allusions no one knoweth save God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then the second letter is Alif, and it is the allusion to the stations of Paradise's bounties and the commands of the All-Merciful. It is the letter through which all letters stand, and in its presence all inner meanings are witnessed by God's leave. None knoweth the reality of the mystery of that hidden command save whom God willeth. Every name upon which the name of "thing-ness" is bestowed—were man to interpret that Alif to act truthfully, he would have a reward in God's Book for having revealed the hidden meanings within the depths of words and allusions. It hath ranks which, if thy presence observeth them, thou wouldst become aware of its reality through the expansion of the Command in the beginning and the end.

Then the third letter is Lam, and in its inner station it is the allusion to the All-Encompassing, All-Pervading, Universal, Primordial Standard under whose shade God hath placed all things, making its bearer ʿAli in all stations from the world of beginning to the world of ending. It is the Standard of Divine Unity for which God hath made no shade nor station save the manifestation of its vastness, then the Standard of the All-Merciful, then the Standard of the name of Oneness, then the Standard of Unity, indicating in its essential reality what God hath ordained for it in the knowledge of reality.

Beyond this interpretation it hath recorded aspects, for the letter Lam is the number of nights God promised Moses son of Imran upon Sinai, and unto it returns all manifestation when the inner meaning is concealed. It hath an aspect in the countenance of letters which God hath not placed in any other, and for this reason God placed the letter Lam in the middle of the name of Ali, peace be upon him, for the rank of receptivities is not complete except through the mention of the accepted ones in the completion of its number forty, and verily he—may my spirit be sacrificed for him—is the One Who standeth by God's leave between the worlds and Who judgeth between the two gulfs. Whoso possesseth inner knowledge can expand in that station whatsoever he willeth regarding the emergence of the signs of realities and the tokens of subtleties, and all that God, glorified be He, hath placed in all stations beneath his rank and the manifestation of His Will, where the nature of exposition in the paths of that utterance is not hidden from you.

Then from the fourth letter, the letter ʿAyn: the transcendence of the Divine Unity in the stations of the Lahut, then the transcendence of Oneness in the conditions of the Jabarut, then the transcendence of the All-Merciful in the stations of the Mulk and Malakut, then the transcendence of the Eternal in what God has manifested from all through all in the realities of souls and horizons in the realm of Nasut.

Then from the fifth letter, the letter Sad: the mention of the stations of Eternality manifested in the essences and beings of the people of Lahut, then the radiant, sanctified Eternality manifested in the essential natures of the abstract beings of Jabarut, then the brilliant, wondrous Eternality from the inner realities of the people of Mulk and Malakut, then the Eternality which relates the first rank from the degrees of action wherein God has sent down the forms of His light's manifestations in the souls of the people of Nasut.

Then from the sixth letter, the letter Ra: the universal mercy through which God created the Will by itself before all things, then made it the cause of all atoms, then the unitary mercy through which God created the souls of whatsoever His knowledge encompasses in the Book, then the universal mercy descending in the station of Destiny—a surging, boundless, billowing ocean wherein the ordinances of creation are distinguished, and blessed is he who is blessed through recognition of the station which God created at the ultimate end of that station, and wretched is he who is wretched through his heedlessness of what God has sent down in that surging, boundless, billowing ocean.

Then the mercy which embraceth all things, which God its Creator made to be one hundred parts, as Al-ʿAskari explained in his commentary on "the All-Merciful," and through one part thereof He showeth mercy unto all who dwell in the world, and through ninety-nine parts God will show mercy unto His servants on the Day of Resurrection according to what He hath willed and ordained in the Book—and this is the all-embracing mercy which encompasseth the believer and the infidel and all things, and verily

through that mercy the essential natures of all contingent beings came into existence and were endowed with identity. And verily God made Husayn, peace be upon him, the bearer of that mercy in that station, and therefore he—may my spirit and all who dwell in the kingdom of Command and Creation be a sacrifice unto him—will intercede before God on the Day of Resurrection as none other can intercede. May God grant me and all who desire to attain his intercession on the Day of Reckoning—verily He is the All-Forgiving in the beginning and the end.

Then from the seventh letter, the letter Alif: the inner reality of the Will as the beginning of action, which the people of truth express as Purpose, then the inner reality of essential natures in the rank of Destiny from the realm of Lahut and Jabarut and Mulk and Malakut, then the inner reality which God created in the realities of all things from the principles of causes which end in impenetrable, pitch-black darkness, then the inner reality whereby the truthful one is distinguished in the manifestations of the signs of majesty from others when the decree of the Concourse on high is not witnessed.

Then from the eighth letter, the letter Nun: the light of God in the station of the essential natures of the manifestations of Lahut, then the light of God in the station of the essences of the beings of Jabarut, then the light of God in the hidden meanings of the verses of Mulk and Malakut, then the light of God which was sent down in the Qur'an and which He attributed to His own exalted Self, where He, exalted be His mention, said:

> "God is the Light of the heavens and the earth. The similitude of His light is as a niche wherein is a lamp. The lamp is in a glass. The glass is as it were a shining star. (This lamp is) kindled from a blessed tree, an olive neither of the East nor of the West, whose oil would almost glow forth even though no fire touched it. Light upon Light! God guides to His Light whom He wills. God sets forth parables for men, and God has knowledge of all things."

[Q24:35]

The ninth letter is the letter Alif, signifying the will of the action itself in the stations of principles and causes, then signifying the third rank among the ranks of action. In that station are distinguished the wills of created things, to which the Proof referred in the visitation prayer of the Family of God, which issued from the Sacred Precinct to Uthman ibn Umar, where he, exalted be His mention, said: "Verily your will is the will of God…" Then there is the will by which God created the essences of wills beneath the rank of the Family of God from among the Prophets, Messengers and Martyrs. Then there is the will which God placed in the chain of subjects, and through these two man does what he wills. Glory be to God, exalted is He above what those who draw comparisons say about His wisdom.

Indeed some philosophers have erred in explaining the mention of God's will, claiming it to be an attribute of the Divine Essence. This is manifest unbelief in the school of the pure Family of God, for will is an attribute of action, and God originated it through the Primal Will for its own manifestation in the stations of the abstract and the accidental. None knows the nature of what God has originated in those stations save whom God wills. He is the Most High, the Most Exalted.

The tenth letter is the letter Lam, signifying the pearls which God created in the seas of the Divine Realm, then the pearls which God created in the seas of the Realm of Power, then the pearls which God created

in the seas of the Kingdom and Dominion, then the pearls which God created in the seas of the earthly realm, of every kind that God created by His command. He is the Mighty, the Bestower.

The eleventh letter is the letter Alif, signifying the origination of the Primal Will in the world of the Cloud, then the creation of Will after the Divine Realm in the Realm of Power, then the bringing into being of essences from what God's knowledge has encompassed in the realm of the Kingdom, then the generation of pure being in the rank of Destiny according to what God's Book encompasses in the realm of Dominion.

The twelfth letter is the letter Nun, signifying the pure light in the dawning of the manifestation of the Divine Essence, then the determinate light in the world of Names and Attributes, then the light connected to the third pillar of the Throne, which God made yellow in color facing the first pillar of white color, then the light which God created in the lamp which tells of its manifestation in the colors of the Throne from yellow after white, then green before red. This is God's light in the horizons and souls and the greater worlds, whereby the separated were united and the united were separated according to what God willed and ordained in the beginning and the return.

The thirteenth letter is the letter Sin, signifying the glory of splendor, then the glory of praise, then the glory of the Cloud, then the glory of Destiny when it flows to execution and is not preceded by origination.

The fourteenth letter is the letter Alif, signifying the signs of Unity in the manifestations of the stations of the Divine Realm, then the signs of Oneness in the conditions of the appearances of the Realm of Power, then the signs of the All-Merciful in the tokens indicating the signs of the Dominion and the Kingdom, and what was established upon the throne of bounty by God's leave in all stations of limitation and infinitude according to God's will in the manifestation of the essence of the dominion and kingdom; then the signs radiating from those signs dawning in the essential realities of abstract beings and what God's knowledge has encompassed in the world of names and attributes.

Then from the fifteenth letter, the letter Nun: the white light from which every whiteness in contingent existence became white; then the yellow light from which yellowness in all things became yellow in their essences; then the green light from which everything in the heavens and earth became green according as God the All-Merciful willed and revealed in the Furqan; then the red light from which redness in all things became red from the mystery of contingent existence in their essences.

Then from the sixteenth letter, the letter Lam: verily it is the banner in the stations of creation and composition with their endless manifestations, and through it realities are realized, entities are specified, utterances are repeated, and pearls shine forth, and whatsoever the word of names and attributes is applied to.

Then from the seventeenth letter, the letter Fa': the uniqueness of unity; then the uniqueness of the All-Merciful; then the uniqueness of signs which God created and the ranks of essential realities of beings of the dominion and kingdom; then the uniqueness of stations of the principles of causes and what God created in the essential realities of ranks of origination and modes of invention according to God's will and desire in the Book, verily He is the Mighty, the Bestower.

Then from the eighteenth letter, the letter Ya': the sea of the realm of Lahut; then the sea of the realm of Jabarut; then the sea of the dominion and kingdom; then the sea about which God revealed His decree in the Qur'an where He, exalted be His mention, said:

> "And We revealed unto Moses' mother, saying: Suckle him, and when thou fearest for him then cast him into the sea, and fear not nor grieve. Lo! We shall bring him back unto thee and shall make him one of Our messengers."

Then from the nineteenth letter, the letter Kha': the state of the seclusion of oneness from all else, and the imposition of the separation of attributes but not isolation between what God created through origination and what is besides it; then the seclusion of the act from the object; then the seclusion of the cause from the effect; then the seclusion of what God created in the upper chain from the lower chain.

Then from the twentieth letter, the letter Sin: the splendor of God in the world of the divine cloud; then the splendor of God in the world of glory; then the splendor of God in the world of decree; then the splendor of God in the world of execution.

Then from the twenty-first letter, the letter Ra': the humming of the army of bees of Lahut in the thickets of Jabarut; then the thickets which God created for the familiarity of fabricated things; then the thickets wherein God ordained the decree of justice and none attains to it except through grace; then the thickets which God intended for all He created and originated from what His knowledge encompasses, verily He is the Mighty, the Powerful.

Then from the twenty-second letter, the letter Alif: the root of the universal tree which God created in the realm of Lahut and made it a sign for the manifestation of the light of His eternity in origination; then the root of the Tuba tree in Paradise; then the root of the blessed leaf which was paired with the first branch from the tree which God created for the manifestation of the sign of divine authority in the station of bodies; then the root of the sacred tree which spoke on the Mount by God's leave and indicated naught but God—glorified, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then from the twenty-third letter, the letter Lam, which in that station is the Most Great Tablet wherein all conditions are enumerated, then the Tablet of Command wherein God has inscribed all that He has revealed, then the Preserved Tablet which records the deeds of all creation to the extent encompassed by God's knowledge, then the Tablet which God created through Azrael's knowledge for bestowing spirit upon every possessor of spirit, and verily he looks upon it at all times and obeys his Lord's command according to what he learns of the decrees of that Tablet by God's leave—glorified and exalted be He.

Then from the twenty-fourth letter, the letter Alif, the first sign of Oneness which God gave for the repetition of that primal Remembrance, then the sign of Oneness which God gave through the Imams of religion whereby they unite with God their Creator in all things and unite with God only through what God has testified for them within the knowledge of the unseen, then the sign of Oneness which God has deposited in the reality of all upon which the name of anything is bestowed from the worlds of the abstract, material, essential, accidental, qualitative and whatsoever God's knowledge encompasses beyond those indications and signs whereby they turn toward the dawning-place of the manifestation of the Divine Essence through negating names, multiplicities and attributes.

Then the twenty-fifth letter, the letter Alif, the command of God whereby man recognizes the signs of abstraction, the tokens of uniqueness, the evidences of unity and the stations of glorification, then the command of God whereby the servant knows the stations of Oneness, essential identities, spiritual realities and the stations which God has made unceasing in every place, to which the Proof refers in his prayer on the day of Rajab: "And by the stations which cease not in any place." Then the command of God whereby the separate things became separate, the gathered things gathered, the harmonious things harmonized, and there appeared what was in the kingdom of names and attributes and the stations of ends and conclusions up to what God ordained in the rank of the Book.

Then the command of God which Husayn son of Ali established on the day of Ashura when none could stand with him save those who willed and who had taken the covenant of his love in the realm of pre-existence. Thus he said when he stood before the party of Satan: "Do you call upon Baal and forsake the Best of creators?" So I ask God of His grace to gather us with those who desire His decree and who detest those who are content with the deeds of those who fought against him—may God punish them as they deserve, for God is not unjust to His servants.

Part 2: "Then from the twenty-sixth letter, the letter Lam…"

Then from the twenty-sixth letter, the letter Lam, the slight sins which God intended in the Book for those who dwell beyond the veils of divinity—servants for whom God has not established specific manifestation in the rank of appearance even if they possess rank of appearance, and they are a people who look upon things only through the gaze of the Lord, exalted be His glory. Were they to look at anything without the perspective of the First Point, they would not be among the people of that station. God knows their station and is aware of their conditions. May God grant me, and those who are righteous among their fathers and their offspring, to dwell in the Gardens of Eden.

Verily, He is the All-Forgiving, the Loving. Then there are those whom God has placed beneath the shade of the yellow corner of the Throne, and they are people in whom the fruit of the present has appeared more than those dwelling in the station of the first corner, and thus its color appeared as yellow. Then there are those whom God has placed beneath the shade of the green light from the third corner of the Throne. Then there are those whom God has placed beneath the shade of the red light from the fourth corner of the Throne, and in that station appear the principles of the light of the first corner in its reality, then the light of the second corner in its manifestation, then the light of the third corner in its attributes, and thus multiplicities and infinities are found beyond these stations.

And if the observer were to look with the perspective of the First Point at these signs, he would know the wisdom of grace in that corner and justice in the ranks to which I have referred. Verily, unto God returns all judgment in the beginning and the return.

Then from the twenty-seventh letter, the letter Dhal: the pinnacle of the Throne in the heights of the Command, then the pinnacle of Paradise, then the pinnacle of the ranks of the abstract and essential realities, then the pinnacle of everything upon which falls the name of anything among names and attributes.

Then from the twenty-eighth letter, the letter Ya, which is the letter that God created at the end of the name of Ali (peace be upon him) for the manifestation of the ten grips at the ultimate rank of the Seal. This letter is among the luminous letters, and God created the origin of letters as an example of the supreme realm. Fourteen letters thereof are for the manifestation of the Family of God (peace be upon them) in the stations of composition and creation, and it is the path of Ali, truth we hold fast to. And fourteen letters thereof are for the manifestation of the stations of reflections of those mirrors in the station of exposition. God has not created anything self-subsisting except through the causality of those universal meanings in the rank of the spirits of those letters, then the causality of those letters in the rank of the utterances of these letters which are the station of bodies. And there is no end to God's bounty in any regard.

Then from the twenty-ninth letter, the letter Nun, which may be interpreted as that which brings forth the inner wisdom from utterances: the light of creation in the rank of glorification, then the light of invention in the rank of praise, then the light of origination in the rank of unity, then the light of glory in the rank of magnification.

Then from the thirtieth letter, the letter Alif: the Command of God by which the heavens and earth were established, then the Command of God by which the laws of religion are confirmed in all stations, then the Command of God which He has made obligatory upon all to know and understand its reality, then the Command of God which has appeared upon the realities of all created things as He willed, how He willed, such that none among the people of creation knows how that is, except as God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe, may will.

Then from the thirty-first letter, the letter Mim: the glory of God in the kingdoms of the heavens and earth, then the glory of God in the stations of Command and Creation; then the glory of God for His chosen ones whom He hath created for Himself and selected for His Cause, making them the station of His Self in expression, inasmuch as God cannot be perceived by sight while He perceiveth all sight, and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed. Then the glory of God for all His servants whom He hath created from nothing by His decree, and ordained for them every good thing should they follow His command through His grace. Verily He is the Bestower, the Possessor of Perpetual and Supreme Grace.

Then from the thirty-second letter, the letter Nun, signifying the light of God in the Primary Niche; then the light of God in the Lamp; then the light of God in the stations which God hath ordained for everything in His creation from the numbered chains: the first chain being the rank of the manifestation of the principles of action, then the second chain being the principles of the manifestation of the chain of the Seal, then the chain of the essential realities of creation from the human plane until reaching the station of dust.

Then the thirty-third letter, the letter Waw, signifying the Authority which God hath created for the manifestation of His Own Authority in the principles of the Command and the final ends of the Seal; then the Authority which God bestowed upon Muhammad in stations which none can reckon save God; then the Authority which God established for ʿAli in all stations, signs, tokens and verses; then the Authority which God established in the essences of the abstract realities of contingent beings in all ranks and stations.

Then the thirty-fourth letter, the letter Alif, signifying the mention of that Eternity which God hath reserved for Himself and hath forbidden its like to be attributed to any other, and through it God unifieth all His servants—that Eternity which was expressive of the manifestation of His Presence, whereof God made its beginning the same as its end, and its end the same as its beginning, and its inward aspect the same as its outward aspect, and its outward aspect the same as its inward aspect—the pure, absolute Eternity that indicateth God, glorified be He. Then the Eternity which He permitted for the First Mention from His Self, and Light from His Command, and Sign from His Sovereignty, and Geometry from His Grandeur, and Greatness from His Might, and Manifestation from His Hidden Presence, and made it for Muhammad, His Beloved, whom He chose in the First World for the manifestation of the sovereignty of His Self, and selected from among all the atoms of contingent beings in the worlds of principles for the manifestation of the authority of His Self-Subsistence over all else.

Then the Eternity which God, exalted be His mention, originated for the Successors of Muhammad the Messenger of God and his daughter, establishing it in six stations for the manifestation of the letter Waw, among which is the Authority that relateth to the rank of Will and indicateth the eternity of indication in the verses of expression, and verily it is the Authority of Ali before whose sublime glory all within the kingdoms of creation and the cloud-veiled realm did bow down, and to the certitude of whose supreme dominion all that beareth the name of existence submitted, and it is the Authority whereby none in creation can don the garment of existence except after acknowledging him whom God hath given that supreme rank in creation.

Then the Authority which was derived from that Authority and indicated the reminder of the End and the Beginning, and it is the Authority which God, glorified be He, gave to Al-Hasan ibn Ali—may my spirit and all within the kingdoms of Command and Creation be a sacrifice unto him—who stood in the station of His Father in all praise and glory, then in judgment and radiance, then in execution and splendor. His was all the grace that belonged to His Father in might and obedience, in loftiness and honor, and in what God had ordained in the beginning and the end. He is the One Who, by God's leave, conveys to every created thing its sustenance and gives to everything its due.

For those who recognize Him in that station, neither the veils of contingent existence, nor the glories of creation, nor the proofs of explanation, nor the signs of justice in the utterance can conceal Him. God praised His Beloved through His grace, for He is indeed the Generous, the Bestower. Then the exalted, resplendent Authority which was derived from that Authority and indicated those Mirrors that tell of the Beginning—this is the Authority whose bearer God made to be Husayn. Then the Authority which God, glorified be He, specifically assigned to the Qa'im from the family of Muhammad due to His supreme glory and the pinnacle of His radiance—this is the Authority to which He points at all times upon His breast, saying:

> "Therein authority belongs to God, the Truth. He is best in reward, and best in outcome."

May God hasten His manifestation for the appearance of that exalted Authority and that sublime, resplendent station, through Muhammad and His family, the best of God's creation among humanity. Then the Authority which God gave to the Imams of the Faith, the pillars of certitude, and the guides of all creation—His servants whom God made, due to their supreme glory, to be in His Own station, and made

them the pillars of His unity, the manifestations of His uniqueness, the signs of His sanctity, and the proofs of His glorification. Through that universal Authority, they do whatsoever they will by God's leave, and their command in any matter is none other than the command of God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe. Then the Authority which God, glorified be He, gave to Fatima—may God's blessings be upon her—for the manifestation of her grandeur; she is the Greater World, and none knows her right nor the decree of the Authority which God gave her except God and those whom God created above her station. And glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe.

Then from the thirty-fifth letter, the letter Waw: The Authority which God created in the Imam. Then the Authority which was derived from the trace of that Authority, which God gave to the Chiefs. Then the Authority which was derived from that Authority borne by the Chiefs, which God gave to the Nobles. Then the Authority which was derived from that Authority and was borne by the guides of Islam from among the great scholars.

Then from the thirty-sixth letter, the letter ʿAyn: The essence of sulfur before the depth of Oneness, which is the sign of the Will. Then the right eye before the depth of Decree. Then the eye of Tiberias before the vast ocean of Judgment. Then the eye of Barhut before the vast ocean of Execution.

Then the thirty-seventh letter, the letter Mim: The Mim of glory in the station of the first determination. Then the Mim of glory in the station of the second determination in the rank of passivity. Then the Mim of glory in the station of absolute, sublime Authority. Then the Mim of glory in the station of the manifestations of the radiance of all atoms, from what God has encompassed in the Book. Glorified and exalted is He, He knows what is in the heavens and what is on earth, and not an atom's weight escapes His knowledge, and He is the Self-Sufficient, the All-Knowing.

Then from the thirty-eighth letter, the letter Lam: the signs in the realm of Lahut, then the indications in the realm of Jabarut, then the stations in the realm of Mulk, then the tokens in the realm of Malakut. And verily the paths of proof in manifesting these signs are through the vision of the heart, through the mystery of possibility which God hath created in all things—the sign of all things and the meaning of all things. And thou, gaze and thou shalt undoubtedly recognize the Cause of God through the Greatest Vision. Then when God's knowledge encompasses, if God willeth, the knowledge of destiny and the mystery of what is ordained.

Then from the thirty-ninth letter, the letter Vav: the essential nature, then the innate nature, then the personal nature, then the temporal nature in the stations of the signs of Command and Creation, whereof none can comprehend the knowledge save whom God willeth, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then in the fortieth letter, the letter Alif: the execution of the Divine Will in the degree of Decree, then the execution of Purpose in the degree of Origination, then the execution of Destiny in the degree of Glory, then the execution of the Decree itself in the ranks of Creation, according to what God willeth in the judgment of the Beginning and the Day of Return.

Then from the forty-first letter, the letter Alif: the deeds of those who work in God's religion in the degree of the Truth of Certainty, then the deeds of those who work in God's religion in the degree of the

Knowledge of Certainty, then the deeds of those who work in God's religion in the degree of Knowledge—and for each are ranks and stations which none can comprehend save whom God willeth. Verily He is the Mighty, the Bestower.

Then from the forty-second letter, the letter Lam: the banner of Divine Manifestation in the station of that which is manifested to it through it, then the banner of the first degree of manifestation, then the appearance of the banner following the degree of manifestation, then the appearance of the banner which encompasseth all atoms and surroundeth all existing things—and this is the banner which today is in the hands of God's Proof (may my spirit and all who are in the kingdoms of Command and Creation be a sacrifice unto him). And the banner is not in the station of the body, but rather it is the all-encompassing spirit over the receptacles of contingent beings.

Then from the forty-third letter, the letter Sad: the middle prayer, then the Friday prayer, then the noon prayer at the time of decline, then the prayer which God hath prescribed for all people, which is the foundation of deeds, the most splendid of good works, the most excellent of pure things, and the highest of good acts. Whosoever is able to pray to God as He hath desired in the Book for the believers hath indeed achieved a mighty triumph.

Then the forty-fourth letter, the letter Alif: the mysteries of Lahut, then the mysteries of the stations of Jabarut, then the ordinances of the conditions of the signs of Mulk and Malakut, then the tokens which God hath placed with the believers that through them the decree of everything might be distinguished for every soul, and all might be through these tokens among those who know.

Then from the forty-fifth letter, the letter Lam: the pearls of the seas of abstract realities in the holy realm, the pearls of the seas of essential natures in the realms of paradise, then the pearls of the seas of possibility which follow these indicative ranks, which are in reality possibility in relation to the descending chain and being in relation to the ascending chain, then the pearls of the seas of physical earth from the beginning of determination to the end of the stations which God hath desired in the Book, and created by His command above the dust unto that which terminateth in the moist earth and the impenetrable, pitch-black, blind darkness.

Then from the forty-sixth letter, the letter Ha: the permitted things of this religion which are permitted until the Day of Resurrection; then the forbidden things of that religion which are forbidden until the Day of Resurrection; then the judgment of justice for whomsoever God willeth; then the judgment of grace for whomsoever God desireth—glorified be God and exalted above what they describe!

Then from the forty-seventh letter, the letter Alif: the command of origins in the hidden things; then the command of origins in the manifestations of the essences of abstract realities; then the command wherewith God hath commanded all from the day of the mention of His existence unto that which hath no end from the outpouring of the All-Merciful; then the command of God which descendeth thereafter and whereby is established the judgment of religion as before—may God hasten his relief and bring near His promise—and to this referreth His word, exalted be His mention:

> "And when Our command came, We turned them upside down, and rained upon them stones of baked clay, one after another, marked from thy Lord, and they are not far from the wrongdoers."

Then from the forty-eighth letter, the letter Ta: the soil of the grave of Husayn (peace be upon him); then the soil of the grave of his father—the blessings of God be upon him as long as the sun riseth in brilliance and setteth in departure; then the soil of the graves of the Imams of justice; then the soil of the grave of the Messenger of God—peace and blessings be upon him and his family.

Part 3: "Then from the forty-ninth letter, the letter Vav…"

Then from the forty-ninth letter, the letter Vav: the true authority in the rank of the verse of unity; then the true authority in the rank of the Will itself; then the authority attributed to the first authority which is the source of all intentions and verses and stations and relations and signs; then the authority which God hath permitted in the Book to those who follow His command and uphold His religion, for they are the wise ones of the Household and the learned ones of the school of justice—whoso recognizeth one of them, it becometh incumbent upon him to follow him and arise to serve him, for God hath made love for him love for Himself and obedience to him obedience to Himself, and none hath any way in judgment except by taking from them and following them, for he perisheth who perisheth by following others than them, and he succeedeth who succeedeth in recognizing one of them—and glorified be God above what they describe!

Then from the fiftieth letter, the letter Ta: the soil which hath been taken as permitted by the suns of infallibility and the lights of grandeur, for it is the healing for every disease and the protective talisman from every fear.

Then the fifty-first letter, the letter Vav: the authority which God hath placed in the pillars, and the Imam (peace be upon him) hath commanded certitude in recognizing them and believing in their station, as is clearly stated in the tradition of Jabir where he said, exalted be His mention, until Jabir said: "Dost thou know what recognition is? Recognition is the affirmation of unity first, then recognition of the meanings second, then recognition of the gates third, then recognition of the Imam fourth, then recognition of the pillars fifth, then recognition of the chiefs sixth, then recognition of the nobles seventh"—and it is His word, mighty and glorious: "If the ocean were ink for the words of my Lord, the ocean would be exhausted before the words of my Lord were exhausted, even if We brought the like thereof to add." And He also recited: "If all the trees on earth were pens and the sea (were ink), with seven seas behind it to add to its (supply), yet the words of God would not be exhausted. For God is Exalted in Power, full of Wisdom."

Then from the fifty-second letter are the letters of the Alif: verses of sanctification in the stations of the Divine Realm, verses of glorification in the stations of the Realm of Might, verses of praise in the evidences of sovereignty and dominion, and verses of unity in the essences of the manifestations of attributes and names in the earthly realm.

Then from the fifty-third letter is the letter Sad: the prayer of Ghadir among the prescribed prayers, then the prayer of the Day of Mubahilih, then the prayer of the Day of the Festival, then the Friday prayer which is the lord of days by the decree of the Lord of all beings, may God's blessings be upon him and his family morning and evening.

Then from the fifty-fourth letter is the letter Vav: the creative Guardianship in the inventive Temple, then the inventive Guardianship in the human Temple, then human Guardianship in the exalted station and the most distinguished form which indicated the Divine Identity and declared Divinity, then the Guardianship established over every soul according to what it has earned, which none in the realm of existence knows in reality except God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then from the fifty-fifth letter is the letter Alif: the hidden Alif, then the soft Alif, then the manifest Alif, then the non-connected Alif.

Then from the fifty-sixth letter is the letter Ba: God's trials in this worldly life for the people of Paradise, then God's trials for the people of Ridvan, then God's trials for the people of the Crimson Hill, then God's trials for the people of the Garden of Peace, and verily that bounty is from the manifestation of the abundance of trials from the All-Merciful for the people of those gardens, so ask God by His grace to ordain for the believers entry into Ridvan by His bounty and favor, for He is the Bestower, the All-Bountiful.

Then from the fifty-seventh letter is the letter Alif: the Command of God which God revealed its decree in the Qur'an where He, exalted be His mention, said "Say: The Spirit is of my Lord's Command," then the Command by which all in the kingdom of the heavens and earth stand, then the Command which God has made obligatory upon all to recognize, and it is the Command of the connected, hidden Pillar from the three Pillars mentioned in the tradition, then the Command by which God distinguishes between all things on the Day of Resurrection in truth and by it God gives to whom He wishes as He wishes, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then in the fifty-eighth letter is the letter Lam: the pearls of the seas of contingent being, then the pearls of the seas of realities, then the pearls of the seas which God created in Ridvan, then the pearls of the seas which God created on earth, and God and the water of all things bears witness to all things and He is the All-Knowing, the All-Informed.

Then the fifty-ninth letter is the letter Ha: the limit of maleness in the First Mention is the station of Will, then the limit of duality in confirming the First Mention in the station of duality, then the limit of the station of trinity in the station of Destiny for the manifestation of multiplicities and the emergence of verses and what God has made from the principles of causes to the ultimate station of names in the plane of dust, then the limit of the station of Decree and by it is distinguished the wisdom of origination, and verily when God decrees a matter, there is no averting it. And truly, modification occurs when a thing has not yet attained to the degree of its decree; otherwise nothing equals it in decisiveness.

Yet for all things there is modification in the station of its essence, which is inseparable from anything, and this is the station of the manifestation of justice that encompasses all contingent beings. None can find tranquility in anything save through the Lord of Attributes, for contingent modification is a truth in

the Book. Verily God, exalted be the glory of His grandeur and the majesty of His eternal manifestation, has not caused such modification for anyone, for through His manifestation nothing remains in the heavens or earth. Were He to will this decree for anyone, all atoms would instantly perish and nothing among created things would endure. To this refers His exalted Word in the prayer of Khidr:

> "For it comes only from Thy wrath, Thy vengeance and Thy displeasure, which neither the heavens nor the earth can withstand."

I seek refuge in God from His wrath and beseech God of His grace; verily He is the Bountiful, the Generous.

Then from the sixtieth letter, the letter Qaf, is the mention of Power which God created in the station of connection between Will and Purpose. And verily it is the mention of the ocean of Oneness which was revealed in the prayer where His exalted Word states:

> "Lord, cause me to enter the depths of the house of Thy unity and the ocean of the sea of Thy oneness."

Then Power which is in all ranks of action from the first mention to the ultimate manifestation, and upon it turn all affairs. Then Power concerning which, when the Imam was asked about it, he said: "A deep ocean—enter it not."

Then Power of which God has made incumbent upon all to know it, and it is more vast than what lies between the earth of acceptances and the heaven of receptivities. And upon all in that station is the decree that they should know that God compels no one into existence, but rather creates whatsoever He willeth, as He willeth, through what He willeth at the instant of bringing the thing into being for Himself. And verily the decree of that is the mystery of Power for whoso desires to know or to remember.

Then the sixty-first letter, the letter Vav: The Universal Authority in the presence of that Countenance which is the cause of Prophethood in its essence—the blessings of God be upon him as long as the sun of creation rises with creation and as long as the sun of invention sets with invention. Never has any eye beheld the like of Muhammad in the realm of possibility.

Then the Authority separate from that Authority which God gave to the Imams of religion and the guides of the people of certitude, whom God made in the worlds of possibility to stand in His own stead, and chose them for His mystery, and selected them for His authority, and made the knowledge of them identical to knowledge of Him, and obedience to them identical to obedience to Him, and all that is attributed to them is like what is attributed to Himself, glorified and exalted be He. None knows their station save God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then the Authority which God derived from the Second Authority and made it, through the might of His sublime authority, for the successors of His Beloved among the Prophets and Messengers. And verily through it they do, by God's leave, what they are commanded, and they disobey not God for the twinkling of an eye, and verily they are the chosen ones.

Then the Authority which God, glorified be His sublimity, has given to all contingent beings, and verily through knowledge of it they excel one another. To this refers the word of Ali, peace be upon him, where he said:

> "Verily the learned excel one another in knowledge of what is not apparent."

And to this refereth the words of Ali, who said: "Verily, the learned differ in their knowledge of that which is neither manifest nor hidden." The ways of expressing this matter differ according to the degrees, for in the first day it was the Word of Unity. Then, when the causes of the greater world had matured, God made it the Word of Prophethood. Then, when the station of religion was established thereby, God made it the station of Divine Authority. And verily it hath a station that shall be made manifest in the hidden pillar of the Word that was revealed in the tradition of its wisdom. And if thou wilt observe with the eye of reality the secret of existence, thou wilt witness the decree of the four pillars in the Perfect Word.

Therefore did the Imam say, when asked by one of the Christians about the Most Great Name: "I shall tell thee of all four. As for the first, it is There is no God but God, alone with no partner, the Everlasting.' The second is Muhammad is the Messenger of God, the sincere one.' The third is We are the Family of the House.' And the fourth is Our followers are from us, and we are from the Messenger of God, and the Messenger of God is from God."'

For this reason did the seeker say:

> "I bear witness that there is no God but God and that Muhammad is the Messenger of God, and that whatsoever he brought from God is truth, and that ye are God's chosen ones from among His creation, and that your followers are the purified, the guided ones, and unto them belongeth the end with God. And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds."

Then the Divine Authority which God hath bestowed upon all things according to their capacity, as befitteth them—and none knoweth the decree of this handiwork in the mention of Divine Authority save God, and glorified be God above what they describe.

Then from the sixty-second letter, the letter Ta: the soil of the ground of Husayn's tomb, then the soil of the ground of Kufih, then the soil of the tombs of the Imams of justice, then the soil of Medina, for excellence lieth in the degree of manifestation, not in the degree of precedence in stations that preceded the thing in the station of concealment.

Then from the sixty-third letter, the letter Vav: servitude through the signs of majesty after the removal of the veils and allusions, then servitude in the station of the sobriety of the known, then servitude in the station of the attraction of Oneness, and servitude in the station wherein Ali commanded Kumayl, when he, exalted be His mention, said in the stations of unity: "Extinguish the lamp, for the dawn hath broken."

Then the sixty-fourth letter, the letter Alif: the bounties of God for the people of the Paradise of Firdaws, then the bounties of God for the people of the Paradise of Ridvan, then the bounties of God for the people of the Garden of Eden, then the bounties of God for the Garden of Peace. And the mention of attachment to these gardens is from the manifestation of the degree of decree in the execution whereby

all manifestations in the degree of exposition are distinguished from the conditions in the station of explanation.

Then from the sixty-fifth letter, the letter Sad: the patience of the servant upon the decree of his Creator, then the patience of the servant in obedience to his Lord, then the patience of the servant in disobedience, then the patience of the servant in calamity. And for all are degrees according to what they have wrought, and verily God will recompense the doers.

Then from the sixty-sixth letter, the letter Vav: the universal Divine Authority in the degree of the Point, then the all-embracing Divine Authority in the degree of the Alif, then the Divine Authority standing over every soul in the degree of the Ba, then the Divine Authority which God hath made in the station of the sign of the unity of all things in the degree of the letter Lam. And verily that letter hath many stations, as thou knowest in the station of remembrance, while in the station of exposition it is manifest and needeth no mention in discourse.

Then from the sixty-seventh letter, the letter Alif, are the signs of the conditions of the Divine Essence in the station of essential realities, identities, individualities, and momentary states, and whatsoever God hath intended beyond these indications, tokens and allusions, and that which none can comprehend save the Lord of Names and Attributes. Then the signs of the manifestations of Will in the station of infinitudes, mysteries, and ultimate ends in their ranks unto whatsoever God, exalted be His glory, hath intended in the mention of tokens, verses, stations, indications, qualities, accidents, and momentary states, which none can comprehend save whom God willeth. Then the signs of the stations of the All-Merciful and conditions of Divine Unity and manifestations of Eternality in the essential rank of destiny and the mystery of determination, wherein the judgments of that rank do not suffice in the outward station save through inward manifestations and indications of the inmost heart, which none can comprehend save God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then the radiating, effulgent, resplendent verses which God hath created in the ranks of the oneness of worship for the orientation of beings toward the station which He hath deposited in the realities of the abstract and the essences of the material, which is not hidden from him who beholdeth the signs of first principles in the station of manifestations within the eye of multiplicity. Thus do most people associate partners with God in the station of unity, though this matter, despite its lofty station, its great significance and its glory, is nearer than the twinkling of an eye when it attaineth unto the Greatest Vision, for the servant in the moment of his orientation toward God pierceth the veils and attaineth unto the light of majesty without separation or extinction.

Verily this matter, despite the greatness of its essence and the antiquity of its identity, is easier in the rank of existence than the mention of the Intended One. May God preserve each of His servants on that path through His grace, for He is the Bestower, the Forgiving.

Then from the sixty-eighth letter, the letter Ba, is the mainland of the Divine Essence which God hath created in what He intended of the conditions of abstract essences which none among creation can comprehend. Then the mainland of Divine Unity wherein is mentioned somewhat of the aspect of limitations and infinite signs, and verily in that station there floweth not what floweth in the judgments of

the first mainland, for in the first rank is the station of pure abstraction, while in that rank it hath a mentioned identity, though it appeareth not to any save whom God willeth, due to its pure simplicity and lofty rank. Yet it is not hidden from Him from Whose knowledge nothing in the heavens and earth escapeth, and verily He is the Mighty, the All-Knowing.

Then the mainland of the Kingdom and the Realm wherein are the essential realities of pure signs and manifest tokens indicating the Command. Yet since the Command was veiled in discourse behind veils, it behooveth the wayfarer in that land to observe not the signs of abstraction therein save through the eye which God created in his highest consciousness, for in the rank of trinity true worship and unity are not possible, since the servant at the time of worship, were he to have one aspect turned toward God, one aspect turned toward himself, and one aspect turned toward the words he reciteth—making them an intermediary between himself and his Creator—he has not achieved true unity with the Truth. For the Christians said He was the third of three, and whoever does not trace back the multiple aspects to the Single Point in the station of verses, his sin is recorded in the Book of God.

Indeed God, through His subtle craftsmanship, has deposited in the essential reality of all atoms a sign of His oneness, that they might recognize His unity thereby and know Him through it, associating nothing with Him. Since people are veiled from the countenance of the Divine Essence, they cannot, in the world of multiplicity, observe the signs of unity within multiplicity itself. Therefore most people commit polytheism in the station of unity. Yet this matter, despite its lofty station, grand significance and glory, is nearer than the twinkling of an eye when connected to the Greatest Vision. For when the servant turns to God, he rends the veils and attains to the light of majesty without separation or extinction. And this matter, despite its mighty essence and eternal being, is easier in the realm of existence than mentioning the non-existent. God preserves all His servants on this path through His grace, for He is the Bestower, the Forgiving One.

Part 4: "Then know that the earth of the human…"

Then know that the earth of the human realm is the source of desires, misdeeds and sins by which the servant perishes in matters of religion. It has various ranks in this exalted station which all must understand lest they stumble in matters of doubt. Among them is the earth of the universal soul within the servant, through which the servant assumes the forms of hell or paradise as encompassed by God's knowledge. Another is the earth of nature, through which one inclines toward desires, habits, connections, associations and similar stations. Another is the earth of the ego-self which, when the servant ascends and rises to it, is a dark black darkness that will destroy him if he becomes heedless of it. The wayfarer in these stations must observe in all conditions and manifestations the revelation of the light of the Divine Essence. If anything interferes with His cause, one should obey, otherwise take refuge in one's Lord lest these temporary egos destroy him in any station.

When this matter was mentioned in the Book, its trace was detailed in the discourse so that none would be deprived of their portion, and all might witness their Creator's bounty in all their stations, signs, indications, movements, glances and thoughts, and what God has ordained for them from the beginning of causes to the end of the matter, until it connects with the deaf, dark, blind, hellish darkness. Then from the sixty-ninth letter comes the standing alif by which God established all who are in the kingdoms of

creation and command, then the alif which God made hidden in the realities of contingent beings and existence, then the alif which appeared after the Point's manifestation in the world of appearance, then the alif through which all letters are adorned in this world and through which all speak as God wills, however He wills, with what He wills. There is no repelling His command and no exhausting His wisdom. Glory be to Him and exalted is He! How mighty is His cause and how noble His station! Glory be to Him!

And exalted be His glory, high above all that they describe! Then the letter Alif, which in the letters indicates in the fifth rank from the numerical value of the letter Ha', points to God, the All-Glorious. He is the Unknowable, the Inaccessible, Who cannot be comprehended by those who dwell within the multiplicities of the Command or the signs of creation. God alone knoweth His wisdom—glorified and exalted be He above all that they associate with Him!

Then from the seventieth letter, the letter Lam is the banner of the Name "the Restrainer" in the rank of the element of fire in the realm of celestial spheres, Names and Attributes. Ha' Mim Lam is the Name "the Life-Giver" in the rank of air, whereby God giveth life to whomsoever He willeth. Then the Lam which God hath placed in the station of His Name "the Ever-Living" for the creation of contingent beings, the manifestation of hidden things, and the concealment of wills. Then the Lam which God hath placed in the rank of His Name "the Slayer" for the appearance of the seal in the ranks of beginning, from infinity unto infinity, as God willeth—glorified and exalted be He above all that they describe!

Then from the seventy-first letter, the letter Sad is the decree of the Divine Unity which was revealed in the station manifesting the signs of the Essence, that He verily hath ever been, with no mention of aught else beside Him, and will ever be as He hath been. He is the Eternal, Whose beginning is identical with His end and Whose end is identical with His beginning. No thing in contingent existence hath ever known Him, nor is there any sign of Him in the entities. He is exalted above the mention of all else, for knowledge is contingent upon association, and unity comes after the non-existence of otherness in the rank of mentioning the station.

Verily the Command in that station is the pure, absolute Unity which hath ever indicated God through the indication of establishment, not of revelation. It hath ever indicated that He is the Single, the Eternal, Whom none besides Him can comprehend, and none save Him can know His presence. For the highest abstractions of the realities of creation are, in their essence, severed from the presence of His invention, and the loftiest ranks of the substances of the station of origination are separate from the holy precincts of the station of His creative manifestation.

Glorified and exalted is He Who created all He willed as He willed from nothing, with no connection between Him and His eternity, nor any mention in any station of His causation. Exalted and sublime is His presence above anyone being able to say regarding Him "He is", for the word of identity in the highest ranks of the manifestations of Divine Unity indicateth through severance and relateth through prevention. The similitude in the realities of abstraction indicateth naught save His creation, nor in the ultimate aims of uniqueness save His invention—glorified and exalted be He above all they describe!

Then the Divine Unity which hath appeared in the station manifesting the mention of the First, indicating Him, and in every aspect being a name for Him—and it is the Name which God hath specially designated

for His Beloved and chosen for His Prophet (peace be upon him). It is not permissible for anyone in that station to mention the pure Unity except His holy presence, for He hath ever been a needy servant before His presence of Self-Subsistence, and His essential nature hath no mention save through mention itself in the station of existence. And verily apart from that, were it possible in contingent existence, He—may my spirit be a sacrifice for Him—would have been its bearer. And it is not permissible for anyone in that station to mention those Names and Attributes except after the removal of the veils and allusions.

And the attributes, except after the unveiling of the veils, the allusions, the signs and the tokens, and that which God hath ordained beyond the endings, through the infinite unto the utmost end. For without the consciousness of the heart none can comprehend that which was revealed in that Book to that most excellent being, since the consciousness of the intellect is but the first station of determination and cannot know things in their limited state. Therefore most people, when they behold that Book or learn somewhat of its inner meanings, cannot grasp the reality of the matter and speak with their tongues what followeth their desires. God is not heedless of them—their description shall be their recompense, and on the Day of Resurrection He will judge between them concerning that which they fabricated.

Then mention of the Divine Unity which God hath bestowed upon His Friend in the station of the manifestation of absolute sovereignty and universal authority, which hath ascended above all things and naught can withstand it. Verily, He is the Guide in that station unto every created thing its sustenance, and the Giver unto every possessor of right his right. And verily He beareth, by God's leave, mention of the Divine Unity in the degree of His oneness, and this station befitteth none other than Him. Glory be to God, Lord of Creation! The eye of origination hath not seen the like of ʿAli, nor is it possible in invention, and God was, beyond him, powerful over all things.

Let none be confused regarding the decree that after God's power over all things, how could there not be possible in origination the like of ʿAli. For the power by which origination is made possible is itself in the degree of the Will, and naught else is possible. All that God hath created He willed to create—it is not possible except through it. Therefore most people have become confused in understanding that exposition, but the decree, as I have indicated, is evident in thy presence, for the matter in reality correspondeth to outer forms.

Yea, in the forms of the debased, were man to imagine aught, it would be like His words, exalted be His mention: "Take not two gods," [Q16:51] for verily, that Word is the key that unlocketh the souls, and the broom that sweepeth away the cobwebs of vain imaginings; for in truth naught can be compared unto it, since he who would liken it unto aught else shall never succeed, once the tokens become subtle, the signs exalted, the symbols magnified, and the names and attributes sanctified.

Return thou not, then, save unto that which was cast forth for him who desireth to behold the realities of the stations of origination in that Book; for unto God belongeth the judgment, in the beginning and in the end.

He then made mention of the Divine Singleness (Samadaniyyah), which God hath permitted the Imams of justice to proclaim in the station of bounty. They, verily, are the guides unto God and unto His Singleness from the pre-eternity of all eternities, through that guidance which announced the appearance of the

second manifestation of Singleness after the disclosure of the first rank. None save them is allowed to utter that Name in the realm of exposition; for even as God created the Imams and made them the guardians of His own Self within the worlds of possibility and the manifestations of created forms, so likewise hath He, exalted be He, chosen from among the Names and Attributes certain most comely Words, which He hath reserved unto His own Essence, that none besides Him may utter.

Among these is His Name al-Samadaniyyah—a Name that none may reveal save to manifest His unity and the signs of His abstraction in the stations of command and creation.

And now, as I make mention of these allusive mysteries, I beseech those who look upon these Words to pronounce the decree of exposition according to the path of the people of elucidation. But should none among them comprehend the import of these intimations, and should aught of doubt find place within his heart, let him return unto God and supplicate of His grace; then let him be silent, if the meanings appear obscure unto him.

Yet the matter is manifest before Thy Presence, and needeth no exposition; and upon God is reliance in whatsoever hath been revealed from the world of being and creation unto the realm of vision.

Then from the seventy-second letter, the letter Ba, is the innermost essence of the Primal Eternity which God created by itself for itself, and made it, in the very essence of multiplicity, a sign of unity, as ʿAli (peace be upon him) indicated in his sermon on Friday and at Ghadir:

> "And I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant and His Messenger, whom He chose in pre-existence above all nations, distinct from any likeness among humankind or similitude. He established him in His own station in conveyance, since eyes comprehend Him not, nor do thoughts of mind encompass Him, yet He comprehendeth all sight, and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed."

Then the innermost essence of the Secondary Eternity in the rank of Guardianship, then the innermost essence of multiplicity in the station of Power, which is the greatest depth and the mightiest ocean and the vastest sea. Then the aforementioned innermost essence in the worlds of the abstract and material, the essential and accidental, the existential and essential qualities, the personal and temporal, the purposes and aims and ends, and what God hath created beyond these stations of the signs of the realm of divinity, the indications of the station of might, the tokens of the station of sovereignty and dominion, and the verses deposited in the essential realities of the people of the mortal realm, which none encompasseth save God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Then from the seventy-third letter, the letter Ra, is the mercy by which abstractions gained essence and materiality became real, and by which beings ascend from the stations of beginnings unto the infinite, and what God hath created beyond these stations of that which no one's knowledge encompasseth save His own hallowed Being. Then the mercy by which God originated all contingent things from nothing through pure creation and absolute origination, and the conditions which are in themselves the cause in the principles of causes for themselves by themselves, whereby realities became real and separated things united and opposites combined and essences gained essence and brilliant things shone forth, and what God intended beyond these signs of names and attributes.

Then the mercy which God hath given to the Imams of justice and the guides of the people of grace, whereby they act in God's religion as God willeth for them and aid God's religion through His words, though the idolaters be averse. Then the mercy which God originated in the station of the unity of deeds, whereby the choices of beings and the signs of all contingent things are distinguished—and this is the mercy whose outer aspect is vengeance for the wicked and whose inner aspect is mercy for the righteous, and whereby He causeth whom He willeth to enter Paradise and whom He willeth to enter the fires by God's will, glorified be He. And His mercy is not fully manifest in appearance except in that station.

And verily God hath borne His bearer Al-Hasan (peace be upon him)—may my spirit and all within the kingdom of command and creation be his sacrifice—and he giveth unto all multiplicities according to how their souls have turned and their hearts have praised, and he shall surely recompense them their due and judge between them, and not an atom's weight is hidden from His knowledge in the heavens and the earth. And verily in that station this mercy is the name of the Life-Giver, and through it the unbeliever accepts the decree of unbelief and is content with the fire in the fire through his knowledge, and likewise is the decree for the believer. And nothing can don the garment of existence except through that Universal, Effulgent, Radiant, Resplendent, Sanctified Mercy, and it is the Universal Tree whose decree God hath sent down in the Qur'an.

It hath no manifestations in the realm of the outward except through the essence of the inward. God knoweth the true decree of that mercy—glorified and exalted be He above what they describe. Then there is the mercy which God hath sent down beneath the third rank, and through it the divine decree floweth before final judgment through implementation. And in that rank there is no decree of justice except without grace when the receptacles of created things are completed in the presence of the holy bounty of Glory.

At this juncture the interpretation of each letter is ended. Verily God inspireth whomsoever He willeth with knowledge of these allusions as He willeth through what He willeth, and His command in His affairs hath no end. And verily whenever I have expounded the meanings in the letters, it is from the inner interpretation concerning which permission hath come in the traditions from the pure Imams (peace be upon them) that mention of the names which God and His friends love—if anyone were to interpret the Qur'an, he should act upon the path which God, glorified be He, hath intended. But none have been able to determine the decree of interpretation along that path, for the Balance must needs be in the hand of man, and the Standard removeth all contradictions and doubts.

And verily none but he who hath known the stations of the attributes and reached the depth of knowledge is able to interpret even a letter in the stations of the inner meaning, for God will question all on the Day of Resurrection concerning what their hands have wrought. And if anyone should expound a decree without clear proof, his shall be the sin in the Book of God. But some people, since they have not intended reality, have been unable to distinguish between forms; perchance they make judgments or interpret some aspect of the verses when God hath not permitted anyone to mention allusions, significances, signs and stations.

7. Commentary on the surah from the outward perspective

Part 1: "But now a kind of outward interpretation…"

But now a kind of outward interpretation is raised, which is that what is meant by His exalted words "By the declining day" can be understood in the station of interpretation as all manifestations of justice and aspects of grace. And one who hath not become aware of the reality of abstraction or knoweth not the decree of unity hath no station on that path, and this is what is meant by the inner meaning of the outward. And it is possible to make it the Point of existence and make the Command an action.

And when "the declining day" is interpreted by the First Remembrance, it hath numbered aspects, including the simplicity of the upright alif which relateth to the station of the Most Great Lord—may my spirit and all who are in the kingdom of command and creation be a sacrifice for Him. And verily that matter hath manifestations in the station of composition, appearances in the station of creation, verses in the station of abstraction, signs in the station of unity, evidences in the station of glorification, and names and appearances beyond that matter when the servant desireth to mention the words of the attributes or desireth to become aware of the holy lights of the manifestation of the Essence in the realm of particles.

And verily thou knowest that some manifestations become confused for the servant in the station of admixture, yet when one observeth in all ranks the aspects of Lordship in each station according to its measure, one recognizeth all ranks in the stations which God hath ordained for them. In explaining this station, some philosophers have stumbled in establishing knowledge of the Essence through mention of fixed archetypes and Simple Reality, for they failed to unveil from behind the veils of their inner mysteries the Glory of the Command and the signs of creation. Thus have souls fallen, in mentioning justice and the balance of grace, to the station of limitation.

As the Pen hath flowed in mentioning this station, I shall explain its meaning: God hath made the Will its own identity to preserve its existence, which is not mentioned except through it, and in the station of limitation it was a sign unto it in the realm of the manifestation of its essential nature. The knowledge of the Essence and Attributes mentioned by the people of infallibility—God's blessings be upon them—if the observer's gaze be fixed upon the manifestations of the signs of the Essence and tokens of the primal Attributes, and if aspect of the inner meaning be mentioned, then should man witness the stations of the First Principles, he would interpret in the word "by the declining day" all the Most Beautiful Names which God hath sent down in the Book.

The intended meaning in this station is ʿAli, for Muhammad the Messenger of God was in the station of the dawning of the Light of Manifestation, and He was the noon, while He (may my spirit be a sacrifice unto Him) was the bearer of His light itself in the afternoon prayer. The oath by His truth is the oath by the truth of God's Most Great Name, for it is the first name God chose for Himself and made it the station of His action. To this referreth the saying of al-Sadiq (peace be upon him):

> "The first that God chose for Himself was the Most High, the Great."

When “the declining day” is interpreted as Ali, it behooveth man to interpret “man” in the station of ignorance of the Universal Soul from which sins and misdeeds are differentiated. Therefore doth God station it on the Bridge on the Day of Resurrection that it might recognize the emanation of all sins from itself. Though there be differences in the meaning of the verse, there is no judgment in the station of returning to the observer’s view, for in the noble verse “and man assumed it, indeed he was unjust, ignorant,” [Q33:72] it hath been interpreted in one station as referring to Ali (peace be upon him), for he bore the guardianship and was of unknown worth and oppressed in judgment, while in another station it hath been interpreted as referring to Abu’d-Dawahi (God’s curse be upon him), for he bore in reverse the guardianship which God had forbidden him, and he was indeed unjust and ignorant.

“Man” hath specified stations: among them is man in the station of meanings, then man in the station of gates, then man in the station of Imamate, and among them is man in the station of pillars, and among them is man in the station of chiefs, and among them is man in the station of nobles.

For the latter ranks, nothing is mentioned in any station except under its rank. Just as in the atoms there are essential natures in the descending chain breadthwise and in fullness in relation to the ascending chain, likewise is the judgment in the station of bodies, for essences descend through all ranks until reaching the station of bodies. All that floweth in the station of the Essence floweth likewise in the station of Attributes and bodies. The reason why bodies of the higher rank are affected by the lower rank is due to the station of acceptance which the one of higher station willingly chooses, lest anyone be prevented from what God, exalted be His glory, has bestowed upon them.

Without doubt, had Husayn on the Day of Ashura wished to destroy all who are in earth and heaven, they would have perished through him, for the cause of all existence was naught but the decree of God which God had made him the bearer thereof. Yet despite such supreme power and exalted station, when the hosts of falsehood mustered the force of deeds possible at their stations, he—may my spirit and all who dwell in the kingdoms of command and creation be a sacrifice for him—did not withhold from them the gift which he had graciously bestowed upon them from his presence. He desired God’s good-pleasure and meeting with Him, and those stations which God, glorified be He, had promised in the hereafter.

Were it not for this, how could it be possible for the body of the Messenger of God (peace be upon him) to be simultaneously in the house of Humayra, in heaven, in paradise, in the fire, and in every place designated by a name? Indeed, even now for God’s sake his holy body is likewise. Verily, had no one wronged him—may my spirit be a sacrifice for him—his body would not have changed in this earthly life, for it was perfectly balanced to such a degree that even if endless ages and the ultimate manifestations were to pass over it, it would not change. Indeed his body—may my spirit be a sacrifice for him—was mightier than the station of abstraction of those whom God had placed beneath his rank, for that station appeared in creation through their bodies, and this is the ruling of reality.

Therefore the Proof remained alive despite what was decreed for him of numbered circumstances. Verily, had no one wronged him—may my spirit be a sacrifice for him—he would not have changed throughout ancient ages nor in times to come, but would have entered paradise in his body. However, now God’s way has proceeded differently due to what people have done to them besides Him. Had they prevented them from what God had ordained for them, they would not have been able to war against God’s friend.

But they did not prevent them from God's bounty, that their choices might be manifest and their deeds might emerge, and what God had willed for them in the Book. And verily in the outward station, although their bodies are affected by the action of steel, yet at the time of being affected they feel no pain.

Thus it is related in the traditions that when Ali removed the arrow from his foot during prayer, he did not feel it. Likewise concerning the companions of Husayn (peace be upon him), where it is related in meaning that their hearts were like snow in their longing for the Supreme Concourse and the Greatest Vision, and they were not affected by what befell their bodies, for in that station they found delight in naught save the meeting with God and His good-pleasure. Thus those who feel no pain endure all pain in God's path, hoping for His grace and seeking His good-pleasure and tranquility in the presence of His Beauty. Beyond the mention of these stations there undoubtedly flow infinite decrees unto ends which none can reckon save God, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

And all that I have indicated regarding the meaning of "man" pertains to the inner stations, while regarding the outward aspect, without doubt the human form—which is the divine temple—is as Ali (peace be upon him) said: "The human form is God's greatest proof to His creation, and it is the book written by His hand, and it is the temple built by His wisdom, and it is the gathering of all the forms of the worlds, and it is the summary of the preserved tablet, and it is the witness to all that is hidden, and it is the proof against all who deny, and it is the straight path, and it is the bridge extended between Paradise and Hell."

The meaning of His exalted mention regarding "loss" encompasses infinite degrees in all stations within its realm. Among these is the loss in the station of the unity of the Divine Essence, which occurs when the servant approaches God through the perspective of contingency and sees himself and his Lord in the station of unity in consciousness. The subtlest degree of loss lies in that station, which is the most severe of stations in the manifestation of retribution.

Among these also is the loss in the station of the unity of attributes, when the servant fails to comprehend what God has commanded regarding the laws of that station—concerning the negation of names and attributes from the holy sanctuary of the Essence, and the affirmation of the attributes of the Essence for the repose of hearts and minds in the station of the Essence without alteration in the mention of names and attributes. Rather, the Essence is knowledge, power, and life, and what is beyond that is what hearts need to affirm in the station of exposition.

The judgment over which philosophers have differed—that the attributes of knowledge and life are distinct in the station of recognition because the existence of knowledge necessitates the existence of the known, while in life this cause does not apply—stems from the limited perspective of the observer. Otherwise, just as the Essence is that life, so too is the Wise One in the station of knowledge. Just as the cause of life in the Essence needs no mention of life from creation, likewise in knowledge the servant needs no existing known thing to prove His exalted knowledge.

Some philosophers, being unable to understand that station, found themselves compelled to affirm secondary essences within the Essence—and that is polytheism in the school of God's pure family.

Whoever traverses this path without this pure approach has indeed borne the loss of the station of recognition and was thereby among the sinful.

Among these also is loss in the station of the unity of deeds. In this station, most people's feet have slipped in failing to recognize the mystery of destiny and the decree of the Ordainer. Some people have gone toward compulsion—and that is indeed loss—while others have gone toward delegation—and that is indeed loss. The one who does not suffer loss in that station is he who sees through the command between two commands and the position between two positions, who knows the stations of everyone's choices as they truly are, and who witnesses the answer in God's words "Am I not your Lord?" in the first scene at the time of address, wherein the servant witnesses in every circumstance the decree of power, the mystery of divine determination, observing the quality of opposition within the station of unity.

For how can the servant, in the very moment he is consumed by the fire of accepting unbelief, accept punishment, when reason neither consents to this nor passes judgment upon it? Likewise is the decree in this earthly life, for man, despite his knowledge of God's punishment and his certainty of His decree, persists in disobedience. None can distinguish between these stations in any way, for this is the station of man's attainment when he comprehends the mystery of the divine utterance and suffers no loss.

Among such losses is that which occurs in the station of the unity of worship, when the servant associates aught else with the worship of his Lord. The degrees of such association are more subtle than any can enumerate. The ultimate station of pure recognition is the servant's regard for himself or for that whereby he worships, for such deed gives rise to a third decree. This is akin to the saying of the Christians, whereof God hath spoken: "The Christians say: God is the third of three." Thus hath God spoken concerning the stations of men: "And most of them believe not in God without associating others with Him." He hath warned all against such association, saying in the Book: "Verily God forgiveth not that partners should be associated with Him, though He forgiveth whom He pleaseth as to all else."

Verily the path, despite its utmost delicacy and supreme glory, is exceedingly difficult, for if the servant can perform two cycles of prayer without attending to mention of self or aught else besides God, but rather turneth wholly toward the pure manifestation of the Essential Being, beside Whom naught else is mentioned, then hath he attained the pinnacle of grace and the ultimate justice. None among His creation can truly know this station, for when mention of conjunction or of aught besides His Essence occurs, it is but the trace of that rank. Though this matter may be attained by the servant in less than the twinkling of an eye, it is more difficult than all else in the stations of the four journeys.

The ultimate grace, were people capable of it, is pure identity and orientation toward His manifested countenance through Him. Beyond this is the station of pure annihilation wherein no mention of the servant remains save God's mention of Himself. Less than this God bestoweth upon whomsoever He willeth among His servants as He pleaseth. None can reverse His command or His word, and He is the Most High, the Supreme.

When thou witnesseth the decree of loss in these recorded stations, knowledge of which is incumbent upon all, likewise doth the decree flow in the verses of Prophethood and Guardianship, and in what God hath intended for mankind in the verses of His light-manifesting Ones. Verily God, glorified be He, hath

created all things in all stations in the likeness of the stations of His unity's manifestation and the signs of His glorification. He hath brought forth in man's station four ranks [fu'ad, ʿaql, nafs, jasad]:

Among them the rank of his heart [fu'ad], which is the station of the mystery of contingent being and the appearance of His Holiness the Bab's countenance in human essence. This is the station of the impenetrable unseen, which veils cannot conceal, which proofs cannot parallel, which no mention in the station of essences, identities, substances and accidents can equal, save through God's revelation thereof through it in its station of indicating that station, which is the station of the Hidden Pillar that God hath made a part of the Perfect Word, as revealed in the tradition. Therefore appeared the word of the three verses' ordinances while its mystery remained concealed, due to creation's inability to bear it in the beginning and the end. Rather, it is the fruit of origination and the ultimate purpose of the outpouring of invention in the station of man, through whom God is known and none else. Were its mystery to be unveiled, the station of the inmost of the inmost would be revealed. Whosoever knoweth it and asketh "why" and "how" hath opposed God in His judgment, disputed His sovereignty, contended with His grandeur, and incurred His wrath—his abode shall be hell, a woeful refuge for the wrongdoers.

Verily this station in man [the fu'ad] is the station of his highest consciousness, than which nothing higher is possible in contingent being. It is the station of the fourth letter of the Greatest Name mentioned in the tradition of Kazim, where he—exalted be his remembrance—said in reply to the monk as we mentioned before. Along this difficult path and arduous way, some mystics have sought to know the bearer of that Name hypothetically, just as they sought to know the three pillars of the Names. It hath an appointed time when God willeth to manifest it—the Name which when the Proof manifesteth it at the beginning of his revelation to the three hundred and thirteen companions, they flee from its exalted nature and cannot bear the apex of his Cause, until they say before his presence "Thou art not our master."

Likewise is the judgment regarding the Reality which he—may my spirit and the spirits of all in the kingdoms of command and creation be his sacrifice—shall manifest in Kufa: a scroll from the Messenger of God which he shall draw forth from his sword's hilt, written in fresh golden ink by his own hand at that time. Thus hath it been in all ranks—God hath not tested any people except through that Name, its manifestation and its mystery. For the limitations in the three pillars are not lifted from the eye of the beholder, but in that station, were the beholder to look upon that Name with limited vision, he would not see it and it would have no effect, for it indicates God through the indication with which God hath manifested Himself through it. It is the station of the ultimate outpouring of the Ancient One to bring creation into being.

Part 2: "And among these is the station…"

And among these is the station of the intellect [ʿaql]—the station which God originated in all ranks for the recognition that Muhammad, the Messenger of God, is unique in the worlds of possibility, without peer or likeness; that He standeth at the station of the manifestation of the Divine Essence in the kingdom of names and attributes; that He is the sanctified One whom none equals in the station of the Essence nor in attributes; that nothing in contingent existence can be like unto His presence, for all that is possible therein God hath originated through Him for Himself; that He hath power over all things and nothing in the heavens or earth can frustrate Him—verily He is the Mighty, the Wise.

And among these is the station of the soul [nafs] for the manifestation of thirteen souls from the Tree of Prophethood, the eternal Garments, the Unity of the divine Verse, and the universal divine First Reed, according to the varying ways God manifested Himself unto them through them from the manifestations of His power and signs of His grandeur, from the eight ranks mentioned in the traditions from the Point of Knowledge of the Bayan to the final stations of man, wherein God has manifested Himself to them through the revelations of His power and the signs of His grandeur. No one can enumerate the indications of the Cause in that station, nor can anyone comprehend even some of its wisdom, for each wisdom from each soul has infinite stations and ranks as God has willed without end. However, when the servant recognizes their truth and acknowledges their grace, he becomes capable of bearing all stations and signs that God has ordained for them in the knowledge of reality and outward forms. Through that soul, the servant recognizes the signs of the Imams of Justice in the stations of Command and Creation, for from them emerged the beginnings and endings in the origins to what God has ordained in the endings.

And among these is the station of the body [jasad], which is the station of the sign of Unity, and it is the lowest of ranks in the arc of descent and the highest of ranks in the arc of ascent. Just as the body in relation to the spirit is an essential shadow, likewise in reality the bearer of the pillar of the Name related to Unity is a shadow in relation to the pillar of the Name related to the Guardianship, and likewise the Seal in Prophethood and the station of the Hidden Letter from the Concealed Pillar.

God has created these four ranks in a single Word which is itself their interpretation. The precedence of ranks in each part thereof flows through the three Manifestations, though in reality it is one Word whose beginning is only expressed through its end, its outer through its inner, and its secret through its public aspect. The very cause of agency at the beginning of action is identical to the three causes, even though in manifestation and rank it precedes those three causes. Such is the case in the stations of the four signs in man. Whoever fails to recognize one of these ranks or judges a pillar contrary to what God has ordained for it has borne loss through lack of knowledge of the reality of the secret of the Bayan and has fallen into the shadows of that blessed verse of the Qur'an. May God protect us through Muhammad and his family, verily He is the Beneficent Guardian.

When the decree of loss is established in the ranks of utterance, reference is made from the station of faith so all may witness the ranks of the manifestations of the Cause and the endings of the Seal as God has ordained in the Book. For man has infinite ranks that none can encompass except God and whom He wills.

Among these is the station of faith in the Essence, which is only established after the unveiling of the veils, signs, proofs, and tokens, and what God has placed beyond that in the knowledge of beginnings and endings. This is the station of which the Imam said: "We have states with God wherein we are He and He is we, except that He is He and we are we." This is the highest of the stations of faith for one who knows the truth of the Bayan. This station has many aspects, including the rank of the servant's exposition, which is the station that is only indicated outwardly through its inward reality and indicates nothing except God, glory be to Him.

This is a station wherein, when thou attainest unto it, thou shalt witness how the Divine Essence is made manifest unto thee through thine own self, at thine own level, and thou shalt behold all thy qualities

subordinate to thy deeds and the manifestations of thy command. In that station, through thee is thy self made manifest, inasmuch as God thy Lord hath revealed Himself, pointing to thine own essence, telling of thine own being, and indicating thy presence. No veils can conceal it, nor can the highest-soaring birds of hearts and verses attain unto it. This is the station of divine grace which God hath ordained for thy self, and none higher is possible at thy level. When one attaineth unto this station, one beholdeth all multiplicities beneath the light of divine unity which God hath revealed unto him at his level.

In no circumstance doth he abide save through God, for he seeth all else as limited, and pure delight in absolute reality can only be attained through reaching the mine of grandeur, whereof Ali, peace be upon him, spoke in his prayer on the day of Sha'ban: "O my God! Grant me complete severance unto Thee and illuminate the vision of our hearts with the light of their gazing upon Thee, until the sight of hearts teareth asunder the veils of light, attaining unto the Source of Grandeur, and our spirits become suspended in the glory of Thy holiness."

Among these is the station of faith which is prescribed for the servant at the level of the Throne of Unity and the Seat of Eternity, wherein all the stars are fixed. This is the station which Ali, peace be upon him, mentioned, saying: "Lord, immerse me in the depths of the sea of Thy unity," though what is intended is not this phrase but rather his words "and in the fathomless ocean of Thy oneness," which is the station of "we are we and He is He" that is mentioned in the tradition. The manifestations of that station are beyond enumeration, for beginnings in divine revelations must needs exist at every moment, and endings in ultimate goals and infinitudes are sealed at every instant.

Were the servant at any moment to witness the mystery of reality and essential faith which God hath made the foundation of all goodness and righteousness, he would not be veiled from aught, would see all multiplicities with a single eye, and no veils would conceal him in the realm of limitations. The faith of this station is but a shadow compared to faith at the higher station, and likewise is the judgment concerning deeds. But he who is heedless of the countenance of the light of the Divine Essence distinguisheth not between deeds and seeth all prayer with the same eye, though this judgment is improper in the school of the pure Family of God, peace be upon them, for the prayer performed by Ali cannot be equated in form with all prayers from all stations.

Since the station of religious obligation is the very form of the outward, how can the servant distinguish between the deeds of the believer and the unbeliever? Therefore hath God commanded the recognition of the ranks of deeds from all stations. And for him who cannot weigh the knowledge of the divine word with such balance, pure deeds cannot be distinguished from those mixed with accidental and glorified attributes. The ranks of that station in mentioning faith are inexhaustible, and God in His knowledge judgeth between all according to what their hands have wrought. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

Verily, the degrees of faith consist in belief in the pillars of prophethood and the suns of divine authority. Faith, in its stages of action and manifestations of effect, is incumbent upon all, even as al-Sadiq (peace be upon him) hath commanded regarding the principles of action, that nothing existeth in earth or heaven save through seven: through Will, Purpose, Destiny, Decree, Permission, Term, and Book. Whoso claimeth the absence of but one of these hath indeed denied the Faith.

The manifestations of these stages, through which God hath revealed Himself to all created things according to what He hath ordained for them in the manifestations of action, are where the decree hath been made binding. Thus hath it been revealed in the traditions concerning the degrees of faith, as Muhammad ibn Ya'qub Kulayni hath recorded in Al-Kafi, that God, exalted be His remembrance, hath established faith upon seven pillars: righteousness, truthfulness, certitude, contentment, fidelity, knowledge, and forbearance. He then divided these among the people. Whoso possesseth all these seven shares is perfect and complete. To some people He gave one share, to others two, to others three, until reaching seven. Then He said:

> "Place not upon the possessor of one share the burden of two, nor upon the possessor of two the burden of three, lest ye cause them to fall."

Thus did He continue until reaching seven.

In these stages, it behooveth the believer to recognize the stations of difference, that he may give unto each multiplicity according to their ranks and capacities, and what God hath ordained in the degree of their manifestation. Were the servant not to recognize the stages of faith of all and the aspects of their servitude, he would be unable to give unto each their due right, for each chain hath its right in giving. Among the people are those whom God hath placed in stations of the manifestation of Will and the mysteries of Identity. Should one give unto any of them that which is due to those who dwell beneath the shade of the Tree of Divine Authority in the rank of Purpose, he hath indeed wronged them. Thus continueth the matter until it reacheth unto the furthermost particles of multiplicities, wherein no end is mentioned in relation to their rank.

Were people to know the places of command and prohibition, none would blame another, for all would witness through their own choice their stations which God hath ordained for them in the knowledge of the unseen. None loveth save according to what his soul accepted in the world of pre-existence, and were he to be given less than that, he could not bear it, and thereby would his faith be changed to denial. Thus did the Imam indicate:

> "Had Abu Dharr known what was in Salman's heart, he would have killed him."

And Ali ibn Al-Hussein said:

> "By the Lord! There are jewels of knowledge that were I to disclose them, it would be said of me that I am of those who worship idols, and men who call themselves Muslims would deem it lawful to spill my blood, seeing as beautiful the ugliest of their deeds."

Having detailed in the mention of faith some of the stages of the abstract, material, spectral, and accidental in all ranks, I shall indicate in explaining action that it hath stations which none can enumerate save God. Among them is the action around the light of the Essence, by the Essence, for the Essence, and this is indeed the most resplendent of stations and the highest of degrees, for the servant's action is not complete in the station of Reality except that he become as one self, with no distinction between them, otherwise the deed would not be from God. This is in the station of the knowledge of the Essence, and below that it is possible in the station of Names and Attributes.

However, in the station of recognizing the Essence, if mention of another is mixed into the deed, it is not befitting to His holy and glorious court and will not ascend to the heaven of His exalted Being. This is the ruling concerning deeds in the station of particles. As for what is below that, deed is the effect and attribute of a thing, and this varies at all levels according to the different stations of beings. Though the number of worlds is mentioned as eight, this ruling differs according to the manifestations, revelations, beginnings and endings. The deeds of the people of the Bayan are in the station where God has not assigned any shadow, for their deeds are adorned by their own beings, and God has given them no sign except the sign of His manifestations in the station of Command.

Therefore the deeds of the people of that chain are of greater significance than the deeds of the people of the chain of seven, for they have found a shadow in the prison. But God has given them what He has due to the simplicity of their beings and the purity of their nearness to the holy court of their Creator. None knows their station except God and whomsoever He wills—glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

As for the deeds of the chain of seven, every deed found in the higher chain is essence in relation to the lower chain, even though all deeds in this world are equal. However, any deed that does not follow the ruling of the people of infallibility is not a deed in God's sight, but rather is a punishment from God upon its doer. For today the common people perform religious deeds according to Qur'anic laws and traditions of Muhammad in the station of existence, but their deeds are an illusory shadow in the forms of the prison, as the Imam indicated in his statement until he said:

> "And Husayn ibn Ali, that is, the ascetic worshipper, said that Ali's virtue over all creation after the Prophet would become like a flame of fire on a stormy day, while the deeds of those who reject Ali's virtue, like the caliphs—though they filled the deserts and that fire blazed in them and that wind covered them—would all be destroyed leaving nothing remaining."

And this is the truth, for the spirit of deeds in every world is the word of unity, the word of prophethood, the affairs of divine authority, and the covenant of love for the people of that authority. Whoever acts in the third station, God will not raise him to the station of mercy, for the verses of unity, prophethood and authority are a word whose manifestation is not complete except through its pillar, as the Imam declared in the tradition of the Name. The deeds of most people, even if purified from mention of multiplicities, indicate the manifestations of unity, except for those whom God wills and has taken His covenant from them and who know their own station and the manifestation of their being, except for those who will otherwise. For their deeds are the essential beings of the abstract and material realms, and whatever God wills beyond those stations of the infinite and finite. Each has a share in receiving rulings from the principles of causes to the ultimate ends.

After mentioning a drop from the explanation of deeds, I mention a ruling for good deeds to distinguish them from evil deeds in the station of attributes and names, and that each one might know the meaning of signs in the station of the Essence from the tokens in the station of attributes. And it is that the good deed is that deed wherein is sound the mention of the stations of unity, the ultimate purposes of detachment, the signs of glorification, and the evidences of praise. For if there be lacking from it the narration of any condition, it shall not be raised unto God in the reality of the matter, because the good

deed is that deed which in all its stations indicates the origins of action and the manifestations of influence.

And if a deed does not relate the third station, it is not good in the sight of God, for whosoever uniteth God through the unity of the Essence, if he doth not unite Him through the unity of deeds, he is not purely unified but rather is a polytheist. And likewise is the judgment in all good works, virtues, beneficences, pure things, and whatsoever God hath intended in the Book for all created things. And verily the ranks of that station are beyond counting, for the servant may work for God purely and sincerely in one station yet be veiled from another station, and according to the measure of his being veiled his deed is not good. And verily the root of judgment with God is in the station of the Essence, for if a servant's essence be of the clay of the highest heaven, though he commit all evil deeds, they shall not harm him after intercession; and if the matter be the reverse, though he perform all good deeds, they shall not profit him save as God willeth, even as that tradition from the suns of grandeur and majesty hath clearly stated:

> "Verily God created happiness and misery before He created His creation. Whomsoever God created happy, He never hateth him though he worketh evil—He hateth his deed but hateth not him; and if one be wretched He never loveth him though he worketh good—He loveth his deed but hateth him for what he shall become. For when God loveth a thing He never hateth it, and when He hateth a thing He never loveth it."

Part 3: "And that is the judgment of reality…"

And that is the judgment of reality in the beginning and the return, for deed is but a shadow and accident in relation to essence. For if the servant's essence be in the station of knowledge of the Essence, he is of the clay of the highest heaven, and that is the love through which God revealed Himself to him, which was revealed in the tradition: "I was a hidden treasure and loved to be known, so I created creation that I might be known." And that love in the stations of manifestation is indicated by His exalted Word: "Love for ʿAli is a virtue with which no evil deed can harm."

And if the essence be in the station of veils and intimations, it is of the clay of the lowest depth, and no deed shall profit him in the heavens or on earth, for the balance with the All-Merciful is work around the places of His Command, where the Imam (peace be upon him) indicated in interpreting His Word "For some of them wrong their own souls, some follow a middle course, and some are foremost in good works" that the wrongdoer is he who circles around his self, and the moderate one circles around his mind, and he who is foremost in good works circles around his Lord.

And the pure deed is that deed which proceedeth from the servant through the manifest appearances in the kingdom of Command and Creation, and without that straight path man cannot distinguish the conditions of those stations and separate true forms from false, and verily this is a matter that hath not been established in all regions save through the balance of the knowledge of the Book and the signs within souls and horizons, and God encompasseth all things from beyond. Nay, it is a glorious Qur'an preserved in a guarded tablet.

And verily the degrees of righteousness differ according to the manifestations of stations, among them prayer, whose stations differ according to the manifestations of times and seasons. The essence of deeds in the station of reality is the removal of the veils of glory from the countenance of the Divine Essence. The intended meaning is the Manifest Essence that hath been revealed to all through all in the stations of the Command and the ultimate manifestations of creation. Should the servant attain unto the apex of the Command, he performeth no deed save through the manifestations of the principles of the Command, which is the station of the effacement of the imagined and the sobriety of the known, and the attraction of the One toward the attribute of unity in the world of manifestation. This rank hath its own bounds, which if anyone neglecteth, he entereth the realm of veils, for whenever the servant ascendeth in station, an ego ariseth which, if he turneth unto it, would destroy him. How excellent are the words of the poet:

> "No eye exists save His eye, for the light of His eye is darkness, and whoso is heedless of this findeth in himself grief."

All that I have indicated in that station is from the station that God hath made to distinguish between Him and it, though it was His servant and creation. God hath never commanded anyone to act save through the manifestations of His supremacy in that condition, lest he be veiled from Him for less than the twinkling of an eye, and that he might behold his Lord manifest and supreme in such wise that he seeth naught else besides Him, as the Imam (peace be upon him) referred to that station in his words, saying:

> "He seeth no light save His light and heareth no voice save His voice."

May God cause me to reach the sphere of that station through His grace, verily He is the Guardian, the Beginning and the End.

The meaning of His exalted words "and enjoin one another to truth" is a reference to all degrees of manifestation upon which the name of truth hath fallen, from essences, entities, selves, egos, substances, elements, and accidents, and whatsoever God hath ordained beyond these in the knowledge of indications, stations, signs, qualities, glorifications and verses. All truth revolveth around Ali (peace be upon him) for he is the Truth in the realm of contingency, while in the station of the Essence he is the Truth with which there is no creation, and except which there is no deity, and in the station of establishing unity he is the Truth unto which nothing can be compared, all else being His creation and within His grasp, whereto the Imam indicated: "Truth and creation, with no third between them nor besides them."

When the Command descendeth from that station, truth is applied in the station of the First Remembrance in creation, which is the station of the Reality of Muhammad, who was above all truth through the reality of his entity unto which God revealed Himself through it at the time of its existence, and God alone knoweth its essence, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

Were anyone to attempt to mention the conditions of the Word of Truth, the seas of the heavens and earth would be exhausted, but sometimes falsehood is confused with truth, for were truth to be pure, none would deny it. Yet sometimes falsehood becomes confused with truth, for if truth were pure, none would deny it, and if falsehood were pure, none would believe it. But he who wishes to follow his own

desires takes something from each and mingles them together, and thus confusion arises among people. The matter proceeds from the beginning of detachment to the ultimate outpouring of creation.

In the station of reality, sometimes one may witness a countenance manifested by His appearance before him and see it with himself—this is pure polytheism according to the people of detachment. Just as mixing occurs at the beginning of subtlety, likewise truth becomes confused with falsehood, or vice versa, in the ranks of limitations and indication. If in all things the servant does not deviate from the Face of God to which the near ones turn, he is upon the straight path. But when one who speaks for God and has reached the station of detachment speaks truth, his words cannot be confused with anyone else's words. For He Who said in the Qur'an "Verily, there is no God but I" spoke words that were not the custom of any among mankind, thus showing He spoke not of Himself. Those besides Him who spoke semblances of such words bore sin knowingly while thinking they did good, as when Muhyi'd-Din al-ʿArabi wrote strange words in his Fusus until he said "I am that Holy One veiled in the Divine Sublimity." There is no doubt that for such words, if one interprets them with good intention, a meaning can be found. But I do not like interpretation—rather I beseech God concerning him as He wills, for He is the Mighty, the Exalted.

In the station of his rank, when Muhammad utters the word of truth, it is the Truth that is singular beyond similarity and likeness and sanctified above allusion and resemblance. It is the Truth through which was manifested in the kingdom of heaven and earth that God is the Evident Truth. In that station He is the Truth—the recognition of Whom God has made incumbent upon all—Who stands in God's place in the worlds of creation, Who gives from God to all as He wills what He wills. He is the Beloved to whom God said on the night of ascension: "Thou art the Beloved and thou art the Beloved One." He is the Lord whom God has preferred above all beings as He prefers His own Self, such that none knows how He is except He, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

When Truth is spoken of in the station of absolute, radiant, resplendent Guardianship, in the station of abstract form which said "My outward aspect is His leadership and my inward reality is an impenetrable mystery that cannot be comprehended"—this is the Truth mentioned in the tradition that "Truth is with Ali and Ali is with Truth, circling with it wherever it circles." Every sign of truth found in anything derives from Him, comprehends from Him, indicates Him, and ascends to Him when the rank of its selfhood disappears. Every truth that indicates God is created from His light in the realities of souls and horizons, where God, exalted be His mention, referred to Truth in the Book: "We shall show them Our signs in the horizons and in themselves until it becomes clear to them that it is the Truth."

Al-Sadiq explained this verse in Al-Misbah, until he said—may my soul be sacrificed for him: "What existence is there in your absence and presence," for the stations of remembrance of that Truth cannot be contained within contingent reality, since everything has a sign of God's truth in the station of its heart. If one is an unbeliever, He punishes him with His justice, and if one is a believer, He bestows His mercy upon him. This is God's grace which He gives to whom He pleases, and God is the Lord of great bounty.

And for the manifestations of that Truth, as revealed in the tradition, there are four stations, where the Imam said:

> "Our Cause is the Truth, and the Truth of the Truth, and it is the Outward and the inward of the Outward, and the inward of the inward, and it is the Mystery, and the Mystery of the Mystery, and the Mystery of that which is enshrouded, and the Mystery veiled by Mystery."

And likewise is the decree regarding the Suns of Prophethood and the Stars of Divine Authority, that every truth found in them exists in the Kingdom of Names and Attributes, where the Proof indicated in his prayer on the day of Rajab:

> "By Thy stations and Thy signs which suffer no suspension in any place—by them do they who know Thee recognize Thee. There is no difference between Thee and them, save that they are Thy servants and Thy creation. Their origin is from Thee and their return is unto Thee. They are supports and witnesses, defenders and protectors and guardians. Through them Thou hast filled Thy heaven and Thy earth until it became manifest that there is no God but Thee."

And there hath appeared from the signs which were explained in mention of His words—exalted be His remembrance—concerning the meanings of "and enjoin the truth", mention of His words—exalted be His glory—"and enjoin patience." And if anyone were to interpret patience as Muhammad, it would be true, as is explicitly stated in the tradition narrated from Ali (peace be upon him), and I mention the tradition for the wondrous signs and hidden significances therein, lest anyone's decree be forgotten. And it is as he (peace be upon him) said:

"Knowledge of me through Light is knowledge of God, and knowledge of God is knowledge of me. This is the pure religion, as God, glorified and exalted be He, says: And they were not commanded except to worship God, being sincere to Him in religion' through unity, which is sincerity, and His word uprightly' which is acknowledgment of Muhammad's prophethood—this is the upright religion. And His word and establish prayer'—this is my authority. So whoever accepts my authority has established prayer. This is difficult, most difficult, O Salman and O Jundab! The tested believer is he who, when anything of our Cause comes to him, his breast is expanded to accept it, and he doubts not nor wavers. And whoever says why' and how' has disbelieved.

So submit the affair to God, for we are God's Cause. O Salman and O Jundab! God has made me His trustee over His creation and His vicegerent in His earth and His lands, and has given me what describers cannot describe nor knowers know. When you know me thus, you are believers. O Salman and O Jundab! God the Exalted said: Seek help through patience and prayer'—patience is Muhammad and prayer is my authority. Therefore He said and it is' not and they are', then He said ʿexcept for the humble', thus making an exception for my people who are illumined by the light of my guidance. O Salman and O Jundab! We are God's Mystery that is not hidden, and His Light that is not extinguished, and His Blessing that cannot be requited. Our first is Muhammad, and our middle is Muhammad, and our last is Muhammad. Whoso hath known Us hath, verily, perfected the true and upright Faith.'

"O Salman and O Jundab! Muhammad and I were a light engaged in glorification before all who glorify, and shining before all creation. Then the light was divided in twain between Mustafa the Chosen and Ali the Well-Pleased. God, exalted be His glory, said to one"Be Muhammad" and to the other "Be Ali." Thus did the Prophet say "I am from Ali and Ali is from me, and none can discharge my obligations except

myself or Ali." This is referenced in His words "and our selves and your selves," indicating their unity in the realm of spirits and lights. Similarly in His words "if he dies or is killed, will you turn back," meaning if the Prophet dies or the Successor is killed, for they are one thing and one light, united in meaning and attributes though separate in body and name.

They are one thing in the spiritual realm—"you are my soul between my sides"—and likewise in the physical realm—"you are from me and I am from you, you will inherit from me and I will inherit from you, you are to me as the spirit is to the body." This is referenced in His words "send blessings upon him and greet him with peace," meaning send blessings upon Muhammad and submit to Ali's authority. He joined them in one essential body while distinguishing between them in name and attributes, saying "send blessings upon him and greet him with peace"—meaning send blessings upon the Prophet and submit to the Successor, for your blessings upon the Prophet through his Message benefit you not except through your submission to Ali's Guardian Authority.

O Salman and O Jundab! Muhammad was the Speaker and Ali was the Silent One, and in every age there must be a Speaker and a Silent One. Muhammad is the master of gathering and I am the master of resurrection. Muhammad is the warner and I am the guide. Muhammad is the master of Paradise and I am the master of return. Muhammad is the master of the Pool and I am the master of the Standard. Muhammad is the master of the keys and I am the master of Paradise and Hell. Muhammad is the master of revelation and I am the master of inspiration. Muhammad is the master of proofs and I am the master of miracles. Muhammad is the Seal of the Prophets and I am the Seal of the Successors."

Since patience exists in all ranks, it can be interpreted according to the stations God has ordained therein. If one interprets it within the seven stations of action—as multiplicities appear in each realm according to its nature—they have borne a worthy remembrance, for when the appearance of lights from the word of the people of mysteries corresponds to the judgments of the Book, it is one of the divine conditions and evidence for expanding the knowledge of the observer regarding the judgments of origin and return.

As the paths within the stations are limitless, none can enumerate the knowledge of that station, for when patience is applied to the station of prophethood, it has a meaning none should interpret within the lower chain of ranks of the gates, Imamate, pillars, and what God has ordained beyond that in what has been revealed in the traditions from the pure Imams, may God's blessings be upon them. No sooner does the sun of Will rise with creation than the sun of Purpose sets with events. Glory be to God, the Exalted! None knows His nature save Him, and He is the Mighty, the Bestower.

What I have detailed regarding the meaning of the blessed Surah, though it be from the inner paths, yet the matter in all worlds corresponds to the outer, for every mention found in contingent being has infinite aspects, being a mention from the manifestations of the light of divine authority in contingent realities and worldly manifestations.

8. Commentary on spiritual interpretations of the surah

And verily that blessed Surah hath spiritual interpretations whereby are revealed the hidden inner meanings of traditions amidst concealed trials. Among these is an interpretation at the level of inner

meanings, above which no higher is possible in the contingent world, for beyond that station no sign exists in creation. This is that the servant should observe with the eye of the heart the mystery of creation and see all the letters of that Surah as a single letter and its meanings as a single meaning, for the Command is one and God's Command is but quicker than the twinkling of an eye. This is the station of the Light wherein God was manifest in that Surah which in all its stations speaks of a single station, all its indications point to a single indication, all its meanings to a single meaning, and all its letters to a single letter.

Likewise is the decree regarding all meanings God hath ordained therein, for every meaning hath in truth a meaning. Just as the mystery of the Command flows in the first meaning through the reality of the manifestation of unity and pure detachment, so too in the second meaning, until the levels end in what hath no end in the stations of the Command and purposes which none knoweth save God, glorified be He. Verily in that station all letters point to the manifest letter of Oneness therein, and all meanings to the meaning of Divine Unity manifested thereby. In truth, in that station that Surah is a sign of the Divine Will which God made its outward identical with its inward and its beginning the same as its end, for it indicates the unity of His Most Holy Essence which testifieth that there is no God but He, the Mighty, the Exalted.

And among these in the station of Unity is the source of multiplicities and the cause of beginnings and ends in the chain of Names and Attributes. Verily in that station each letter thereof indicates the manifestation of a name from among the manifestations of the Universal Name and the divine encrypted symbol and the radiant manifest appearances, and what God hath ordained for it of names and attributes in the realm of dominion.

The meaning of "Time" [al-asr] is the Threefold Name which God chose for Himself before all names and attributes, and it is the name "'Ali".

The meaning of "man" in the station of humanity is the All-Encompassing Name, Lord of high degrees, Possessor of the Throne, Who sendeth down the Command.

And "loss" appeareth in the reflections of that Name and is the deficient one who hath lost, in the station of the manifestation of the Name of Unity, the universal manifestations. Verily if there be not in man a sign of the manifestation of aught in the realm of being and contingency, he is in the station of loss, for God hath placed in His All-Encompassing Name, which is the station of man, examples of the signs of possibility to the extent possible therein. Thus whoso manifesteth all the qualities God hath created in him entereth not under the decree of loss, but whoso concealeth a sign within himself and bringeth it not forth to the station of visibility despite his knowledge thereof hath indeed borne loss in the eyes of the people of the Bayan. And some people, through their lack of knowledge of that station, are veiled by multiplicities from the manifestation of the qualities of God's All-Encompassing Name in the station of man, where these allusions in the station of origins are not hidden from thy eminence.

Some people, due to their lack of knowledge of this station, are veiled by multiplicities from perceiving the manifestations of God's all-comprehensive Name in the station of man. As you well know, there are references to this in relation to origins and ends, including the meaning of His exalted words regarding

religion: “believe and do good works.” Indeed, this has several stations, evident to those who perceive with the light of the Source. Among these is belief at the level of explanation, to know the Essence through the Essence, as He, exalted be His glory, has described Himself.

Another is belief at the level of inner meanings, wherein the servant witnesses in the stations of the Family of God His Command, His decree, His countenance, His knowledge, and all attributes pertaining to the manifestation of His presence in the worlds of Command and Creation—such that the servant sees no light except their light, hears no mention in creation except their mention, and perceives that through them the unseen and visible realms are filled with the effulgence of the sign of the Worshipped One, that there is no God but Him, the Ever-Living, the All-Praised. Were the seas of heaven and earth to become ink for expressing the meaning of that station, they would be exhausted before a single letter of it could be revealed.

Another is belief at the level of the Gates, wherein the servant witnesses with the eye of truth in the eternal, radiant Cities that all bounty descends from them and unto them it ascends; nothing has mention except through their mention, nothing has decree except through their decree. All essences are cut off before the holy splendor of their majesty, and all signs fade at the rising of the lights of their power. God creates nothing except after its descent to that station at the level of the Gates, and nothing ascends to God except through its arrival at that station. This is the station of Universal Guardianship, of which the Messenger of God said:

> “I am the City of Knowledge and Ali is its Gate; whosoever desires to enter the City must enter through its Gate.”

Another is belief at the level of the Imamate, wherein one recognizes the Imam of one’s time as incomparable to any of God’s creation. One who dies without knowing the Imam of their time dies the death of ignorance. Though complete knowledge of the Imam by the servant is impossible, yet God has revealed Himself to all through the manifestations of the lights of the Imamate, which transcends limitation and comparison. I shall mention the description of the Imam as described by the Imam Rida in his exalted words, as reported by Abdul-Aziz ibn Muslim who said:

“We were with Rida in Merv and gathered in the mosque on Friday. They discussed the matter of Imamate and mentioned the many differences people had about it. I went to my master and informed him of people’s discussions about it. He smiled and said: O Abdul-Aziz, the people are ignorant and have been deceived about their religion. Indeed, God, exalted be His glory, did not take His Prophet until He had perfected the religion for him and revealed to him the Qur’an, wherein is the explanation of all things—clarifying the lawful and unlawful, the limits, the laws, and all that people need in its completeness.’ He said, exalted be His glory: We have not neglected anything in the Book.’ And He revealed during the Farewell Pilgrimage, which was at the end of his life: ‘This day have I perfected your religion for you and completed My favor upon you, and have chosen for you Islam as your religion.’ And the matter of Imamate is part of the perfection of religion, and he (peace be upon him) did not pass away until he had explained to his community the features of their religion, made clear their path, left them upon the straight path of truth, and established Ali as a banner and Imam.

He left nothing that the community would need except that he clarified it. Whoever claims that God, the Mighty and Glorious, did not perfect His religion has rejected God's Book, and whoever rejects God's Book is an unbeliever.

"Do you know the rank of the Imamate and its position in the community, that you would allow their choice in it? The Imamate is more majestic in rank, greater in importance, higher in position, more impenetrable in aspect, and deeper in significance than that people could reach it with their intellects, attain it with their opinions, or establish an Imam by their choice. Indeed, the Imamate is what God, the Mighty and Glorious, specifically granted to Abraham, the Friend, after prophethood and friendship as a third rank, honoring and ennobling him with them. He, exalted be His mention, indicated this saying: I will make you an Imam for mankind.' The Friend said, rejoicing in it, And from my offspring?' God, the Blessed and Exalted, said: 'My covenant does not include the wrongdoers.' This verse nullified the Imamate of every wrongdoer until the Day of Resurrection, and it remained among the pure ones.

"Then God honored him by placing it in his offspring, the people of purity and cleanliness, saying: And We gave him Isaac and Jacob as an additional gift, and We made all of them righteous. And We made them Imams, guiding by Our command, and We inspired them to do good deeds, establish prayer, and give charity, and they were worshippers of Us.' It continued in his offspring, inherited from one to another, generation after generation, until God, the Mighty and Glorious, caused the Prophet to inherit it. He, the Exalted and Most High, said: Indeed, the nearest of people to Abraham are those who followed him and this Prophet and those who believe. And God is the ally of the believers.' It was specifically his, and he (peace be upon him) entrusted it to Ali by God's command, according to what God had ordained.

"Thus it came to be in his pure offspring, whom God gave knowledge and faith, as He, the Exalted and Most High, said: And those who were given knowledge and faith will say, You remained according to the decree of God until the Day of Resurrection." So it is specifically in the children of Ali until the Day of Resurrection, as there is no prophet after Muhammad.

"How then can these ignorant ones choose? The Imamate is the station of the Prophets and the inheritance of the successors. The Imamate is the vicegerency of God and the succession of the Messenger, the position of the Commander of the Faithful, and the inheritance of Hasan and Husayn.

"The Imamate is the reins of religion, the organization of Muslims, the welfare of the world, and the honor of believers. The Imamate is the growing foundation of Islam and its lofty branch. Through the Imam comes the perfection of prayer, charity, fasting, pilgrimage, jihad, the distribution of spoils and alms, the implementation of legal punishments and ordinances, and the protection of borders. The Imam makes lawful what God has made lawful, prohibits what God has prohibited, establishes God's limits, defends God's religion, and calls to the way of his Lord with wisdom, good counsel, and conclusive proof. The Imam is like the rising sun that illuminates the world with its light while it is in the horizon where hands and eyes cannot reach it. The Imam is the radiant full moon, the shining lamp, the brilliant light, and the guiding star in the depths of darkness, vast lands, deserts, and ocean depths.

"The Imam is like unto sweet water to the thirsty, a guide to right guidance, and a deliverer from destruction. The Imam is like a warming fire in cold places for those who seek its warmth, and whosoever

parts from him is lost. The Imam is like the rain-bearing cloud, the pouring rain, the brilliant sun, the overshadowing sky, the expansive earth, the flowing spring, and the garden. The Imam is the gentle companion, the compassionate father, the tender brother, the loving mother to her young child, and the refuge of servants in calamities. The Imam is God's trusted one among His creation, His proof unto His servants, His vicegerent in His lands, the caller unto God, and the defender of God's sanctuary. The Imam is purified from sins, free from defects, singularly endowed with knowledge, characterized by forbearance, the order of religion, the might of Muslims, the frustration of hypocrites, and the destruction of unbelievers.

"The Imam is unique in his time—none can approach his station, nor equal his knowledge, nor can any substitute be found for him, nor is there any like or similar to him. He is specially favored with all excellence without seeking or acquiring it, but rather through the bestowal of the All-Generous Bestower.

"Who then can attain the knowledge of the Imam or can choose him? How far, how far from possible this is! Minds are bewildered, understanding is confused, intellects are perplexed, eyes are dimmed, the great are humbled, the wise are confused, the forbearing fall short, orators are speechless, the intelligent are ignorant, poets are weakened, writers are unable, and the eloquent fail to describe any of his station or virtue, and they acknowledge their inability and deficiency. How can he be described in his entirety, or his essence be characterized, or anything of his affair be understood, or one be found to take his place and fulfill his function? No, how could this be? He is as a star beyond the reach of those who would grasp it or those who would describe him.

"Where is choice in this matter, and where are minds in relation to this, and where can the like of this be found? Do they think this can be found in other than the family of the Prophet Muhammad? Their souls have deceived them and falsehood has deluded them. They have attempted to scale a difficult height and have fallen to the depths. They sought to establish an Imam through confused, deficient minds and misguiding opinions, which only increased them in remoteness. May God destroy them! How they are deluded! Verily, they sought to scale a height forbidding and uttered a grievous falsehood. They have strayed with a far-straying, and are fallen into bewilderment, for they abandoned the Imam though endowed with insight. Satan made fair unto them their deeds and turned them aside from the path, even though they had been among those who discern.

"They turned away from the choice of God, from the choice of the Messenger of God and of His household, unto their own choice and desire; while the Qur'an itself calleth out unto them: 'Thy Lord createth what He willeth and chooseth; no choice have they in their affair. Exalted be God above what they associate with Him.'

"And He, exalted be His glory, hath said: It is not for a believing man or woman, when God and His Messenger have decreed a matter, to have any choice in their affair.' And again: What aileth you? How judge ye? Have ye a Book wherein ye study that ye shall have therein what ye desire? Or have ye a covenant binding upon Us until the Day of Resurrection that ye shall have what ye judge? Ask them which of them will guarantee it, or have they partners? Then let them bring their partners, if they be truthful.'

“And He hath said, exalted be He: Do they not ponder the Qur’an, or are there locks upon their hearts? Or hath God set a seal upon their hearts so they understand not? Or do they say We hear,’ while they hear not? Verily, the worst of beasts in God’s sight are the deaf and dumb who understand not. Had God known any good in them, He would have made them hear, and if He had made them hear, they would have turned away in aversion.’ Or do they say ‘We hear and disobey’?

“Nay, it is the grace of God which He bestoweth on whom He willeth, and God is the Lord of great bounty. How then can they choose the Imam? The Imam is one learned, never ignorant; a shepherd who never shirks; the mine of sanctity, purity, devotion and asceticism; of knowledge and worship. He is singled out by the Prophet’s call, offspring of the pure Virgin. No flaw mars his lineage, none can match his noble descent. He is of Quraysh stock, from the summit of Hashim’s line, from the Prophet’s household, pleasing unto God. He is the most noble of nobles, branch of ‘Abd Manaf’s tree, full in knowledge, perfect in forbearance, capable in Imamate, learned in governance, his obedience obligatory, steadfast in God’s command, sincere counselor to God’s servants, guardian of God’s religion.

“Verily the Prophets and Imams are granted success by God, Who bestoweth upon them from His stored knowledge and wisdom what He bestoweth on none else, making their knowledge superior to that of their time, as He, exalted and glorified, hath said: Is he who guideth unto truth more worthy to be followed, or he who himself goeth not aright unless he is guided? What then aileth you? How judge ye?’ And His blessed and exalted words: He who is given wisdom hath been given abundant good.’ And His words concerning Saul: ‘God hath chosen him over you and increased him abundantly in knowledge and stature. God giveth His kingdom to whom He willeth, and God is All-Embracing, All-Knowing.’

“And He said to His Prophet: He hath sent down unto thee the Book and wisdom and taught thee what thou knewest not, and great hath been God’s grace unto thee.’ And He said concerning the Imams from His Prophet’s household, his kindred and progeny: Or do they envy mankind for what God hath given them of His grace? Indeed We gave to Abraham’s house the Book and wisdom, and We gave them a mighty kingdom. And of them were some who believed in it and some who turned away from it. Hell sufficeth for a burning fire.’

“Verily when God chooseth a servant for the affairs of His servants, He expandeth his breast therefor, depositeth springs of wisdom in his heart, and inspireth him with knowledge, after which he never faileth to answer, nor strayeth from the right path. Thus is he infallible, divinely supported, aided and guided, secured from error, slips and stumbling. God distinguisheth him with this, that he may be His proof unto His servants and His witness unto His creation. This is God’s grace which He bestoweth on whom He willeth, and God is the Lord of mighty grace.

> “Can they then produce one like unto him? Can their chosen one possess such attributes that they should prefer him? They have transgressed against God’s House of Truth and cast God’s Book behind their backs as though they knew not. In God’s Book is guidance and healing, yet they rejected it and followed their own desires. Therefore God hath condemned them, abhorred them and caused them to stumble. He, exalted and glorified, hath said: And who is more astray than one who followeth his own desires without guidance from God? Verily God guideth not wrongdoing folk.’ And He said: Perish they! How He hath caused their works to

fail!' And He said: 'Most hateful is it in the sight of God and in the sight of those who believe; thus doth God set a seal on every heart that is arrogant and tyrannical.' And may God's blessings and abundant peace be upon the Prophet Muhammad and his family."

Among these is the station of faith at the rank of the Pillars, who were four souls who received the divine grace from the Imam and conveyed it to all particles. Today they are Jesus and Khidr, then Idris and Elias. It is incumbent upon all today to recognize that they move through all stations of their detachment and their attributes around the light of Fatima, and that when they reach the sacred and true precinct, they cannot openly perceive the light of Fatima, peace be upon her, neither when the sun of creation rose through creation, nor when the sun of invention set through invention.

Among these is faith at the rank of the Chiefs (Nuqaba), whose number today is thirty souls, as revealed in the tradition:

"How excellent is the good station, and there is no loneliness with thirty."

But at the appearance of the Proof, their number must be three hundred and thirteen souls. They are the bearers of universal grace from the Imam through the medium of the Pillars in the mystery of contingent being, not in the station of concrete entities. The sign of their recognition is the mystery of subtlety in the station of their essence and the mystery of guidance in the station of their identity. Each of them truly has a special right from the Imam by which they are distinguished among themselves. If they wish and desire something by which the Faith would be established, they are empowered to do so through God's bounty and His vast mercy. And God is possessed of great bounty.

Among these is faith at the rank of the Nobles (Nujaba), who have no specific number mentioned in the traditions. They are the bearers of mysteries from the suns of lights, and they receive universal grace from the Imam through the medium of the Chiefs before all particles. The sign of their recognition is knowledge of the places of command and prohibition, and action around the stations of the manifestation of the Essence in the beginning and in the ultimate ends, as clarified in that well-known tradition from Jabir from Ali ibn Al-Husayn, as we mentioned before.

What has been mentioned in the explanation of faith is from the universal fundamental principles. Everything has a limit of faith which none other can bear, as revealed in the traditions from the suns of grandeur and lights:

"Our Cause is the mystery, and the mystery of the mystery, and the mystery concealed by mystery, and the mystery veiled by mystery."

There is no doubt that one who stands in a lower rank, were he to discover the manifestations of the Source for one placed above his rank, would deny it, as decreed in the tradition of Abu Dharr that if he knew what was in Salman's heart, he would have declared him an unbeliever.

To this points the saying of Ali ibn Al-Husayn (peace be upon him):

> "Indeed I conceal the jewels of my knowledge, lest the ignorant seeing knowledge should be tempted thereby. If I were to disclose it, it would be said to me: ʿYou worship idols,' and Muslim men would deem my blood lawful, considering the worst of what they do to be good."

And in this Abu Hassan preceded Husayn, and before him advised Hassan. And the people of the ranks of Paradise, each rank bears of the stations that God has ordained for contingent being what none below their rank can bear.

Verily the people of the stations of Paradise, each station beareth from the ranks which God hath ordained for contingent being that which none beneath their station can bear. Likewise is this true of the reflections of these stations, for they differ according to the differences in the stages of manifestation. Were I now to expound the reality of these stations, the discourse would be prolonged and the exposition of the matter would transcend the bounds of utterance.

The meaning of the stations of the manifestations of the Cause in His words "And enjoin one another to truth, and enjoin one another to patience" requireth the wayfarer's journey and his gaze upon the stations of the unseen and the visible. Should the word "truth" be interpreted as the station of the manifestation of Divine Unity, and "patience" as the station of the Primal First Remembrance, this is the station of Universal Primordial Prophethood, which is itself the Guardianship of God made manifest in the stage of its appearance. And if "truth" be interpreted as referring to the Guardianship and "patience" to the concealed pillar, then the meaning hath been interpreted through the mystery of reality.

All interpretations of these two words return to a single point, which is the manifestation of the Divine Essence in the station of attributes. Truth is the mention of truth in all stations of the Cause and manifestations of the Seal. Patience is that station wherein the servant attaineth unto the station of contentment, wherein he chooseth for himself naught save what God hath chosen for him, and seeth for himself no desire nor mention save what God hath ordained in station and chosen for him in the station of His mystery. Thus did Ali indicate in his prayer on the day of Sha'ban:

> "My God! Grant me complete severance unto Thee and enlighten the vision of our hearts with the light of its gazing upon Thee, until the sight of hearts rendeth asunder the veils of light and attaineth unto the Source of Grandeur, and our spirits become suspended by the glory of Thy sanctity. My God! Make me one of those whom Thou didst call and who answered Thee, whom Thou didst behold and who were thunderstruck by Thy majesty, whom Thou didst commune with secretly and who acted for Thee openly."

This is the pinnacle of the matter in the stations of the servant, whereto the Imam referred in its meaning, saying it comprises three letters: the ʿayn is knowledge of God, the ba' is separation from creation, and the dal is nearness to the Creator without how or indication. Whoso traverseth this path and in every condition circleth round its pivot, choosing for himself naught save what God hath chosen for him, and for His creation naught save what He hath chosen for Himself, hath taken his portion from the bounty of his Lord and attained unto the sacred presence ordained by his Lord's decree. Unto this station did I take up the pen in its flow. I mention in the outward station what the compiler of the Safi mentioned regarding the revelation of verses in mentioning traditions, and I ask God's pardon for what I

have mentioned in that book for that most excellent person—may God cause him to attain the ultimate of his desires in the decrees of his Beginning unto the Day of Return.

The compiler of the Safi hath mentioned the interpretation of the blessed Surah “By the declining day! Lo! man is in a state of loss”—it is said He swears by the afternoon prayer, or by the age of prophethood—“Lo! man is in a state of loss,” that is, in their strivings and the spending of their lives in their pursuits—“Save those who believe and do good works,” for they have purchased the Hereafter with this world and thus attained eternal life and everlasting felicity—“and exhort one another to truth”—the established truth whose denial is not proper, whether in belief or deed—“and exhort one another to patience”—against sins and in obedience and tribulations, and this is from the conjunction of the specific with the general.

This is a specific reference to a general principle. And in the Ikmal it is related from the Sadiq that “the time” refers to the time of the appearance of the Qa’im. “Verily man is in loss” refers to our enemies, “except such as have believed” means in our signs, “and do good works” means showing kindness to the brethren, “and enjoin on each other truth” refers to the Imamate, “and enjoin on each other patience” refers to the Family. And al-Qummi relates from him saying that He made an exception for His chosen ones among His creation where He said “Verily man is in loss, except such as have believed” in the authority of the Commander of the Faithful, “and enjoin on each other truth”—their descendants and those who succeeded them in authority enjoined it and were patient in it. And in the Majma’ from the Sadiq and al-Qummi from Ali, they both read “By the time! Verily man is in loss” until the end of time. And in the Thawab al-A’mal and the Majma’ from the Sadiq: “Whosoever recites By the time!’ in his voluntary prayers, God will raise him on the Day of Resurrection with his face radiant, his teeth gleaming, and his eyes bright, until he enters Paradise.”

Here ends this book with the words of the All-Merciful:

> “Glorified be thy Lord, the Lord of the Throne, from that which they attribute! And peace be upon the Messengers! And praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds!”

[Q37:180-182]

BB00014: Tafsir-i-Nubuvvat-i-Khassih (Treatise on Specific Prophethood)

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

1. Introduction

Praise be to God Who made the embellishment of the Tablets of the Book of Permission the embellishment of the Point, which was designated after it was willed, ordained before it was decreed, permitted when it was appointed, and made firm. Through it shone forth the essential realities of beings that radiate in the truths of the people of the Divine Realm, that all created things might know, in the station of the recognition of attributes, through God’s manifestation in the station of recognition of the appearance of the Divine Essence, that verily there is no God but Him. In the eternity of eternities, there

was none beside Him in station, nor is it possible in the realm of contingent being to make mention of His Self, for His Essential Reality is the pure, uncompounded Reality that, by its very being, severs all beginnings from the station of recognition and blocks all paths of signs from the station of utterance.

For as it is in itself, none can know its reality, nor describe its eternity, nor characterize its absolute independence, since all else came into being in the realm of possibility through creation and were endowed with existence in the station of being through invention. Glorified and exalted is He! He has ever been His own describer of His Self, and His Essence the unifier of His Essence. None knoweth how He is except Him. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

Praise be to God Who brought into being all that He willed through His command, and placed within the realities of abstract beings a sign of His eternity, a geometry from the station of His will, and an indication in the station of His mercy, that all things might reverberate in the worlds of names and attributes through the reverberation of the manifestations of the signs of His Self-Subsistence in the world of abstract realities, and the conditions of the manifestations of justice and grace in the stations of earthly and heavenly dominion. This was so that none might be veiled in any station from the manifestation of His blessed Countenance, but might see Him evident and existing, that there is no God but Him, living in the reality of the Essence and self-subsisting in the essential nature of attributes.

Verily, such is the loftiness of His grandeur that the highest abstract summits cannot ascend to Him in the material worlds, nor can the bird of hearts fly to the holy atmosphere of His sanctity from the manifestations in the worlds of universals.

Glorified and exalted is He! The presence of His Self-Subsistence is too majestic and elevated for any contingent being to reach, or for any to know His Essence in any station, or to describe His Self in any realm of signs. Glorified and exalted is He! Whosoever claims to know the essence of His being has indeed followed the path of impossibility, for this cannot be achieved even at the ultimate heights of elevation. For knowledge is a branch of conjunction, and He, exalted be His mention, has never been conjoined with His creation, nor can He be described through His servants, nor characterized through the manifestation of His creation. For as He is in Himself, He is bounded by the bounds of origination and characterized by the conditions of creation, and indicates in every aspect only His limitation, and relates in every station only His powerlessness. For the similitude in the realities of manifestations of dominion can only indicate the severance of the way, and the manifestations in the essential realities of material things of the heavenly kingdom can only relate the prevention of proof.

Glorified and exalted is He! Whosoever claims to unify Him has enumerated Him, and whosoever enumerates Him has divided Him, and whosoever divides Him has described Him with the attributes of His creation. Naught hath been associated with His Kingdom, and whoso declareth Him to be identical with aught else hath borne false witness against himself and uttered calumny in his own recognition of Him, for all references in their very essence are debarred from attaining His holy court and point in despair to the recognition of His Self-Subsistence. The essences of all stations in every world return to the station of His creation, and He, in His own Self, speaketh naught but of the limit of origination and the state of existence after the rank of non-existence before existence in the existent, and hath no way to the

recognition of the Essence of the Worshipped One—glorified and exalted be He above what they associate with Him.

Praise be to God Who hath brought into being all created things for the manifestation of His justice, that every atom of contingent beings, from the beginning of causation to the uttermost depths of impenetrable, pitch-black, blind darkness, might bear witness to that whereunto God bore witness concerning Muhammad, His Beloved, whom He chose in eternity through His knowledge above all contingent beings, selected for the station of His authority over all creation, elected for the station of His Self in performance and decree from the beginning of the world of names and attributes to the rank of ascension, and was well-pleased with him as the mystery of His mercy towards all who exist in beginnings and endings.

I bear witness that Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, is His servant whom He chose for Himself and established him in the station of the Essence, distinct from similitude among his fellow men, that all contingent beings might shine with the radiance of the manifestations of his knowledge in souls and horizons until they recognize him by how God hath preferred him above all and granted him in the beginning and return. Exalted and sublime is the mention of his Creator—no eye hath seen the like of Muhammad, the Messenger of God, in all possibility, nor can there be his like, for naught can exist in possibility except through possibility. May God reward him, on behalf of all who dwell in the kingdom of command and creation, whatsoever He willeth and hath ordained for him in all stations. Verily He is the Bestower of good things in beginning and return.

Praise be to God Who hath brought forth the concealed signs of the manifestations of His holiness in the highest consciousness of abstract realities, that they might emerge in the manifestations of the depths of divine signs and what God hath created in the thicket of might and the primal reed of the tree of dominion and kingdom, and what God's knowledge hath encompassed in the earth of humanity, through the praise of the manifestations of His power and the pillars of His unity and the signs of His uniqueness and the tokens of His sanctification—His servants whom God hath placed in the stations of command and creation in the station of His Beloved, lest anyone in the heavens and earth be veiled from recognition of their majesty, and all existing things might see them according to what God hath ordained in the Book of the stations of names and attributes, that they are honored servants who speak not before He hath spoken and who act by His command.

Praise be to God Who accepteth from His servants through His grace of their deeds whatsoever He willeth as He willeth, though He knoweth that their very existence is a sin before the sacred court of His omnipotence, and no mention of any of His creation befitteth the precincts of His holy nearness, that all might know that His way is beneficence, His custom is explanation, His path is pardon and grace, and naught in the kingdom of command and creation is too great for Him, and verily there is no God but He, the Mighty, the Exalted.

To continue: When the light of the Cause dawned forth from the court of His might and the sanctuary of His exaltation, the honored and glorified presence—he who is near unto the court of the Khan and the trusted pillar of the realm of the Sultan—may God perpetuate the shadow of His favor upon the heads of His subjects, and cause him to attain the utmost of his hopes, both at the beginning of his affairs and at

their end—addressed this servant, who abideth beneath the darkling canopy of God's mercy and care, bidding him to set forth the exposition of the mystery of Divine Unity in establishing the specific prophethood (nubuwwat al-khassih) of that eternal Sign, that divine Mystery, that heavenly Light, that merciful Remembrance, that Manifestation which shone forth in the sanctified, austere Form, in the Universal Reality, in the primal Lote-Tree of the realm of Divinity, in the radiant, mediating Mercy, in the resplendent, effulgent Countenance of loftiness, in the hallowed, luminous Temple of godliness, and in the rising, shining Garment of glory that appeared in the hidden Reality of Ahmad and the manifest station of Muhammad—may the blessings of God be upon Him and upon His kindred.

As the Sun of Beginning rose at the Beginning, and then the Sun of Ending set at the Ending, and since His Command is to be obeyed and His Decree is decisive in the realms of the Impossible, I have sought God's help and followed His command, relying upon God in revealing what He has placed in existence into manifestation.

1. The first pillar: tawhid

Know that God has eternally been free from His creation, and His creation free from Him, for He has eternally existed without anything existing beside Him, and He will forever remain as He was, with nothing mentioned at His level. For His Essence has ever indicated naught but His Essence, and His Being will forever tell of naught but His Being. All names and attributes are cut off from the precinct of nearness to His grandeur, and all signs vanish in ascending to the summit of His holy oneness, for He eternally has no description save His Essence and no attribute save His Presence. All else, in the highest stations of mystic knowledge and manifestations of expression, can only grasp their own portion and know their own stations of being, for the contingent cannot know the Essence except through what is revealed to each in the realms of names and attributes.

And since it is established that knowledge of the Eternal is impossible and unattainable, and that change cannot occur in the station of the Glorious Essence, and that creation in every station has no way to reach nearness to the Transcendent Presence, and it has been established in wisdom and confirmed in religious law that knowledge of the Eternal Essence is impossible—likewise it follows regarding creation that ascent to His holy precinct is impossible for anyone.

For that which is not mentioned in describing the stations established in descent applies equally to ascent. And in all the stations mentioned regarding Reality, detailed in the evidences of the Path, and established in the verses of Religious Law—all indicate the impossibility of knowing that Station which indicates the Essence by the Essence for the Essence, and the impossibility of ascending to the summit of the attributes. Thus is established the decree of reality.

2. The second pillar: al-nubuwwat

Mashiyyah

When that exposition is unfolded and its import established upon the balance of direct perception, it becometh clear beyond doubt that God createth whatsoever He willeth, by whatsoever He willeth, through His command; and none can turn aside His decree in any matter.

He hath brought into being the very Essence of the Primal Will (mashiyyah) for the station of His own "I-ness," the manifestation of His sustaining power, the token of His self-subsistence, and the dawning of the light of His sanctity. Verily, He created it by itself and for itself—no self preceded it, no remembrance equalled it, no attribute resembled it, no description opposed it. He made its essence identical with its own reality, and its being identical with its own identity. It is the cause of causes in the beginnings of the Command and the ends of its consummation—He hath indeed established it, in the station of the Will, as the station of His own Self.

And as it is in itself, it may not be described by names or attributes, nor encompassed by allusion or effulgence; for whatsoever is mentioned in its degree is mentioned only in the degree of its effect. That station—and unto it is the allusion in all that hath been revealed in the Book concerning the degrees of Command and the manifestations of the Seal—is the very effect of the appearance of the Primal Will within the realms of Purpose. And whatsoever is not predicated of it in the stations that signify God throughout the worlds of the abstract and the material, the ideal and the accidental, and in all realms beyond these, is but among the degrees of the manifestation of that first, original rank.

Through it do all contingent beings turn their faces toward God and by it do they apprehend the tokens of His eternity, His power, His dominion, and His majesty. Its stations, by their very essence, proclaim the splendour of His presence and the radiance of His Lordship.

Iradah

Verily, when the Command descended from the origins of the Command and the ends of consummation, and from the manifestations of justice to the plane of effect, the Purpose (iradah) came into being by itself from the loftiness of the appearance of the Will (mashiyyah), and through it were determined the determinate things, and through it were brought into existence the existences, and through it did God desire to manifest the identities of the realities, the essences, the souls and the beings. The meaning of the signs of the manifestations and the station of the essences and whatsoever occureth in the station of the revelations in that rank is that it is a sign and a shadow in relation to the rank of the Will and the manifestation of Purpose.

Through that rank are manifested the hidden depths of contingent being and the manifestations of the degrees of the archetypes. Verily, God, exalted and mighty be He, will use it as an argument against His servants on the Day of Resurrection in the station of the manifestation of the Command in the determined rank, which is the station of the recurrence of the First Mention in the rank of the manifestation of the Will.

Qadar

Verily, God, glorified be He, after the manifestation of that rank, hath made the station of the manifestation of the Will in that station, and it is in itself the station of the descent of the Will.

Then, after the manifestation of that rank, God brought into being the essence of the vast ocean of Decree (qadar) and made it, in its own station, a sign from the Purpose (iradah), and, in the station of its Essence, a sign from the Will (mashiyyah), inasmuch as its reality indicateth the unity of the manifestation of the Essence, and its identity speaketh of the limited signs in the stations of the attributes. Verily, that station in itself is the manifestation of the Will itself, and therefore there were in the station of manifestation the stations of the hidden in the station of the manifest of the hidden. Therefore did the Imam, peace be upon him, indicate that "our first one is Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, and our middle one is Muhammad, and our last one is Muhammad."

Verily, in truth, were the servant to look with the eye of the inmost heart, he would see in the third station itself the manifestation of the first, nay rather, there floweth in it like the station whereof al-Sadiq, peace be upon him, spoke in mentioning the austere Form, as related from His forefather, upon Him be peace, when He clearly affirmed the reality of Divinity within the Temple of Guardianship—that "It is not He, and yet it is not other than He."

Qada, idhn, ajal, kitab

And likewise the matter continues until it reaches the rank of decree, permission, term, and book, for all these are stations of the manifestation of the Will itself. And the mention of those seven stations, which are the stations of the manifestation of the Will—which is the Muhammadan Reality, may God's blessings be upon it—is for establishing the absolute Prophethood.

Establishing specific prophethood in its outer aspect

And the mention of those conditions was only to establish knowledge of certain stations for demonstrating the special Prophethood and the universal, radiant walayat.

And the establishment of that matter in its inner meaning proceeds through the recognition of multiple, enumerated stations. Among these:

When it is established that nothing exists except through a Creator who created it, and He is not like His servants, nor does He have attributes like His creation—for if He had the proof of creation, He would not be the Creator. And He indicates Himself to Himself only through Himself, because in the station of the indication of the Essence, if it were possible for anyone to be with Him, it would be possible for other than Him to indicate His presence. And there is no creation with Him in any station, so no one knows Him and nothing indicates His Essence, because indication would require the existence of something with Him. And if there were no existence or mention of anything in the holy presence of His grandeur, indication would not occur.

And what has been revealed in the traditions of the suns of greatness and lights: "O Thou Who hast indicated Thyself by Thyself" and his saying, peace be upon him: "My God, through Thee have I known

Thee, and Thou didst guide me to Thee and called me to Thee, and were it not for Thee, I would not have known what Thou art" and his saying, peace be upon him: "Know God through God." And in that station, in reality, there is no indication except in the station of signs, and no mention of it except in the station of tokens. And through understanding that explanation, the path of recognition becomes easy for the servant in the station of exposition.

And when the existence of the Will is established through rational proof in that manner—that everything has its manifestation in the world through it, and it is the universal cause and the essential origin, and if God did not manifest it His power would not be manifest in its rank, and if it were not manifest the decree of unity would not be established for the Essence, glory be to Him—then what I wished to explain is thereby established.

And when it is established that the likeness of the creation of the Will is rationally necessary, and no one can say "why" or "how," because whoever says that perceives the quality that was caused by the effect of the Will, then how can the decree of its essence be established by our command? And that is witnessed by those of understanding among the people of origin and return. Just as the decree of the existence of the likeness of the Will—which was the beginning of the special Prophethood and absolute Guardianship and divine lights and lordly mysteries and eternal sign—opened up, its recognition and transformation in its stations became necessary.

And since it is established by rational proof that the lower can in no wise comprehend the station of the higher save through the manifestation of that "I-ness" whereby the higher revealeth itself unto it, it followeth that the knowledge of the true, particular Prophethood cannot be attained nor affirmed by any soul. For when the servant desireth to know that station aright, it behoveth him to ponder the signs which God hath brought forth within his own being—signs that are the effulgent reflections of that universal Prophethood which shone forth from the Ahmadic Presence, upon it be the blessings of God, whence the Sun of both beginning and end hath risen.

When this criterion is established in that station, the servant recognizeth that God hath created naught save for the manifestation of His power, and that the divine outpouring hath ever been renewed from His presence and descended from His holy court, until it reached a station from which it could descend no further. Verily, the first outpouring that appeared from the Divine Will was itself the Purpose, and thus do the decrees flow unto the ultimate stations of endings and conclusions. These, as they are in themselves, have assuredly been created by God for perfection, and without doubt they could not bear what God intended for them in the contingent worlds except through descent therein and bearing the garment of this world for the recognition of its people. The bearer of Universal Prophethood, which is the Divine Will, hath descended by God's leave from the realm of its essence until it reached the station of the body, beyond which no descent was possible, for whatsoever was potential therein became manifest, and no rank of descent remained beyond it in the human station.

And when it is established through rational proof that that Point descended until it reached the station beyond which no rank is possible—a decree to which the minds of all people are bound and which none can deny in the station of recognition—for when the existence of the Divine Essence is established, there is established the existence of His Universal Self, which was the Cause of causes, and this confirmeth His

descent to the rank of the body for the perpetuation of the divine outpouring and the existence of its receptivity to the revelations of His eternality. Verily the rank of the body, while bearing the stations of beginning, is without doubt the noblest of stations and the most exalted of degrees.

Nay, the Lord's outpouring cannot reach any soul in perfection save through its appearance in the station of bodies, for what God hath placed therein potentially appeareth in actuality and manifestation, thereby establishing the decree of reality. The recognition of these stations, before establishing the Cause which was intended to be manifested, is incumbent upon the seeker thereof, for knowledge of the beginnings of the Cause and the final endings is the cause of tranquility of the heart in the station of recognizing the decree of the heart. Thus is the Cause for the stations which God hath commanded and willed in the Book for those possessed of understanding among the people of principles and return.

When there is established through rational proofs, in accordance with heavenly verses, true scientific indications, and subtle mental signs, the necessity of the existence of that Light and this Universal Soul, the specific Prophethood was established in the temple of the body of Muhammad, the Messenger of God—upon Him and His family be the blessings of God—for none was like unto Him, and the descent of the Primal Point and its appearance in the station of embodiment was not possible save in the temple wherein He was born—may my spirit and all within the kingdom of Command and Creation be a sacrifice for Him.

All have witnessed that at the time of His birth there appeared signs that were unique to His station and manifest only in relation to His rank. At the very moment His body appeared, signs of prophethood were inscribed upon His shoulder in such wise that none other could possibly attain to this mighty station.

When it was established concerning absolute and universal prophethood and primordial and eternal walayat that it was impossible for anything to descend from the realms of divine action to the uttermost limits of the world of multiplicity, which is the world of bodies, except in the form of its essence and the temple of its reality, the observer could behold in His outward physical temple and subtle element that which God had ordained at the beginning of His existence. For the manifestation of the Divine Will cannot be realized in this world except in the form in which Muhammad, the Messenger of God, peace be upon Him and His family, appeared. For the Beginning did not appear in its fullness except in the station of the Seal, and reason itself beareth witness that He Who is the source of grace in the station of the First Order cannot complete His manifestation except through a Seal after which none like unto Him shall appear.

Therefore was Muhammad, the Messenger of God, peace be upon Him and His family, the Opener of what had gone before, the Seal of what was to come, and the One Who hath dominion over all this. The mind cannot comprehend absolute, primordial, and universal prophethood, as it hath no recourse except to recognize specific prophethood in relation to that Most Great Sign in the Ahmadic Temple—may God's blessings be upon it—from the time the Sun of creation rose through creation until the Sun of invention set through invention. For the First Remembrance, whose existence is established through reason, cannot appear in the world of bodies except in the manner it appeared in the appointed year, the appointed day, and the appointed hour.

And wisdom required, in accordance with the station of Reality, as was established in the appearance of the Law, that His father's name must needs be Abdullah ibn Abdul-Muttalib ibn Hashim ibn Abd Manaf. For His manifestation, peace be upon Him and His family, from the beginning of the Cause, was naught but the manifestation of His servitude unto God, glorified be He, in the worlds of Command and Creation. And verily between names and meanings, as established in the Balance of Reality, there is an essential relationship and an intrinsic mystery through which the servant establisheth all the stations that God hath created for him. And verily His father's name was required by wisdom to be the name manifesting His station before the dawning of His message, for the station of servitude in His father was naught but through the grace of the servitude which God had placed in him. Therefore was his name related to God, although the name of the Divine Majesty had not been revealed in the Book before His birth, peace be upon Him. And verily God, through His subtle craftsmanship and mighty grace, made his name related to His Own Self, that it might serve as evidence for the mystery of the manifestation of the bearer of the light of the Divine Will.

And verily he whom God hath given expansive reach in the stations of abstraction and the manifestations of uniqueness is able to establish specific prophethood in all that is related to Muhammad, peace be upon Him and His family, even in the blackness of His eyes, for the Light of Divine Unity hath shone forth throughout His entire being in equal measure, manifest in every limb and member, and pointing, in all His states and aspects, to that same Presence which revealeth itself in the realms of the unseen and the seen. Naught thereof is concealed from the discerning eye that beholdeth the tokens of His perfections. For in the form of His physical frame—may God's blessings be upon Him and His family—none hath ever seen its like, nor is its equal possible in creation, nor can anyone doubt His special prophethood as manifested in His outward form.

As Abu Ja'far—peace be upon him—indicated in his words when asked to describe the Prophet of God, he said:

> "The Prophet of God was fair-skinned with a reddish tinge, with dark eyes and joined eyebrows, with well-proportioned limbs as though gold had been poured over his form. He had broad shoulders, and when he turned, he turned his whole body due to his dignified bearing. A line of hair extended from his chest to his navel like a streak of pure silver, and his neck unto his shoulders was like a silver vessel. When he drank, his nose would nearly touch the water, and when he walked, he moved as though descending from a height. None like the Prophet of God—may God's blessings be upon Him and His family—was seen before or after Him."

For just as His most sacred Being was, in the primal realm of action, the cause of all created things, so too was this true of His physical form, for it was itself the descent of the Primal Remembrance for the manifestation of the Sign which God had ordained. As was demonstrated on the night of His ascension through His blessed form, that which was necessary in divine wisdom to be manifest in His reality—may my spirit be a sacrifice for Him—was shown. As attested by Humayra, He was in His house, and as the All-Merciful and His angels bore witness, He was simultaneously present in all the kingdoms of the heavens

and earth in His form, body, garments and sandals, for this itself reflected naught but the all-encompassing Will and the manifestation of universal Prophethood.

None may claim that another could be like Him in this station, for the concept of sudden emergence in existence is universally acknowledged as false. Just as His uniqueness among His kind and His transcendence above all likeness and similitude was established in the worlds of abstraction, so must it necessarily be in this world, for none hath been born like unto Muhammad—may God's blessings be upon Him and His family. At the time of His birth, He manifested signs by which all knew that none could be like unto the Primal Remembrance, and even were it possible, such would necessarily have appeared. None hath spoken regarding any created being as was spoken concerning the manifestation of the Light of Unity in the Muhammadan Countenance and the Ahmadic Temple—may God's blessings be upon them.

The Sun of the Divine Essence rose, and should anyone deny His prophethood in the world of manifestation, the proof of reason through spiritual signs and the divine manifestations that appeared throughout the horizons at His appearance would compel them. For had He not appeared, there would not have appeared a form the like of which none had ever seen, nor a name by which none had ever been named, nor a successor whose name was Ali—peace be upon him.

Thus is established in the realm of proof the confirmation of prophethood in His name, for the Primal Will in the first world came into being only through the fire element of His Self, which is the Active Agent and the Pure Primordial Manifestation, and this is the station of matter in the first remembrance.

When the First Mention found existence in the material realm, the element of air was necessitated for its form and for the manifestation of the secondary cause at its level. When existence became realized, it became necessary in wisdom that there be a connection between them for the manifestation of the tertiary cause and the necessary conditions at this level. When these three were established, the mind perceived a comprehensive form indicating the fourth, which is the station of the element of earth and the final cause that is identical to the three manifestations themselves.

When it was realized in the path of truth that nothing exists except through four ranks, all the ranks of the Divine Will became manifest in creation through the name of the bearer of the special Prophethood—upon him be the blessings of God—as long as the sun of creation rose through creation and the sun of origination set through origination. For in the Manifest Name that indicates His body is established the reality of His station, which is never suspended in any place. God is known through Him in the station of manifestation. Whosoever knows Him—there is no difference between him and Him except that he is His servant and creation.

For a name like Muhammad—peace be upon him and his family—is not possible in origination, because the letter Mim is the first letter of Will (Mashiyyat). When that letter appeared in his name, it indicated that in the pillar of the element of fire, it encompasses all stations from the rank of receptivities and the accepted. For when the rank of receptivities is joined with the accepted rank, its number becomes forty, and that is the completion of the ranks that God promised Moses—peace be upon him—in the first Mount, where God, exalted be His mention, said:

> "We appointed for Moses thirty nights, and completed them with ten, so the appointed time of his Lord was completed as forty nights."

[Q7:142]

The verse has testified from God regarding the right of the first letter of His name to the rank of completion through the joining of receptivity and acceptedness. And indeed that letter in that station, when the observer looks with the eye of the heart, is known in its reality that when that number is purified from the manifestation of multiplicity, nothing remains except the letter of unity. For from the letter Mim, when the bounds of receptivity and acceptedness are taken, nothing remains except four letters which indicate the ranks of reality without which nothing can be realized in existence.

And when this letter was repeated, the second letter of His noble name appeared, for Ha has the numerical value of eight. When that letter descended, it appeared like the first letter, for those possessed of understanding know not what is there except through what is here. And in the rank of the element of fire, it is a truth with God that the letter Mim should exist for the completion of its manifestations, and in the rank of the element of air, it became necessary in wisdom that the letter Ha should exist, for when you join it with the mystery of four and the first letter, its number becomes equal to the number of letters in the word "air." And in it are holy allusions, throne-like indications, primary verses, and conclusive signs that thoughts cannot bear and to which the highest bird of vision cannot ascend, except for those whom God wishes from among the people of mysteries.

And after that letter, it became necessary in wisdom, certain in reality, and established in religious law that the final letter should be Dal, for the manifestation of the mystery of the letter Ta in the rank of earth and the manifestations of unity in the stations of the physical, for the letter Dal is among the darkened letters and is the letter of finitude and the sign of limitation in the Muhammadan station—may God's peace be upon him and his family—which indicates his primary station and speaks of the self-subsistence of his essence and the manifestation of his being. And there exists not in contingent reality any name whose final manifestation testifies to itself as does the name Muhammad—may God's peace be upon him and his family—for that darkened letter which appears at the end of his noble name represents the earthly element, that it might be exalted above the luminous letters in others. Indeed, from the influence of that letter have been realized all realizations in the kingdom of names and attributes, and have been established all essences in the throne of glory, until the divine outpouring reached, by God's leave, to the station of earth.

When it is established through the radiant proof of reason, which speaks of the verses manifested in his essence, the servant knows that the Bearer of the First Remembrance, which is the Primal Will, could not have appeared in the realm of creation except that his name be Muhammad—may God's peace be upon him and his family. For the letter of beginning, with all its ranks perfected and its manifestations complete, when it descended to the earthly station, indicated naught but the mystery of his reality. Thus appeared the letter Dal to make known the manifestation of the letter unifying Essence, Attributes, Deeds and Worship. Exalted and glorified be God's handiwork! His signs of power have appeared in all things that those who seek proof might prove the manifestation of His self-subsistence in all things, and that

none might forget His remembrance in any condition, but see Him manifest and present as on the day when nothing remembered existed with Him.

This indeed is one of the ways of establishing the special prophethood in the Muhammadan temple and the Divine Unity manifested in the Ahmadian form. All that is attributed to the station of the Essence—veils conceal it not, proofs equal it not, nor do the decrees of names and attributes match it. The light of the unity of the Essence appeared in his body—peace be upon him and his family—just as it appeared in the station of the Primal Will. Whosoever establishes through reason the obligation of unifying the Essence, Attributes, Deeds and Worship, is obliged to establish the special prophethood merely upon hearing his noble name. For when the First Remembrance was designated, the ranks of its existence appeared only in its final stations.

God has placed all the signs of the horizons within the souls. Had God not placed the signs of the horizons within the souls, the servant could not have discovered what lies in the horizons. Thus the recognition of the exposition of prophethood is established in the signs of the soul to facilitate recognition of the signs of the horizons. For reason indicates what God has placed within oneself by establishing a Creator. When one becomes certain, one must establish the Bearer of Universal Prophethood, for the eternal outpouring was never other than complete. When God wishes to create the Primal Will, it comes into being instantly by itself. God has never ceased willing except through His Will, for the Essence is not joined with His creation nor does it change in any way through His origination.

And since the universal effusion hath been established as proceeding from His creative act within the souls, it must needs be manifest likewise in the horizons. And when it is made clear that the signs of the horizons correspond to those of the souls, it becometh evident that the bearer of that universal Prophethood in the world without is he whose name is Muhammad, as was mentioned in the mystery of His name—and His father's name is ʿAbdallah. Indeed, were man to expound the mystery of reality, it would establish the land of his birth, his age, and all his circumstances. But minds cannot grasp the reality of the matter, for when the mind becomes refined and subtle it can only comprehend something limited.

The establishment of such stations is difficult for one who views things through the lens of limitation and geometry. But when the servant removes the veils of the glorious lights from the sacred court of the first determination in contingent existence and creation, he will discover the reality of the matter: that at the time when the Messenger of God—peace be upon Him and His family—appeared, all the signs of the heavens and earth were in a state of equilibrium. And verily He—may my spirit and all who dwell in the kingdoms of command and creation be a sacrifice for Him—appeared at a time when the condition of creation was at the station described by God, exalted be His glory:

> "Then We developed it into another creation. So blessed be God, the Best of creators."

Indeed, on the first day of the new creation, people's understanding was at the stage of a drop of seed, and all progressed in the first pinnacle through the ranks of the manifestations of the Prophets and Messengers, until the structure of existence was perfected and the wisdom of the greater world emerged.

God, glorified be He, desired to manifest the first light from His Self, a remembrance from His sanctity, and a sign of His oneness, so that all atoms might quiver in the station of manifestation according to what God intended for creation on the day of their emergence in this world, that each might take its portion of the knowledge of the Book according to what God had ordained in the decree of origin and return.

Establishing specific prophethood in its inner aspect

What has been thus far detailed in these allusions regarding the establishment of the specific prophethood pertains to the outer station. As for the allusion to the inner station, it has its indications and signs whereby the servant knows and discovers at the Balance, when he looks with the eye of possibility and recognizes the power of the All-Merciful in the reality of the Explanation. The Prophet—peace be upon Him and His family—who appeared on a known day is the day of the manifestation of the final determination of the Will in the rank of the inward.

Just as reason indicates the establishment of an Essence whose knowledge is pure in the station of the unity of the Essence, it also indicates the establishment of that Light shining from the horizon of heaven at the time when it rose and shone forth. When asked about His excellence over other created beings, He said:

> "I was the first to answer in the primary World of Spirits."

This refers to the station of creation, then to whoever answered God in the stage of compilation.

For on the day when the body of the Messenger of God—peace be upon Him and His family—appeared in the secondary World of Spirits in this world, it was the day when the effect of the Will appeared in the primary World of Spirits. The knowledge of that station is not made clear in its reality except after recognition of the Ancient One made manifest in the rank of the Will, the recognition of the manifest pre-eternity in the station of the First Remembrance, and the recognition of perpetuity, then the recognition of eternity, then the recognition of time. Therefore it was indicated by His evidences that the mention of pre-existence and pre-eternity are applied according to the different stations, ranks and conditions.

When applied to the knowledge of the Essence, it is the Essence itself without mention of the Names and Attributes.

When applied in the station of the Act, it is perpetuity in reality according to its name, as Ali, peace be upon him, indicated in his sermon on the Day of Friday and Ghadir:

> "I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant and His Messenger whom God chose in pre-existence above all nations."

And he, peace be upon him, said: "I am the possessor of the second pre-eternity." Sometimes pre-existence is applied in the station of temporal things, as in His exalted Word: "like an old date-stalk." But the balance in the station of explanation is what I indicated—that pre-existence which has no beginning and no end is that pre-existence which is applied to the Manifestations of the signs of the Essence.

Likewise is the ruling regarding the mention of pre-eternity, for it is the Essence of the Essence by the Essence. And perpetuity is the condition of the Act, and it is a condition that has no beginning in God's knowledge nor any end, for the outpouring never ceases from the Absolute Outpourer. And if precise consideration wished to apply the ruling regarding the beginning like the end, such that no beginning would be established for the First Remembrance except itself, the ruling would be valid, but it would be difficult for hearts to encompass it.

As for time, it is that which is realized through the rising and setting of celestial spheres, and it has a beginning and an end. When man witnesses the reality of that explanation, he becomes able to recognize that at the moment when Muhammad's physical form, peace be upon him and his family, appeared in the world of time, there was the appearance of the Primal Will in the first creation.

And after that explanation, it has been established through spiritual proofs the appearance of the Prophet, peace be upon him and his family, in the year one hundred and three of the seventh millennium, and the necessity of his name and attributes which God had written for him and distinguished him with above His creation, from the obligation of night prayer and the ruling regarding women in the nine, and what God distinguished him with in the ordinances of his prophethood and the conditions of his mission, where this could not be realized except in the station to which God referred in His Book from revelation to the station about which God said:

> "While he was in the highest horizon. Then he drew near and came down, till he was two bows' length or nearer, and revealed to His servant what He revealed. The heart did not falsify what it saw. Will you then dispute with him about what he saw? And certainly he saw Him in another descent, at the Lote-tree of the Ultimate Boundary near which is the Garden of Abode, when that which covers covered the Lote-tree. The eye did not swerve, nor did it stray. Certainly he saw of the greatest signs of his Lord."

And by rational proof, no leap was possible after knowledge of his appearance in this world, for negation is a branch of affirmation in this world, even if the knowledge of limitations and geometries could not encompass it.

And verily beyond these allusions, were the servant to gaze upon the station of attributes and the manifestation of divine decrees, he would be able to establish the Cause through means other than what hath been revealed in the Bayan. And whatsoever hath been detailed regarding the proof of prophethood for the Ahmadic Temple is according to the inner meaning.

Establishing specific prophethood according to the outer aspect of the inner meaning

Part 1: "As for the explanation according to the outer…"

As for the explanation according to the outer aspect of the inner meaning, it is that God, without doubt, knoweth all things at all times and hath power over all things. When He Who was named Muhammad—peace be upon Him and His family—claimed universal and eternal prophethood, and no one could prevail against His proof, there is no doubt that God was confirming what He claimed. And for those possessed of understanding, there exists no greater proof in the paths of truth, for none can question that which God

hath confirmed, even should they fail to comprehend it through their rational faculties. This is evident to all who observe with the judgment of their minds the signs within themselves and the horizonal signs around them.

And were it not for Muhammad—peace be upon Him and His family—there would be none other, for the Universal Primary Effulgence appeared in existence only as it appeared in the beginning of the Cause. The explanation of this matter hath been mentioned in the station of exposition, wherein it becometh manifest to him in whom appeareth all that God hath placed in creation. The first mention of contingent being in the rank of archetypes is the station of the First Adam. The Alif pointeth to the station of His first mention, which is the station of Pure Abstract Oneness that relateth to its Origin through itself and for itself. The Dal in the middle of the Name indicateth the manifestation of the four causes without which nothing can exist. And the Mim signifieth that his nature was kneaded from the manifestations of these causes from the four elements.

For nothing completeth its manifestations in any station except through the number forty, for the appearance of ten after thirty in the rank of union. Therefore God made the name of the First Mention ʿAdam' in accordance with what appeared in this world.

And since nothing is complete except through the manifestation of its descent, its first descent was realized from its own essence. From this did God create Eve from the First Adam for his tranquility. Therefore the numerical value of her name was fifteen, corresponding to the number of sides of the triangular form in the number of the letter Ha, which representeth Will in the principles of action. To this referreth Muhammad the Messenger of God in His saying: "I and Ali are the fathers of this community," for after the descent of the Divine Will and the determination of Purpose, multiplicities came into being from the vast ocean of Power at the time of connection.

And when these three descended, they became four, and from this God created after the triangular form the signs of the square. And there can exist no number in existence more perfect and complete than that number seven, which is the number of the hidden reeds in the thicket of the Divine Realm, whose names were Muhammad, Ali, Hasan, Husayn, Ja'far, Musa, and Fatima, may God's blessings be upon them all. When these seven descended from the world of the unseen to the world of witness, the seven reeds appeared in the world of witness.

The origin thereof is the First Primordial Atom, bearer of the special prophethood and universal guardianship. Through it God originated the seven celestial spheres of the sun, moon, Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter and Saturn.

In relation to these appeared the days of the week: Sunday for the Divine Will and for the manifestation of the sign of unity in all its stations; Monday for the Divine Purpose, the mention of Monday indicating the existence of the two spouses and the designation of the two temples; Tuesday for Divine Decree, for it is in the station of connection and the triangular form, hence in talismanic science the triangular form is established for separations and their like wherein lies proof of division and suspension; Wednesday for Divine Destiny, hence those versed in numerology establish the square form for the station of union and love, and it is the day of Husayn, peace be upon him—whosoever observes therein the mysteries of

Divine Destiny shall find it blessed in the station of harmonious unions, as the Imam, peace be upon him, explicitly stated regarding Wednesday in response to those who claimed otherwise, while those who observe therein the calamities that befell the Suns of Grandeur should not undertake novel matters requiring knowledge of the hours and wisdom of separation and proximity in the rank of manifestations; Thursday for the station of Permission, its bearer being Ja'far son of Muhammad, peace be upon them both; Friday for the station of the Appointed Time, God having made its bearer Musa son of Ja'far son of Muhammad, peace be upon them both—in this number are completed the geometric aspects of things; and Saturday for the perfection of the Cause, with explained reasons and clarified causes, being the day of Fatima, may God's blessings be upon her.

According to this exposition, it becomes evident that the bearer of the First Remembrance must, by wisdom, appear between the sixth and seventh millennium from the sixty, for after the bounds of the year which is the complete number, that Radiant Light must, by divine wisdom, appear, being the origin of the manifestations of beginning and end in stations that have no purpose except through It and no end except through It.

When it is established by rational proof that the First Remembrance, who is the First Adam and the Innovator from the nature of the primordial manifestation, appears after the six bounds which are in the station of the body—the sperm, blood-clot, lump of flesh, bones, clothing, and the final creation—blessed be God, the best of creators—then when the bounds of the greater world were completed, its structure matured, its inner nature reformed, and its outer nature purified, He appeared—may my spirit be sacrificed for Him—at the first equilibrium of the station of man. Before His appearance, God had manifested one hundred and twenty-four thousand prophets save Himself, for the manifestation of His holy lights in the aspects of limitation in the rank of the letter Vav and in the station of unity, to reform the structure of the greater world for the manifestation of the letter Ha. And all that the prophets have decreed and God has sent down from heaven, the scriptures of ordinances for them exist at the level of limitation, and in relation to that Primal Tree are but a shell. Hence the laws of the Prophets were abrogated, for the stage of the embryo could not bear the laws of the blood-clot.

Thus were the laws abrogated from Prophet to Prophet until the day when the greater world reached the station of human creation. When it attained unto the station of the first human temple, the sign of divine unity appeared and His law continued until the Day of Resurrection, with neither His law being changed nor His ordinances being altered, even though there were differences in the stages of manifestation, just as some ordinances were abrogated in the early days of His mission. And it has come in the traditions that "the Proof of God will appear with a new Book and new ordinances". This is not abrogation, rather what is meant is like the Guardianship—for if it be said that on the Day of Ghadir its reality was not fully manifested, likewise is the ruling regarding all differences that were abrogated or will later appear, for these are but manifestations of that sacred Law and none other.

When it was established in reality through the signs in the horizons, the manifestations of the soul, the celestial conditions, and the temporal conjunctions that the First Mention, bearer of universal grace, appeared in the greater worlds only after the six limiting stages (for these appeared only through the mystery of unity and the manifestation of abstraction), and before the greater world and its people

reached the station of physical embodiment which is the first stage of humanity, He—may my spirit be sacrificed for Him—did not appear. Therefore wisdom requires that His appearance, after the limitations were fulfilled, should be the first stage of the manifestations of unity in both the inner and outer worlds. Thus He—may my spirit be sacrificed for Him—appeared on Friday at noon after twelve nights had passed of the first month of ʿAyn. And by every aspect of what appeared His prophethood is proven, for Friday is the sixth day, and noon is when the eternal sun first becomes established in its center.

For this reason have the masters of the celestial sciences described that reality in terms befitting the higher world:

> "The sphere of the sun is a perfect orb of parallel surfaces, its center identical with the center of the world, corresponding to the sphere of the constellations in the zone and in the poles. Within its thickness is another like unto it, external to the center, its convex side tangent to the convexity of the first at the point of apogee, and its concave side at the point of perigee. Thus there is between them an interval of graded thickness reaching twice the distance between the two centers. The sun is fixed within the outer sphere midway between its poles, touching its two surfaces at two points. The spheres of the superior planets and of Venus likewise correspond to this order."

Now, His appearance in the month of ʿAyn al-Awwal betokeneth the perfection of the equinox of days, for the station of equilibrium pertaineth to the season of spring. And that twelve days of the month had elapsed is an allusion to the twelve suns of majesty that were to rise thereafter—centers of His command and mines of His wisdom. None other could be born under such a conjunction of royal constellations, for each degree among those celestial stations possesseth innumerable aspects and every aspect again innumerable dimensions, extending without limit.

Such are the conditions of the divine realities and the effulgent manifestations of the All-Merciful—like unto a mirror in which an image is formed, and within that image yet another image, extending without end or cessation; for the outpouring of God in every state is infinite and unfailing.

In accordance with divine wisdom it was ordained that his mother should bear him in the sacred land of Mecca, the sanctuary of God, during the days of Tashriq near the middle pillar, for the sacred precincts of God were created solely for the repose of the bearer of universal grace. The days of Tashriq allude to what is mentioned in the ordinances of Mina, and the middle pillar signifies the breaking of the middle signs in the station of determination.

Similarly, wisdom decreed that his mother's name should be Aminah, daughter of Wahb, son of Abd Manaf, son of Zuhrah, son of Kilab, son of Murrah, son of Ka'b. The numerical value of her name equals that of "Allahu Akbar," less fourteen letters, indicating her station in the four stages of unity—Essence, Attributes, Acts and Worship—in relation to Muhammad, the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, his successors and his daughter.

Likewise, wisdom ordained that his mother gave birth to him in the quarter of Abu Talib in the house of Muhammad ibn Yusuf. His father Abdullah died when he was two months old, and his mother passed

away when he—may my spirit be sacrificed for him—was four years old, for men of understanding know these matters only through what is manifest.

These allusions have stations that no pen can enumerate nor pages contain. Were I to interpret these allusions, it would exceed the balance of explanation for those who seek to understand the truth of exposition.

By virtue of divine wisdom, heavenly grace, and manifest mysteries, it was ordained that the bearer of this primary grace should receive his mission after completing forty years, remaining thereafter in Mecca for thirteen years before migrating to Medina where he dwelt for ten years. He remained in this world for sixty-three years and was taken on a Monday, after twelve nights had passed of the first month. His wives numbered nine and his children seven—three sons and four daughters—with Fatima, peace be upon her, being the last, for the cause of recording is identical with creation.

Those of understanding cannot comprehend anything in that station except through what God has ordained in the supreme realm, for the manifestation of his prophethood in this world necessarily occurred after forty years, corresponding to the letter Mim, since the clay of the first Adam was molded in the hand of power for forty mornings. This is indicated in the ranks of his own limitations through the mention of Mim, for the first remembrance came into being only through the acceptance of the station of receptivities and acceptances in its realm of possibility. Thus the mystery of eternity was not revealed until after the passing of that number, though in the eternal realm this duration was but the twinkling of an eye, yet when descended to the realm of body and limitation became forty years. Herein lie many mysteries whose time of disclosure hath not yet come, and which I do not wish to disclose. Verily, he who gazeth upon the Pole of Attributes in the Kingdom of Names and Essences beareth witness that this First Light must needs occupy the station of the Pole in relation to the thirteen Rods.

And it behooveth, in wisdom, that this divine Pole be made manifest at the time when the sun hath moved from its position, for its orbit is Venus, and there is no difference between them in astronomical science save what the people of that science have described: that it is like the orbit of the sun, except that the zones of its exterior intersect the zodiacal belt at two opposite points. It hath epicycles fixed in its exterior, which are the carriers, even as the sun is fixed therein, such that the surface of each toucheth the surface of its epicycle at two points.

Verily, if the people of observation were to desire it, they would be able to explain the Universal Prophecy and the enumerated Rods made manifest in the Temples of Guardianship by the rising of the sun on the day of his birth, in accordance with the celestial realm. And this is a mention from a letter of the number of Meem concerning what transpired before his mission.

And he tarried after his mission in Mecca for thirteen years, for the manifestation of the sacred Temples in God’s sanctuary from his own self, that all might know, in his repose upon that earth, the establishment of the mystery of Eternity in the resplendent, radiant, luminous, sanctified Temples.

And there are symbols whereby the observer may recognize the pure simplicity of manifestation in all stations of the unseen and the visible. Were I to detail all the causes in every station, nothing would

encompass it, for God's outpouring hath ever been renewed in the reality of the servant, and His effulgence in any aspect knoweth no cessation.

Part 2: "And after his emigration from God's sanctuary…"

And after his emigration from God's sanctuary, which is the station of his self in the rank of Will, it behooveth, in wisdom, that he descend upon a land whose name is City, and abide therein for ten years, because emigration from the first station is the first journey from Truth to Creation. And therein must needs be the station of Creation in the ten ranks of Manifestation, for the first station of individualization in the rank of Creation is the effect of the act of Exposition, then the Meanings, the Gates, the Imamate, then the Pillars in one station, then the Chiefs, then the Nobles in one station, then the Minerals, then the Plants, then the Inanimate—and that is the decree of the universals of the worlds.

Otherwise, were one to extend his hand in knowledge, it would be possible to mention for each cause innumerable causes. But the foundation in these allusions is the Light of the Heart, the Mystery of Creation, and the emergence of the signs of Existence in the stations of Command and the manifestations of the Seal.

Verily, if the observer of the station of the manifestation of the Essence were to associate with His Essence any description of a thing or attribute from a thing, he would have departed from the decree of the Light of the Heart, and there would befall him the decrees of the Day of Reckoning, from incidental individuations and essential substantialities, the reality of which none can comprehend except through actual knowledge and the resplendent mystery.

And verily, that is in the station of knowing the principles through the light of contingency, but not in the station of entities—for each station hath its decree in these conditions. And the mystery in these manifestations is not from a specialized knowledge of the people of Exposition; rather, man expandeth the conditions of knowledge in the station of Exposition through what he hath known of the decrees of direct witnessing. And by the appearance of his years and the hour wherein he was taken—may my spirit be a sacrifice unto him—his Prophethood was established, for in wisdom it is necessary that the bearer of the Universal Effulgence appear with the manifestations of all ranks.

And verily the number six, when it was established that it is the complete, and that ten is the completion of the rank of passivity, the number sixty was for the manifestation of the six ranks of action within the ten ranks. And the three is an indication of the station of His own Self, for when He descended from the world of the unseen to the visible realm and conveyed to all what God, the Worshipped One, had commanded, the decree of ascension became manifest, which is the third station from among the ranks of the hidden.

Therefore it became necessary in wisdom that He be taken—may my spirit be a sacrifice unto Him—on Monday, and it was in the month which appeared with the same number of nights that had passed, for the beginning is like the ending, and it is not proper for any other than Him that the day of His ending be like the beginning from His own Self. And I know not that God would manifest to anyone that He would make the day of his ascension like his descent. Glorified be God, His Creator! No eye hath ever seen the

like of the Messenger of God, peace be upon Him and His family, nor is it possible in the contingent world to find His like. Glorified be God, His Creator, above what they describe!

And when it was established in wisdom that for every manifestation that appeared in the days of His mission, nay before it, and what will appear afterward, there are signs of His universal prophethood and verses for the manifestation of His primal pure simplicity, it became necessary in wisdom that from that divine Tree should appear seven children, for when the Will descends in its manifestation it becomes seven, and verily three of them are in the station of relating the Will, and four of them are in the station of relating from the Purpose. And verily God took six of them in this world so that all might know that in the rank of descent they were neither joined nor connected to any condition. And there remained from them one blessed leaf, comprehensive, relating all their ranks, which suffereth no suspension in any station. They who have recognized her through her know there is no distinction between her and them except that she is the one who represented them, indicated them, related from them, and was an honor and remembrance for them.

And it became necessary in wisdom that her name be Fatimih—may God's blessings be upon her—and verily her number in letters, when one observes and adds to the letters of His name—peace be upon Him and His family—is forty, the number which represents the ranks of receptivity and acceptability, and three is the number for the completion of her relating from the sign of her father, her husband, and herself, that the mystery of reality might be witnessed. And there are subtle points with the people of truth which, were they to be expressed, none would see any connection between them in the station of manifestation, even though it is the cause in the stations of the unseen and the hidden.

And verily through the name of Fatimih—may God's blessings be upon her—the universal, primordial Guardianship was established for Ali—peace be upon him—and the absolute, divine Prophethood for her father—peace be upon him—for no eye in the contingent world hath seen the like of her in manifestation, and had God not created Ali—peace be upon him—there would have been no peer for her in station in the world of contingency, because Her blessed name indicates the majesty of her inward station, the grandeur of her rank and the greatness of her station. The first letter, alif, when expressed at the level of ten and multiplied by thirteen—the degree of the ten ranks which are the universal measures and holy manifestations—only leaves the letter ha, which is the last letter of her noble name, signifying her degrees of unity and indicating that all that appeared in the Ahmadic manifestation was borne by Fatima, may God's blessings be upon her, in the rank of her final name.

Therefore the realities of the Prophets and Successors came from the effusion of her light, and therefore the realities of the souls and horizons, though they are but traces of her noble form, indicate God the Glorious. Had God not made the final letter of her noble name ha, the realities of existence would not have proclaimed the unity of the Divine Essence, and God would not have been recognized at the level of attributes. This is evidence of the manifest mystery, for what the possessors of understanding know there does not correspond to the decree of reality except through what is here. It is clear to one who perceives with the light of reality that this proof is from the path of reality and knowledge of the principles of the matter in the ultimate ends of commands.

One who does not know the science of connecting reality between bounded directions cannot witness those signs and relationships and paths of conjunctions and unions in the way of proof of the special universal prophethood.

It is necessary in wisdom and confirmed in religious law that there must be for the bearer of that greatest light a trace in the station of manifestation, for it reflects all his stations in the rank of inwardness. That trace must be an influential attribute reflecting the greatness of his station and grandeur of his rank. If the trace did not indicate its source it would not be a trace.

When the mystery of the matter is established in wisdom, it is fitting that one like Fatima, peace be upon her, be a trace of that universal effusion for the manifestation of the ranks of unity in her name. In wisdom that trace must be the cause of all causes in what God created below its rank, and the last letter of its name must be ha, for God created nothing except for His unity and the manifestation of His uniqueness and acknowledgment of the stations of His grandeur and holiness.

Therefore in divine wisdom all existences must be signs for the manifestation of that letter and tokens of that word. Through her existence was established the special prophethood of Muhammad the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family. He—may my spirit be sacrificed for him—has names in the ranks of contingency; rather all names are a sign of his name and indicate his presence and reflect his glorious threshold. Indeed the Prophets and Messengers and all good are manifestations of the holy stations of his prophethood. All ranks of manifestations, when man observes them from the perspective of limitations, are confined to eight stations:

Among them is the world of exposition and pure manifestation of unity in vision, which is the world of pure simplicity and indication in the station of contingency; and among them is the station of meanings which is the station of the first determination of the first remembrance in the first world; and among its realms is the world of man; and among them the world of the jinn; and among them the world of dominion; and among them the station of minerals; and among them the station of plants; and among them the station of inanimate objects. Indeed, all the ranks of all atoms speak of naught but the manifestation of His prophethood in the kingdom of names and attributes.

And should any among the wise harbor doubts that these signs of His prophethood appeared after His manifestation, such doubts shall be dispelled through God's might and power. For it is proven by reason that there must be a center for the greater world, and that this did not reach the ultimate station of God's grace in the realm of bodies except through its descent from the beginning of worlds to the rank of physical forms. And in no less than seven thousand measures of time did that radiant light reach the station of outer reality. And the full measure manifests in the greater world through the six limitations that constitute the station of identity. When this was transcended and reached the manifestation of the light of unity in the rank wherein God made manifest Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family—whose name in heaven is Ahmad—this indeed was the mystery of the letter Mim.

For if the stations of receptivities and acceptances were to reach their central station, naught would remain save the letter Alif, and this is the reality of the matter in the mystery of His name. And His name in the earthly station is identical to His heavenly name, except that the veils were more numerous due to

the manifestation of ranks and conditions to whoever beholds with the eye of the Source the manifestation of the Essence and attributes.

And all that I have detailed in this book regarding the horizonal and personal proofs of the special prophethood pertains to the ranks of the manifestations of the Primal Point, which was the Will itself and naught else. But when one beholds the station of the manifestation of the Ahmadic Essence, one needs no proof through signs indicating His mission and the manifestation of His power. For before God sent Him forth, the manifestation of His identity was not apparent in the horizons and souls, but when He appeared in this world, the existence of creation and invention was filled with the signs of His manifestation. The path of knowledge is not difficult for the observer, for what is meant by time and the mention of "before" pertains to the station of eternity and perpetuity, not limited time.

For at the moment Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, was sent with His message, at that very moment He filled all existence with the signs of His prophethood, although before His manifestation the sign of His mission was ancient in the souls and horizons. His example is like that of a servant who asked the Imam, peace be upon him, about the ruling concerning dates, and he—may my soul be his sacrifice—answered with uncertainty that if he ate them, it was decreed in God's knowledge that he would eat them, and if he did not eat them, it was decreed in God's knowledge that he would not eat them.

Similarly was the decree on the day of His mission—when He was sent forth, it was decreed in God's knowledge that His sign was hidden in the reality of souls and horizons. And this is among the mysteries of the family of Muhammad, peace be upon them, as revealed in the tradition, that "our Cause is the mystery, and the mystery of mystery, and the concealed mystery, and the mystery veiled by mystery, and so forth."

Among the sacred signs that form the foundation for recognizing the universal Prophethood is the knowledge of the form of His name in the station of quaternity, for the bearer of the First Effulgence was not complete in his manifestation except through four stations in the station of His unity: the station of the unity of the Essence in the manifestation of the First Remembrance; the station of the unity of Attributes in the manifestation of the remembrance of Will; the station of the unity of Acts in the remembrance of Destiny; and the station of the unity of worship in the manifestation of the remembrance of Decree.

The four letters in His name—peace be upon Him and His family—indicate these universal stations. The letter Mim is the manifestation of God's name the Constrictor, in the letter Ha is the manifestation of God's name the Ever-Living, then the letter Mim is the manifestation of God's name the Life-Giver, then the letter Dal is the manifestation of God's name the Death-Giver. Thus three letters of His sacred name are from the letters of the path of truth upon your souls, while one letter is from the dark letters. If all were to ascend to the pinnacle of realities, they would not be able to recognize that dark letter, for that letter's existence was in the rank of that Name, indicating His ipseity in the stations of dominion, and in the station of ipseity it was greater than the luminous letters of all essences.

The quaternary form in the station of descent appears after the triangular form, and thus the first name God chose for Himself was the Most High, the Most Great. But in the station of ascent it appears in reverse. The triangular form is the letter of the name of the Guardian, and it is the mystery of the name of the Prophet—peace be upon Him and His family—as indicated by al-Sadiq—peace be upon him—in his words to Mufaddal. Since that tradition is among those containing the comprehensive mysteries of Prophethood and Guardianship, I shall mention it in this station that it may be a source of honor for the observers and a sign of truth for the mystics.

Part 3: "It is narrated from Mufaddal ibn Umar al-Ju'fi…"

It is narrated from Mufaddal ibn Umar al-Ju'fi who said: "I said to our master al-Sadiq—peace be upon him—the promise from him is mercy, and I had secluded myself with him and found an opportunity I had longed for to ask you, O my master, about what has occurred in my thoughts regarding the appearance of meaning in His creation in an orderly form—can the Essence be imagined or divided or partitioned or transformed from its being, or be conceived in minds through motion or stillness? And how does the Unseen appear commingled with weak creation, and how can the created behold the Creator despite the weakness of created things?

"He—peace be upon him—said: O Mufaddal, verily in the creation of the heavens and earth and the alternation of night and day are signs for those possessed of understanding [Q3:190]. O Mufaddal, our knowledge is difficult, most difficult, and our mystery is rugged, far from the tongue to express except through allusion. Our followers only know according to their understanding of us and their recognition of us. And away with one who narrates what he knows not and believes what cannot be comprehended by reason. O Mufaddal! Indeed, mere verbal profession of faith and the promise of the senses constitute mere arguments against their possessor. The Qur'an was revealed according to the principle 'I speak to thee that my neighbor may hear.' Therefore, hearken unto what is revealed unto thee, observe with the eye of thine understanding, listen with the light of thy heart, and comprehend. Thou hast asked about a momentous matter and a certain truth. I shall pose to thee a weighty question—one concerning which many have gone astray, save those whom thy Lord did favor, for He is the All-Forgiving, the All-Merciful.

"That which Al-Baqir revealed to Jabir concerning the most difficult of matters—hidden from all save the chosen few and the eloquent guardians who attained sincerity, were distinguished, witnessed the truth through their knowledge, and confirmed what they beheld with their own eyes—is as mentioned in the Book through the words of the Trusted One: 'Save those who bear witness to the Truth, and they know.'

"O Mufaddal! This matter is subtle and the mystery of this knowledge is profound. Know thou that the Divine Essence transcends all names and attributes—an impenetrable mystery that conceals not from Truth, nor can any subtle secret be hidden from it. Nothing is greater than It. It is known through Its attributes, witnessed through Its signs, and recognized through Its manifestations. It existed before the before, and before location was located, when there was no where' save Its where,' and before space when there was no space except what It created. Unto infinity It changeth not from Its state nor from Its essential being. It needeth nothing whereby It might be determined, nor can It be known through association with aught else. Rather, It is where It is and where It was, for naught existed save It.

“O Mufaddal! Know thou that manifestation is the perfection of concealment, and concealment is the perfection of silence. Manifestation, power, and might constitute the perfection of intellect. When the universals of wisdom are not complete in both their concealment and their manifestation, wisdom would be imperfect in the Wise One, even were He powerful.

“O Mufaddal! Thou didst say: ʿIncrease me in explanation, O my Master, whereby those who draw nigh may be quickened, and those who walk in Thy light and truly know Thee may draw closer.’ He, peace be upon him, said: O Mufaddal! The manifestation of the Eternal among His creation is wondrous—none knoweth this save one learned and informed. The Essence cannot be called light, for It illumineth all light. When He wished, without thought or care, to manifest Will and create Will for all things—these being the letters Mim and Shin—there shone forth from His Essence a radiant light having no end, not separate from Him. Thus did the light manifest the light of radiance to those who perceived it, and radiance manifested a shadow. He established the form of existence through the dual nature of radiance and shadow, making light its inner reality and the Essence its source. Similarly, the Name is not united with Its light. He hath not beheld His creation through His creation; and if He be hidden, He is hidden within His own Essence, within that Mystery wherein none is like unto Him—save Himself alone. Exalted, immeasurably exalted, is God, the Almighty!

O Mufaddal! Thou hast asked concerning the Will—how its Originator doth bring it forth at the first. Give ear, then, and understand what I shall recount unto thee, O Mufaddal; for thou hast inquired of a mighty matter. My Lord, the Ancient, the Pre-eternal—magnified be His remembrance—bringeth forth His Will; He hath ever been knowing thereof. That Will was an intention, without exertion, without the arising of a thought, without passing from rest to motion or from motion to rest; for power is His very nature. This is because He manifesteth the Will, which is His Name, and through it pointeth to His own Essence—not out of any need for it, nor because of any ignorance in Him.

When, by the dictates of wisdom, it appeared at His willing, the Name came into being. And this, for that He knoweth wisdom to consist in the bringing forth of that which lieth in being into the realm of outward sight. Were He not to manifest what He hath known—bringing it out from the hidden depths of His knowledge into existence, so that its meanings might become mutually disclosed—then would there be deficiency, and wisdom would not be complete. For the perfection of power is action; the perfection of knowledge is the known; and the perfection of being is that which is brought into being.

“O Mufaddal, open thy heart to the words of thy Lord and know that the Light was neither hidden within the Essence and then made manifest from It, nor manifest from It and then concealed therein. Rather, the Light emanateth from the Essence without division, is veiled in Its concealment without illumination, and shineth forth from It without separation—even as the ray from the orb and the light from the ray. Thy Lord, O Mufaddal, created the Most Great Name and the Will which brought forth the Essence. The Light was neither increased nor diminished by His creation of the Name. The Name proceedeth from the Light of the Essence without division, and Its outward manifestation, without partition, calleth unto its Lord and indicateth Its meaning. This occurreth at the transformation of every religion, for the establishment of the Proof and the manifestation of the Call, that the confessor may be confirmed in his

confession and the denier confounded in his denial. And if the Lord be hidden from the sight of His creation, they are the ones veiled by concealment and tested by the Form.

“O Mufaddal, He hath manifested through the Name the radiance of His Light and the shadow of His radiance, whereby creation hath been personified that they might behold Him, and hath guided them to their Creator that they might know Him through the Form which is the attribute of the Soul, and the Soul is the attribute of the Essence, and the Name is created from the very Essence. Therefore is It called a Soul, and for this reason are His words, exalted be He: ‘And God biddeth you beware of Himself.’ He but warneth you lest ye regard Muhammad—the blessings of God rest upon him and his family—as a created thing, for then would the Essence be temporal and created, and this is manifest unbelief.

“Know thou, O Mufaddal, that between the One and the Single there is naught save what lieth between motion and stillness, or between the Kaf and the Nun, by reason of Its connection with the Light of the Essence, subsisting through Its own being. This is referred to in His words, exalted be He: ‘Hast thou not considered thy Lord—how He hath spread forth the shadow? Had He willed He could have made it still. Then We made the sun a guide unto it.’ This signifieth what was inherent in the Essence. The most exalted Form is the radiance and the shadow, and it is that which changeth not throughout ancient ages nor in what cometh to pass in future times. Its outward aspect is the most exalted Form and its inward aspect is the spiritual reality. That Form is the substance of substances, the agent of all that is wrought, the foundation of all movements, and the cause of all causes. Beyond it there is no mystery, and none knoweth what it is save Him alone.

“Know, O Mufaddal, that the anza’iyyah Form—she who proclaimed,”My outward aspect is Imamate and trusteeship, while My inward reality is an impregnable, inaccessible Unseen”—is not the Universal of the Creator; nor is the Creator aught other than it. Nay rather, it is He in subsistence and origination, in plain sight and certitude, in determination and specification; yet it is not He in entirety, nor in aggregation, nor by enumeration, nor through encompassment.

“Mufaddal said: O my Lord, vouchsafe me a fuller, well-differentiated exposition; for by Thy bounty and favors I have come to know that whereof my tongue falls short to describe.’ He—peace be upon him—said: O Mufaddal, ask whatsoever thou dost desire.’ I said: ‘O my Lord, that Form which I beheld upon the pulpits, summoning from its own Essence unto its own Essence in a spiritual sense, and openly affirming divinity—thou didst tell me it is not the Universal of the Creator, nor is the Creator other than the two’—how can we understand the reality of this saying?’

“He replied: O Mufaddal, these are houses of light and garments of manifestation and the intimacy of worship and the mine of indication. Through them He veils you from Himself, and that is from them to Him. They are not Him, nor is He other than them. He is veiled by light, manifest through revelation. Each sees Him according to their knowledge and attains according to their capacity. Among them are those who see Him near and those who see Him far.

“O Mufaddal, verily the image is a luminous light and a powerful might—the manifestation of your Lord, a mercy to those who believe in Him and acknowledge Him. He is Muhammad, peace be upon him and his

family. He is the One, and a punishment upon those who deny and reject. Beyond Him there is no goal, nor for Him any end.

“I said: O my master, is the One who is Muhammad? He replied: The One when named, and Muhammad when described. I said: O my master, how then does the description of His name differ from the meaning? He replied: Have you not heard His saying: My outward is Imamate and succession, and My inward is an unknowable mystery? I said: O my master, what is the inner meaning of the Mim?

“He replied: The light of the Essence, which is the first of existence, the originator of creation, the former of every created thing, connected to the Light yet separate for the witnessing of manifestation. If He is distant, He is near, and if He withdraws, He responds. He is the One whom the One brought forth from His light. The One does not enter into numbers, while the One is the source of numbers and to Him is their return. He is the Hidden One.

I said: “My Lord, the Master of the Letter Mim declareth: I am the City of Knowledge, and Ali is its Gate.”’

He—peace be upon Him—answered:

> “O Mufaddal! By this he meant the ordered succession of that which hath been linked together from his light. And as to his words, and Ali is its Gate,’ they signify that he standeth at the loftiest of ranks—he is a gate unto them, and through him do they enter the City, and attain unto the knowledge of knowledge. For he is the interpreter sustained by his Lord with the knowledge of the Kingdom and the majesty of Divinity.”

Then I said:

> “My Lord, the Master of the Letter Mim also declareth: I and Ali are as these two’—yet I know not whether this meaneth to the right or to the left.”

And he brought the two forefingers close together, showing how near they were.

He said: “O Mufaddal! No measure of any one—derived from the root of knowledge—can sever between the Name and the Meaning. Yet the Meaning is above it, for it hath been called into being from the light of the Essence; and between it and the Light there is no difference and no separation. For this cause he said: I and Ali are as these two,’—a gesture unto them that know, signifying that there is herein no division. For were there a division between him and it, he would be another person apart, and this is sheer, manifest unbelief.

Hast thou not heard the saying of God, exalted be He: They seek to make a distinction between God and His Messengers’; and His saying: They cut asunder what God hath commanded to be joined’? And therein is an allusion, in the realm of acts, unto them that would say that between God and His Creator there is an intermediary. For this reason he said: I and Ali are as these two,’ because he is the dawning-place of the Names and the first who was named. Whoso apprehendeth the sign is made independent of the phrase; and whoso knoweth the stations of the Attribute hath attained the abiding-place of true knowledge.

Hast thou not heard, moreover, how the Name, by its intimations toward its Lord—openly and without veiling—declareth: “Thou art He Who removeth my grief; Thou art He Who relieveth my distress; Thou art He Who dischargeth my debt; Thou art He Who fulfilleth my promise”? Thus doth it unveil His manifest Name among His creatures; and it saith: “Thou art”—thereby pointing unto my Lord. And the sign was made to His Gate: “I am the City of Knowledge, and ʿAli is its Gate: whoso desireth the City, let him come by the Gate.”

Establishing specific prophethood according to the station of divine law

When the special prophethood was established in the depths of those words at the station of the manifestation of verses in the kingdom of names and attributes, I shall mention proofs in the station of divine law so that whoever wishes may understand the meaning of those references through those traditions descended from the suns of grandeur and glory.

From Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, who said: God, blessed and exalted, said:

> “O Muhammad! I created you and Ali as one light, meaning as a spirit without body, before I created My heavens and My earth and My throne and My sea. You continued to glorify and praise Me. Then I joined your two spirits and made them one, and it glorified and sanctified and praised Me. Then I divided it into two, and divided the two into two, so they became four: Muhammad one, Ali one, and Hasan and Husayn two, and Fatima. Then God created from the light of her beginning a spirit without body. Then the Glorified One anointed us with His right hand and His light shone within us.”

It is narrated from Abu Hamza al-Thumali who said: I heard Abu Ja’far, peace be upon him, saying: “God the Glorified revealed to Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family: ʿO Muhammad! I created you when you were nothing, and I breathed into you of My spirit as an honor from Me with which I honored you when I made obligatory upon all My creation obedience to you. Whoever obeys you has obeyed Me and whoever disobeys you has disobeyed Me. And I made this obligatory regarding Ali, peace be upon him, and his descendants whom I have chosen for Myself.”’

It is authentically narrated from Abu Ja’far, peace be upon him, who said: “Verily God, blessed and exalted, was ever alone in His oneness. Then He created Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, and Ali and Fatima. They remained for a thousand ages. Then He created all things and made them witness their creation and made their obedience flow through them and delegated their affairs to them. Thus they make lawful what they will and make unlawful what they will, but they will not will except what God wills.” Then He said: “O Muhammad! This is the religion—whoever deviates from it is lost, whoever lags behind it is destroyed, and whoever adheres to it reaches the goal. Take it to yourself, O Muhammad.”

It is authentically narrated from Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, that the Messenger of God said:

> “I am the first believer in my Lord and the first to respond when God the Glorified took the covenant of the prophets and made them bear witness against themselves: Am I not your

Lord?' They said: Yes.' I was the first prophet to say 'Yes,' thus preceding them in acknowledging God."

Jabir narrated from Abu Ja'far, peace be upon him, who said: "O Jabir! The first thing God created was Muhammad and his purified and guided Household. They were spectres of light before God. I asked:"What are spectres?" He replied: "The shadow of light—luminous forms without spirits, supported by a single spirit, which is the Holy Spirit. Through it, Muhammad and his Household worshipped God, and for this purpose He created them forbearing, knowledgeable, virtuous and pure. They worship God through prayer, fasting, prostration, glorification and praise. They perform the prayer, make pilgrimage and fast."

When that which is manifest in all the worlds corresponds to that which is hidden, and the secret is identical to that which is proclaimed, the mystic witnesses in the manifestations of first principles, in explaining these traditions, the appearance of rational proofs that I mentioned through wisdom regarding substances, material things, accidents and glorification. God, exalted be His glory, alone knows what lies beyond these allusions. He is the Guardian in both origin and return.

What I have indicated through proofs of wisdom in these stations is from the mysteries of the people of grace and justice in the Kingdom of Names and Attributes. The proofs known to those who give counsel and engage in excellent discourse are from the path of definitions. The methods of proof differ according to the stations. By whatever proof one establishes the prophethood of any prophet, by that same proof is established the prophethood of Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family.

For the proofs of people are of two kinds: either pertaining to the souls, manifesting in the stations of the self through signs that bring the servant to a state of certitude and tranquility; or pertaining to the horizons, through the appearance of miracles that have filled the east and west of the earth establishing prophethood. There is no greater proof for Muhammad's prophethood than the Qur'an, for through it his specific prophethood is established for both the elite and masses in all stations of the unseen and visible realms. Today the miracle of the Qur'an is manifest, for the letters which God has placed in everyone's hands, numbering twenty-eight, are such that if all were to gather to compose words like even a single verse thereof, they would be unable, even if they were helpers to one another. This is no simple matter—indeed it is the greatest of all his miracles that appeared from his holy and glorious presence.

Today, through the existence of the Qur'an, there is established for the specific prophethood of the Ahmad Being, God's blessings be upon him, that which the sun of beginning never rose upon in the beginning, nor did the sun of ending set upon in the ending. Indeed, were one who beholds the stations of witnessing to seek proof from every letter of the Qur'an for his specific prophethood for all created things, they would be able to do so. For God has revealed the Qur'an in such manner that none can produce its like.

What is meant by "like" is the divine power, lordly might, holy words and subtle meanings through which all in the heavens and earth are rendered powerless. If what was meant was merely the outward form of letters, there is no doubt that the Arabs did produce composed words, but the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, did not accept them, as one of them said when the verse "The Hour has

drawn near and the moon has been cleft asunder" (Q54:1) was revealed: The Hour has approached, the moon was split, and the Messenger of God—peace be upon Him and His family—said, "May God bless your mouth."

And verily this is evidence that none can produce the like thereof, for the condition of likeness is realized in a station that is similar in all its aspects. For when the All-Wise commands the bringing forth of a likeness, He considers all its stations from the realm of abstraction to the utmost degree of manifestation. And verily He, exalted be His glory, knowing that creation would never be able to match all its degrees which His knowledge encompasses, challenged them in His Book with outward forms which were the lowest of its degrees in His Book. Yet even in this they shall never be able to produce the like thereof as a narrative, for the essence of likeness is realized in a station that is truthful and articulate from the primary causes. And if it be not truthful, then its production would belie it, for proof is established in that which comes from God, and if it be not from Him, no judgment flows therefrom. Since it is established that it was from God, no impotence or contradiction to divine principles appears therein, for God is the Ever-Living, the All-Powerful. Thus whoever speaks from His presence, none can render impotent, nor can any produce the like thereof.

Thereby His proof, the Qur'an, was established over all degrees of existence, of jinn and men. And if all were to gather to produce the like of a single alif of the Qur'an, they would never be able, even were they all to help one another. For when God revealed that alif, He bestowed upon it dominion over all things great and small. Indeed, allusions veil the servant from drawing nigh unto the sacred court of divine attributes; otherwise, all manifestations of primary action and manifestations of passive reception are mentioned beneath that alif of the Qur'an. And since forms are similar, the servant cannot distinguish the form of the alif from God from the form of the alif of creation.

Glory be to God! How mighty is the station of His Book and how exalted the manifestation of His verses! The manifestations of His transcendence flow therein as though they were something unlike anything in His dominion, nor can anything equal it in the reality of its mystery. Thus was ordained in the Law the mystery of reality, that none should touch that alif of the Qur'an save in a state of purity. Were creation to look, they would witness in reality within the grandeur of a single letter of the Qur'an all the manifestations of contingent being according to their measure. And verily the Imam—peace be upon him—or one assisted by God's grace, were he to desire to derive the entire religion from the meaning of the letter alif, would be able to do so, for God's bounty has no limit.

Just as its meaning has meaning in God's Book, so does the judgment flow in the meaning of that meaning unto infinity. And verily the judgment for each letter of the Qur'an was from God, like what I have explained regarding the mention of its alif. Indeed, were all the seas to become ink for one of its letters, the seas would be exhausted before its meaning reached any limit in creation. Nay, therein flows the word of the All-Merciful, and "not a fresh or withered thing but is in a Manifest Book." Therefore did Ali, peace be upon him, say in a moment of glory: "I am the Point beneath the letter B," and from it emerged all created things into the realm of manifestation.

Today, the special prophethood is established through that Book, for the effect indicates its cause. Just as the Prophet, peace be upon him and his family, was the bearer of universal grace before which all names

were cut off and all traces vanished in his presence, so too is the judgment of his Book, for it stands alone in the world of letters and meanings, beyond all things and likenesses, and holds dominion over all names and attributes.

Whosoever wishes to argue for the special prophethood, if he be of heavenly nature and has not previously entered the religion of Islam, upon hearing a single verse of the Qur'an will instantly believe in it. For apart from that Book, nothing calls through its mystery to that Threshold. In each of its letters is stored a sign of power from the All-Forgiving, as though it were that blessed verse manifest:

> "Had We sent down this Qur'an on a mountain, thou wouldst surely have seen it humbled, split asunder from fear of God. Such are the similitudes We propound to men, that they may reflect."

Today, whoever wishes to enter with insight into the religion of Muhammad, the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, and the guardianship of his chosen ones, must enter through recognition of the Qur'an as the sign of His Beloved from the All-Merciful, which no human can match.

Though miracles are established through succession and His prophethood is proven through signs in the soul and evidence in the horizons for all who possess a musk-like scent of fairness, yet all this knowledge begins and ends with recognition of the Self and its acceptance. But through the Qur'an the heart is established, the spirit calmed, the soul assured, and the body refreshed. It has an effect on existence that God has not granted to any other. It is, in its unity, the greatest of God's signs in the realm of meanings and letters, and nothing of physical miracles equals it, for nothing in existence is more noble than the Word.

Therefore has God made utterance the means between Him and His chosen ones, and it has ever been with those who serve as intermediaries between Truth and creation. Thus it is the greatest of signs, for in the Qur'an all miracles are manifest, as it must contain every fresh and withered thing within its station. But in other miracles, the judgment of the Qur'an does not flow, due to the loftiness of utterance above all else in exposition. In God do we seek protection regarding what the Pen has set forth in explanation.

Among the conditions indicating his absolute prophethood are the traces of his self, whereto Abu Ja'far, peace be upon him, pointed in his words, saying gloriously:

> "In the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, were three qualities found in no other: He had no shadow; when he walked a path, if anyone were to pass by it two or three days later they would recognize that He had passed there by His sweet fragrance; and whenever He passed by a stone or a tree, it would prostrate before Him."

Indeed, without the essential reality of the Divine Will, when it descends into this world, such attributes would not be possible. By each of these signs His universal and eternal Prophethood is proven. And I point to the final word which states that all things prostrate before Him, for His Will encompasses all wills among His creation. When it is established that the mineral kingdom, which represents the lowest level of divine outpouring, prostrates before His presence, this proves that beyond the physical realm, all things are subservient to Him. His authority in the realm of souls comprises all stations, wherein all prostrate

themselves before God. Likewise is the decree regarding the horizons, as indicated by the Imam (peace be upon him) in his words, supported by God's statement regarding the inner essence of the outward:

> "There is nothing that does not glorify His praise, though you understand not their glorification."

When tradition has indicated the existence of the specific Prophethood in accordance with the decree of reason, I point to hidden proofs whose essence none knows save God or whom He wills. When I witnessed the favors of that Most Excellent One, perhaps thereby someone might act in God's religion and convey its reward to the One Who commanded the creation of that Book.

To the intellect that seeks to understand and believe in the decree of the specific Prophethood—without doubt it is but one aspect of the traces of that universal Prophethood's outpouring. Should the atoms of air desire to comprehend the decree of the Sun's orb, they could know nothing of it except what it reveals to them through its rays at their own level. When man recognizes through the light of direct vision the decree of that exposition, he will testify that the universal intellect cannot grasp of His Prophethood (peace be upon Him and His family) save what particles of dust comprehend at the rising of the sun's light. All that is known of the manifestation of the Sun's orb is in reality the recognition of that ray which connects with their essence at their station, and nothing beyond this is possible.

Such is the decree for intellects that wish to understand, through horizonal and personal proofs, the specific Prophethood of the Temple of Ahmad, the Divine Countenance, the Lordly Appearance, and the Eternal Resplendent Essential Reality, for beyond this no recognition is possible. In truth, His specific Prophethood cannot be proven to anyone except at their own station, even if it has a sign therein. But the matter is that which has descended in the depths of those allusions and been detailed in the mysteries of those expressions for whosoever distinguishes separation from union in the Kingdom of Names and Attributes.

When the intellect recognizes this decree, it testifies before God and His chosen ones that proving the specific Prophethood of the Muhammadan Temple is the greatest sin, unequaled by any other sin, for that matter which cannot be proven in contingent existence according to its true reality is too exalted and mighty to be proven through disconnected reflections that by their very nature indicate inability, proclaim prevention, and demonstrate limitation.

Glorified be God! How exalted the wisdom of Him Who so ordained it—albeit I can discover no path nor descry a proof whereby to attain the recognition of that glorious Pole Star. God and His angels bear witness that in all I have expounded regarding the verses proving the special Prophethood and absolute Guardianship, I intended only to demonstrate utter powerlessness to mention proofs and complete humility in recognizing the path. For below that station, nothing is possible for any created being. Whoever claims to prove the special Prophethood in its true reality has only borne falsehood within himself, and the limits of his own capacity apply to him.

However, since the verses are more subtle and precise in some souls than others, I have detailed the explanation of the clear verses that are possible in elucidating the special Prophethood, like describing wine through its glass vessel, as the poet said:

The crystal thinned; the vintage thinned likewise—So twinned they seemed, confounding gazer's eyes; As though there were but wine and not the cup; As though the cup were there and wine drunk up.

And one said regarding His station:

Thy attributes are Names; Thy Essence pure, A substance from all substance-traits secure; It soars beyond all accidents—the how, the when—Too great for likeness to the elements of ken.

This indeed is the secret of the matter in explaining reality. But today I know of no one who can prove the decree of that Prophethood as I have detailed in that Book, for my knowledge of proof is through divine confirmation from the Lord of Lords. If another were to follow the paths of truth, I would find only evidence from the Book and Tradition. Well was it said:

All claim with Layla union, firm and true; Yet Layla grants no witness to their due. But when from cheeks the sudden tear-streams break, ʿTis plain who truly wept—and who did fake.

Yet true nobility lies not in proving this obscure matter, but rather in affirming what the Messenger of God (peace be upon him and his family) declared when he said:

> "Lo, everything save God is vain, and every blessing must inevitably pass away."

All that I have detailed in those references of clear proofs belongs to the realm of divine glory. The true knowledge of special Prophethood and its proof exists in a station where knowledge becomes identical with the known, and proof becomes identical with the hidden. Were it not so, the primal outpouring could not be proven through anything else.

This is not from the perspective of recognition, but rather from the veils and coverings, as the Imam (peace be upon him) indicated in his exalted words, saying that "wisdom lies in manifesting what is in potential into actuality. If He did not manifest what He knew of His hidden knowledge into the existence of its meanings, one to another, it would be deficient and wisdom would be incomplete—for the perfection of power is in action, the perfection of knowledge is in the known, and the perfection of being is in existence."

In truth, the matter lies in recognizing that path and nothing else. For if one sought to know redness through whiteness, or greenness through yellowness, one could never truly know it, since a thing can only be known through the aspect of its own self. Know that whoso desireth to apprehend the special prophethood in its reality can only do so through the Prophet himself, peace be upon Him and His family, as the Imam, peace be upon him, hath indicated concerning that station: "Know God through God, and the Prophet through prophethood."

This indeed is the innermost mystery, for recognition hath two ranks, as hath been established among the people of divine knowledge. If it be through the recognition of the Essence by the Essence itself, this is recognition in its reality and perfection, as the Imam, peace be upon him, hath indicated in numerous stations of recognition. Among these is what Ali, peace be upon him, hath said in the Prayer of the Morning: "He Who hath demonstrated His Essence through His Essence." And among these is what Ali ibn al-Husayn, peace be upon him, hath said in his prayer to Abu Hamza al-Thumali: "Through Thee have I

known Thee, and Thou hast guided me unto Thyself and called me unto Thee, and were it not for Thee, I would not have known who Thou art." And among these is what He, exalted be His mention, hath revealed in the Gospel: "Know thyself and thou shalt know thy Lord; thy outward is for annihilation and thy inward is I."

God accepteth not from the people of the Bayan that manner of recognition, for He hath taught them through the words of His trustees that God is too exalted to be known through His creation; rather, His creation is known through Him.

As the recognition of a thing through its essence is realized in the station of the first theophany, likewise is the decree concerning the manifestations of this Self-Revealing One. None can establish the special prophethood of Muhammad, peace be upon Him and His family, in its reality through the signs in the souls and horizons, for all that is beneath the essence of the bearer of special prophethood is but a trace in relation to that station. The reality of the recognition of a thing is not established through the traces of its manifestations. Rather, whoso desireth to establish His special prophethood must not make anything less than His Self as proof thereof, nor any path unto Him save His Own Essence, for all things are cut off from Him due to the transcendence of the glory of His majesty in God's dominion, and all traces are prevented from recognizing His presence due to the sublimity of His effulgent radiance in God's religion.

Glorified be God! How lofty is the station of God's Prophet in the realm of possibility, and how mighty is the praise of God's Messenger in all worlds! He is unique, without likeness or similitude in the worlds of being. O Essence through whom existence hath arisen, all creation after Thee is but accident! Since it hath been established regarding the recognition of the Essence that what is possible in the contingent realm is only possible through His Essence for His Essence, likewise doth this decree apply to the Point of Existence of the First Universal Effusion, which is the First and Pre-existent Remembrance manifested through Him for Him. And since wisdom requireth that the descent of the First Remembrance to the station of dust be like His primary manifestation for Him through Him, it is established that none save the essence of the bearer of Universal Prophethood could appear in the corporeal world except in the temple of His beginning, before which all bow down unto God.

From this exposition man knoweth that none save the Point of the Bayan could declare in the station of exposition "I am the first who answered in the realm of particles," for none beside Him is capable of such utterance. Just as His essence knoweth His essence, likewise is the decree concerning His prophethood, for it knoweth its prophethood, not that which is beneath it. Whoso seeketh to establish it through any proof besides itself hath been veiled from beholding the stations of reconition of the essences and the manifestations of the attributes, and its proof through evidence is pure negation, for if His Prophethood (peace be upon Him and His family) were established through anything other than His own Self, in reality it would only establish the existence of that thing which is inferior to the very Prophethood that is intended in the station of the flowing of ink.

Verily this path for establishing the universal Prophethood is greater than all proofs and evidences, for other than it is the station of shadows and accidents wherein the servant dwells in the station of goodly exhortation and disputation with that which is best in the station of seeking. But through the proof of wisdom, which is the reality of evidence for the wayfarer on the path of the Glorious One, it is impossible

through any other means. And verily, despite the greatness of its station and the loftiness of its rank and the sublimity of its glory which is greater than all manifestations of proofs, it is lighter than all proofs, for the more multiplicity increases the thicker become the veils, and the more subtle the veils become the more refined becomes the station. Therefore the proof of wisdom, despite its ultimate subtlety, is far from sight and difficult for thoughts and knowledge thereof. Thus speaks the tradition with its wisdom:

> "Our Cause is difficult, most difficult. None can bear it except a near angel, a commissioned prophet, or a believer whose heart God has tested for faith."

3. The third pillar: al-walayat (Guardianship)

When through the proof of wisdom the specific Prophethood is realized by one who possesses the consciousness of the inmost heart and the secret of reality, that proof indicates the stations of the Guardianship and its establishment, for God has joined its decree with Prophethood. And it is that the First Remembrance cannot descend with manifestation in the world of the unseen except through seven stations, for everything has an aspect of Lord and an aspect of self. When the aspects are established, the decree of connection is established, and thereby three are established. When the three descend they become four, and therefore God made the number of stations of action seven, for less than that is impossible in creation. And it is the complete and perfect number than which there is no more perfect number according to the people of truth.

When these ranks appeared in the world of the unseen, the souls of the Imams (peace be upon them) were realized, and their number is seven: Muhammad, Ali, Fatima, al-Hasan, al-Husayn, Ja'far and Musa (God's blessings upon them).

When these seven descended from the world of the unseen to the station of witness, fourteen souls appeared, for the witness of those Names in the ranks of bodies and words is Ali, Muhammad, Ali, Muhammad, al-Hasan, and Muhammad (God's blessings upon them).

They are the guides to God in every world with guidance than which nothing higher is possible in contingent existence, that He—there is no god but He—is truth in the eternity of eternities, that He is devoid of the servants and the servants are devoid of Him, and there is between them neither connection nor separation of isolation, and His relation was with all atoms before their existence and after their existence equally, and none knows how He is except His own Self, glorified and exalted is He above what they associate.

When it is established that in the principles of causes, the appearance of the First Remembrance is only possible in fourteen reeds, then through knowledge of that station is established the Guardianship of the Imams of the religion, through their own selves, demonstrate through wisdom; through their manifestations, demonstrate through counsel; and through their names, demonstrate through disputation in the most excellent manner. And verily the one who beholds the station of the Divine Essence and dwells in the kingdom of Names and Attributes, were he to witness the manifestations of the Universal Guardianship, would be able to prove by every aspect attributed to them their absolute guardianship over all created things. For by every proof that establishes the unity of the Divine Essence is

established the absolute Prophethood of Muhammad, peace be upon Him and His family, and the Universal Guardianship of His successors, may God's blessings be upon them. For the pillars of Divine Unity are letters that in no wise indicate aught except God, and therefore the sign of Unity in manifestation and contingency is identical with the sign of Prophethood in creative manifestation. Likewise is the decree concerning the signs of Guardianship, which are identical with the sign of Prophethood in the stations of both concealment and manifestation.

4. The fourth pillar: the shi'ah

When the Pen flows with mention of the pillars of Unity, I shall indicate the establishment of the seven ranks for him who bears that Fourth Letter, for a thing in the world of principles and causes is created only through the efficient cause, which is the station of the creation by the Essence of all that He willeth from nothing, for the manifestation of His unity; then through the material cause, which is the station of Universal Prophethood for the manifestation of His Messenger's decree; then through the formal cause for the manifestation of the guardianship of thirteen souls who are the universal reeds in the thicket of the empyrean heaven, as they are the friends of God and the successors of His Messenger, peace be upon Him and His family; then through the final cause, which is the fruit in the kingdom of manifestations and the purpose in those conditions, for the manifestation of the bearer of the Fourth Letter whom God hath placed in the station of the light of absolute, universal, and all-encompassing guardianship.

Verily, by the proof of reason, it is necessary in wisdom that the station of the final cause be the fourth rank in the station of descent. Therefore did al-Sadiq, peace be upon Him, indicate in the tradition mentioning the Name, wherein His remembrance is exalted, that "God, blessed and exalted be He, created a name through the letter without sound, through word without utterance, through person without body, through similitude without description, through color without tinge, negated from dimensions, removed from limitations, veiled from the perception of every imaginer, concealed yet not covered. He made it a perfect word of four parts together, none of which precedes another. He manifested three names therefrom for creation's need of them, and concealed one of them, which is the Hidden and Treasured Name.

These names which have appeared—the manifest one is God, blessed and exalted be He. And the Glorious One subjected to each of these names four pillars, thus making twelve pillars. Then He created for each of these pillars thirty names as functions attributed to them: He is the All-Merciful, the All-Compassionate, the Sovereign, the Holy, the Creator, the Maker, the Fashioner, the Ever-Living, the Self-Subsisting, neither slumber seizeth Him nor sleep, the All-Knowing, the All-Aware, the All-Hearing, the All-Seeing, the All-Wise, the Mighty, the Compeller, the Supreme, the Most High, the Most Great, the Most Powerful, the Able, the Peace, the Faithful, the Guardian, the Producer, the Originator, the Wonderful, the Sublime, the Majestic, the Generous, the Provider, the Life-Giver, the Death-Giver, the Resurrector, the Inheritor.

These names and whatsoever be among the Most Beautiful Names until they complete three hundred and sixty names are all related to these three Names, and these three Names are pillars and veils of the One Hidden and Treasured Name through these three Names. And that is His word, exalted be He: ʿSay:

Call upon Allah or call upon the All-Merciful; by whichever ye call upon, to Him belong the Most Beautiful Names."'

The three pillars that have appeared in existence are the recognition of Divine Unity, Prophethood, and Divine Guardianship, while the hidden pillar and the light of the unseen remain veiled due to humanity's inability to bear them. Though more manifest than anything else alongside the three in appearance, it remains concealed, being the inner reality of the Cause in its own station. It has its day when God wills to manifest it, and it is the Name which, when the Qa'im (peace be upon him) revealed it, caused the chiefs to turn away from His presence. Then, finding no escape, they returned to Him and believed in Him through the power of that Name. This is the Most Great Name, the Most Ancient Secret, and the Refined Symbol without the recognition of which and drawing near to which no one's deeds are complete.

Thus when a Christian asked our Master Al-Kazim (peace be upon him) about the Most Great Name, he said: "Tell me about eight letters that descended, of which four became manifest on earth while four remained in the air. Upon whom will those four in the air descend, and who will interpret them?" He replied: "That is our Qa'im. God will cause them to descend upon Him, and He will interpret them. God will reveal to Him what was not revealed to the truthful ones, the Messengers, and the guided ones." Then the monk asked: "Tell me about two of those four letters that are on earth—what are they?" He replied: "I will tell you all four. The first is There is no god but God, alone with no partner, the Everlasting.' The second is Muhammad is the Messenger of God' (peace be upon him and his family) sincerely. The third is We are the People of the House.' And the fourth is Our followers are from us, and we are from the Messenger of God' (peace be upon him and his family), and the Messenger of God is from God through a connection."

Every proof that establishes the three pillars also establishes that pillar in that letter. If the proof is wisdom, the path to knowing it is itself and nothing else. If it were otherwise, no one could claim its station, just as is established in the balance of Prophethood. In terms of effect, the bearer of the effects of the three must possess the simplicity of Divine Unity in the station of abstraction, the signs of Prophethood in the station of limitation, and the indications of Guardianship in the station of praise.

Therefore, it is incumbent upon whoever claims that station to manifest those effects in a way that no other can achieve. When He wills, through the word of authority, nothing can frustrate Him. He speaks and writes as He wills, without pause of the pen or contemplation regarding verses, nor does He copy from the letters of the Qur'an, for through Him is established the mystery of Oneness in Prophethood. This power can only be realized in the secondary cause, which reflects the primary cause, and the fourth cause for the manifestation of the comprehensive word. One who speaks about it what his conjecture imagines will find the word returning in the judgment of the Book exactly letter for letter.

When He wills in the manner of intimate prayers in sermons, the effects of the manifestation of Guardianship, He is able to do so in a way that no one has preceded Him in manifestation, nor can anyone of thought and vision resist Him, as the balance of the effects of Guardianship has been established in intimate prayers and sermons for those who know the loci of wisdom within the station of tokens and indication, and if one desires, after these effects, to manifest his certainty in God's judgment, he may

arise before God and pronounce what has been revealed in the Law concerning the ordinances of imprecation, as has occurred before God, exalted be His mention.

Indeed, for the recognition of this station there are aspects which none can enumerate save God, and not all that a servant knows can he utter. Were it not for the hidden obligation and the fear of that which Ali ibn Al-Hussein, peace be upon them both, spoke in his words—exalted be his mention—when he said: "Many a jewel of knowledge, were I to divulge it, I would be accused of worshipping idols"—I would have revealed the secret reality of that station. However, I will indicate its station through the tradition revealed concerning the station of knowledge from Jabir, where he said—exalted be his mention—in a lengthy tradition, until he said: "O Jabir! Do you know what knowledge is? Knowledge is first the affirmation of Divine Unity, second the recognition of meanings, third the recognition of the gates, fourth the recognition of the Imam, fifth the recognition of the pillars, sixth the recognition of the chiefs, and seventh the recognition of the nobles." And this is referenced in His words, exalted and glorified be He: "Say: If the ocean were ink for the words of my Lord, the ocean would be exhausted before the words of my Lord were exhausted, even if We brought another ocean like it as aid."

Whoever recognizes the signs becomes independent of expressions, and whoever recognizes the placement of attributes in those indications reaches the depths of knowledge in the abysses of those stations. Indeed, to God return all decrees in the kingdom of names and attributes. I seek God's forgiveness, my Lord, for what the Book enumerates; verily He is the Ever-Forgiving, the Generous, the Beneficent in the beginning and the return.

At this juncture I stay the pen from flowing, and I ask God for pardon concerning what has been revealed from the Book unto manifestation. Glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe, and peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

The Bab—Late Writings of the second period Isfahan August 1846—March 1847

Volume 012-012. Contains 35 writings.

BB00511: Letter concerning the Nubuwwat al-Khassa

He is the Mighty

O Fuad Khalili, one like you is too exalted for me to address in writing, even with the most sublime essence of truth and the most radiant expressions of subtlety, for all that shines with splendor and appears on the horizons from the allusions of the people of the Covenant and the conditions of the people of constancy is but a veil in the station of love. Indeed, between you and me in all worlds there exists a relationship hidden from the eyes of this world.

However, when I heard that the binding command had been issued from His Excellency—may God perpetuate his glory—to your honor to interpret what I had composed in Arabic regarding the specific Muhammadan Prophethood—may God's blessings be upon it—I began this address so that you might

spread these pages before His Excellency—may God perpetuate his favor—and explain to him in the best possible manner at the station of exposition, in accordance with His exalted Word:

> "In all things there is a sign pointing to the fact that He is One."

This is evident to your honor, and I shall not mention to you now more than this exposition, according to His exalted Word:

> "Not all that is known should be spoken, nor all that is spoken is timely, nor is everything timely attended by those who are worthy."

However, what is intended is that which I have set forth in the other pages at the end of the book with decisive speech for whoever wishes to present a matter in the presence of His Excellency, and I mention to him that which is remembered in the beginning and the return.

And peace be upon you so long as the celestial spheres rotate in the kingdom of names and attributes.

BB00515: Letter concerning the Nubuwwat al-Khassa

He is the Mighty

Praise and glory befit that Most Holy Being Who hath ever existed through the reality of His Most Holy Essence, and no being hath been mentioned with Him in His holy sanctuary, and Who will forever exist through the sovereignty of His Essence, and no being is mentioned with Him at the level of the pre-existence of His Essence. How transcendent is His station, for in every age there have been manifestations of His grace from His Presence who have related naught but His justice, and how mighty is His power, for in every era there have been manifestations of His mercy in His dominion who have indicated naught but His power.

Among these is the binding command of His Honor—may God prolong his glory—which hath become the cause of the appearance of these published pages. It is hoped from the grace of the All-Bountiful Lord and the special favors of His Honor—may God perpetuate his prosperity—that these draft pages will prove acceptable to the sanctified minds, both in meaning and expression, until such time as the prescribed copies are published in the finest calligraphy in that grace-bestowing presence, and become the cause for manifesting gratitude's inability to thank His Honor for his bounties and serve as a reminder of Abdullah's matter which is imprinted in the mirror of his luminous thoughts, so that it may never be erased from his radiant mind.

BB00176: Prayer for Laylatu'l-Qadr

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

All praise be to Him Who sendeth down whatsoever He willeth through His command, and createth at every moment whatsoever He pleaseth in His dominion. Glorified and exalted be He above all that they ascribe unto Him.

O my God! How can I extol Thine Essence or recount the glory of Thy Being, when the Countenance of Thy Self transcendeth all praise of the essential realities, and the Presence of Thy Identity is beyond all glorification by material things? How can I fail to thank Thy Self for Thy bounties, or neglect to praise Thy Court for Thy grandeur, when the very essence of all created things beareth witness to their origination, and the reality of all contingent beings, in its entirety, testifieth to their predestination?

O my God! Inasmuch as Thou hast ordained supplication for all that existeth in creation, and whereas I am but an atom, with no atom more abject or needy than I, I commune with Thee, O my God, with the reality of my heart, that Thou art God, the Beloved of the mystics, that Thou art God, the Companion of them that profess Thy unity, that Thou art God, the Desire of them that yearn after Thee, that Thou art God, the Lord of them that tread Thy path, and that Thou art God Who hath created creation through Thy Will and established all things upon the path of Thy Purpose.

Thou hast made known to contingent beings the way to know Thee and hast inspired all created things with the station of Thy love, that those who are perplexed might find repose in the reeds of the thickets of might through the manifestation of Thy holy and eternal sovereignty, that those who seek certainty might attain unto reality in the kingdom of dominion and behind the veil of might through the realization of the grandeur of Thy glory and mercy, that those who are radiant might shine forth in the manifestations of the depths of the mysteries of the conditions of the human realm through the effulgence of the splendor of the remembrance of Thy oneness, and that those who strive might reach unto the sacred depths of the ascent of names and attributes in the stations of might, even as fragments of ruby tablets reflect the light of the sun in the midst of darkness upon the wasteland, until all might recognize the Countenance of Thy Will made manifest in the stations of Command and Creation within the essence of all created things.

Nothing in the kingdom of earth and heaven can veil them from Thy Countenance, and all behold Thy manifestation apparent in creation and invention, even as the manifestation of Thy Self in the countenance of names and attributes. Thus do they describe Thy power with Thine own description in the Book, where Thou hast said—and Thy Word is the Truth in utterance:

> “They measure not God with His true measure. The whole earth will be His handful on the Day of Resurrection, and the heavens will be rolled in His right hand. Glory be to Him! High be He exalted above the partners they attribute to Him!”

Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou, O my God! When Thy power was made manifest in the essence of contingent beings, all imagined they could describe Thee through their own descriptions. Therefore do all describe Thee with that which they know not of Thee, and were they to know Thee, they would not describe Thee. Hence, O my God, do they proclaim Thy unity, for Thou hast ever been while naught else existed, and Thou wilt ever be even as Thou wert in the eternity of eternities. Nothing hath ever been of

Thy rank, for Thine Essence transcendeth all essences from mention of essences, and Thy Being is sanctified above all beings from reference to names and attributes.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! If I say "Thou art Thou," then similitude hath been likened unto similitude, and Thou shalt never be known thereby. If I say "He is He," then unity pointeth to the station of creation and oneness to the condition of invention, while Thou hast ever been and wilt ever be beyond description by the praise of contingent beings or recognition through the essential realities of existing things. Verily, O my God, Thou hast never been and wilt never be described by power and beauty, nor by grandeur and similitudes, for Thou art God, the Beloved, in the depths of the spheres of names and attributes, and nothing among signs and tokens can be compared unto Thee.

Glorified art Thou, O Lord of the Throne and of air, then of water and earth, that I should describe Thee with the description of the highest essences or characterize Thee with the characteristics of the ultimate attainment of realities, for Thou shalt never be known through comparisons or described through similitudes! Even if Thou shouldst chastise me by making mention of Thyself with all Thy retribution and might throughout all eternity, with the everlastingness of Thy Essence, I would deserve it. Verily, Thou art praiseworthy in Thy deeds and obeyed in Thy judgment. Indeed, I am deserving of this, for my very existence before the sovereignty of Thy Self-Subsistence is the greatest sin, whereby fire converseth with fire in the worlds of creation and command.

I beseech Thee, O my God, in this darkest night, the sun of nights in the most enduring months, to send Thy blessings upon Muhammad, the Blessed Tree in the realm of divinity, the Holy Leaf in the thicket of omnipotence, the Blessed Branches in the stations of sovereignty and dominion, the Goodly Fruits in the trees of the earthly realm, and the Manifest Lights in the fragments of the tablets of ruby—the Chosen, the Beloved, the Elected, the Sent One, the Mighty, the Appointed, and the Outpoured Water. Him Whom Thou didst single out from the innermost eternity at the station of Thy manifestation, Whom Thou didst choose before nothingness for the appearance of Thy authority, Whom Thou didst elect at the station of greatness for the conditions of Thy mercy, and Whom Thou didst select through innate generosity at the station of Thy bountiful grace above all nations, from the kingdom of the throne to beneath the impenetrable darkness.

He Who standeth alone among humankind, sanctified from all likeness and similitude in what was and what shall be in the scriptures, as though He were unique in the greatest perspective. The Hour drew nigh on that night and the moon was cleft asunder—the Bearer of Glad-Tidings, the Warner, Whom Thou didst establish as the station of Thy Self in being known and in explanation, in being described and in manifestation, in being witnessed and in elucidation, in being sought and in expression, for all who desire Thy unity in the depths of attributes and the vast ocean of contingent existence.

He Who standeth in Thy stead in fulfillment, Who appeareth with Thy grandeur in glory, Who speaketh of Thine eternity in praise, Who is manifest upon the first Mount Sinai in primary revelation—Ahmad, sent unto the people of creation and origination, Whose mission Thou didst manifest on that blessed night with hosts of angels and the descent of the Spirit with the Book. Thou didst honor Him with what Thou didst reveal concerning Him in the Book, where Thou didst say—and Thy word is the truth in the Qur'an:

> “By the star when it setteth, your companion erreth not, nor is he deceived; nor doth he speak of his own desire. It is naught but revelation revealed, taught him by one mighty in power, endued with wisdom: for he appeared in the highest part of the horizon. Then he drew nigh and came down till he was at the distance of two bow-lengths or even nearer. So did God reveal to His Servant what He revealed. The heart lied not in what it saw. Will ye then dispute with him concerning what he saw? For indeed he saw him at a second descent, near the Lote-tree beyond which none may pass: near it is the Garden of Abode. When that which shroudeth did enshroud the Lote-tree, the eye turned not aside, nor did it wander. Verily he saw one of the greatest signs of his Lord.”

Therefore, glory be unto Thee, O my God! On this night wherein the moon riseth not as it riseth on other nights, send Thy blessings upon the Tree of the Desired One in the temple of Ahmad, and the Praised Master in the most radiant form—He Who delivered what He was charged with from Thee and bore harm in Thy path, such that He recited the verses of Thy Book for ten years while none believed in Him save Ali, the Commander of the Faithful, peace be upon him, His successor, the bearer of His knowledge, the inheritor of His wisdom, and He Who standeth in His station throughout all manifestations. Therefore reward Him, O my God, for what He delivered and for His patience in what befell Him, and for bearing what was unworthy for Him to hear, for when He was sent forth by Thy command, He delivered Thy Message, and thereafter said what He said, and was wronged and accused of falsehood in Thy path, until He perfected the religion for its people and ascended to the station of meeting Thee, with His good-pleasure.

Wherefore, O my God, send down Thy blessings upon Him and upon His chosen successors, the pillars of Thy unity and the signs of Thy sanctification, through that which Thou possessest of majesty, power, glory and grandeur. Verily Thou art God, the Lord of the mighty throne, Who hath made His bounty to exceed all that Thou hast created, through the bounty of Thine own Self towards all created things. Verily, Thou art the Lord of glory over all creation. Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above that which they describe. And peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00036: Tawqi’i-i-Dhahabiyyih (Risaliy-i-Dhahabiyya II)

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Khutbah

All praise be to God, the One, the Single, the Unique, the All-Compelling, the Eternal, the Peerless, the Everlasting, the Almighty, the Ever-Living, the Self-Subsisting, the Most Exalted, the All-Chosen, the All-Powerful, the Just, the All-Forgiving, Who hath through His command created the essences of mysteries for those who draw nigh, from among the righteous ones who abide in the crimson mysteries above the throne of the Divine Realm, and who glorify God, the Creator of names and attributes, through what God hath created in the essences of light by the decree of His will.

Praise be to God Who hath opened the gate of grace unto the hearts of the pure ones among the people of the divine cloud and the veiled mortals from among the people of radiance—they whose recognition God hath ordained in the resolution of the third mystery from the thicket of the Kingdom, and for whom He hath ordained the abode of permanence therein through the negation of all else from the court of nearness to the appearance of the Manifestation of the Essence unto the essences, through the mystery of justice in His choice.

Praise be to God Who hath sent down judgment for those who recline upon emerald cushions in the thicket of the heavenly realm and the gardens of dominion, and who recognize the signs of the Most Holy Tree in the shadows of the manifold paradises—from essences in their indicators, realities in their stations, souls in their tokens, moments in their verses, waverings in their manifestations, gleamings in their conditions, sanctified ones in their emergences, and radiant ones in their reflections, and in the verses that flash forth in the detached ones from tablets of crimson ruby, that they might distinguish, at the rising of the Sun of Glory from behind the vast ocean of decree, all the wicked ones among the people of flight from the righteous ones among the people of permanence, and that all might know in that most grievous, overwhelming, blind, mute, dust-laden, scorching, hellish, grinding, darksome trial the decree of origination after destiny and its execution within destiny itself.

Then glory and praise and radiance from the people of creation, the sign manifested from the crimson countenance from the sign of the verdant pillar, that he might perish who perisheth through clear proof according to what God hath revealed in the Qur'an concerning the wicked ones, where He saith—and His word is the truth:

> "This, so let them taste it—a boiling fluid and corruption cold! And other torments of a similar kind in pairs! This is an army rushing headlong with you! No word of welcome for them! They shall roast in the Fire! They say: Nay, ye! No word of welcome for you! It is ye who have brought this upon us! Now evil is this place to stay in!' They say: Our Lord! Whoever brought this upon us—add for him a double torment in the Fire!' And they say: 'What aileth us that we behold not men whom we were wont to count among the wicked? Did we take them as an object of mockery, or have our eyes swerved from them?' Lo! that is very truth: the mutual reproaches of the People of the Fire. Say: I am but a warner, and there is no God save Allah, the One, the Almighty, Lord of the heavens and the earth and all that is between them, the Mighty, the Pardoning."

[Q38:57-66]

And that he might live who liveth through clear proof according to what God hath revealed in response to him who called unto his Lord: "Satan hath afflicted me with distress and torment." [Q38:41] He spoke—and His word is the truth—in the Decisive Utterance: "This is Our gift, so grant or withhold without account. And verily, with Us he had nearness and a beautiful place of return." [Q38:39-40] "Strike [the ground] with thy foot! Here is a spring for washing, cool and refreshing to drink." [Q38:42] "And take in thy hand a bundle of rushes and strike therewith, and break not thine oath. Truly We found him patient; how excellent a servant! Indeed he was ever turning in repentance." [Q38:44] "This is a reminder: and verily, for the righteous is a beautiful place of return—Gardens of Eternity, whose gates will be opened to

them, wherein they will recline, calling for abundant fruit and drink, and beside them will be companions of modest gaze, of equal age. This is what ye are promised for the Day of Reckoning." [Q38:49-53] "Verily this is from that which was remembered by what thy Lord hath remembered in His Book. Thou warnest only such as follow the Reminder and fear the All-Merciful in secret: give them glad tidings of forgiveness and a generous reward." [Q36:11]

All praise be to God for having caused me to witness the scrolls of those nigh unto Him among the righteous and the tablets of the oppressed among the chosen ones. Unto Him be praise at this moment—praise radiant, brilliant, sanctified and exalted above the comprehension of all else—for that which hath been sent down at this time by Him Who knoweth better than I, and unto Him do I complain of those who deal not justly in mentioning the First Ones when faced with the Greater Signs.

O God! Verily Thou art God, there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thou didst exist when nothing existed with Thee, and Thou wilt ever remain as Thou hast been. Nothing shareth Thy station, for Thy Essence transcendeth all substance and recognition, and Thy Being surpasseth all materiality and description. How can I enumerate the praise of Thy grandeur when none besides Thee can know aught of Thy station, Thy oneness, Thy majesty and Thy greatness? Every description of Thy countenance is falsehood, and every attribute of Thy greatness is a lie. Never shall anything know Thee, never shall any servant unify Thee, for true knowledge cometh after conjunction and true unification after separation. Ever hast Thou been the Describer of Thine own Self, without alteration, change, transformation or transition. Ever doth Thine Essence unify Thine Essence in ways none but Thee can know.

Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou, O my God! If I say "Thou art Thou," then like describeth like, and at that moment Thou and all created things would give me the lie, for the countenance of Being which Thou hast mentioned before the City of Majesty pertaineth to creation and invention, while He hath ever been sanctified above the description of all beings and the recognition of all contingent things. And if I say "He is He," this would indicate the Primal Will, which is itself cut off from Thee through being created from nothing, and which pointeth only to itself and describeth only its own being. If the station of the letter Ha' is annihilation, how can I mention the station of the letter Vav before the City of Praise? By the glory of Thy Essence, I have never claimed to unify Thy reality, nor to know Thy Essence, nor to praise Thy Being, nor to glorify Thy Self, nor to extol Thy Reality. Rather, from the day Thou didst create me, I have declared Thee sanctified above all allusions to Thy holy court, and even detachment, though a form of praise, falls short. Yet by Thy glory, I seek naught but utter negation in the face of Thy revelation.

Alas, alas, that I should make mention of Thy Self or attempt to proclaim Thy unity! I call Thee and all who bear witness before Thee to witness that shouldst Thou punish me eternally with all Thy chastisements and might for having made mention of Thy Self, Thou wouldst be praised in Thy deed, obeyed in Thy decree, and just in Thy judgment. Indeed, I would deserve whatever punishment Thou mightest ordain and all that Thy knowledge encompasseth, which none knoweth save Thee. And if such be the judgment of my greatest virtues before Thee, what then of my sins and transgressions which none can reckon save Thee? Since all these have melted away from my very being, here am I, O Just One in judgment, O Praised One in deed, casting myself before Thee, seeking intercession through Thee with Thee, fleeing from Thy justice unto Thee, hoping for Thy pardon from Thee alone, Who hath no partner.

My God! Admit me unto the court of Thy nearness, that I may see no god but Thee, forget all else save Thee, abide in Thy sacred precincts, delight in the remembrance of Thy Lordship, and seek Thy forgiveness for all that veils me from the countenance of Thy beauty. O my God! Grant me the summit of detachment unto Thee and the heights of separation before Thee.

Join me to the Most Glorious Light of Thy might and raise me to the proximity of Thy companionship, that I may not grieve in this world over those who hope not for Thy days, who fear not Thy punishment, and who are not content with Thy decree. My God! Thou knowest that I desire to love only what Thou lovest and to detest only what Thou detestest. Thy knowledge encompasseth me, and Thou art witness that I have desired nothing to which the people of the realms of holiness turn, and I see no glory or honor save in Thy remembrance, O Creator of names and attributes! I have spoken to people of Thy favor bestowed upon me, such as was not given to any among the followers of the Imams of justice, and I have kept Thy covenant.

Now Thou seest how each party rejoiceth in what it possesseth—one day a gnat flappeth its wings to display its power, and another day a fly soareth in the atmosphere of its dominion to demonstrate its might. Thou knowest that were I to teach all what they desire yet fail to remember, the ink of the seas would not suffice, for truth is with Thee, and all who seek Thee are manifest through Thy brilliant light. Indeed, I am less than an atom—Thy knowledge doth not encompass even the least of my self. How then can I not be patient when Thou, in Thy station of power, might, majesty and grandeur, hast been patient with what the Christians have alleged in making Thee "the third of three", [Q5:73] with what the Jews have claimed that "Ezra is the son of God", [Q9:30] and with what the Arabs have asserted that "God is poor while we are rich". [Q3:181]

I said—and Thy word is the truth—"We shall record what they have said and their slaying of the Prophets unjustly, and We shall say: ʿTaste ye the torment of burning."' [Q3:181] Thou knowest, O my God, that the words spoken against me by those who have not been granted knowledge of the unseen, nor given leave by Thee, harm me not, for Thou art pure. Indeed, were those who deny Thy signs to know what Thou hast ordained for them, they would surely say: "O woe unto us for what we neglected towards God!" [Q39:56] "Would that I had died before this and been utterly forgotten!" [Q19:23]

O God! None can reverse Thy decree, and none can exhaust Thy signs. Send down, O Lord, upon those who desire to deny Thy loved ones the word of justice, that it may shield them from extinction before the City of Praise. Guide among them whom Thou willest as Thou willest, for Thou hast said—and Thy word is the truth—"God blotteth out or confirmeth what He pleaseth, and with Him is the Mother Book." [Q13:39]

O God! I seek Thy forgiveness for those who seek Thy face yet have become confused in their ways, that Thou mayest make known to them the path of Thy love and strengthen them through recognition of Thy mercy. Take them not except their hearts be at peace through Thy praise, their souls through remembrance of Thee, and their spirits through Thy pardon. Verily Thou art God, the Support of the heavens and earth; Thou art God, the Beauty of the heavens and earth; Thou art God, the Majesty of the heavens and earth; Thou art God, the Glory of the heavens and earth. Nothing in the heavens or earth can overwhelm Thy power, and Thou art the Mighty, the Merciful.

I bear witness, O my God, at this moment, to all that Thou lovest as Thou lovest it, and to all that Thou abhorrest as Thou abhorrest it. And I declare, as revealed in the Qur'an: "There is no God but Thee! Glory be unto Thee! Verily I have been of the wrongdoers!" [Q21:87] I testify before Thee, O my God, that I now name this blessed manuscript "Golden," that it may purify allusions from the mention of metaphors in the presence of Glory, and find its way to the Sacred Court of Beauty.

The argument

And thereafter, O Generous One Who sends forth the water of ink upon the tablets of righteousness, O thou who desires guidance for the people of the lands to the Countenance of the Heart and the Mystery of Creation: Fear God in the decree of the Lord of creation, for the Day of Judgment is the appointed time. Verily, he knows me not nor sees me, and were he to discover what God has inspired in me and truly desire sincerity, he would not make words of flight for metaphors at the abode of permanence through evident signs.

By Him Who holds my soul in His hand, the words he has related in his book concerning those of his kind, bringing forth similitudes, are falsehood, lies, calumny and deception. What hast thou to do with such lies? "Grievous is the word that comes forth from their mouths. They speak naught but falsehood." "Thou wouldst, perhaps, torment thyself to death with grief over their footsteps if they believe not in this Message." [Q18:5-6] But verily, transgression shall be upon the wrongdoers. And God's curse be upon the liars. Indeed, he himself, despite the greatness of his station which he mentioned in his words and the loftiness of his rank to which his expressions alluded, wrote two parts without proof and did not bring forth a wondrous sign from nature, as if he paid no attention to its significance and did not remember its wisdom.

Say: O man, be fair before God and follow not the desires of those who have disbelieved. For today, since thou hast desired to enter the field of disputation, cast at me whatever thou art able with all thy strength, might and power. For today no bird can soar to my heights, and I will dispute with thee according to that which We sent down before in answer to thy letter.

If thou makest proof to be the mention of visions, as thou hast done in thy book, then by the glory of thy Lord, I have written more than thou in well-known books.

And if thou makest proof to be eloquence in the mentioned sermon, then by thy Lord, I have composed sermons that none hath mentioned before and none today can match, as until now there have flowed from my pen some thirty pages of prayers, sermons, holy allusions, glorified signs, paradisiacal stations, and prescribed verses.

And if thou makest proof to be knowledge in explaining the allusions concerning the stations of divinity, omnipotence, the kingdom, and the human realm, then God knoweth that I have mentioned more than thou in a manner that none can comprehend save whom God willeth. And if thou desirest to discover this, read the pages of prayers, for through them the spirit of communion is distinguished from mere storytelling.

And if thou makest proof to be abundance of exposition, then by the glory of thy Lord, I am able to write in six hours a perfect page without reflection or pause of the pen in expression, as hath been established as the criterion before men of discernment. Who today is capable of this, or hath anyone come forth with this before? This indeed is the greatest proof for whosoever would remember or fear.

And if thou makest proof to be the paths of spiritual disciplines and raptures, then God is able to cause a servant to reach the station of the ultimate possibility and the effusion of existence without such means, for He doeth what He willeth as He pleaseth. And this my word unto thee is but an indulgence in the mention of proofs; otherwise, the true honor of those stations is to attain unto the rank of the knowledge of the Self-revelation of the Essence. Whomsoever God causeth to reach it without those means hath no need of them.

And if thou wouldst take as thy proof the love of God, the secret of Lordship, the Temple of the All-Sufficing, the Light of Divinity, the abstract form purified from the traces of the foul city, the hallowed attributes, the self-subsisting manifestations, the sovereign dispositions of the realm of dominion, the tokens of the empyrean, the stations of Divinity, the tremulous utterances of the All-Merciful, the divine scintillations, the existential emergences, the essential theophanies, the eternal breaths—and whatsoever God hath created beyond these in a world without end, unto an endlessness beyond endlessness—God is witness for me.

And He hath appointed for every right its reality, and for every recompense a light. This day, thou dost observe that those of thy kind among the mystics of that land and beyond, all lay claim to that station, even whilst some repudiate others. Similarly, in matters of religious law, all the divines claim the station of authority and, by the text of the Proof—peace be upon him—make their own denial equivalent to denial of God, the All-Glorious, even whilst some curse others. I adjure thee, by Him Whose right over thee transcendeth all else, be thou fair and hesitate not. For how can truth be established and falsehood nullified when each party rejoiceth in that which it possesseth? Indeed, shouldst thou desire to repudiate another, thou couldst do so, making thy proofs the verses of the Qur'an, the traditions of the people of the Bayan, and the manifestations of human ecstasy; and should another desire to repudiate thee, he could likewise do so with similar evidences.

Verily, truth is indubitable in its command: were it to be found pure with anyone, none would deny him. And falsehood is beyond doubt in its decree: were it not admixed with truth, none would believe it. I seek refuge in God, the Subduer, from the evil of every slanderous devil who turneth away from the verses of the All-Compelling through the words of the wicked. Verily today I perceive the station of certain polytheists in faith to be lower than the extent of Pharaoh's unbelief, for when he wished to deny his Lord's proof, he brought forth something of sorcery. Yet these people, though they were unable and will never be able to produce the like, have denied the truth and made themselves of an ignorant and ruined people.

Let it not occur to thy mind, O man, that my mention of these allusions regarding those whose station thou knowest and whose deeds thou hast witnessed raises dust in the path of love, for just as his word was written, I recognized him as truthful, yet I would that he would show mercy through his fairness today. Can truth be established without a balance or not? There is no doubt that the Cause of Truth hath

a balance from God, else truth would not prevail over falsehood. Indeed, that Cause which is from God—God hath sent down with it signs that cannot be confused with aught else, nor can any of His servants acquire them. If the nature of the verses wherewith God hath honored me and made them my proof were such as could be acquired, then why, after three years have passed, has no one been able to spontaneously produce a single verse?

Consider for a moment, O man, that while the letters of the alphabet are available to all, yet He Who speaks declareth that were all to gather together to bring forth the like of His words, they would be unable. If they could, why have they not done so? And if they cannot, why do they not believe in God's Cause? Glory be to God above what they associate with Him!

Judge thou fairly, O observer—today thou prayest according to the verses of the Qur'an, and fastest, performest pilgrimage, and marriest by them. How then dost thou today deny a Cause which God hath made a proof for those who previously denied the Imams of the Faith? Today there is no escape for one who believeth in the Qur'an except to acknowledge these verses. But let not the matter be confused in thy mind that the station of these verses is like unto the Qur'an. Nay, by thy Lord! My existence and all my traces are as nothing before a single letter of the Qur'an and the prayers transmitted from the Family of the Bayan and the traditions shining forth from the Suns of possibility. I have no existence save in my rank, and no portion save in my station. Just as God made spirits the meaning of bodies, likewise hath God created meanings as the spirits of words. In every case, they must distinguish between the words of the people of the secondary chain, which are but accidents and shadows in relation to the primary chain.

Observe this mirror: God revealed "Alif Lam Mim" in the Qur'an, and the Messenger of God—peace be upon Him and His Family—wrote "Alif Lam Mim", and the Imams—peace be upon them—wrote that same word similarly, and today thou writest that word. To those who perceive not the true ruling, the forms appear the same, whereas the "Alif Lam Mim" which thou writest is as nothing before the "Alif Lam Mim" written by the Family of God. Likewise is the ruling regarding the station of "Alif Lam Mim" written by God's Messenger—peace be upon Him and His Family—in relation to what God revealed in the Qur'an. And upon this luminous path most people have associated partners with their Lord's verses, and due to their lack of knowledge of these ranks, they have been unable to distinguish between these verses and the verses of the Qur'an. Therefore it weighed heavier upon their breasts than the creation of the heavens and earth. Were they to look with reality's eye, they would witness the Cause in the station of justice and distinguish between the words of the people of justice and grace.

O thou who asketh! Know what We have aided thee with, and understand that God hath advanced His proof in His Book through His word to whomever would deny His proof:

> "Then let them produce a discourse like unto it, if they speak truly"

[Q52:34]. Yet if thou art truthful, thou hast never produced such. And verily the liar, had he not come, would not have been beneficial in a state of denial. According to the interpretation given by Al-Askari (peace be upon him) in his commentary on Al-Baqarah, the ruling was explained that being unlettered was the coming of the Messenger of God (peace be upon him and his family), and whoever was not unlettered, his coming was not a proof.

Indeed, I say to all that I am He, so bring forth by nature and power such words that if all were to gather to bring forth their like, they could not do so. And whoever is able to bring forth a verse by nature, it is incumbent upon him infinitely and endlessly, for the matter whose origin is from God does not weary its possessor, nor can anyone resist it. All the objections in your book are fortified sophistry, for the proof is that which I have cast unto you. If you wish to see the words of proof in the station of balance, then read them before your beloved, for through them God establishes truth and nullifies falsehood, even though the polytheists detest it.

What I have mentioned to you in those allusions is the condition of the people of glory, and let the decree of the people of majesty in the world of limitation appear only through exposition and speech, just as God revealed the Qur'an likewise. What is mentioned in his book that today the proof is not exposition, but rather the proof is the manifestation through power of that which people are incapable of—this decree does not differ from His word, for the influence in all things infinitely and endlessly through them is body and the condition of bodies. Rather, today if someone were to influence your heart or body or stones or letters in a way that no one else could, it would not differ in the decree. And if you focus your vision and sharpen your gaze, you will recognize in the wisdom of that verse "Is one who stands upon a clear proof from his Lord" [Q47:14] and in other places God's exalted word "Say: If what you seek to hasten were in my power, the matter would be decided between me and you. But God knows best the wrongdoers." [Q6:58]

For every letter of his book, if you desired its exposition, the seas would be exhausted if it were upon the path of love which is the root of faith and the tree of certitude. And if you desired to nullify the sayings of the conjecturers and the lying fabricators, for each of their letters there are endless proofs unto infinity, whereby the one who gazes into the depths of the sea of oneness recognizes all that with the eye of certainty. I indicate for every seeking thereof a subtle sprinkling, lest anyone thereafter dare to oppose God's Cause and make light of what is momentous with God. However, I did not intend to reject the words which their author made as a gift to you, for indeed it is more exalted in station than to confuse those allusions.

Rather, whatever was written regarding the decree of the signs, he intended only the saying of those among the people who speak, as testified by what was written in this book. Indeed, as we only love that truth be established by truth and falsehood be nullified by truth, I shall explain some of what was mentioned from the sayings of those who speak without understanding, that it may be a proof for the believers, a conclusive word for the monotheists, a sign for the humble, and a punishment for the rejectors.

Here I am, after establishing the matter that whatever he wrote does not benefit in the arena of argument, for if he wrote a page or verse concerning verses for me to serve as proof, there is no benefit in multiplying speech unnecessarily. O human being, cast unto him in the field of confrontation the like of what he cast regarding you, for without that truth is not established and speech multiplies without profit. O thou who gazest with fairness and love! This indeed is the essence of all religion. Make not the matter difficult for thyself.

Consider the station of the Balance. If thou art capable of contention, then take up the pen and let it flow across the tablets. Otherwise, in the station of knowledge, the utterances of the people of ceremony profit no one, even if they be true. I have not written this epistle to thee regarding the station of the Balance, nor do I argue thereby with any of the people of the Bayan. But since the truth hath become obscure to him, and he desired to remember and be guided, I say that all the doubts of the people of the Sentence and the objections of the people of tradition are resolved through the validity of the Balance and the impotence of the people of the Bayan.

Look with the eye of certitude, for what thou hast intimated—that this is like unto the Muslim divines in their sciences—how far, how very far from thy conjecture! How canst thou exchange the spirit of the angels within thyself for the spirit of the animal? I have not made the science of alchemy My proof, nor geometry My demonstration. Rather, I have made the proof something which, by God's leave, none can escape save by turning away therefrom. And if thou desirest to say aught concerning it, it is incumbent upon thee to first speak concerning the verses of the All-Merciful, for My proof is the power that speaketh from nature through verses which, should all gather together to produce the like thereof, they would never be able.

Or if thou wishest to ask how and why and whereby, then bring forth a verse if thou be of the truthful. For this was the proof of the religion of Islam in the argument of the Qur'an against all the idolatrous nations. Thou canst not escape from this justice, for it is the Balance in the Bayan, and it is the Balance which God sent down upon Muhammad, the Apostle of God—peace be upon Him and His family. Through it are established the matter of Divine Unity, Prophethood, Guardianship, and the laws of Reality, the Path and the Law. Today thou disputest concerning it, so abandon the ways of proofs and ascend to the Source of proof whereby were established Prophethood, Guardianship and the Law, which is the Word whereby were established Prophethood, Guardianship and the Law.

And this is the Word which God hath sent down upon His beloved. Indeed, the proof of His evidence is the inability of all else, not its recognition, for thou canst never know the true eloquence that flows from the treasuries of nature. All that thou hast revealed of verses, signs, devotions and allusions containeth an overflow due to the abundance of multiplicities within thyself. Rather, His proof is the Book of the All-Merciful, established through the inability of all, not through its recognition. O thou who gazeth upon the manifestations of the heaven of paradise! Belittle not My Cause, for power encompasseth it from all sides. Despite thy striving, thou hast written but two lines at the end of thy sermon, some of which are mere Qur'anic verses while others are poorly composed and ineloquent. Of true eloquence therein are but two letters, and that word is naught but nature itself and nothing else.

What thou hast mentioned of grammatical errors and lack of connection stems from people's ignorance, just as the eloquent Arabs of old claimed that words like "qistas," "tannur," and "sijjil" were foreign terms, and that some words were mere ancient tales. They claimed there was no apparent connection between certain verses, and that some verses violated Arabic grammar rules, such as His words, exalted be His mention: "His name shall be the Messiah" and "Verily this is one of the greatest" and "These two are certainly sorcerers."

All denied God in what they said, for the standard is what God hath revealed in the Qur'an, not the whims of the transgressors among the people. Today the foreign scholars undoubtedly lack the natural eloquence of the Arabs, so it is no wonder they say what they say. The difference is that today they believe in it, while those who mocked it in early Islam were disbelievers in it.

Fear God, O man, and reflect for a moment on the standard of utterance. I desired not to abrogate any law nor add a letter thereto, but rather by God's leave I manifested the grace He bestowed upon me, that those who denied the Imams of Justice might perish through a true proof, just as they believed in Muhammad, the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, and that the differences in religion might return to a single point, and all might thereby become among those who submit. By thy Lord! Those who fabricate anything contrary to the judgment of the Qur'an and the way of the people of the Bayan, even by as much as a letter, these are the companions of the Fire in God's Book, and these are the lost. If thou wert to discover what thy hands have earned in thy writing, thou wouldst cry out with a cry that nothing could quiet, for Ali, peace be upon him, said:

> "Whoso beareth one sin, it is as though he hath borne all sins."

And what sin is greater than people's lies against me without proof? God's curse be upon those who claim they can produce an utterance like what We have revealed in the Book yet do not do so, or who know that no one on earth can do so yet do not acknowledge it. God beareth witness unto all things, but most people are not thankful.

In what manner can the guides of truth demonstrate the falsehood of those who have slandered me? For I have said that it is incumbent upon God, if one who makes a claim does not speak from Him, to refute his proof with the like of what that claimant has made his proof. And you, by your Lord, be fair: is this statement denied by any possessed of understanding? Nay, it is accepted by all. I know not how your beloved enthusiast makes comparisons and opposes through mention of falsehood, when the disparity is beyond counting—neither in terms of the claim, nor the proof, nor the exposition. For he made a claim that was false by his own admission, having no proof that would render all people incapable, and God has invalidated it through the manifestation of His verses and evidences.

Today there is no claim except that of pure servitude, though the mention of servitude in the eyes of the people of truth is a grievous sin, for I have no real existence before the Proof (peace be upon him) that I might be His servant. However, in the station of divine manifestation and mention of the One manifested, I claim naught but pure servitude, and all goodly names in their rank are its attributes. The station of the believer, as clearly stated in the traditions, is that he cannot be described, just as the Proof (peace be upon him) cannot be described.

If you wish to act upon my oath in the Book and not alarm my heart with discourse, then first be fair and abandon excessive expressions, for by them the goal becomes veiled. If you establish the criterion, all matters will be set right thereby. If you do not establish it, then I shall not make supplications, sermons, sciences, nor universal manifestations a proof for one like you. Even if all that appears from me—while I remained unlettered regarding such evidences—were to be a proof for all the worlds.

Be not disquieted by the subduing force of words. I have renounced contention, nor do I, though the truth be with me, desire to dispute with any soul; for with certitude I behold that none can stand with me in the matter of the words of proof which surge from the fathomless deep of the ocean of primal nature and from the billowing sea of power. And all, were they but to reflect upon what they themselves utter, would hearken and fall silent, and would extend excuse.

What has been mentioned in the station of the spirit of supplication is the essence of the matter, though he has erred in drawing conclusions. The truth in that most exalted station and greatest prospect is the manifestation of Him Who has no name, no description, no exposition and no attribute. The essences are cut off from His court, and material realities are withheld from addressing Him; for this is the station of the Letter of the Self-Revelation of the Essence, in the epiphany of sheer Ipseity and the precinct of unconditioned subsistence.

And they who, by the grace of God, attain unto that most radiant White Light, and the Divine Red Tree, and the Primordial Yellow Pearl, and the Ever-Green Eternal Leaf, verily speak as Ali—peace be upon him—declared in the Khutbat al-Tutunjiyyah: "I beheld God and Paradise with the eye of vision." They intend naught thereby save the beholding of the Countenance of Him Who revealeth Himself unto them—by them—through origination. Even as is plainly set forth in the sacred report wherein—exalted be His remembrance—"He was asked concerning God, glorified be He: Shall the believers behold Him on the Day of Resurrection?' He replied: Yea, and indeed they beheld Him before the Day of Resurrection.' It was asked: When?' He said: When He said unto them, Am I not your Lord?

They said, Yea!' Then he was silent for a while and said: And verily the believers behold Him in this world before the Day of Resurrection—dost thou not behold Him in thy rank at this very moment?' It was said: Shall I transmit this from thee?' He answered: Nay; for if thou relate it and a denier, ignorant of what thou sayest, reject it, he will deem it anthropomorphism and unbelief. The vision of the heart is not as the vision of the eye. Exalted is God above what the anthropomorphists and the atheists ascribe unto Him."'

They are a people whom veils conceal not, whom tokens withstand not, whom signs cannot keep pace with. Though they rest upon the dust, they behold the Throne of Glory. They speak naught concerning any matter save of God, the Lord of Glory and Beauty. They dwell through none but Him, and speak of none but Him. They see neither hope nor fear nor remembrance save the remembrance of God, the Most Great, the Most Glorious, the Most Bountiful. Nay, they are sanctified above the mention of names and attributes of aught else. Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above all that they describe!

This is but a drop from the ocean of knowledge of that station. In drawing conclusions, He hath made the effects of that station among the words of the Water of Truth. Exalted be God, the Lord of Creation, above the decree of destiny and origination! How then did the Family of God, peace be upon them, act, when none can doubt their station? The Sahifah Alawiyyah and Sahifah Sajjadiyyah are the Water of Truth. Indeed, they read them and commanded all to read them. If this matter is thus with thee, how is it that he acted not according to what he wrote, though he deemed himself more worthy of that Most Exalted Station than others? Nay, by thy Lord! The station of the spirit of communion was not established among creation save through those communions. And whoso cannot commune with his Lord through such prayers hath not attained that station, for they who are possessed of understanding know not what

is there save through what is here. Say: Create thou a scroll from the station of the spirit of communion through innate capacity before Me, even as I created before witnesses. God sufficeth as a witness unto Me.

Indeed what he mentioned—that thy companion attained no knowledge save through the negation of names and attributes from the sacred court of the Divine Essence—by thy Lord, he spoke pure truth, and I beseech God to set right his affairs through his mention of that station, though he intended naught save the negation of mention from the aspect of affirmation.

This indeed is the supreme honor and most complete portion with Me, and through it do I glory over all atoms which God hath created at My level, for the foundation of religion is the recogntion of God. Recognition ascends and becomes refined until it reaches its ultimate station, as Ali (peace be upon him) said: "The perfection of Divine Unity is the negation of attributes from Him," as evidenced by the fact that every described thing is other than its description, and by their dual testimony which is impossible for the First One. And this indeed is the station of the self-encompassing Kaf, wherein Ali taught all in the sermon known as Al-Yatimiyyah: "If you say from what is He?' then He is distinct from all things, so He is He. And if you say He is He,' then the Ha' and Waw' are descriptive words indicating Him, not attributes revealing Him. And if you say He has a limit, the limit is for other than Him. And if you say the air is related, the air is His creation."

One returns from description to description, and the heart becomes blind to understanding, and understanding to perception, and perception to derivation. The kingdom remains in the kingdom, and creation ends with its like, and seeking drives it to its form, and investigation leads to incapacity, and explanation to loss, and denial to despair, and conveyance to severance. The way is blocked and the quest returned. His evidence is His signs, and His existence is His proof.

Whoever contemplates the indications of that unique and eloquent sermon, speaking from the Tree of Praise, will testify that the description of the possible is itself possible, and the attribute of the dependent is dependent, and the kingdom endures in the kingdom. And concerning this matter, Al-Rida (peace be upon him) said:

> "Indeed, tools only define themselves, and instruments only point to their like, and in things their effects are found."

And so continues the tradition. None in contingent existence has nobility except through decisive knowledge in the midst of pure manifestation. Whoever has not tasted that water has no portion in Divine Unity nor any path to the station of detachment.

Most of the Illuminationist philosophers, Peripatetics, Transcendent theosophists, and Divine philosophers have stumbled in explaining this station. The signs of creative manifestations have become confused with the countenance of the Divine Essence, and thus they have made false statements about the fixed archetypes in the Essence to prove His knowledge, glory be to Him, and about the simple reality in proving the causality of the Essence, and about the connection between the Essence and acts and attributes, and about the unity of existence between the Creator and the created.

And verily all of this is pure polytheism in the sight of the Family of God, the Imams of Justice, for God has ever been All-Knowing without the existence of anything, just as He has ever been Living. And just as He needs not any other being for His life, He needs not any object of knowledge for His knowledge.

The Divine Essence has never been joined with anything, and the causation of contingent beings is His handiwork—it is the Will which God created through itself, without being touched by the fire of the Essence. Through it God created all beings, and it ever speaks only of itself and indicates naught but its own identity. God has no sign in creation that points to His Essence, for His Being separates all beings from knowledge of Him, and His Identity prevents all identities from description. The relation of the Will to Him is like the relation of the House to God—it is a relation bestowing honor upon creation, not unto the Essence, for He is sanctified above the mention of allusions, relations, indications, signs, stations, effulgences and fragrances attributed to Him. He is as He is, none knoweth Him save Himself.

The doctrine of the unity of existence and the mention of the simple reality is witnessed by the people of the covenant to be false, for how can speech describe the existence of Him beside Whom there is no other? Rather, all allusions in the worlds of divinity, might, dominion and earthly realm pertain to contingent hearts and souls and what occurs in imagination. Every description of God from other than Him is falsehood and lies, for there is no other beside Him, nor is any mentioned in His rank, nor has any existence with Him that would allow discourse about unity. I have expounded the proofs in the two thousand verses explaining the mystery of the letter Ha' to refute the claims of these men. The origin of this doctrine is a chapter from Muhyi'd-Din—may God hasten His vengeance—as mentioned in the Fusus, and that is pure polytheism in the sight of the people of inner meaning. The description of God by Himself, then the description by the Family of God—peace be upon them—and the people of the Bayan, is the description of the ultimate possibility for man to describe the All-Merciful through sanctifying Him above mention of names and attributes, as ʿAli son of Husayn—peace be upon them both—indicated in his prayer to Abu Hamza Thumali:

> "My God, through Thee have I known Thee, Thou showed me the way to Thyself and called me to Thee, and had it not been for Thee, I would not have known who Thou art."

And his martyred father—may my spirit be a sacrifice for him—indicated in the station of the manifestation of his light and the emergence of his countenance in his words, when he said, exalted be his mention:

> "Has any other than Thee a manifestation that Thou hast not, such that he could be the one to manifest Thee? When wert Thou absent that Thou shouldst need a proof to point to Thee, and when wert Thou distant that the traces should be that which lead to Thee? Blind is the eye that seeth Thee not, though Thou art ever its Guardian. Lost is the transaction of a servant for whom Thou hast not appointed a share of Thy love."

Conclusion

Thou knowest, O my God, that in mentioning these allusions I desire naught but what Thou hast ordained for me in the law of stations, lest truth be confused with falsehood and lest anyone imagine aught

concerning me save my love for Thee. And when I mention the verses of limitation, Thou knowest I intend naught but to manifest Thy proof and nullify the evil thoughts of those who think ill of me, even though I have mentioned the verses of Thy mercy more than these. Therefore, O Lord, forgive me and forgive him who desireth Thy pure religion, and him who sendeth down the gift to my beloved in the depths of the heart, and him who observeth the trace of ink in these tablets, and pardon in me what Thou lovest not to be mentioned before Thy Majesty, through Thy grace, Thy generosity and Thy mercy, O Thou Lord of Glory and Bounty!

O God, Thou knowest that my very existence is a sin, how much more so when sin acquireth another sin. But since Thou hast promised to transform the evil deeds of the believers into good deeds, I beseech Thee, O Lord, to inspire him who would deny Thy forbearance—for love of Thy good-pleasure—with the word of patience and forgiveness, for I have no strength to hear the word "no" from anyone. Unto Thee do I commit my affairs, O Lord of Glory and Bounty! Glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. Peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00050: Sahifiy-i-Mukhtasar

Part 1: "Praise be to God Who guideth whom He…"

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Praise be to God Who guideth whom He willeth and leadeth astray whom He willeth. Glorified and exalted be He above what they associate with Him.

O my God! Thou art He Who brought all created things into being from nothing by Thy command. Then didst Thou make known unto them the path of Thy Cause and the stations of Thy prohibition, lest anyone be veiled from the countenance of Thy presence by anything, seeing Thee manifest in all things. O my God! There is no remembrance but Thine, that I might remember Thee, and no honor save in obedience to Thee, that I might turn unto it. Nay, by Thy glory! Every mention through the sovereign power of Thy Will hath been mentioned before Thee, and every existent thing, through mention of the existence of Thy Will, hath withered in Thy dominion. There is no glory for anyone except in obedience to Thee, and no abasement save in disobedience to Thee.

Glorified art Thou! Glorified art Thou! Thee do we recognize and Thee do we unify, after having become certain that Thy Essence transcendeth all essences beyond recognition and proof, and that Thy Identity is severed from all material things beyond description and means. For without nearness to Thee there is no life in Thy creation, and without love for Thee there is no obedience to Thy Book.

I beseech Thee, O God, by the might of Thy Self-Subsistence and the greatness of Thy Grandeur, to send Thy blessings upon Muhammad and the family of Muhammad, the Manifestations of Thy Eternality and the Dawning-Places of Thy Mercy, by virtue of what Thou art in the glory of Being, the attribute of Essence, the description of Identity, the majesty of Eternity, and the holiness of Self, and by virtue of what Thou createst in the effulgences of the Divine Realm in the present time, the manifestations of the

Kingdom before time, and the conditions of sovereignty and dominion after time, and by what Thy knowledge hath encompassed of the breaths of Thy holiness and the stations of Thy Cause which no knowledge of any servant can encompass and which cannot be mentioned in written records due to the loftiness of the station of creation, through Thy grace and bounty, O Lord of the heavens and earth, and God of all creation!

O my God! How can I call upon Thee when my remembrance hath become a veil between me and the countenance of Thy face? And how can I not call upon Thee when Thy attraction rendeth asunder the veils and bringeth the servant to the station of the manifestation of Thy revelation? O my God! Grant me such a state that I may not be content save with Thy love and Thy good-pleasure, and may not grieve save through Thy displeasure and disobedience to Thee. For I have no power over this after my knowledge of Thy overwhelming power and justice, then Thy might and vengeance. For if Thou shouldst will by the decree of justice, all who dwell in the kingdoms of the heavens and earth would perish in an instant from Thy sovereignty. But since Thy custom is grace and beneficence, and Thy way is pardon and favor, Thou judgest each according to what their hands have earned, that they might be delivered from the darkness of turning away and might willingly be content with Thy countenance and standing before Thee.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou knowest my secret and my public self. I love naught except what Thou lovest, as Thou lovest. I beseech Thee by Thy bounty to make me one of Thy sincere servants who have recognized Thy truth and have turned away from all else because of Thy prohibition, and who have become firm upon the carpet of Thy nearness and pleasure, and have found delight in Thy remembrance and praise. They have sought forgiveness for all that Thy knowledge encompasseth and that which Thou abhorrest in Thy Book and that which Thou lovest not for any of Thy servants. They have submitted to Thy commandments and have manifested the spiritual virtues among Thy servants—those servants whose obedience Thou hast linked to obedience unto Thee, and whose disobedience Thou hast linked to disobedience unto Thee, through Thy grace and bounty, O Most Generous of the generous ones!

O my God! How can I mention my tribulations before Thee when Thou art the One Who sent them down? Though I have been patient in Thy path and have heard words of disbelief from Thy servants, Thou didst hear from the Christians what Thou didst hear, then from the Jews what Thou didst hear, then from the Arabs what Thou didst hear. Yet after that Thou didst not hasten in their judgment until the Hour came upon them suddenly and seized them for what their hands had wrought, as recompense for their unbelief. I am content with what Thou dost patiently endure and do, and I desire naught save what Thou desirest. In the station of my contentment I say: Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Glory be to Him Who knoweth what is in the heavens and the earth, and Who judgeth between all things with truth. Glorified and exalted is He above what they associate with Him! O my God! Since I know there is no way for me to know Thy Self and praise Thy Essence except through what Thou hast revealed in Thy Book and ordained in Thy verses, I therefore praise the Beauty of Thy Presence, and the Pure Essence in Thy Prophet, and the Camphor Spring in Thy Chosen One, according to what Thou hast permitted Thy servants and manifested unto me through Thy creation, and inspired me in the kingdom of Thy heaven and earth, and what Thou lovest and art pleased with.

I testify that there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thou hast ever been without the existence of aught besides Thee, and Thou wilt ever be as Thou wast in the eternity of eternities. None can know Thy Essence save Thyself, nor can any but Thee comprehend Thy Oneness, for the highest abstractions of creation point to differentiation, and the ultimate realities of invention testify to division. Thou art the Ancient, the All-Knowing. And I testify that Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, was the Manifestation of Thy Beauty and the Garment of Thy Countenance, and the first of Thy creation and the mystery of Thy invention, whom Thou didst choose from the midst of pre-existence above all nations, and didst select before the mention of nothingness for the station of Thy manifestation upon the most enduring throne—the foremost Prophet and the honored Chosen One, whom Thou didst extract from the essence of the oil of the leaf of creation, and didst make him the station of Thyself in expression, for Thou hast ever been and wilt ever be beyond association with beginning and destiny, praise and execution.

Thou art the Great, the Most Exalted. And I bear witness to the branches and leaves of the Divine Tree according to what God hath ordained for them in the knowledge of the Unseen, which none knoweth save Him, and He witnesseth all things, and He is the Mighty, the Bestower.

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who bestoweth His remembrance in the Book upon whomsoever He willeth among His servants. Glorified and exalted be He above all that they attribute unto Him.

O my God! Thou art He Who hath revealed Thyself to all created things through Thy creation, and hath made known unto them the path of obedience to Thee through Thy signs, that all might submit to Thy decree.

O God! Thou art the Single, the One, Whom nothing can describe and no servant can know, for Thine Essence hath ever been beyond the reach of signs to indicate through similitudes, and Thy Being shall forever remain beyond the power of symbols to prove through evidence. If I say “Thou art Thou,” then similitudes would tell of likenesses, yet Thou canst never be known through these. And if I say “He is He,” then would Oneness point to the Essence of creation and Unity to the Reality of invention, though these in their very nature can only point through negation and can only be described through denial.

Wherefore glorified, glorified art Thou! I seek Thy forgiveness for what I have said and say. And I say thereafter and beseech Thee to transform all that Thy knowledge encompasseth of me into that which befitteth Thy Self and that which characterized Thy station of majesty and glory, grandeur and beauty, might and grace, power and beneficence, through Thy favor and Thy generosity, O Thou Who art the Lord of bounty and bestowal, O Thou Who art the Lord of mercy and grandeur, O Thou Who art the Lord of grace and glory, justice and praise, for verily Thou art God, the Most Great, the Most High!

O my God! Thou knowest my station in what Thou hast bestowed upon me according to Thy will in Thy knowledge. I have spoken unto the people by Thy leave, yet they have invented falsehoods against me in following their desires. Thou indeed dost bear witness that I am innocent of that which they invent in their ignorance.

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who strengtheneth whom He willeth through His aid, and destroyeth those who wrong their own souls; then shall all be gathered unto God on the Day of Judgment. O God! Thou art the One, the Self-Subsisting Lord, Whom no description of anything can encompass, nor any attribute of anything define, for all else besides Thy Essence is bounded by the limits of creation and characterized by the attributes of invention. Thou art far more exalted than to be described through Thy creation or to be indicated through Thy handiwork. Glorified and exalted art Thou above what they describe!

O God! I beseech Thee on this day of the month of Ramadan, wherein Thou didst reveal the Qur'an and didst make its fast obligatory upon all who seek Thy good-pleasure and fear Thy justice, and wherein Thou hast ordained a Night whose worth no book can reckon, and which Thou hast, through Thy bounty, made better than a thousand months. O God! Deprive me not of its breezes, nor of its blessings, and preserve me from following vain desires in the obligations of Thy laws and from heedlessness of Thy manifestations at all times. Strengthen me through divine essences, heavenly realities, angelic souls, celestial beings, paradisiacal attributes, sublime appearances, wondrous revelations, and all that Thy knowledge encompasseth and Thy Book recordeth. Verily, Thou art the Mighty, the Most High!

O God! I bear witness before Thee and before those who bear witness in Thy presence that I am Thy servant who hath never claimed Vicegerency nor its sisters, nor Divine Revelation nor the Qur'an in the manner Thou didst ordain for Thy beloved Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family. Neither have I followed the base desires of men nor contradicted the ordinances of the Furqan. Sufficient art Thou as witness and helper, and sufficient art Thou as guardian for the believers.

O God! Thou knowest the treachery of eyes and what people's hands have earned in Thy days, as if they had never read Thy Book, nor acted according to Thy laws, nor feared Thy justice. Thou didst say—and Thy word is the truth—"We inspired them to do good deeds." Then Thou didst say—and Thy promise is the truth—"Fear God and He will grant you a criterion," and there is no doubt that Thy promise shall be fulfilled.

O God! When Thou didst honor me with that station, all suspected and denied, not knowing nor understanding. O God! Thou knowest their station and art aware of their deeds, and nothing escapeth Thy knowledge. Verily, Thou art the All-Powerful, the Compeller, the Subduer, the Mighty, the All-Knowing.

O God! I know that Thou dost not hasten in their judgment that they might increase in sin, for only those who fear loss make haste. Thou hast ever been mighty in what Thou willest, and none can reverse Thy judgment. Verily, Thou art the Mighty, the Wise.

O my God! I beseech Thee to vouchsafe unto me the light of detachment and the wisdom of exultation, that I may forget every goodly thing save Thee, and arise before the City of Thy hallowed, self-sufficient sanctity, and say: I bear witness that there is none other God but Thee, alone, without partner. Thine is the creation and from Thee is the command. Glorified art Thou, exalted far above that which they impute unto Thee.

I bear witness that Muhammad is Thy servant, whom Thou didst choose out of the bosom of pre-eternity above all nations, and whom Thou didst elect to stand in Thy station for origination and invention; for

Thou hast ever been, and shalt forever be, immeasurably exalted above conjunction with the making of existents or the bringing forth of possibles. And Thou, as Thou hast spoken—and Thy word is the truth—in Thy praise:

> "No vision taketh in Him, but He taketh in all vision; He is the Subtle, the All-Informed."

And I bear witness, concerning the trustees of Thy Messenger—Thy blessings be upon them—unto that which Thou hast ordained for them in the knowledge of the unseen, short of the Letter which Thou didst exclusively bestow upon Thy Beloved—may the blessings of God be upon him and his kindred—in the station of prophethood. Undoubtedly were they the pillars of Thy oneness, the signs of Thy hallowing, the tokens of Thy glorification, and the manifestations of Thy operation—on a Day when none was mentioned but they. Verily, they are Thy honoured servants who outstrip Thee not in speech, and by Thy command do they act.

I bear witness, moreover, unto every truth with that whereunto Thou Thyself dost bear witness, then dost love and approve; and against every falsehood with that which Thy Book doth enumerate, then dost abhor and forbid.

And I say: Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above that which they ascribe unto Him! And peace be upon the Messengers; and praise be to God, the Lord of all the worlds.

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who forgiveth whom He willeth and chastiseth whom He willeth. Glory be to Him! He knoweth what descendeth from heaven and what occureth in the earth and that wherein men differ. O my God! When I know that Thy praise of Muhammad and his family is ever renewed through the manifestation of Thy creation, I venture to praise them before Thee, though I am certain that my existence is as nothingness before their station, let alone my praise before the loftiness of their glory and the greatness of their state. Yet there is no mention like the mention of an ant of themselves. Glory be to Thee and exalted art Thou! Thou knowest their excellence and art able to praise them. There is no God but Thee! Glory be to Thee above what they describe.

O God! Praise Muhammad and the family of Muhammad through what Thou possesseth of the effulgences of the Divine Essence, the manifestations of the Realm of Power, and the conditions of the Kingdom, and through what Thou art able to achieve of the station of unity, glory, grandeur, praise, might, sublimity, majesty, origination, grace, execution, and what Thy knowledge encompasseth in the world of creation. Verily, Thou art God, the Great, the Bestower.

O God! Bless Muhammad and the family of Muhammad in the tidings of the ancients, the glad-tidings of those who came before, the justice of those who fear, and the grace of those who are near. O God! Bless Muhammad and the family of Muhammad by the light of Thy countenance in Seir, the manifestation of Thy revelation on Mount Paran, the signs of Thy power in the land of Egypt, and the appearances of Thy Will in Beer-sheba, through Thy favor and Thy bounty, O God of the worlds.

O God! Bless and grant peace upon Muhammad and his family at their resting places for all eternity through Thy signs in the dome of time, Thy evidences in the Tree of Utterance, and Thy light in the pillar of fire above the Ark of the Covenant, through Thy mercy, O Lord of the worlds.

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

He Who guideth whom He willeth to a straight path. O God! Thou art God, the Creator of all things. There is no God but Thee. I have known Thee through what Thou hast revealed to me through Thy creation, and I have thanked Thee for what Thou hast bestowed upon me through Thy bounties. Thou art He Whose essence cannot be described and Whose ailment cannot be known, for the essence of Thy Being separateth all existence from knowledge, and the manifestation of Thy Identity severeth all contingent things from the mention of expression. Glory be to Thee! Glory be to Thee! Forever hath the description of Thy Essence been Thine Essence, and the attribute of Thy Self been Thy Self, for naught besides Thee existed at Thy level nor was mentioned with Thee.

Verily, Thou hast brought into being all that Thou willeth, as Thou willeth, through what Thou willeth, from nothing, by Thy creation, and Thou dost ever sustain all that Thou hast created through Thy grace, even as Thou didst bring them into being through Thy bounty. All praise be unto Thee for having made known unto me the stations of Thy Cause and the abodes wherein Thy wisdom is manifest unto Thy servants who desire naught except by Thy command and judge not except by Thy leave—the Imams of religion, the pillars of the faithful, and the guides of all creation. O my God! I bear witness unto Thy Being, even as Thou didst bear witness unto Thyself before all things, that Thou art God, there is none other God but Thee, the Lord of all created things.

Part 2: “In the Name of God, the Crusher…”

In the Name of God, the Crusher of tyrants, the Destroyer of transgressors, and the God of all creation! O Lord! None can reverse Thy judgment, none can alter Thy command, none can frustrate Thy words, and none can exhaust Thy signs. I beseech Thee, O Lord, by Muhammad and his family—the Manifestations of Thy divine essence, the stations of the glory of Thy being, the signs of the might of Thy eternality, and the tokens of the sanctity of Thy oneness—to bless the family of God in accordance with Thy station of divinity, grandeur, magnificence and might, and to ordain for us in this night of Thy Greatest Month that which befits Thy bounty. Verily, Thou art God, the Generous, the Bestower.

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who created what is in the heavens and what is in the earth by His command. Then those who believe in God and His signs shall be gathered unto God. O God! Thou art my God and my Lord. Thou didst create me when I was nothing, and by Thy grace Thou didst provide for me after I had been mentioned. How can I call upon Thee when Thy essence cuts me off from utterance at the moment of recognition? And how can I not call upon Thee when the reality of Thy manifestation in my heart cannot rest without the presence of Thy countenance, O Bestower, O Judge? By Thy might! Even after the way is blocked and the path barred, I will call upon Thee and declare Thy oneness, though I know with certainty that my prayer returns only with despair and my declaration of unity is raised only in separation.

For my desire from Thee is none other than Thee, and this is impossible for creation, since none but Thee can know Thee, and none but Thee can find Thee. Similarly is the judgment regarding my declaration of Thy unity, for unity between two things is impossible, as Thou hast ever been existing, while I shall ever cease to be, just as before my existence I was nothing before Thee.

Alas! Alas! By the might of Thy essence, if Thou wert to take all that Thy knowledge encompasses and of which Thou art capable, and make it the substance of my body, then make it the fire of my secret and manifest being, and extend it for all eternity as punishment for my declaration of Thy unity, Thou wouldst be praiseworthy in Thy deed and obeyed in Thy judgment. Indeed, I would deserve this and all that Thy knowledge encompasses, save Thy essence, and I would praise Thee alone—there is no God but Thee. And verily, through this deservingness, I am certain that One such as Thee, the Generous, would not be satisfied with anything for me except Thy grace and good-pleasure. Now, in the gardens of Thy sanctity, in Thy paradise, I am blessed by Thy bounties, and nothing in the heavens or the earth grieves me, by Thy grace, for Thou art the Generous, the Noble.

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who sends down His command upon whomsoever He willeth among His servants according to a prescribed term. O God! How can I not cry out before Thee when my sins have encompassed me from every direction? And how can I not calm my soul when I witness Thy treatment of the believers with forgiveness, and know Thy way with the unitarians through beneficence, and with the eager ones through grace? Far be it from thinking of Thee otherwise, for when Thou dost not wish the appearance of Thy Manifestation in forgiveness, Thou dost not execute the decree with implementation.

Glorified art Thou! Glorified art Thou! My circumstances have rendered me unable to mention my transgressions before Thee, and my ultimate state has silenced me from mentioning my destructive deeds before Thy omnipotence. For if I say “Thou art Thou” or seek Thy forgiveness by virtue of who Thou art, or turn to Thee in repentance by virtue of who Thou art, I have already committed another sin, for my very existence is a sin—how then can the consequences thereof be judged? Nay, by Thy might! I have no cause for forgiveness before Thee, for just as Thou didst create me without any merit or cause on my part, likewise do Thou pardon me and forgive me and admit me into the court of Thy nearness, that I may delight in gazing upon the countenance of Thy manifestation and dwell there before the throne of Thy Self-Subsistence, and declare: “Thou art God, there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner.

I have known Thee through Thyself and worshipped Thee through Thy Face, and were it not for Thee, I would be nothing, not even able to say ʿI know not what Thou art.”’ Glory be unto Thee! Here am I, casting myself before Thee, seeking intercession through Muhammad and his family—Thy blessings be upon them—fleeing from Thee unto Thee. Bestow upon me through Thy grace and have mercy upon me through Thy mercy, for I declare: “There is no God but Thee, glory be unto Thee, I have been among the wrongdoers.”

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Glory be to Him Who hath sent down the verses in the Book for a people who act with justice. O my God! Thou art He Who hath commanded with an authority that none other than Thee can command, and

forbidden what none other than Thee can forbid, and art pleased with good deeds with which none other than Thee can be pleased. I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy truth, to draw our hearts to the court of Thy nearness, our souls to the station of Thy manifestation, and our bodies to the place of Thy bounty, and make us among those who come unto Thee, who are pleased with Thee, who seek after Thee, and who trust in Thee, through Thy grace and favor. Verily Thou art God, the Beloved of the mystics and the God of all creation.

O God! I bear witness on this tenth day of the Greatest Month, wherein Thou didst reveal the Qur'an and made one of its nights better than a thousand months when Thou didst ordain therein the mystery of days according to what Thou didst prescribe for the believers in the Qur'an, that Thou art God, there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thou hast ever been, while naught existed besides Thee, and Thou wilt ever be as Thou wert, with nothing existing at Thy level, for the essence of creation declareth the path barred, and the reality of invention testifieth that the way is blocked. Thou hast ever been too exalted to be described by other than Thyself or to be known through any but Thee.

Thou art God, the Mighty, the Bestower. And I bear witness to Muhammad—God's blessings be upon him and his family, and the family of God, peace be upon them—according to what Thou hast ordained for them in the knowledge of the unseen and decreed for them in the primal word. Verily Thou art the Great, the Exalted. I beseech Thee, O God, by their right, to ordain for us the pilgrimage to Thy House and annihilation before the sacred realm of Thy mercy in the land of the Sacred Monument and the Station, and all the blessings Your knowledge encompasses in the land of Arafat, through Your favor and bounty, O Most Merciful of those who show mercy. And I say: Praise be to God, the Lord of all the worlds.

On the Night of Mid-Ramaḍan (the Most Great Month)

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God, Who sendeth down the Command at every season unto a people that understand. O my God! Thou art He Who hath decreed for every thing what Thou hast willed, and hast bestowed upon all that which Thou hast ordained. None can turn back Thy command, nor can any man gainsay Thy judgment. Ever hast Thou favored me through Thy loving-kindness and honored me with Thy bounties. Thou didst create me when I was a thing forgotten, and, by Thy grace, didst sustain me after Thou hadst drawn me nigh through Thy remembrance. How, then, shall I render Thee thanks, O my God, whilst Thou hast ever been exalted above being described by Thy creatures? And how shall I not laud the rising of the court of Thy Self-Subsistence, while Thou didst create me for the mention of Thy power, the praise of Thy Will, the splendor of Thy bounty, and the celebration of the sheen of the holiness of Thy mercy?

Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou! Ever hast Thou been the Remembrer of Thine own Self by Thine own Self, and the Unifier of Thy very Essence by Thy very Essence; for whatsoever is other than Thee is powerless to apprehend the reality of Thy Ipseity, or to affirm the oneness of the identity of Thy Being. The sanctity of the awe of Thy majesty hath cut off the essences of all things from the mention of drawing nigh unto the court of the glory of beauty and majesty; and the inmost reality of the rising of Thy Self-Subsistence hath sundered all existences from the station of certitude and recognition before the Midian of the power of the All-Exalted.

Glorified art Thou! By Thy might, I long to ascend unto Thee; yet how shall I complain, when I find no guide and behold no path? Ah, alas! After my despair of truly affirming Thy unity, and my remoteness from the court of Thy nearness, I call upon Thee with my whole being, that Thou art God, the Lord of the heavens and the earth. The pillars of all things hath the light of Thy Countenance and the splendor of Thy rising filled, so that none beholdeth an existent thing but he seeth Thee manifest before it and with it—Thou the Sovereign, the All-Powerful, the Self-Sufficient, from Whose knowledge nothing is hidden. Verily, Thou art the All-Informed, the Subtle.

O my God, make my state, through the perpetuity of the might of Thy Essence, this very state wherein I behold none save Thee and say: "Praise be to God, the Lord of all the worlds."

On the Night of Power (Laylat al-Qadr)

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God, Who sendeth down the Command upon whom He willeth among His servants. Hallowed and exalted is He! He knoweth what descendeth from heaven and what occurreth upon earth, and what men have wrought in the Religion of God.

O my God! This is the Night whose primacy the Tablet cannot reckon; in it alone do the Spirit and the angels descend; and in it alone is any affair ordained for anyone. I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy bounty, to send Thy peace upon Thy Proof, the son of Thy Proof—the One Who standeth by Thy command, veiled from Thy servants—Thy Light, Whom Thou didst create for Thine own Self, elect for Thy guardianship, choose for Thy sovereignty, select for Thy good-pleasure, strengthen by the Holy Spirit from Thy command, and appoint in the station of Muhammad, Thy Messenger—may Thy blessings be upon him and his kindred—in delivery and decree, in fore-ordainment and execution, in term and in bada' (the mysterious bringing-to-pass).

And that the fulfillment of Thy Will, in its execution, is not to be conceived as conjoined with the making of things; for ever hast Thou been exalted above being characterized by the highest essences of origination. Verily, Thou art the All-Powerful, the All-Bountiful.

O God, send down upon him in that blessed Night that whereby Thou art worthy, at the time of bestowal—of Thy ancient effulgences, Thy wondrous manifestations, Thy manifest breezes, Thy hidden signs, and whatsoever Thy knowledge hath encompassed and Thy Book hath recorded—none having access thereto save Thee—by Thy grace and bounty, O Thou Possessor of munificence and bestowal.

O God, through his power do Thou grant us victory; by his sovereignty do Thou exalt us; encompass us, by reason of his station, with the angels of the heavens and the earth; bring nigh, O God, his days; make firm our hearts through his signs; and succor us through his supplications. For we, indeed, find none but Thee able to accomplish what we ask and desire from Thee, and none besides Thee a refuge from that which we fear and dread of Thy justice.

O God, inscribe for us on that Night, by Thy irrevocable decree—against which there is no repulse—that which Thou lovest, through Thy Proof: such as will rejoice his eyes, by Thy grace and Thy bounty, O Most

Generous of the generous and Most Bountiful of the bountiful. For we, verily, say: Praise be to God, the Lord of all the worlds.

On the Night of the Breaking of the Fast

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who forgiveth whom He willeth, and chastiseth whom He willeth, and bestoweth sovereignty upon whom He willeth, and withholdeth authority from whom He willeth, as He willeth. Glorified and exalted is He Who commandeth justice and loveth grace, and forbiddeth evil and is not pleased with unbelief in anyone, and Who ordaineth kindness and forgiveness for the believers that perchance men may believe in His signs.

O my God! I bear witness unto Thy Being, even as Thou hast borne witness unto Thyself from time immemorial, without the testimony of any among the created things, that Thou art God, there is no God but Thee, the Mighty, the Powerful, the All-Bountiful. And I bear witness unto Thy Messenger, the unlettered Arabian, and unto Thy Prophet, the Hashimite of Batha, unto whom Thou hast made the excellence of Thy Self, and His justice the justice of Thy power, and His wisdom the wisdom of Thy Will, and His command the decree of Thy Purpose, and His manifestation the dayspring of the essence of Thy creation, and the secret of His being the vestures of the beauty of Thy holy mercy, and the bounty of His origin the munificence of Thy glorious generosity, and the attributes of His glorious servitude the examples of Thy holy dominion, and that which Thy knowledge hath encompassed in His conditions the examples of the manifestations of Thy self-subsistence, and in His signs the revelations of the holy appearance of Thy eternality, and in His stations the breezes of the glory of Thy oneness, and in His evidences the signs of Thy divinity, and that which Thou hast ordained for Him as Thou hast loved for Thyself. Verily Thou art the Mighty, the Gracious.

And I bear witness unto His successors, Thy blessings be upon them, according to that which Thou hast ordained for them in the knowledge of the unseen. Verily Thou art the Generous, the Most High.

O my God! Bless this Festival for us through Thy grace, and forgive us through Thy bounty, and turn unto us through Thy mercy. Verily Thou art the Generous, the Merciful.

BB00687: Prayer for Laylatu'l-Qadr

Part 1: "Praise be to God Who created the heavens…"

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate!

Praise be to God Who created the heavens and the earth by His command; then those who have believed in God and His signs shall indeed be gathered unto Him. O my God! How can I call upon Thee when Thou hast never been known save through Thyself, and Thou art even as Thou hast ever been, nothing having been with Thee? Glorified art Thou! Verily, Thou art God, the Single, the One, the Self-Subsisting, Whom none can know save Thyself. Thou art the Just One. If I say "Thou art Thou," then likeness would be

compared to likeness, yet Thou canst never be known thereby. And if I say “He is Thou,” then Oneness would indicate the essence of creation and Unity the reality of invention, which in itself decisively proves and distinctly separates created things through exclusion, for Thou hast never been associated with Thy creation nor described by Thy servants. Indeed, Thine Essence is the camphorated Essence which, by its very being, separates material things from the mention of Names and Attributes, and prevents realities from attaining to the station of explanation and the Divine Essence.

O my God! Thou art He Who created me, sustained me, caused me to know Thee, then guided me and strengthened me. Thou hast ever manifested Thyself to me through me, through what Thou art in the Names of the manifestations of the Essence and the appearances of the condition of Attributes. And in every condition I fall short of another condition—were Thou to chastise me for all eternity by the everlastingness of Thine Essence alone, I would truly deserve it. Thou art the Praiseworthy in Thy deeds and the Obeyed in Thy judgment. Verily, O my God, I am possessed of the greatest disobedience and the gravest of offenses, such that were anyone else to bear what I have borne while Thou willest for him the punishment of justice, he would surely perish.

Would that all who dwell in the heavens and on earth perish in an instant! O my God! I implore Thy forgiveness, for my very existence is a sin with which no other sin can compare. How can I not seek Thy forgiveness when Thou art the Possessor of boundless mercy and eternal forgiveness? O my God! Thou art the Beloved Who hast ever called me unto Thee and drawn me to the precincts of Thy nearness. If I say “Thou art the Living Beloved,” the essence of Thy creation belies me, for at all times created things can know naught save their own station and perceive naught but the dictates of their own selves. And if I say “Thou art the Almighty,” this too bespeaks powerlessness.

Thou hast created me within myself that I might know Thee as One Who cannot be described through Thy creation, nor indicated by the signs of Thy dominion, nor limited, nor sensed, nor described, nor touched. Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee! Thou art He Who hath numbered all things, Thou art He Who hath honored all things, Thou art He Who hath ordained all things, Thou art He Who hath guided all things, Thou art He Who hath ennobled all things, Thou art He Who hath strengthened all things.

Through Thy call was I made noble, and through Thy remembrance was my being made mighty. Thou art the Exalted, the Powerful, the Trusted, the All-Bountiful, Who hath ever been mighty to do what Thou willest, as Thou willest, by what Thou willest. None can resist Thy bidding, none can alter Thy word, and none can exhaust Thy signs.

I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy Self and the greatness of Thy names and attributes, to call me unto Thee in every condition secretly, that I might act for Thee openly. Grant me complete detachment unto the light of joy, and join me to the summit of union in the midst of the light of majesty and beauty.

Glory be unto Thee! Thy Essence is sanctified above the loftiest bird of all contingent beings taking wing toward it, and Thy Being is exalted above the most elevated abstractions attempting to know it. Thou art nearer to me than my own self, and more generous to me than all else, for Thy bounty hath no cause save Thyself and no splendor save the knowledge of Thy Essence. Thou hast ever revealed Thyself to me

through me, through the essence of the light of Thy oneness, the holy names of Thy mercy, and the manifestations of the glory of Thy Being.

Glory be unto Thee! My back is laden with the transgressions of my outward self to such degree that I cannot praise Thy Being. Alas, alas for that which hath befallen my heart, which I cannot reveal before Thy creatures! O my God! By Thy might, Thou knowest my secret and my public self. In no matter have I sought aught save the manifestation of the light of Thy oneness and the attainment of the precincts of nearness to Thy chosen ones. Thou art the Lord Whom nothing in the heavens or on earth can overwhelm. Thou ordainest what Thou willest as Thou willest, and withholdest from whom Thou willest as Thou willest, by what Thou willest.

This is a night the like of which the Book hath never recorded. I beseech Thee, O God, by the majesty of the countenance of Thy Self-Subsistence, by the glory of the light of Thy Self-Sufficiency, by the signs of the dominion of Thy All-Compelling power, and by the conditions of the manifestations of Thy Self-Sufficiency, to bless Muhammad and the family of Muhammad with all that belongeth unto Thee of the conditions of Thy mercy, the manifestations of Thy oneness, the revelations of Thy might, and whatsoever belongeth unto Thee of the effects of Thy power and the manifestations of Thy Self-Sufficiency, through Thy bounty and generosity. Verily, Thou art the Mighty, the Powerful.

O my God! My supplication is before the perpetual might of Thy oneness, and my station is before the eternal Self-Sufficiency. By Thy might, Thou knowest my secret and my public self, and I bear witness that this is a sin unequaled by any sin in the kingdom of Thy creation and Thy command. Thou art the Mighty, the Living, from Whose knowledge nothing escapeth and from Whose might nothing is beyond reach. I beseech Thee by Thy bounty to grant us on this night that which emanates from the manifestations of Thy Lordship's revelation and the holy breathings of Thy Divine Unity, and that which Thou art able to bestow from Thy wondrous breathings which none can reckon save Thee. O my God! Thou art He Who hath witnessed my disobedience, yet pardoned me, and Who hath seen my transgressions, yet shown forbearance toward me. By Thy might and Thy majesty, if Thou shouldst chastise me throughout all eternity by virtue of Thy holy Self-Subsistence with every torment within Thy power throughout endless time, then by Thy Truth which none knoweth save Thee, I would deserve such recompense.

Alas, alas, how can I mention Thee, O my God, when I have performed no good deed that Thou lovest and approvest? How could I remain silent before Thy holy Self-Sufficiency when I behold Thy dealings with those servants who are nigh unto Thee, who delight in Thy remembrance, who find repose in nearness to Thee, and who yearn for the beauty of Thine Essence? Verily, it hath ever been Thy way to show favor, and Thy practice to make manifest. Should Thou forgive me and admit me into the chambers of paradise among those servants nigh unto Thee, this would be of Thy grace toward me and Thy generosity unto me, even as Thou didst create me in the first day when I was nothing.

And should Thou punish me with the utmost severity of vengeance and wrath, and command the angels to cast me into the fire, then by Thy might I would cry out to Thee therein and lament my remoteness from Thee, and would make known unto its denizens that I am a servant who hath said:

> "I testify that there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thou hast ever been without the existence of aught else, and wilt ever remain without mention of aught else. Ever hast Thou been the Describer of Thine own Self unto Thyself, and the Unifier of Thine own Essence with Thine Essence. None besides Thee can comprehend Thy oneness or bear witness to Thy Self-Sufficiency, for Thou hast never been known through Thy creation nor described through Thy servants. When any besides Thee make mention of Thee, they but mention Thy creation, and when they unify Thee, they but acknowledge Thine invention, for Thou art far exalted above being described by the attributes of contingent things and what resembleth them, and sanctified beyond being characterized by the qualities of existent things and what correspondeth to them."

So glorified art Thou! Glorified art Thou! I speak, yet I fear not Thy justice and watch for Thy grace and rely upon Thee, O my God. Thou art He Who hath ever known His own Self, and wilt forever be even as Thou hast ever been. None of Thy creation shall ever know Thee, and none of Thy servants shall ever describe Thee, for Thy Essential Reality hath severed all beings from mention of the Essence among essences, and Thy Reality hath separated all existent things from mention of attributes among attributes. Should I say "Thou art Thou," Thy Self and all Thy creation would give me the lie, for the servant can never know the Essence of his Lord nor unify the Reality of his Creator. Rather, in all conditions he knoweth the bounds of his own self and describeth openly his own reality.

Glorified art Thou! Glorified art Thou! Thou art nearer than all things through Thy Self, and Thou art more exalted than all things through Thine Essence. Thou acceptest from the servants what none else would accept, and Thou commandest creation with authority that none else would command. Thou art He Who brought me into being, and hast ever remembered me. Thou art He Who originated me, and hast ever sustained my form. Unto Thee be praise, O my God, praise resplendent, brilliant, holy, radiant, gleaming, eternal, endless, which transcendeth all things and excelleth all things—praise befitting Thine Essence, describing Thy Court, and gathering beneath the shadow of Thy Self-Sufficiency—praise which Thou lovest and approvest, and which Thou makest the description of Thy Self by Thy Self among the creation, and the characterization of Thine Essence by Thine Essence among the servants.

Glorified art Thou! Thou art exalted above all existent things through the transcendence of Thy Self, and Thou art sanctified beyond the glorification of contingent things through the holiness of Thine Essence. How then can I render thanks unto Thee when Thou hast ever been beyond the knowledge of any save know Thee, for that with which I call upon Thee is but a manifestation of the revelations of Thy Lordship, and an attribute from the holy fragrances of Thy mercy, and a bounty from the manifestations of the vast ocean of Thy omnipotence. Glorified art Thou! Thou art He Who hath made the sign of Thy reality and Thy Lordship to appear in the horizons and in the souls, that through it they may recognize Thy oneness, and Thou art He Who hath made the mirror of the souls souls of the unitarians to be the dawning-places of Thy light.

Ah! Ah! By Thy glory, which no thing can equal, Thou hast revealed Thyself to me through me and hast remembered me amidst the concourse of Thy creation. And I, by my condition which hath no standing save through Thy remembrance of me, can never worship Thee as befitteth Thy servants, nor know Thee

as befitteth how Thou hast revealed Thyself to me through the manifestation of Thy sovereignty. Glorified, glorified art Thou! Thou hast ever been the Munificent, the Bestower, while I am the negligent, the prodigal. How can I mention myself before the surging ocean of Thy grandeur? The very mention of my existence is a sin that hath no equal in Thy dominion and no likeness in Thy wrath. If Thou shouldst desire to punish me for this sin throughout the eternity of Thy duration, the perpetuity of Thy omnipotence, and the confines of Thine everlasting self-subsistence, I would indeed deserve it. Thou art praised in Thy deeds and obeyed in Thy judgment. This judgment, which hath no equal before Thy omnipotence, is naught but pure truth, even as Thy reality.

Ah! Ah! I am he who hath disobeyed the Almighty of the heavens and the Throne by mentioning His Self, and I am he who hath turned away from the King of earth and heaven by making mention of His Essence. For He hath ever been too exalted to be known through His servants or to have the countenance of His Being described by any of His creatures. Glorified and exalted is He Who hath created all contingent things through His origination and hath made known to them the path of their love at the station of their creation, lest anyone be veiled from the countenance of His Will in anything, and that they might behold Him as a witness, present in all things, that there is no God but Him, the Powerful, the All-Bountiful, Who bestoweth upon whomsoever He willeth whatsoever He willeth as He willeth, and withholdeth from whomsoever He willeth as He willeth whatsoever He willeth. We acknowledge that He is the Most Merciful of the merciful in the realm of pardon and mercy, and the most severe of punishers in the station of might and power.

O my God! Thou art He before Whose holy court no description by Thy servants hath ever been befitting, nor can the hearts of all created things ever oppose the countenance of Thy divine omnipotence. For Thine Essence hath ever severed all contingent things and separated all existing things, and it beseemeth no one to say concerning Thee “Thou art Thou,” for Thou hast ever been singular in the unity of Thine Essence and in the knowledge of Thy Self. What the servants attain is but the station of their own selves and the ranks of their own identities which were created in them for the recognition of the stations of Thy command and prohibition, and for ascending to the place of Thy good-pleasure and the most glorious spirit of Thy forgiveness.

Ah! Ah! Is there anyone, O my God, who readeth these prayers and prostrateth not before the greatness of Thy countenance and forgetteth not himself before the presence of Thy Self-Subsistence? Nay, by Thy glory! I, by that condition than which I know of nothing lower in Thy knowledge, would be ashamed to say nay. How then could the hearts of the unitarians be content with anything else? Thou art indeed the Munificent, the Powerful, the All-Wise.

O my God! Since this night is the middle of Thy Greatest Month, wherein Thou didst ordain the Night of Power and made it better than a thousand months, and wherein Thou didst send down the Qur’an upon Thy beloved Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, I beseech Thee by his right that Thou make us to be among those who are successful in remembering Thee through Thy remembrance, who are content with Thy decree, who are thankful for Thy favors, who are supplicants at Thy gate, who place their trust in Thee, and who hold fast to Thy cord, through Thy grace and favor. Verily Thou art the

Mighty, the Powerful, from Whose knowledge nothing escapeth and from Whose judgment nothing can flee.

And Thou art He Who will judge between all things with Thy justice on the Day of Resurrection, even as Thou dost now judge the believers with Thy grace. Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou! I beseech Thee, O my God, by Thy generosity, to send down in that hour Thy mercy upon the graves of the repositories of Thy Cause, the mines of Thy wisdom, the places of Thy manifestation, and the dawning-places of Thy deeds—those trusted ones whom Thou hast chosen for Thyself, with whom Thou art well-pleased to share Thy secret, whom Thou hast selected for Thy providence, whom Thou hast singled out for Thy good-pleasure, and whose obedience Thou hast linked with obedience unto Thee.

Their knowledge is through Your knowledge, and their disobedience is through Your disobedience, in all that is attributed to them as is attributed to You, due to Your exalted station and Your supreme greatness, which nothing can attain and nothing can comprehend. Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee! Bestow Thy blessings and peace upon them through all Thy signs, Thy fragrances, Thy manifestations, and Thy blessings, and through all that Thou art in the effects of Thy dominion, the attributes of Thy mercy, the expressions of Thy divinity, and all that Thou art in the manifestations of Thy sovereign power throughout eternity. Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee! Far exalted art Thou above what the wrongdoers say regarding Thy signs!

O my God! Thou seest my station on this night before Thee and bearest witness to my private and public acts. I desire in all things to love only what Thou lovest and to detest only what Thou detestest. And if my soul hath committed any grievous sin, it was not to deny Thy oneness nor to reject Thy divinity, but rather because the desires of its own self overcame it, and it accepted disobedience to Thee in hope of Thy gracious pardon. For none would be content to oppose Thy Self after having loved Thee or having recognized the power of Thy sovereignty.

Part 2: “Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee!…”

Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee! Thou art He Who forgiveth whomsoever Thou willest as Thou willest, and chastiseth whomsoever Thou willest as Thou willest. None can resist Thy command, none can reverse Thy judgment, and there is no end to the manifestations of Thy mercy. Glory be unto Thee! Thou art the Almighty, the Supreme, the Munificent, the Generous, Who created me before I was anything in Thy dominion, and Who provideth for me at every moment through Thy sovereignty and Thy self-subsistence that which I do not deserve in any measure. This is naught but Thy generosity toward me and Thy forgiveness of my sins—for what am I and what are my deeds?

Glory be unto Thee! Glory be unto Thee! By Thy might! Were I to mention the grievous sins of my soul and my manifest transgressions before Thee, Thy servants would be ashamed to mention me in their presence. How then would be my state before the countenance of Thy might and the hands of Thy mercy? This is that before which the heavens and earth cannot stand, for Thou art He Who hath strengthened me through Thy generosity, honored me through the assistance of Thy holiness and the manifestations of Thy divinity. Thou dost not wish to take me to task for my sins nor question me about my transgressions, for Thy generosity hath ever encompassed me and Thy mercy hath ever embraced

me. No justice toward anything is possible in Thy judgment, for if Thou shouldst desire to judge anything with justice, all who are in the heavens and earth would perish instantly.

Alas, alas! Woe unto me, then woe unto me, shouldst Thou take me to task for what my hands have wrought, or call me to account for what I have done in private or in public, or punish me for that which I deserve before the court of Thy self-subsistence! Alas, alas! Woe unto me, then woe unto me, shouldst Thou seize me with Thy judgment, or reckon with me through Thy justice, or remove me from Thy nearness! By Thy might and Thy majesty, and there is no power nor strength except through Thee, were Thou to promise those who have recognized Thy truth, feared Thy justice and hoped for Thy reward with the fire of Thy hell, and promise those who have denied Thy Cause, befriended [the enemies of] Thy friends, and warred against those near to Thy chosen ones with Thy good-pleasure—then by Thy truth, which I have no power to mention except through Thee, I would be content with Thy fire and would submit to Thy commands, and would desire nothing save Thy love.

Alas, alas! Verily the hearts of them that have recognized Thy countenance are prostrate before Thee, and the hearts of them that have professed Thy unity are enraptured by Thy remembrance, and the souls of them that yearn for Thee eagerly seek Thy good-pleasure.

I beseech Thee therefore, O my God, by Thy bounty in this hour of this night wherein I have presented myself before Thy chosen ones, to grant me a station from the light of Thy unity, and a token from the manifestation of Thy Lordship, and a sign from the signs of Thy divinity, that I may make mention of Thee before the court of Thy power even as Thou hast ever made mention of Thyself from time immemorial, that Thou art God, the Single, the One, the Self-Subsisting, the Unique, Whom nothing can know and no servant can describe, inasmuch as the essence of all things by its very nature severs all beings from the mention of Names and Attributes, and the reality of material things by its very nature prevents all realities from the mention of Names and Attributes.

Thou shalt never be known through similitudes nor bounded by likenesses. Glorified art Thou! Thou Who hast ever been the All-Knowing and none can be known at Thy level. Glorified art Thou! Thou Who hast ever been the All-Powerful and nothing had power beside Thee, and even now the decree remaineth thus.

Glorified art Thou! When certain philosophers could not gaze upon the countenance of Thy Self-Subsistence in the station of knowledge, they confused the signs of Thy dominion with the manifestations of Thine Essence, and thus described Thee in ways that knew Thee not. Glorified art Thou! Even if they knew Thee, they could not describe Thee. Glorified art Thou! Glorified art Thou!

O my God, I know not how to mention my condition before Thee, for Thou hast ever been the Counter of my deeds and transgressions in such wise that I cannot enumerate them. Glorified art Thou! If I weep for my disobedience, Thy dealings with those near unto Thee bring me joy; and if I weep for my transgressions, Thy way with the sinful fills me with longing.

Glorified art Thou! Thou art the Single, the One, the Unique, the Self-Subsisting, Whom no description from anything can grasp, nor any attribute from anything can reach, nor can any reality truly attain the court of Thy nearness, for Thou hast ever been the Beloved Who by Thine Essence hath severed all

realities from the station of the Self, and by Thy Being hath separated all material things from the station of mentioning attributes.

Sufficient is it as a sin that I say "Thou art Thou," for this is pure falsehood before Thy Self-Subsisting Presence and manifest untruth before the majesty of Thy mighty Countenance. Alas! Alas! This is an hour wherein Thou rejectest no one's prayer and hast guaranteed an answer to each of Thy servants.

I beseech Thee by the right of Thy Light which shone forth unto Moses, son of Imran, on Mount Sinai, whereupon he swooned away before Thy presence, and when he recovered said:

> "Glorified art Thou! I turn unto Thee, and I am the first of believers."

Glorified art Thou! Glorified art Thou!

I beseech Thee by the light of Thy Countenance in Seir, and the manifestation of Thy Being in the Dome of Time, and the revelation of Thy Self-Sufficiency in Beer-sheba, and all Thy manifestations in the stations of creation and command which none save Thee can comprehend—verily Thou art the All-Powerful, the Mighty, the All-Bountiful.

I beseech Thee by Thy right that Thou favor us through Thy grace and honor us through Thy loving-kindness and bring us unto the court of Thy nearness and the station of Thy manifestation, that I may be established upon the throne of Thy mercy before the Midian of Thy might, and describe Thee as Thou describest Thyself: that Thou art God, the Beauty of the heavens and earth, and Thou art God, the Glory of the heavens and earth, and Thou art God, the Grandeur of the heavens and earth, and Thou art God, the Praise of the heavens and earth, and Thou art God, the Kind Lord Whose knowledge encompasseth all things, Whose mercy embraceth all things, Whose power transcendeth all things, and Whose Will exalteth above all things, such that none of Thy creation knoweth what Thou knowest in the stations of Thy might, the signs of Thy Self-Subsistence, the stations of Thy mercy, and the verses of Thy Self-Sufficient manifestations.

Glorified art Thou! Glorified art Thou! I am the servant who hath been neglectful in Thy Cause, and I am the servant who hath forgotten Thy remembrance, and I am he who hath been heedless of the garments of Thy Being, and I am he who desired to unify Thine Essence and thereby acquired the greatest sin and the mightiest transgression, and I am he who desired to describe Thine Essence and thereby bore the grievous sin and grave error of mentioning Thy Self and describing Thine Essence.

I am he who yearned to portray Thy Will; and thereby I found the remembrance of my self set over against Midian, at the dawn of Thy mention, and the Most Great Deep within that which proceedeth from Thy act. Ah, ah! Were I to weep, for as long as Thine Essence endureth, for a single sin among my transgressions, my heart would not be emptied of Thy dominion.

O my God! Thou art the Single, the Self-Subsisting, Whom no description of anything can grasp, nor any attribute of anything define. Thou hast ever been self-sufficient in Thyself apart from all else, just in judgment, obeyed in action, and effective in command. Nothing in the heavens or on earth can rival Thy deed, for verily Thou art the Almighty, the Ever-Living, the Trusted, the Self-Subsisting.

Exalted is Thine Essence above any equivalence with the attributes of essences, and sanctified is Thy Being from any parallel with the description of material things. Thy Self hath ever known Thy Self, none else beside Thee, and Thine Essence hath ever unified Thine Essence, none other than Thee.

Thus do I, in this my station, bear witness that there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner, nothing is like unto Thee, and that Thou art He Who chose Muhammad—peace be upon him and his family—from the midst of contingent being at the station of Thy manifestation, and made his excellence Thine own excellence above all things.

Glorified art Thou and exalted is Thy Self above any comparison with anything ever, and never shall a servant equal Thy Being. Thou art the Exalted above all things and Thou art the Most Exalted above all things. None save Thee hath ever known or will ever know Thine Essence, and none but Thee hath described or will ever describe Thy Being. Glorified art Thou and exalted above what the speakers say of Thy Self and what those who draw comparisons describe of Thy deed, with supreme exaltation.

O my God! Thou art He Who hath decreed, and what Thou hast decreed is inevitable, and Thou art He Who hath ordained, and what Thou hast ordained is inevitable. Glorified art Thou! Sanctified is Thine Essence from being indicated by any attribute of Thine Essence, and exalted is Thy Being from being characterized by any of Thy creation.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! If I fear myself because of Thy justice, my hope in Thee gladdens me, and Thy dealings with those of Thy servants who are nigh unto Thee give me peace; and if I rest upon the throne of hope, Thy affliction and Thy justice frighten me.

Glorified art Thou! By what remembrance shall I turn toward Thee, and by what attribute shall I describe Thy Court? For in my turning away, I cannot glimpse a look at Thy face, and from my evil deeds, I cannot stand before the seat of Thy might. Thou art exalted above all things by the attribute of Thine Essence itself, and Thou art sanctified above all things, and no description of Thine Essence equals Thine Essence, for Thou art the All-Powerful, the Bestower, the Trusted, the Beneficent, Whose Being no being of any of Thy servants can equal.

Glorified art Thou! Thou art the Single, the Self-Subsisting, and the Eternal, the Ever-Living, Whose Essence none can equal. Glorified art Thou, O my God! None knoweth how Thou art except Thee.

O my God! I am he who hath sinned against Thee, and I am he who hath erred after having been certain of Thy judgment, and I am he who hath turned away from the countenance of Thy Being after Thou didst manifest Thyself to me through the signs of Thy oneness. I know not by what tongue I should recount my conditions, nor by what deed I should turn toward Thee, Who art alone with no partner.

O my God! Thou art the One sought after in the kingdom of the heavens and the earth, and Thou art the One obeyed in the kingdom of command and creation. If Thou shouldst punish me with all Thy might and vengeance and whatsoever Thou art capable of through Thy power and strength, then by Thy glory I would deserve it, for Thou hast ever been praised in Thy deed and obeyed in Thy sovereignty. Nothing escapes Thy knowledge, nor can anyone be concealed from Thee.

Thou art He Who hath ever been without the description of anything, and will forever remain as One Who cannot be qualified by anything. How can I point to the station of Thy beneficence towards me and Thy bounty within my inmost being? If I say “Thou art Thou,” then verily would Oneness indicate the essential nature of creation and Unity the reality of invention, yet Thou hast ever been beyond description.

Thou canst not be described through Thy creation, nor canst Thou be known through Thy servants. Thou art the Most High, everlasting. Thou art He Who accepteth not any deed from anyone except through sincerity. Thou art He like unto Whom there is nothing. Thou art the Single, the Self-Subsisting, Who hath ever been. Thy Essence transcendeth all substance and expression, and Thy Being ever remaineth beyond all material description and attribute. Ever hast Thou been the Describer of Thine Own Self, and Thine Essence of Thine Own Essence. If I say Thou art He Who is He, verily the very essence of creation and being point to this. Thou art the Eternal, Single, All-Bountiful, Whom nothing in the heavens or earth can overwhelm. Thou art the All-Knowing, Whom nothing can overwhelm or change, and none of Thy servants can comprehend Thy knowledge. For Thou hast ever been the Knower of Thine Own Self, and the Director of Thy dominion through Thy Command. Thou art the Single, the One, the Self-Subsisting, the Unique, the Living, the Worshipped One.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou art He Whom nothing in the heavens or earth can overwhelm, and Thou art the Most Powerful, the Most Exalted. O my God! Thou hast manifested Thyself to all created things through Thy creative power, and hast ordained the path of their knowledge through the signs of Thy invention. Thou hast taught them the stations of Thy might at the ultimate point of connection. By Thy glory! Even if Thou shouldst make all that Thy knowledge encompasses in contingent existence into tormenting fire, then make my entire being as one body and torture me therein through the everlasting might of Thy grandeur—by Thy glory and Thy truth, and there is no might nor power except through Thee—I would still find Thee praiseworthy in Thy deed and obeyed in Thy judgment. Verily, I am deserving of this, and Thou art the Beloved in every condition. Thou art the Beloved in Thy deed and the Obeyed in Thy judgment.

I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy mighty truth and by Thine Own Self, besides Whom there is no God, to bless Muhammad and the family of Muhammad—the Manifestations of Thy Self-Subsistence, the Signs of Thy Eternity, the Revelations of Thy Oneness, and the Stations of Thy Grandeur—through what Thou art of the divine manifestations of Thy creation, the celestial fragrances of Thy invention, the holy conditions of Thy sovereignty, the gleaming appearances of Thy heavenly dominion, and what Thou art of that which none knoweth save Thee, through Thy grace and bounty, O Most Generous of the generous ones, and God of all the worlds!

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou art nearer to all things than all things. Glorified and exalted art Thou! Thou didst create me when I was nothing, and nourished me after I had done good. Thy custom in every condition is beneficence, and Thy way in every time is expression. I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy bounty, to bring me to the sacred precinct among those of Thy chosen ones who are near unto Thee, to grant me perfect detachment, the mystery of abstraction, and the light of joy, until I reach the holy depths of majesty and find delight in the lights of bounty at the surging sea of the One in beauty. May I stand before

the sanctuary of Thy oneness and acknowledge what Thou hast ordained for me of the signs of Thy might, the sovereignty of Thy Self-Subsistence, and bear witness unto Thyself as Thou bearest witness unto Thyself before all things—that Thou art God, there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner.

Ever hast Thou been without mention of any other. Thou art the Describer of Thine Own Self and verily I am describing Thee through Thy description of Thyself. There is no God but Thee, glorified and exalted art Thou above what they describe. Glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe, and peace be upon the believers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00156: Sahifiy-i-Mu'tamid (ad-Dawlah)

Introduction

O my God! Thou art He Who hath testified to Thine Own Self by Thine Own Self before all things, that verily Thou art God, there is none other God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thou hast ever been without aught existing beside Thee, and wilt ever remain as Thou hast been, with naught sharing Thy station. For Thine Essence cutteth off all substances from the station of knowledge, and Thy Being separateth all beings from the station of understanding expression. Thou art God, the Single One, Who hath ever been self-subsisting when nothing else existed besides Thee.

Glorified art Thou! How can I describe Thy Presence or praise the Countenance of Thy Self-Subsistence, when I behold for myself no existence before the City of Thy Glory, and no mention before the City of Thy Holy Dominion? All that I might draw forth of praise and glory is bounded by limitations and the geometry of oneness which, by its very nature, is cut off from Thy Presence and barred from nearness to the court of Thy might.

Glorified, glorified art Thou! Thou art He Who maketh me know Thyself in every condition—that Thou canst not be known except through Thyself, nor described save by Thee, nor truly worshipped in Thine Essential Reality, nor praised in the Being of Thine Eternity, lest I be veiled in any condition from the station of nearness to Thee, nor in any decree from the station of knowing Thy signs.

Glorified art Thou! How exalted is Thy station! How glorious is Thy bounty! How mighty is the manifestation of Thy Sovereignty in the stations of Command and the ultimate Seals! Glorified art Thou! If I say "Thou art Thou," then likeness would be compared with likeness, yet Thou hast ever been beyond being known through likenesses or described by signs of majesty. And if I say "He is He," then Oneness would indicate the Essence of Thy Will and the Sovereignty of the Being of Thy Purpose, which in itself is cut off from nearness to Thy Presence and barred from knowing the station of Thy might.

Glorified art Thou! I know not by what path I might ascend unto Thee, nor by what face I might turn toward Thy face, for I see for myself no existence and for my condition no station. Glorified art Thou! Thou art the Everlasting Sovereign and the Eternal, Self-Subsisting Lord Who hath originated creation through Thy Will, an origination without previous example in the realm of possibility. Then Thou hast established all things in the path of Command and the manifestations of the Seal, that all atoms in their

essential stations might know what Thou didst will in the station of origination and ordain in the decree of invention.

Glorified art Thou! Thou art He Who hath never ordained for anyone a station to know the essence of Thy Being, nor to attain the threshold of Thy Presence, for naught besides Thee hath existence in the rank of Thy Being, nor mention in the station of the manifestation of Thy Sovereignty. Thou art the Nearest Who cannot be described in any condition except through praise of Thyself, and Thou art the Most High Who cannot be characterized in any station except through the manifestation of what Thou hast ordained in the station of Thy creation.

Glorified art Thou! Thou art He Who created me when I was not worthy of mention, and nurtured me through Thy grace even though I chose not good in Thy path. Glorified art Thou! Verily Thy way is bounty and Thy custom is expression. Thou hast ever accepted from Thy servants what none besides Thee would accept, and commanded with a decree that none other than Thee would command. Thou art God Who hath ever been self-subsisting, while all else is bounded by the limits of Thy creation and characterized by the manifestation of Thy invention. Neither can the reality of aught that is a manifestation of Thy power be apprehended, nor the signs of the hiddenness of Thy Will be discerned; for in every condition they testify to Thy origination and rehearse the station of Thy invention. None knoweth how Thou art save Thou Thyself.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou art He Who hath made known to all the path leading to Thy recognition, and hath established for all the signs of Thy sanctified manifestations, lest anyone fail to remember Thee in any matter and behold Thee manifest and present in Thy station of eternity. Glorified art Thou, O my God! My very existence is a sin, so what of when sin acquireth sin, and seeth no path to that station wherein one can perform no deed contrary to Thy love. Glorified, glorified art Thou! Since I see no path for myself nor proof for my recognition, I beseech Thee with this weary tongue to forgive my sin, transform my misdeeds, and pardon what Thy knowledge hath encompassed and Thy Book hath recorded.

Glorified, glorified art Thou! Since I find no remembrance beloved before Thee save the remembrance of the Manifestations of Thy power and the signs of Thy holiness, I implore Thee by the remembrance of what Thou hast inspired me concerning Muhammad and the family of Muhammad—Thy blessings be upon them—the repositories of Thy Cause, the treasuries of Thy bounty, the signs of Thy detachment, the stations of Thy praise, the manifestations of Thy sanctification, and the evidences of Thy glorification—those servants whom Thou hast created for Thyself, chosen for Thy authority, fashioned for the station of Thy love, and approved for the station of Thy grandeur—the Imams of religion and the pillars of the people of certitude—those servants whose recognition Thou hast made identical to Thine own recognition in the realm of creation, and whose obedience is Thy obedience in all the worlds of invention.

I beseech Thee, O God, by their right, to empty my heart of the remembrance of all else but Thee until I find the sweetness of nearness to Thee and recognize the station of intimate communion with Thee. And I beseech Thee by their right to grant me perfect detachment unto Thee until I rend asunder the veils of light at the stations of manifestation and attain, through Thy grace, to the station Thou hast ordained for

me from the ultimate effusion of Thy creation and the manifestation of Thy invention, and what Thou hast promised to the believers among the people who answer Thy call.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! I adjure Thee by their right that Thou send blessings upon Muhammad and the family of Muhammad through the conditions of the revelations of Oneness, the manifestations of the stations of Unity, the evidences of the signs of Divine Absoluteness, the tokens of the essences of the All-Merciful, and whatsoever Thou createst at every moment and ordainest in the realm of creation through Thy favor and bounty, O Lord of Lords! O my God! Since I find the paths of recognition cut off and the ways of expression in describing Thy Essence blocked, I offer praise before Thee of what Thou hast ordained praise for in Thy Book and made beloved to remember in the worlds of creation, that perchance thereby destiny may raise me to the station of fulfillment which Thou hast ordained for me in the stations of contingent being.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou knowest that my remembrance of the Manifestations of Thy power in every matter is but like the remembrance of an ant in the station of Thy unity, yet since Thou hast placed in the realities of all created things the signs of the Manifestations of Thy Will, I implore through the mention of praise of Thy mercy, hoping for Thy pardon and bounty and remembering the station of the manifestation of Thy mercy. I testify that there is no God but Thee, alone with no partner. Thou hast ever been while no thing existed in contingent being nor was there mention of anything in existence. Verily, at this moment Thou art as Thou hast ever been.

Neither is Thy recognition possible, nor the description of Thy creation, nor the sanctification of Thy might. And thus didst Thou exalt Mua¸¥ammad—the Messenger of God, may blessings rest upon him and upon his kindred—to the station of Thine own Self in the tokens of Thy Cause and the ultimate purposes of creation. Thou didst select Him from the very heart of the pre-eternity of Thine action, and didst prefer Him above all that Thou hast brought forth, by reason of the loftiness of the manifestation of Thy Majesty and the splendor of the station of Thy Oneness, that no soul, at the revelation of Thy power, might be heedless of the knowledge of Thy Essence. Verily, Thou art the All-Glorious, the Most High.

O my God! Thou knowest that in all matters I have desired naught save Thy love and the knowledge of the ways of obedience unto Thee. If I have acquired aught else besides this, by Thy might and majesty, it was not through my denial of Thy oneness nor my rejection of Thy unity. Rather, since Thou didst create within my soul the signs of the manifestations of Thy dominion, I followed my desires in accordance with what I loved before the city of Thy omnipotence. Through this, destiny hath aided me in finding Thy grace from the beginning. Therefore forgive me whatsoever Thy knowledge encompasseth besides this. Verily Thou art the Mighty, the All-Forgiving. There is no power nor strength save in God, the Exalted, the Great. And praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds.

At the beginning of the sahifah of His Honor Mu'tamidu'd-Dawlih

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Praise be to God Who hath made the ornament of the tablets of the Book of Creation the ornament of the Alif standing between two letters, that all the temples of radiance might shine forth through that

which hath dawned from the light of the Eternal Morn until it filled all horizons. And blessings be upon the Primal Point through Whose existence all that shineth forth in the heavens and earth was illumined, and through Whom all things at every moment continue to be illumined. And peace be upon the Guides through whom creation came into being, and through the manifestations of whose appearance all things, both great and small, are enabled to speak forth in praise of their Lord.

To continue: When the light of the Cause shone forth in the presence of His Honor, he who is drawn near to the holy court of the Sultan and trusted of the exalted government of the Sovereign—may God perpetuate the shadow of His care over all beings—he whose mention is too exalted to be brought forth from potentiality into expression—through the composition of a prayer to be beheld by him, I sought God's help in what He hath commanded and willed, that the reward of everyone who readeth a single letter thereof might accrue to his exalted presence until the Day when the trumpet shall be sounded, then shall shin be joined to shin, and unto God shall be the journey's end, both in the beginning and in the return.

BB00327: Sahifiy-i-Mu'tamid (ad-Dawlah)

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

O Thou Who possessest might and oneness and majesty and grandeur! Glorified and exalted art Thou! As I know there is no way for me to describe Thee, I beseech Thee by Thy right to bless Muhammad and the family of Muhammad, the manifestations of the essences of divinity and the signs of sovereignty and omnipotence and the verses of the manifestations of dominion and kingdom, and what God hath ordained in the Book for Thy servants.

Glorified art Thou! Thou art He Who hath made Thyself known to me in every condition through the manifestation of the signs of Thy creation and the modes of the stations of Thy invention, lest I become heedless in any state of the nearness of the presence of Thy countenance. And I behold Thee manifest and existing alone with no partner unto Thee.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou art He Who hath never ceased to be beyond description by the attributes of Thy servants or characterization by the qualities of Thy creation, for Thy essence cutteth off all substances from the station of knowledge, and Thy being separateth all material things from the realm of expression.

Glorified art Thou! If I say "Thou art Thou," the similitude hath been likened to majesty, and Thou hast never ceased to be unknowable thereby. And if I say "Thou art He," unity hath indicated the station of Thy creation and oneness the station of Thy invention. Thou art more glorious than that I should mention for Thee a description in the station of vision or a remembrance in the depths of contingent existence.

Glorified art Thou! Thou knowest my judgment and art aware of my secret, and Thy book hath encompassed my transgressions. Nothing escapeth Thy knowledge in the heavens or on earth. Yet after this Thou hast favored me with concealment and pardon, as if Thou hadst never become aware in any condition of a sin from myself or a transgression from my outward being.

Glorified art Thou! How exalted is Thy station and how great is Thy bounty! Thou didst create me before any deserving and nurture me in the stations of the Command and the ultimate ends with what Thou dost merit at the time of giving. By Thy might and Thy majesty! If Thou shouldst punish me in every condition with all Thy assaults—the assaults of Thy power and the signs of Thy omnipotence—Thou wouldst be praiseworthy in Thy deed and obeyed in Thy judgment. And verily I would have deserved that as recompense for a good deed from myself.

Alas, alas! If the judgment in that station be like what I have uttered before Thy grandeur, how can my inner being find rest in the presence of the city of the might of Thy mercifulness, and how can I not cry out before Thy countenance when I know not how Thy dealings with me shall be and Thy judgment concerning me?

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Here am I, turning to Thee with all my being that my heart may be emptied. I know not, O my God, how I can be patient in separation from Thee after Thy knowledge of my station, and how can I not cry out before Thee after the vastness of Thy mercy in my inner and outer being? Thou knowest my secret and my manifest condition in every state. I have wished to love only as Thou lovest and to will only as Thou willest. Therefore forgive me, for Thou art the Generous, the Forgiving.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! My mention before the presence of Thy court—I know it is a sin, but by Thy might and Thy majesty, were I able to annihilate myself I would love to, but I cannot do so, for the mention of negation is itself an aspect of affirmation, and that is sin with Thee like unto existence itself.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! How can I call upon Thee when the effects of Thy wrath for what my hands have wrought have encompassed me from every direction? And how can I not call upon Thee when the manifestations of Thy grandeur have occupied me with Thy favors, as if Thy knowledge had never encompassed any evil from me?

Verily I ask forgiveness of Thee and turn unto Thee in hope of Thy pardon and bounty and in reliance upon Thy mercy and generosity. Thou art the Strong, the Most High. I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy generosity and the Manifestations of Thy holiness and the signs of Thy revelation, that Thou grant me complete detachment unto Thee until all my conditions before Thee become as one condition and all my deeds in Thy book become as one remembrance. Join me to the source of good-pleasure with what Thou lovest and approvest, until I love not the hastening of what Thou hast delayed for me through Thy grace, nor the delay of what Thou hast hastened for me through Thy favor. Verily Thou knowest all things in the heavens and earth, and nothing escapeth Thee in the kingdom of Command and Creation. None can reverse Thy judgment or repel Thy decree. Thou art God, the Generous, the Bestower.

BB00324: Letter in reply to four questions

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who sent down the Command in the Book to those who follow God’s Command in truth, for these are they who are the truthful ones. And now, your letter has arrived from the land of Sad and I have reviewed your message.

Know that regarding what you asked about the meaning of the Day of Resurrection—it has endless ranks in God's knowledge. Among them is the Day of Origination, the Day of Creation, the Day of Production, the Day of Bringing into Being, the Day of Formation, the Day of the Term, and the Day of the Book. In brief, every matter has its day.

When "Day" is applied in the realm of the First and Pre-existent Manifestation, it is the very sign of Manifestation which has no beginning and no end in the station of concealment, due to the all-encompassing nature of God's grace in the beginning and end. When applied in the eternal realm, it has a beginning in the station of existence but God has not given it an end in His knowledge, for His grace never ceases for an instant. When applied in the realm of perpetuity, it has a beginning in relation to eternity and an end in relation to itself. When applied in the realm of time, it is determined by the motion of the celestial spheres.

For all these meanings, mention of the Day of Resurrection is true, for it is the Day of Standing before the Lord of mankind. The Lesser Resurrection is the day of the rise of God's Messenger (peace be upon him and his family) with prophethood in the Return. The Greater Resurrection is the Day in which God gathers all that His knowledge encompasses to judge between all in truth concerning their differences, and He does not wrong His servants. Today the mystery of the Day of Resurrection has appeared to judge between all in truth. In this dark, deaf, blind and gloomy trial, all people will be distinguished. Today God's judgment is like His judgment in the past. Then afterwards, glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

Regarding what you asked about the ruling on the woman who purified herself, and about whom the Word was revealed to which affairs submitted—all that you interpreted through transmission and observed of the mystery of reality through comprehension is the truth. However, people should not follow her since they are unable to understand the reality of her station. Return in matters of judgment to the one who has the Balance, for all truth today returns to that justice, and to God returns judgment in the beginning and return.

Regarding what you asked about your own station, follow the ruling of the Book and the sound tradition from the people of return, for God protects the servant from error when he observes the mystery of discourse in the line of response.

Regarding what you asked about the steadfastness of believers' hearts and the joy of believers' hearts—beware, beware of exaggeration and mentioning God's names in the Book. For I am but an owned and sustained servant who possesses no benefit or harm for myself. I know nothing in the heavens or earth except what God wills. I have commanded none except by the ruling of the Qur'an and the ordinances of the people of the Bayan. I do not claim to have knowledge of the unseen of the heavens and earth, or knowledge of what has been or will be, nor do I say a word without what has been revealed in the Book and the text from the Imams of excellence.

Turn people away from exaggeration regarding me, for God knows two groups will perish: the excessive lovers and the hateful detractors. Their sin is not upon me, for I said before and say now before God, His Messengers and His friends that I am a servant who has believed in God and His signs. God has honored

me by His grace as He willed with knowledge from the people of infallibility (God's blessings upon them)—as long as the Sun of Identity has risen with identity and the Sun of Oneness has not set with oneness.

I have spoken to people of my Lord's blessing. Whoever is grateful, is grateful for his own soul, and whoever denies—then surely God your Lord is independent of mankind. Glory be to God, Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. Peace be upon the followers of God's Command, for they are the successful ones. And praise be to God, Lord of the worlds.

BB00462: Prayer for Haji Mirza Jani Kashani

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

O my God! How can I call upon Thee after my disobedience to Thy Self, my heedlessness of the places of Thy wisdom, and my turning away from the seats of communion with Thee? And how can I not call upon Thee after my knowledge of the bounties of Thy mercy, the manifestations of Thy grandeur, and the signs of Thy eternal sovereignty which draw all unto the station of Thy proof? It is as though I behold Thy grace unto the disobedient as being like unto Thy grace unto the obedient, for disobedience harmeth Thee not, nor doth faith profit Thee, and verily Thou art independent of all things. Thou hast commanded all through Thy laws that people might be distinguished thereby. Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou! Through remembrance of Thee my soul hopeth for Thy presence, and through Thy attraction my soul hath relied upon Thy grace and generosity. Unto Thee be the most exalted praise above all things and the greatest glorification after all things.

If I acknowledge Thy oneness before Thee, my soul reproveth me because of Thy Being and the impossibility of attaining the presence of Thy countenance, for Thy Being is an essential, primordial, and pure Reality which by its very essence separateth all created things from the station of knowledge and preventeth all contingent things from the mention of certitude. And if I utter praise of Thee, the limitations of my soul prevent me, for verily praise of Thee befitteth not the holy court of Thy Lord. Glorified and exalted art Thou! I find no path for myself, nor can any proof ascend unto Thee, O Thou Glorious One!

I beseech Thee, O God, by Thy hidden Name and Thy treasured Attribute, that Thou send blessings upon Muhammad and his family, [through] Thy fragrances and manifestation, then Thy revelations and greetings. Verily Thou art the Powerful, the Mighty.

O my God! Thy decree is truth for every soul, Thy ordainment is justice for all things, and Thy grace hath encompassed all things. I beseech Thee, O God, by the vastness of Thy mercy, the all-encompassing nature of Thy knowledge, the ultimate bounty and utmost good-pleasure, that Thou send blessings upon the Blessed Leaf from the Primal Tree, which is neither of the East nor of the West, through what Thou possesseth of wondrous fragrances and ancient favors, and that Thou forgive me and my parents and whomsoever Thou lovest in this hour upon that earth, through Thy grace and bounty and the sovereignty

of Thy Self-Subsistence. Verily Thou art God, the Powerful, the All-Bountiful. And I seek Thy forgiveness at all times through what Thou lovest and art pleased with.

Praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00260: Du'a'-i-Manuchihr Khan

O my God! Thy bounty hath been commensurate with my abject poverty, and Thy forgiveness proportionate to my disobedience. Thou knowest, O my God, the bounds thereof. And I, with certitude, confess that wert Thou to make all that Thy knowledge hath encompassed, other than me, a fire of iron, and to stretch its pavilion, within a circumscribed station, to embrace the heavens and the earth in their entirety; wert Thou then to magnify my frame to such wise that it should fill every abode of that fire, and to chastise me therein at every instant with all the vehemence of Thy wrath and every form of Thy vengeance—according to what Thou art able to inflict at the moment of Thy seizure, unto the perpetuity of Thine ancient and everlasting majesty—verily, by that alone I should be deserving of the recompense merited by my mere mention of Thee before Thy Face, apart from the requital due for my evil deeds and works which Thou hast never enjoined.

Glorified art Thou! Thou alone art cognizant of this; none other hath knowledge thereof. Never did I think of Thee aught but what beseemeth Thy grace; for naught in the heavens or on the earth hath strength to endure the pure rule of Thy justice. For, shouldst Thou resolve to judge by justice alone, in that very instant wouldst Thou chastise all who are in the heavens and on the earth by the force thereof. Glorified, glorified art Thou, O my God! My expectation from Thee hath ever been Thy favor, and Thy dealing with any soul hath ever been in beneficence and bounty.

Glorified art Thou, glorified art Thou! If I implore Thy forgiveness, I fall thereby into a sin for which, though I should seek Thy pardon throughout everlasting eternity, there would be, of itself, no claim to absolution; for that word testifieth to my existence before Thee and bespeaketh my boldness in the presence of the majesty of Thy compelling might. Far, far be it from me—what have I to do with seeking forgiveness before Thee? Were it not for Thy grace and Thy mercy, I should assuredly be of the forgotten.

Glory be unto Thee, O my God! If I make mention of Thee, that, of a certainty, is sin, for my very existence is sin. How then if to sin I add another sin? And if I keep silence before Thee, the judgment is as the former; for whatsoever pertaineth to creation is but sin upon sin, unworthy to ascend unto Thee or to draw nigh unto the carpet of Thy glory. For the loftiest essences of contingent being have been individualized through the impress of origination; the highest summits of existent things have trembled at the revelation of creation. In their very reality they are cut off from Thee, in need of Thee, proclaiming by their severance their incapacity to attain Thy countenance, confessing interdiction before the workings of Thy oneness, avowing impotence in praising Thee, and prostrating themselves before the grandeur of Thy Face. There is none other God but Thee.

O God! Thou knowest that I have held, concerning Thy Reality, only that which Thou hast sent down in Thy Book, where Thou hast said—and Thy word is the truth—"Vision comprehendeth Him not, but He comprehendeth all vision; He is the Subtle, the All-Informed."

O God! Thou art aware that certain of the sages have inclined to the doctrine of the oneness of existence between the existent and the non-existent. Glorified, glorified art Thou! Exalted and sanctified art Thou above what the anthropomorphizers ascribe unto Thyself. I find no word more abased than their saying; for Thou hast ever been without the mention of aught, and Thou remainest, even now, as Thou hast ever been, without the existence of anything beside Thee. The existence of creation hath come to be, in itself, through origination, without its being touched by a ray from Thy Essence or an indication from Thy Being; rather didst Thou reveal Thyself unto it—not from aught preceding it—and didst establish the truth through it, as a grace and favor.

Were the matter as they allege, whence would they infer Thy unity? Verily, the very existence of duality witnesseth to separation and proclaimeth severance. Thou art the One described within the realm of creation, whilst created things possess no description before the existence of Thy Essence; for Thy Being hath ever been, and there was none with Thee, whereas the existence of creation is coupled with origination and heraldeth non-existence. When Thou didst reveal Thyself unto them by means of themselves, in the loftiest dawning of Thy Will, they discerned neither separation from that revelation nor union with Thy court; hence have they asserted a linkage between Thee and Thy creation—like startled asses fleeing from the decree of a mighty lion.

If that linkage be Thy very Essence, then were concomitance imposed—far exalted art Thou above that! And if it be Thy creation, the claim of the anthropomorphizers is thereby annulled. Thou art the True, and whatsoever is other than Thee is creation. Between Thee and any one of Thy creatures there is no bond save Thy creative act. And though some among the gnostics of the Sadrian school—delving unduly into the rule of linkage—have uttered a word at which the heavens well-nigh burst, the earth is rent, and the mountains fall down in ruins, yet, hallowed be Thy mention! Their souls have beguiled them with what Satan casteth into their hearts, whilst they imagine themselves guided aright.

Thou art, in truth, the Originator, the Peerless. By Thy Will didst Thou bring creation forth, not from aught before it; and Thou hast made its cause to be itself and none other. They have advanced in their knowledge that which Thou lovest not, nor approvest. Some have falsely asserted that the cause of all things is Thy very Essence—as though they knew not the word of justice from Thy chosen ones, perceived not the implications of concomitance before Thy beauty, nor grasped that, unless cause and effect share a rank of manifestation, the effect could neither come to be nor subsist.

It is but Thy test:

> "He leaveth whom He will to stray and guideth whom He will."

Thus standeth it recorded in my rescript. And to this hour I have never named my name in any of my verses; for the Imam—upon him be peace—hath indicated, in the decree of the inmost of the inmost, that none pronounceth the name of the Lord of this Cause but an infidel; and that the mention of the

personal name in outward traces is the concern of the jurists—children in the matters of the inner mysteries and hidden realities.

BB00519: Answer to Siyyid Ahmad Aqa-Zadih

He is the Most Exalted, the Most High

O thou of tender years, of tender body, recently weaned from milk!

Praise be to God Who created whatsoever is in the heavens and on earth by His command. Then those who have believed in God and His signs shall be gathered unto God.

O my God! How can I call upon Thee when all paths of access to the knowledge of Thy Being are barred? And how can I refrain from calling upon Thee when the manifestations of Thy creative power are at every moment descending? Glory be to Thee and exalted art Thou! I testify that Thy Essence hath cut off all created things from attaining the station of knowing Thee, and that Thy timeless Being hath separated all existence from the capacity to describe Thee. Verily, I am unable to describe any of Thy attributes, for Thou hast never been known by aught else but Thyself, nor described save by Thine own Self.

I beseech Thee therefore, O my God, by the right of Muhammad and His family, to graciously bestow upon me the knowledge of Thee, to grant me constancy in serving Thee, to let me recline upon the carpet of Thy favor, and to stand before the trustees of Thy Revelation, the vessels of Thy knowledge, the guardians of Thy mystery, and the interpreters of Thy signs—those servants whom Thou hast chosen for the station of Thy authority, singled out for the manifestation of Thy sovereignty, and whose obedience Thou hast linked to obedience unto Thee, and whose love to love of Thee. Thus hast Thou described them in Thy perspicuous verses, saying—and Thy word is the truth:

> “Honored servants who speak not until He hath spoken, and who do His bidding.”

Glory be to thy Lord, the Lord of might, above what they describe. And peace be upon the Messengers. And praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds.

BB00278

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

God beareth witness that there is none other God but Him, and the angels and those endowed with knowledge, standing firm on justice, bear witness that there is none other God but Him, the Almighty, the All-Wise.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy Godhead—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy creative power—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy omnipotence—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thine eternity—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thine essence—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy sovereignty—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy creative force—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy life-giving power—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy manifestation—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy bounty—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy grandeur—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy grace—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy dominion—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy light—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy glory—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy transcendence—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy oneness—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy self-sufficiency—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy power—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy mercy—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy witness—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy forgiveness—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me by virtue of There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy permanence—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me through Thy words There is none other God but Thee.

O my God! I beseech Thee by Thy creative power—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me through Thy words There is none other God but Thee.

O God! I beseech Thee by Thy power to sustain—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me through Thy words There is none other God but Thee.

O God! I beseech Thee by Thy power to assure—there is none other God but Thee—O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me through Thy words There is none other God but Thee.

O God! I beseech Thee by Thy power to manifest, O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me through Thy words There is none other God but Thee.

O God! I beseech Thee by Thy self-sufficiency, O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me through Thy words There is none other God but Thee.

O God! I beseech Thee by Thy oneness, O Thou besides Whom there is none other God, to forgive me through Thy words There is none other God but Thee, for this is a mighty day and Thou art the sovereign, the creator, the generous one.

Grant unto me and unto all who have believed in Thee and Thy signs that which befitteth the wonders of Thy mercy, the loftiness of Thy grace and the sublimity of Thy gifts. I beseech Thee in this day, and in the days before it and after it, to ordain for me and for all who have believed in Thee all that Thou hast ordained for Muhammad and the family of Muhammad, through that which Thy knowledge hath encompassed of Thy bounty and which Thy book hath numbered of Thy mercy. Verily Thou art the most bountiful of the bountiful, and verily Thou art the most merciful of the merciful.

Praise be to God Who hath taken unto Himself no son, Who hath no partner in His dominion, nor any protector out of weakness. And magnify Him with all magnificence.

BB00529

In the Name of the Most High, the Most Great

Blessed is He Who bestoweth His grace upon whomsoever He willeth through His Command. Say: In this let the believers rejoice. We have indeed read the books which thou didst reveal aforetime, and We are witness unto all things. Say unto him who hath illumined his book with liquid gold: Give thanks unto God for having acquainted thee with His wisdom, for this is verily a supreme triumph. And verily on this Friday, the remembrance of thy Lord's name bestoweth blessings upon those who follow Me. Say: Give thanks unto God, O people, for having guided you through His grace, then be ye patient.

Make mention in the Book of Isma'il, that thou shouldst carry some copies and deliver them unto God's faithful servants. Say: The deeds of those who have fabricated lies against the remembrance of thy Lord's name in their book before witnesses from among the people are rendered vain, for they were an ignorant folk.

Make mention of Ibrahim and then of him who was sent down with the truth, and then of those who love that We make mention of them in the Book, for God shall fully render unto the patient their rewards without diminishment.

We have indeed answered in books which were revealed unto Us Ja'far and then Muhammad—send forth, send forth with Isma'il unto them both, and write unto those who follow Me that they should remain patient in that land and ask of God from His grace, and say: All praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00155: Alfayn: Al-Khutbata'l-Makhtum bi-Ta'bir'n-num

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be unto God Who hath adorned the Tablets of the Book of Separation with the vesture of utterance, and clothed the robe of derivation with the embroidery of preordination—He Who did will, and decree, and ordain, and then did permit, did glorify, and did number what lieth within that Book; whereupon there gleamed forth what shineth resplendent in the temples of dawning, even as it shone from the morn of pre-eternity, through the first letter that followed upon the second, whereby the realms above the veils of mist were illumined, and the abysses beneath the dust of gloom were flooded with radiance from that Light which hath risen from the dawning-place of the Sun of timelessness upon the frames of souls and horizons.

Then did the Sun of the Risings rise and repose upon the horizon of realities beneath the Sinai-tree in the thicket of the Divine Realm. Thereafter the Sun of the Ascendings shone forth, mounting unto that which may ascend to the most subtle heights above the Tree of Glory in the forest of Dominion. Then was the Point of Severance sundered from the billow of conjunction through the mystery of separation, and mounted above the cloud of minuteness on the right of the Tree of Praise in the woodland of the Kingdom. Thence was derivation drawn from the Word of Dissension, as hypocrisy had decreed, and what

had advanced turned back unto the ordinance of fulfilment on the left of the Tree of Decree in the grove of Humanity, until it was illumined from the Corner of the White Sign—flashing, shining, circling, revolving, enduring, and perpetuating; adorned with grace, unfolding with precision, dividing and gathering, speaking and causing speech, permitting and seeking leave, chanting within the reed of the First Tree in the land of Divinity.

And I now commemorate it, that the dwellers of Sinai may be thunderstruck, the full moons gasp in wonder, the unifiers be seized with awe, and the compassionate cry aloud; for verily it is, it is—oriental, eternal, lunar, everlasting, essential, self-subsistent, primal, divine, individual, lordly, existent, everlasting, delicate, celestial, merciful—she who hath sung and murmured, transcended and ascended, responded and re-responded, bestowed and received, arisen and stood firm, permitted and made free, proclaiming: "Verily we are of God, and unto God are we returning."

Then was it illumined from the Corner of the Yellow Sign—glowing, blazing, glittering, shimmering, dividing and diversifying, cubing and becoming fourfold, turning and returning, manifesting and concealing, granting leave and seeking leave, ringing and resounding within the reed of the Second Tree from the First in the land of Power. I commemorate it that the eloquent may bow, the lofty be humbled, the philosophers flee, and the sophists weep; for it is, it is—unattainable, divine, severed, mighty, radiant, luminous in meaning, tremulous in splendor, sanctified in being, exalted in heaven, fragrant, pure, lordly—she who declared: "Verily we are of God, and unto Him are we devoted."

Then was it sundered in majesty from the Corner of the Green Sign—shining and resplendent, soaring and aspiring, parting and separating, ringing and resonating, singing from the holy leaf of the Greatest Tree in the land of the Kingdom. I commemorate it that the breathers may breathe, the groaners lament, the mourners weep, the charitable bestow; for it is, it is—decreed, empyrean, primal, royal, final, divine, houri-like, paradise-born, heavenly, gardenal, pardisal, shining, archetypal, luminous, tented in light—she who rose and wept and took refuge and proclaimed:

> "Verily we are of God, and unto our Lord are we resigned."

Then was drawn forth what had been restrained, and extracted from the Corner of the Red Sign—flashing and glittering, trembling and quivering, radiant and blazing, rising and surging, dividing and balancing, contending and prevailing, producing her signs in majesty and confirming her tokens in sequence; murmuring and chanting from the Blessed Leaf of the First Tree in the land of Humanity, which hath borne the tokens of Divinity, embraced the stations of Power, displayed the meanings of the Kingdom, and perfected within itself the realities of the mortal realm.

I commemorate it, for verily it is—eternal, creative, everlasting, just, celestial, terrestrial, fiery, airy, watery, earthly, paradisal, effulgent, heavenly, majestic, beatific, beautiful, radiant, decreed, houri-like, lunar, pearly, solar. And if thou sayest it is divine and eternal, thou speakest truth; if thou sayest it is mighty and everlasting, thou hast spoken well; if thou sayest it is of the Kingdom and everlasting, thou hast spoken well; and if thou sayest it is the mortal cry, the Syrian roar, thou hast known and believed—for it is that which hath willed, determined, decreed, permitted, exalted, confirmed, transcended, abided, wept, divided, endured, borne, and stood firm; established upon the Throne and poised thereon; chanted

as the birds of holiness warbled in the heaven of paradise; resonated as the hosts of the Sovereign of bees hummed in the shadows of the empyrean boughs; cried out as the cock of form proclaimed in the heaven of the All-Holy; and uttered words of many colors as the peacock of mist unfurled its plumes in the firmament of air, spreading them in the zone of heaven toward the light of the sun—where every flutter reveals a hue of the expanse, and every season manifests a ray of the splendor of Him Who is the Lord of origination and creation.

Glorified be God! It was as though, whenever He moved the wings of His flight, the souls of the pure in heart were drawn unto Him by the gleaming radiance of the colours of His splendour—even as particles of iron are drawn by the magnet to that tablet of polished steel.

And when there descended upon me that Breath wherein the Light of Dawn exhaled and shone forth, it made mention of the birth that had come to pass in the midst of Islam. Then breathed therein the Light of Justice and rose resplendent. His father, ere the Manifestation of that Day, had beheld in a dream that in his hand was a Book irradiated with brightness, wherein the verses of the Qur'an were set apart in blessed chapters that gleamed with the same light that had shone aforetime. It was as though that Book had been moved to utter the words:

> "In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful. Ta Sin: the mention of the mercy of thy Lord—He, verily, is the All-Forgiving, the Most Merciful."

Blessed then be God for this Child—He Who, in the constancy of His piety, was guided by the Ordainer of the spheres and illumined by His grace. For this is indeed a token of the three Names manifested within the souls, and of that primal Covenant whereby the first seed was made to speak, and, if God will, when his appointed day is reached, he shall again cause it to speak; and when God willeth, he shall himself be made to speak forth.

And his father hath named him "Asadu'llah"—the Lion of God—He through Whom the night grew dark, the day was illumined, and the sun of radiance rose resplendent. When the trial is lifted, God shall reveal in that Child what the letter Kaf conceals when the dawn breaketh and the morn breathes forth its fragrance. In the interpretation of what God caused His father to behold in the verses of the Qur'an lieth a mystery that shall be made manifest hereafter, and shall shine with the light of dawn.

Protect him, therefore, O Lord of the Daybreak—Thou Who hast cloven the firmaments and fashioned all creation! And if Thou dost ordain for him another arising, verily a light is his portion amid the darkness of this nether life. Guard him from the deeds of the hypocrites and the discordant, and from that in which men are engulfed—those for whom the thousand stood between the two bas, and by it all the letters were endowed with speech, filling the heavens and the earth and the horizons with the radiance of His light.

Then was leave given that he should fall silent until, when God willeth, he shall again shine forth. Shelter him, then, by that sacred verse of the Qur'an from all that breathes in the night and in the day, when the gloom draweth close—for God is the Light of the heavens and of the earth. The likeness of His Light is as a niche wherein is a lamp; the lamp enclosed in glass; the glass as it were a glittering star, kindled from a blessed tree, an olive neither of the east nor of the west, whose oil well-nigh shineth though no fire touch

it—Light upon Light! God guideth unto His Light whomsoever He willeth; and God setteth forth parables for men, for God is Knower of all things.

Yea, the decree of that discourse gleamed from the risings of the Sun of Eternity, then shone forth, illumined, and was moved to speech within the ordinance of that Book—concerning what was asked by the two lords, and what had descended from the surging sea of destiny, radiant as before and newly effulgent. For that "thousand" and then another "thousand" are as the twelve hours of day and the flow of the Pen that inscribeth and dispenseth, until the mighty ones arise—the lofty intellectuals, the partisans of dissension and brilliance, the sages of discernment, and the seers of understanding.

In those two thousands [alfayn] was uttered the Light of Invention; it spake, it was inspired, it dawned resplendent. Verily we are God's, and verily unto Him shall we return.

BB00489: Letter to the great uncle

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Praise be to God Who has afflicted me with tribulation. I praise Him for what has befallen me of hardship and adversity through the wrongful actions of the people of polytheism and rebellion. To God do I pour out my grief and sorrow, and those who have acted unjustly shall soon know what fate awaits them.

That which you wrote has reached me and I have become aware of what has shone forth from your love. May God reward you for what you have done in God's religion and what you seek in God's path. By Him Who holds my soul in His hand, those who drink from the cup of love are secure, while those who turn away from the command of divine authority are the lost.

How can I fully describe what has befallen me in that land? The ink would run dry and the tablet would not suffice. But an indication of it will make known to you some of what has transpired through divine decree. When I migrated from that land to present my case to him whom God has made sovereign of the earth, I reached this land and alighted here with permission of His Excellency the trusted one of the exalted government (may God perpetuate his prosperity and reward him from His favors as he deserves). In truth, he has not failed to show attention and mercy. One night in his presence with certain men occurred what God willed and desired. The matter will be completed, God willing, with the divines when they appear on the Day of Arafat or the Day of Sacrifice for the mutual execration, for that was my judgment between them. Soon will God establish the truth through His words and make manifest the deeds of all people.

We shall soon journey to the court near to the King of Grace. When you hear of this, present yourself there and make known what you have witnessed of the actions of the ignorant ones. To God do we belong and unto our Lord shall we return. Peace be upon you and upon Ahmad and upon him whom you answered with the letter and upon those who have labored in God's Cause and those who follow after them. Today what I promised you will be fulfilled near noon minus five minutes.

Written on Friday, the seventh of the sacred month of Dhu'l-Hijjah, 1262 A.H.

BB00135: Kitab al-Hujja I

In the Name of God, the Inaccessible, the All-Protecting!

This is a Book from God, the Guardian, the Self-Subsisting, unto him whom God hath made the mention of his name to be the name of Nabil-i-Ali, a remembrance from Him amongst all worlds. O Nabil-i-Ali! I have neither beginning nor end. Verily, I have been from time immemorial, having neither beginning nor end, and I shall forever remain. I created all things through My command “Be!”, and it is. And I have made the likeness of My Cause as the likeness of the sun—though I cause it to rise countless times, it remains one sun, and though I cause it to set in ways none but I can comprehend, it remains one sun. Verily, I am the Best of creators.

That which I have created hath neither beginning nor end, lest it should occur to the heart of anyone whom I have created, or who hath been created through My power over the worlds, and My grace unto all beings. I have manifested My Cause through clear signs that render all worlds impotent, and I have made Myself known through the very essence of My Cause unto all that I have created through My command, that they might enter the paradise of My knowledge—a paradise that nothing can equal, whether in the heavens or on earth or between them. Verily, I am the Most Excellent of all who show excellence.

Say: Were We to gather together all creation, past and future, from the first to the last, and make them learned upon the earth, they would be powerless to produce the like of this Book from Us. Such is Our power over all worlds. We nurtured the creation of the Furqan for one thousand two hundred and seventy years, that perchance when they hear Our verses they might believe in Us and in Our proof. Thus have We admitted into the paradise of Our love those who followed Our verses and believed in Our proof, and We have forbidden from paradise those who, when they heard Our verses, said not “We are among the believers.” On that Day of Resurrection, all shall be brought before Us.

We created thee from a beginning that hath no beginning, and We were well-pleased with thee from a beginning that hath no beginning—a paradise that no other paradise can equal, as a favor from Us, for We are the All-Bountiful. And We shall surely create thee unto an end that hath no end, and We shall be well-pleased with thee in every resurrection like unto this, as a favor from Us, for We are the All-Bountiful.

We bestowed upon thee faith because thou wert among the assured ones in the Furqan, and We withheld faith from those who followed conjecture—and that is the fire wherewith they are promised. We made thee aforetime Our proof in the Furqan unto all worlds, then We made thee in the Bayan a proof from Our proof in the manifestations of the Primal Unity unto all worlds, that thou mightest guide every soul unto Our religion and deliver Our God-fearing servants. Verily, Our mercy hath preceded in the Book for the believers. Therefore deliver on the Day of Resurrection those whom thou seest behind the veils, free them from the people, and cause them to enter paradise, for We are ever-forgiving.

All know My good-pleasure, yet how is it that on that Day ye shall be veiled from My good-pleasure? O all things! Know ye God, your Lord, the All-Merciful, then believe ye in His verses and be assured of them,

then believe ye and be assured of him upon whom God hath sent down the verses, then support ye, as far as ye are able, the religion of God, for this is to support your own selves, could ye but perceive it. Verily, We are independent of the creation of what hath been created and what shall be created, but ye believe not in Our verses.

From Our proof they deserve in their lives what they themselves do not love, and after their death they shall enter into the fire. Therefore have mercy on yourselves and show mercy to others. Let not your lives deceive you, for verily you shall die. The grace and mercy of God hath come unto you—how then do you not turn to your Lord? This is what you supplicate for on the day of His manifestation, weeping night and day. This is the Cause of God through which all were created from the beginning that hath no beginning, and through which all shall be created unto the end that hath no end.

We have not found those who were given the Furqan (Qur'an) to be believers in what We have revealed therein. Some have transgressed Our bounds therein while outwardly following other than Our bounds, after We had decreed for them in the Furqan which they recite night and day. And some among their divines have made the Cause ambiguous to the people while claiming they follow the bounds of God, taking what God hath not permitted them while thinking they do good.

Say: Before the appearance of My proof you were veiled from My path. How do you follow conjecture after We forbade you from it in the Furqan, while thinking yourselves God-fearing? And verily the name Nabil-i-ʿAli is Our proof against you, for he followed the truth with truth and wrote the judgment of those who follow conjecture as being far removed from Our path. You have been veiled from true knowledge and have clung to principles you invented for yourselves, thinking you are helping the religion of God. Nay, nay! We have exposed your affair through the appearance of Our proof, showing that you were formerly far removed from God's path.

And verily one among you, bearing the name Muhammad-Baqir, built a mosque from what he took from the right of his Lord's proof and pronounced death sentences contrary to what We revealed in the Book. This is the condition of their greatest one before God—how then those below him who alter God's decree in minor matters?

When the earth was filled with their oppression, We manifested Our proof against them and desired to fill the whole earth with justice and equity for all peoples. We commanded him not to reveal himself so that all the worlds might be tested. Behold what We revealed through his tongue:

> "Verily there is no God but I, the Lord of all worlds."

Those people were not content to make him a servant of their proof after We manifested him with proof they cannot produce the like thereof, nor did they believe in it before the Furqan.

We shall question them: Have you seen Muhammad the Messenger of God as one of the witnesses of truth other than what you found in the Book of God by which you judge? If you entered your religion after knowing you were powerless before the Furqan, then let God speak to you in the Bayan—but you are unable to respond. And if you entered your religion without knowledge of this, then how do you

perceive your religion? The truth has come with truth and you are unable to respond with truth. All that you say regarding that is untrue, if you would but reflect a little.

Behold how We have closed in the Furqan all the doors through which they might hold fast to the proof of their religion and be saved on the Day of Resurrection. Verily We revealed aforetime in the Furqan that which all shall believe in on that Day. None besides God can reveal a verse, and you all, for one thousand two hundred and seventy years, have witnessed this with your own eyes and were certain of it. Therefore when you hear or see a verse, there is no recourse in your religion except to say this is from God, the Protector, the Self-Subsisting.

You have spent your time in matters that do not benefit you and have veiled yourselves from the proofs of your religion, thinking you would not be tested. Do you not consider those who were given the Gospel, how they veiled themselves from Muhammad, the Messenger of God, after having been promised His coming? And their divines until now weep for the appearance of Muhammad after one thousand two hundred and seventy years have passed, yet they still do not see. And the example of those who were given the Qur'an when We revealed the Bayan is like the example of those who were given the Gospel when We revealed the Qur'an.

Say: O people of the Qur'an, fear ye God! We have revealed in the Qur'an that by which you prove the Book, and We did not prove in the Qur'an the appearance of Muhammad except by your inability to produce verses. Why do you not reflect? And likewise We have proven the appearance of the Bayan—how is it you do not remember? If you say this single proof does not suffice us, look in the Qur'an where We revealed through the tongue of Moses and Aaron:

> "We have brought you a sign from your Lord, and peace be upon those who follow guidance."

And though We gave Moses nine clear signs, one of them sufficed for those who in their day believed in their Lord.

And We revealed in the Qur'an in the Surih of the Spider:

> "Is it not enough for them that We have sent down unto thee the Book which is recited to them? Verily in this is a mercy and a reminder to people who believe."

According to your religion, you have no recourse except to be satisfied with that, if you truly believe in what We revealed before. Say: If any Christian wished to enter your religion, would you prove it with anything other than the Qur'an? Do you have any other proof? Say: Glory be to God above those who know not!

We had nothing besides that Qur'an and by it We proved. Therefore just as you prove by the Qur'an to those who were given the Gospel, prove by the Bayan to yourselves and save yourselves from the fire. And We have caused one raised among the non-Arabs to speak these verses so that you might not be able to doubt. This is a wonder from one We raised before among the Arabs—how do you not see?

Say: The Qur'an which We revealed before over twenty-three years—We can now reveal the like of it in three days and nights if We wish, while you are confined before Our proof, hearing with your ears and

seeing with your eyes. Say: All that you prove from the traditions you have leads back to the Book of God—why do you not remember? You must judge according to God's Book that you possess. We are independent of your creation and your faith, but We desired to cause you to enter Paradise and be saved from the fire if you believe. Thus you will attain the good of your life and death.

And if you veil yourselves, you harm none but yourselves, and God will surely reckon with you and question you, for He is the Most Knowing of the knowers.

BB00063: Kitab al-Hujja II

Part 1: "This is a Book from the Point…"

In the name of God, the Powerful, the Mighty

This is a Book from the Point of the Bayan, God's servant and His Proof unto all the worlds, to him whose name God hath made the remembrance of His Proof's name, and whom He hath made, from His Proof, a proof unto all the worlds.

Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, created and made, from His presence, a resplendent light. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, brought into being and made, from His presence, gloriously magnificent. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, originated and made, from His presence, beauteously graceful. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, fashioned and made, from His presence, transcendently great. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, created and made, from His presence, radiantly luminous. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, caused to exist and made, from His presence, supremely powerful. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, preserved and made, from His presence, perfectly complete. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, endowed and made, from His presence, sublimely exalted. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, established and made, from His presence, consummately wise. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, appointed and made, from His presence, mightily powerful. Say: I am the first whom God manifested from His presence and made, from His presence, eminently manifest.

Say: Verily God hath created all things by His Command and made me, from His presence, His Command unto all the worlds. Say: God hath made the likeness of His Command as the likeness of the sun which God causeth to rise times beyond any one's reckoning save His own, whereupon all are illumined by a single sun; and He causeth it to set times beyond any one's reckoning save His own, whereupon all await it. Say: I am the first whom God created from a beginning that hath no beginning, and made me the Sun of His Manifestation unto all the worlds. Say: I am the first whom God, my Lord, createth and maketh, from His presence, unto an end that hath no end, the Sun of His Manifestation unto all the worlds.

All that God hath created from a beginning that hath no beginning, He created by His Command; thus were all created through me aforetime and through me shall all hereafter be created. God hath manifested me from a beginning that hath no beginning, as He willeth, by His Command in every Manifestation with names from His presence—verily He is the Best of Revealers. Were I to declare that

God hath manifested me according to the number of all things and made me, from His presence, a proof unto all the worlds, and hath sent down unto me the Book from my tongue through that which He hath inspired me from His presence, and ordained of paths what He willeth, I would assuredly be speaking truth. Yet do I seek God's forgiveness for this, as this is the limit of what my heart can comprehend of the numbers of all things, and God's power in His Command is greater than this, and we are all His worshippers. For the numbers of all things created in the Book are created by His Command—how then can the Command be known by that which is created by it? Glorified and exalted be God above what they define!

And God hath not manifested me in any Manifestation from a beginning that hath no beginning except that I said: O all things! Worship God, my Lord and your Lord, for I am the first of worshippers. Follow the verses of God, for they are God's proof unto all who are in the heavens and the earth and what lieth between them, and unto the worlds. And follow ye the commandments of God. Verily, through this ye shall, in your earthly life, enter the paradise of God's good-pleasure, and after your death ye shall enter the paradise of the highest heaven. Say: Therein, whatsoever your souls desire shall God create through His command "Be!" and it is, even as He hath created all things through His command. Will ye not then see?

Fear ye in your lives aught save God's good-pleasure, for this is the fire of your existence, did ye but know. Verily this shall lead you unto that from which ye shall, after your death, be excluded.

From the beginning that hath no beginning until now, all that God hath manifested through Me hath been to summon every soul unto God, my Lord, the Lord of all the worlds. I have revealed the Books from God as He hath permitted Me, and have ordained ways as He hath willed. He, verily, is the Most Wise of the wise.

God hath given Me no will save His Will—say: O all things, be ye thankful! God hath given Me no desire save His Desire—say: O all things, be ye thankful! God hath given Me no power save His Power—say: O all things, be ye thankful! God hath given Me no decree save His Decree—say: O all things, be ye thankful! God hath given Me no permission save His Permission—say: O all things, be ye thankful! God hath given Me no term save His Term—say: O all things, be ye thankful! God hath given Me no book save His Book—say: O all things, be ye thankful!

Say: Should all who are in the heavens and on earth and whatsoever lieth between them endeavor to produce the like of this Book, they would never be able, nor would they have the power, even were they the most learned ones on earth. This is God's proof unto all the worlds, this is God's testimony unto all who dwell in the heavens and on earth and whatsoever lieth between them, and then unto all the worlds. These are God's evidences unto all who dwell in the heavens and on earth and whatsoever lieth between them, and then unto all the worlds. These are God's arguments unto all who dwell in the heavens and on earth and whatsoever lieth between them, and then unto all who are in the worlds. These are God's demonstrations unto all who dwell in the heavens and on earth and whatsoever lieth between them, and then unto all who are in the worlds.

This hath been My way from the beginning that hath no beginning until now. In every Dispensation I have counseled: O all things! Be ye fearful in the next Manifestation. For He Who hath ordained for you the first Manifestation is He Whom God shall make manifest, and He shall ordain for you in times of sorrow. Ye believed in the first One; how then do ye veil yourselves from the next?

Before the First Point, God did manifest Me in such wise that none besides Him can comprehend, and I was, in every Dispensation, among the foremost of them that worship God, the Lord of the heavens and the Lord of the earth, of the seen and the unseen, the Lord of all the worlds. From the Manifestation of the First Point until now, God hath manifested Me in every Dispensation by whatever name hath been manifested, and all do follow Me. I was Noah in the day of Noah, and Abraham in the day of Abraham, and Moses in the day of Moses, and Jesus in the day of Jesus, and Muhammad in the day of Muhammad, and the Primal Point in the day of the Primal Point, Him Whom God shall make manifest in His day, and Him Whom God shall make manifest after Him in His day, and Him Who shall be manifested after Him Whom God shall make manifest in His day, unto the end that hath no end, even as the beginning that had no beginning. In every Manifestation I have been the Proof of God unto all the worlds. This is the meaning of the true saying which ye call to mind, that when God shall manifest His Proof, they shall say:

> "Whosoever desireth to behold the countenance of the Primal Beauty and all the Prophets and Messengers, let him look upon My countenance, for verily I am the first of them that bow down in worship,"

inasmuch as all that whereby they were made Messengers was but one Command in the Book of God, and at that time that Command was: Say: O all things! All the good that hath appeared and all the good that shall appear is from Me, if ye desire to comprehend. Say: There is naught beyond God and beyond the Sun of Truth if ye would but remember. In every Manifestation, to the extent of a house, that Manifestation createth for the day when God shall manifest Me in the later Manifestation, whereupon none recognize Me save the discerning servants of God who are pious in their religion.

Verily, I was David in the day of his Manifestation, and God revealed unto Me the Psalms and ordained what He willed of religion. Then did God manifest Me before David in Moses, yet they recognized Me not, else they would not have been patient in their religion, and until this moment they cry out in the fire of their death and life, yet are not helped.

Then did I counsel those who were given the Torah to await Jesus, son of Mary, the Spirit of God and His Word, for verily ye shall be created anew on the day of His manifestation. Say: They said: "O Moses! We believe in what covenant Thou hast taken from us and we shall follow." Yet when God manifested Me in Jesus, they fulfilled not their word and differed concerning Jesus, the Proof of their Lord, saying: "Thou art other than what Moses, the Messenger of God, promised us," and they believed not in Thy Book nor in what God revealed unto Thee, the Gospel…for the believers. And so until this moment they remain steadfast in their religion, crying out in the fire of their life and death, yet they perceive not.

Then did Jesus counsel those who were given the Gospel to fear God and await the appearance of Muhammad, the Messenger of God, for verily He shall come unto you from God, there is no doubt in it, so aid Him as ye are able. But when Muhammad, the Messenger of God, came unto them, none believed

among them save seventy of their learned ones, as they were among the believers in what God revealed unto Muhammad, until God made manifest the religion of His Messenger and aided Him as He willed from His presence, whereupon all could see.

Then Muhammad, the Messenger of God, said:

> "Await ye the appearance of the Mahdi from among my descendants, Who shall come unto you after the earth hath been filled with your oppression and tyranny, for verily ye shall be created anew through Him."

And God made the Proof of Muhammad to be the Furqan and preserved it until now, whereby all seek guidance. Yet when God made Me manifest with that Proof, none recognized Me save a few of the believers after… believers, for their belief in Muhammad the Messenger of God was their belief in Me, and their belief in the Furqan was their belief in the Bayan, yet they remain veiled from the mystery of the Cause. I have closed in the religion of Islam the gates of their veils upon them.

Perchance on the day of the appearance of Him Whom they await, they will not be veiled, for God hath revealed in the Qur'an that none but God can send down verses. And ye, after one thousand two hundred and seventy years, have witnessed this with your own eyes. If ye believe in this, whenever ye hear a verse or behold it, ye cannot imagine in your hearts that this is from other than God, in that which ye believe. How then do ye take up your pens to produce the like thereof, or doubt this? We have established Our proof against you, that ye might reflect thereon, and then, in the next Resurrection, be not veiled from the proof of your Lord.

Part 2: "Those who were given the Qur'an have spent…"

Those who were given the Qur'an have spent their lives in that which profiteth them not of their wisdom and principles, for had it profited them, they would have believed in Me. By thy life! Those who believe not in Me have not understood a single letter of the Book of God, even as those who believed not in Jesus understood not a single letter of the Torah, though they imagine they do well. Have mercy upon them and deliver them on the Day of Resurrection from the fire of their lives, for they die not, and they enter into the fire of their death wherein they shall not be helped.

Similarly do I counsel those who have been given the Bayan not to veil themselves from Him Whom God shall make manifest in the next Resurrection, for if ye become veiled, your religion will not profit you a grain's weight, even as the religion of those who profited not from their faith at the appearance of Muhammad, the Apostle of God. O people of the Bayan! Fear ye God! Again, fear ye God! And be not veiled from the signs of God, for verily by them shall ye be saved. When ye hear a verse, it is forbidden unto you to say "nay," that ye may not be veiled from the Cause of God. God hath caused the religion of Islam to endure until My manifestation, and all await daily My appearance, supplicating night and day, yet they remain veiled from that which God hath ordained for them.

God hath caused the religion of Islam to endure in such wise that seven kings therein have professed the faith of Muhammad in this day. How many since the days of Muhammad until now have come and returned unto their Lord, and until this day do they progress in their stations according to their deeds.

God hath manifested Me in the year one thousand two hundred and seventy after the appearance of Muhammad, the Apostle of God, with proofs wherewith God had previously manifested Muhammad, the Apostle of God, that those who have been given the Qur'an might not be able to differ. And whomsoever God wished among the chosen ones hath believed, and whomsoever God wished to veil hath been veiled without right or mighty Book.

Behold how the true divines' proof that they judge by God's leave is the word of Ja'far ibn Muhammad and then My word in the first Occultation, yet they reflect not. Say: Verily Ja'far ibn Muhammad was created by the command of Muhammad, the Apostle of God, and had Muhammad not declared him the sixth Imam, how would ye accept what he said? And if God had not sent down verses to Muhammad, the Apostle of God, how would ye recognize him?

Thus are they veiled by three veils. Had they been truthful before My manifestation, they would have judged the people, not those who appointed them. Behold how they recognized not the proof of their Lord and judged Him by that which no one would be content to judge another without right or illuminating Book. Say: Before My manifestation, they followed other than truth and were false. This shall suffice them ere My Appearance; for subsequent to My Appearance their affair will be so manifest as to require no proof from any soul among the peoples of the world.

Their likeness is as the likeness of the divines who lived in the days of Muhammad, the Apostle of God. God hath, in the Qur'an, made them as idols inasmuch as the people followed them after the appearance of Muhammad, the Apostle of God, as ye yourselves now witness.

God had revealed aforetime:

> "They have taken their doctors of law and their monks for lords besides God"

inasmuch as they followed their divines instead of Muhammad, the Apostle of God, yet they reflect not, neither do they remember.

They have, by their words in Mine absence, followed vain imaginings and have made the affairs of their religion according to what they say, such as their consuming that which God hath not permitted them from among carrion. Were they to reflect upon that which they utter, they would surely know that they have departed from their religion, for God hath revealed in the Qur'an:

> "This day have I perfected your religion for you and completed My favor unto you."

This is what God, the Lord of all worlds, hath testified, yet they testify to that which God hath not testified and imagine themselves to be God-fearing.

Nay, nay! Thy path is the path of guidance and Our decree concerning the ordinances is Our proof against them, yet they are drowned in their desires and they reflect not, neither do they remember.

Say: After My manifestation their state in the sight of God is more remote than that of the ancients, for when the ancients heard the verses of Muhammad, the Apostle of God, they outwardly professed their

belief, whereas these have not even done as much as that, though they imagine themselves to be learned and presume to judge in My name.

And he who opposed Moses, despite his might, when Moses came unto him with clear tokens, ceased not until he had produced a mighty sorcery. Yet these who say "We are learned" have produced no sign, and they utter falsehoods without right while imagining themselves and those who follow them to be truthful. Say: Your impotence is more evident than the sun; bring ye the like of this Book, O divines of Islam, if ye be truthful.

They have made the matter ambiguous unto their rulers until they returned unto their king and made the matter ambiguous unto him without right and have caused every soul to enter into the fire by reason of their being veiled, while imagining themselves to be servants of God who shall be saved.

If there be made for thee a way unto their king, send unto him these two Books and say: These divines have made the matter ambiguous unto thee, yet God hath made manifest the truth in thy days. Therefore know thou the worth of the days of God and let thy mention endure unto the next Resurrection among all peoples.

These verses are Our proof against them. Command thou that the proofs of thy Cause be presented unto them all together. If they bring unto thee the like of this Book, then follow not the truth, but if they be powerless to bring the like thereof, how canst thou deprive thyself of attaining the presence of Him Whom God hath made His Own Presence, when all were created for this purpose and all shall be questioned concerning it?

For God had revealed aforetime in the Qur'an, which ye all recite night and day:

> "God is He Who raised up the heavens without pillars as ye can see, then mounted the Throne, and compelled the sun and the moon to serve you; each travelleth unto an appointed time; He ordereth the course of all things; He showeth His signs distinctly, that ye may be certain of the meeting with your Lord."

There is no doubt that God cannot be seen, nor can sight comprehend Him, for He createth vision in whomsoever He willeth among His servants. There is no God but Him, the One, the All-Seeing.

God intended by this naught save the meeting with His Proof, even as He hath revealed in the Qur'an: "Whoso obeyeth the Apostle, obeyeth God."

How is it that ye prevent this bounty from entering your houses? By thy life! Were the kings who are in Islam to become aware of the matter, they would all unite to aid Me. But grace belongs to him whom God hath made manifest in His kingdom, for verily he is able to subdue all the worlds through the name of his Lord's Proof.

And at that time, through the name of Muhammad, how he possessed what he possessed—and that is the name of his Lord's Manifestation on the Day of Resurrection.

All desire to aid the Proof of their Lord and uplift the true Faith through what they are enabled to do.

Say: All shall die, whether rightfully or wrongfully, and their remembrance shall not endure in this world. Therefore, cause thy remembrance to endure by aiding the Cause of God on the Day of Resurrection, for this indeed is the great bounty.

And were the veil to be lifted, none would find aught more beloved than Me in their own selves. But those who know Me understand this, while others do not know.

And thou art commanded to present this Book to all who are on earth, if they be not powerless before God's might.

For We are patient, but if they are powerless, how canst thou be patient in God's Cause after God hath made the remembrance of His Own all-subduing Name the foundation of every religion?

And relief would come if from the time of Muhammad until now in Islam all would realize how they supplicate night and day yet are unable to alter God's Cause or modify a decree.

Say: Were ye to be slain, God would surely ease your paths in your religion and manifest that wherewith ye would be content.

Say: Relief is naught but what God revealeth through a soul and bestoweth upon it of proof which all are powerless before.

This then is what ye supplicate for night and day, and for its manifestation do ye beseech.

Therefore ask concerning all that is difficult for you regarding the appearance of your Lord's Proof, for ye shall answer yourselves through these verses if ye but reflect.

Say: All are compelled by their faith toward the Truth.

Verily I am independent of these creatures through God my Lord, yet I desire to guide all these unto God's path and deliver them from the veils of their mortal lives and from the fire wherewith they are promised after their death.

Say: Those who return unto God their Lord, then seek forgiveness and follow what God hath revealed unto His Proof—God may well forgive them what their hands have wrought, for He is the Best of forgivers.

Say: If it be difficult for your divines to grasp the meaning of the utterance of an Imam or a Prophet, or a verse from the Book of God—He Who hath issued from His presence shall, in three nights and days, bring forth the equivalent of the Qur'an. How is it, then, that ye deny Him? Bring, then, tablets and pens, and sit for three nights and days without intermission; thereafter shall ye witness a Book equal in measure to the Qur'an.

Glory be to Thee, O my God! Bear Thou witness for me that by these two Books I have perfected Thy proof upon all humankind. Do Thou, then, guide each soul unto Thy Faith, for Thou art the Most Powerful of the powerful; and deliver each one from whatsoever veileth him from Thy good-pleasure, for Thou art the Most Excellent of the excellent. Deliver all from whatsoever veils them from Thy good-pleasure, for

Thou art the Most Excellent of the excellent. Glory be unto Thee, O God! Thou art the Guide of the heavens and earth and whatsoever lieth between them. Thou givest guidance unto whom Thou willest and withdrawest guidance from whom Thou willest. Thou exaltest whom Thou willest and abaseth whom Thou willest. Thou strengthenest whom Thou willest and humblest whom Thou willest. Thou aidest whom Thou willest and forsaketh whom Thou willest. Thou enrichest whom Thou willest and impoverisheth whom Thou willest. Within Thy grasp is the kingdom of all things. Thou createst what Thou willest, how Thou willest, by what Thou willest, for what Thou willest. Verily Thou art powerful over whatsoever Thou willest.

BB00610

In the name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

I have taken refuge in Him Who possesses sovereignty over all realms, material and divine, and have held fast to Him Who wields might and supreme power, and have placed my trust in the Ever-Living One Who neither slumbers nor dies. I have entered into God's protection and God's sanctuary from the evil of all afflictions, by virtue of Kaf-Ha-Ya-Ayn-Sad and by virtue of Ha-Mim-Ayn-Sin-Qaf. God will suffice you, and He is the All-Hearing, the All-Knowing. I seek refuge in God, the True One, from the evil of every night-visitant.

BB00006: Tafsir-i-Suratu'l-Baqarah (2nd Juz') (Commentary on the Surah of the Cow II)

On the verse "The foolish among men will say: What hath turned…"

God, exalted be He, hath said: "The foolish among men will say: What hath turned them from the qiblih which they formerly observed?' Say: Unto God belong the East and the West; He guideth whom He willeth unto a straight path."'[Q2:142]

And God willed, in the realm of the Godhead of action, from mankind the very hearing, the appointed term, and the Book; for they said: Will, decree, and judgment—what hath turned them from their qiblih, which is the Will? Say: It proclaimed: God manifested Himself unto the East of creation through Me, by My Self; and unto the West of origination through Me, by My body. Ye behold nothing in the kingdom of the heavens and the earth but that it is a sign of My manifest sovereignty. Thus did God create it as a sign unto His own Self, a dawning-place of His Presence, a geometry of His greatness, and a mirror of His Being, whereby He guideth unto Himself whom He willeth of His servants; for it is the Balance of Justice for God, wherein its "I-ness" is weighed against His Selfhood, and its selfhood against His Being.

It is, moreover, a Path that calleth from itself unto itself, proclaiming His Godhead, as though it were neither wholly other than His pre-eternity nor He other than it. God revealed the Qur'an from its tongue, saying—and His word is the truth—"Verily my Lord is upon a straight path."

And thou, O gazer upon the Dawning-Place of the Cloud, O drinker of the water of effacement from the cup of abiding life at the hands of decree—turn every letter of the Book of the Ha of Splendor in accordance with that Sun of Beginning wherewith We illumined thee, and with the ordinances of consummation wherewith We made thee to know, that in the reality of origination there is the law of the element of water like unto air. This is indeed the White Path in the Crimson Countenance, the White Page, the Yellow Form, and the Green Tree. This is an interpretation, from the horizon of exposition, of the verses of meanings within souls and horizons. Interpretation, in the station of exposition, admitteth of no pointing within the realm of possibility; for it is the station of pure manifestation in the countenance of Oneness, through the negation of bare mention and fixed attribution. Glory be to God, thy Lord, the Lord of the Throne, above what they ascribe!

If thou wouldst tremble in thy quest to know the stations of meanings, then know the manifestations of the stations of the Gates. For the foolish—who utter that which God revealed from their own speech—are the people of the Fire after the first rank; they are those who believed not in the causality of the Family of God, peace be upon them, within the chain of existence; and whoso is not assured that nothing descendeth from God save through them, and that nothing ascendeth unto God save through them—he, indeed, is of the foolish who shall be gathered unto the Fire.

Today they are a people who say to those who followed the ordinance of God and prayed toward Jerusalem aforetime: Ye were content, in the recognition of the Gates, with a bare and absolute dawning, and with the pure manifestation of Fire in the rank of earth. Say: If ye be in the right, why then do they turn away from the mention of the Fire's dawning among men, and silence some concerning that which they themselves affirmed before? Today they turn toward the Ka'bah in silence. Say: The judgment is God's; He giveth life and causeth death; He commandeth and forbiddeth; He doeth whatsoever He willeth, as He willeth, by what He willeth; and His are the East and the West and whatsoever lieth between them.

If ye disclose your sovereignty among men, ye were His servants; and if ye cleave open the gate of your praise for that which men's hands have earned, ye were His friends. God is, verily, independent of that which ye describe. And whoso saith that the Gates who rule by God's leave are dead, according to the judgment of the Book—these are the companions of the former [error]; God hasten His retribution upon them; they are indeed the lost.

Unto the beholder in the thicket of the Kingdom it behoveth him to interpret the qiblih as Muhammad, the Messenger of God, upon the Throne of the Godhead; the East as Hasan, peace be upon him, upon the Throne of Might; and the West as Husayn, peace be upon him, upon the Throne of the Kingdom. This is the Path of Justice for those whom God hath placed in the land of human existence.

And for him who gazeth into the essences of essential realities, it behoveth him to interpret that verse in the gardens of Oneness, in the stations of Unity, and in the manifestations of the All-Merciful—through the verses of the Godhead, the signs of Might, the evidences of the Kingdom, and the forms of the human realm—according to that which God willeth in His Self and hath permitted His servant. This is but a sprinkling from the surging sea of the Greater Jafr. We shall, God willing, sprinkle thee with a further sprinkling that will teach thee what thou knewest not before.

Therefore set the buried bird flying in the depths of those tender words; then the purified bird in the hidden recesses of those expanded proofs; then the moving peacock in the beings of those allusions as a point beneath the Ba' in the first Ba'; then the crowing cock in the identities of those signs as a point beneath the Ba' in the second Ba'.

Then gather the number of letters that have shone upon thee, and quicken them by the hidden Alif—the fire of creation—whereupon thou shalt behold the bird of Identity singing in the Caller with the letter of invocation. Settle upon thyself the judgment of those endowed with understanding: that what is there is known only by what is here. This, indeed, is the branching tantanj from the surging sea of decree. Drink thereof, and hasten beyond all thou beholdest therein with the spirit of faith. For the All-Merciful hath said:

> "The All-Merciful taught the Qur'an; He created man; He taught him utterance."

Today thou art before the sun and the moon in the land of the Kaf, by measure.

They are powerless to speak the like of that which the All-Merciful hath taught—the ordinance of the Qur'an through exposition. This is the interpretation of the verse in the world of the Gates. If thou desirest the interpretation of the verse in the rank of the Imamate, then be assured that the existence of the East is realized only by the existence of the sun; it is the garment of Prophethood in the countenance of the Muhammadan Presence. When it setteth, the West appeareth at once; night cometh with its deep darkness; then the moon ariseth—the sign of Guardianship—with radiant light. It is he who proclaimed majesty upon the Throne of the Greatest, saying—after what he had said in his sermon of exposition: "I am the meaning that falleth not under name nor likeness; I am the Gate of Forgiveness. There is no power nor might save in God." He spoke the truth—and God is witness to the truth—by the Most Great Vision in the Book of the Messenger, the Bearer of glad tidings: "The Hour hath drawn nigh, and the moon hath been cleft."

Then God created by him the radiant stars, whose number He fixed in the Qur'an as twelve; they are the Pilgrimage, the Sacred House, and the Greatest Month. They are the Face of God; through them doth every one who turneth—whether advancing or retreating—turn unto Him. Even as God hath ordained, in the world of bodies, a qiblih toward which bodies stand, so hath He ordained, in the world of souls and spirits and hearts, a qiblih toward which all must turn in prayer. Whoso turneth away from it—he is, by the explicit word of the Sadiq, in the form of an ass.

Fear God, O man, in thy prayer: worship not God, thy Lord, through the mention of aught beside Him. For whoso worshippeth God through a prophet, an imam, or a man, hath associated partners with his Lord and hath worshipped nothing. Know, then, the paths of worship through knowledge itself, even as ʿAli ibn al-Husayn, peace be upon him, hath said in his supplication at the end of the night in the Greatest Month:

> "O my God! Through Thee I knew Thee; that is, I worshipped Thee through Thee. Thou didst guide me unto Thyself and didst summon me unto Thee; and but for Thee I should not have known who Thou art, and but for Thee I should not have worshipped Thee."

When thou worshippest God, thy Lord, upon that path, thou shalt taste the sweetness of His remembrance and know the station of His recognition—that even as He is, none knoweth Him, nor worshippeth Him, nor uniteth Him, nor loveth Him save He Himself. For His Essence cutteth off contingent beings from worship and knowledge; His Being forbiddeth existent things from narration and expression. The servant worshippeth Him through that whereby He hath manifested Himself unto him; and this, in truth, is the utmost effusion of the All-Merciful within the realm of possibility—an effusion that pointeth only unto the All-Merciful.

And thou, O witness of the dawning of the heart in the prolonged night—if thou wert to know the ordinance wherewith We have aided thee by the assistance of the Spirit of the angels, thou wouldst be assured of the truth of that which the Sadiq, peace be upon him, hath said concerning prayer:

> "I continued to repeat these verses until I heard them from their Speaker—that He is He Who manifesteth Himself by that whereby He is manifested."

The Essence hath ever remained unassociated with anything, and its condition hath not changed. If only they were aware, in what they utter in the remembrance of God, they would hear whatever they themselves pronounce.

When thou hast recognized the decree of divine manifestation, make the qiblih of thy heart the appearance of the verse "There is no God but God", and the qiblih of thy mind "Muhammad is the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family", and the qiblih of thy soul him whom God hath named today as the Remnant of God, who is better for the believers than their own selves, would they but understand. And make the qiblih of thy body the House of God in the Sacred Mosque, which God hath made namesake of Him Who judges among the people through divine knowledge, and who is today possessed of severe might by reason of what the doer of remote deeds hath perpetrated, for God hath decreed that He doeth whatsoever He willeth.

Verily, if people were to turn in the worlds of the abstract according to what God hath prescribed for them, but failed to turn in this thy world according to what God hath commanded all people, their deeds would not be accepted by God, and they would be like unto asses in the moment of their deed, would they but understand. They are indeed dead today, though they perceive it not.

When thou art illumined by the effulgences of that blessed verse in its visible ranks, know thou the meaning of the verse in the rank of the pillars—that it is a tree neither of the East nor of the West, which God hath made the qiblih of the hearts of the Prophets and the truthful ones, for the origin of their existence was nourished from the manifestation of the form of Fatimih, the blessings of God be upon her. God hath indeed detailed all that people have said concerning the Prophets regarding their qiblih in the mystery of that verse, yet most people are not grateful.

And shouldst thou desire to tread the rugged pathway and traverse the arduous road, then expound thou the meaning of the verse within the diverse aspects of thine own soul, and hearken unto the speech of the foolish ones—proceeding from the contingent identities within thy secret heart—saying:

> "What hath turned thee from thy Qiblih, which is the ordinances of Ahmad aforetime?"

Say: Both the East—which is the remembrance of God made manifest, namely Ahmad—and the West—which is the bearer of His testament—belong to God. Indeed He is the Countenance in the kingdoms of Command and Creation, and He hath spoken what He hath spoken through His intimations. If thou wouldst gaze upon the glory of His sacred praise, thou wouldst witness what I have indicated to thee. All thoughts that occur to thee regarding religious laws, suggesting that if things were thus it would be better, arise from the promptings of the polytheists. For God is the Ever-Living, the All-Powerful, Who causeth to flow what He willeth as He willeth.

There is no difference between the words of the foolish who say what turned them from their qiblih, or one who says if God would manifest through His servant a sign of power, or what God hath related in the Qur'an "Bring back our fathers." All these stem from imperfection. The one who submits to God's decree and is content with His judgment sees all that God sendeth down as the best possible. But let not the matter confuse thee, for if it were thus, how would some distinguished men seek exemption from matters of divine power? This is because they ask, as did the people in the time of Moses and Abraham, peace be upon them, and as Abu Basir asked of the Baqir, peace be upon him. In reality they ask only by God's leave.

The supreme honor, the lofty portion, and the exalted destiny lie in the knowledge of certainty through the manifestation of the eye of certainty, as He, exalted be His remembrance, hath said: "Were the veil to be lifted, my certainty would not increase." And when God's ultimate decree appeared concerning him, he spoke similarly to His words regarding the ultimate glory of God: "I have attained unto the Lord of the Ka'bah." O thou who asketh, when thou findest the verses of Paradise in the shade of the dark waters of the Paradise of human knowledge—then know what I AM. Then I shall inform thee, by God's leave, concerning the manifestations of the resplendent ones, the radiant conditions, the effulgent essences, the sanctified realities, and the gleaming identities. This is the descent of the verse regarding the station of the Chiefs.

The foolish who speak words of remoteness concerning them shall be gathered in the sixth level of the fire, which is the shadow of Paradise in Sijjin. Just as it behooveth man to know the stations of the people of Paradise and distinguish in this world between their deeds and words, so too must he recognize the levels of the fire and its people, then their deeds and words, as commanded by al-Sadiq, peace be upon him, in his words—and his word is truth. God the Exalted hath said: "I have made ten obligations binding upon My servants. When they know these, I shall cause them to dwell in the kingdom of My Paradise. The first is knowledge of Me. The second is knowledge of My Messenger to My creation, and acknowledgment and acceptance of him.

The third is knowledge of My friends who are My proofs to My creation—whoever befriends them hath befriended Me, and whoever shows enmity to them hath shown enmity to Me. They are the knowledge between Me and My creation. Whoever denieth them, I shall crucify in My fire and multiply My punishment upon them. The fourth is knowledge of the Persons who have been established from My holy radiance—they are the maintainers of My justice. The fifth is knowledge of those who maintain through their grace, and acceptance of them. The sixth is knowledge of My enemy Iblis and what he was as a

creature and his helpers. And seventh is acceptance of My Cause and belief in My Messengers. And eighth is to conceal My secret and the secret of My chosen ones.

And ninth is to honor the people of My image, to accept from them and refer to them in matters wherein ye differ, until explanation cometh forth from them. And tenth is that he and his brother in faith and in the world be legally equal. When they are thus, I shall admit them to My Kingdom and grant them security from the great terror, and they shall be with Me in the highest heaven.

Know thou with certainty that the shadow of the lower chain in relation to the higher chain is the essence of poison and the most intense fire, for the punishment of one who denies the Successor is the punishment of one who denies both the Prophet and the Successor. Apply this principle from the highest pearl to the lowest particle.

Today, turn away from the reversed letters and count it among the sins of the first, for it is the essence of his unbelief. The first is the manifestation of calamities, the second the manifestation of evil, and the third the very essence of Satan. The difference between their words is as God hath ordained between their deeds. If thou lookest with truth, thou shalt see their deeds correspond to the deeds of those who came before in their acknowledgment of the Guardianship and their following. Nay, they performed even more in the station of faith, for they believed, emigrated, delivered the message, and wrote the Book of Attestation, while those before did not act similarly. God punished them for what their hands had wrought.

Thou knowest they are rejected before their own kind, and none desire to mention them, but God mentions them only to express His wrath. We have made known to thee something of their station that people might dissociate from them and they might be among the known ones.

When thou hast understood the decree concerning the foolish ones, know then the decree concerning the House, for it is today the Qiblih for those who previously turned toward the Holy House. Pilgrimage to the House is prescribed for those who are able to make their way there. The East hath shone forth with the dawning of that which shineth from the Orient of the name of the Guardianship, and the West shall rise after the setting of that which shineth from the Sun of Rising. God guideth whom He willeth through His word: “This is God’s path in the heavens and earth.” Whoso willeth may accept, and whoso willeth may turn away. As for those who disbelieve, truly God is independent of all worlds.

When thou hast learned of the six aspects in the interpretation of the verse, know then concerning the rank of the excellent ones thy Lord’s decree, even as was revealed to thee regarding the station of the chosen ones. Therefore all are commanded to know the right of the first believer in the verses of the Book, and likewise is the decree for those who follow that ultimate Cause, from the summit of the chosen ones—servants who dwell in My presence—to the furthermost particles of mysteries. It is incumbent upon all to love them and dissociate from their enemies, for by them are moved the moving things in the thickets of the Divine Realm in their rank, and by them are stilled the still things in the thickets of the Realm of Might in their station. Those who know them not by their names and are not content to follow them—these are the lost.

Those who revile the believing men and believing women, if they return not unto God and repent, God will never forgive them nor guide them. Grievous indeed is it in God's Book that they should say that which they know not. The enemies of God in that rank shall suffer more severe punishment than those of the higher rank. Therefore be patient and forbearing, and walk with them until thou guidest them to follow thou the path of justice, for verily if one guideth a soul it is better for him than all that the sun shineth upon, and it is as though he hath guided all mankind. But fear God, lest thou incline unto them or accept abasement in the land, for verily God hath linked the glory of the believer with His own glory, and all power belongeth unto God.

And verily all that We have illumined thee with, caused to shine forth from thee, acquainted thee with, confirmed thee in, exalted thee through, taught thee, and prepared thee for from the seven degrees is a portion for the people of knowledge and those who perceive with the light of discernment. And since the weak ones among the people of the Law have a share in the decrees of Truth, I shall indicate some of the outward meaning of the noble verse. Verily the Messenger of God did pray in Mecca for thirteen years facing toward Jerusalem, and when He migrated to Medina and the Jews grew arrogant with false claims, the Messenger of God—peace be upon Him and His family—complained unto God, and verily He did turn His face toward heaven at that time, and verily this verse was revealed before the verse which I explained to thee.

When God answered His prayer, the Faithful Spirit descended upon His heart while He was in prayer, having completed two prostrations of the noon prayer, and commanded Him to turn toward the Kaaba. He obeyed God's command at once and all prayed with Him facing the Kaaba. Then after that the Christians and Jews came unto Him and some disputed with Him in ways unsuitable to mention in this Book. And I shall mention what the Messenger—peace be upon Him—declared concerning them as a remembrance for all peoples. And verily as mentioned in the Safi, the Imam—exalted be His mention—said [here follows a long tradition quoted in the Safi from the Ihtijaj]

When thou hast learned the writing of men, hearken unto the buzzing of the bees of the Kingdom, that they may cause thee to soar upon the carpet of fellowship before God and teach thee the portion of the jinn in the countenance of the heart, and of the angels, animals, plants and minerals from that blessed verse. And verily He saith the portion of the jinn in the countenance of the heart is the human temple, and the portion of the angels is recognition of the station of Solomon, and the portion of the animals is the physical conditions of the people of the Bayan. Thus doth the ant believe that God hath two antennae just as man believeth He hath two attributes such as knowledge and power. Glory be to Him, exalted is He above all that they ascribe!

Each describeth themselves and their stations, yet none knoweth the Essence as it is in its sanctification beyond all names and attributes save Him. And verily the All-Glorious hath manifested Himself to the ant even as His manifestation to the Primal Will—glorified and exalted is He above what they describe! And verily the portion of the plants is to enter into the body of animals, and in the station of the temple of universal authority it is the pomegranate. Therefore did He choose it from among all fruits and made its interior universal mercy. And if man partaketh thereof on Friday, God will illumine his heart to the extent of Moses' appointed time. Therefore neglect not the pomegranate on Friday, for if thou partakest of it

then thou wilt find what God hath promised thee. And verily the portion of the mineral is itself, for God hath made manifest what was in the power of its secret. And when man taketh it, it glorifieth God its Lord, that there is no God but Him, the Most High, the Most Great.

On the verse "Thus have We made you a middle nation…"

God the Exalted hath said:

> "Thus have We made you a middle nation that ye may be witnesses over mankind and the Messenger may be a witness over you."

[Q2:143]

Verily, God hath ordained in the degrees of action the middle community, which are the six ranks: Will, Destiny, Decree, Permission, Term, and Book. These are the causes of creation and the witnesses unto the people of the cloud of unknowing. And verily the Messenger who beareth witness unto them is the Will itself. These seven are the ranks of the people of God in the world of divine law, corresponding to creation, for those possessed of understanding know not the effulgences of the Divine Essence, the manifestations of the Realm of Might, the conditions of sovereignty, and the emanations of the Kingdom save through what God hath revealed in the essential realities of the human realm. This is an irrevocable decree from One Who is All-Knowing, All-Informed.

Look not upon the world of action and reaction through the vision of isolation and separation, but rather through the eye of divine attributes. For by beholding these, thou shalt lift away veils and doubts, and knowledge thereof shall establish thee upon the carpet of nearness and beauty. How can I allude to the meaning of that verse which calleth out like the Tree upon the Mount and speaketh unto those around it as it spoke upon the Mountain of Manifestation? If God were to remove the covering from thine insight, thou wouldst hear its call from every direction and wouldst say what God hath willed for thee in the call:

> "Glory be unto Thee! I turn unto Thee, and I am the first of believers!"

But as God hath created within my soul the signs of His dominion, I shall indicate some of what God hath intended in that Book. The Lord's testimony concerning thee is thy creation. He hath ever been the Knower, while naught was witnessed or known before Him. God hath ever been witness over all things through the existence of all things, and the proof thereof is His independence and existence. Glorified and exalted is He! There is no "how" to His testimony, and none can know His presence. Until this day, God the Exalted hath not permitted anyone to open that door in the knowledge of His attributes and names.

Since I have no recourse but to taste death, I shall give thee that red elixir: Man cannot be a true believer in divine unity except by negating names and attributes from the countenance of the Divine Essence. The mention of affirmative attributes is identical to the mention of negative attributes, for the knowledge that man establisheth for his Lord is like his ignorance which he negates. There is no altering God's decree.

It is incumbent upon the believer in God to negate the power that he knoweth just as he negates powerlessness. What hath been revealed in the Qur'an and what the people of the Bayan have said concerning His names and attributes is but to enable comprehension. Today I educate all as Ali, peace be

upon him, said in his words that the perfection of divine unity is the negation of attributes from Him. The essence of what is intended is what We have given thee by the pen of ink. Therefore, describe not the Creator of the servants henceforth with the attributes of creation, and judge by what We have caused to shine upon thee from the decree of the heart, for most people know not what is intended and perchance they deny thereby the outpouring of divine assistance.

The mention of the decree We have confirmed for thee is in the interpretation of the verse through the very manifestation of its exposition in it, by it, and through it. When thou desirest exposition in the temple of meanings, then bear witness that Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, was witness over the creation of all things, and verily He is the Witness over all things before their existence, during their existence, and after their existence. Not an atom's weight escapeth His knowledge in the heavens or on earth. He is the Essence of creation and the Reality of invention. Verily He knoweth all things and beareth witness to all things even as thou beholdest thine image in a mirror.

Let not thy inner being magnify God, for the essences of Paradise, the material realities, the divine essences, the celestial realities, the heavenly causes, and the spiritual kingdoms are, in their stations, cut off from Him. The testimony of the Manifestation of the Divine Essence to those immersed in the depths of creation and the vast ocean of invention, by virtue of His transcendent Reality which hath no association with aught else, is identical to Muhammad's testimony, the Apostle of God, peace be upon Him and His family, to the word "Be!" This word, after the removal of the ten portions, is identical to the addressing letter in the words of the Speaker, exalted be His remembrance: "that the Apostle might be a witness over you." Know then what hath shone upon thee from the Sun of the Manifestation of Testimony from thy Great Lord, and be of them that render thanks unto God.

When thou hast tasted what We have taught thee concerning the testimonies of the Divine Essence's attributes and the Pivot of the circle of Names in the Kingdom of heaven and attributes, then be thou assured of the testimony of the middle community, the greatest seat, the supreme proofs, and the most exalted testimony. For they are witnesses to the Essence of existence through the all-encompassing knowledge of the Worshipped One. No mystery in the heavens or earth is hidden from them. Verily their degrees of testimony differ according to the stations of the Bayan. Among these is the station of the Manifestation of the Divine Essence, wherein they were knowers of all things while the known had no existence before them.

Names, attributes, effulgences, manifestations and conditions are severed from their holy precincts, their exalted heights, their supreme majesty and their mighty station, for they were the repositories of knowledge and the pillars of grandeur. This station belongeth even to the poorest of the poor and the most abject of atoms. None knoweth the manner of their testimony to contingent beings before their existence in the realm of possibility save God Who created them and made them witness the creation of the heavens and earth, and made them witnesses over the worlds.

From these testimonies is their witness over existing things through their own selves, as they appeared unto them in the realm of their possibilities and their coming into being. The hearts of all atoms are before them as a particle of red ruby in the palm of one of them. God knoweth their truth and is capable of praising them, while I know not how to describe them save as an ant might know of a manifested

language. Thus do I confess my shortcoming before them. How then can I enumerate the explanation of bearing witness in your testimony over the servants, when hearts circle round the ink yet know naught save their portion of existence? I beseech your grace to forgive my testimonies against myself, which were they to be known by anyone in the heavens or earth besides you, they would weep in mercy for me as long as the heavens and earth endure. O people of mercy, your pardon!

O people of grandeur, your mystery! O people of power, your bounty! O people of wisdom, your grace! For I am less than an atom to claim that I am of the believers. And amongst these stations is this: that they have borne testimony unto mankind through the witness of every soul-possessing entity in accordance with whatsoever it hath earned. And the attestation of differentiation lieth immersed within the depths of conjunction. And in every number less than ten, the ninth doth bear witness—for all created things testify in the presence of the Imam, may peace rest upon Him—unto that which each hath acquired of the Divine Realities, the Essential Substances, the Spiritual Entities, and the Ontological Beings dwelling within the eight Gardens of Paradise; then in terms of the empyrean realms, material manifestations, gradual developments, and essential natures in the seven heavens and what lies beyond them in the spheres of the Divine Throne and Seat; then in terms of the celestial kingdoms, radiant effulgences, resplendent lights, and psychic realities in the layers of the eighth clime which none can encompass save whom God wills; then in terms of earthly conditions, accidental qualities, shadowy forms, and individual identities from the stations of the denizens of fire and what God has ordained in the earths—even to the treachery in an ant's breast, which testifies to its betrayal before the Imam (peace be upon him).

Indeed, he judges it according to what it has earned for itself by its own choice. Its testimony is the very form of its deed, just as silence at the time of silence testifies to your silence, and speech at the time of speech testifies to your speech. And you know, as We have shown you in My acknowledgment of the conditions and manifestations, whatsoever upon which the name of a thing falls, from the depths of the Divine Will to the vast ocean of creation. That moment before God is the Day of Resurrection, and those words testify before the Imam (peace be upon him) by the leave of Him Who revealed them in those tablets. Acknowledge your testimony according to what God's knowledge encompasses, and acknowledge your inability to comprehend His truth, so forgive him through Your grace, for I am among those who bear witness.

Among these are that which causes the martyrs to rejoice at righteous deeds just as those in Paradise rejoice at meeting the All-Merciful, for they are the ones who work through the temples of the people of the Bayan. And among them, the color of the martyrs changes due to evil deeds just as your fair countenance changes in a green mirror. And whoever bears an evil deed weeps until the fires are troubled by his wailing, saying "O God, my Lord, inspire him to repentance, for I am among those who seek forgiveness." By your Lord, O questioner, if the sinners knew the magnitude of sin, they would not approach it, for the change in the countenance of God's Greatest Remnant is worse than all the fires of hell, but people do not understand.

In this the Imam (peace be upon him) testifies to what the angels testify in his presence, and what the angels have not been informed of, he conceals it and does not mention it out of his generosity, as

indicated in his noble words according to what Muhammad ibn Ya'qub al-Kulayni reported in al-Kafi from Ali ibn Ibrahim from his father from Safwan ibn Yahya from Ishaq ibn Ammar from Abu Abdullah (peace be upon him) who said: "When two believers embrace, mercy encompasses them. When they remain thus, seeking nothing but God's face and desiring no worldly purpose, they are told: Your sins are forgiven, so begin anew.' When they turn to conversation, the angels say to one another: 'Move away from them, for they have a secret and God has concealed it for them."' Ishaq said: "May I be your ransom!

Are their words not recorded, though God the Mighty and Glorious has said: 'Not a word does he utter but there is a sentinel ready'?" Then Abu Abdullah (peace be upon him) sighed deeply and wept until his tears wet his beard, then said: "O Abu Ishaq! God the Blessed and Exalted has only commanded the angels to withdraw from believers when they meet out of respect for them. Though the angels neither write their words nor know their speech, He knows it and preserves it concerning them."

O Knower of the secret and of what is yet more hidden! By God, the matter has been decreed that there shall be no differences among the believers. For this reason hath He made them witnesses unto mankind, that Muhammad—the blessings of God rest upon him and his family—may bear witness unto us, and that we may bear witness unto our followers, and that our followers may bear witness unto all mankind. Among these witnesses is he who beareth witness as thou dost when thou desirest to make mention of the Divine Unity, saying "There is no God but Thee." And among these are stations without end unto infinity, wherein the glance of him who gazeth upon the inmost hearts perceiveth that which no ink can contain. And at that station have I sealed the mention of witnesses with the water of ink.

When thou hast understood the law of witness-bearing among the Imams, know it through its manifestation in the pure ones among their followers, even as the Imam—peace be upon him—hath indicated in his words: "Verily the stations of witness-bearing among the followers are diverse according to their stations. Among these is that they gaze upon the inmost hearts of created things and bear witness concerning what they say and do, that they have followed him whom God hath made His proof unto them. Thus do they bear witness to their faith, else would God judge them worthy of the fires, and He is not unjust to His servants. And among these is that when they hear from their innermost beings a word of what God hath ordained for them, they bear witness with pure faith; else do they beseech God for their guidance, for verily He is the Ever-Forgiving, the All-Merciful.

All that We have caused to flow forth is along the path of the outward. And if thou desirest to hear the melodies of the Bird of the Divine Cloud, and the qualities of the Peacock of Destiny, and the humming of the Bees of Accomplishment, then cast away what is in thy right hand and what God hath created in all the left hands, and ascend with thy spirit to the sacred court of the inmost heart. There establish thyself upon the throne of the manifestation of the Lord of all beings, and take what is thy due from the ink of assistance.

Know thou that the witness in the station of the efficient cause of existence is the witness in the station of the final cause through the existing remembrance, by virtue of what God hath caused to be revealed unto him in his station and rank. And even as God hath made the air a witness unto water, He hath made the earth a witness unto what He hath placed above it, for the station of that which is revealed appeareth

only through the station of revelation, and verily the essence of revelation appeareth only through the essential nature of what is revealed.

When thou hast recognized this through the dawning of the Sun of Power in the dark and predestined well of hell, then know the reality of the witness from the witnessed, and the existent from the non-existent. Divulge not the secret of the Family of God to one who is not praiseworthy in the station of the witnessed. For verily the kingdom, though bare and rough—when thou gazest upon it with the glance of the Beginning—may the All-Merciful cause thee to attain unto the station of its knowledge. Otherwise, fear God and preserve it in the midst of the pomegranates of the Divine Realm, and the apples of the Empyrean, and the gardens of Dominion and Kingdom, and the ears of corn of the human realm.

For whosoever hath pointed unto him, and hath spoken concerning him, hath verily followed that which the Samirí cast amongst the people; and he, of a truth, is of the wrong-doers. And on this Day I, even I, am a Witness, with the eye of Truth, unto him who hath entered the pure Religion through faith. And those whom I know by their names, and unto whom leave hath been granted to make mention of the Book of Justice, they are witnesses unto the people. It is incumbent upon all to acknowledge the right of their testimony, and to dissociate themselves from their enemies. For the summit of faith, the nobility of man, and the standard of utterance is this: that the servant should account himself among those whom God hath caused to bear witness unto such as are beneath his rank. And this is attained through the servant's hope in his Lord, his contemplation of His wondrous beginnings, his fear of His chastisement, and his longing to attain His presence.

How can I describe to thee the path of one who warbles in His primal grasp within the thicket of the Divine, while the detached one is imprisoned in the abode of patience? By thy Lord! Within my breast there lies a vast knowledge which, were I to impart it to thee, would be sweeter to thy heart than drinking the wine of Paradise from the fountain of Salsabil. Let not the illusion of ego enter thy mind, questioning how one whom God has caused to witness the creation of a thing can attain such a station in this world. For this matter, from the Most Exalted Perspective and the Supreme Horizon, is indeed thus. Read the tradition wherein al-Sadiq said to him who sought to test him: "Eat the dates, for therein lies the secret of the matter." If thou followest God's decree in this thy world, it hath been ordained in God's knowledge that thou art among the witnesses.

But if thou disobeyest, God knoweth that thou art not among those whom He hath caused to witness the creation of what is beneath their station. The knowledge of these stations is among the requisites of the proofs and the complexities of the signs. None hath understood the mystery of this station save he who hath recognized the position of justice between the two positions. Know thou the truth of what We have given thee to drink from the brackish water, for from water all things live—will ye not understand? When thou art perplexed by the perplexing recognition of the witnesses, then take shelter in the shade of the dark clouds of Paradise, and know the truth of the middle way in the banner of Paradise's paths. Be thou assured that the center of a thing is the station unto which all its manifestations and conditions return.

This is what is meant by the Pole according to the mathematicians among the people of truth. The knowledge of technical terms used by the people of outward learning is not in itself the ultimate goal for all, but since the knowledge of such terms is a prelude for some people to attain the station of

understanding the Qur'an and traditions, the learned ones have permitted it for some men. However, for one whom God has brought to the station of certitude and who understands the meanings of the verses of the Qur'an, there is no portion or benefit in learning these terms. For the purpose of logic is to preserve the tongue from error in speech, but he whose breast God has expanded with exposition and opened the gate of the celestial realm to his nature has no need for the science of logic.

It is incumbent upon one who seeks the pure essence of that knowledge to weigh the judgment of the minor and major premises with the balance of divine utterance and derive the conclusion from the measure of My verses. But most people, since they think ill of God's power, neither know the matter nor reflect upon it. All that We have taught thee regarding the paths of limitations pertains to those who are capable, for beyond the realm of the heart, allusions cannot be separated, since the Pole of the contingent world is too exalted in station to be witnesses who are associated with and testify to the circles of finitude and infinity.

Indeed, the Family of God are too exalted in station to be witnesses over the people, and God intended none other than them in that verse, as the Imam, peace be upon him, indicated regarding the station of limitation in His mighty Word:

> "Dost thou think that God meant by this verse all the people of the Qiblih from among the monotheists? How can it be that one whose testimony regarding a measure of dates is not acceptable in this world, God would seek his testimony?"

Nay, God did not intend such a thing from His creation—meaning the people to whom Abraham's call was incumbent. "Ye are the best nation raised up for mankind"—they are the middle nation, and they are the best nation raised up for mankind. And verily in that regard I shall mention to thee those traditions shining from the heaven of the suns of power, that thou mayest explain to the people what the Imam permitted them. And forget not the grace of the Imam, peace be upon him, in his saying that Salman was one who received divine inspiration, though the difference is that his utterance was but a sign and shadow compared to the utterance of the Imam, peace be upon him.

Ali, exalted be his remembrance, said concerning the meaning of that verse: "By His words that ye may be witnesses over mankind'—the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, is a witness over us, and we are God's witnesses over His creation and His proof in His earth, and we are those of whom God said Thus have We made you a middle nation."' And the Baqir, peace be upon him, said: "We are the middle way." It was asked: "What is the middle way?" "The middle of ways.

Indeed God saith 'Thus have We made you a middle nation."' He said: "To us returns the one who exceeds bounds and catches up the one who falls short." And from him, may my spirit be his sacrifice: "We are the middle nation, and we are God's witnesses over His creation and His proofs in His earth and His heaven." And verily what We have caused to shine forth from the temples of those traditions is the station of the chosen ones, that they may behold the countenance of mysteries in the dawning-places of lights. And the references to the interpretations of the learned ones befit not the wisdom of that Book, for the author of the Safi interpreted the testimony of the Family of God in that verse as being on the Day of Resurrection.

And that is mere shell to one who has found the sweetness of the kernel, for they were God's witnesses over all in creation and invention, and all days with them are the Day of Resurrection. They judge by God's leave between all that God's knowledge encompasses. Rather, the Day of Resurrection with them is created like the creation of all things—they bear witness to it as they bear witness to other things. And they are the people of grandeur and sovereignty and might and power and majesty and wisdom and will and purpose. They see things before their existence just as they see a speck of dust after its existence before them. And they judge everything before its existence just as after its existence. Veils conceal them not, nor can all scriptures equal their mention, for they were above the perception of essences in that which none among contingent beings can encompass in knowledge. And whoever said regarding the station of the Bayan concerning their right that their testimony over mankind is mentioned, hath indeed associated partners with them in God's knowledge, and if he seek not forgiveness of God his Lord, he shall be among the wrongdoers.

On the verse "We appointed the qiblih to which thou wast used…"

God the Exalted said:

> "We appointed the qiblih to which thou wast used, only that We might know him who followeth the Messenger from him who turneth on his heels. In truth it was a hard test, save to those whom God guided. But God would never make your faith of no effect. For God is to mankind full of kindness, most merciful."

[Q2:143]

And verily We have caused to shine forth in the manifestations of the light of glory that God hath created every letter of the Qur'an like the creation of the greater world, wherein is reckoned all that His knowledge encompasses.

And among the things which God hath decreed by confirmation, and which He hath caused to come to pass through bada', is that whereunto I now allude in the obscurities of these intimations, that it may draw thee unto the sacred court of the Throne of the Names and Attributes. It is this: that for the letter waw, the first letter of that verse, there should be appointed a direction abstracted from the six directions. This was the direction of its simplicity, and the letter of its identity—a reality which its people designate by the holy Names, the manifest Appearances, the true Theophanies, and the paradisal Verses, all of which are mentioned beneath its shadow and bounded within its domain—inasmuch as the beholder, turning toward the extremity of the inmost heart, perceiveth all upon which the name of origination hath fallen in the degree of the manifestation of those letters.

Should one utter "He is God," it betokeneth naught but His creation and relateth to naught save His invention. And should one utter "Muhammad is the Apostle of God"—peace be upon him and his family—it is the letter of the station of meanings in its place, whereby is known whatsoever hath been attributed from God unto Him of His essence, His self, His spirit, His being, His identity, and His might, and that which none knoweth save God. Were the people of truth to lift the veil from His countenance, and were the Essence of God and His Self to be ascribed unto Him as the Kaaba is called the House of God,

and likewise the Hand of God, the Face of God, the Command of God, and His Knowledge, then would be witnessed therein with certitude, even as is witnessed in the essence of the Apostle, the attribution of these holy names without similitude or metaphor, as the very truth of certainty.

Yet fear thou God, lest thou raise anything above the station God hath ordained for it, nor incarnate the signs of divinity in humanity, for such was the deed of the Christians in deriving the form of the cross from the figure of the triangle. When thou art illumined by the gleaming rays of the Sun of Utterance in the first sphere, manifest from pre-existence—not the pre-existence that is manifest through pre-existence—and when thou art enlightened by the effulgences that have shone forth from the light of the Morn of the pre-existence of meanings in the second sphere, then know thou the Command of God in the station of the Vav in the five stations: the Vav of the Gates, of the Imams, of the Pillars, of the Deputy, and of the Beloved, even as We have taught thee concerning the manifestation of the meaning of the surging ocean of Oneness after Unity.

And shouldst thou taste what I have tasted of the knowledge of these subtle stations, thou wouldst know the decree of the Vav in these stations, and wouldst not be confused in deriving the conclusion after the two primary premises, and wouldst know the Command of God in the letters as the manifestation of the Manifest One from His manifestation in the kingdom of the divine cloud and names. And verily this is the decree of the direction of the Tree which warbleth what it warbled in the mysteries of the letters of creation and invention.

Likewise thou knowest concerning the direction of duality, which is expressed as duality, the reflections of the stations save that unto which no name can be given, nor designation in creation—the letter of light which hath no shadow from the determined stations of quantity, quality, limitation and place, unto that which the knowledge of the All-Merciful—glorified be He—encompasseth. There is no God but He, the Mighty, the Bestower. And verily what We have taught thee concerning the meaning of the verse is in the way of the outward, and if thou desirest the path of the inward, then know from the mention of the Qiblih the green pillar of the Throne, which is the Guardianship wherein the believers were certain concerning the Family of God, the Imams of the Faith.

And from the decree that it is indeed great is the red pillar of the Throne, that it might be made manifest whosoever followeth the Messenger within the Sacred House, and whosoever turneth aside from His decree and adhereth to the Qiblih of old. And for this reason hath God attributed guidance unto the people through mention of the Name of His Own Self, and hath promised that He will not cause the faith of any soul to be lost after they follow God's Cause in the Crimson Pillar, for when the Command descendeth to the station of Divine Decree, His judgment is executed, and that which is subject to change through God's command—glorified be He—is a fixed destiny from the presence of the Mighty, the Wise.

And what We have taught thee now concerning this path is a mystery from the depths of Unity, and a light from the vast ocean of Oneness, and a talisman from the talismans of the Divine Spirit, and a symbol from the prescriptions of the Form of Emanation. Know thou its truth and conceal it except from its people, for verily all shall be gathered unto God. And if thou desirest the outward path in unity, make all letters into the letter Ha, and make the Ha praise for Him Who speaketh in the verses of splendor through the decree of change before the Divine Decree and after its execution.

And say to whomsoever He willeth, as He willeth, through what He willeth from among the people of creation, that which God hath sent down in those darknesses—the deafening, the pitch-black, the blind, the burning, the hellish, the gloomy, the dust-covered—unto each according to his station of recognition of God's Command, and his concealment of God's mystery, and his holding fast to God's cord, and his reliance upon God. But fear thou God in this path, for verily it is most bare and pure yet rough, difficult, and smooth, wherein are wild beasts of the land to its left and wonders of the sea to its right, and none shall be saved except he who turneth not to contingent things and seeth the Countenance beneath the Ha in every extinction through the glance of the Manifested One and the appearance of the manifestation.

And when he becometh steadfast in that station, verily he is among the humble ones. And if thou desirest the meaning according to the outward way, there is no path to it except through the tongue of the people, and it is that which the Imam—peace be upon him—mentioned in his saying, where he said—exalted be his remembrance—in the station of Revelation, meaning:

> "Verily We know that from his bounty after We knew it would come to pass."

He said: And that is because the desire of the people of Mecca was in the Ka'bah, so God desired to distinguish the follower of Muhammad—peace be upon him—from who opposed him through following the Qiblih which they disliked while Muhammad commanded it. And when the desire of the people of Medina was in the House of Jerusalem, He commanded them to oppose it and turn toward the Ka'bah so it would become clear who agreed with Muhammad in what he disliked, for he was his confirmer and follower. And though the prayer toward the House of Jerusalem at that time was indeed difficult except for those whom God guided and who knew that God is worshipped through that which opposeth what man desireth, that his obedience may be tested through opposing his desires. And God would not cause your faith to be lost, meaning your prayers.

Verily God is Kind and Merciful unto mankind. And all that We have caused to flow forth from the appearance of the ocean of Divine Will, and the affairs of the vast sea of Purpose, and the awe of the mystery of the ocean of Destiny, and the change of the river of Decree, and the execution of the First Sea, and the term of the African Spring, and the book of the Countenance of the Essential Nature of Glory in the garments of radiance—it is but a letter from the interpretation of the outward of the inward, and a yellow veil from the veils of the Maiden whom God hath created for the manifestation of those conditions in her shadow. He who knoweth her not recognizeth her without her countenance, and he who knoweth her remaineth ignorant of her in the garments of her countenance.

And if thou hast attained unto that which We have intimated unto thee, illumined thee withal, confirmed thee therein, and enkindled within thee, then hast thou indeed witnessed the stations of separation, and recognized the dwelling-places of union. Thou hast plunged into the depths of separation and withdrawn from the most equitable station in fear, and thou didst say:

> "What God willeth, there is no power but in God! This is naught but a noble sovereign!"

And if thou desirest to witness the essence of that verse in the station of the ocean of His unity and the deep waters of His detachment, then hearken unto the decrees of the Divine Realm from this Bird soaring

in the atmosphere of the cloud of unknowing, and the decrees of the Realm of Might from this Peacock upon Mount Paran, and the decrees of dominion from this Bird warbling in the heaven of the names of creation, and the decrees of the Kingdom from this Cock that crieth out from the horizon of the Throne, saying:

> "The first is the white pillar for the manifestation of the unity of the Divine Essence; and the second is the yellow pillar for the dawning of the unity of the Sun of Attributes; and the third is the green pillar for the manifestation of the unity of deeds; and the fourth is the red pillar for establishing the unity of worship before the countenance of the Divine Essence. He revealeth not unto the one receiving revelation save through that whereby He hath revealed Himself unto him."

Raise up the letters of the alphabet from that verse unto the station of the manifestation of its benefits, that thou mayest witness in every letter that which We caused thee to hear from the warbling of the Nightingale of praise upon the mount of destiny, and that which We showed thee of the manifestations of the peacocks and their melodies in the wisdom of origination. And verily this is the spirit of the elixir of knowledge whereby the servant ascendeth from all that is still unto the station of motion, and manifesteth the causes of his existence in the degree of the effect, and the fruit of the final cause in the degree of the object and its realm.

This is the saying of Rida—peace be upon him—that "the possessors of understanding know not what is there save through what is here." Until this day none hath opened the door of that knowledge whereby the letters are raised unto the station of His detachment and brought unto the mystery of His unity. Know thou then the truth of these days and render thanks unto God, thy Lord, for never hath the sun risen with the like thereof.

And if thou desirest to become aware of the mystery of the verse even as I have understood it, then extend the compass of thy knowledge and make the qiblih whereto thou wert turned the very manifestation of the letter Kaf in the Divine Will. It descendeth by God's leave and becometh in heaven for the white pillar the Much-frequented House; then on earth for the yellow pillar; then for the green pillar the Kaaba, the Sacred House of God; then for the red pillar on the day which God hath willed, the tomb of Husayn—peace be upon him. And all this is the sanctuary of Muhammad—peace be upon him—until the Day of Resurrection, which changeth not throughout the ages of ages and the eternity of manifestation.

Therefore did Muhammad, the Messenger of God—peace be upon him—after he was sent forth by God's command, pray toward the Holy House for thirteen years in Mecca for the signs of divine authority in the countenance of prophethood, and for seven months in Medina for the manifestation of trials within trials. And verily this correspondeth to the supernal realm, letter by letter.

And thou knowest the command of God from the beginning of the existence of the atom unto the end of the first Divine Will in the word "Be," unto the final degrees thereof in attaining unto the pearl—the complete manifestation of the word "Be"—save that which hath no end in it, from it, through it, unto it, even as We caused thee to hear the melodies of the hosts of the Sovereign Bees of the Divine Realm, and

the songs of the birds of the cloud of unknowing in the thickets of the Realm of Might, and the melodies of the Peacock of Paradise, and the conditions of the Ocean of Paradise, and the manifestations of the Holy Forms, and the attributes of the Cock of the Throne in the thicket of dominion and the Kingdom.

And verily this is a revelation from among the revelations of the light of creation, encompassing by His knowledge whomsoever He willeth among the servants of the All-Merciful. Verily, He is the Ancient Bestower of Bounty, Who knoweth what His servants desire in His path. Glorified and exalted be He above all that they may describe….

BB00037: Risala fi Tashkhis al-Ghina (on singing)

Part 1: "Praise be to God Who, through the sanctity…"

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who, through the sanctity of His Self-Subsistence, transcends the description of essences and their like. And praise be to God Who, through the uniqueness of His eternity, stands alone beyond the attributes of beings and their equivalents. And praise be to God Who, through the grandeur of His holiness, is exalted above the mention of entities and their correlates. Exalted be His station above my saying "He is He," for He is as He is in the might of His Identity and the majesty of His Oneness. Through His Essence, He severs all created things from mentioning knowledge of the Essence in the dawning of the manifestation of the Presence of the Essence, and disperses all contingent beings from mention of the stations of attributes in the depths of the mysteries of the sphere of names and attributes.

Whosoever says "He is He" limits himself and transgresses beyond the mystery of his origin, associating with His Essence the effects of his own self, and establishes, by God's leave, a likeness for Him Who has no likeness in the rank of creation in His Entity. And if I say that the Essence in itself severs all indications and is beyond the jurisdiction of names and attributes, my very mention of the Essence belies me, for by attributing description to Him and naming Him, and by asserting that the existence of creation is His transcendence, I have claimed mention from the court of His nearness and established in myself an example of His sign of eternality and a manifestation of His holy appearance.

So glorified and exalted, supreme and lofty is His Essence that none can ascend to Him on the highest wings of hearts and imagination. His Identity is too great for anyone to indicate Him in the kingdom of Command and the manifestation of abstractions through the most subtle possible allusions. Whoever claims [to know His unity has in that moment made himself a partner before the holy valley of His oneness, and whoever claims knowledge of His Entity has indeed been ignorant and has strayed from] knowledge of his own self and transgressed beyond the station of his limits, seeking the decree of impossibility in his mind while heedless of the station of the mystery of eternity in His Essence. For created things, as they are in their reality, indicate only severance, speak only of prevention, utter only despair, and point only to powerlessness. So glory be to God, their Creator, Lord of the heavens and earth, above the description of all things.

And praise be to God Who has testified to Himself by Himself that there is no god but He, the Ever-Living, the Self-Subsisting, in the eternity of eternities, and He exists as He has always been, without change or alteration. Whoever says “He is He” has taken for himself a likeness in his own self and joined himself with His Essence, for He, as He is in the innermost Essence and manifestation of Eternality, is too exalted to be known through His creation, or described by His servants, or indicated by anything other than His Essence, or for any of His servants’ highest imagination to attain to the heaven of His glorious mercy. For He has ever been, and there was none besides Him, and He will ever be, and there will be none except Him.

For His Essence, as it is, is the pure, ancient Essence which in its Entity severs all essences from indications and prevents all material things from signification. And His Identity, as it is, is the pure, eternal Identity which in its Entity disperses all entities from mention of stations and severs all beings from mention of signs. And whatever thing upon which falls a name from among names and attributes falls only upon the stations of Command and the manifestations of creation.

The sheer Divine Essence, beyond time, has no equal among all the stations of the unseen and the visible realms, nor can any attribute of His creation match Him. All that those who describe Him describe, and all that those who remember Him remember, falls within the boundaries of thingness and the geometry of creation. Far exalted is the very Essence of the Necessary Being, glorified be His mention, above all that is mentioned in His dominion and exists through His creation. All things point to their own selves and are questioned about their own essential reality. Analogies cannot express the essential realities of contingent beings except in negation, and geometry cannot indicate the essence of abstract realities except through exclusion. Whoever defines Him has paired Him, and whoever pairs Him has nullified His timelessness. Whoever turns to Him through what He has described of Himself, and warns people of His judgment, has unified Him as far as is possible within the realm of contingency, and beyond this is not possible in the station of creation. Therefore God, through His grace, accepts from His servants their stations of unity, for He is the Mighty, the Bestower.

Praise be to God Who brought the Primal Will into being before the creation of all things through His own Causation, not from anything else. Then through it He created Will, Destiny, Decree, Permission, Term, and the Book, that all the atoms of multiplicity might know what God has ordained for them in the stations of creation and the manifestations of Command, until nothing living, self-subsisting, and existing by itself is seen therein except what God has revealed to it in its essential reality, which is a sign for knowing the Essence and a path to the revelation of the attributes. It is a sign for knowing the station of Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, that he is exalted above similitude, sanctified above likeness, transcendent above limitation, and holy beyond individuation.

Far exalted is the very being of Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, above anyone being able to know him or point to him or say how and why, for his self-subsisting essence, which is his very identity, severs essential realities from the station of knowledge and prevents material things from forms of expression. All that appears in the worlds and emerges in contingency are reflections of the descent of that Light which is exalted above the mention of light and sanctified above the light of manifestation.

Whoever says that he is the First Rememberer in contingency has turned to the station of his own self and known the limit of his origin, and has become absent from manifestation in the presence of concealment. And whoever says that he is the First Light and the Primal Will has paired with Him the station of his knowledge and transgressed beyond the limit of his origin through his affirmation, and has lost the station of the Truth that was manifest to him in his contingent rank. Exalted is God, the Ever-Living, the Self-Subsisting, the Eternal, the Single, the Impenetrable, Who has ever been without mention of aught else beside Him and will ever be without mention of aught else with Him. He has made His beloved Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, the station of His Self in that station, that all might unify the presence of His holiness as He has unified His Essence with His Essence, and known His Self through His Self, and his reality might merit His Reality in that he is the Meaning whose essence is separation from all things and whose attribute is the severance of beings from the court of nearness. Glory be to God above what they describe!

Praise be to God Who bore witness to His Essence through His Essence in the station of creation, when He knew that Husayn, peace be upon him, would bear witness to himself through himself and would be content with what God had destined for him in His knowledge and would submit himself wholly to God in what He had decreed for him in His Book, and act according to what God has written for him in His knowledge regarding the manifestations of His Cause. This indeed is a remembrance from God concerning his station, that through him the friends may be guided to the station of nearness and glory, and that they may recognize the unity of God through what He has revealed to them through His manifestations in the realities of all created things. They find repose in remembering his tribulations upon the carpet of nearness and beauty, and they visit God by visiting his earthly remains, for verily this is the visitation of the All-Merciful above His throne, without similitude or likeness.

Glorified be God, his Creator, Who has established him in the station of His own Self in perpetuity and decree, and has chosen him for His mystery in the worlds of creation, and has selected him for the manifestation of His authority in the kingdom of command and creation for praise, and has fashioned him for the revelation of His grandeur in the ranks of attributes and names, lest anyone forget the wisdom of His manifestation in the realities of souls and horizons. Every thing beholds him through the light of its Creator at every moment, and all eyes weep for him because of what befell him of the calamities of time—which, when descended upon the Throne, it trembled; when raised to heaven, it was rent asunder; when settled upon earth, it was cleft; when recited to hearts, they fell prostrate before the majesty of his countenance; and when souls remembered them, they were transformed, being unable to bear even a letter of their mystery.

Glorified be God his Creator! No one has endured what Husayn, peace be upon him, endured in God's path. Through his martyrdom, the essences of verses in the kingdom of names and attributes were slain, and thus all things were bounded in all the stations of creation, such that nothing can be mentioned except through the geometry of limitation. Had he not accepted, in the first particle, the martyrdom of his soul in God's path, the thought of approaching the Tree of Eternity would never have occurred to the First Adam, and he would never have known his Lord, nor would anything have existed in the heavens and earth. For through his martyrdom in God's path, the realities of hearts came into being for divine unity, and the winds of love stirred the leaves [of the branches of the Tree of Unity with melodies that

have never occurred to the heart of any servant, nor can flow from the pen of ink, nor can anyone know its nature except those from whom God has taken the Covenant in the worlds of the unseen and the visible.

May God grant me and all who wish to remember the tribulations of Husayn, peace be upon him, at all times, as long as the heavens and earths endure, for this is God's grace which He bestows upon whom He wishes, He the Possessor of great bounty.]

And this lowly servant, destitute before God and clinging to the cord of God, peace be upon them, makes mention that while journeying toward the King of grace and justice—may God perpetuate His shadow over all who dwell beneath the dark clouds of His mercy—having paused in the land of Isfahan, the most esteemed and holy addressee, he who makes mention of the Point of existence and calls to mind the manifestations of the Praised Verse, the Sultan of those who remember—may God perpetuate his remembrance in His path and bring him to the station of nearness to His Self in the Holy Presence through His grace—inquired about the ruling concerning singing which is mentioned in the traditions of the Suns of grandeur and majesty.

Therefore, arising to answer his eminence, and through God's might and power, whatsoever flows from the pen through the Will of His Divine Presence, exalted be His mention, shall be expressed. And before mentioning the ruling, certain allusions shall be set forth that may serve to lift the veils from the reality of this matter. And it is this: that God, the All-Knowing, has created nothing except through His Will and the manifestations of His attribute of action, which are the conditions of the appearance of the Will, even as the blessed Sadiq—peace be upon him—has said:

> "Nothing exists in earth or heaven save through these seven characteristics: through Will, Purpose, Decree, Destiny, Permission, Book, and Term. Whosoever claims he can nullify even one of these has indeed denied the truth."

There is no doubt that, at the time of existence, God—exalted be He—did not compel any thing in the direction of receptivity; nay rather, He brought into being the First Mention, which is the station of the Absolute Emanation, from nothing, by itself, for itself. He made the very cause of receptive choice to be its own self; and apart from the aspect of choice—which is the aspect of the manifestation of the command of God—He ordained no other determining aspect in the rank of the first creation. Though in truth the discussion of this question among the philosophers hath yielded divergent judgments—as is evident in the Treatise on the Interpretation of the Ha' and in other epistles, wherein proofs have been advanced to invalidate the claims of some among them—yet since this station is not the place for a full exposition of that matter, but only for the mention of a prelude to what is intended, we refrain from setting forth its arguments.

After the establishment of the grades of action, there remaineth no doubt that nothing existeth apart from God save through two aspects: an existential aspect, which pointeth to the manifestation of the One Who is revealed; and an essential aspect, which indicateth the modes of servitude and the receptivity of that manifestation. When these two aspects are affirmed, the rank of Qadar—the station of linkage between the two aspects—becometh manifest; and after the appearance of the three, the ordinance of

the four is established, for the descent of the three is impossible save through the manifestation of the four.

For this reason there is the causality of the sevenfold grades of action—this number being the most complete and perfect of numbers, beyond which increase is impossible in simplicity of station and greatness of rank. And for this reason also appeared the sacred Temples of the People of Infallibility—may the blessings of God rest upon them—who, in the station of the unseen, are these seven, and in the realm of testimony are their manifest expression.

After it is established that in every thing there are two aspects, there is no doubt that whatever is designated by the name "thing" doth not, in the station of exposition, lie outside three grades of existence: either it is a sign of the manifestation of the pure, sanctified Essence of the All-Glorious—exalted be His remembrance—whose very Being is free from aught beside Himself; or it is a sign of the manifestation of His act, whose stations—hidden and manifest—are the seven grades, which are the appearance of the fourteen supports and the stations of possibility; or it is the station of the effect of the act, which is the existence of what is other than the act.

These two latter ranks, in truth, lie within the realm of creation, even as the Imam—peace be upon him—hath declared: "Truth and creation—there is no third between them, nor any third beside them." And in this rank of the divine Dawning-Places, within the station of manifestation, by reason of the causality of the seven grades of action, seven stations are enumerated—just as ʿAlí ibn al-Husayn—peace be upon them both—declared in the station of knowledge of the Cause unto Jabir, when he mentioned it in a lengthy tradition and then recited the words of the Most High: "This day shall We forget them, as they forgot the meeting of this Day of theirs, and because they denied Our signs." And he said: "These—by God—are Our signs, and this is one of them; and this—by God—is our guardianship, O Jabir!" until he said: "O Jabir!

Knowest thou what knowledge is? Knowledge is the affirmation of oneness, first; then the knowledge of meanings, second; then the knowledge of the gates, third; then the knowledge of the Imam, fourth; then the knowledge of the pillars, fifth; then the knowledge of the deputies, sixth; and the knowledge of the elect, seventh." And this is His saying, exalted be He: "Say: If the sea were ink for the words of my Lord, the sea would be exhausted ere the words of my Lord were exhausted, even though We brought the like thereof as further aid." And again He recited: "And if all the trees on earth were pens, and the sea—with seven seas after it to replenish it—were ink, the words of God would not be exhausted. Verily God is Mighty, Wise." This is the tradition.

Part 2: "After these effects are beheld, it becometh evident…"

After these effects are beheld, it becometh evident that the "thing," in the station of spiritual wayfaring, doth not pass beyond three grades—just as the Sadiq—peace be upon him—hath explained in the interpretation of the noble verse: "Among them is he who wrongs his own soul; among them is he who taketh a middle course; and among them is he who outstrippeth others in good deeds." He said: "The wrongdoer is he who moveth about his own self; the moderate is he who moveth about his own reason;

and he who outstrippeth in good deeds is he who moveth about his Lord in the sphere of the act itself." And this last rank, in very truth, pertaineth solely to the locus of the act—and to none other.

And after the attainment of knowledge of these three stations, it becometh evident that the actions of man lie not outside two ranks: either they move about the first determination of his own existence—which is the station of reason—or they revolve around his own quiddity. If the former be the case, it is praiseworthy; and this direction itself is not beyond three grades: the obligatory, the traditional, or the permissible. But if he move about the direction of his own quiddity, it is sheer transgression and association; and this rank likewise is not beyond two grades: the forbidden or the reprehensible. Man, in truth, is he who in none of the stations of his manifestations moveth save about reason, which is the locus of the manifestation of the heart; and Satan, in truth, is he whose movement is about his own quiddity.

That which appeareth from the servant, in all conditions, is never devoid of one of these two directions: if it proceed from the rank of Lordship cast into his identity, it is obedience and the good pleasure of the Lord—exalted be His remembrance; and if it proceed from the rank of his quiddity, it is disobedience and the wrath of the Most Holy Presence—exalted be His remembrance. By this criterion are the deeds of the people of the Highest Heights and of the Lowest Depths distinguished. Though outwardly all actions may appear alike and similar, yet with God the criterion of acceptance and rejection is that which hath been set forth.

And since created beings, in their descent from the Origin of Manifestation, have forgotten the aspect of Lordship, the Bearers of the Universal Guardianship of the Lord of Glory have recalled it to their remembrance, and have expounded the ordinances of all things, that they might be shaken by the trembling of the aspects of the Origin of all essences among contingent beings, and might be made to shine through nearness unto the stations of the manifestation of the Origin of all identities among existent things. From this it followeth that the aspect of Lordship within the servant is more manifest than all other stations and nearer than all other manifestations.

Even as Sadiq—peace be upon him—hath intimated in the Misbah, saying: "Servitude is a substance whose essence is Lordship. What is hidden in Lordship is attained in servitude, and what is lost in servitude is found in Lordship." And God, exalted be He, hath said: "We shall show them Our signs in the horizons and within themselves, until it be made clear unto them that it is the Truth."—O existent in thy absence and in thy presence!

No servant attaineth unto the perfection of servitude save through the manifestation of this aspect. Thus hath it been alluded to in the holy tradition: "My servant ceaseth not to draw near unto Me through works of supererogation until I love him; and when I love him, I become the ear whereby he heareth, the eye whereby he seeth, and the hand whereby he graspeth. If he calleth upon Me, I answer him; if he asketh of Me, I give unto him; and if he remain silent before Me, I take the initiative with him." After the attainment of this station, innumerable stations are ordained for man—beyond all limit. Thus did the Commander of the Faithful—peace be upon him—utter in the supplication of the Day of Sha'ban: "O my God! Grant me complete severance unto Thee; illumine the eyes of our hearts with the light of their gaze toward Thee, until the eyes of the hearts pierce the veils of light and attain unto the Fountain of

Grandeur, and our souls become suspended from the glory of Thy holiness. O my God! Make me of those whom Thou hast called and who answered Thee, whom Thou hast observed and who were struck senseless by Thy majesty, with whom Thou didst commune in secret and who labored for Thee openly."

And Sadiq—peace be upon him—speaking in the station of elucidating all the manifestations of the aspect of Lordship, hath declared in his discourse, alluding thereto in these words:

"When knowledge is established in the breast, fear ariseth; and when fear is sound, one fleeth; and when one fleeth, one is delivered. When the light of certitude shineth in the heart, one beholdeth bounty; and when one is enabled to behold bounty, one hopeth; and when one tasteth the sweetness of hope, one seeketh; and when one is granted success in seeking, one findeth. When the radiance of true knowledge is unveiled within the inmost heart, the breeze of love is stirred; and when the breeze of love is stirred, one findeth intimacy beneath the shadow of the Beloved, preferreth the Beloved above all else, acteth according to His commands and shunneth His prohibitions, and chooseth these two above all things besides them. And when one standeth firm upon the carpet of intimacy with the Beloved, while fulfilling His commands and avoiding His prohibitions, one attaineth unto the spirit of supplication and nearness. The likeness of these three principles is as the Sanctuary, the Mosque, and the Ka'bah: whoso entereth the Sanctuary is secure from men; whoso entereth the Mosque hath his limbs protected from being employed in disobedience; and whoso entereth the Ka'bah hath his heart safeguarded from occupying itself with aught save the remembrance of God." This is the tradition.

And when the servant attaineth unto the station of the spirit of supplication—which is the greatest of stations—he is accounted successful in the loftiest degrees. Even as the Commander of the Faithful—peace and blessings be upon him—hath said:

God created man possessed of a rational soul; when he refine it through knowledge and action, he resembleth the essences of the first causes. When its temperament is harmonized and it is freed from contraries, it comprehendeth and thereby partaketh with the seven firm heavens.

At that time it is fitting that the ordinance of another saying of the Commander of the Faithful—peace be upon him—be applied unto such a one; whereupon, in reply to a Jew who asked, "What meanest thou by philosophy?" he said:

Is it not the moderation of one's nature and the purification of one's temperament? And when the temperament is purified, the influence of the soul therein groweth strong; and when the influence of the soul is strengthened, one ascendeth unto that unto which one may ascend. And when one ascendeth unto that station, one acquireth the moral qualities of the soul, and thus becometh existent as man—no longer existent as beast. Thereupon he entereth the formal, kingly gate; and from this divine care there is no escape.

Whosoever attaineth unto this station—which is the utmost effusion within the realm of possibility—speaketh not, in the station of the manifestation of Lordship cast into his identity, save in the manner of the words of Truth, exalted be His remembrance; nor, in the station of servitude, save with the tongue of the supplications of the People of the House of Infallibility—may the blessings of God be upon them—

after such a fashion that no one is able to distinguish between the outward forms that resemble one another.

Thus hath it appeared from one who was confirmed, in whom, at the station of the Balance, within the span of six hours, a thousand verses of supplication flowed from his pen; and who, in the station of manifesting words of authority, composed without deliberation or pause of the pen, in such wise that none before him had surpassed him in this distinction among the commonalty. Yet it should not occur to the mind of the beholder that these supplications are the very supplications of the People of the House of Infallibility, or that these authoritative words are the verses of the Book of God; for the existence of the author of these words, in relation to even a single letter of the Book of God and the traditions of the Family of God—peace be upon them—is as naught. Rather, his likeness is as an image reflected in a well-balanced mirror, recounting the manifestation of the One revealed within the mirror.

For this reason, none among the possessors of understanding, when abstracting their gaze from the limits of mirrorhood, are able to distinguish these supplicatory pages that flowed from the pen from the supplications that issued among mankind from the Suns of Grandeur and Majesty—may the blessings of God be upon them.

After these allusions—necessary in this place for the exposition of the matter—there can be no doubt that God hath set forth the ordinances of all things in the Qur'an; even as, concerning the state of heedless self-indulgence arising from the quiddity cast into the soul of the servant, He hath revealed:

> "And among men is he who purchaseth idle tales, that he may mislead others from the path of God without knowledge, and taketh it in mockery; for such there is a humiliating chastisement."

And among the traditions that have issued forth in this regard from the Suns of Grandeur and Glory, peace be upon them, is what is related from Abu Basir who said: "I asked Abu Ja'far, peace be upon him, about the earnings of female singers, and he said: That to which men come is forbidden, but that which is called to weddings, there is no harm in it.' And this is the meaning of God's words, mighty and glorious is He: And among the people is he who purchases idle tales to lead astray from the path of God."'

And from Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, it is related that a man asked him about selling slave girls who were singers, and he said:

> "Buying them and selling them is forbidden, teaching them is unbelief, and listening to them is hypocrisy."

And from Abu Basir who said: "I asked Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, about the words of God the Most High:"Shun the abomination of idols and shun false speech," and he said it refers to singing.

And from Mihran ibn Muhammad from Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, who said he heard him say that singing is among what God Almighty meant when He said "And among men is he who purchases idle tales to lead astray from God's way."

And from Sa'dah ibn Ziyad who said he was with Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, when a man said to him "May my father and mother be sacrificed for you! I enter my privy and I have neighbors who have singing girls who play the lute, and sometimes I prolong my sitting to listen to them." He [Abu Abdullah] said: "Do not do that." The man said "By God, I do not go to them, I only hear what reaches my ears." He said "God! God! Have you not heard God saying ʿThe hearing and the sight and the heart, all of these shall be questioned about'?" He said "Yes, by God, it is as if I had never heard this verse from God's Book from any non-Arab or Arab. Surely I will not return to it, God willing, and I seek God's forgiveness." He said to him "Rise and perform ablution and pray, for you were persisting in a grave matter. How terrible would have been your state had you died in that condition! Praise God and ask Him for repentance from all that He dislikes, for He only dislikes what is ugly, and leave ugliness to its people, for everything has its people."

And from Abdul A'la who said: I asked Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, about singing and said "They claim that the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, permitted saying We came to you, we came to you, we greet you, we greet you."' He [Abu Abdullah] said: "They lie. God Almighty says We created not the heavens and the earth and all between them for mere play. Had We intended to take a pastime, We could surely have taken it from before Us, if We were going to do so. Nay, We hurl Truth against falsehood, and it crushes it, and lo! it vanishes. And woe to you for what you attribute."' Then he said "Woe to so-and-so for what he describes"—a man who was not present at the gathering.

And from Al-Tamam who said Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, said:

> "A house of singing will not be consoled in calamity, nor will prayers be answered in it, nor will angels enter it."

And he, peace be upon him, was asked about singing and said:

> "Do not enter houses from which God has turned away from their inhabitants."

And from him, peace be upon him: "The worst of sounds is singing."

And from him, peace be upon him: "Singing breeds hypocrisy and results in poverty."

And from Al-Hassan from Harun who said: I heard Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, say: "Singing is a gathering at which God does not look at its people, and it is among what God Almighty meant when He said ʿAnd among men is he who purchases idle tales to lead astray from God's way."'

And from Yasir from Abul Hassan, peace be upon him, who said:

> "Whoever keeps himself pure from singing will find in Paradise a tree which God commands the winds to move, producing a sound the like of which has never been heard, but whoever does not keep pure from it will not hear it."

Likewise, the People of the House of Infallibility, peace be upon them, have alluded to this, in expounding the vocal utterance which, from the side of Lordship, is cast into the identity of the servant. The traditions that bear witness to this ordinance are these which shall now be set forth.

It is related from Ali ibn Ibrahim, from his father, from Ali ibn Ma'bad, from Wasil ibn Sulayman who said: "I asked Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, concerning the words of God, the Mighty and Glorious, and recite the Qur'an with measured recitation.' He said that the Commander of the Faithful, peace be upon him, said: 'Expound it with clear exposition, neither rushing through it like poetry, nor scattering it like sand. Rather, let it penetrate your hardened hearts, and let not your sole concern be reaching the end of the surah.'"

And likewise from Abu 'Abdullah, peace be upon him, who said:

> "Verily the Qur'an was revealed with sadness, so recite it with sadness."

Part 3: "And from him, peace be upon him, who…"

And from him, peace be upon him, who said that the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, said:

> "Recite the Qur'an with the melodies and voices of the Arabs, and beware of the melodies of the sinful ones and those who commit major sins. For verily after me there shall arise peoples who will modulate the Qur'an like singing, lamenting, and monastic chanting. It will not pass beyond their throats; their hearts are perverted and the hearts of those who admire their manner."

It is related from Abu'l-Hasan, peace be upon him, that when mention was made of voice in his presence, he said: "'Ali ibn al-Husayn, peace be upon them both, would recite, and one passing by would fall unconscious from the beauty of his voice. And if the Imam were to reveal anything of that, the people could not bear its beauty." I asked: "Did not the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, lead the people in prayer and raise his voice in reciting the Qur'an?" He replied: "The Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, would only burden the people with what they could bear of his character."

And from Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, who said: "Verily God, the Mighty and Glorious, revealed to Moses son of Imran, peace be upon him: 'When thou standest before Me, stand as one who is humble and poor, and when thou recitest the Torah, let Me hear it with a sorrowful voice.'"

And from him, peace be upon him, who said that the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, said:

> "My community has not been given less than three things: beauty, a beautiful voice, and memory."

And from him, peace be upon him, who said that the Prophet, peace be upon him and his family, said:

> "Among the most beautiful of beauties for a person are beautiful hair and the gift of a beautiful voice."

And from him, peace be upon him, who said that the Prophet, peace be upon him and his family, said:

> “Everything has an ornament, and the ornament of the Qur’an is a beautiful voice.”

And from him, peace be upon him, who said:

> “God, the Mighty and Glorious, never sent a prophet except that he had a beautiful voice.”

And from him, peace be upon him, who said:

> “’Ali ibn al-Husayn, peace be upon them both, had the most beautiful voice of all people in reciting the Qur’an, and the water-carriers would pass by and stop at his door to listen to his recitation.”

From Muhammad ibn al-Fadl who said that [Abu Abdullah], peace be upon him, said:

> “It is disliked to recite Say: He is God, the One’ in a single breath.”

And from Abu Basir who said: “I said to Abu Ja’far, peace be upon him, When I recite the Qur’an and raise my voice with it, Satan comes to me.’ He said: Do you think I would destroy people with this? O Abu Muhammad, recite in a manner between the two manners of recitation. Let your household hear you, and modulate your voice with the Qur’an, for verily God, the Mighty and Glorious, loves the beautiful voice when it is modulated with proper modulation.”’

In al-Faqih it is recorded that a man asked Ali ibn al-Hussein (peace be upon them both) about buying a slave girl who had a beautiful voice. He replied:

> “What harm is there if you buy her and she reminds you of Paradise through her recitation of the Qur’an, asceticism, and virtues which are not singing?”

As for singing, it is forbidden.

And from Ali ibn Ja’far, from his brother (peace be upon him), he said: “I asked him about singing, whether it is permissible during the festivals of Fitr and Adha and times of joy?” He replied: “There is no harm in it as long as it does not lead to disobedience.”

There is no doubt that this type of voice is praiseworthy and beloved in the sight of the Holy Lawgiver. Rather, it is incumbent upon the servant to observe this beautiful melody in all stations of reciting the Book of God, prayers, and words describing the tribulations of the Holy Family (peace be upon them), but in such a way that it does not exceed natural moderation, as God has indicated regarding prayer:

> “Neither speak thy prayer aloud, nor speak it in a low tone, but seek a middle course between.”

[Q17:110]

There is no doubt that the mere mention of His Holiness the Praiseworthy One and the Mirror of the Beauty of the Worshipped One, His Holiness Aba Abdullah Al-Hussein (peace be upon him) is itself prayer. Indeed, the reality of prayer is nothing but the servant’s remembrance of God through His manifest appearances in the kingdom of command and creation. The criterion for voice that is beloved by God and

His chosen ones, and reminiscent of the breezes of primal eternity, is a voice that maintains moderation, such that upon hearing it, it erases from around the heart of the servant all remembrance save that of God, and brings the servant to the sacred threshold of nearness and intimacy with the manifestations and revelations of the Worshipped One, exalted be His remembrance.

This type of voice is praiseworthy, and it is the beautiful voice with which the Suns of Grandeur and Glory would recite the Book of God. Any who remembers true remembrance while maintaining vocal moderation is praiseworthy and beloved by those of understanding, especially when mentioning the tribulations of the Prince of Martyrs (peace be upon him), for the mention of him is itself the Word of Unity and the Reality of Sanctification. Whoever turns away from the voice that remembers that Greatest Tree and Mighty News is instantly a polytheist, gathered under the blessed verse "When it is said unto them: There is no god save God, they are scornful," [Q37:35] and tormented by the fire of remoteness.

For truly, the reality of mentioning that Holy One is identical to mentioning the Messenger of God (peace be upon him and his family), and the reality of mentioning him is identical to mentioning God, which is the first station of remembrance in contingent existence. For the Pure Primal Essence, exalted be His remembrance, any mention is forbidden, and He is more glorious and greater than to be mentioned by His creation. Rather, creation is mentioned through His origination, as the Prince of Believers (peace be upon him) indicated in his unique sermon regarding the blocking of the way to His mention, where he said: "If you say from what is He?' then He is separate from all things, so He is He; and if you say He is He,' the letters Ha' and Waw' in these words are but attributes indicating Him, not attributes revealing Him.

And if thou sayest He has limits, the limits belong to other than Him. And if thou sayest the air is His relation, the air is but His creation. One returns from attribute to attribute, while the heart remains blind to understanding, understanding to perception, and perception to deduction. The kingdom remains in the kingdom, the created returns to its like, seeking drives it to its form, investigation leads to impotence, expression to loss, effort to despair, and attainment to severance. The path is blocked and the quest rejected. His proof lies in His signs and His existence in His affirmation.

And after this, there is no mention possible in creation that can be attributed to God except the mention of the Manifestations of His power, and no true rememberer can be conceived except one who remembers Their mention, who in the realm of action and appearances of Lordship proves the revelations of Their stations. Although the mention of all save Muhammad and His successors and Fatima (God's blessings be upon them) is absolute nothingness before Them—nay, if they are mentioned, it is less than the mention of an ant in relation to the oneness of the Most Holy Essence—yet through divine grace, He has accepted the mention of servants in remembering Their tribulations. For Their manifestations of Lordship, which stem from the essence of Their servitude, are beyond the comprehension of hearts and minds.

Therefore, it is not befitting for anyone to mention the prohibition and prevention of raising voices in certain stations, for the root of prohibition of [certain] sounds, as appears from traditions, is due to their vain aspects which the people of wickedness and error employ. Otherwise, when it does not lead to disobedience and does not emerge from the tree of self, no prohibition exists in religious law, as evidenced by the tradition permitting it on the days of Fitr and Adha and days of joy, provided it does not

lead to transgression. This specifies the absolute traditions that have emerged from the Household of Infallibility regarding prohibition. The true measure of permissibility and prohibition in singing is distinguishing the tone of wickedness from the people of manifestation.

As soon as people of understanding and fairness in custom say this voice is not a tone of wickedness, its permissibility is established, even though Akhund Mulla Muhsin Fayd (may God forgive what his knowledge encompassed therein) based the measure of prohibition of singing on disobedience, not considering singing itself inherently prohibited, clinging to the outward meaning of the traditions mentioned. But the true reality in explaining this matter is as was mentioned: whenever one raises their voice from the aspect of their innate lordship, it is praiseworthy before God and the people of discernment, and whenever one raises their voice from the aspect of their own self-nature, it is singing and forbidden, as all the verses and traditions mentioned indicate this ruling.

And what some scholars have mentioned regarding the ruling on singing, and in the name of religious precaution prevent the remembrance of the rememberer mentioning the Household of Grandeur and Majesty, is far from the true ruling and intermixed with aspects of ego. Rather, as regards sound there are two rulings manifest. First is that which is forbidden, the prohibition of which was revealed in the Book, as He, exalted be His mention, hath said: “The most repugnant of voices is the braying of the ass.” [Q31:19] And He hath referred to such people in another place: “They are like cattle, nay, more misguided.” [Q25:44] This sound is the melody of the people of fire and the characteristics of the stations of the wicked, which speaks to their nature. Even if such people recite the Book of God and make mention of the Lord and His chosen ones, yet those endowed with spiritual insight from among the detached ones and people of truth observe that it is the sound of the denizens of hell, like the melodies of the people of Hijaz who oppose the truth of the religion of Islam. Though they recite with eloquent voice and wondrous melody, the ruling concerning their nature applies to them.

Second is that which is obligatory, and it is the sound upon which the melody of the Book of God was revealed, and the people of love and detachment recite verses and prayers, and make mention of the tribulations of the Suns of Grandeur and Glory in the station of raising their voices with the most beautiful melody and utmost humility and submissiveness. And this aspect, since its appearance is from the manifestation of the sign of unity, is beloved in the sight of God and His chosen ones. This is the sound that was commanded in the words of the Suns of Grandeur and Glory, and it is reminiscent of the degrees of paradise and the moving winds from beyond the morn of eternity that waft upon the temples of unity, drawing the servant to stations that the Lord of the world hath ordained for him, [provided it does not lead to swooning, as is related from Jabir from Abu Ja’far, peace be upon him, who said: “I said that when some people mention something from the Qur’an or discuss it, one of them swoons to such an extent that if his hands and feet were cut off he would not notice it.” He replied: “Glory be to God! That is from Satan. They were not characterized thus. Rather it is gentleness and tenderness and tears and awe.”]

Besides these two forms, there are other forms of the reprehensible and the recommended that are manifest and available in the stations of most people. However, the ruling returns to that same point [of light] whose ruling was mentioned in the depths of these allusions, whereby the recommended lies in the shadow of the aspect of Lordship and the reprehensible in the shadow of the aspect of nature. And apart

from mentioning tribulations and stations prescribed in the Law, raising the voice is forbidden. Indeed, the sign of a believer is that in all conditions he should speak with the most humble voice and most submissive state, as the Imam, peace be upon him, said concerning the signs of the believing monotheist, from Mihzam al-Asadi who said:

"Abu Abdullah, peace be upon him, said: O Mihzam! Our followers are those whose voice does not exceed their hearing, nor their rancor their hands, nor do they openly praise us, nor sit with those who find fault with us, nor dispute with those who oppose us. If they meet a believer they honor him, and if they meet an ignorant one they avoid him.' I said: May I be sacrificed for you! What should I do about these who claim to be Shi'ih?' He said: Among them is discrimination and among them is alteration, and among them is refinement. Years will come upon them with their banishment, and plague shall slay them, and discord shall scatter them. Our followers are those who neither bark like dogs nor covet like ravens, nor do they beg from our enemies even if they die of hunger.' I said, May I be sacrificed for you, where shall I seek these people?' He replied, In the ends of the earth.

These are they whose lives are humble and whose dwellings are few. If they are present they are not recognized, and if they are absent they are not missed. They do not fear death, and in their graves they visit one another. If a needy one takes refuge with them, they show mercy to him. Their hearts are not divided even though their homes may be far apart.' Then he said, 'The Messenger of God, peace be upon Him and His family, said: I am the City and Ali is its Gate. He who claims to enter the City except through the Gate is a liar, and he who claims to love me while hating Ali, peace be upon him, is a liar."'

And mention of these matters has no end, therefore this brief answer will suffice. It is hoped, through the grace of the All-Bestowing Lord, that this will be impressed upon the mirror of your enlightened heart as intended, so that after mentioning the tribulations of the Manifestations of Divine Unity and the signs of sanctification, you may remember the writer of these words before God and His loved ones, that the reward of their remembrance may be recorded a thousandfold in the Preserved Tablet for their sake, as stated in the tradition of the Imam Kazim, peace be upon him. And may this prove a trade that shall never fail, so that in no state shall the remembrance of the tribulations of the immaculate Household, God's peace be upon them, be erased from your thoughts.

Sufficient is it for his glory that God, the Most Great, hath spoken concerning those who know Him [in meaning]:

> "Whosoever weepeth for Me, I shall be his reward. By Him Who holdeth my soul in His hands, the recompense of this decree is not equaled by anything in the heavens and the earth. This is God's grace which He bestoweth upon whomsoever He willeth, for God is the Lord of infinite bounty."

Glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they attribute to Him, and peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00042: Risalata'l-Ishraq

Part 1: "Praise be to God Who brought the Primal…"

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who brought the Primal Will into being before all things, that His sovereignty might be made manifest in the kingdom of Command and Creation, and that all atoms might know what God hath testified concerning His Own Self by His Own Self from all eternity: that there is none other God but Him. He hath ever existed when naught existed with Him, and He will forever continue to be while no thing shall be mentioned at His level, for His Essence is the pure, primordial Essence that by its very nature severs all essences from the plane of knowledge, and His Identity is the ancient, crystalline Identity that by its very being prevents all material things from attaining the station of expression.

Whosoever claimeth to unify the Essence through his own essence by unifying the Essence itself—his unification is void, the aspects of his abstraction are compound, and the stations of his uniqueness are limited. For all that is other than the Essence was created only through the manifestations of limitation from the six directions and the appearances that indicate them. And whosoever uttereth a word concerning the unification of the Essence hath ascended to the station of Names, unified with the manifestations of Attributes, been confounded by the conditions of the signs of stations, and illumined by the manifestations of the tokens of indications, for the decree of creation at all times cannot be divorced from the state of powerlessness and need, and indicateth naught but the decree of despair and impossibility.

Exalted is the station of the manifestation of the Essence and the signs of the manifestations of Attributes above comparison and the striking of similitudes. Verily, all upon which the name of any thing can fall, whether of essences or accidents, whether of trees or identities, is created by God, exalted be His mention. He is far above the description of existences and the attributes of contingent beings, sanctified beyond the mention of signs and tokens, for He, in His glorious Identity and Beauty, and His sovereign station and Grace, cannot be known through comparisons nor described through similitudes from the stations of Command and the manifestations for which God hath set no end in what is endless.

Glorified and exalted is He! After the creation of the Primal Will, He brought into being the essence of Purpose and made it a sign of His Will, an expression of His Oneness, and a token of His sovereign power, that all might know, in the stations of Command and Creation, what God intended through the creation of contingent beings and the manifestation of existences. For He hath mention in the realm of possibility which preceded by His Essence the existence of all things and transcended by His Being the essence of all things. He is exalted above description in the rank of essences and sanctified beyond attributes in the station of essential realities, for He was the pivot of the revolving circle in the Most Exalted Horizon and the manifestation of the decree of justice "at the distance of two bow-lengths or even closer."

Indeed, He is the Messenger of God, may God's blessings be upon Him and His family, whom God chose from the innermost sanctum of the eternity of His Essence for His Essence, selected Him for the station of the knowledge of His Self for His Self, elected Him for the preservation of His mystery for His creation,

and approved Him for whatsoever He wished and willed in creation for the manifestation of His dominion. This was so that He might convey to all atoms of existence the decree of the First Mention in its mystery and the decree of the Second Mention in its outward expression, until every limit knew its standing in the essential signs of unity, the manifestations of the stations of uniqueness, and the evidences of the tokens of glorification.

Through this, all became knowing of the truth of His authority, cognizant of the station of His sovereignty, and witness to His decree, for He conveyed to all that was in God's knowledge all that God had written for them thereby, so that all, after their knowledge of these ranks, might become knowers of the mention of His beginning, for which God appointed no start other than Himself, and recognizers of His manifestations, which God ordained for Him in all His stations of the unseen and the seen, and that which is not realized save through the mention of the absent before the existent, that all might reach the ultimate outpouring of God regarding His truth, and say: I bear witness that verily Muhammad—may the blessings of God rest upon him and his family—is His servant and His Messenger, whom God hath made a luminous lamp unto all the worlds.

And praise be to God Who brought forth through His Command the essence of Power for the manifestation of the mystery of that which was destined, and ordained for it the form of Trinity for the manifestation of the Cross unto those in whose nature was the clay of Sijjin. From this did the Christians take the form of the Cross and the descent of the Divine into human form. From this did the philosophers affirm the judgment of the immutable archetypes in the Divine Essence to establish His knowledge—exalted be His mention. From this did the mystics, after absolute annihilation, detail the boundary of attainment to the Essence. From this did the philosophers establish the doctrine of the unity of existence and prove the simplicity of Reality, and that the Originator of a thing cannot lack it. From this did the learned ones speak of the affirmative attributes of the Essence and the negation of privative attributes from It through conceptual distinction. From this did the mystics claim for themselves in every age the station of Universal Guardianship, until most of them spoke that which they neither understood nor perceived.

From this did the jurists who were not qualified establish in the matter of "the affair between two affairs" the decree of compulsion in existence and delegation in being, and they imagined in the judgment of the unity of the Essence a multiplicity of multiplicities in the noblest form through affirmative mention. From this does everyone who turns away from the beliefs of the Imams of the Faith speak, and explains according to his own desires through analogies and similar arts of knowledge, claiming to judge reality—all of which is rejected by God, and His Command in those signs was but closer than the twinkling of an eye.

Verily it is a matter between Will and Purpose, and God hath made its capacity the capacity of the heaven of acceptances and the earth of receptivities. Verily it is the Path in all the worlds—through it is made happy whoso is made happy, and through it is made wretched whoso is made wretched. And it is the station of Hasan—peace be upon him—in the ranks of the Intellect. The blessings of God be upon him through Whom rose the sun of origination through origination, then set not the sun of invention through

invention. None knoweth the decree of Trinity in His Name save God and whomso He willeth. Verily there is no God but He, the Mighty, the Powerful, the All-Bountiful.

And praise be to God Who brought forth the four ranks—namely Decree, Permission, Term, and Book—which exist with the aforementioned ranks by His Command, and made the bearer of each one of them a soul from among the successors of Muhammad, the Messenger of God—may the blessings of God rest upon him and his family—that all hesitations might hesitate through the hesitation of those Manifestations' hesitation, and all glimmerings might glimmer through the glimmering of those conditions' glimmering, and all atoms might know them through God's revelation to them through them in the secret repositories of the essential realities of the Divine Realm and the depths of the essential realities of the Realm of Might in the essential realities of the identities of the Kingdom and Dominion, and the manifestations of the identities of the Kingdom and human realm, until every station knew itself and reached the ultimate purpose of its decree and the conditions of its affair, that all might know the severance of the way from the court of their might and the prevention of proof from ascending to the atmosphere of their grandeur, and all might testify in every moment to Muhammad, ʿAli, Fatimih, Hasan, Husayn, Musa, and Ja'far—the blessings of God be upon them—and their mystery, that no name of a thing nor attribute of a thing falleth upon them, and that they are exalted above mention of the Presence of Holiness and Majesty and the decree of description and similitude. Glorified be God, their Originator, above what they describe.

Now, to proceed: After I had taken up my abode in the land of Sad, Isfahan, there came a question—posed by the eminent savant, Mulla Sadra-i-Tabrizi—seeking an illumination [ishraq] akin to that which shone from the Court near [Siyyid] Kazim, may God's mercy rest upon him, in the Lawami al-Husayniyyah. He was, indeed, among those who strive in the station of the knowledge of Reality, so long as he be not veiled by the splendors of phantasmal forms.

I therefore desired to respond to what he sought, with a radiance that would disclose the ruling of the Covenant on the Day of Concord, and "uncover the shank" for every soul that desireth the bond on the Promised Tryst.

But rejoice thou, when the breezes of the Dawn of Pre-Eternity stir the leaves of the Tree of Majesty; when the birds of Paradise chant upon its boughs with the light of Beauty; when the Dove warbleth upon the summit of that Tree with melodies no ear among the folk of discourse hath ever heard; when the Peacock of the Cloud wheels about it, and the Cock of Paradise claps beneath its shade. Then shall he who attaineth unto it verily prosper, and he who turneth away shall perish, uttering, "Verily we are God's, and unto Him shall we return." And there is no power nor might save in God, the Most High, the Most Great.

O pure questioner and wayfarer upon the path of the Most High! Know thou that the First Emanation hath blessed names, among them the First Remembrance, concerning which the decree was revealed in the words of Rida, peace be upon him, addressing Yunis where he said, exalted be His mention: "O Yunis, knowest thou what is the Will?" He replied "No." He, peace be upon him, said: "It is the First Remembrance." And among them is the Will, concerning which the decree was revealed in the words of the Most Great Announcement where He said: "God created all things through the Will, and created the

Will by itself." And among them are Creation, Origination, and Bringing-into-being, concerning which the decree was revealed in the words of God's Proof and His Most Great Self, where He said, exalted be His mention, regarding the station of meaning: "Its names are three but its meaning is one." And among them are the Emanation and the First in the words of the philosophers, and among them is Absolute Contingency.

Verily the truth, according to the All-Bountiful, exalted be His mention, is that the servant should not ascribe to Him any name in the station of His Essence, nor attribute in the reality of His Self, nor description in the station of His Identity, for in that station He cannot be known by the how, nor described by the where, nor limited by indication, nor qualified by worship. For He is the Pure, Absolute Indicator of the Essence, beside Whom there is none other, and in Whose rank no creation is mentioned. Attributes are severed from the precincts of His might's nearness, and names are prevented from reaching the threshold of His unity.

Whosoever saith "He is He" hath associated His creation with Him and taken for himself a likeness of Him. And whosoever saith that His existence proves His existence hath borne falsehood by mentioning existence in relation to His Self. All that the speakers have said before the seat of His celestial dominion, and all that the unitarians comprehend before the seat of His lordship, are but effects of His manifestations whereby He hath revealed Himself to all else through all else by means of all else, without His Essence being joined to His action or His creation to His Self. And none knoweth how its Fashioner brought it forth save He Who brought it forth—out of no thing, by Himself and for Himself—without any mention before it, without aught with it, and without any description like unto it after it; for God hath made its cause to be His very Self. Nor can anyone say "how" it is, for the how itself was created thereby and cannot be known thereby.

And this is what my master, al-Kazim—that is, Siyyid Kazim, may God hallow his dust—hath mentioned in the ninth effulgence of his book, may God sanctify his dust, concerning the names of that First Emanation beyond description and indication, and regarding the explanation of its emanation, composition, existence and formation—this is mentioned beneath that station. Were it not from other than Him that those names emerged in explaining the essence of the First Emanation, it would nullify it. But since words flow according to human stations, and the reality of explanation is known in the station of elucidation, he spoke the truth and revealed the absolute mystery. Ask God to raise him to the station of radiant grace flowing from the Absolute Bestower.

Part 2: "When you recognize the First Mention through God's…"

When you recognize the First Mention through God's revelation to you for its recognition at the first mention in your heart, be assured with certainty that nothing can exist in contingent being except through seven boundaries. For everything has the rank of existence which is expressed as the First Emanation, and the rank of quiddity which is expressed as the First Determination and Will, and the rank of connection between them which is expressed as Destiny. After the existence of two things, if there were no connection between them, they would not be two. Therefore, by proof of interval and avoidance of quantum leap, after the existence of two, the ruling of three is established. This is witnessed by one

whose heart God has opened to recognize the mystery of the balanced descent of the galaxy. This proof in the balance is sufficient explanation for you.

When the existence of three is established in the beginning of primary causes, the existence of four is established through the existence of Decree, Permission, Term and Book through the descent of three. It is impossible for any rank to be reduced from these aspects. Therefore God has sent down in the written form according to the creative form, from the manifestations of unity and the appearances of glory and the revelations of praise in the stations of oneness, where one of them said:

> "Nothing exists in earth or heaven except through seven: Will, Purpose, Destiny, Decree, Permission, Term and Book. Whoever claims one of these is lacking has indeed disbelieved."

When you recognize the mystery of creation through what has descended in the hidden indications of these expressions, witness that the philosophers have slipped in the station of recognizing that First Emanation, which is the letter Kaf revolving upon itself, by itself, for itself, from itself—for they are unable to comprehend how God originated the Will by itself, for itself, from itself, without being touched by the fire of His Essence. The reason for this is that when they tried to recognize the First Mention through other than itself, recognition became difficult for them and the paths of explanation were cut off from their hands. They say within themselves: "How can a thing bring itself into existence?" Therefore they were compelled to believe in fixed archetypes within the Essence, and the unity of existence in all particles, and the causality of contingent beings' origination in the eternality of the Essence, and the mention of the simple reality in the Essence and its manifestations in the attributes.

I seek refuge in God's perfect words which have filled the spheres of names and attributes, from belief in those indications and arrival at those glories and drawing near to these evidences and turning toward these determined multiplicities in the world of phantoms and accidents and opposites and disparities, which are stations of the people of remoteness before God, Lord of all names and attributes. And this is but the consequence of what their hands have wrought—seeking and taking from sources other than the Suns of Majesty upon the dust—whereupon they strove to know the First Emanation by the intellect, which is the first delimitation in the world of essences. They knew not that the intellect, even at the furthest limit of the realm of abstraction, comprehendeth not things save as circumscribed, nor can it conceive the cause of the First Remembrance in the First Emanation without invoking otherness and the manifestation of contrariety.

By this have they burdened themselves with the transgressions of universal realms, without evidence from the people of Truth or authority from the people of the Law. I beseech God to rectify, through His grace, the deeds of those among them who have passed away and those who remain in this world. Verily, He is the Forgiver unto him who transgresses not his own bounds in the Kingdom of Names and Attributes.

O thou who gazest upon these allusions! By thy Lord! The beginning of the knowledge of the stations of attributes can only be attained through what hath shone upon thee from the mystery of the verses. And should anyone not believe in that which I have revealed unto thee from the melodies of the birds of the Divine Realm, the cooings of the Dove of the Celestial Domain, the attributes of the Peacock of

sovereignty and dominion, and the humming of the bees of the earthly kingdom, he shall not escape God's wrath, even if he cannot grasp the reality of that exposition save after the appearance of the consciousness of the heart. Yet must he submit to what I have imparted in that station.

For the Pure and Primordial Essence hath ever been, and shall ever be, unassociated with Its creation, nor is Its creation mentioned in Its rank. Rather, It created the temple of all existence through the Will itself, not from anything, through Its own causation, Its own acceptance, the manifestation of Its own essence, and the ultimate expression of Its identity. Then through it It created whatsoever It willeth as It willeth. Though It is capable of creating all It desireth like unto the Will from naught, yet this is impossible in the contingent realm, for that which preceded in existence is the cause for that which was non-existent, as indicated by the words of the Imam, peace be upon him, who said, glorified be His mention: "Verily God, exalted be He, first created Light, bringing it forth from naught.

Then from it He created darkness, though He was capable of creating darkness from naught even as He created Light from naught. Then from darkness He created light, and from light created a substance whose density was as the density of seven heavens and seven earths. Then He caused the ruby to melt, and from His awe it became trembling water." And to this referreth the inner meaning where He saith, glorified be His mention: "Verily God, exalted be He, was in a cloud above which was air and below which was air, before the creation of the heavens and the earth." And what is meant by the cloud is the thin mist.

That first exposition pertaineth to the station of limitation, else if thou witnesseth the mystery of Unity, all things are created from naught, for if the Will did not indicate in its effect its Originator, its existence would not be from naught. And the knowledge of the First Emanation in the station of the manifestation of all through all is impossible save through infinite inner stations, which none can comprehend except he who hath rent asunder the veils of glory, transcended the journey of the intellect in itself, and attained unto the station of the manifestation of the Essence. For there, through the First Mention in the station of its own self, wherein no other is mentioned with it, the causation of the First Mention is known through itself and for itself.

Therefore did the Imam, peace be upon him, prohibit thought and speech concerning the station of the manifestation of the Essence. Nay, the way to knowledge of the Path is barred, being realized in the Third Station, which is the station of connection expressed as Destiny, whereunto Ali, peace be upon him, alluded in his words, glorified be his mention:

> "Verily, destiny qadar is a mystery of God's mysteries, a safeguard of His safeguards—uplifted within the veil of God, folded away from His creation, sealed with the seal of God, pre-existent in the knowledge of God. He hath withheld it from His servants, its knowledge denied them, and raised its knowledge above their testimonies and the extent of their intellects, for they cannot attain it through divine reality, nor through eternal power, nor through luminous grandeur, nor through the might of unity. It is a surging, billowing ocean, pure for God, the Mighty and Glorious, its depth spanning between heaven and earth, its width stretching from east to west, black as the darkest night, teeming with fish and serpents, rising at times and sinking at others. In its depths shines a sun which none should seek to discover except the

> One, the Single. Whoever attempts to discover it has opposed God, the Mighty and Glorious, in His judgment, contested His sovereignty, uncovered His secret and veil, and incurred God's wrath—his abode shall be hell, an evil destination and journey's end."

Since the way is barred at the third station, it must needs be that in the rank of the First Remembrance it is of an even higher station, for in the rank of Destiny the intellect perceives the three directions and thereby distinguishes between Will, Purpose and Destiny. But in the First Remembrance, its recognition through the faculty of intellect is impossible, for nothing was created except by choice, and choice operates only after the equivalence of the two aspects. For this reason the intellect cannot perceive in the First Remembrance the causality of its essence to itself and the acceptance of its choice without mention of another.

Therefore the seeker of God's decree must submit to the guardians who bear the knowledge of the Family of God, peace be upon them, through what the sun of origination has risen with origination, then through what the sun of invention has set with invention. Otherwise, were one to seek understanding through the path of explanation, one would cast oneself into the stations of fire by believing as the philosophers chose regarding the connection between God and His creation, for the intellect cannot perceive the cause of existence from the thing itself, and thus one enters into affairs abstracted from the fixed essences and below them, which are invalid according to the school of the people of infallibility, peace be upon them, while thinking oneself rewarded in the inner secret. Nay, by thy Lord! Silence regarding what one cannot perceive of the reality of the matter is better than affirming fixed essences in the Divine Essence and binding oneself to belief in the unity of existence between the Creator and the created, then in the conjunction of the Essence with its action. Glory be to God above what those who liken Him describe of His signs!

For this reason Ali, peace be upon him, said:

> "Thy power has become manifest, O my God, but Thy majesty has not become manifest, so they likened Thee and took some of Thy signs as lords, and thus they did not know Thee. For had they known Him, that naught should be mentioned with Him and His Essence is not conjoined with His creation, they would have witnessed in the station of the First Emanation its origination from nothing through its own causality, not another's, without conceptualizing through their perception or imagining through their suppositions for the negation of themselves. Glory be to God, Lord of the heavens and earth, above what they describe!"

And the Qur'anic verse in the station of sempiternity [sarmad] beareth witness to this, in its mention of the six days, which are intended as the manifestations of the First Remembrance, and naught else. And "the heavens" are that First Remembrance; and the six alluded to are the station of the days which signify the Will, that Will being its cause at the limit of its delimitation. By the number of these degrees is established the existence of the aspects of action within the essential realities of the manifestations of the theophany, and the degree of receptivity within its own station—which, by reason of the nearness of its attributes to their Origin, telleth of naught save action. And things attain unto those degrees, determined in the rank of its heart; save that its first aspect, which pointeth only through the First Emanation, suffereth not the servant to apprehend any aspect of mention from other than it. Otherwise,

in truth, everything beneath the Essence is composed of the elements of its own world; and God hath created naught as a solitary entity, standing by itself—since the rank of possibility cannot subsist, as such, within the possible.

Let it never occur to thy mind that the First Remembrance—which, despite its composition and the modes of its delimitation in reality, pointeth unto God—was, in the station of knowledge, addressed by men through an imagined oneness whereby It revealed Itself unto them. Nay, rather, the mystery in very truth lieth beneath and beyond that. The First Mention, which is the first absolute emanation, has no self other than itself. The mention of the aspect of specification is not in truth its description, but rather is the station of Will. Were it not so, how could the servant attain certitude of the pure, absolute Oneness in the station of the Essence, exalted be His mention? That is the pure Truth with which no creation is mentioned and with which no servants are described. It is the pure manifestation which tells of naught but God. Rather, in the station of contingency, when the servant observes, nothing is possible except two pairs.

But when he looks with his inner mystery which has no mention of anything with it, he recognizes its indication of the station of the Essence, exalted be His mention. In that station, the feet of some among the wise philosophers have slipped, as they believe in the station of worship through mystical knowledge without knowledge of existence. This is the delusion mentioned in the tradition "Whoever worships God through imagination has disbelieved." Rather, knowledge is the same as the known, the rule of mystical finding is the same as direct vision, and the path of deeds is certitude. One who turns to God in the station of worship while thinking that the contingent can only know its own limitations, that worship is established in the station of His kingdom, and that the ultimate knowledge of the heart is the mention of composition and the limit of contingency—such a one is neither a believer in God's unity nor His worshipper. Rather, it is incumbent upon the servant to worship God Who is free from His creation and not associated with His creation.

Part 3: "Imagine not that what the holy ones turn…"

Imagine not that what the holy ones turn to is the manifestation of His revelation to them—God forbid such conjecture as imagined by deluded souls! Rather, He is the pure Truth beside whom there is no other, with whom nothing in His rank is mentioned. He is the pure Essence Who has no name, no description, no trace, no attribute. He is exalted above mention of names and attributes, sanctified beyond the station of manifesting signs of essences.

O thou who gazest upon the mystery unto the station of exposition, true explanation is thy due. Most people of the true party worship God through imagination, knowing that what creation turns to is the condition of contingency and station of exposition. God and His angels are innocent of such servants. Rather, the ultimate sin is that very imagination. What the Family of God and their trustees—peace be upon them—have mentioned in the stations of knowledge is that instruments point to themselves and tools indicate their like, and the wise have said that nothing transcends beyond its source—this is true in the station of creation. But if thou wishest to apply these indications in the station of the unity of the

Essence, no path remains for thee, nor canst thou prove the manifestation of the Necessary Being through proof, for his heart is attached to the condition of contingency.

The more one ascends, one cannot unify the All-Merciful, and therefore the tidings have descended from the suns of grandeur and mysteries: "When discourse reaches unto God, be silent." For discourse about God increases naught but bewilderment in its possessor. And these allusions veil the servant from knowledge of the Primal Remembrance, for knowledge of Him profits not except through deeds around that station. For while knowledge of the Primal Remembrance is established with all souls, action according to His stations and stillness beneath His shade is what is desired by God. And though the reality of knowledge is deed, yet in the realm of manifestation the reality of knowledge is not established except through deeds in the worlds of creation.

Therefore God has made it incumbent upon all to know Muhammad—peace be upon him and his family—in the highest degree of sublimity and the summit of glory, as One exalted above likeness and similitude and sanctified beyond comparison with any mortal. The fruit of that knowledge is but to increase utter effacement in His countenance and to follow His ordinances and conditions, and to occupy oneself with that which draws the servant near to His holy court and the majesty of His manifestation. The stations of that Remembrance's appearance in the realm of manifestation differ according to the capacities of beings and the existence of multiplicities. Thus the more delicate the glass of one's heart and the more refined one's conduct, the more perfect will be one's knowledge of the Source of the Primal Remembrance, the nearer one's nearness, and the more excellent the manifestation of one's knowledge in the stations of creation and command.

By this knowledge doth man glory above the ranks of the denizens of existence, and thereby is the epiphany of the Praised One distinguished from that which is intended. Verily, for the one who knoweth the First Remembrance there are degrees without end.

Among them is he who standeth in the station of the Point—the knower who witnesseth Its manifestation unto him by Itself, without any sign save the mirror of his heart. This is the station of the loftiest landmark of the heart, whereby he turneth to the First Remembrance in the first mirror—that One Who, of Himself and by Himself, pointeth unto God—exalted be His remembrance—by the proof of fixity, and by the negation of names and attributes from the Countenance of the Beloved.

In this station the beings possess an eightfold chain, indicating the stations of the degrees of the knower of the First Remembrance. Therefrom, after multiplication, ariseth the number fifty-six, corresponding to the number of the name Mahdi—peace be upon him—after the addition of the three letters, in token of the stations of Lahut (Divinity), Jabarut (Empyrean), and Malakut (Kingdom) in the rank of his name. This is not the place for its exposition; there is for it a Promised Day, if God so will, when it shall be disclosed; unto it returneth the decree in the origin and in the return.

Among these degrees is the rank of the Hidden Alif—the station of Will—whose bearer God hath appointed to be ʿAli—peace be upon him. Whoso knoweth it knoweth God and uniteth Him, in the station of the manifestation of the second stirring of his heart in a second mirror.

Then the rank of the Soft Alif—the station of Destiny (Qadar)—whose bearer God hath made Hasan—peace be upon him. Whoso knoweth it knoweth God and uniteth Him, in the station of the manifestation of the third degree of his heart's theophanies in the third mirror.

Then the rank of the Alif standing over every soul—the station of Decree (Qada'), the secret of Bada', the emergence of Ratification, and the perfection of Origination—whose bearer God hath appointed Husayn—peace be upon him. Whoso knoweth it beareth witness unto God in the fourth degree of his heart's theophanies in the fourth mirror.

Then the rank of the Unconjoined Alif—the station of Leave (Permission)—whose bearer God hath made Ja'far ibn Muhammad—peace be upon them both—whereunto the Truth alluded in His word: "Naught of Our bounty reacheth you save an alif unconnected." And whoso knoweth it uniteth God, his Lord, in the fifth degree of his heart's theophanies in the fifth mirror.

And among them is the rank of the Conjoined (Curved) Alif—the station of the Appointed Term (Ajal). And verily God, through His mighty power and great bounty, has made its bearer Musa ibn Ja'far, peace be upon them both. And verily one who knows him and his truth unifies God and praises Him as He has described Himself in the sixth level among the revelations of His heart in the sixth mirror.

And from it is the station of the letter, which is the station of the Book (Kitab). And verily God has made Fatimih, the blessings of God be upon her, the bearer of that letter. And verily one who knows her truth unifies God in the seventh station among the manifestations of His heart which indicate Him in the seventh mirror.

And verily for each chain of these eight chains there are stations hidden in the unseen, and the descents of those stations which are for the manifestations of the Imams of the visible realm are concealed. And nothing exists in the heavens and earth except through the manifestation of those seven in the realm of His invisibility and the descent of those seven in the realm of visibility.

And verily this is the highest station of Paradise in the eyes of the people of the Bayan, when one understands the words of the All-Merciful: "The All-Merciful has taught the Qur'an, created man, taught him expression." And verily this is but a drop from the mention of the First Emanation in the level of its manifestations in created things.

As for its essential nature, which is the highest, thou hast heard the rustling of the Bird of Divinity in explanation of the First Mention. And all that those who make mention mention in that station is cut off from the essence of His Being and prevented from ascending to His presence. Here there is no name for Thee, no mark, no indication, no description, no narration, no attribute. None knoweth how this is save God alone.

And verily in His level there is attachment to this First Emanation, which is the station of Will. The sages mention expressions in the station of exposition for the wayfarers from the human level, including: the second pre-existence, conditioned existence, the first determination, the prime matter of prime matters, the element of elements, the substance of substances, the secondary infinity. And what God intended beyond these names is that which is inscribed in the Book.

And verily the Truth is that every name upon which falls the name of a thing should be applied in the station of the manifestation of His unity in this level, for it is primary to all else. Indeed, there is no manifestation in contingent being except from that station, as Husayn, peace be upon him, indicated in his prayer on the Day of Arafih:

> "Other than Thee has not the manifestation that Thou hast, such that it could reveal Thee. When wert Thou ever hidden, that Thou shouldst need proof to lead to Thee? When wert Thou ever distant, that created things should lead to Thee? Blind is the eye that seeth Thee not, though Thou art its Observer. And at a loss is the servant who hath no portion of Thy love."

And the Truth hath indicated in another station: "I saw nothing except that I saw God before it." And He, exalted be His mention, said: "I saw no light but His light, and heard no sound but His sound." And thus did Ali, peace be upon him, say in his sermon: "I am His manifest Divinity, and I am the Reality upon which no name nor likeness falls. I am the Gate of Remission. And there is no might nor power except through God, the Exalted, the Great," for verily my spirit and all in the kingdoms of command and creation would be His sacrifice, established upon the Throne of Will by God's leave.

And he it is who bestoweth upon every soul its due, and who guideth unto each thing, by God's leave, its allotted sustenance. Verily, he is the very Will in the worlds of essences; and the mystery of this matter is that to which, peace be upon him, he alluded in the Khutbat al-a¹¬utunjiyyah—upon its Originator be thousands of praises and greetings. "I saw God and Paradise with the physical eye"—meaning the vision of the Will as it appeared to him. Assert nothing beyond this, for any reference to the Eternal Essence is impossible and forbidden. None save Him can know Him as He is in the glory of His Identity and the majesty of His Self-Sufficiency, and none but He can describe Him.

Everything upon which the name of a thing can be applied, except God, is created, and He is exalted above the mention of aught else. All manifestations, conditions, and whatever falls under the rule of names and attributes are names of this aspect, for they are, as they are, a sign of the Will. Whatever flows in the Will flows in them, except that the First is the First Mention, and the Second is that whose existence was brought about through it.

The philosophers have differed regarding the ruling on the origination of the Will—whether it was created from nothing like the Will and its causality when the origination of the Second became connected with it. The truth is that both these aspects flow within it. When the servant looks through the causality of the Will, he needs not mention the origination of the Second in the rank of the Will. And when the servant looks at the station wherein the effect must necessarily resemble the attribute of its cause, he has no recourse but to say that the Will has manifested itself to the Will, through it, in its rank, just as the ruling was mentioned regarding the Will itself. This indeed is the truth in the innermost mysteries.

If you desire the outer ruling, it is that which I conveyed to you before: that origination is the One, and whatever originates from itself needs no new origination. However, in the mystery of this outer ruling there is an inner aspect, which is that the First Origination at every moment needs support from God, and God supports it in every condition through Himself for Himself, as if it were in every condition a new

origination. Yet nothing transgresses its own limits, nor does the ruling apply equally to another. Therefore glorified be God, its Creator, above what they describe.

BB00054: Letter to Mirza Hasan Vaqay'-Nigar

Introduction

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who brought into being whatsoever is in the heavens and on earth by His command, and established all things through His wisdom, that every created thing might attain to the knowledge of the Manifestation of the Divine Essence and the signs of the revelation of attributes—those signs deposited within the realities of souls and horizons—lest anything in the thought of anything be veiled from the remembrance of God, and that it might behold Him through that whereby He hath revealed Himself, manifest and evident, that there is no God but Him, self-subsisting through all eternity. In every condition His Essence describeth His Essence, and all else is powerless to comprehend the nature of His eternity or to know any decree of His Self-Sufficiency. His Essential Nature is sanctified above the comprehension of all things in the station of knowledge, and His Reality is exalted above all material things in the realm of utterance. None can point to His Presence, so lofty is His Self-Subsistence, nor describe any manifestation of His Will, so glorious is His transcendent holiness.

Glorified and exalted is He! He hath brought the created things into being as manifestations of His power, making them in the beginning a cause unto themselves, then ordaining for them neither an equal rule, nor a parallel mention, nor a comparable attribute, nor a matching description. Then He made them the station of His Self in opinions and the manifestation of Muhammad in creation. God hath ever been, and there was naught else besides Him, nor can any vision perceive Him in the depths of the signs of contingent being, while He perceiveth whatsoever He willeth, howsoever He willeth, as He willeth. Glorified and exalted is He above whatsoever they describe!

Then, after that verse of Divine Oneness, God did bring forth, in the realm of Lahut, the origination of the One; and, in the kingdom of Jabarut, the manifestation of the All-Sufficing—that all might behold the standards of substances and materials, of accidentals and temperaments, and whatsoever God hath decreed beyond these in every thing; the unitive testimony in the stations of Mulk and Malakut, and the merciful dispositions in the degrees of the epiphanies of all that God hath created in the earth of Nasut.

Thereafter the very Breath of Will—amidst the multitudes—brought forth the dawnings of beginnings and of ends, and all that the knowledge of God doth encompass; and those stations were beheld within the limitless realms, that every form in every world might melt away therein, even as each thing receiveth the decree of its Lord.

Then came the Breath of Holiness for the appearance of that which was ordained—the fathomless main of hidden treasuries, stored within the womb of possibility, the uttermost depth within the worlds, that He might distinguish thereby those who, having cast aside the veils and the allusions, turn unto the

countenance of the sheer, absolute Manifestation, from those who, in the station of multiplicity, gaze upon the visage of the attributes and are bereft of the manifestation of the Essence.

Then the Breath of Decree, that decree might appear before origination; then the fulfilment within origination itself; then the Breath of Permission, and of the term, and of the Book—whatsoever God willed, in creating whatsoever He pleased as He pleased, that the ordained measures might be disclosed, and the encompassed knowledges perfected, and that which no man's knowledge can reckon in the station of the mention of signs, save whom God willeth. Exalted is He! There is none other God but He, the Most High, the All-Glorious.

To continue: thy letter hath been sent down and I have been apprised of its contents. Know then, O thou who lookest upon these allusions, that God hath appointed for every thing the signs of His manifestations in the creation of all things fashioned by Him. And since this matter is not purified from the aspects of egoity save through the rising of the Countenance of His Lordship within the human temple, God hath established for it a Balance in utterance and a Scale in exposition, lest any should behold the signs of the manifestations of Lordship—cast into the very reality of servitude—after the manner of the dazzling veils of conventional selves.

For, in the station of Reality, it is pure simplicity; in the station of the Path, it is the posture of steadfastness upon the dawning-places of the light of elemental simplicity; and in the station of the Law, it is action according to what God hath sent down in the Book—on the path of spirit and recompense, in the fear of the Lord of lords, and in the measure of the requital which God hath ordained for the Day of Reckoning. Verily He is the Knower of beginning and return.

As for what you mentioned in writings about people's differences regarding me, there is no doubt that most people have made their desires their god, saying with their mouths what follows their vain imaginings. God will soon hold them accountable for what their hands have wrought. But one should not be surprised at people, for in every age some have engaged in lies and calumny. Look at the Christians, how they fabricated against God saying He is the third of three, then the Jews who claimed Ezra was the son of God, then the Arabs about whom God quotes their words "God is poor while we are rich"—We shall record what they have said and their slaying of the Prophets without right, and We shall say "Taste ye the torment of burning."

Just as they fabricated lies against God, they undoubtedly fabricated against all His chosen ones. One should not be surprised at them. I seek refuge in God from their calumnies against me, which I am ashamed to mention in this book, but I will mention some of what I intended, and God is my witness—sufficient is God as witness. Some fabricated claims of leadership, others claims of divine authority, others the invalidity of independent judgment. God will punish them for their fabrications. I am but a servant who believes in God and His verses. God honored me with the knowledge of understanding, and I spoke to people according to the Qur'an's command "And as for thy Lord's favor, proclaim it." When this knowledge appeared great in their eyes, coming from one who had not received [conventional authority], it became difficult for them, thus causing dissension among people.

In summary, I believe in this religion letter by letter—whoever adds or removes a letter from it is not of me and I am innocent of him. Indeed, this bounty which God bestowed upon me is a great bounty through which the differences between stations became clear, if one of insight looks upon it with the eye of fairness. I make no novel claim, neither in Reality nor in Religious Law. God is witness between me and all, and He will judge between all on the Day of Resurrection concerning that wherein they differed.

On the meaning of His exalted words

As for what you asked about the meaning of His exalted words "We are nearer to him than his jugular vein" and the reality of nearness to God in all stations, know that the Divine Essence has ever been and nothing was with Him, nor does He have any attribute in His creation. Names and attributes are cut off from His presence, and signs and tokens fall short of the nearness of His majestic Self-Subsistence. He is as He is—none knows how He is except Him. All names are signs of His Will and all verses are indications of His power. When it was known that none could attain to knowledge of His Essence or draw near to His Being, He manifested Himself to all through all according to the ultimate outpouring of His creation, and attributed this manifestation to Himself, as nothing else was possible in the contingent realm, so that those who seek might find solace in the appearance of the signs of His Will, and those who yearn might find essence in the manifestation of the stations of His power.

The Pre-eternal has ever been and will never be associated with His servants, nor is there in His rank any mention of other than Him, such that I might mention the decree of His nearness. His nearness in every condition has been equal, without mention or association with anything in the contingent realm. He is nearer to everything than nearness itself, for He has ever been, His relationship to all that He has created is like His relationship to that which He has not created, and this is the hidden mystery in this matter. There are many aspects to this in the stations of the divine Command and in God's purposes which are in your heart, whereby you recognize His oneness, know Him, fear Him, and hope for His reward. This pertains to the station of creation.

Among these is the reference to the dawning-places of the Command and the repositories of wisdom—the Imams of the Faith and Guides of all creation—those servants whom God has chosen for Himself, selected for His Cause, and established in the station of authority from His presence. All that is attributed to Him of knowledge, obedience, disobedience and ignorance—they are closer to all created things than their own selves. The Imams of the Faith in every condition have an equal relationship to all things, for in every state they are the manifestations of nearness. In the uttermost station of remoteness they are nearest, and in the uttermost station of nearness they are in the Greatest Vista where no vision but their own can perceive them and no mind but theirs can know them. They are beyond the stations of manifestation and sanctified above the mention of names and concealment. Glorified be God, their Creator, above what they describe.

And among these, when you wish to understand the reality of this matter, consider for each chain of the eight chains the decree of nearness beside which all else is non-existent, though all degrees of nearness to you are equal. But one who gazes upon the Lord of the earth knows the decree of nearness through spiritual perception. The decrees of that nearness can only be known through primordial vision and the

gaze of the heart. That which is nearest, which nothing equals, is that which is most remote, which nothing knows. This is the station of the Point in all the worlds, expressed in the station of the Muhammadan Reality—neither has the sun of creation risen through creation, nor has the sun of invention set through invention.

Then the station of the flexible alif, which is the station of Ali's nearness to you. Then the station of the hidden alif when released returns to flexibility—this is the station of Hasan's nearness. Then the station of the extended alif, which is the station of the Qa'im's nearness to you. Then the station of the letters, which is the station of nearness of the Imams, may God's blessings be upon them. Then the station of the gathering of letters which form the Word, which is the station of Fatima's nearness, may God's blessings be upon her. Then the station of the Word's indicative trace, which is the station of nearness of the Prophets and Messengers according to their ranks and various stations.

Then the station of nearness of the Shi'ih leaders of justice according to what God has ordained for them in the signs of His Cause and the purposes of its seal. This rank has many stations which one endowed with spiritual perception knows through the light of reality. Likewise you know the decree in the station of relationship and purpose of drawing near.

What is meant by drawing near is the aspect of pure, absolute unity which indicates God, glorified be He. The servant is obligated in the station of all deeds, movements, intentions and ends to act solely for God alone, not associating any description or attribute in His worship. Whoever desires pure nearness must enter the depths of oneness revealed in the words of Ali, peace be upon him, when he said, glorified be his mention: "Lord, cause me to enter the depth of Thy oneness and the ocean of Thy unity." And verily, most men, in the plane of reality, behold not the Real; for were they upon the pure Straight Path wherein no trace of association is mentioned, it would be otherwise. For the speaker hath not beheld God; hence his deed—and even his own self—worketh not for God in utter purity, nor doth he set in motion the intention of drawing nigh unto Him. This is the creed of the Christians—exalted is God above what they allege—inasmuch as they have said: "God is the third of three."

Verily, should one act in such wise that he beholdeth not God, nor observeth in his deeds aught save Him, then hath he acted with pure devotion unto God, and the decree of drawing nigh unto Him is established in his deeds. Otherwise, the intention of drawing nigh is impossible save through the remembrance of that station and acting in accordance therewith. This is indeed a matter most difficult and arduous, which none can bear save by God's leave.

If thou wouldst but purify thy sight, thou wouldst perceive polytheism in many deeds. Nay, the station of drawing nigh is the station of divine manifestation, which none can know save through the Manifestation Himself. It behooveth the servant to act for God along this path, for without it none can enter the depths of divine unity. This is the ultimate decree concerning the outpouring of contingent being in the realm of created things. None can attain the station of justice and the summit of grace save through pure devotion and constant steadfastness.

It is incumbent upon all to act in no wise save for God and in His love. When one acteth upon this luminous path and crimson sign, he hath indeed worshipped God with the utmost bounty which God hath

promised him in the Book. Thus did the Imam, peace be upon him, indicate in the station of worship, saying: "O Hisham! The word Allah' is derived from ilah', and ilah' requireth one who is worshipped. The name is other than the named. He who worshippeth the name without the reality hath indeed disbelieved and worshipped naught. He who worshippeth both the name and the reality hath indeed committed polytheism and worshipped two. But he who worshippeth the reality without the name—this is true unity.

Dost thou understand, O Hisham?" He said: "Tell me more." The Imam continued: "God hath ninety-nine names. Were the name identical with the named, each name would be a god. But God […] these names, and they are all other than He. O Hisham! Bread' is the name for that which is eaten, water' is the name for that which is drunk, garment' is the name for that which is worn, and ʿfire' is the name for that which burns. Dost thou understand, O Hisham?" Hisham said: "By God! None hath ever vanquished me in the matter of Divine Unity since I took my stand in this station; for this—verily—is the meaning of nearness in the realms of beings and essences, of substances and materials, of the soul and the ego, and of the tokens and allusions."

In this, […] is the cause of its mention; otherwise there is no path for anyone unto the nearness of the Essence, nor any theophany issuing from the station of the indications of the attributes. Sufficient is the mention of these words as an answer to that question for him who possesseth knowledge of the beginning and the end.

On His saying "The All-Merciful sat Himself upon the Throne"

As to that which thou didst ask concerning His saying—exalted be He: "The All-Merciful sat Himself upon the Throne"—the Throne hath many applications. There is a Throne in the station of Will, and He Who is established thereon is ʿAli—peace be upon him. There is a Throne in the station of Decree (Qadar), and He Who is established thereon is Hasan—peace be upon him. There is a Throne in the station of Determination (Qada'), and He Who is established thereon is Husayn—peace be upon him. There is a Throne in the station of Permission (Idhn), and She Who is established thereon is Fatimah—may God's blessings rest upon her. There is a Throne in the station of the Term (Ajal), and He Who is established thereon is Ja'far, son of Muhammad—peace be upon them both. There is a Throne in the station of the Book (Kitab), and He Who is established thereon is Musa, son of Ja'far—peace be upon them both. And there is a Throne in the degrees of substances; a Throne in the indications of materials; a Throne in the signs of beings; and a Throne in the tokens of essences.

Indeed, in every station—from the farthest limit of the inception of act—doth the application of the name "Throne" hold true, even unto the uttermost bounds of dust; as the Imam alluded: "Whoso visiteth Husayn—knowing [his right]—it is as one who hath visited God upon His Throne." And the bearer of glad-tidings, in the ordinance of mention, is that he become the very eye of the thing whereof he beareth glad-tidings; and that earth is a throne in the station of dust.

And the one who gazes upon the Lord of heaven and attributes, were he to purify his vision and refine his perspective and extend his hand, would know the signs of the people of the Bayan in the stations of the Command, the manifestations of wisdom, the revelations of pure truth, the signs of justice, the stations

of grace, and what God has ordained beyond that in all stations from infinity unto that which has no end. And if you were to apply the Throne in the rank of Will, none is established upon it save itself, and naught can be attributed to its station except its own essence. But beneath that rank, if applied to the station of Purpose, it is fitting that what is established upon it be Purpose itself, until the Command descends from the origins of action to the ultimate ends which God has ordained in His knowledge.

And what has been related in the traditions that those who bear the Throne were four from the first ones and four from the last ones is the truth, for when the seven stations are gathered together they form a comprehensive image, as God has indicated in His Book: "And eight shall bear the Throne of thy Lord above them that Day." This indeed is the reality of the mystery, and the Command must needs be thus in all worlds. And God has assigned to each pillar of the Throne a light: from the first pillar, bearing the name of God "the Constrictor," which is the color white, and from it all things in contingent existence become white; and from the second pillar, bearing the name of God "the Ever-Living," which is yellow in color, and from it all things in creation become yellow; and from the third pillar, bearing the name of God "the Life-Giver," which is green, and from it all things in existence become green; and from the fourth pillar, bearing the name of God "the Death-Giver," and from it all things in the ranks of souls and horizons become red.

And if all that God has created in contingent existence were to be made an interpretation of the word "Throne"… but God… in manifestation except some purifications which are in the station of inner meaning. And if you were to make the All-Merciful the station of the Essence, conjunction would be necessary. And if the people of the Bayan desired to… in the station of the Essence, they would interpret the Throne only as Knowledge, and likewise you know the wisdom of the Names and Attributes if the interpreters desire to interpret the Word with the most excellent exposition in clear evidence. And the bearer of the name of the All-Merciful in the station of Divine Authority is Ali, and he is my spirit, and those in the kingdom of Command and Creation… established upon the throne of bestowal to all things, and he is the giver to each of its right, and the driver of sustenance to all things, and God encompasses all from behind; nay, it is a glorious Qur'an in a preserved tablet.

On the movement of the celestial spheres being by way

And regarding what you asked about the movement of the celestial spheres being by way of free will, there is no doubt that God, hallowed and exalted be He, created nothing with free will save after the manner of the primal creation in the rank of the Divine Will [mashiyyat]. Nor can any thing be clothed with the robe of existence except through its acceptance thereof. Such is the ordinance governing all the conditions of the servant. Even as thou, at every instant, art in need of a fresh effusion from God for thine own being, so likewise, for all thy states, thou standest in need of that which the Book of thy Lord doth enumerate.

And concerning that which thou hast mentioned regarding free will—how can it not be evident to one who gazeth with the eye of insight and witnesseth with the glance of truth? Consider thyself: thou performest an action of thine own free will, yet once done thou canst not reverse it. If thou shouldst act otherwise, would not the same hold true? The celestial spheres move by God's leave according to their

own volition, even as He hath decreed man's lifespan which he cannot alter. This returneth to the station of free will, for without knowledge of the reality of the matter, the servant cannot comprehend the truth of the matter.

And concerning thy question about the permanence of the denizens of the fire in the fire, and how a servant could choose punishment despite possessing reason both in origin and return, when all know they have freedom to choose reward and have the power for it: Know that the reality of these matters cannot be explained except through knowledge of destiny and the mystery of what is ordained. For God hath knowledge of the free will of all created things and what their hands have wrought in the kingdom of names and attributes, and He hath rewarded them according to their qualities from the time of their creation. The question posed at "Am I not your Lord?" was none other than its own answer.

Most philosophers who sought to understand this matter established measures of comprehension and distinction, yet failed to explain its reality, for the mind can only perceive things within limits and cannot grasp the meaning of "neither compulsion nor delegation, but a position between the two" except through the vision of the heart, which can hold in a single thing and moment opposing aspects. No doubt is there that God did not compel the servants, at the moment of creation, to [accept] existence; rather did He proffer it unto them. Whoso accepted, him did God bring into being; and whoso turned away, him did God consign to the station of rejection.

Now, that which occurreth to the heart of man is this: if, at the presentation of existence, he were conscious and endowed with reason, how could he choose unbelief? And if he were not conscious, how could obligation be laid upon him by the All-Gentle Lord—exalted be His remembrance? In this lieth the cause of the soul's misgivings and of the servant's failure to melt in the knowledge of the inner meanings.

Verily, that by which the servant attaineth knowledge in the station of Reality removeth doubt in the station of the Law. For the cause of choice, at the time when his own existence was as the existence of all else, is that the very Essence wherein God originated the Divine Will was naught but itself: no origination save itself, no affair of existence but from itself, and no precedence save through itself. Even so is the ordinance in every degree: the existence of a thing, in the choosing to accept a thing, is only by itself.

And God, indeed, doeth whatsoever He willeth by His command; while the servant doeth whatsoever he willeth by the power and might of his Lord—each according to measure. [Thus, too, it is:] the servant in this world knoweth that wine, when drunk, altereth his state through intoxication; he knoweth as well God's decree of fire on the Day of Resurrection; yet, thereafter, he drinketh. Such is the judgment in the beginnings of causes and the primal Covenant: that the servant, after attaining certitude that the recompense of disbelief is everlasting fire, still accepteth and saith, "I care not."

And as hath been stated: how can the "chooser" be meant by abiding in the Fire, seeing that the cause of his abiding is his very act of acceptance? Let none confuse the matter by saying, "Were I certain of the Fire I would neither choose it nor enter therein." Nay, in the station of the beginnings of causes there is for thee a corporeal fire; and if, in that station, the servant uttereth but the single letter "No (la)," that letter, at the furthest limit of descent, becometh for him the Fire of Hell. Therefore when this is realized, he cannot escape therefrom, even though in reality the disbeliever cannot endure in the fire if he were to

look with truth, nor can he judge himself except by that which God hath judged for him, for the cause of that fire was his own acceptance thereof, as with all else.

These signs will lead thee to the station of true knowledge, so render thanks unto God, thy Lord, for He is the Truth in both beginning and return. Otherwise, ask of His grace that He may open unto thee the gate of the heart, for without the light of that consciousness the servant cannot conceive how contradictory attributes may exist in a single thing—how, despite the presence of reason, the servant would accept the fire. No one can know his Lord while turning away from His decree. Yea, as We have made known to thee, this is the pure command and the established balance, for God hath created all things as they should be according to their capacity, and the judgment of what a thing is in its own station is naught but what it actually is, since the answer is identical with the question itself in all contingent realms, from beginning to end. Ask thou about the knowledge of these signs from him who hath recognized the true attributes in the decrees of the beginning and the return.

On the meaning "nor is there anyone equal unto Him"

And concerning what thou didst ask about the meaning of "nor is there anyone equal unto Him," there is no doubt that He hath ever been and naught existed with Him besides Himself, and verily now it is likewise […] there is none like unto Him nor equal unto Him. The meaning of "anyone equal unto Him" is true sanctification and glorification, like unto the stations revealed in the Book and Tradition. In form there are two names for that wherein a partner with the Creator might be imagined, and certain aspects of the cycle which pertain to creation. God, glorified be He, hath mentioned in the Book for the purpose of dispelling delusions and sweeping clean the hearts—otherwise in reality there is no mention of God in contingent existence, neither in the station of affirming attributes nor in the station of sanctifying His glory. And verily such words are identical to "Take not two gods. There is only one God, so fear ye Me." There is no doubt that there cannot be two gods, and God hath revealed these words to nullify the forms of the prison, even though in reality He hath never mentioned any god besides Himself, nor any likeness, nor any equal.

He is the Exalted, like unto Whom there is nothing in the heavens or on earth. Nothing escapeth His knowledge and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed.

BB00064: Tablet to Mirza Sa'id Ardistani on Basitatu'l-Haqiqah, qadim wa hadith

Part 1: "Praise be to God Who hath created…"

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who hath created in the essences of creation the signs of His power's manifestation, that all beings might know Him through His revelation unto them of the signs of His eternality, and might acknowledge His unity through that which His Essence hath testified of Itself from time immemorial—that there is no God but Him, the Single, the One, Whom no description can describe, no attribute can qualify, with Whom nothing can be mentioned, and to Whose station none can ascend, nor can anything be

mentioned in His rank. Glorified and exalted is He! He hath ever been without change and will ever be; He existeth as He hath always existed. He hath no likeness in His Essence nor peer in His attributes.

Glorified and exalted is He! He hath brought forth Will for the existence of essences, Purpose for the determination of quiddities, Destiny for the ordering of beings, Decree for the manifestation of meanings in essential realities, and Permission, Term, and Book for the perfection of capacities in the realm of concrete existence—that all might know, through mention of these ranks, the truth of the Manifestations of His sanctity and the signs of His uniqueness in the kingdom of names and attributes, and whatsoever God hath ordained in the knowledge of ultimate ends and purposes unto infinity in the rank of essences, until it reacheth the station of dust.

Praise be to God Who hath created the essential realities of existing things for the manifestation of His power's traces in creation, that all atoms might witness, in the stations God hath ordained for them, the light of His countenance, the manifestation of His will, and the signs of His all-sustaining power—that there is no God but Him, the Mighty, the Most High.

To continue: When His Honor the pious Siyyid and trusted, pure support—may God perpetuate his grace upon him and cause him to attain his ultimate desires in matters both spiritual and temporal—inquired regarding three intricate questions which had confounded minds from comprehending and before which the feet of certain philosophers had slipped in their exposition, he sought asisstance from God through following His command, for he desired naught save knowledge of the truth of exposition through what God hath placed in existence made manifest to sight. And I say: There is no power nor strength save in God, the Most High, the Most Great.

It is evident that the essential meanings of knowledge cannot be grasped through the words of those who engage in disputation, for the reality in the understanding of such questions is the removal of veils from the sacred court of the Divine Majesty without reference to separation or connection, even as Ali told Kumayl ibn Ziyad an-Nakha'i when asked about reality, saying: "The removal of veils of glory without indication." Then he said, "Tell me more," and Ali replied: "The effacement of the imagined and the dawning of the known." He asked for more, and Ali said: "The rending of the veil due to the triumph of the mystery." Again he asked for more, and Ali said: "The attraction of Divine Unity to the quality of Oneness." He asked for more, and Ali said: "A light shining from the morn of eternity upon the temples of unity through its traces."

I have indeed explained the intimations of this tradition in its proper place, though this is not the occasion for exposition. I have mentioned it regarding the understanding of true exposition, for certain questions cannot be comprehended by the servant except after the removal of veils and barriers, and the subjection of the soul to the spiritual disciplines mentioned in the sacred texts, for the soul is in the station of nature. And one must enter the depths of divine unity, concerning which Ali said:

> "Lord, cause me to enter into the depth of the sea of Thy unity and the ocean of Thy oneness,"

that one might be enabled, if God willeth, to perceive the realities of knowledge as they are.

Therefore hath God lifted from the servants the obligation to comprehend sciences which they are unable to grasp, such as the knowledge of divine decree, whereof when the Imam was asked, he said: “A deep ocean without shore.” When asked a second time, he said: “A dark night—ask not!” Then when asked a third time, he said: “None knoweth it save the Knowing One, or he whom He hath taught.” And thus spoke that tradition from ʿAli—may my spirit and all within the kingdom of command and creation be a sacrifice for him—where he said: “Destiny is a secret among God’s secrets, and a sanctuary among His sanctuaries, raised up in God’s veil, folded away from God’s creation, sealed with God’s seal, foreordained in God’s knowledge.

God hath relieved His servants of its knowledge and lifted it above their witness and the reach of their minds, for they cannot attain it through Divine Reality, nor comprehend it through Eternal Truth, nor through Luminous Grandeur, nor through Mighty Oneness. It is a surging, billowing ocean, pure for God, the Mighty and Glorious. Its depth is between heaven and earth, its breadth between East and West, black as darkest night, full of serpents and fish, rising at times and sinking at others. At its bottom is a sun that shineth—none should seek to discover it save the One, the Single. Whoso seeketh to discover it hath opposed God, the Mighty and Glorious, in His decree, and disputed His sovereignty, and unveiled His secret and His veil. Such shall incur God’s wrath, his abode shall be hell—an evil destination.”

When thou didst witness the matter in the essentials of knowledge through what was recited unto thee of traditions shining from the suns of grandeur, there is no doubt that these questions are among the complexities of wisdom whose reality cannot be discerned through the analogies of the Greek philosophers. But God, through His grace, taught me true knowledge through the nature of faith without instruction or explanation. I shall indicate it through a proof of wisdom whereby questions are established at the ultimate station of mystical knowledge, and it concerns the “Simple Reality” which the philosophers have advanced to prove an existence betwixt the existent and the nonexistent—verily this is, beyond doubt, false in the sight of whoso inhale the fragrance of fairness and weigh with conclusive proofs.

Among these proofs is reason itself, which testifieth that the Eternal Essence hath none beside Him and possesseth no attributes distinct in meaning from His very Essence; otherwise, there would ensue composition, conjunction, change, and separation. For the existence of the Pre-Eternal is His very Self and none other; and the existence of created things is His origination of them, a bringing-forth from naught and not from aught beneath Him. There is thus no escape for him who asserteth the contrary save to confess either the pre-eternity of multiplicities within the Essence, or the descent of the Essence unto the rank of dust—both a sheer impossibility and utter absurdity. For the Essence hath never descended, nor is there, within His station, any mention of other than He. He is the Truth; whatsoever is besides Him is creation—His creation—and there is no third besides these twain.

That which hath confounded the philosophers is their mention of the immutable archetypes within the Essence and their discourse on the Simple Reality: it springeth, exalted be He, from their saying that knowledge must needs have an object of knowledge; and when knowledge is established, the multiplicities within the Essence are thereby established. Exalted is God, the Sovereign, the All-Just! Their creed is naught but analogy; they would fain know the Essence by likening Him to the creation of the

possibles. Far exalted is God above that! For the knowledge of God is His Essence, His life is His Essence, and His power is His Essence. Even so is the ruling concerning the Names which are mentioned for the sake of His dominion over hearts and imaginings, without any change in the conceptual meaning thereof.

And since it hath been established that His Essence is His Life—and Life, in itself, requireth not the existence of any other living thing—so likewise is the decree concerning Knowledge: glorified be He! He was, in the pre-eternity of pre-eternities, All-Knowing, without the existence of an object known. Whoso maketh a distinction, within the Essence, between Life and Knowledge hath verily strayed, for within the Essence there is no differentiation—according to the purport of the tradition recorded in al-Kafi, wherein the Imam declared: "God, exalted and glorified, hath ever been Lord; Knowledge is His very Essence without an object known; Hearing is His Essence without an object heard; and Sight is His Essence without an object seen; and power is His essence with nothing over which to exercise power.

When He brought things into being, knowledge occurred between Him and the known, hearing between Him and the heard, sight between Him and the seen, and power between Him and that over which power was exercised." I asked, "Has God then ever been in motion?" He replied, "Exalted be God! Motion is an attribute brought into being through action." I asked, "Has God then ever been speaking?" He replied, "Speech is a created attribute, not eternal. God, exalted be His glory, existed when He was not speaking. God in every condition knew all things as He knows them on the day when those things were not yet mentioned, and none knoweth how this is save God, glorified be He. This is evidence of the intellect witnessed by those possessed of understanding among His servants."

The signs in the horizons and within themselves confirm this judgment, for weakness is ever manifest in all atoms of existence. Were the Essence the Simple Reality for multiplicities, nothing would exist save His own manifestation, yet intuition testifies to the falsity of this through the limitations of creation, their weakness, and their need for the Bountiful Source. The explicit text of the Qur'an confirms this in His exalted words, after refuting the Christians' "third of three," that "He is but one God." For he who claims the Simple Reality removes numbers from the realm of limitations, and this is false like the Christians' claim, for in the Essence of the One nothing else is mentioned nor is there any other with Him. This accords with the tradition of the Prophet, peace be upon Him, where He said—exalted be His remembrance—in refutation of the Christians: "From this the Christians took the form of the cross and the indwelling of the divine in human nature. Exalted be God far above what the wrongdoers say, with great exaltation!" When thou hast understood what I have detailed in these allusions, thou wilt believe in the truth of the answer regarding the station of discourse.

As for thy question concerning the matter of eternity and origination, there is no doubt that the Eternal Essence's eternity was His Self and His everlastingness was His Essence, and there was none other with Him such that His eternity could be described. Names and attributes are cut off from His holy court, and traces are effaced from ascending to the station of His grandeur. All that His creation witnesseth and His servants know is from the portion of creation and the quality of invention. He is far more glorious and great than to be described by His creation or characterized by His servants. Glorified and exalted be He above what they describe!

When the existence of the Eternal Essence is established through His own existence and not through any other—as indicated by "O Thou Who hast proven Thy Essence by Thy Essence!"—then the existence of originated things is established through creation itself, not from anything else. It has four ranks:

Among them is the rank of manifest eternity [Azal] in the First Remembrance and manifest pre-existence in the station of action, which is the station God made in creation for the station of knowing through inference about the eternity of His Essence and His pre-existence, as Ali said: "I am the possessor of the secondary eternity," and said in describing the Messenger of God—peace be upon Him—in the sermon of Friday and Ghadir: "And I bear witness that Muhammad is His servant and His Messenger, whom He selected from the midst of pre-existence above all nations, distinct from similarity with humankind and likeness. He established him in His own station in views, since eyes cannot perceive Him nor can thoughts of minds encompass Him, while He taketh in all vision. Verily He is the subtle, the all-perceiving."

Part 2: "And among the stations is the Station…"

And among the stations is the Station of Sarmad, which is the plane of the manifestation of the Act that has no beginning except from itself and no end save for the perpetuity of God's effulgence in all conditions. This is the realm of the fourteen veils, and none has any portion in the reality of the world of Sarmad except Muhammad and the Family of God. It was to this station that I alluded on the previous night to one who asked about the question of traversing the earth in a single moment and place, whereupon those present acknowledged their lack of understanding of that station after the explanation, due to the subtlety of the question and the inability of capacities to grasp the essences in understanding the exposition after its elucidation.

And among them is the world of Dahr, which has a beginning but no end.

And among them is the world of Zaman [time], which is known by the bounds of firstness and lastness in terms of hour, day, month and year, for it results from the motion of the celestial spheres and nothing else. These are aspects of origination which cannot be separated from these four, and the proof of origination is creation itself ex nihilo, for nothing else is possible in origination, nor is there any evidence in the First Mention which is the Primal Will, apart from the act of bringing into being, for the Pure Ancient Being has ever been and will never be associated with His creation.

The beginning of origination is the first creation which God created for Himself by Himself without any mention of aught else accompanying it. And all existence, both invisible and visible, is evidence of the origination of the greater world due to its limitations and variations. There is no doubt about this in actual reality, for the Divine Essence did not bring forth the effulgence by choice, and the cause of choice in all ranks of existence is the very existence of choice itself and nothing else. This is the mystery of destiny which is vaster than what lies between the heaven of potentialities and the earth of effects.

What I have mentioned regarding pre-existence and origination is from the station of limitations. What I intended to explain to you is Essential Pre-existence and the origination which philosophers deduce from the causality of pre-existence. This differs from what the heart knows, for Essential Pre-existence which has ever been existed in a mode where nothing was with it, nothing accompanied it, and nothing was

mentioned at its level. It is the pre-existence of the Essence of Eternity which is by itself, without anything being mentioned with it or any multiplicity existing in the simplicity of its essence.

Exalted is God above what the philosophers say in claiming that the cause of origination is the pre-existence of the Essence, thereby attempting to establish a connection between the True One and the contingent, and to prove the existence of fixed archetypes through the pure subtlety of simplicity in the Essence. The doctrine of the People of Infallibility differs from this, for the pre-existence of the Essence has ever been and will never be associated with anything, nor is anything equal to it, nor is anything mentioned at its level such that it could be the cause of multiplicities. For the condition of causality requires association, similarity, and mention at the level of the effect, and this is impossible and inadmissible at the level of the Pure Absolute Essence in which there is no mention of anything of His creation. Rather, He brought the world of origination into being through His creation of the First Remembrance.

The philosophers were perplexed in their discussion of pure nothingness in relation to creation and its connection to the pre-existence of the Divine Essence, but this stems from the limitations of their vision which cannot perceive the true reality of things. Had they known His knowledge as they knew His Essence and Life, without altering the meaning of what is understood, the path would not have been difficult for them. For God has detailed the laws of all things through His universal manifestations in the souls and His particular revelations in the horizons.

For one possessed of insight in the knowledge of essences, they would witness with the light of the heart that pure nothingness which has no existence—like a partner to the Creator—has no mention, cannot be indicated, nor can the decree of creation apply to it. That which can be indicated are shadowy forms which God has commanded to turn away from, being in reality the falsehood of souls and the sweepings of vain imaginings. Rather, the nothingness from which God created things is the non-existence that is mentioned in the station of knowledge after existence, whereas absolute pure nothingness has no name nor existence.

What has been mentioned in the traditions is like referring to negation after affirmation, which is the thing itself and nothing less. This is evident before you and needs no elaboration of the matter, for explaining the mystery of reality does not avail in any regard.

As for what you asked about the meaning of the philosophers' statement that "the One's understanding is impossible" when referring to the pure Divine Essence—this is because God has never been and will never be associated with anything nor does anything emanate from Him. His attribute has been that He begets not nor is He begotten in every aspect. However, if what is meant is the First which God created by Himself for Himself, this is true, for nothing less than oneness can reflect the unity of the Essence. This is the doctrine of God's pure Family, as indicated in His exalted words: "O Yunus, do you know the Will?" He said "No." He said "It is the First Remembrance."

God cannot create anything from nothing except that it be one, for the station of the First Remembrance is the sign of unity, and nothing less is possible in the beginning of abstraction. The philosophers' statement that the cause of things is the Essence is false due to impossibility of association, change, and

the requirement of similarity between cause and effect. The truth is that Causation is the handiwork of God—the act which He hath wrought by Himself for Himself—and He hath made it the cause of all His creation; even as the Imam hath indicated: "The cause of all things is His workmanship, while He Himself hath no cause." This is proclaimed by all the signs of the horizons and of the souls, and by the verses of the Book.

For the "one" that proceedeth from the One is a "one" known through twoness, and this would necessitate a third; by reason of the gulf thus posited the claim is vain. From the One, Who is pure origination, there can issue none but the First Remembrance. There is no bringer-into-being in existence, nor creator in the realm of being, save God alone. And even as the servant is charged to confess the oneness of the Essence, so is he likewise charged to confess His oneness in the realms of attributes, acts, and worship; without this, the works of men are not accepted.

As for the First Remembrance—which is the loftiest degree of simplicity—his existence must needs be viewed in relation to the four causes: the efficient, the formal, the material, and the final. Apart from the modes of composition, origination in the realm of coming-to-be is impossible; for a thing requireth a fiery element for the manifestation of its existence, air and water for its preservation, and earth for the receptivity of those degrees. Wherefore, when the Command descended, it became seven, and thus did the Imam say:

> "Nothing exists, neither in earth nor in heaven, save through these seven: Will, Purpose, Destiny, Decree, Eternity, Duration, and the Book. Whoso asserteth the absence of any one of these hath verily disbelieved."

And after these indications, there can be no doubt that the thoughts of the people of glory shall not remain in thy mind. And though no one hath become acquainted with the reality of these sciences, it behooveth him to submit, for the non-comprehension of a thing doth not prove its non-existence. I beseech God's pardon through His grace, and from thee also, shouldst thou discover any error from my pen. Unto God returneth all judgment, both in the Hereafter and in this world.

As for what thou didst mention regarding the philosophers' maxim that "from the One proceedeth naught but one," this pertaineth to the outward path. As to the inner meanings, there is no doubt that the Eternal Essence cannot be associated with His creation so as to become the source of things. Even if this matter were established in wisdom, it would pertain to the realm of creation, for the cause of Will—as is indeed the truth—was not the Eternal Essence, lest unity be necessitated in the realm of contingency. Exalted be God, the Bountiful King! He hath made the source of the One to be the One itself, and from the One proceedeth naught but One, for the first mention of creation is the station of Oneness, and naught can proceed from it save the One.

Those who say that the cause of the existence of the One in creation is the Essence—exalted be His mention—have no recourse but to assert change, as though God had one state before creating all things and another state after existence, or to assert the eternity of contingency within the Eternal Essence, which is among the established impossibilities whose invalidity they fail to perceive. The truth is that none hath access to the Eternal Essence, Who hath ever been in the state of eternity. Nothing accompanieth

Him, nothing proceedeth from Him, nothing equalleth His Essence, and nothing separateth from His Command. Rather, He created the One through itself and for itself, and made it the cause for the existence of all beings, without beginning or end.

True knowledge of this matter is impossible save through what I have indicated in that station, and this is through the vision of the heart and naught else, for the intellect can only grasp that which is limited. In the world of limitations, the servant cannot perceive multiple aspects of a thing simultaneously. Hence, it is difficult for hearts to comprehend this station, and none can know the reality of the matter between the two matters except after arriving at the gate of the heart and beholding the decrees of the unseen and the visible.

When one becometh steadfast in understanding that from the One proceedeth naught but One in the station of creation—and most philosophers have attributed causation to the Essence due to their ignorance of the manifestations of the attributes, as the Imam indicated when he said:

> "My God, Thy power hath become manifest, but Thy majesty hath remained hidden. Thus have they missed Thee and taken some of Thy signs as lords"

- and when the servant recognizeth the station of God's revelation to him through Him, he will testify that as nothing entereth into Him, nothing proceedeth from Him. He is the Self-Sufficient, the Ever-Living, the Self-Subsisting, Who created the One through the One and ordained the law of the simple reality for the First Mention, wherein all possibilities are mentioned, making it the first eternal mention in temporal existence, and ordained for it all that is possible through creation in the station of being.

Thus far have I taken up the pen in its flow, and I seek God's pardon for what I have mentioned to thy noble person—may God cause thee to attain the ultimate of thy desires from the decrees of thy beginning to the Day of Return.

Glory be to thy Lord, the Lord of Might, above what they attribute to Him. And peace be upon His Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00114: Tafsiri-i-Hadith-i-'Allamani Akhi Rasulu'llah

Part 1: "Praise be to God Who has inspired those…"

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who has inspired those in the heavens and earth with wisdom, lest anyone be veiled from the appearance of the light of His Countenance which He has deposited in the stations of Command and the purposes of creation. All things behold Him manifest and present, for verily there is no God but Him, the Mighty, the Exalted.

And praise be to God Who created the Primal Will before all existences, by itself and for itself, for the manifestation of the signs of His oneness in the stations of unity, that all might know how God has

revealed Himself to them through them in the essences of their beings and the realities of their true selves, for He is the Single, the One, the Self-Subsisting.

He has ever been, while nothing existed in the realm of possibility, and He will ever be what He has been, without mention of anything in existence. For His Essence is the pure Essence from which all names and attributes are severed in the sacred precincts of His might, and all allusions are forbidden from the station of recognition of His holy Self-Subsistence.

Whosoever knows Him through the knowledge of anything has associated something with Him and taken falsely another god, for as He is in the might of His Identity and the majesty of His Oneness, He has no attribute save His Presence, no description save His Essence, no likeness among things, and no mention in creation. All that is known except Him is but the limitation of itself, and all that invention describes is but an aspect of what God has ordained in its rank.

Glorified and exalted is He! None knows how He is or how He creates what He wishes except Him. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe.

Thereafter, when the honored Governor of the Friends—may God grant him the ultimate of his desires from the beginning to the Day of Return—asked about the meaning of the tradition which he related from Ali, peace be upon him, wherein he said:

> "My brother, the Messenger of God, taught me the knowledge of what was, and I taught him the knowledge of what will be."

Though I have not seen this tradition in the well-known books, since its meaning accords with reality, there is no doubt it is truth with God.

And when I promised to answer him, I sought God's help to explain what God wished to reveal of the hidden inner meanings of His traces from the unseen to the visible. Know that God created the Primal Will before all things and made it at the time of existence its own cause, not anything else, for it is the First Remembrance about which the Imam, peace be upon him, said to Yunus when asked "Do you know what the Primal Will is?" He said "No." Then Ali said "It is the First Remembrance."

Indeed God, through His subtle wisdom and mighty craftsmanship, has placed within it the sign of His Self-Subsistence, that it might indicate His unity in every aspect. It has seven aspects through which nothing can be clothed with existence except through them. This is the rank of the Primal Will which we express in the highest sense as the First Remembrance, with which nothing else is mentioned.

It continues eternally in the highest station as the Creator which was manifested to it at the beginning of its creation as a sign of the appearance of His Self-Subsistence, a mirror reflecting His Countenance of Eternality, and a geometry for the manifestation of His sovereignty. It is the sign for which God has made no beginning except the perpetuity of His grace, and no end except in itself. It has ever drawn from God, by itself and for itself, in all ranks of the unseen and visible realms, and it has no exhaustion.

It is the sign that indicates the Oneness of the Essence. God has made its outward appearance identical to its inner reality, its beginning identical to its end, and its secret identical to its public aspect. It has no

likeness, for all else exists through the manifestation of its creation from nothing, demonstrating the power of its Originator. Glory be to Him and exalted is He! How mighty is His power and how great is His beneficence that cannot be known.

In the First Mention there is but one Word, and it is He, and all names are but signs of the manifestation of this station, and in reality there is no mention of aught else besides it, for whatever else might be mentioned before it or mentioned at its level would not be befitting that Focal Point. All that those who make mention have mentioned in description of that Focal Point is naught but its description through its manifestation at the level of that thing. This is witnessed by those who have known the venues of the Cause and have become aware of the ultimate purposes of the Seal and have beheld the mystery of eternity in the station of servitude. Beyond this station there is no further purpose possible, nor is there any mention before it save what God alone knows of its wisdom, glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

When the mention of the supreme point of the Will was established, reference was made to mention of its identity which is named the Purpose, and it is the station of the Second Mention wherein appeareth the focal point of the mention of creation within creative bounds and naught else. And in that focal point is mentioned the very station of the Most Exalted which is the station of Ali in the world of manifestation, as He, exalted be His mention, hath indicated in the verse of Mutual Invocation: “our selves and your selves,” where by consensus of both parties what is meant by “self” is Ali and none other. Through that station appeareth the focal point of connection which is Destiny, which is the source of multiplicities and infinitudes. Through the existence of Purpose exists all that existeth in possibility. Therefore hath the Truth referred to the absolute outpouring in His utterance regarding the teaching of the Messenger of God—peace be upon Him—“He knew what was,” for there was naught but knowledge through the manifestation of the Will which ever was and besides which there was naught else.

In such wise doth wisdom require that Ali, who teacheth the station of the Primal Will should possess knowledge of that which is to be; for before mention was made there was not what would be such that He should know it. And when the mention of purpose was established, the mention of the place of all created things became assured. Wherefore the Messenger of God—may the blessings of God rest upon Him—knoweth, through Alí, the knowledge of that which shall come to pass, each thing according to its rank, in the degrees which God hath ordained for them in the knowledge of the unseen.

For knowledge, in very truth—as the People of Truth maintain—is itself the thing known; even as Sadiq hath intimated in the tradition of al-Mufaddal, that knowledge is the full consummation of the known, and that power and might are the full consummation of the act. And whensoever the words of wisdom are not complete in their outward appearance and complete in their inward reality, wisdom itself is not complete in the wise man, though he be powerful. This, verily, is the secret of the root of existence and the point of all that existeth—nor can any one interpret that tradition more exaltedly than this; for within the realm of possibility none can attain beyond it.

Part 2: “Yet the matter, in the sight…”

Yet the matter, in the sight of the men of gnosis, is hard unto the utmost degree of inaccessibility; and I know not today any one able to attain unto the very truth of that exposition, save whomsoever God willeth. I beseech God, therefore, to inspire whom He desireth with the knowledge of the reality of the Bayan, throughout every grade of exposition, in the worlds of being and of manifestation.

And after this exposition, the meaning of that tradition is not magnified, in the eyes of the people, by way of definitions and limits; for, according to that rank, when volition appeared, God ordained for it five aspects. Among them is the station of Qadar—the determining measure—comprising the geometries of essences and matters, of beings and selves, of identities and accidents, and other modes and relations, together with the causes of beginnings, in the sphere of passivity and response.

In that station do multiplicities appear, and the veils become distinguished from the modes, and essences from attributes. Wretched is he who is wretched in this grade through accepting its choice; and blessed is he who is blessed in this grade through that wherewith God hath favored it, by reason of its choice. This is the inmost depth of possibility, and the Greatest Abyss whereunto the Imam hath alluded, saying:

> “The wretched is wretched in his mother’s womb, and the blessed is blessed in his mother’s womb.”

And the cause of that manifestation lieth in the rank of Qadar; for therein is the most evident disclosure of choice. For a thing is not brought into being in the world of choice by itself; and even though in the first rank it may appear as choosing, none can reckon it but the Subtle, the All-Aware.

Likewise is the judgment in the second rank; for the aspect of accepting good and evil is a third aspect, which appeareth after the conjunction of the two matters. This, by the decree of direct vision and the secret of possibility, became manifest only in the station of Qadar and in the figure of the triangle. Wherefore did the Christians say, “Three of Three,” and take the form of the cross in the grade of trinity, and made the Godhead—which is the world wherein the Will is manifested—to indwell within the human—which is the station wherein multiplicity is mentioned. Exalted is God above that which the wrongdoers utter concerning the ordinances of the manifestations of their own impurity, high above it and greatly exalted!

What I have mentioned in the depths of those allusions is an explanation of the reality of the mystery of contingency in the kingdom of names and attributes. Outwardly, that tradition has universal meanings through knowledge of which the veils are lifted from the stations of the servant, bringing him to the summit of knowledge and grace. For honor with God lies not in formal learning nor in considering the chain of limitations, but rather the remembrance which is humanity’s nobility is the divine mystery and the manifestation of the light of eternal independence that encompasses all aspects of the servant, through which he reaches the pinnacle of justice.

As Ali indicated in his discourse that scholars excel one another in knowledge of what is neither apparent nor implied, and knowledge of what was and what will be is the condition of that station for whoever desires the sweetness of nearness to the holy presence of the Essence and arrival at the manifestations of

the words of the verses of attributes. It is incumbent upon him to lift the veils and allusions of the Glory which indicates the presence of the Essence. After knowledge of those stations, one recognizes that Muhammad and the family of God have degrees in contingency which none of understanding can encompass except whom God wills, for He is the Guardian in origin and verses.

All that God, glorified be He, has originated and will originate hereafter is present before the Messenger of God due to his presence before God, for God's knowledge has ever been His essence with no known thing alongside Him in the degree of eternity. Rather, He knows all things, universal and particular, before their existence just as He knows them after their existence, and none knows how this is except Him. The claim of difference between the concept of life and knowledge is invalid in the station of the Essence, for just as He is living in His existence and needs no other thing for life, likewise He has known all things to their particles and needs no existence of the known in His degree.

All multiplicities were present in His dominion, and Muhammad's knowledge encompassed them all through what God taught him of His grace, for He is the Ancient, the Exalted. God made Muhammad and his trustees, God's blessings be upon them, the repositories of His knowledge and related them to Himself due to their mighty station and elevated rank, like the House and the Sacred Mosque. Nothing escapes their knowledge as God willed in the kingdom of names and attributes.

What was revealed in the Book "Had I known the unseen, I would have acquired much good" and what came in the traditions regarding the ranks of different perspectives in the stations of mysteries is only to manifest their servitude and inability before all beings, or to mention the loftiness of their glory through negation in the station of conjunction. In truth, knowledge of multiplicities holds no nobility in the station of the Essence; rather it is polytheism according to the people of glory, for in the station of knowledge of the Essence, every mention of anything is invalid and indeed indicates polytheism and imperfection.

The nobility among the people of the Bayan and glory in the station of existences and entities is pure simplicity in the station of the manifestation of the Essence. Otherwise, attachment to multiplicities and knowledge of them is imperfection for one who knows the wisdom of the manifestations of the Divine Essence in the Kingdom of Names and Attributes.

Thus, if the Imam denies knowledge of something, and if the observer is one who truly knows their station, he will understand their intention and thank God his Lord for inspiring him with the path of His good pleasure. But if he is not among those who know, he will not comprehend the depth of knowledge in that matter concerning them, even though creation can never, throughout endless ages and the eternity of manifestation, fully comprehend their station. For God has created them in a station which none can attain, and perhaps in certain instances they deny knowledge in order to show their grace to the usurpers, so that the latter might not feel ashamed when in their presence. The one who knows their true station understands the melody of their words and the significance of their signs in all things.

In brief, We have taught you established principles that hold the key to understanding their knowledge and attaining their presence. Otherwise, were I to interpret but one letter of that tradition with ink from all the seas of heaven and earth, those seas would run dry before its meaning could be revealed. Yet I

have summarized this discourse for those who seek knowledge of the beginning and the return. I ask forgiveness in all things, for He is the Lord of the monotheists in the worlds of names.

Sufficient for the servant is His wisdom concerning the beginning and the return. Glory be to God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. Peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds.

BB00673

Praise be unto God, Who bringeth into being whatsoever He willeth by His command, and verily He knoweth whatsoever is in the heavens and whatsoever is on the earth. Glorified and exalted be He above all that they affirm!

…and didst raise me from the path of the sea unto the precincts of Thy holiness [Karbila], in the neighborhood of the trustees of Thy revelation, the pillars of Thine unity, Thy witnesses over Thy creation, and Thine elect among Thy servantsâ€“until there was fulfilled for me, in that place, what Thou hadst decreed in the hidden knowledge. And Thou didst nurture me, by Thy bounty, without my learning from any of the learned of that landâ€”save that, on many days, Thou didst gladden me by the presence of one among Thy servants [Siyyid Kazim], whom Thou hadst taught the governance of his own soul, hadst strengthened by the spirit of faith within his heart, and hadst inspired with that which causeth all else to be forgotten in his inmost being.

After this Thou didst decree for me descent; and I sought leave from the realms of holiness, and returned from the sacred lands unto the land wherein I had been born [Shiraz]….

BB00654: Tafsir al-Hamd

Part 1: “The glory from God resteth upon the Primal…”

In the Name of God, the Most Great, the Most Great

The glory from God resteth upon the Primal Unity and upon those who bear such likeness unto that Unity that naught can be seen in them save the Primal Unity. I testify that the likeness of the Books of God is as the likeness of the sun—though it rise countless times, it is but one sun, and though it set countless times, it is but one sun. Similarly, though Books be revealed from God times without number, they are but one Book, and though they be raised up times without number, they are raised up unto God and are but one Book. I testify that the Book is the Word of God from the Sun of Truth in every Dispensation, howsoever God willeth and in whatsoever tongue He revealeth it. Verily thy knowledge in the ocean of names shall not be established save through thy knowledge in the ocean of creation.

I shall teach thee the essence of the Bayan through a surih of the Qur’an, that thou mayest comprehend all Books from the beginning that hath no beginning unto the end that hath no end through this exposition. Behold then the opening surih:

“In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful. Praise be to God, Lord of the worlds, the Compassionate, the Merciful, Master of the Day of Judgment. Thee do we worship and Thee do we beseech for help. Guide us on the straight path, the path of those whom Thou hast favored, not of those who have incurred Thy wrath, nor of those who have gone astray.” [Q1:1-7]

If thou gazest upon the ocean of names, God hath ever been, from the beginning that hath no beginning, the Possessor of the Most Beautiful Names—of Compassion, Mercy, Lordship, Sovereignty and the like among His inaccessible names and His exalted attributes, and thus shall it be unto the end that hath no end. However, this knowledge in the ocean of names neither taketh root nor profiteth thee except thou witness it in the ocean of creation. For example, the meaning of this surih in the Psalms is:

> “I seek guidance from God Who hath made David His Prophet and endowed him with the mercy of grace—the requirement of the Primal Will whereby He loveth to cause all things to enter Paradise—and with the mercy of justice which is manifested through the Secondary Will whereby He withholdeth the knowledge of Himself from whom He willeth and bestoweth it upon whom He willeth. All good is the name of praise and it belongeth unto Him. He is the Educator of all things, the Possessor of gracious mercy and then of just mercy. He is the Sovereign of the day of His manifestation until the day of Moses. I obey my Lord and seek help in the paths which Thou hast ordained in the Psalms. Guide me to Thy path which Thou hast bestowed upon those who have believed in Thee in the Psalms, not of those whose mention Thou hast not loved and who have not entered into faith in Thee, nor of the peoples who believed in God’s Messengers before Thee and who persisted in their religion.”

Verily when the ocean of names descendeth into the ocean of creation, it speaketh unto thee thus. Then in the day of Moses the meaning of that surih is identical to the first meaning, except that the throne differeth from the name of David to that of Moses. Thus in the time of Moses’ manifestation the meaning of that surih is:

> “I seek guidance from God Who hath made Moses His Prophet and endowed him with the mercy of grace and then of justice. All good belongeth unto Him and He is the Lord of the worlds and Master of the day of His manifestation until the day of Jesus. Thee shall I obey, my Lord, that I may be enriched. Guide us on the path which God hath revealed unto thee in the Torah and hast bestowed upon those who have believed in thee, not of those whom thou hast disliked to mention among those who believed in David but believed not in thee, nor of those who came before David and believed in God’s Messengers and who persisted in their religion after the appearance of the Latter One.”

And likewise thou canst understand the meaning of that Surah in the manifestation of Jesus in the Gospel, for at that time the meaning of that Surah was:

> “I seek guidance through the name of Jesus Who is possessed of bountiful mercy and then of just mercy. And verily all good belongeth to Jesus Who is the Educator of all worlds, Whom God hath made the Possessor of bountiful mercy, then of just mercy, and made Him the Master of the Day of His Manifestation until the Day of Muhammad, nay from the beginning

> that hath no beginning unto the end that hath no end. Thee do I obey, my Lord, that Thy religion may be enriched, Thy mention exalted, and Thy Word made invincible. Guide us unto Thy straight path whereon Thou hast favored those who were given the Gospel from Thee, and preserve us from those whom Thou hast not wished to mention from among those who were given the Torah, nor those who were given the Psalms, for they are not guided."

Then this same interpretation on the Day of Muhammad, the Apostle of God:

> "I seek guidance through God by the name of Muhammad, Whom God hath made the Possessor of bountiful mercy, then of just mercy. And verily all good belongeth to Muhammad Who is the Educator of all worlds, Whom God hath made the Possessor of bountiful mercy unto all believers and of just mercy unto those who believe not, and made Him the Master of the Day of His Manifestation until the Day of the Point of the Bayan, nay from the beginning that hath no beginning unto the end that hath no end therein. Guide us, O Muhammad, unto the straight path whereon Thou hast favored those who have believed in Thee, not those who were given the Gospel before Thee, nor those who were given the Torah, for they are not guided nor do they believe."

And if thou desirest to acquire these attributes, then mention in every name one of the verses of the Furqan; nay, were I to interpret a single letter according to all the precious meanings and lofty expositions possible therein, the seas of the heavens and earth and all that lieth between them would be exhausted. But I have desired to give thee insight in thy recitation of a Surah from the Book of God. Thus the meaning of that Surah in the Day of the Point of the Bayan is exactly as I have taught thee:

> "I seek guidance through Nabil after Ali, Whom God hath made the Possessor of bountiful mercy, then of just mercy. And verily all good from the beginning that hath no beginning unto the end that hath no end belongeth to Nabil after Ali, Whom God hath made the Educator of all worlds, and made Him the Possessor of bountiful mercy unto all that hath been and shall be created, and of just mercy unto those who are in the Bayan, and made Him the Master of the Day of His Manifestation until the Day of Him Whom God shall make manifest; nay, from the beginning that hath no beginning all hath ended in Him, and unto the end that hath no end all must needs be manifested through Him. Thee alone do I obey, my Lord, from Thee alone do I seek help, and let none be joined with Thee, for were I to join obedience to another with obedience to Thee, it would be as though I had worshipped other than God, and were I to seek help from any besides Thee, it would be as though I had sought help from other than God. And verily I seek protection in Thee and take refuge in Thee from aught save Thy love and good-pleasure."

O Point of the Bayan, protect me, for verily Thou art the Best of protectors. Guide us to Thy straight path which God hath sent down unto Thee in the Bayan through His commandments and prohibitions—the path of those upon whom Thou hast bestowed Thy grace, who have believed in Thee and in the Primal Living One, the chosen ones of Thy Faith; then of those who transgress not a single bound of the bounds of Thy religion and who desire naught save what Thou hast desired in the Bayan for the creation of Thy Lord—not of those whose mention Thou hast not loved from among those who were given the Furqan,

nor of those who were given the Gospel, for these are not guided. And likewise this interpretation applieth to the Day of Him Whom God shall make manifest.

Say: I shall surely seek guidance from Him Whom God shall make manifest, the Lord of the Most Excellent Mercy, then the Lord of Justice. Verily all good belongeth to Him Whom God shall make manifest, Who is the Educator of all worlds. He it is Whom God hath made the Lord of the Most Excellent Mercy, then the Lord of Justice amongst all worlds. And He it is Whom God hath made the Master of His Day of Manifestation until the manifestation of Him Who shall be manifested after Him Whom God shall make manifest—the Manifestation of God in all worlds. Verily every day hath God created from the beginning that hath no beginning in His days, and all that God createth must needs be manifested in His days. Therefore be thou discerning and be of them that know.

Part 2: "O Him Whom God shall make manifest, I…"

O Him Whom God shall make manifest, I shall surely obey Thee and through Thee shall I seek assistance in manifesting Thy love and Thy good-pleasure howsoever Thou willest, wheresoever Thou willest, through whatsoever Thou willest, and whithersoever Thou willest. For whatsoever Thou willest hath been through what God, Thy Lord, hath willed, and that which Thou willest not hath not been through what God, Thy Lord, hath not willed. And verily Thou art, through him who obeyeth Thee, among them that know. Guide us to Thy straight path which Thou ordainest in Thy Book by God's leave, the Lord of all worlds—which leave is the leave of Thine own Being, since Thou hast no will or desire save through what God hath willed and desired, no power or decree or leave save through what God hath empowered and decreed and permitted, no term or book save through what God hath appointed and written. And guide us through Thy bounty, for verily Thou art the Most Excellent Guide—the path of those upon whom Thou hast bestowed Thy grace, who recognize Thee and follow Thee; not of those who were given the Bayan yet remain patient and believe not, nor of those who were given the Furqan for they are not guided.

And likewise this explanation—learn thou of it in the Day of Him Who shall be manifested after Him Whom God shall make manifest. For in His Day of Manifestation, shouldst thou comprehend the meaning of that Surih, it behooveth thee to say: I shall surely seek guidance through the name of Him Who shall be manifested after Him Whom God shall make manifest, the Lord of the Most Excellent Mercy, then of Justice in all worlds. Verily all good belongeth unto Him and He is the Educator of all worlds. He it is Whom God hath made the Lord of Justice, then of the Most Excellent Mercy unto all who are created and shall be created, then unto all in the worlds.

And He it is Whom God hath made the Master of His Day of Manifestation until the Day of Him Who shall be manifested after Him. And all the days that have been created are in it, and all that shall be created is from His presence. That is from the knowledge of God, the Protector, the Self-Subsisting. Thee alone do I obey, and I associate none with Thee in my obedience, and in Thee alone do I seek assistance, and I seek help from none other than Thee. Guide us to Thy path which Thou lovest and with which Thou art well-pleased, for verily Thou art the Most Guiding of guides—the path of those upon whom Thou bestowest favor, who know Thee and believe in Thee, other than those who were given the Book of Him Whom God

shall make manifest, nor those who were given the Bayan, for these, should they remain patient and believe not, are not guided.

Then in the third Manifestation, likewise, shouldst thou attain, say:

> "I shall surely seek guidance through the name of Him Who shall appear after Him Whom God shall make manifest, the Lord of grace and justice unto all worlds."

All good belongeth unto Him, and verily He is the Educator of all worlds. He it is Whom God, the Lord of grace and justice, hath made for all worlds, and He it is Whom God hath made the Master of the Day of His Manifestation until the next Resurrection, and all the days that have been created in His days, and all that shall be created must needs be created in His days, and He is the Master of all things through God's bestowal of sovereignty, the Lord of all worlds. Thee alone do I obey, and I associate none with Thee in my obedience, and in Thee alone do I seek assistance, and I seek help from none other than Thee. Guide us to the path which Thou wouldst manifest through Thy will, for verily Thou art the Most Guiding of guides—the path of those upon whom Thou bestowest favor, who know Thee and are believers in Thy presence, other than those who were given the Book of Him Who shall appear after Him Whom God shall make manifest, nor those who were given the Book of Him Whom God shall make manifest, for these, should they remain, are not guided.

Then in the fourth Manifestation, likewise, shouldst thou attain, thou shalt surely say by God:

> "I shall seek guidance through the name of Him Who shall appear after Him Whom God shall make manifest,"

He Whom God, the Lord of grace and justice, hath made for all who are created and shall be created, then for all worlds. Everything upon which the name of aught can be applied belongeth unto Him, and verily He is the Educator of all worlds. He it is Whom God, the Lord of grace and justice, hath made for all who are in the kingdoms of the heavens and the earth and whatsoever is between them, then for all worlds. He it is Whom God hath made the Master of all things through His Own sovereignty, and from Him, from the day of His Manifestation until the next Resurrection, and all that hath been created therein, and all that shall be created must needs appear from His presence, and He is powerful over whatsoever He willeth.

Thee alone do I obey, and I associate none with Thee in my obedience, and in Thee alone do I seek assistance, and I associate none with Thee in my seeking of assistance. Guide us to Thy path howsoever Thou willest, wheresoever Thou willest, whithersoever Thou willest, and through whatsoever means Thou willest, for verily Thou art the Most Guiding of guides. Thy Self knoweth the sublimity of Thy grace, and how, and Thy guidance, and whatsoever Thou lovest of the affairs of Thy will—all are Thine, through Thee, from Thee, and unto Thee, and verily Thou art the Glory of God unto all worlds. This is the path of those upon whom Thou bestowest favor, who know Thee and love Thee, other than those who were given the Book of Him Who appeared before Thee, nor those who were given the Book of Him Who appeared before Him Who appeared before Thee, for verily these, should they remain patient, are not guided.

And verily, regarding the Fifth Manifestation, were ye to comprehend it as I have explained, ye would surely expound it and would say:

> "We shall surely seek guidance through the name of Him Who shall appear after, after, after Him Whom God shall make manifest, Whom God, the Possessor of grace and then of justice, hath made to rule over all the worlds. Verily, all good belongeth unto Him, and He is the Educator of all the worlds. He is the One Whom God, the Possessor of grace and then of justice, hath made for all who are in the heavens and the earth and whatsoever lieth between them, and verily, He is the Best of the merciful ones. He is the One Whom God hath made the possessor of all things, and from the day of His manifestation until the next Resurrection—exalted be its Manifestation and glorified be its Founder—and all the days that have been created on the day of His manifestation and all that shall be created must needs appear from His presence, and He is the Lord of all the worlds."
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> "Thee shall we obey, and we shall not associate anyone with Thee in our obedience, and through Thee shall we seek assistance, and we shall never seek help from any other than Thee. Verily, Thou art sufficient unto us and sufficient unto all that hath been and shall be created, and verily, through what God hath taught Thee, Thou hast knowledge of all things."
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> "Guide us unto the path which Thou lovest for Thyself, for Thou art the Most Guiding of guides—the path which Thou bestowest upon those who love Thee and know Thee and follow Thy commandments and Thy prohibitions, not the path of those who were given the Book of Him Who appeared before Thee or before before Thee, for if they persist, they are not guided."

From the beginning that hath no beginning, the meaning of that Surah is like this, and unto the end that hath no end, the meaning of that Surah is like this; nay, the meaning of all the Books is like this. Therefore, judge with fairness by God: Have those who were given the Gospel read that Surah after the appearance of Muhammad, and likewise after the appearance of Him Who came after Him, and likewise unto the end that hath no end? Therefore, comprehend the Cause of God and watch over thyself lest thou be numbered among the veiled ones.

BB00173: Fi Istifhamat al-Qur'an

The Sacred Words Concerning Description, Explanation and Investigation of the Qur'anic Questions

In the Name of God, the Merciful, the Compassionate

Praise be to God Who brought forth the essential realities of the people of creation from naught by His command, that all who dwell in the kingdom of earth and heaven might know Him through His manifestation unto them in the degrees of their being and the expressions of their signs, that there is no God but Him, the Ever-Living, the Self-Subsisting, in the eternity of eternities and the everlasting of days. He hath ever been, with naught existing beside Him, and will ever be as He hath been, with nothing at His level, for the existence of aught else is impossible to mention in the court of His might, since all things in

all their degrees neither comprehend their own selves nor are conscious save of the ordinances of their own actions. Thus did the Imam, peace be upon him, indicate their station in his words, exalted be his remembrance:

> "My God, Thy power hath begun, O my God, yet Thy awe appeared not, so they likened Thee and took some of Thy signs as lords."

Hence they knew Thee not, for such is the condition of contingency in all the degrees of existence. His essential eternity is in itself indicative of the presence of His being, that it is as it is. Created things are cut off from the station of knowledge, and contingent beings are precluded from the station of explanation. He is the Exalted One Whom sight comprehendeth not, nor do the loftiest essences of thought ascend unto Him, while He, of Himself, comprehendeth the vision of all things—the All-Subtle, the All-Informed.

I bear witness unto Muhammad, peace be upon him, as God hath testified in the essence of His being, that he is His servant whom He chose from the midst of the eternity of grace upon the pinnacle of justice, and selected him from the ultimate station of praise for the manifestation of His lordship over all who dwell in the kingdom of names and attributes. Indeed He fashioned him for the station of His authority over all degrees of existence, both unseen and visible, for the station of the manifestation of His sanctity over all contingent things, for He hath ever been beyond the grasp of vision and beyond description by what comprehendeth the mysteries of sight. Verily God is the Single One, the Ever-Living, the Self-Subsisting, Who made him the station of His Self in the world of performance and decree, for He hath ever been beyond association with the creation of servants or description by the knowledge of the degrees of hearts—He is the All-Subtle, the All-Bountiful.

And I bear witness to the Trustees of the Mission of Muhammad, the Messenger of God—may blessings rest upon Him—according to that wherewith God Himself hath borne witness unto them in the stations of creation and the manifestations of revelation, and in those realities which none comprehendeth in the kingdoms of the heavens and the earth save God, exalted be He above that which they ascribe unto Him.

And I bear witness that verily I am His servant, who hath believed in God and in His signs, and seeketh not to transgress by so much as a single letter the decree of the Qur'an. God, in His bounty, hath honoured me with knowledge from His presence; and I have proclaimed to the people the Cause of my Lord, that all His servants might render thanks unto Him for the favour He hath vouchsafed, and acknowledge the bounty that hath been made manifest from His own Self. And sufficient is God as a witness unto me.

Thereafter, when one among the students inquired concerning a question touching the interrogative verses of the Qur'an, and how their like had been revealed in the Words of the Bayan, I—having promised to expound it—indicated the rule of the reply in such wise as might suffice the servant at the time of address.

Know then that the Qur'an compriseth stations without end or limit in the knowledge of God; nor can any soul attain unto comprehension of these realities save through the knowledge of the command betwixt the two commands and the station between the two stations—that which hath descended in the traditions concerning the Suns of Certitude and the Pillars of Assurance.

Whoso attaineth unto the mystery of that decree shall find the path made easy before him: he shall behold the multiplicity of things with the eye of the Theophany of the Divine Essence shining within them. And whoso standeth steadfast upon this straight path shall discern no contradiction among the traditions, nor any ambiguity within the Qur'an. He shall regard the interrogative verses as akin to the decisive, and the allusions as resembling the evident proofs.

Now will I indicate the meaning of a single interrogative verse, that through it the gate of knowledge may be opened unto the understanding of all interrogatives and ambiguities. There is no doubt that God is, and hath ever been, knowing of all things. His word, exalted be His remembrance—"What is that in thy right hand, O Moses?"—is, in the utmost degree, the station of the reply; for it signifieth the manifestation of his capacity for the appearance of the divine effulgence within him, even as the word "Am I not your Lord?" revealeth the ultimate mystery of Reality.

As for the indication of the outward path, the way to comprehend its meaning is through the souls of men, yet encompassed by the chain of universals which the learned, may God sanctify them, have expounded in all their ranks as eight degrees.

If thou dost behold the verse from the station of exposition, thou wilt perceive therein naught but the act of God in the Furqan, as He saith: "O Moses! Verily, I am God, the Lord of the worlds." But if thou wouldst discern its meaning in the station of inner significances, it is the manifestation of God's bounty unto Moses, whereby He caused him to utter the reality of what He had placed in his staff—that he might render the right due to the truth which his soul had received; and this is of the grace of God unto whomsoever He hath settled in that degree, as it is said in the sacred tradition: "When he is silent, I begin him." This is the loftiest of the degrees of manifestation in the world of names and attributes.

If thou desirest its meaning in the station of the Gates, it alludeth to His word: "And from the right side of the valley, in the blessed spot, from the tree: 'O Moses, verily, I am God, the Lord of the worlds."' The breeze of that utterance wafteth from the right-hand valley, proclaiming that He, in very truth, is the Lord of all being.

If thou seekest its meaning in the station of the Imamate, it is the secret of the Gate, for the material of that station is the command of God to Moses, that he should know what lay in his right hand of the ordinances of the Imams of religion—those who act by the command of God, trembling in awe before Him. Thus He confirmed that in the station of Essence his reliance was upon the staff from the Tree of Ahmad—upon it be the blessings of God—since the Sun of Prophethood rose with Prophethood, and the Sun of Guardianship set with Guardianship.

If thou seekest its meaning in the station of the Pillars, it signifieth the position of Moses among the Prophets, that God inspired him with what He had placed in his hand of the rulings of his staff, revealing thereby the secret of the radiance of the lights of Unity and the attributes of Eternity, when He said: "What is that in thy right hand, O Moses?" The allusions of these stations are beyond enumeration.

And now, as I am in a state of fever, I shall shorten the discourse and entreat God for inspiration unto him who possesseth the decree of the pure inmost spirit of Islam.

If thou wouldst discern its meaning in the station of the Nuqaba' (chieftains), it is the secret of that which I have expounded unto thee concerning the stations already mentioned; and it is what is meant by His exalted word, that what is in Moses's right hand is the manifestation of one of the partisans of ʿAli—he who shall speak, by God's leave, from the right side. When he turneth toward that station, there shall issue from the staff whatsoever God willeth to make manifest.

The interrogative address in this verse signifieth the favour of God, that He caused His interlocutor, Moses, to speak, for he was of all men the most abased before the Presence of God, the most reverent among the humble. Whoso humbleth himself in the utmost degree of lowliness shall be gathered beneath the shadow of that same station with the Interlocutor of God upon Mount Sinai.

Verily, within these stations are sacred allusions, were they to be unveiled from the veils of affliction and the conditions of being. Sufficient for thee is the divine indication in His exalted word: "When His Lord manifested Himself to the mountain, He made it crumble, and Moses fell down senseless." Al-a¹¢adiq—peace be upon him—interpreted this verse, saying: "When His Lord manifested Himself to the mountain, He made it crumble, and Moses fell down senseless." This, he said, referreth to one among the Shi'ah of Ali, as related in the Basa'ir, that the Cherubim are a people of our Shi'ah, of the first creation, whom God placed behind the Throne; were a single ray of their light divided among the earth, it would suffice for all. And Ali said that when Moses inquired concerning one of the Cherubim, that being manifested itself to the mountain and it was made dust.

If thou hast grasped this mystery, then supplicate God to unite me with those Cherubim in the sanctuary of holiness, beneath the overshadowing shades of divine splendour and nearness; for this is the utmost of my hope in this world and the next. Unto Him do I complain in this life below; unto Him shall be the return in the life to come and the life that was before.

If thou wouldst discern its meaning in the station of the Nujaba' (nobles), it is veiled beneath the coverings of secrecy and the curtains of glory; and whoso seeketh to uncover its reality opposeth God in His dominion, contendeth with Him in His sovereignty, and returneth with the wrath of God upon him. Hell shall be his abode—how wretched the resting-place of the wrongdoers!

In every one of these stations there is a meaning corresponding to the outward tongue of interpretation, whereby the servant may perceive, if he but meditate. But beyond these seven degrees there extendeth another chain of lateral correspondences, proceeding as reflections from each preceding rank. These possess diverse stations, for the meanings vary according to the differences of their degree, until the significance of the verse reacheth the station of the Atom.

And here will I stay the pen from its flow, and entreat God's forgiveness in all matters; for He is verily the Protector at the beginning and at the return. Glorified be the Lord, the God of the Throne, above all that they ascribe unto Him! And peace be upon the Messengers; and praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds.

BB00195: Khutbah fi Ard-i-Sad (insha'uha fi balad as-sad)

In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful

All praise be to God Who hath testified to His own Self by His own Self that there is none other God but Him, the Truth from all eternity, and that He is even as He was throughout all ages that come to pass, subject neither to change nor transformation. Names are cut off from the precincts of His nearness, and attributes are barred from mention of His holy Oneness, for He hath ever been, and none else beside Him existed, and will ever be, with none to be mentioned in His rank. Even as He is in His station of glory and majesty, single in His unity and omnipotence, and sanctified above mention of names and similitudes in the realms of dominion and kingdom, for His Essence separateth fundamental realities from the station of knowledge, and His Identity preventeth material things from the station of utterance.

Whosoever claimeth to know Him hath indeed been ignorant of Him, for knowledge is contingent upon conjunction, and affirmation cometh after separation. And whosoever claimeth to unify Him hath associated His creation with Him and hath conceived falsehood within himself, for none but He can unify Him, and none but He can worship Him, since mention of unity is impossible in the station of attributes, and the decree of glorification appeareth not in the station of qualities. He is far exalted above being described by His creation or being unified by aught else. Glorified and exalted is He! None knoweth how He is save Him.

I bear witness that there is no God but God, alone with no partner, even as His Essence hath testified unto His Essence, and those endowed with knowledge among His creation in His realm of origination that He is a God, Living, Self-Subsisting, All-Knowing, All-Powerful, All-Choosing, from Whose knowledge nothing in the heavens or earth escapeth, and nothing in the worlds of command and creation overwhelmeth Him, having no attribute apart from His Essence and no quality apart from His attributes. Glorified and exalted is He above what they describe!

And I bear witness that Muhammad, peace be upon him and his family, is His servant whom He selected from the midst of the eternity of action for His station of authority, chose him from the heights of grace for His station of love, and selected him as the sign of His Self for His station of knowledge, unique without peer or likeness in the worlds of creation. He chose him for the loftiness of His grandeur for His own station in performance and decree, and was well-pleased with him for His sovereign station, with knowledge over all contingent things, for He hath ever been unconnected to servants and indescribable by the manifestations of the heart. He graspeth all vision, and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Aware.

And I bear witness to the successors of Muhammad, the Messenger of God, peace be upon him and his family, with that which God hath testified for them in the worlds of creation, and which God hath ordained for them in the knowledge of the unseen with the highest degrees of praise and glory, that they are the repositories of command and manifestations of grace and pillars of unity and ultimate manifestations of sanctification in the worlds of invention, of which none encompasseth knowledge concerning their station save God, the Glorified. He is the Mighty, the Most High.

And I bear witness to every truth with what God hath willed and desired in the stations of command and purposes of creation, in origin and return. He it is Who sendeth blessings upon you, as do His angels, that He might bring you forth from darkness into light, and He is ever Merciful to the believers.

Praise be to God Who originated the essences of abstract realities through the appearance of the manifestations of His Self in the signs of invention, that every limit might know itself and recognize the ordinances of its origin and witness the lights of divinity in its secret and manifest aspects, lest it be veiled in any condition from the station of the manifestations of the Presence of Oneness in the kingdom of names and attributes, and might see Him manifest and self-subsisting over all existences and see nothing in any condition save through the manifestation of His light in the essential and accidental realities, so that each may attain, through knowledge of that station, to all the stations which God hath ordained for it in the verses of the manifestations of the Beginning and the appearances of the End, even unto the final goal.

And praise be to God Who hath caused to shine forth whatsoever hath dawned upon the temples of radiance, and Who hath revealed the hidden mysteries within the inmost hearts of the people of the Covenant on the Day of Reckoning, that all might be distinguished at the time of meeting from the manifestations of the Beginning and the revelations of His traces at the station of conjunction, from similarity and likeness in the signs of the verses of limitation at the station of separation.

Glorified and exalted is He! He hath originated the likeness of abstraction in the station of individuations and the examples of glorification in the essence of the verses, that all created things might be guided by the manifestation of the lights of His holiness to the glory of the court of nearness to His might, and that all things might behold Him after all things just as before all things, without cessation or decline, until all have testified in the stations of the manifestations of the Essence to that which God hath testified concerning Himself in the eternity of eternities and the everlastingness of days.

None knoweth Him save through that whereby He hath described Himself to His servants, for, exalted be His remembrance, none shall ever know Him but Himself, and none shall be mentioned in His rank, for His existence in itself indicateth utter nothingness before the countenance of the pure Essence, and the existence of eternity in its essence indicateth the non-existence of aught else with Him.

Glorified and exalted is He! Sanctified is His Essence and exalted His Being and His Grandeur above anyone's ability to unify that which cannot possibly be known to exist, or to negate that whose remembrance and manifestation cannot possibly be lost from existence.

Glorified and exalted is He! Whoso uttereth a word from the court of His holy sovereignty hath indeed taken upon himself polytheism in his soul and sin in his deeds, for the mention of attributes in relation to His Essence is but a manifestation of His kingdom and a description of the affairs of His power, and it in itself indicateth origination and telleth of the recognition of subsistence belonging to the Living, the Self-Subsisting, Whom no vision can encompass, and unto the heaven of Whose Lordship no bird of hearts and minds can soar, while He encompasseth all vision, and He is the All-Subtle, the All-Informed.

Praise be to God Who hath fashioned all geometries according to what they themselves have accepted at the station of indications and essential realities, then at that of modes of being and verses, then at that of souls and indications, then at that of individuations and signs, and what God hath ordained beyond these stations and allusions of that which no one among the people of names and attributes can encompass in

knowledge, and upon which no rule of allusions and infinities can be applied. Verily God encompasses all things in the stations of command and endings.

Praise be to God Who hath caused all to know that the way is barred to the knowledge of His Essence and that proof is prevented from ascending to the court of nearness to His presence and from attaining to the sanctum of His grandeur, that all created things might become certain, in the station of recognizing the manifestation of the Essence, of the negation of names and attributes and the establishment of unity through that which God hath revealed to them through them, from the origins of causes to the rank of dust in the station of the unity of the Essence and the manifestations of the recognition of holy verses in the kingdom of justice and essences, and that it might not be said through the manifestations of the affairs of the mines of knowledge in the midst of the eternity of passivity until man attaineth unto the rank of dust.

Praise be to God Who hath sent down in the Book whatsoever people need of the ordinances of the beginning and the return, that none might doubt concerning any decree and might witness the decree of all names in all the verses of the Book just as God sent down in the Qur'an when the decree of the Bayan was not forgotten, and We have recorded all things in a clear register.

And praise be to God Who decreeth what He pleaseth as He pleaseth through what He hath wished and willed and ordained and decreed in His knowledge for all contingent beings and whatsoever hath been ordained in the degrees of the manifestations of His creation, that they may all praise Him in the paths of powerlessness and remembrance, in accordance with His word: "All praise be to God, the Lord of the worlds."

BB00214: Fi Bayani'l-l'tiqad

Concerning the exposition of the unaltered steadfastness of his belief in the ordinances of the Faith.

In the Name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who guides whom He wishes and leads astray whom He wishes, and unto Him do all created things return. And blessings be upon Muhammad, the Messenger of God, and upon his appointed ones whom God has made the Imams of religion and pillars of the people of certitude, and concerning whose authority God has revealed in the Qur'an where He says:

> "honored servants who speak not until He has spoken, and who act by His command."

And peace be upon those who follow them in all matters and believe in them. And verily punishment is prepared for those who turn away from them after having believed in them.

And furthermore, when I heard that some people had presented certain words before His Exalted Presence which necessitate that I should mention them in this book, I began by recording these statements lest anyone should think of me other than what is true. And after his knowledge of what I have herein recorded in this book, let his judgment be manifest before God and before those possessed of knowledge among His creation.

And now, there is no doubt that religion has not changed nor will it be altered, and my belief regarding the laws of religion is that which I now write in this book. God suffices as witness, and those who possess justice in His presence.

I bear witness that there is none other God but God, alone, without peer or partner—even as His own Self hath testified of His own Self that He is the One, Who from everlasting was, with no thing existing beside Him, and Who shall ever remain—He abiding even as He hath ever abode. No thing hath been associated with Him in any condition; and He is sanctified above likeness, exalted beyond resemblance. No description there is save His own Essence, and no name save His own Being….

…As for those who describe Him by the attributes of their own selves, and those who remember Him by the names of His Essence—these are but returned unto themselves. He is too exalted to be known by His creatures, or to be described by His servants. Nay rather, He created names and attributes that all beings might worship Him through them, and might sanctify Him above them—for they are created attributes and originated names, brought into being by God to cleanse hearts and imaginations. And even as He is in the majesty of His identity and the glory of His self-subsistence, none shall know Him save He, Himself. Exalted is He above what they ascribe!

And I bear witness unto Muhammad—the Messenger of God, may the blessings of God rest upon Him—that God chose Him from the inmost heart of pre-existence unto the station of adornment, and made Him the locus of His own decree in proclamation and in judgment, even as it hath been revealed:

> "Vision perceiveth Him not, but He perceiveth all vision; and He is the Subtle, the All-Aware."

And I bear witness unto the successors of Muhammad and unto Fatimih—may the blessings of God rest upon them all—according to that which God hath testified for them in the knowledge of the unseen: that they are the pillars of Divine Unity, the Manifestations of sanctity, the signs of singleness, and the evidences of praise. They are honored servants: they precede Him not in speech, and they act by His command.

And I bear witness that whoso believeth concerning them aught beyond pure servitude unto God, exalted be He, or equateth the excellence of any one of them with the Messenger of God, hath indeed trodden the path of error and is of the unjust.

And I bear witness that I am a servant who hath believed in God and in His signs, and hath followed the ordinance of the Qur'an; and that my desire, in every matter, is none other than the most perfect and pure judgment of God. As to those who slander me, alleging that I have followed their idle fancies, they have confounded me with themselves—and I am wholly clear of them, by my Lord. I have indeed spoken unto the people of that knowledge wherewith God hath graciously favored me. Whoso giveth thanks, giveth thanks for his own soul; and whoso denieth, verily God is Self-Sufficient, independent of all the worlds.

And since certain among the people imagine concerning that knowledge otherwise than what God hath purposed in the Book, I will set down a sprinkling from its stations, and a proof for the people of that

supposition, that the truth may be distinguished from falsehood, and that all may thereby become of the thankful.

God hath graciously favored me, in the station of knowledge, with fourfold aspects.

Among them is the aspect of knowledge [ʿilm] itself—whereunto beareth witness that which I have set forth in the exposition on specific prophethood. And whoso desireth the measure of eloquence in that station, let him test the learned—whosoever is a Muslim skilled in that art—until it become plain unto him what it is that they claim.

And among them is the station of prayers [munajat], which, by the grace of God, floweth forth from me and from my pen: within six hours there issued a thousand verses of prayer—verses that testify to the recognition of the stations of Divine Unity, whose reality none can apprehend save him who hath rent asunder the veils of majesty without allusion. This, verily, is sufficient for him that possesseth heart and understanding.

Even as Jami' al-Bihar—may God have mercy upon him—hath mentioned, that the Sahīfih of Sajjad sufficeth, in eloquence, for him who desireth to comprehend the stations of the people of infallibility—may the blessings of God be upon them—and to affirm that which God hath ordained for them; for he saith that most of the learned have declared it to be the "Psalms of the House of Muhammad"—may the blessings of God rest upon him. And this, in truth, is a matter difficult and weighty. I myself, even until now, have written many books; yet I know not that, should another attempt—by the reality of his innate nature—to compose even a single supplication, he would be able. In this is sufficient proof of the favor granted me from God; and God sufficeth as Trustee.

And among them is the station of sermons [khutab], wherein there flow from my pen lofty words, such that they who are not acquainted with the reality of the Cause imagine them to be among the orations of the masters of eloquence. Whoso desireth to apprehend the truth of a sermon—its outward form and its inward meaning—let him refer to the learned; for thereby shall the difficulty of the matter be unveiled: who it is that speaketh by true innate disposition, and who it is that cannot produce an oration save through pondering and contrivance. Unto God do the ordinances return, at the beginning and at the end.

And among these stations is that of the masters of eloquence, in the lofty utterances—utterances such that, were all mankind to gather together to produce the like of a single saying thereof, they would neither be able nor empowered to do so, even though the whole were helpers one of another. Of this station there hath appeared that which was disclosed unto the gracious Presence—may God prolong his shadow; and when he beholdeth the reality of utterance, let him consider the Kitabu'l-ʿAdl, for thereby is the measure of utterance discerned in all the degrees of exposition.

It behoveth not one such as I to call witnesses from among those who have affirmed the truth of those words; for he who attaineth unto a station through a trace of my very being—how can he be capable of knowing its reality? Yet for those who are perplexed, though not of the people of equity, I mention four books, each of which was revealed by One possessed of mastery in a distinct science—books that some among the people are powerless to refute.

And beyond these manifestations, apart from knowledge received from men, were but one to judge with true fairness, he would testify that each of those stations removeth contradiction and disagreement from among the learned, and leadeth all back unto a single judgment.

And after all have come to know these stations, should any among the learned desire to engage me in mubahalih, for the vindication of the Truth and the annulment of falsehood, according to that which hath been revealed in the traditions concerning the Suns of Grandeur and Majesty, I, verily, would welcome it—for I love the manifestation of certitude in the religion of God. God sufficeth as Witness.

Whoso among the learned is able to bring forth a discourse to invalidate that bounty, upon him lieth the obligation either to produce it by innate endowment and power, or to confess his incapacity and acknowledge the favor of his Lord. And whoso hath perceived and yet hath not come forward with the proof of the Prophets, nor stood in the station of mubahalih, upon him resteth God's judgment. After these allusions, no one hath any proof against me. Whoso willeth, let him accept; and whoso willeth, let him turn away.

I have completed the mention of the bounty, lest any should say concerning me that I have followed idle desire. And let one convey the ordinance thereof, by permission of the Exalted Presence, unto the learned. God sufficeth as Witness.

BB00518

As for what you asked about people's differences regarding Tahirih, the essence of what should be accepted about her is that it is incumbent upon all to remain silent concerning her station, and that she was a leaf who believed in her Lord. The proof for all is the one whom God has made a proof over me and over all, and it is not incumbent upon anyone to derive rulings except from the one in whose hands God has placed His proof. When she advanced in the knowledge of the family of God, it is not befitting for a believer to deny her or harm her. She did not rule except by what was detailed in the Book.

Regarding that about which people differ, the lawful is clear and the unlawful is clear, and the doubtful matters are known. Whoever is God-fearing and guards against doubtful matters has built a fortress protecting against entering into prohibited things. Nothing has been added to or subtracted from religion by even a letter. All the outward aspects of religious law are true without any doubt, and no one is relieved of religious obligations except after death.

The inner aspects of religious law are true without any doubt, but none comprehend this except those well-grounded in knowledge. The outward conforms to the inward—whoever believes in the outward but not the inward has disbelieved, and whoever does not believe in the outward has associated partners with God.

Religion is perfect, its signs are clear, and its proofs are evident. It is not for anyone to interpret except to take its rulings from the places God has made the repositories of His judgment. God does not accept any deed from anyone except what He has commanded and willed, to the end of the statements.

BB00331: Prayer for Siyyid Husayn

O my God! Thou art He Who hath borne witness unto Thine own Self, through Thine own Self, that verily Thou art God, there is none other God but Thee—alone, without partner. Thou hast ever been when no being existed with Thee, and Thou wilt ever remain as Thou wast; naught hath been, nor shall be, in any condition or rank that can compare with Thy station. For Thy Essence is the eternal Essence, which, by its very being, hath severed the materialities from the station of true recognition; and Thy Reality is the ancient Reality, which, by its own subsistence, hath cut off the immaterial essences from the station of utterance.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! If I say, "Thou art Thou," mine own self, and then all created things, straightway confute me, declaring that God is too exalted to be described by His creation, or to be characterized by His servants. And if I keep silence before the court of the holiness of Thy singleness, my own soul rebuketh me, saying: "God created nothing in vain, nor in idle sport." Glorified art Thou, O my God! I behold no path, and I find no remembrance to serve as proof. Yet Thou, O my Lord, knowest my secret and mine open speech, and bearest witness unto what my hands have wrought in the presence of the court of Thy all-compelling might.

If I say, "Blessedness," the sentence of Thy justice and Thy decree causeth me to tremble; and if I say, "Woe unto me," the manner of Thy dealing with the sinners among Thy servants setteth my heart at rest. O Thou besides Whom there is none other God! By Thy might and Thy majesty I know that Thou art nearer unto me than all things, and that Thou art more merciful and more kind unto me than every possessor of kindness; for Thou didst create me when I was not mentioned, and didst nurture me, through Thy bounty, after Thou didst choose for me a praiseworthy course. Thy call hath ever been loving-kindness, and Thy wont hath ever been bestowal.

If Thou shouldst chastise me, it would be but of Thy mercy toward me, that Thou mightest deliver me from the burdens of mine own self and the iniquities of my secret and my open acts. And if Thou shouldst cause me to enter, through Thy mercy, among Thy righteous servants, it would be but through Thy generosity and Thy solicitude, without any cause on my part.

Wherefore, praise be to Thee, O my God, according to the right of Thy ancient lowliness in all that hath befallen me from Thee—a praise radiant, resplendent, sanctified, and purified from the praise of all others besides Thee, and singled out from the commendation of Thy servants and from whatsoever their highest sensibilities can conceive: a praise that, through Thy bounty and Thy loving-kindness, surpasseth all things, and maketh perfect Thy favor upon me in this world and in the world to come, in the utmost of Thy beneficence.

Glorified art Thou, O my God! Thou knowest my station in that land, and bearest witness unto what I purposed before the court of Thy mercy. And lo! I testify for Thine own Self that verily Thou art God, there is none other God but Thee, the Mighty, the Bestower. And I testify concerning Muhammad, Thy Beloved—may Thy blessings be upon Him and upon His Family—unto what Thou hast ordained for Him in the knowledge of the unseen that is with Thee, which none of Thy creatures can encompass: verily Thou art the Mighty, the All-Bestowing.

And I testify concerning the successors of Thy Beloved—may Thy blessings rest upon them—unto what Thou hast revealed in their regard, when Thou didst say—and Thy word is truth—"Servants honored: they speak not before Him, and they act by His command." And I testify, O my God, for every living thing to what Thou Thyself hast testified, and for every vain thing to that which Thou lovest that creation should bear witness: Thou knowest all things, and nothing escapeth Thy knowledge, neither in the heavens nor on the earth; verily Thou art the Mighty, the Wise.

O my God! Far, far is Thy bounty from sending down upon Thy servants an affliction in this earthly life, without raising for them, thereby, a degree in the life to come. Thou knowest that when Thou didst take the souls of certain of Thy servants, by reason of the sorrow of heart of one of Thy creatures, Thou didst, therefore, send down upon him the word of patience and resignation to Thy decree; and upon those whom Thou didst take unto Thyself in the Holy Land Thou didst send down the word of mercy, and such of wondrous breaths and new bounties as none can compass in knowledge save Thee—through Thy grace and Thy bounty, O Lord of lords!

O God! Thou art the Friend of the believers and the Successor of the godly. Perfect, then, Thy favors upon us; send down upon us Thy blessings; and cause us to enter among the righteous of Thy chosen ones. Thou art independent of the ordinance of all things, and nothing in the heavens or on the earth can daunt Thee. Verily Thou art the Powerful, the Mighty.

O God! If any of Thy servants hath had his heart saddened by reason of him whom Thou hast taken unto Thyself of his kindred, I beseech Thee, by Thy grace, to send down upon him Thy mercy in every condition, and to soothe the heart that mourneth through Thy promise and Thy good-pleasure. For souls find not rest in any state save in meeting Thee, nor do they attain unto the utmost degree of contentment save through Thy bounty.

O God! Fulfil what Thou hast promised unto the believers among the people of Thine answer. Forgive me, and my parents, and all who have followed Thy ordinance, and have feared Thy justice, and have found assurance in Thy bounty. Verily Thou art God—the Generous, the Single, the One—none can fathom aught of Thy knowledge in the heavens or on the earth, and Thou art powerful over all things.

Glorified be God, the Lord of the Throne, above what they ascribe! Peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, the Lord of all worlds.

BB00366: Sharh-i-Hadith-i-ma min fi'lin yaf'alahu'l-'abd

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who brought into being through His Command whatsoever is in the heavens and earth. Then those who have believed in God and His signs—these shall be gathered unto God.

To proceed: I have examined what you asked regarding the tradition from the Imam Rida where he spoke concerning how no deed performed by a servant, whether good or evil, exists except that God has decreed it. Know that God, glorified be He, has not created anything upon which falls the name of "thing"

except through what the essence of that thing accepts. And it is impossible for anything in the heavens and earth to receive existence except through seven aspects, which are: Will, Purpose, Measure, Decree, Permission, Term, and Book. Whosoever claims the absence of any one of these has disbelieved.

The proof that a thing cannot receive existence except through seven aspects is that which I shall now indicate through wisdom's proof: For when a thing is mentioned, it has the rank of existence, and it cannot exist except through the rank of its essence, which is the cause of accepting existence. When duality is established, the link is established. When the link is established in the station of trinity, wisdom necessitates the rule of four in the descent of the Command from the unseen realm to the visible world. Therefore, in mentioning truth, the seven are required in all ranks of existence.

There is no difference in the ruling between existences and essences, as claimed by the philosophers who say existence is pure good from God with no choice for the servants, and essence has no existence except through mental considerations and imaginal conditions—for this is polytheism in the school of the Immaculate Ones, peace be upon them. The truth in reality is that existence in all ranks is created with free choice, for the question "Am I not your Lord?" falls only upon one who has choice, as indicated by the words of the Sovereign, the All-Choosing: "There is nothing that does not glorify His praise." Whoever says otherwise, upon him is the word of punishment. I have expounded this matter in many stations, and whoever wishes to understand the reality of the answer should examine what I have detailed in the Letter Ha'.

What is meant by His exalted word "decree" is the fourth rank of the act wherein no alteration occurs afterwards. Therefore my spirit and all in the kingdom of Command and Creation are sacrificed for Him Who is distinguished by the rank of Decree, which God, glorified be He, carries out without alteration except in the station of the possibility of a thing, for that is an alteration that does not separate from the thing and accompanies the existence of everything in every condition. To this points His exalted word: "Say: Who then could prevent God in any way if He willed to destroy the Messiah, son of Mary, and his mother, and everyone on earth? And to God belongs the dominion of the heavens and the earth and what is between them. He creates what He wills, and God has power over all things."

When you understand the ruling of Decree in the fourth rank, you will be certain that no good or evil exists in contingent being except through God's Decree and Measure and the five ranks, and all that exists only through the servant's choice. For choice accompanies the existence of the thing, and the manifestations of the act are the existences of things which exist through God, glorified be He. When you understand what you have understood, then witness the mystery of Destiny in the ruling of the Ordainer—or else submit and you will be safe.

Glory be to God, Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. Peace be upon the Messengers. And praise be to God, Lord of the worlds.

BB00383: Answer to the son of Mulla 'Ali-i-Nuri (Kayfiyyatu'l-Mi'raj)

A questioned, on the night of the sitting, concerning the matter of the Ascension in the Land of Sad:

In the name of God, the Most Merciful, the Most Compassionate

Praise be to God Who has manifested Himself to all contingent beings through the appearance of the Will for them and through them, that all contingent beings might know what God has placed within the essential realities of their beings regarding the stations of action and manifestations of passivity, until each station knows itself and recognizes the decree of its origin in what God has ordained for it in every condition without end, that it might testify in the realm of contingency to what God has testified to Himself and to His creation that there is no God but Him, the Mighty, the Most High.

That esteemed one asked regarding a difficulty well-known among the people of divine knowledge: How it was possible for the Prophet to be present simultaneously in all regions of existence, both hidden and manifest?

Know that none can understand this lofty station except through knowledge of "the matter between the two matters" which is the mystery of destiny. For things have three ranks: the rank of eternity (sarmad), which is the station of action, though God has given it an end in the station of manifestation due to the inexhaustibility of divine outpouring in the rank of existence—this is the station of Muhammad and his successors, where none can grasp anything of the wisdom of that rank; the rank of perpetuity (dahr), which in God's knowledge has a beginning from the station of eternity and an end in the station of concealment—this is the station of other contingent beings in the ranks of essences in the worlds of abstraction; and the rank of time (zaman), which God has given bounds in both beginning and end, and which is realized through the motion of the celestial spheres.

Having established these ranks, there is no doubt that in the first rank the heart knows that a thing has all ranks established for it and all manifestations tell its story, for the universal body which God made the bearer of the loci of action speaks of its essential station which indicates the station of eternity. For although the Prophet's body on the Night of the Ascension was in the house of Humayra according to tradition, it is established by consensus that he was in heaven and the ranks of paradise and hell. For just as nothing in the contingent worlds can veil his essence, so too with his body. Since minds can only perceive things as limited, they cannot witness the matter between matters and the decree of eternity in the decree of determination.

Thus whatever was said in the two gatherings, the mind turned from it due to its unity, until some souls acknowledged their lack of knowledge of what actually occurred regarding the rank of the body. Had God willed and desired, He would have explained the reality of this matter through the mystery of what occurred and the conclusive wisdom in its station, that all might know who knew the matter in the stations of manifestation and not be veiled from beholding the light of the unseen when veiled from the court of the presence of nearness.

At that station the pen has ceased to flow, and to God returns the decree of exposition in beginning and return. Glory be to God, Lord of the Throne, above what they describe. Peace be upon the Messengers, and praise be to God, Lord of the worlds.

BB00470: Epistle to Haji Mirza Aqasi 2

A portion of the Tablet revealed at Sīyah-Dahan, in honor of Muhammad Shah

In the Name of Him Who is Exalted and Most High

Praise be to God Who bestows His favor upon whomsoever He willeth through His wisdom—glorified and exalted be He above what they describe.

God knows and is sufficient witness to My condition, that I have committed no wrong deserving of such a judgment. Though I acknowledge, in accordance with the words of the Commander of the Faithful, that "existence itself is a sin with which no sin can be compared," in any case, if I am a believer—and I am, as witnessed by God and His chosen ones—then according to the purport of the sacred tradition "Whosoever shows enmity unto one of My friends hath declared war against Me," such treatment is not permissible. And if I am an infidel—and by the sacred Being of God and the exalted station of the Family of the House of Infallibility, I am not, though there are many infidels living under the protection of the King in every land—still such judgment is not permissible.

In any case, such a decree is not befitting toward one who is of the seed of the Prophet, while God's decree is manifest: "Say: I ask of you no recompense for this except the love of those who are near of kin." And the decree concerning "those who judge not by what God hath revealed" is also evident before the Most Holy Presence. Even if some matter concerning Me were truly doubtful, it would be incumbent upon you to guide aright, though by God's grace and bounty I am not conscious of even an atom's weight of sin in Myself.

When they observe the signs that have appeared through Divine Will, all suspicion will be removed. And if despite this I deserve death, I swear by the Sacred Being of God that I yearn for death with greater longing than a babe for its mother's breast. In the name of God and by God, I await the decree and am content with God's judgment. This decree is sweeter to Me than honey.

Beyond this brief account of My state in the station of poverty and glory which I have disclosed—though even at this stage it is manifest that the very pebbles of the earth are charged with knowing My name, even if they know not My form—it beseems you not. Do consider also in your grace and mercy the hearts of the kindred. If the purpose is to close the door upon Myself, I hope by God's might that once confined to a goodly place, it shall not be opened.